The Brightmoon Institution (Catradora Boarding School AU)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42894891.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma & Scorpia (She-Ra), Angella/Micah (She-Ra), Mermista & Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra), Light Hope/Mara (She-Ra)

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Alternate Universe - Boarding School, Razz is amazing, Catra is a fashion designer, Catra gets drunk, Adora gets drunk, Catra and Glimmer are sisters, Catra and Glimmer are rich/famous

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by bleeber

Summary

Adora called out across the ice, feeling as if she was floating on air. It was a strange sense of euphoria, the wind biting her skin and the vast sea of stars above her. It almost felt surreal. What made it even more unbelievable was the girl in front of her, chuckling as she watched Adora trip over herself slightly as she realized the weight of this experience.

A socially isolated girl leaves the comfort of an abusive mother to meet a world of richness, both metaphorically and literally. Though Adora is undoubtedly intelligent, her confinement in Shadow Weaver's home prevents her from fulfilling her 'lifelong pursuit' of becoming President. After eleven years of carefully monitored studies, Adora leaves to attend the Brightmoon Institution, an academy founded to educate the brightest minds.
There she makes friends....as well as enemies. Cue Catra. A forgotten ally from a forgotten place, a reawakened memory in Adora's mind.

Most characters are created and owned by the creator and writers of SPOP, I'm merely presenting my interpretation of them.

A/N

A/N:

I literally took a 'small' ~intermission~ from my W.I.P to write this and ended up finishing a whole draft. Anyway, I'll keep this brief, it's mostly just "housekeeping" and small stuff like that.

Hi, my name is Cara, and I'm 16 (or I was at the time of writing this). I will stipulate that this was just a fun break from my current project because I was on a creative block and suddenly felt like writing some good old fanfiction. I did not do an outline for this, so please don't expect it to be a fully developed and revised piece of work because it is not (even though it is long enough to be considered a novel). However, if you do have any suggestions, please feel free to politely provide constructive criticism, I'm always open to improving myself as a writer :)

The ships in this ff are mostly canon, or popular among the community. However, if you do not agree with them kindly stop reading because I literally just wrote this for my own enjoyment and for some reason it landed up here.

If any artists come across this and maybe feel inspired, please send it my way (esp the uniform fits lmao). My art skills just managed to scrape this cover together, but if you want to replace it (and be credited, of course) then feel free too.

I've already written this entire book, so I hope you enjoy this story as much as I did writing it. If you do, I would greatly appreciate it if you vote, comment and/or share it with a friend!

Happy Reading <3

President Adora

Chapter Summary

just read it lol

Adora shut her laptop quickly, guilt suddenly flowing through her. She shouldn't be relaxing right now, she had midterms to study for, finals to think of. It was criminal to think of anything other than school, but perhaps that was the fun of it...

"Adora!"

A sense of uneasiness pooled within her at the voice, and she quickly scampered from her luxurious desk space to the kitchen where the dreaded voice was projected. Looking back at the desk, Adora frowned. Fresh pale post its, pastel highlighters and a brand new laptop. The brand new laptop on which she was watching-

She fought the blushed, her cheeks turning rosy.

"Adora! Dinner's ready."

The smell of roast chicken wafted into the air, and that was enough to send the young girl barreling down the crooked stairs in vivid anticipation.

"Good evening, Adora."

Adora sat down on one of the kitchen stools, looking up at her adoptive mother.

"Good evening Shadow Weaver."

The woman wore a mask, though Adora never understood why. Shadow Weaver had mentioned she'd been angrily burned in a house fire, but Adora was too afraid to question her further.

Shadow Weaver wasn't much of a talker, preferring to question Adora rather than reveal her past.

Cold hands gripped her shoulders softly, and goosebumps came to life on her skin.

"I hope the new study accommodations have been treating you well?"

"Yes, Shadow Weaver."

Her response was automatic, too much so that the woman detected it the same way she detected lies. Adora looked down on the cold stone table, guilt and shame threatening to crack into her expression.

"Adora," the old woman cooed at her. "You can call me mother, sweet child."

The girl didn't respond, didn't really know how too. Only a trickle of surprise flowed through her, surprise at the somewhat tender tone.

Shadow Weaver had been good to her ever since she'd been adopted eleven years ago, but somehow Adora couldn't spit out the words without feeling a slight uncomfortable.

"Yes...mother."

Shadow Weaver flashed a smile, well at least her eyes did, and pulled out a plate for Adora.

"I've been thinking..."

Adora waited, watching the steaming piece of chicken with eager eyes. The pause wasn't for Shadow Weaver's thoughts, she didn't speak unless she knew exactly what she was going to say. The pause must've been for dramatic effect, which was never out of the question for her adoptive mother.

"It's time for you to return to school."

Her eyes flew up to meet hagged hazel, and she stared in confusion.

"But you pulled me out of school so I could get ahead?"

Shadow Weaver slid the plate of food in front of her, but her eyes didn't leave the old woman's face.

"Yes, but if we-" she paused.

"You," Adora made note of the amendment, "decide to run for office one day, we need to have precautions set in place."

Adora chewed on her chicken absentmindedly, the words occupying her thoughts. School was a foreign thought, nearly taboo in the house.

"You need to be in the right social circles, and need to gain skills other than...studying."

Other than the orphanage, Adora wasn't really exposed to people her age. It frightened her, made her stomach flip with uneasiness. Though...she had always held a fascination for the high school experience.

"It's great in theory, but I'm advanced for my year level."

It might sound like she was speaking highly of herself, but it was the truth. In fact, advanced was putting it lightly, and they both knew it.

"Did you really believe I'd let my prize winner in a common high school?"

Adora blushed faintly as Weaver cackled in a fit.

"No child, you'll be attending the finest institution. The Bright Moon Institution."

Institution? Adora inwardly cringed, it sounded like a psych ward.

"And when will I be attending this institution?"

Weaver scolded her with thin eyes for Adora's joking manner.

"Next year."

Adora nearly fell off her chair. Next year was too soon to get her social skills together, she was at least thinking university or something, not junior year.

"That's in two weeks, not including the break."

Shadow Weaver leaned across to stroke Adora's hair, wrapping the golden strands in her long fingers.

"Well then it's perfect."

Adora held a breath as Shadow Weaver released her, and looked at the woman with wide eyes.

"Go on now, you have plenty of studying to complete."

Adora nodded, her throat suddenly dry.

———————

Finally stretching out her hands was exhilarating. Halfway through the exam, Adora felt her leg shaking (for absolutely no reason?) and her arm cramping painfully. The only thing that made her finish the paper was the incessant voice of Shadow Weaver filling her ears.

President Adora. President Adora. President Adora.

She opened her laptop, mind somewhat void of stress, and searched up the only thing that had been intruding her mind.

The Bright Moon Institution.

Adora quickly clicked on the link, which instantly redirected her to a website.

Her jaw hung out of her mouth as she stared at the image, a castle like structure complete with a scenic view of the mountains, a nearby lake, and picture perfect students.

She would never fit in here, not in a million years. She looked down on her worn, faded jeans, tattered converse, and red jacket. Shadow Weaver wasn't poor by any means, a former famous legal representative and house senate. But she only adopted Adora for her potential, and invested money into her education rather than wardrobe. Adora didn't mind, it wasn't like she had exposure to any teenagers to know what was in trend. She sighed, scrolling down until she hit the large bolded words which caught her attention.

"THE BEST BOARDING COLLEGE FOR ELITE STUDENTS"

Boarding School, as in, BOARDING SCHOOL?

Adora felt a rush of anxiety overwhelm her, being around rich perfect people every hour of every day? It was too much, the social aspect was scaring her enough.

Then again, it couldn't be that much more stressful than being around Shadow Weaver. Adora mentally berated herself for the thought. She ought to be more grateful towards Shadow Weaver. No one else thought to adopt her, only the fierce lady with a hidden face and piercing eyes.

Speaking of Shadow Weaver, how come she didn't' tell her....Did she not know?

Adora found her answer when she stumbled into the formal lounge room, finding Shadow Weaver packing a series of items into cardboard boxes.

"What's this?"

"I've ordered clothes for you, along with a second pack of stationary, a new school tablet and-"

"You knew?"

Adora stared wide eyed at her, incredulous at her adoptive mother's secrecy.

"Knew what?"

Shadow Weaver reached out to tuck Adora's hair, and Adora had the urge to knock her hand off. But she didn't, she couldn't.

"That I'm being shipped off to who knows where for a year?"

How could Shadow Weaver be so nonchalant about this? Adora had barely seen the outside world by herself, let alone without Shadow Weaver.

"Adora, you're ready. It's time for you to take what you deserve, what we both do."

Adora felt something prick her eyes, grabbing onto Shadow Weaver without a second thought. The woman stroked her hair, hugging the girl back.

"I know you're special Adora, you're destined for great things."

Adora clung all the tighter, afraid to let go.

Roommates With No Filters

Walking onto the wide open campus was indescribable. It was identical to the photos; pristine amethyst statues, soft stepping stones, the rippling of a river. Adora was nearly put into a trance by it, her senses exploring as much as they could.

"Good Morning, I'm Dean Perfuma at your service, how may I assist you?"

Adora was afraid to meet the lady's eyes, but the woman did not even look to consult Shadow Weaver, only waiting for the young girl's response.

Adora looked up shyly, her hair down to hide her face.

"Um, I'm here to...check in?"

Adora looked to Shadow Weaver for assurance, but received none. She quickly averted her gaze from the lady, Perfuma, and her kind gaze.

"You've enrolled for Year 11, how exciting! Could I grab your name?"

Her voice was a touch softer, which Adora greatly appreciated.

"Adora Gray."

"Perfect, would you mind if I just confirmed a few details of you?"

Adora felt herself loosen up in her presence, slowly nodding her head.

"When's your birthday, Adora?"

"The 19th of January."

"Oh, we just passed it! Can you tell me your address."

Her seventeenth wasn't very significant, but she felt an odd sense of warmth spread at the fact that Perfuma had realized they'd just passed the date. Shadow Weaver certainly didn't forget, passing Adora a silver wrapped box of stationary on the gloomy day. It wasn't very picturesque, despite the warm summer they'd had previously.

"Apartment Number 5 in the Fright Zone, Brooklyn."

"Wonderful, thank you so much Adora!"

Adora smiled at the lady, finally meeting her eyes. The woman beamed at her, freckles scattered along her face with warm dark eyes.

The woman used the keys tied around her neck to open a filing cabinet, pulling out a manilla envelope and a set of keys.

"Follow me, Adora."

Adora looked back at Shadow Weaver, hesitant to leave her.

"I'll be calling every week to monitor your studies, and who you make social connections with."

Adora noted the odd expression on Perfuma's face at the words, but brushed it off.

"Yes, Shadow Weaver."

The eyes bore into her.

"Yes....Mother."

The woman nodded before curtly shaking Perfuma's hand, leaving in the matter of seconds. Adora felt something in her deflate at the cold farewell. Shadow Weaver was by no means affectionate, but this was blunt, even for her.

"Hey, follow me. You have great roommates."

Adora looked at her.

"Ill actually be living with people?"

Perfuma laughed, the sound of fairy dust.

"Of course!"

Adora stayed silent for the remainder of the journey, afraid she'll sound even more ignorant. Perfuma seemed to notice, but didn't push too far, blocking the awkwardness with a bit of context on the school. Outlining the features of certain areas, and the fact that there were three swimming pools.

It's so big, I'll definitely be lost.

"Where are all the students?"

"It's after hours, some stay up in one of the recreational centers or go on a campus walk, but other than that.."

She nodded up to the spirals of windows and Adora gulped. Dorm rooms.

_____

Perfuma knocked softly against the door, waiting for a response.

"Hello? We aren't expecting anyone!"

Adora felt her nerves calm slightly at the voice, soft and sugary. At least the girl inside sounded nice.

"It's Perfuma, Glimmer."

Glimmer.

"Oh! Why didn't you say so?"

The door unlocked to reveal a...sparkly girl. Hair made of cotton candy and eyes a soft lavender. Adora vaguely wondered if the girl

was wearing contact lenses. She adorned the school uniform, albeit slightly modified and ruffled. Adora's pristine version felt like blades weighing down her suitcase.

"Oh." Her eyes flitted to Adora and she quickly ducked her head. "Ohhhhhhh, one sec."

The door slammed on her face and Perfuma smiled apologetically at her.

"Bow, get in here!"

The door quickly opened again to reveal two open faces. Adora quickly scanned the new one, Bow.

"Hi, you must be Adora. I'm Glimmer, and this is Bow!"

Adora eyed the toothy grins with suspicions.

"Adora huh? Weird name for an orphan-"

Bow was swiftly shut up by a shove from Glimmer, and Adora couldn't help but chuckle inwardly to herself at the small yet affectionate interaction.

"Well, I'll let you get settled in Adora. Your boxes will all be transported by the morning, so you'll have the weekend to unpack. I'll drop off your timetable tomorrow morning, along with any provided school essentials, and maybe a comfort plant!"

Adora blinked at the last few words, and Perfuma winked, passing the keys to Adora before walking away.

"Sorry about him, he doesn't really have a filter."

"And you do, Glimmer?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes, but Adora knew she was kidding from the grin plastered on her face.

"Well? Don't just stand there, this is your home now too!"

Adora was yanked into the room by the shorter girl, and yelped in surprise.

"We were sad to know we didn't just have a spare dumping bed for storage, but having you here will definitely be worth it."

Despite the genuine look in her eyes, Adora felt a ripple of resentment stem from Glimmer as she examined her, eyes flicking up and down a few times. Adora had to restrain herself from nervously touching the ends of her hair.

"Where did you say you were from again?"

"I didn't, but Brooklyn."

Glimmer nodded, looking behind Adora to Bow.

"Well, do you want a campus tour?"

Adora nodded, feeling slightly emboldened by the lively girl.

They wondered out into the courtyard, and she couldn't help but be enraptured by every piece of art around her. She absorbed it like a sponge, the desire to look at every corner of the world suddenly overtaking her. If this school was just one pocket of the globe, imagine...

Adora didn't let her imagination track too far, Shadow Weaver would never let her mindlessly travel....But maybe she could under the guise of presidency. One day...

"What are you thinking about?"

Glimmer's voice snapped Adora out of her trance as she looked around the room they were suddenly in, the gym.

"Nothing...The whole infrastructure of this place is amazing, my old school didn't even compare."

"I thought you were homeschooled?"

Glimmer was frowning at her while Bow spoke, and Adora felt slightly targeted. How did they even know so much about her?

"I was, but before I was adopted I went to a regular public school."

Adora didn't remember much of her past life, it wasn't exactly a joyous time. The school was dingy and horrible, and she only had one friend for her entire duration. Shadow Weaver was her teacher, Adora still didn't really know how someone as prestigious as Weaver came to a hole like that. But she was lucky she did, because it caused Weaver to notice and eventually adopt Adora.

"Right."

Glimmer sounded unconvinced, as if she didn't trust Adora (even though Adora didn't really understand why).

They started walking back to the dormitories, Bow chatting to fill the air. Adora appreciated it, he seemed to tell that she didn't feel like sharing her whole life story right at this moment, or even provide small talk.

"Oh, you'll adore Sea Hawk Adora! He's the hottest gym teacher we've had."

Bow giggled to himself at the wordplay, and Adora refrained from playfully rolling her eyes. She didn't want to seem rude.

"He is definitely into his assistant, Mermista, but she despises him. It's honestly hilarious to watch."

Adora let the words ripple in and out of her mind as they walked, listening to glimpses of names and identities from the stories Bow told. She tucked her head down as they passed small groups of students looking inquisitively at her.

"Oh no."

Her eyes quickly flicked to Glimmer, to see the pale lavender darkening. Adora tracked her attention up ahead, at a group of people walking towards them, pencil cases and textbooks in hand.

Glimmer quickly sidestepped in front of Adora, and Bow didn't quite overshadow her, but his stance was defensive.

"Hey, Sparkles."

Adora's view of the girl was blocked, but she felt her skin prickle at the voice. Rolling with texture, paired a purring quality.

"It's Glimmer, Catra."

Catra? No, it was practically impossible.

Tight pitched laughter rang clear and Adora felt the urge to push back against Glimmer and Bow to see the girl.

"Whatever you say, Sparkles."

The girl's friends nearly walked past them when Glimmer erupted.

"That's it! I'm telling mum about you. Seriously, how hard is it for you to just call me by my name?"

"Go ahead and try, I'm sure she'll give a shit."

Adora reeled back in surprise, was this Glimmer's sister? The girl didn't retaliate, but someone beside her did.

"Calm down Rogelio, Sparkles is all bark and no bite."

The tall boy eased off of a cowering Glimmer, returning to his place besides Catra.

"Tell your mother Glimmer, I dare you."

Adora felt her nosiness spike at the interesting 'family' dynamic these two had going on. She waited for the group to pass them, but they never did.

Instead, she was harshly yanked by the tall muscular boy, Rogelio, pulled up against the white cobbled wall.

Adora felt her head thump with the impact, pain blooming dully. Not enough to bleed, but her skull would've been bruised.

"And what, or should I say, who are we hiding here, Sparkles?"

Adora finally had the girl in front of her, and nearly gasped at the sight.

Smooth, freckled tan skin, and a messy head of dark locks. But those were only compliments to her assessing eyes, one a royal blue and the other a shining gold.

Probably just a coincidence, there was no way they both landed up here.

Adora watched the girl's eyes carefully, waiting for a spark of recognition, but she couldn't read the stare.

"Catra?"

Catra blinked at her voice, tilting her head ever so slightly. Adora stared at her, waves of memories threatening to ebb at her emotions.

"Catra it's me, Adora."

In the corner of her eye she saw Glimmer open her mouth, but Bow gave a slight shake of his head.

"I'm sorry, do I know you?"

Adora stared at her in shock, Rogelio's grip around her neck loosening slightly.

"We were taught by Weaver, the Fright Zone?"

A cloud misted over her eyes, dampening the brightness of sapphire and gold.

"You must've mistaken me for someone else, Adora."

Adora's eyes widened at her, finally seeing a crack in her expression. She remembered, she knew who she was. But why was she lying about it?

"Sparkles, next time you go looking for strays-"

Her eyes roamed freely over Adora's figure, and she couldn't help but look away, unable to meet the intenseness of her stare.

"Buy them some proper clothing."

Rogelio finally dropped her and Adora slid to the floor, Bow instantly rushing to her side while Glimmer death stared Catra. She laughed cruelly as she walked away from them, offering Adora a final wink, but one full of menace.

Adora groaned as she sat up, feeling around her head for any bumps or cuts. Bow gave her an apologetic look, while Glimmer fumed as she paced up and down the walkway.

"I hate her, I hate everything about her, she's insufferable."

"Uh, Glimmer?"

Bow gestured to Adora beside him and Glimmer rushed over.

"I'm so sorry about that, that's-"

"Catra."

They both looked at her with a question in their eyes.

"Back there...you acted as if you knew her."

"Do you?"

Adora sighed, rubbing the side of her body that was in pain.

"She was my best friend in that public school I told you about. Shadow Weaver was our teacher. I managed to get adopted, but I always wondered where she ended up."

Glimmer nodded.

"Mum adopted Catra when I was around ten, but all she's done since then is everything but kill me."

Adora stared at Glimmer, but her mind was everywhere at once. Happy, that Catra had been adopted. It was painful to look back on the memory she tried to avoid at all costs, but it couldn't help but flash into her mind now, when she'd just witnessed the...thing Catra had become.

"Adora, someone's here to see you."

The child glanced at Catra next to her, scared.

"Can Catra come? Please?"

Sharp nails edged onto her arm, but Adora didn't mind the slight pain. It was comforting, in an odd sense.

"No, Adora. Catra will stay here, with me."

Hordak twined his claws around Adora's friend, and Catra's scream pierced the wind, penetrated the walls built around Adora's mind.

Adora stared at her friend, silent communication buzzing between them.

Catra shook her head, no, but it was too late. Someone had gently clutched her shoulders, and Adora reached out, trying to maintain some sort of contact.

"I'll be back, don't worry."

"You promise?"

Adora looked at her friend, conviction shone through her tears.

"I promise."

The girl had been dragged to a bright room, too bright. Shadow Weaver, her and Catra's mentor, sat in a chair. A part of Adora was relieved at the sight, Shadow Weaver was scary, but at least she'd return back to Catra soon.

"Adora, Shadow Weaver has agreed to adopt you."

The small child's heart dropped as the woman cooed at her. She wanted to leave, more than anything....But not without Catra.

"What about Catra, can't you adopt her."

Shadow Weaver pulled her hair out of the ponytail it was held in, stroking the golden strands tenderly.

"Catra is lazy and ill tempered. I could never choose her."

Adora would always choose her, but she didn't want to speak up.

"You have always been mine, Adora."

The child stared at her with wide eyes.

The memory snapped out of focus as a sharp pain stung her arm.

"Ouch!"

She swatted away Bow's hand that pinched her, glaring at him in the process.

"What was that for?"

"Sorry! You were zoning out and I panicked."

Adora softly brushed the length of her arm, forgiving Bow with a slight smile.

"It's fine, I'll live."

Bow smiled back at her, and Adora felt something alleviate in her chest. A friend, perhaps?

"Who's your mother, Glimmer?"

Glimmer blushed and Adora opened her mouth to question her, but Bow answered instead.

"Angella Brightmoon."

Adora gawked at Glimmer, realizations clicking into place. The relaxed uniform, glittery hair, purple eyes and unnatural blush. Of course she was the Principle's daughter, she matched the literal aesthetic of this hypnotic school-castle.

"Your mum is-"

"Yes, yes, she owns the place, a multimillion dollar company and is a goddess, I know! I've heard it all before."

Adora swore she heard a note of bitterness in her voice, but she must've been imagining it. Glimmer must've had a close to perfect childhood.

"Let's get back to the dorm."

Bow was eager to change the subject.

"You have unpacking to do and you're probably really tired. We have the whole weekend to finish the tour."

Adora nodded and they started walking back. Glimmer kept at a distance, and Adora frantically wondered what she had done wrong. Maybe Catra had just put her in a sour mood? They didn't seem to have the strongest relationship...

Still, Glimmer seemed to be nice to her out of necessity, not as warm or open, though Adora didn't expect that of anyone.

She might've found a friend in Bow, but she wasn't convinced she'd found one in Glimmer.

Cats and Idiot

Adora thought she was going to be sick, her stomach roiling in dread as she stared down at the timetable.

"Calm down, Adora, everyone's going to love you."

Glimmer definitely didn't, so she doubted anyone else would.

"Just don't count on Catra."

Glimmer scoffed from the corner, brushing her hair in the mirror. Adora felt her stomach twist even more with the thought of Catra. She hadn't seen her at all since their initial encounter, and she was almost frightened of seeing her again. Why did she act like they hadn't been all each other had twelve years ago? Why was she so cold? What on earth happened to her?

"Come on, you don't want to miss breakfast."

Bow placed a comforting hand on Adora's as she examined her uniform in the mirror. She caught Glimmer glaring at the affectionate contact and felt her gaze like a knife burning a hole through her head. Great, she'd have to deal with this weird tension for the next two years. The table vibrated with the sound of a phone ring next to her and Adora didn't hesitate to pick it up to see Shadow Weaver FaceTiming her.

"Hi!"

Her voice was too breathy and too bright. Fake, and they both knew it.

"Adora? You look too pale, get some sun."

"Yes, ma'am."

Shadow Weaver raised her eyebrows and Adora instantly amended.

"Yes mum."

"I wanted to wish you for your first day, you clearly need it."

Adora coughed, Shadow Weaver's disappointment eating at her.

"Don't fail a class, or you'll receive a personal visit from me."

Adora gulped, Shadow Weaver's innuendos doing nothing to calm the storm in her stomach.

"I won't."

"That's my star. Now don't be late to your first class, get there early, make lots of new connections and-"

"Yep, got it. Bye!"

Adora quickly hung up, Bow's questioning glance prickling at her conscience for no apparent reason. Shadow Weaver's relationship with her wasn't conventional, but she still valued and cared for her adoptive mother. How could you not?

Bow stood up and walked around her chair, leaning on it as he hummed at the mirror.

"Hmmm...Wearing your hair out won't do."

Adora met his eyes in reflection.

"Why not?"

"It's pretty, just not very you."

"What does that mean?"

Adora twisted in her chair to look up at Bow, ignoring Glimmer's stare at them.

"I love it, I really do, but something's off."

"It hides her eyes, they're too pretty to be hidden like that. And she'll die in phys ed if she wears it down like that."

Adora's head flicked to Glimmer so fast her neck strained. Her roommates face heated up, as if she hadn't meant to blurt that out.

"You think my eyes are pretty?"

Adora used her hair to hide the slight blush as Glimmer furrowed her eyebrows, looking down.

"You're anything but ugly, even an idiot could see that."

Glimmer grumbled, but she was looking at Bow despite answering Adora. Adora looked between them with a quizzical expression.

"I'm thinking a ponytail, but with a twist!"

Adora shrugged, giving him free reign to do whatever he pleased. A squeal emitted from behind her, and Adora was nearly scared for what was to come.

"Ta da! Don't you love it?"

Adora stared at herself in the mirror, brushing her fingers across the hair. A pulled back ponytail, with a slight poof of volume at the front, and whispers of hairs let down to drape her face.

"I haven't worn a ponytail since I was, like, five."

"Then it was about time it got revived."

Adora smiled, finding herself agreeing with the statement.

"Come on, let's get breakfast."

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"Adora, you have to eat something."

"If I do, I'm going to throw up."

"If you don't, you'll faint."

Adora huffed, finally biting into an apple, although it was sour. She chewed, not really tasting the flavor and swallowed. She bit into it again, trying to focus her thoughts on anything but Catra.

She had tried to convince herself she wasn't waiting for her to walk in, but that was just a painful lie.

"Why are you so jumpy?"

"Where's Catra?" Adora blurted, eyes dancing around the room for a head of messy waves.

"Catra? I don't know actually, she and her friends might have eaten earlier. They're like, obsessed with the library, I don't get what's so great about it. Just looks fancy, I guess."

Bow shrugged before pausing at poking his potatoes, eyes shining as he looked at her again.

"Hang on, why do you care so much?"

Adora's face heated and she waved her hands about.

"Me? No, nooo. I'm just curious is all."

Bow hummed thoughtfully, turning back towards his food while Adora tapped her foot on the ground impatiently.

"You know what, I'm just gonna go to the bathroom."

"Right," Bow drawled.

"Yes, to the bathroom. I'll be back super quick."

"Should I come?"

"Nawh, I'll be fine. I think you should stay here with Glimmer, I'll just be a sec."

Bow nodded knowingly, giving Adora the chance to dash out of the cafeteria, apple still in hand.

Now she eagerly bit into it, a form of a distraction as she walked towards the library. Glimmer had mentioned there were three of them, and Adora had visited all, but she didn't know which one Catra would be in. She supposed she'd have to quickly visit all before gym class. A part of her, a big one, wanted to know why she was acting like this.

She wandered into the first library, this one being her favorite.

Apparently, it was Catra's too, for she spotted her and the gaggle of idiots almost instantly.

Adora placed a hand on her chest, hiding behind a marble pillar. The thought of facing this Catra and her friends hadn't crossed her mind, but she wasn't guaranteed to have any classes with Catra by herself, so this was the best chance.

Deep breaths Adora.

She stepped out, approaching the table where Catra's friends laughed, their apparent leader sullen over a textbook.

The girl spotted Adora walking towards her table quickly, trying to intimidate her from across the room. Adora ignored the tactic, brushing away the fears that kept spinning into her mind.

"Hey, Adora."

Adora blushed at the tone, and the way Catra leaned on the table to look up at her.

"Hi Catra. I was wondering if we could talk before class?"

The words slipped hesitantly from her mouth, but at least they were out. Catra blinked at her in surprise before responding.

"Sit down, we can talk here."

Adora felt her face heat up, but she sat down anyway. At least it was something.

Catra seemed more surprised than her at the fact that she accepted the offer.

"Do you remember me, from the orphanage?"

The table paused in their whispering to one another and turned to Catra, but she smoothly lied.

"I have absolutely no idea what you're talking about Blondie, sorry to disappoint."

Adora narrowed her eyes, feeling persistent.

"Catra-"

The bell sounded, interrupting her. No one hesitated in slinging their bags over their shoulders, but Catra took a little longer than the others.

"Coming Cats?"

A girl with short brown hair turned around, mossy green eyes pausing on Adora for a second.

"Give me a sec, I'll meet you in class."

Adora was glad for a second alone with the girl, the entire library practically empty.

But before she had the chance to speak, Catra loomed over her.

"Don't talk to me again Adora."

"So you do remember me, then?"

She scoffed, rolling her eyes while placing a finger in the centre of Adora's head.

"Of course I remember you, idiot."

Adora laughed, going cross-eyed, but Catra wasn't smiling.

"I've built a name for myself here, I won't allow you to drag me in the mud with my past."

"Catra, can't we just be friends."

She tilted her head back and laughed, wiping tears with her hand.

"No, Adora. We can't."

Despite the act of ridicule, Catra's face was stone cold as she spoke. Adora frowned, tilting her head at her.

"If this is about Shadow-"

Something struck her across the face, and Adora was shocked to see it was Catra's hand. The sting was harsh, but it didn't deter Adora from getting answers.

"Don't say her name."

Adora looked at her, a hand covering her cheek.

"Leave me be Adora, go play with Sparkles and Arrowboy. I don't need you screwing with me. Not now."

She adjusted her uniform, a short royal blue and purple pleated skirt, paired with high rise white socks, and a button up with a matching tie and fitted blazer. Adora had her own version tucked into her closet, but she hadn't needed to wear it today, considering she had P.E. It fitted Catra like a glove, pulling in all the right places. Adora tried her hardest not to stare as Catra

slung a sleek black book bag over her shoulder, adjusting the lapels of her blazer.

"Sorry for the scratch, I didn't really mean it."

Adora hadn't even realized she was bleeding until Catra's eyes flicked to her cheek. She pulled her hand away, shocked to see stark red blood.

"Don't get in my way, and I won't get in yours."

Adora stared at her as she fixed the headband secured to her head, a pearly white one.

"Bye, Adora."

She was speechless.

Dodgeball or Sex Ed?

Adora waved a hand in front of Bow's face as he sighed to the introduction of Mr. Hawk, Mermista rolling her eyes while dragging a sack of brightly colored sponge balls. They both looked fairly young, at the most eight years older than herself.

"Earth to Bow, are you there?"

Adora peered to look at him but her cheeks were yanked as Bow squished her face, turning her to look at Mr Hawk.

"A god Adora, a literal god."

She rolled her eyes, prying Bow's hands off her face while checking to make sure the makeup she applied to Catra's cuts was still intact. She'd felt guilty going through Glimmer's belongings in the morning, but the unused bottle of liquid was far too pale for her anyway. Glimmer likely bought the wrong shade and forgot to return it or something. She wasn't stealing, just borrowing.

"Calm down Romeo, Mr. Hawk is far too old for you."

Glimmer stayed silent next to them and Adora sighed, knowing she was going have to talk to her soon. Tonight. She'd do it then.

"Good Morning young fliers, today we start anew!"

Adora nearly snickered, wondering if Mr Hawk was better suited to being a Performing Arts teacher than a Physical Education one.

"I have a daring quest for you all, a challenge-"

His speech was interrupted by a loud oomph as an orange ball flew into the side of his brain.

"Stuff it, Bubblebrain."

Mermista rolled her eyes, but a teasing smile played on her lips. She grabbed another ball from the bag, a blue one this time, and spun it expertly on her finger.

"Listen up kids. You can play dodgeball, or listen to Sex Ed. Which is it?"

There was a universal cry for Dodgeball as Mr Hawk raised himself from the floor, not the slightest mad at Mermista.

"Glitter you'll be one team captain and uhh..."

Mermista trailed off, eyeing the rest of the group before she landed on Adora.

"Hang on, who are you?"

Adora felt a bit flustered as they all turned to look towards her, but tried to only focus on Mermista.

"Adora Gray. I'm new."

Mermista nodded slowly, freeing all the balls from the sack.

"Right uh huh. Alright Adora, you get to verse Glitterbomb here."

"It's Glimmer!"

"Whatever."

Mermista kicked all the balls away, and Adora hopped over one as it rolled past her. She was a bit nervous, she'd only seen and heard about dodgeball from movies and shows, which she rarely was able to watch.

"Newbie, you pick first."

Adora looked at her blankly before she realized Mermista was referring to teams.

"Uh okay. Bow?"

Bow quickly hopped over to her side, and Adora noticed the heated expression on Glimmer's face. Maybe choosing Bow wasn't the best option.

"Swift."

A boy with a colorful mane and bright eyes skipped too Glimmer's side. Adora chewed her lip nervously, not knowing anyone else in the class. Bow whispered into her ear.

"Go with Double Trouble. They aren't all that athletic, but they know how to play dirty to win."

Adora nodded, looking over to a person with bright blonde hair and glowing eyes smiling at her.

"Double Trouble."

They drifted over to her side and winked.

"Smart choice, darling."

Bow assisted her as she kept going on, listing random names as she called them out. She noticed Glimmer getting more aggressive in her choices, nearly yelling names out by the end.

"Let's get this over with."

Mermista blew into her whistle, signaling the game to begin as she dragged Mr Hawk to the viewing stands. Adora faintly wondered why she chose to become a teacher, she seemed to hate it.

But she didn't have too much time to linger before Bow pulled her down, a ball flying past them.

"Adora! It's dodgeball, you can't just stand there."

"Oh, right. Sorry."

Adora wasted no more time, grabbing as many sponge balls as possible before firing them at various players while Bow dodged various balls.

"I miss the archery unit!"

Adora laughed at his cry out, finding the game surprisingly enjoyable. And not only that, she was good at it. Nearly every ball hit the desired target, and she felt a genuine smile pull on her face.

"Don't worry Bow, it's coming!"

Mr. Hawk heard Bow's comment and yelled out from the sidelines, causing Bow to get distracted. Before either of them knew what was happening, a ball flew into his chest and Bow got pushed back.

"Bow!"

"Don't worry Adora, I know you'll make it!"

Bow theatrically carried himself off the playing field, clutching where the ball hit him. Adora had no time to mourn his presence beside her, now expertly whizzing past balls and ducking to collect discarded ones.

She didn't know how or when it happened, but suddenly Glimmer was next to her, out of her boundary. It was as if she had teleported, one minute on the opposite side of the room and the next an inch away from Adora's face. Adora was about to tell her off for breaking the rules, but was interrupted by a flying ball into her face. Another rule broken.

"Argh!"

Glimmer grunted with the effort and Adora stumbled back, her vision momentarily blank. The ball bounced off of her face, allowing Adora to witness Double Trouble tap Glimmer on the shoulder.

"D.T?"

Glimmer's state of shock allowed Double Trouble to pull a ball from behind their back and direct it with so much force Glimmer fell back into the ground, groaning in pain.

"Apologies, Twinkle, but you started it."

With a flip of their hair, Double Trouble flounced off, satisfied by their work. Adora looked down at Glimmer, offering her a hand, but Glimmer batted it away. Adora bent down to be at eye level with her, only to notice the girl had tears glistening in her eyes. She hid her face, getting up from the floor and sprinting to the exit.

"I'll be right back."

Adora was glad to see no one was really watching them, all occupied in their own conversations except for Bow. He nodded at her, a soft look in his eyes.

Adora ran off after Glimmer, still unsure on where she'd go. She thought she could address this issue tonight, but it seemed to come up sooner than expected.

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Gaydar Repair

Adora was drawn to the bathroom by the sound of sobbing, and a tiny part of her heart fractured at the sound. Glimmer seemed to despise her, and she had no idea why, but clearly there was a plausible reason. Maybe Glimmer's childhood wasn't as easygoing as Adora thought it was? Or perhaps Catra didn't grow to be the person Adora knew in the Horde...

"Glimmer? It's me, Adora."

"For fucks sake, go away!"

Adora nearly listened to her, about to walk off and find Bow when she realized Glimmer was hurting. And people say some nasty things when they're hurt. Adora herself didn't, never really had the courage, but she certainly thought them.

"No. Glimmer, I need to talk to you."

"Go back to Bow! You guys do everything together anyway."

Adora sighed, closing her eyes as she rested against the door. Glimmer's sobs began to slow down, but they didn't fully come to a halt.

"Glimmer, please. I'm sorry."

Adora used the gentlest tone possible, not really knowing what she was apologizing for.

The door slowly cracked open, and Adora watched Glimmer pull her hands against puffy cheeks, silent tears tracking down her face.

"You were really nice when I first met you, but what changed?"

Adora leaned against the door, looking at the shorter girl's face.

"You and Bow."

Adora blinked. Glimmer was...jealous?

"I've known Bow for a total of three days, he's just being nice."

"You like him, don't you?"

Adora stared at her, wondering if she heard correct. Her eyes softened at the look in Glimmer's face, the warmed and slightly embarrassed blush on her cheeks. Adora didn't know much about romance, but she'd heard enough of it through books and art. But Glimmer seriously couldn't think Adora thought any of that about Bow, right? The thought was too ridiculous to even consider.

"Sorry, what?"

"Bow? You want to date him, I can tell."

Adora cracked a smile, continuing to stare at her. When Glimmer was utterly expressionless. A snicker escaped her, before she released herself into uncontrollable laughter.

"You- you think-"

"Shut up."

"I can't- You seriously think-"

Adora gave up on words, tears crawling out as she leaned against the door. Finally she calmed down enough to speak, fanning her warm face.

"Glimmer, I'm a raging lesbian. I can assure you, I have no interest in Bow."

Glimmer's face turned beet red in embarrassment and Adora smiled at her. She remembered being so scared to come out to Shadow Weaver, afraid of judgment or different treatment. But Shadow Weaver said she would've preferred if she was ace or aro,

less 'distractions' apparently. Adora hadn't really agreed, a teenager could get distracted by nearly anything, it didn't necessarily have to be romantic. Apart from that, Shadow Weaver hadn't really cared, as long as Adora kept her 'priorities in check'.

"Oh god, I'm so stupid. My gaydar was completely off."

Glimmer slid back on the wall, running her hands through her hair.

"Gaydar, are you?..."

Adora let the question hang.

"Bisexual. So is Bow."

Adora nodded, she picked up a few fruity notes from the two of them, but it was too early to make her own judgments.

"Sorry for being a complete bitch. I was just...I don't know. I guess I was scared of Bow leaving me to become your new best friend. You two got along so well, and I felt left out."

Adora sat down next to her, playfully nudging her arm.

"Hey, it's alright. I get it."

She could remember feeling that way about-

Not now, Adora.

She let the thought pass by, returning back to the present with her new friend.

The two sat in silence for a few seconds before Adora got the courage to ask the question that had been floating in her head. She already knew the answer, of course. You'd be blind not too, but she still wanted to confirm, just in case.

"So...do you like Bow?"

Glimmer blushed, looking away quickly from Adora, who chuckled.

"It doesn't matter. Bow has more interest in Mr Hawk than he does me."

Adora scoffed.

"Mr Hawk is Bow's fantasy crush, it's like me with-"

She blushed as the name reached the tip of her tongue, but quickly pulled back.

"Who?"

Glimmer peered up at her, and now it was Adora's turn to blush.

"Angelina Jolie. A celebrity crush, someone who's completely unattainable."

Glimmer sighed, resting her chin on her knees while hugging them close to her body.

"It doesn't matter, Bow definitely doesn't think of me like that."

Adora turned sideways to peer at her.

"Have you asked him."

Glimmer shook her head, mimicking Adora to look at her.

"I don't need to make things awkward. Bow has been my best friend since I was born, I can't lose him."

Adora understood to an extent. Glimmer didn't want to jeopardize their friendship.

"Even if you don't want to tell Bow how you feel yet, you should still talk to him. I don't know much about friendship, but I think communication is important. I mean-"

She gestured to them, tucked up in the corner of a bathroom stall after being at odds for three days.

"Look at us. One conversation, and you don't hate me anymore."

Glimmer chuckled, smothering her face with her hands and groaning.

"I cannot believe I thought you were going to get with Bow. I'm a lovesick idiot."

Adora laughed, a weight lifted off her chest. She glanced off the word love, distantly wondering if Glimmer's feelings for Bow were that intense

"We all have our moments."

The bell started ringing, telling them it was the end of class. Glimmer slowly pulled herself up, holding a hand out to Adora.

"You know, you are pretty enough to get with Angelina Jolie."

Adora smirked at her, placing a hand on her hip as she stared into the girl's lavender eyes.

"Are you sure you weren't just jealous of Bow. Awfully flirty, Miss Brightmoon."

Glimmer turned a shade of red so dark Adora laughed.

"Maybe it's just the panic setting in?"

Adora laughed harder as they left the bathroom.

"Hey, don't feel so special! I'm horny for just about everyone in this school, I swear."

Glimmer nudged her in the side as they walked, and Adora was glad they were finally friends.

"Hang on a sec."

Adora turned around to look at her.

"What?"

Glimmer examined the side of her face before gasping.

"Adora, who did that?"

She pointed to her cheek and Adora internally cringed. She forgot about the scar. The makeup had probably been completely rubbed off.

"Uhhh, nothing?"

"That's not nothing, who did that?"

Adora sighed, there was no other excuse to fall back on. She hadn't been anywhere in the morning except the so-called 'bathroom', and Glimmer seemed to be a 'bullshit' detector.

"This morning, I went to the library instead of the bathroom."

Glimmer's purple eyes darkened as they climbed the stairs towards their lockers. They'd probably be late for second class, and Shadow Weaver would kill her if she knew Adora was missing Math....but Adora didn't find herself caring so much.

"Catra. She did that, didn't she."

It was a statement rather than a question, and Adora quietly nodded.

"I hate her."

Adora finally had the chance to ask Glimmer about that...complicated...relationship.

"She's your adoptive sister, isn't she?"

Glimmer nodded, her arms crossed across her chest angrily.

"Yes, but she doesn't deserve to be."

Adora felt something in her get angry at the statement, but she tamed it, letting Glimmer continue.

"Mum took her in when I was ten. She was like a supplement for my dad moving abroad for work."

The way she spoke about her dad indicated there was something deeper, but Adora didn't want to pry.

"I was actually excited for her to come, but the moment she did she treated me like shit. Not in front of my mum, no. In front of Angella, Catra was a perfect angel, but the minute my mum turned around she tortured me. Pulled my hair, ripped up my homework, called me names."

Glimmer got more angry as she kept going, and Adora was in shock. The Catra she remembered wasn't nearly this cruel, but she had already detected a shift in her old friend's personality. A strange obsession with self-perception, and an insatiable thirst for influence. Glimmer's recount and this morning only proved it.

"It just got worse in school, I don't even know why she hates me so much. I only hate her because she started it!"

Adora stayed silent, also unsure of the answer to Glimmer's question.

"Damn, I have Music with Bow, he's probably waiting for me."

Adora groaned.

"I have Math."

Glimmer cringed back shaking her head at the word.

"Yuck, don't say that in my presence."

Adora chuckled lightly, wrapping Glimmer in a hug.

"Thanks for staying when I told you to leave."

Adora smiled over her shoulder.

"Thanks for opening up."

The released each other, waving and yelling hurried farewells and they rushed off to their respective lockers to grab their book bags for the day. Understandably, gym class hadn't required it.

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Is Creature Excused?

Adora was ready to fall asleep as she walked into her next class. The day had flown by and she was barely keeping up with it. While P.E had let her off easy with no homework, the other classes Shadow Weaver assigned to her weren't as kind. She'd need to have a power nap before starting her homework.

At least English was last, one of Adora's more tolerable classes. She had Textiles the following day, the class she was most looking forward too.

She instantly spotted Glimmer and Bow in the middle rows, both waving her over. Adora smiled, glad that there was no longer weird tension between the three of them as a group. Bow and Glimmer could handle their own conflicts privately, without involving Adora.

"Hey, what happened to your face?"

Adora forgot Bow hadn't seen her since the makeup had been plastered on.

"Your answer just walked in Bow."

Adora swiveled around to witness a daunting Catra talking and laughing with a friend as they sat down in front of them. She hadn't even offered Adora a glance. It felt strange, like an odd sense of foreign nostalgia. Seeing the girl Adora was once so attached to act like she didn't even know her. Glimmer narrowed her eyes at the back of Catra's head.

"She did that?"

Bow's eyes switched between Adora and Catra as he leaned across the tables whispering.

"Yes."

"Oh, bitch is going to pay for that."

Adora felt something swell inside of her as Glimmer growled, her fists tightened under the desk. The fierceness in her voice, the protectiveness in the words...It warmed the chill Catra's presence formed. .

"Don't, it'll only antagonize her."

Glimmer rolled her eyes, leaning back into the chair with an annoyed huff. Adora smiled affectionately, exchanging a look with Bow.

Their teacher walked in, a few minutes late. She had icy blue hair that tumbled down her side that contrasted perfectly with her skin. A dark haired child ran in after her as she tumbled papers and a bag on the desk.

"Sorry I'm late, I don't live on campus."

Adora nodded at the explanation, eyes landing on the young girl who climbed into the teacher's chair.

"Call me Netossa, none of that 'Miss' or 'Mrs' nonsense. Refer to me as that and I won't respond to you."

The class was a bit stunned by the blunt tone, and Adora had the feeling Netossa was a new teacher this year.

"Most of you probably know my wife, Spinnerella."

Sounds of recognition were audible from around the classroom.

"She may be soft on you guys, but I plan on winning the Teacher's Award this year, and not even she is going to stop me."

Adora looked across at Glimmer, who made a face.

"This is Frosta. She's our daughter, and we couldn't find a suitable babysitter, so now she's here with us."

The class nodded slowly and Adora wondered how professional this 'institution' really was.

"Alright, let's get into it. Everyone pull out your copies of Frankenstein."

Adora grabbed the slim book from her bag. It was a play adaption of the real thing, but somehow the script format was even more entertaining than regular words. It painted a scene in her mind, described the image more accurately and succinctly than flowery words and poetic language devices. A lot simpler to understand and digest then the actual novel.

"Let's kick off with a discussion, shall we? That's what English is for."

Adora never experienced discussions in her English sessions with Shadow Weaver. Every time she mentioned an opinion that didn't align with Weaver's she was-

Well, she didn't feel like thinking about that now.

Netossa pulled out an electronic wand from her disheveled bag, and a copy of the novel, colorful tabs and notes peeking out of it. She turned on the electronic whiteboard and scribbled the word 'FRANKENSTEIN' before circling it.

"I'll start us off. As you should all know, the Creature is an unnatural being Victor Frankenstein made by stitching together organs of various animals and pumping a heartbeat. To some, including myself 'Creature is not an organic entity.'

Netossa drew out the words on the whiteboard, the wand stretching it out as she wrote. She turned around to face the class.

"Do we all agree."

She twirled the wand in her hand, eyes scanning everyone in the room.

"Come on, don't be shy."

She was about to call on someone, when Catra stuck her hand in the air.

"Yes, you. What's your name?"

"Catra Brightmoon."

Netossa's eyes lightened at the last name, and Glimmer huffed softly in the corner.

"Alright Catra, what do you think."

"Creature was shortly abandoned right after Victor saw him. Anyone who has faced that is practically doomed to become a revenge seeking murderer. It's like De Lacey said, Creature wasn't born inorganic or evil per say, he was purely a product of experience."

Catra leaned back and Netossa smiled, writing down nearly every word Catra spoke. The girl tilted her head to the side, and Adora swear she caught her eye. Were her words directed at Adora in some way? No, they couldn't be, it was about a completely irrelevant subject.

Abandoned.

The word echoed in her head, and before Adora could think twice her hand was raised in the air.

"Oh? I do love a good English debate. What's your name?"

"Adora Gray"

Netossa smiled, placing her hands on the desk.

"What do you have to say, Adora?"

Adora let the words roll off her tongue without thinking, ignoring the glare Catra was shooting her.

"I can agree that Victor made Creature and shortly abandoned him, but it's unjust to just give Creature excuses for his wrongdoings. De Lacey himself was an old man blinded through a traumatic event, and yet he still offered Creature a home and welcomed him. Creature didn't repay him with the same kindness, and just murdered him. It's like excusing every single mean person for their cruel actions because of their past trauma. Yes, it played a part, but it doesn't justify their deeds."

She said the last two sentences directly at Catra, mimicking the girl in her position on the chair. The dark blue and topaz met Adora's soft grey, and the two had to be reminded of the class' presence.

"Well said, Adora."

Netossa finished writing the last of Adora's words, encouraging more discussion from the rest of the class. But Adora had already tuned out, eyes falling on the girl sitting in front of her.

"I was thinking of having you write up individual essays tomorrow and rotating partners for feedback...But Adora and Catra's thoughts gave me a new idea."

Adora looked up at the clock, realizing they only had a few minutes left before she could head back to the dorm.

"Tomorrow I'd like you to work in pairs, writing a collaborative essay. I want the class to get to know each other a bit better before we break out properly into the story."

Adora glanced worriedly at Bow and Glimmer, wondering if they could maybe work in a group of three when Netossa interrupted her thoughts.

"Oh, and don't even bother setting up your own pairs. I'll be assigning them."

Adora groaned inwardly, she didn't want to socialize anymore. Two friends were enough, she didn't really need anymore...okay,

perhaps just one more. Then it'd be perfect.

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Keep The Gay at Bay

Adora was up bright and early before her alarm had even gone off. Was she tired? Absolutely. But that was nothing adrenaline couldn't fix. She had the whole day in front of her, and needed to surpass it.

"Adora go back to sleep, it's five what the fuck?"

Glimmer stuffed her face into a pillow, and Adora dodged the one that was violently flung at her. Adora was actually tired the previous day, she'd only woken up at six. But today was brighter, and easier to tackle. She pulled on a pair of sleek black leggings, a sports bra, and tied the soft school sports crewneck around her waist for when she finished her run. Quickly knotting her hair into a ponytail and pulling on a cap, Adora quietly left the room. Glimmer would murder her if she interrupted her precious princess sleep again.

Adora chuckled to herself as she walked, enjoying the lack of people and silence that surrounded her. It wasn't calming or anything like that, but at least she didn't feel the need to appease anyone. It was just her, and the wind.

She should've been more concerned about getting lost, but she'd figure it out. The nearby woods looked peaceful enough, she was fairly certain she wouldn't get mauled by an animal...Hopefully.

The run was refreshing, it actually cleared her headspace. Adora secretly wished she was able to do more physical activity living with Shadow Weaver, but early morning wake ups were purely reserved for study sessions. She drifted back to the dorm rooms, checking the time to see she still had an hour to kill before her first class. Maybe she'd smash out some revision, or she can try to get Glimmer out of the bed before first bell. Definitely the latter. It took a solid twenty minutes just to get the girl to wake up. Stretching out her legs as she walked, Adora crossed the gym. She poked her head in out of curiosity, even though she didn't

really know how any of the machines worked. If no one was in there, she could experiment.

But, unfortunately, somebody was.

Adora spotted a figure in the corner skipping with an electronic rope. She didn't know who it was, but their general frame was quite slender.

Trying her best to be subtle, Adora hopped on a nearby treadmill, hoping to sneak a glance at the person.

"Hey, Adora."

The voice paused her train of thought, and Adora spun around in shock.

"Catra?"

Fully facing the girl, Adora couldn't help but catch a glance at her body. A slight flush to her skin, Catra was sleek and thin. Adora quickly looked away, heat rising to her cheeks.

"You're up early."

"I could say the same to you."

Catra shrugged, grabbing a water bottle from one of the nearby dispensers and gulping it down. Adora tried her hardest not to stare.

"You're staring."

Catra calmly placed the water bottle next to a sweat towel, her eyes flicking up as Adora fumbled.

"I was not!"

She scoffed and Catra raised an eyebrow.

"Today was a once off, you know better than anyone I hate mornings."

Adora was surprised she even acknowledged their past. Catra seemed to be the epitome of mood swings.

One minute she was slapping her, and the next she was flirting. Well, she didn't know what to really consider flirting, surely this wasn't it.

"So, why all the energy today?"

Catra stretched out her arms above her head, and Adora stared at the wall in front of her.

"Couldn't sleep."

Her voice shifted, even raspier in the morning, and Catra carefully slid her hair out of the twin braids, shaking out her roots.

"Well, uh, I'll leave you to it."

Catra leaned against the handle of the treadmill, looking up at Adora.

"Not feeling the run anymore?"

"Nah, I need to get ready."

Catra nodded, slowly walking back to her own area of the gym.

"Bye Adora," Catra picked up her skipping rope again.

"Have fun skipping!"

Adora hurriedly left the room before she felt the temptation to look at Catra again.

Bad Adora, keep the gay at bay. She probably isn't even lesbian, and if she was she wouldn't like you.

Adora face palmed herself, Catra wasn't even her friend, let alone a romantic interest.

"Snap out of it, Adora. No distractions."

She chided herself, stepping into the room and picking up Glimmer's discarded pillow, whacking the girl with it.

"Get up!"

Glimmer was faster than Adora's eyes could detect, grabbing the taller girl and stuffing her face into the bed hard.

"No one disturbs Glimmer's beauty rest!"

Adora groaned, pushing Glimmer away and yanking her head up.

"Come on, we're gonna be late to English if you don't get up."

"Then be late."

Adora rolled her eyes, knowing it wasn't her responsibility and she should probably leave Glimmer to her fate. But she didn't.

_____

Forty five minutes they were sitting in the cafeteria, Adora digging into her plate.

"Woah, yesterday you could barely eat an apple."

Bow watched in fascination as Adora scarfed down the pancakes and syrup.

"I'm hungry!"

Bow laughed, but it quickly faded as he glanced over at Glimmer, who was staring sullenly at the door.

"Look what the cat dragged in."

Adora paused in her eating to watch Catra and her group of friends enter the cafeteria. She nearly spat out her mouthful of pancake when she got a good look at Catra.

Her plaid pleated skirt and socks were exchanged for a pair of slim navy trousers. Her silk white shirt buttoned down a bit lower than required, and the tie hung around her neck. She'd ditched the pristine pearl headband today, her hair loose and messy with a few waves from the braids she had in during her workout. The sharp black nails gleamed as she adjusted her bag, not even glancing at Adora's table.

Adora felt like a troll in her own uniform, much preferring the comfy crewneck and shorts she wore for P.E the day earlier.

"You can't say she doesn't have style."

Glimmer jabbed Bow as he murmured into his plate of eggs, and Adora heard a muffled yelp.

"She hasn't eaten in the cafeteria a single day in her life, why now?"

Maybe it's because of me.

Adora shooed away the thought, she wasn't even on Catra's radar.

"Who are her friends?"

Adora looked around at them. The tall burly one was called Rogelio, she knew that, and she recognized the one with green eyes in English class yesterday.

The buff one is Rogelio, the short scary one Lonnie, and the skinny one is Kyle. He's like attached to this creepy parrot, Imp. I've literally never seen him without it."

Glimmer snickered beside him.

"Shut up."

Adora looked at them, her interest snagged from the group for a few seconds.

"What? What is it?"

"Kyle had a crush on Bow last year, it was hilarious. Catra threw a fit when she found out at the Annual Gala."

"Gala?"

"It's this lame event Mum throws every year, with all the parents and faculty. The only fun part is dressing up and I get to see my dad."

Adora could tell now wasn't the time to ask about Glimmer's father.

"Sounds fun."

"It's at the end of this year, so you'd have to start getting dress fittings pretty soon."

Her eyes widened at that, a whole year just to make a dress? Then again, she thought about the mass of orders designers must be getting everyday, it made sense you'd have to wait so long for a custom order.

Bow squealed and pulled out his bedazzled diary, marking the date on the calendar. Adora rolled her eyes affectionately, eyes momentarily away from the small group sitting at the centre of the cafe.

"Catra has won 'Best Dressed' every damn year, I'm starting to think it's rigged."

"You're definitely right Bow. DT has the best outfits every single time, and yet Catra still snags the title. It's like she has everyone in a stupid trance."

Glimmer stabbed her sausage with a fork and Bow nodded.

"Do you have any photos of her outfits?"

Adora wanted to see what was so good to win Best Dressed every single year. Glimmer quickly pulled out her phone, handing it to Adora with Catra's Instagram Page.

Adora scrolled through.

"Whoa, she has a lot of followers."

"I'm surprised she's not verified."

Adora didn't bother asking what that meant, clicking on various photos of Catra with her friends and a few recent ones of her and a jet black car.

"A birthday gift from Dad."

Glimmer breathed over her shoulder as Adora moved through the posts.

"Do you have an expensive car like that?"

"Yeah, a pastel pink Jeep. Mum got it covered in glitter for me, but it's sitting in the family garage at home."

She huffed and Adora couldn't believe she didn't truly realize just how rich Glimmer's family was. She should've figured by the sheer size of the castle itself, but somehow it never crossed her mind.

"You havn't even scrolled down far enough to see last year's Gala photos, you're just stalking her."

Adora shushed her, moving through Christmas and various sponsored posts.

"Is she like an influencer, or something?"

"No, just a hot rich girl people like to follow."

Glimmer fired Bow a look as Adora kept scrolling through.

"I'm going to look through your feed next, you know that right?"

Glimmer groaned.

"We're going to be here forever, Adora! Just get Instagram yourself."

Adora blushed, finally finding some Gala pictures and clicking them.

"No one would follow me."

"You already have two, and your follower count means nothing. "

Adora knew that was bullshit, Glimmer was just trying to be nice.

"Maybe," she hummed to appease her.

Looking back down at the phone, Adora examined the outfit. She didn't know much about fashion, but as far as she could judge, Catra looked damn good. Expensive print tights worn under a rich maroon suit, and satin heels to match. A flowery black bralette that was etched into the shape of a classic corset, and a deep cut loose suit jacket to match. Her hair was held up in a tight ponytail, longer than what it was now with rich dark waves tumbling down her back.

"I don't know Glim, she does look pretty good."

Glimmer scoffed as Adora passed the phone back.

"No, you're just gay and horny."

Adora blushed, but didn't fight the comment.

"Show me your page."

Glimmer clicked on her profile and handed Adora the phone.

"What are you going on about, you have nearly as many followers as Catra!"

Glimmer blushed, twirling her hair with her hand.

"Show me Bow's."

"Adora, you've gone mad, she's Instagram obsessed."

She really was. She scrolled through Bow's profile as they walked to English. He didn't have half as many followers as Glimmer and Catra, but he was still very popular.

"We mostly just drag followers in because of our parents."

Adora realized she never enquired about Bow.

"Who are your's Bow?"

"George and Lance Hart."

Adora's organs nearly melted on the spot. Those names, she very much recognized.

"George and Lance fucking Hart? As in the most widely known philosophers and historians. They own like five of the world's best museums."

"Adora, you're going to shatter my eardrum."

Adora didn't even care that people were staring at her as they passed.

"Why did you say historians like that?"

"Like what?"

"hiStOriAanSs."

Adora laughed with Bow at Glimmer's impersonation, all three of them walking into the classroom, only slightly late.

"Sit down boys and girls, we have a lot to get through."

"Where's Frosta?"

Catra's friend, Lonnie, spoke up.

"She's with Spinny for the day, we take turns."

Netossa grabbed her wand and turned around, writing something up on the board.

"Loneliness and detachment from others will inevitably lead humans to despair and tragedy, as shown in the text 'Frankenstein.' Discuss."

Adora quickly scribbled the essay topic in her book, awaiting further instructions.

She started writing a list of names up on the board, copying it down from a piece of paper.

Bow and Peekablue

Glimmer and Starla

Kyle and Jewelstar

Lonnie and Brightwind

Catra and -

Adora paused, fighting the urge to bang her head on the table.

Well shit.

Catra's Hot.

"Netossa, I don't think Catra and I will be very productive, why don't you switch me with someone else?"

Netossa raised her eyebrows as Adora timidly looked down.

"On the contrary Adora, I think you'll collaborate perfectly together."

"Our ideas clashed yesterday."

Netossa smiled slightly at her, eyes darting to Catra before meeting back with Adora's.

"That's exactly why I paired you together."

Adora tried not to huff in her presence, but she was annoyed. Severely annoyed.

"Listen, if it's really not working out and you're both able to find people to switch with, maybe I'll let you off. But not without you two giving it a shot."

Adora nodded, some hope filling back into her. Catra was at her desk, leaning back and watching everyone in their separate discussions. Adora hesitantly sat down next to her, inching away slightly.

"I won't bite, you know."

"No, but you scratch."

Adora's hand grazed her cheek, the cuts still visible. Catra looked down at her long black nails before glancing sideways at Adora.

"The scratch suits you, makes you look...wilder."

There was a sharp glint in the gold eye Adora could see and she fought the urge too blush.

Did she just compliment me?

Not the time Adora, you have work to do.

She quickly peeled back the cover of the book, not wanting to prolong the look Catra was giving her.

"Come on, this is due tomorrow."

She kept Netossa's promise in the back of her head. Tough it out until the end of the lesson, then you get to switch.

"Relax, that's plenty of time."

Adora looked at her.

"If you expect me to do all the work-"

"When did I ever say that?"

Adora's face heated in slight embarrassment. Catra was right, she never actually said it, but that's pretty much the way things worked in the orphanage. Catra would laze around while Adora completed Shadow Weaver's homework, yet she still managed to get nearly the same marks as Adora. Catra was just unusually smart, sort of an underrated genius. Yet Adora still managed to win the attention and favor of teachers. Catra didn't mind though, preferred to sit back in the shadows then share the burden of acknowledgment.

"You didn't."

"Exactly. I'm not dumb Adora."

"I never said that."

"Well you damn thought it."

She hadn't, she never thought Catra to be dumb. Lazy at times, yes, but never stupid.

"Let's just get this done with."

"You know, if you think I'm so ignorant, then you probably should do the work yourself."

"Catra I don't think your ignorant."

Adora struggled to keep her voice as a decent level, becoming increasingly frustrated with the female next to her.

"Yeah, sure Adora."

Adora sighed, trying her best to stay calm.

1...2...3...4

"We'll never finish this essay if we keep going like this, let's just...try."

Catra huffed, but she leaned on the desk, albeit reluctantly. At least that was something. Adora tried her hardest to ignore the way the loose shirt ruffled on her chest as she leaned forward, keeping her eyes strictly on the book in front of her.

"Okay, should we highlight the key words first?"

Catra shrugged at her.

"I guess."

Adora pulled out a blue highlighter, placing a colorful strip on 'loneliness,' 'detachment,' 'inevitably,' 'humans,' 'despair', tragedy' and 'discuss.'

"What do you think?"

Adora tried her hardest to communicate, but it was hard. At least Catra was finally starting to cooperate.

"Well I guess it depends on how we define 'despair' and 'tragedy'. Like that's pretty ambiguous."

Adora nodded, agreeing with her as she wrote down the words and handed Catra the pen.

"You write down your definitions, I'll write down mine, and then we can compare."

Catra took the pen offered and Adora dutifully ignored the spark she felt as their fingers brushed.

Adora grabbed another pen and tapped it against her chin as the words drifted around her. What was despair? Well in the story, Victor, a mad genius scientist, was so mentally isolated he fell into a hole of obsession and power. That could define despair, being alone in thought. Adora quickly jotted it down, a few more thoughts popping up. Tragedy was a more complex one. She'd generally thought of it like a sad ending to a story. A doomed end.

"I'm done."

Adora roughly drafted a few more notes and exchanged books with Catra. She looked down at the words in a messy (yet elegant?) cursive.

Despair is the broken promises and hope which was shattered by multiple characters in the text. Creature held hope in a relationship with Victor, and later with the female creature (one Victor made to be Creature's wife before brutally killing). Tragedy is how despair affects animals (yes, humans are animals). Both Creature and Victor ultimately end up in a tragic situation, due to the despair they've faced in the story.

They both looked up at one another at the same time, and Adora awkwardly coughed into her hand.

"I like your ideas, we should use them."

"We can combine it, just write both. They'll blend together somehow."

Adora nodded, the bell ringing for the end of class. Netossa eyed her with a knowing smile as she walked out of the class.

"We have to get this done by tomorrow, so why don't we just work on it tonight?"

Catra looked thoughtful before slowly nodding her head. The tightness in Adora's chest eased slightly. Maybe this could be a second crack at being friends?

"I'll meet you in Thaymor Library at six."

Adora nodded, elation slowly beginning to consume her.

Keep it together Adora. She's literally only doing this because you're forced to work together.

She walked off, and Adora hugged her books to her chest.

"How was working with the demon?"

"Not as bad as I predicted."

Bow nodded, a suspicious look in his eye. Adora turned to suddenly be faced with Glimmer. She jumped back instinctively, almost dropping her supplies.

"How on earth do you manage to do it every time?"

Glimmer just laughed as Adora steadied herself.

"Come on, we have to get to class."

Adora actually didn't mind her next class, it was Textiles. Shadow Weaver had allowed her to take one subject she was never able to do while being tutored, so she chose Textiles. In hindsight, it wasn't the most suited subject for Adora, but she wanted to try something different.

"What do you guys have?"

Glimmer responded with Art, while Bow answered with Physics.

"You got Textiles, right?"

Adora nodded, a strange combination of nerves and excitement rising inside of her.

"You'll get Ms Ella, she's way nicer than Netossa."

"I don't mind Netossa. I think her teaching style suits English."

It was true, Adora found herself exploring her own ideas and actually enjoying English as compared to learning it from Shadow Weaver. Her old teacher used to just rattle of quotes and tell her to shut up if she argued a different opinion to her.

"I guess, but she scares me."

Adora paused in front of her classroom, checking to see if it matched the one listed on her timetable.

"I get what you mean."

Confirming that she was at the right door, Adora said her farewells to her friends and nervously tugged, opening up to the most gorgeous room she'd ever seen. The whole castle was beautiful, but this room was pure art.

Soft lilac drapes framed the ornate silver windows, the ceiling brushed with swirls of grey. There was no whiteboard, but rather sketches of gowns scattered on various pin boards, and sewing machines set up on a separate table. Adora glanced at the corner, where fabrics of every color were stacked on one another neatly. As she continued to step through as lavender filled her senses, and soft music played behind her. It was as if she'd stepped into a little creative bubble, separate from the entirety of the school.

"Good Morning, you must be Adora."

Adora was one of the first to arrive, and she smiled awkwardly at the short woman in front of her. Ms Ella, Bow and Glimmer had said her name was. She was a contrast to Netossa, soft loose waves of purple framing her rosy face and milky eyes.

"Morning."

Adora scanned the room nervously, searching for a back corner to hide in. She didn't fit in here at all. She wasn't delicate or soft, not artistic or-

"Welcome back Catra."

Her thoughts froze and Adora felt like banging her head against a wall. Of fucking course Catra was in Textiles. If there was one thing Adora remembered, it was Catra snipping bits of fabric from Shadow Weaver's gown when she wasn't looking. She used to make a small collection of scrap fabrics and glue them together in an attempt to make clothing.

"Adora? You took Textiles?"

Catra didn't sound judgmental, but Adora's face still heated up as she got defensive.

"Why does everyone keep saying that?"

She threw her hands up in exasperation and Catra quirked an eyebrow, moving past her to sit next to-

"Double Trouble?"

Catra looked between them in surprise.

"You two know each other?"

Adora gaped at them.

"You two know each other?"

Double Trouble clapped their hands together in excitement.

"Oh! I know what to say. You two know each other?"

Adora took the seat opposite them as other students started coming in. Double Trouble wasn't exactly her friend, but they'd helped her beat Glimmer in dodgeball. Catra didn't argue as Adora sat down, and Adora felt the tiniest shred of hope open up. Rest assured, that was quickly smothered as Catra turned slightly away from her.

The second bell rang, signaling the beginning of class, and Adora looked around in surprise. The room was spacious, but there were only around ten or so students.

"Alright, before we begin, I'd like to clarify that I will be winning Teacher of the Month, okay?"

Adora stifled a laugh, it seemed Ms Ella wasn't as nice as Glimmer and Bow told her.

"Oh, and that's my daughter, Frosta."

Adora only just realized the quiet blue hair child twisting the fabric of the curtains.

Ms Ella started running through the basics of the sewing machine; how to thread a bobbin, do a top stitch, and sew in a straight line. Adora was mesmerized at how she effortlessly stitched a makeshift flower on a piece of calico fabric.

"We'll start running through the course content next week, your first project will be creating your own camisole, nothing too big. For the remainder of this week, we'll keep practicing the basics. Some of you will breeze through, this being your second year in Textiles, but others will need to find their feet a bit."

Adora blushed, looking down at her fingers.

"Don't worry, darling, we've all been there."

DT winked at her and Adora smiled. Catra hadn't said a word to her since the start of the lesson, apparently absorbed in her sewing machine.

"What's got you knotted up, kitten?"

Adora nearly sewed through her finger at the nickname, but she bit her tongue. She knew that DT had spoken loud enough for Adora to hear, they wanted drama it seemed. Glimmer had warned her of that.

"Drop it, DT." Catra didn't miss a beat, snipping the thread connecting her cloth to her machine and lifting it up to the light. She stuck out her tongue in concentration and Adora felt the strange urge to take a photo.

I need help.

"Meow, someone has their claws out today."

DT seemed to have partially abandoned their project for the day, the square of calico fabric sitting idly on the machine. Instead they pulled out a large sketchbook, flipping it open to a fresh page. They caught Adora as she watched and winked, placing a finger to their lips.

"Spinny may throw a fit, so don't tell."

Adora nodded slightly, looking back down to examine her stitching. It still wasn't quite right, the lines a bit crooked. She was about to raise her hand for Ms Ella when she remembered DT. If Ms Ella came over, she'd likely notice that DT had swapped sewing for sketching, and she didn't want to ruin the one tentative friendship she held in this class. She'd just have to try and figure it out.

"Go on kitten, go help your girlfriend-"

DT interrupted themself.

"Oops, my bad. Go help your friend."

Adora paused, glancing up to see a silent conversation occurring between the two. Catra was glaring at them while DT only offered a delicious smile.

"She's not my friend," Catra gritted out. Adora felt a bit awkward, just sitting there watching their little exchange happen.

"Oh, even more delectable."

"Double Trouble," Catra warned.

"The poor girl is dying for help."

Catra turned back to her project, rotating the fabric around as she quickly accelerated on the machine. She was going so hard and fast that the whole table was shaking.

"Why don't you go and help her then."

"Actually, I'll just figure-"

"Hush child, Mommy Catra will help."

Both Adora and Catra turned the darkest shade of red imaginable, and Catra quickly stopped, her foot off the pedal.

Catra abruptly reached over and ripped DT's design from their sketchbook, ignoring the shouts of protest from the designer. She stood in front of them and dangled it in front of them, clearly about to rip it.

"Go ahead, I'll make another."

Catra huffed angrily, throwing the paper down on the desk like a petulant child. Ms Ella was finally drawn over to the table due to the noise they were making.

"Everything alright here?"

DT quickly slipped the piece of paper on the floor as Ms Ella looked to Adora.

"Actually-"

"We're perfect Ms Ella, don't worry you pretty little head."

"DT, I thought we talked about this." Ms Ella scolded them, but her tone was light.

"Catra was just about to help Adora with her sewing, she needs a bit of assistance."

Ms Ella looked at them and smiled knowingly. Adora vaguely wondered if maybe she'd already heard about her from her wife.

"Wonderful, I'll leave you to it then."

She walked off to the next table, and now both Catra and Adora stared daggers at DT.

"What? Were you not just about to help her?"

Catra opened her mouth to object before just giving in. She pushed herself out of her seat, switching off her machine and walking around to Adora's side. Adora didn't know why she felt jumpy and anxious, maybe it was because Catra was acting as if she was about to set the world on fire.

Catra leaned on the vacant chair next to Adora, gesturing for her to move over. Adora quickly obliged, a tiny bit terrified by the look in Catra's eyes.

"When you're sewing something on the edge of the fabric, like a hem, it's easy. You just make sure the edge of the fabric stays against this line."

She pointed to an etched line on the base of the machine and Adora nodded. Catra did a few stitches to show her before sliding the machine back to Adora.

"Try it."

Adora nervously fumbled under the watchful gaze of Catra, trying her best to concentrate.

"Adora! Concentrate!"

Adora shooed Catra away, watching her swing the chair and sit backwards on it.

"Yeah, Adora, concentrate."

Adora shot a glare at Double Trouble's tone, slowly stitching a line down the fabric. She finished, cutting the strings and handing it to Catra, who nodded.

"Good. Now if you're stitching in the centre of the fabric, that's a bit more difficult." Adora shuffled the machine over to Catra, but the girl frowned.

"No, you won't figure it out by watching me."

Adora ignored DT's not so subtle glances at them in between the strokes of their pencil. Before Adora knew what was happening she was engulfed in the scent of musk and mint. It was an odd pairing, but yet intoxicating. Something she'd never thought as addicting. That was before she realized it was coming from Catra.

Catra who was practically wrapped around her, her sleeves slightly rolled up to expose the start of her forearms. Adora tried not to visibly gulp.

"We were never really taught this, but I like to keep the edge of the foot in line with something directly in front of you, like that painting."

Focussing on the art in front of her rather than the art behind her was about the hardest mission to accomplish. The scent, the soft tickle of her hair, and the voice. It was starting to get a bit warm

in the classroom. Adora feared what would happen if she even slightly tilted her head to look at her.

"Go."

It took Adora a few seconds to realize Catra was referring to the peddle under her foot, and she quickly stepped on it. The fabric quickly got eaten up by the machine, and Catra chuckled.

"Not so fast, go slower."

Adora nodded, eyeing the Vivienne Westwood pearl necklace she knew Catra got for her birthday last year. It was in one of her Instagram posts.

She pushed down a bit lighter, and Catra nodded at the pace.

Adora nearly lost it when her hands covered her own, and she guided her. Catra softly reminded her to watch the painting, and Adora absentmindedly nodded, feeling Catra's loose tie tickle her neck as she leaned back. Slowly releasing a pent up breath, Adora murmured her thanks, and Catra shifted back to her seat next to DT.

"Such a chore to help, isn't it kitten?"

"Yes. Yes it is," Catra deadpanned.

———————

Sparkles, Arrows and Poof

Adora flipped open her copy of Frankenstein, brushing up on her ideas before she met with Catra when a soft knock sounded against the door. She looked to Glimmer in confusion, and Glimmer hesitantly placed her MacBook down, looking back at Adora when the knock sounded again.

"Should we call Bow and ask him if he invited someone?"

"Just open it, with a knock as quiet as that they won't do any harm."

Adora obliged, opening the door to reveal a tall slender woman, pink and lilac hair knotted into a messy bun and sunglasses perched on her head.

"Uh...Can I help you?"

Adora glanced down at her outfit, a gentle flowing burgundy dress that contrasted well against her pale skin.

"Mum!"

Adora watched Glimmer tackle the woman into a hug, and suddenly noticed the resemblance. Matching hair and eyes, how did she never realize the Angella Brightmoon was right in front of her.

"Glimmer!"

The woman hugged her daughter tight before gently releasing her to take a good look.

"I havn't seen you since Christmas, have you grown?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes and Adora quietly moved to step away when Glimmer caught her hand.

"You've been too busy with that movie."

Glimmer gently let go of Adora, but glanced at her, telling her to stay put with her eyes.

"Yes, well, I found an opportunity to sneak away."

"Any spoilers?"

Angella tipped her head back and laughed. Adora was still in shock at her sheer presence. Her skin seemed to glow, she was the embodiment of her name. A literal angel.

"No, Glimmer. The script's been written, and the characters are cast, but we're still setting up production. I just had to sneak away to see you and Catra before you got into the thick of it, exams and all."

Glimmer frowned slightly at Catra's name, the change so small yet Angella caught on quickly.

"I know you two aren't very close, but I was hoping I could take you out, my treat."

"I'll come, as long as Bow and Adora can come."

Adora was about to refuse, she wasn't going to trample on their outing when Glimmer hadn't seen her mum since Christmas.

"You must be Adora?"

"Hi! Pleasure to meet you."

Adora waved her hand frantically and Glimmer slapped it down. Angella smiled at Adora, but wasn't overjoyed with Glimmer's suggestion.

"Alright, if that's all it'll take to convince you. I'd like to get to know you, Adora. I've only ever seen Glimmer with Bow."

Adora's eyebrows raised in shock, she turned to Glimmer. She knew Bow and her were best friends, but she didn't know he was her only one.

"Yeah, yeah, I'm not a social butterfly like you mom, I get it. We'll go get ready while you go visit Catra."

Angella opened her mouth to object, but Glimmer had already pushed her out the door and shut it tight.

"Your mom is so cool."

Glimmer rolled her eyes, walking past her to her Walk In Closet.

"Yeah. She is."

Adora frowned, maybe Glimmer didn't have the best relationship with Angella?

"What are you going to wear?"

Glimmer tapped her chin, looking at the array of clothes. Adora had like two pairs of pants and five shirts, but Glimmer's closet was a whole shopping centre. She didn't dare to think what her wardrobe at her actual home would look like.

"Knowing Mom, we'll go to some fancy restaurant."

Adora started to feel anxious, she definitely didn't have the attire for a 'fancy restaurant.'

"Relax, you can borrow something from my closet."

Adora sighed in temporary relief.

"Thanks."

Glimmer skimmed through the various sections, pulling clothes out before putting them back. She handed Adora a few options, blankly instructing her to try they on with a few pairs of shoes.

Adora blindly obeyed while Glimmer continued searching for an outfit for herself.

She stepped out in a cherry red dress, the light shifting the colour to a berry pink when she stepped out. She pulled on a pair of gold sandals and twirled in front of Glimmer.

"Whatcha think?"

"It looks great on you, you should keep it."

Adora frowned. Ever since her mom had come, Glimmer seemed a bit flat.

"Hey, this'll be fun. You havn't seen your mom in ages, won't it feel nice to catch up?"

Glimmer took a deep breath and smiled, turning towards Adora.

"You're right, I havn't seen mom in ages."

She paused, about to say something when her eyes flicked down to look at the dress. She smiled lightly, meeting her eyes again.

"You really do look great, keep the dress."

Adora brushed off the comment, knowing Glimmer will eventually want it back. Pulling out a soft tulle shirt, a pastel blue cardigan and white dress shorts, Glimmer headed to the bathroom to get ready, while Adora went to let Bow know about their sudden plans.

"Bow?"

She knocked on the door and Bow quickly opened it, scanning her outfit.

"What's the dress up for?"

"Angella visited, she wants us to come out with her."

Adora conveniently forgot to mention that it was really Glimmer who invited the two of them.

"Angella? I thought she was working on that new movie."

Adora shrugged. "I think she was able to sneak in a break."

"Oh, in that case, I'll get ready. I have heaps to catch up on with Angella."

Adora looked at him in amusement. He had plenty to catch up with her?

"Be quick, I think Glim's nearly ready."

Bow nodded and Adora wandered back into her and Glimmer's room, sitting on her bed.

Oh, shit.

She glanced down at the Frankenstein book, remembering her and Catra's evening plans to bang out the essay. Should she stay and let Catra go?

Right at that instant, Glimmer stepped out, hiking on a pair of matching blue boots.

"You look great, Glim."

"Thanks. You know what, you're right. This will be fun, just mom catching up with us and meeting you."

She grabbed a compact and a deep purple eyeliner, quickly putting on some eye makeup. She gestured to Adora soundlessly, but Adora shook her head.

"Come on, just a tinsy bit of mascara?"

Adora sighed, she supposed she had to match the dress.

"Oh, alright, give it."

Glimmer smirked, tossing the small tube to her, and Adora headed to the bathroom to carefully apply some. Shadow Weaver didn't let her have any makeup, but that never prevented a prepubescent Adora from playing around with Weaver's products. She capped the wand and put it back in Glimmer's makeup bag

"And here I was thinking you couldn't get hotter."

"I'm starting to really wonder whether you're crushing on Bow, or me?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"I'm a supportive friend, what can I say?"

Adora was about to grab the keys when her eyes snagged on the book laying on her bed for a second time. She'd almost forgotten to mention that to Glimmer.

"Oh, Catra and I were meant to work on our English thing tonight."

"You didn't finish most of it in class?"

"We were too busy arguing."

Glimmer rolled her eyes while Adora continued.

"I'd better stay home and finish-"

"Nuh uh. You don't get to stay home and do all the work. I want you and Bow to be there Adora."

Adora sighed painfully. She couldn't leave an assignment incomplete, or hand it in late. It'd ruin her record. Right as she was going to break it to Glimmer, the door knocked again.

"I hope you all are ready, we have a reservation. Adora, Catra told me about your issue, and it's all sorted. As principal, it was easy to pull through an extension for you."

Adora promptly shut her mouth, glad that she was able to complete her work on time as well as support Glimmer. She didn't know why her friend was so tense, but it wasn't her business to pry into.

"We'll stop by to pick up Catra. I believe she's bringing along a friend as well."

"Great, we have to deal with Catra and Lonnie."

"Glimmer," Angella used a warning tone. She paused by a dorm door and knocked, simultaneously pulling out a phone and dialing a number. The door swung open to reveal Catra in a loose maroon suit, hands adorned in rings and ears with delicate studs. Her headband had been taken out, messy bangs blowing in the slight wind of the corridor. The blue and gold eyes roamed over each of them.

"Sparkles. Arrows, and...."

Her eyes darted to the top of Adora's head.

"Poof."

Adora glanced up, trying to look at her hair before realizing she couldn't see it.

Angella hung up the phone, pocketing it as Catra called out to her companion.

"DT, hurry up!"

All three of them glanced at each other in surprise. Why didn't Catra invite Lonnie?

Double Trouble stepped into view, looking as fabulous as ever in a striped emerald jumpsuit.

"Let's roll."

The Crimson Waste

Catra dragged Double Trouble out, the pair of them walking in front while Bow, Glimmer and Adora tried to discreetly whisper to one another.

"Where's Lonnie?"

"Did they have a fight?"

"Why'd she bring DT? I barely knew they were friends."

"They seemed close enough in Textiles, they call her 'kitten'."

"Wait, hold up. Catra's in your Textiles class, and you're only telling us now?"

"It's not that big of a deal, calm down."

Angella interrupted their conversation, pulling a pair of sunglasses out and stopping before the reached the public grounds.

"I'm just warning all of you, but I think the paps might be onto us."

Glimmer groaned.

"Why must they annoy us every single time we go out?"

"I know, they might not, but I think someone followed me on the way here. Just..be prepared, and wear these. Everyone keep your heads down and answer nothing, especially you two."

She looked at DT and Adora.

"Why us?"

Glimmer answered for her.

"You're fresh meat. They'll literally bash you with questions, answer nothing. Don't even make eye contact."

Adora nodded dutifully, she definitely didn't want Shadow Weaver picking up that she was going out to dinner on a school night. Hopefully she won't even realize, Weaver despises the media and all forms of it. She claims they twisted her into some sort of villain when she lost her job.

They got into a black SUV parked on the side of the strip, and instantly Glimmer handed each of them each a freshly packaged pair of all black sunglasses.

"Don't take them off until Mom does, she'll know when."

Adora looked out of the tinted windows, the scent of fresh leather filling the air.

"Which restaurant are we going to?"

"The Crimson Waste."

Adora had never heard of it, but Adora hadn't heard of a lot of things. She'd come to discover that quite quickly.

"You'll love it Adora, the head chef is Huntara. She's won like five million awards."

Adora nodded, hoping the place was as good as Glimmer described it to be. But she'd probably be impressed, it wasn't like she had anything to compare it to.

"Catra, Glimmer, you're besties remember."

"Got it." Catra and Glimmer answered in tune, they didn't seem the slightest fazed or baffled at this. A uniform structure, a cemented routine.

"Do you guys deal with this every time you go out?"

Adora's eyes darted between the pair of them, and Catra answered her.

"Not every time, most times it's only with Mom or Dad. Sometimes they catch us during the holidays, but the boarding school does a good job of letting us have privacy."

Adora couldn't imagine it, not being able to just dress homeless and leave the house.

"They pay the bills and somehow keep us relevant though, so it's not all bad."

Adora leaned back into her seat, watching them pull up in front of a crowded, lit up restaurant.

THE CRIMSON WASTE

Words illuminated in a bold red, and a soft orange glow emanating from the inside. Adora tried to peer in the windows to get a look at the interior, but she couldn't see much.

"Thanks Juliet, we'll be done in about two hours, but I'll ring you."

The driver nodded, and Glimmer signaled for everyone to put their glasses on. Adora felt a bit like an idiot, wearing sunglasses when it was dark outside, but she did it anyway. Angella stepped out first, and the rest tentatively followed.

Almost instantly, the barrage of people came, almost like a tidal wave.

"Angella, what can you tell us about your latest project?"

"Is it true you've divorced Micah?"

"Glimmer, are you and Bow official?"

"Glimmer, Catra, who are your friends? Are they your dates, are you in a relationship?"

"Catra, rumors have spread that you wear contacts, can you confirm this?"

Outbursts of questions and shouts cut through their silence, cameras and people smothering their personal space. Angella kept a hand out, clearing a small path for them to walk through as they walked into the restaurant.

"Contacts, huh? That's a new one."

DT chuckled at Catra's murmur.

"You know, your eyes are too weird to be real. Maybe you do wear contacts."

DT looked at her suspiciously, and Catra swatted them. Adora turned her attention back on Angella, who was talking to the restaurant manager about their seats.

A middle aged man led them to a small booth towards the back of the restaurant, hidden to snooping eyes and tentative ears.

"I'll let her know you're here."

Angella thanked the man, and he left before returning with a bottle of sparkling water and a glass for each of them. Angella leaned forward, taking the sunglasses off and resting her chin on the back of her hands.

"So, how has school been?"

"Mom, it's only been like a day," Glimmer quickly shut down that route, so Angella tried another.

"Adora-"

Adora paused in her examination of the fizzy drink in front of her, quickly putting it down and looking up.

"How are you enjoying Brightmoon, it's your first year here isn't it?"

"Yes, I'm enjoying it very much."

Angella smiled, and Adora mirrored her.

"What's your favorite subject?"

There were a few, perhaps Math. She always found it easy to sync in with numbers and just zone out, but Netossa recently roped her into English. Textiles was fun, but she wasn't much good at it, and both Chemistry and Biology were plain boring. It was just part of Shadow Weavers mandatory subjects for her.

"Probably English."

She noticed Catra perk up to attention, but she didn't look at her, just calmly sipped the fizzy water.

"Why's that?"

Adora thought about it for a few seconds before responding.

"I guess I just like the fact that you're never really wrong. I mean, as long as you can justify yourself, your answer is correct."

Angella nodded thoughtfully, and Adora felt happy that Glimmer's mom didn't hate her.

"And what about you Double Trouble?"

DT wrapped a finger around a lock of blonde hair, humming in contemplation.

"I reckon Textiles, I just love the buzz of the classroom."

They snuck a look at Adora and Catra, which no one failed to notice. Adora soon felt a slight pinch from Glimmer and knew she'd have to elaborate later in the dorm.

"How's the movie going Mom?"

Catra quickly changed the topic before Angella could pick up on the energy radiating off of them.

"It's a work in progress, that about sums it up."

The girls nodded and they all awkwardly looked down at the menu. It was perfectly clear that Angella didn't really desire for Adora, Bow and DT to be there, but she seemed willing to do anything to see her daughters. Adora looked up to see a muscular woman walking over to their table, wearing a chefs hat and apron.

"Good evening diners!"

"Huntara!"

Glimmer bounced gleefully in her seat and Adora met the chef's eyes as she looked across the table.

"New guests?"

"Huntara is the head chef and owner of the restaurant, and one of my ex-colleagues."

"You used to produce movies?"

Bow looked at Angella and Huntara, who both laughed heartily.

"No boy, I used to act in movies. Back in the day, Angella was a star."

Angella swatted her hand in the day, the laughter dying on her tongue.

"Are you suggesting I've grown old and ugly?"

Huntara paused, afraid that Angella was serious, but she just broke out into laughter again.

"I'm just teasing. I much prefer the sidelines."

The entire table sat quiet as they talked, but DT seemed to be more attuned than the others.

"I love your work in Beast Island Huntara, I don't think it gets nearly as much praise as the others."

Huntara swiveled to look at DT, who held themselves in casual grace as the rest of the table gawked.

"You know, that project was one of my favorites, but no one talks about it!"

"Those amateur reporters never do their due research. You truly deserved the Oscar for your performance in that film."

Huntara smiled, looking to Angella.

"What's this one's name? I like them."

"Call me Double Trouble."

Huntara smiled at them, grabbing up the menus. Angella raised a hand to object, they didn't even discuss what they wanted, but Huntara shook her head slightly.

"Well Double Trouble, come back some time. I like your spunk kid."

Huntara winked and walked off, and Angella turned to raise an eyebrow at them.

"What? Have you never heard of networking, darling?"

Angella was clearly taken aback by the affectionate name, but she didn't comment on it.

"So you're trying to crack into the acting industry?"

DT nodded carefully, and Angella mimicked it.

"Very well, I'll keep my eye out for you."

DT looked ready to bow down to Angella at her words, but Catra looked to her friend in surprise.

"I invited you because you know how to socialize, not for acting opportunities."

Catra seemed a little distasteful towards her friend, she probably didn't like being used.

"When opportunity knocks, you don't wait kitten."

Catra rolled her eyes, and Adora turned to talk to Glimmer.

"Thanks for not telling me your entire family is famous."

Adora remembered the paparazzi, the pitch black SUV and Angella's personal connection to the head chef. Even the booth they were currently sitting in was segregated from the rest of the crowd. Glimmer's face heated up, but Adora wasn't sure why.

"Usually everyone I talk too already knows something about me. Who I am, who my mom is, who Catra is. They befriend me, use me, and then leave...It's why I don't have many friends."

"And I came to this school clueless."

Glimmer nodded, checking to make sure no one was listening to them and was involved in other conversations.

"You didn't know who anyone was, it was kind of refreshing in a way."

Adora supposed she could understand. Even if you were rich, there were disadvantages to everything. Adora didn't think she'd be able to handle that attention.

"Catra seems to enjoy people using her."

Glimmer shrugged. Catra was well known both inside and outside the school, and she was only the adopted daughter of Angella and Micah.

"I think she uses her 'friends' just as much as they use her. I don't work that way."

Adora nodded, it seemed like something Catra would do.

"Glimmer, tell me about your classes, did you take up anything new?"

"Art and P.E."

"And? Are you enjoying them?"

Glimmer sighed as steaming plates of food came out. Chicken wrapped in a steaming orange sauce, various platters of unique creations Adora had never seen before. The smell permeated the booth, but she wasn't complaining.

"Enough with the small talk, Mom."

"Glimmer!"Angella sounded exasperated, and on some level Adora felt sorry for her. But she didn't know their relationship well enough to judge, Bow would know though.

"I am trying and you want nothing to do with me!"

Angella's words were hurt, but she plated her food with expert delicateness.

"You're trying?" Glimmer laughed harshly, and angrily served herself.

"Glimmer, we're in public," Angella's murmer was so soft, but it seemed to cause an internal earthquake within their booth.

"No, don't make me look like the brat. You don't get to drop by once in six months and expect me to go batshit crazy-"

Adora noticed Bow reaching out, placing a comforting hand on Glimmer's knee. Instantly the girl softened, seeming to melt at the touch. She quietened her voice, shifting slightly in her seat.

"Are you done now?"

Glimmer looked ready to take Angella out in a boxing ring, but Bow's touch seemed to soothe her enough to nod her head.

"Good."

Adora looked down nervously at the table, unsure of how the rest of the dinner may unfold.

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Angella Brightmoon

"Argh, she's so frustrating!"

Glimmer stormed into the room like a tornado, nearly banging the door into Adora and she and Bow followed after her.

"Woah, calm down tiger."

Bow quickly moved around to get in front of her, glancing at Adora, who still didn't really understand the scope of the story.

"What's up Glim?"

She wasn't an expert at comforting people, but Bow provided the framework, kneeling in front of a slumped Glimmer on the bed.

"She just- I don't know," her voice broke and Adora exchanged a glance with Bow.

"She's just so perfect," she spat out the words like venom, and something in Adora's mind clicked.

"Everything Angella Brightmoon does is spectacular, and everything I do is a disaster!"

Bow rubbed his hand up and down her back soothingly while Adora sat down next to her.

"That's not true Glimmer."

Glimmer sighed, moving off the bed to grab a box under her bed. Adora watched in surprise, she'd never noticed that under Glimmer's bed. She pulled the lid off, chewing her lip. Adora looked down at the series of cut out newspapers, magazines and photos.

Who is Glimmer Brightmoon?

Former Star Angella Brightmoon replaces daughter with foster child.

10 Shocking Secrets about Angella Brightmoon

Catra Brighmtoon replaces Glimmer as Angella's legacy.

Glimmer Brightmoon is not Angella's daughter, here's why!

The list kept going on as Glimmer pulled out column after column.

"I'll never be her, and everyone knows it."

"That's because you're you Glimmer. You weren't born to be her."

Glimmer wiped away leaky tears, laughing half-heartedly at Bow.

"That's just a shitty way of saying 'don't even try.'" But Bow didn't laugh, just moved her hands that were covering her face. The intensity of that moment made Adora feel intrusive for watching, as if she was peeping through a neighbor's window. So she quietly stepped out, softly shutting the door behind her.

She wandered around their small common room, an area they oddly didn't spend that much time in. Because her and Glimmer's room had direct access to the entrance, they tended to hang around in there. But the small lounge was actually quite comfortable, a soft blush colored sofa draped in blankets and pillows, a clear glass coffee table, a small television and a few other pieces of small furniture scattered across the small room. Adora placed her phone on the table next to Glimmer's and sighed, leaning back into the cushions. She somewhat knew what it was like having expectations surround you. She never aspired to become Shadow Weaver, but her influence was heavily imprinted on Adora, and they both knew it.

President Adora, President Adora.

The phrase was like a mantra in her head, constantly on repeat even if she never realized it. She exhaled slowly, placing her head

in her hands. A buzz sounded on the table, and Adora looked over to see a notification on Glimmer's phone. It was from Catra.

She really shouldn't pry into her and Catra's business, but curiosity ate at her. With a quick glance at their bedroom door, Adora tentatively opened up the Instagram message.

Tell Adora I'll meet her at your dorm during the common study.

Adora quickly put down the phone, unsure whether or not Catra could see if she read the message or not. She peered down. Dammit, she could.

Adora quickly typed out 'ok' for a reply, shutting the phone off and turning it down so she wouldn't feel tempted. At least the message was harmless enough, and Glimmer would've told her anyway. Opening up her own phone, Adora quickly checked what time the common study period was.

Nine o'clock, second period. Well, at least she got it over and done with quickly. She checked her watch for the current time, realizing she shouldn't just laze around doing nothing. Being productive did wonders for distracting herself from her own lingering thoughts. Adora grabbed her glasses, pulling open her book bag to find materials.

A chapter of math homework, a lecture to watch, a novel to review, and a history essay. They were the main bits to do. Shouldn't take her more than...three hours? At least Glimmer's dress was comfortable enough to work in.

Pulling out her iPad and MacBook, Adora set to work.

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The door creaked open, and even though Adora had lo-fi music playing through her headphones, she was attune to her surroundings. One of the things Shadow Weaver always criticized her for was her inability to just zone in and focus on the task at hand, she was always preoccupied looking at everyone else.

"Hey, you feeling any better?"

She looked up to see a splotchy Glimmer smile tentatively at her from the doorway.

"Yeah, a bit."

Adora was about to ask where Bow was when Glimmer answered the question.

"Bow fell asleep, and I did too, for a bit."

Adora's eyes shifted up to Gimmer's head of messy hair, the pink and lavender strewn about in every which way and smiled in response.

"Sleep all you did, huh?"

She waggled her eyebrows suggestively and Glimmer laughed, the mood lightening a bit.

"Shut up."

The laughter quickly died down, Adora shutting off her devices (apparently done for the night) and jumping up to the couch from her place on the floor. She patted the seat next to her for Glimmer to join, wrapping a fuzzy blue blanket around herself for warmth.

"This room is nice, we should hang out here more."

Glimmer nodded, grabbing another blanket (purple for her) and gently placing it on her legs.

"So, do you wanna talk about it? I understand if you don't, like I definitely wouldn't want to talk about how Shadow-"

"Adora calm down. I do want to talk about it, that's why I came here."

Adora nodded slowly, slightly relieved she didn't have to share everything about Shadow Weaver with her just yet. Glimmer took

a deep breath before starting.

"Well, I guess you can sorta guess how I don't really think of myself as mom's daughter. Like, sure we share some features...but I don't really feel like I'm her, you know?"

Adora nodded silently.

"I don't know exactly how you feel, no one does...But I never knew my birth parents, and sometimes, I don't feel like I really belong anywhere."

Adora looked up from her fumbling to see Glimmer with tears in her eyes, lips wobbling.

"I'm sorry, I just- I don't know!"

Adora gave the girl a hug, squeezing her tight.

"Okay, I think I can pull it together now."

She took a few deep breaths and shook her head.

"Well, I never really related to my mom, but it just got worse when we took in Catra."

Adora couldn't tell too much about Catra's relationship with Angella, but she faintly remembered her calling the woman 'mom' at dinner.

"I mean, at first we were like friends, but then the school term started and well.."

Adora waited patiently.

"I don't know how or why, but she befriended Kyle, Lonnie and Rogelio. Those three weren't besties with me or anything, but I didn't think they hated me."

Adora leaned back in thought. Catra was never mean in the orphanage. She teased, got jealous and scratched, but Glimmer's

version of the story made her sound like a damn right bully.

"Well, after that we definitely weren't friends anymore. It took us a few years before we became civil with each other in front of mom and dad, but even then..."

Glimmer paused, glancing up as if to check Adora was still listening to her.

"Speaking of Catra, I have a confession."

Adora practically saw Glimmer's ears perk up.

"I sort of peeked at your phone while you were with Bow, and she messaged you, and I replied for you."

Adora cringed back as if Glimmer was going to attack her, but the sparkly girl just blinked before opening up her phone. Adora watched Glimmer's face, illuminated by the screen.

"Oh, she didn't even say anything important. It's fine, but don't do it again."

Adora nodded, pretending to cross her heart as a promise. Her eyes flicked to her watch, suddenly remembering they had class the next day. For some reason, it felt like weeks had gone by, but it'd only been days.

"Come on, we better go to sleep."

Glimmer reached her arms out and Adora yanked her to her feet, the two girls playfully shoving each other as they walked into the room.

Catra's Laptop

Adora woke up at five am, trying to set herself into the habit of going for a morning run. She found it actually rejuvenated her, rather than depleting her energy levels.

Checking her planner as she got ready, Adora made a mental note to clean the dorm up a bit before Catra stopped by for their study session. She knew Catra was going to be judgmental, and might very well snoop around when she wasn't looking, so it was best to put all valuables out of sight while she was around.

Stepping out of the door, she smiled at the image in front of her. Glimmer was draped, rather ungracefully, on Bow, who didn't seem to mind the slightest; his arm wrapped around the shorter girl. Softly closing the door in an attempt to let them sleep, Adora left for her run.

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The knock on the door was the most anxiety inducing experience Adora had ever felt. Taking in a shaky breath, Adora opened it to reveal Catra leaning against the doorframe. She wore the same clean cut pants and loose shirt (albeit slightly wrinkled) from the previous day, but the blazer had been swapped for a loose purple jumper that hung off her frame, and the headband swapped for a ribbon tied into a messy ponytail..

That girl could literally wear a trash bag and I'd-

Adora paused her thoughts before they entered forbidden areas.

"Hey, Adora."

Adora didn't bother replying, opening the door wider as Catra brushed past. Adora watched as Catra's eyes darted around the room, but Adora had been careful. All the sheets were tucked in, and all personal belongings put into drawers or closets. Catra would have to dig deep to find whatever she was searching for.

"Are we studying here?"

They both eyed the two separate desks on opposite sides of the room, and Adora shook her head.

"Nah, let's go to the lounge."

Catra seemed to know her way around well enough, Adora chalked it up to each dorm having a similar layout. Dropping herself comfortably onto the couch, she pulled out her laptop and materials. Adora wasn't surprised at the colorfully coded sticky notes attached to Catra's version of Frankenstein, but she still stared at it for a beat longer than required.

"You really thought I was an idiot."

"I actually didn't. You studied way less than me, but your grades were comparable."

Catra had nothing to say to that, kicking off her shoes to cross her legs on the couch.

"Let's just get this over with."

Adora made a noise in agreement, opening up her own laptop. They'd started brainstorming on paper, but it would just be easier to type than handwrite on a couch.

"Okay, how should we break it up? Netossa said we have to write one cohesive essay as a duo, we have to turn in the same work."

"Easy. I could just do two of the body paragraphs, and you can do the other one plus the introduction and conclusion."

Adora looked up, perplexed.

"Hold on. Why am I doing three paragraphs when you only do two?"

Catra rolled her eyes and Adora felt her blood boil.

"Body paragraphs are way bigger than introductions and conclusions, dummy."

The anger diffused at the old nickname, and both of them seemed to realize Catra used it at the same time.

"Catra! Octavia called me a dumb face."

The child's face welled up a splotchy red in anger.

"Where is she?"

Adora pointed to one of the common rooms, where the children were supposed to play quietly. An older girl, around eight years old, played with some old crayons and paper on a table.

"Octavia?"

The older girl turned towards Catra, Adora hiding behind the girl's wild messy mane.

"Yeah?"

Catra snarled, reaching out a hand and striking the girl across her face. Octavia looked at her in shock, her mouth a perfect circle.

"You're a dumb face, not Adora!"

She stamped down hard on the girl's foot, and Octavia yelped. The cry of pain was so exaggerated that Adora giggled, grabbing Catra's hand and sprinting before the matrons came to punish them.

"Hurry Catra, they'll catch us."

The girls darted into a storage closet, but the light switch was too high above them to reach. They'd have to wait it out in darkness.

"Catra, I'm scared."

Adora turned to find her friend, head swiveling around like a beacon in distress.

"Just look at me Adora, my eyes glow."

Adora rolled her eyes in the darkness.

"Shadow Weaver told us lying isn't right, Catra."

"You're a dummy if you believe everything she says."

Adora huffed, finally turning around to look for Catra's 'glowing eyes', when she came face to face with...well, glowing eyes. It wasn't bright or scary, more illuminated than anything. As if someone had shone a dull flashlight on the irises. It was beautiful, one a vibrant blue and the other a soft honey.

"You just told Octavia off for calling me a dumb face, and now you're calling me a dummy," Adora huffed.

"Hypo-crite." Adora sounded out a new word Shadow Weaver had taught them, and the blue and gold irises rolled in annoyance.

"You're my dummy, not Octavia's."

Adora smiled in the darkness, shuffling closer to Catra as the shadows swam around them.

They both seemed to snap eyes at the same time, and Catra broke it first, coughing into the back of her hand as she looked down.

"You know, I'll just do the three paragraphs, if it means so much to you."

Adora opened her mouth to rebut her, but instead just decided to let Catra do the three paragraphs. They only had an hour to get this thing done and turn it in.

"Alright, swap laptops."

Adora reached out her hand to exchange Catra's MacBook for her own, but Catra blushed. Adora looked at her in surprise, exchanging MacBooks made her blush?

"I'll just share it with you."

Now Adora's curiosity spiked. Firstly, she blushed, and Adora hadn't witnessed Catra actually blush in years. And secondly, she was being defensive. What was on her school laptop that Adora couldn't see? Was Catra scared of her seeing like old chemistry notes? Was she a note hoarder?

"Just pass your laptop, my storage space has almost run out." The lie fell like honey from her lips, thick and overly sweet. Shadow Weaver had bought this laptop for her at the start of term, there was plenty of storage space on it.

"Bullshit."

Of course Catra caught her out on her lie, she always did.

"What's so special on your laptop?"

Adora leaned from her side of the couch towards a very secretive Catra, who was clutching her laptop to her chest.

"Nothing, nothing!"

Adora reached forward to grab it, but Catra squealed, yanking it over her head and far away from Adora's reach. Adora tried her hardest to keep her gaze trained on the laptop, and not the strip of skin Catra exposed as she was reaching upwards.

Fed up, Adora jumped off the couch and ran to the side where the laptop was dangling, but Catra quickly realized what her plan of attack was and hugged the laptop tight to her chest, flipping on her stomach so the device was under her.

"There, now you won't get it."

Now Adora had tunnel vision. She wanted to know what was so special that Catra was rolling around on the couch to hide it from her.

"Give it!"

She dove for the girl, pinning her under her and trying to find purchase on the smooth silver surface. Catra quickly flipped, and somehow realized Adora was straddling her before Adora even did.

Her face turned a shade of soft pink, but Adora saw her opportunity and grabbed it...literally. She gripped the MacBook and pulled quickly, rolling off of Catra with a laugh. She dropped onto the ground, opening up the laptop to see a blank screen with log in information. Adora pouted like a child, closing the laptop shut without even bothering to attempt a password.

"All that effort for nothing."

She turned her head back at Catra, who simply stared at the wall, a look of confusion written on her face. Adora worried that she might've gone too far, Catra didn't even really consider her a friend. Just a few days ago she was telling Adora to stay away from her, and here she was trying to joke around.

"Sorry, I didn't mean to-"

Catra reached, pulling the laptop from Adora's lap.

"It's fine."

Adora tried not to groan in frustration at the empty silence that followed.

"The period is almost over...I'll just send my paragraphs to you to check, and you can send yours to me."

Adora shifted to see Catra stacking her books and stationary on top of her computer, picking the pile up and approaching Adora's room for the exit. Adora wasn't sure where exactly she crossed the line, following Catra while rubbing the nape of her neck.

"Yeah, yeah...cool."

She opened the door for her, mint and musk overlapping with the breeze of the hallway.

"I'll see you in Textiles?"

Catra nodded, avoiding eye contact as she stepped outside. Adora's heart sank, but what did she expect? After all, they hadn't been friends in years.

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Knock Knock Bitches

The week inched through slowly, each morning beginning with a run and ending with Adora and her laptop, studying late into the nights with Bow as Glimmer fell asleep. The sparkly girl was prone to neglecting her other subjects and focussing purely on Art.

Adora returned to her dorm with the phone buzzing, an incoming call from Shadow Weaver. Adora pulled her hair tie out and slumped over on her desk, glancing over to see if Glimmer had come back yet. She hadn't.

"How's the week been Adora?"

"Good. I'm doing well in all my classes, my teachers are impressed."

Shadow Weaver was silent on the other end.

"It's important you don't become...complacent, Adora."

Adora refrained from rolling her eyes, she was never complacent.

"Yes Shadow Weaver...Mom," she corrected.

"I noticed your outing, you've seemed to create quite a storm around yourself."

Adora didn't know what she was talking about, but at least Shadow Weaver didn't sound angry.

"A storm around myself?"

"Look up 'Angella Brightmoon,' and you'll figure it out."

Adora briefly paused the call to search up the name, finding multiple articles and pictures pop up. Being in her own little school bubble, Adora completely forgot to ask Glimmer about the paparazzi, and if they wrote up anything weird about them. She

scrolled through the most popular articles, several of them trending on social media.

Angella's new take on parenting will blow your mind!

Glimmer's Dinner Outburst

Two new adopted children?

Double Trouble Tells All: An exclusive.

Adora paused at the last article, intrigued. She didn't see Double Trouble take an interview or say anything, how could they find out anything interesting from them. Clicking on the interview, Adora scrolled down.

Meet Double Trouble, a potential star that will grab your attention. After meeting with Huntara, the notorious head chef from "The Crimson Waste," we got to connect with and chat with the sensation. A sixteen year old attending the exclusive boarding school (founded and owned by Angella Brightmoon), Brightmoon Institution, here's what they had to say.

Reporter: Morning Double Trouble, I'm glad I was able to catch you despite your busy schedule.

Double Trouble (DT): I'm glad I could be here.

Reporter: So, let's get into it, shall we?

DT: Let's.

Reporter: Attending such a prestigious school must be mentally draining. How do you cope with constantly being around the children of celebrities and other influential people?

DT: I thrive in it, really. As an aspiring performer, it's really beneficial to be around people who have grown up in, or know someone in the industry.

Reporter: That's great! Is this why you were out to dinner with Angella and her family? Are you the next star of her upcoming project?

DT: I wish. No, I was invited out by Catra, one of my best connections at the school, and a friend since they day I started at Brightmoon.

Reporter: You're a close friend of Catra Brightmoon?

DT: One of my best allies.

Reporter: Interesting...Do you never feel overwhelmed, being around people who are so glamorous?

DT: Not quite, I mean, everyone wears costumes. Under all that glamour is a person, you just have to take the sparkle off.

Reporter: What an excellent line!

DT: I try.

Reporter: So, everyone knows Angella, Catra and Glimmer, but who's the stunner in red?

DT: That's Adora, she just started attending the academy this year.

Reporter: Are you romantically involved with her?

DT: If I was, a certain someone would probably bite my head off.

Reporter: Oh? Can you share who?

DT: I think that's a secret for a second interview.

Reporter: Well played, Double Trouble. We loved having you on today, I hope we get to do it again!

DT: I'm always available, darling, just fit me into your schedule.

"Adora, I hope you're getting ready!"

Adora inwardly cringed, suddenly remembering she was on a call with Shadow Weaver who could still hear her.

"I hope that's Glimmer Brightmoon, Adora."

Her eyes nearly popped out of her head as she returned to the call.

"What?"

"The articles suggest you're fraternizing with Glimmer Brightmoon....and Catra."

Adora winced at the venom carefully placed in each syllable of Catra's name.

"As lazy, horrible and treacherous as she is, you will benefit from being in a relationship of a sort with her."

Adora blushed slightly, and quickly hid her cheeks by resting them on her hands.

"A...relationship?"

"I know, it sounds despicable. Don't be friends, she'll only distract you and be a bad influence...but be seen in public with her. It'll get your name out there and Angella is an excellent person to be connected to."

Adora nodded, feeling guilty for taking this 'advice' from Shadow Weaver. She didn't want to manipulate anyone, and if Glimmer somehow found out what Weaver was telling her....

Adora shivered.

"Actually, I think Glimmer wants to host a study session, we're meeting with a few others in the library." Shadow Weaver wouldn't tolerate a party, but a study session would be permitted.

"Good. I'll call you next Tuesday."

"Good nig-"

The screen shut off before Adora could finish, Shadow Weaver disconnecting. Adora frowned before Glimmer knocked on the door.

"Sorry I yelled, are you done talking to her."

Glimmer peeked in and whispered. Adora sighed.

"Yeah, I'm done."

Glimmer pushed open the door, holding two hangars with various garments hung on them.

"Which one?"

Adora stared at the clothes, noticing they were both various shades of blue and green.

"You know, I'm not sure if green's your color," she mused. Glimmer rolled her eyes and slouched in desperation.

"It's Salineas' house colors. You do realize you have to wear blue and green tonight, right?"

Adora blinked. She had in fact, not realized that. Glimmer groaned.

"You can borrow something from my wardrobe, but we are getting you to a shopping centre as soon as possible."

Adora beamed back at her.

"Tank yew Gwimmer," she sing-singed in a child's voice. The girl only rolled her eyes in response.

"Oh, go with the one on the left."

"My left, or your left?"

Adora took a few beats to figure it out.

"My left, so your right."

Glimmer nodded, taking the outfit back into her bathroom to get ready.

"Pick something out for me while you're at it!" Adora yelled back, shaking out the roots of her hair to loosen it up after days of a continuous ponytail. She liked her hair down, and she liked it up. She didn't know which to choose for the night.

"How do I look?"

Adora turned to see a sparkling (literally) Glimmer. Adora didn't know what body oil Glimmer had put on herself, but the light made her skin shimmer. Her dress was a simple pale jade green, that reflected in an almost metallic fashion, yet the fabric was clearly soft and airy. Glimmer had hooked on a diamond tennis bracelet and a pair of small pear shaped emeralds clipped subtly to her ears. The masterpiece was the coat though. A soft and luscious thing, the milky blue fur hung off her like a cape, yet still sheltered her shoulders and could be wrapped around like a blanket.

"You clean up nice, Glim."

Glimmer winked, slipping on a pair of low silver sandals.

"I try. Come on, see what I've picked out for you."

Adora put down her phone, following her eager friend to the bathroom. Draped across the marble bench was a deep, sparkling blue top, loose and sleeveless with a plunging v-neckline. Sitting next to it was a short black skirt, and a simple pale green jacket, that looked to be cropped. Matching satin knee high boots were placed inside the tub.

"I can't wear that Glimmer, no way."

"Oh come on! I ordered it just for you."

Adora's head turned so fast she nearly got whiplash.

"You bought this for me?"

"Not everything. The shirt and coat were already mine. But I was online shopping the other day, and I saw the skirt and boots on sale-"

"So you bought it for me?"

"I just thought you'd suit them, and I knew the party was coming up."

Adora smiled. She was thankful Glimmer thought of her, but she felt a bit like a charity case. As if she was some poor street girl that needed clothes.

"Thank you Glimmer, I appreciate it."

"Does that mean you'll wear it?"

Glimmer clasped her hands together, her voice pitched almost to a squeal.

"Yes. Since you bought it and everything, I guess I have to wear it."

Glimmer wrapped her into a hug, and Adora squeezed back.

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Adora stepped out of the bathroom, looking down at herself.

"Well, at least I feel hot."

She glanced at the mirror, squinting as if she didn't recognize herself.

"You look it too. Hurry up, we have to do makeup before we leave."

Adora turned to see Glimmer applying a dark green eyeliner, and fumbled with a few of the products. Glimmer's hand quickly swatted her away.

"Don't touch, I'll do it."

Adora nodded, backing away to sit down on the ledge. Glimmer shortly finished and dragged her makeup kit over, pulling out various tubes and bottles.

"I'm not putting foundation on you, just some touch ups."

Adora nodded as Glimmer used the applicator. She worked in silence, asking Adora for her preference between two colors before choosing to dust her eyes with a faint navy sparkle eyeshadow. After applying some black eyeliner and Mascara, paired with a simple nude lipstick, Adora looked into the mirror.

"Woah."

"I know right. How good am I?"

Adora kept staring at herself, barely comprehending that she was standing in front of a mirror.

"I would suggest curling your hair, but straight suits the outfit more."

Adora nodded in agreement, playing with the dirty blonde strands of hair.

"You guys ready."

Bow leaned against the door frame, wearing a cropped emerald shirt and a blue leather jacket.

"Shit, it's already nine. We better get going."

Glimmer shut off all the lights, dragging them out of the room to get to the party. Adora shivered as they wondered the hallways, Glimmer scanning all the room numbers before landing in front of a door.

"The party is in someone's dorm?"

Glimmer nodded, pulling out her Student ID with her House group listed on it. She pulled out Adora's too.

"Hey, that's mine."

"I knew you wouldn't remember to bring it, so I brought it for you."

Adora opened her mouth to protest before promptly shutting it. Glimmer was right, after all. She didn't think to bring her Student ID.

"Who's willing to give up their room?"

Adora considered it must've been a small gathering, for she couldn't hear any music or noise inside.

"Arsan Hawk. He's Sea Hawk's brother, and the only Salineas member with sound proof walls."

Glimmer didn't delay any longer, apparently scared to be seen in the hallway. She knocked on the door loudly in hopes someone would hear her.

"Ah, if it isn't the dazzling star herself."

A boy opened casually pulled open the door, his brown eyes bright and dark blue hair strewn around. His cheeks had the flush of alcohol in them, Adora recognized it through years of experience. But he seemed enlightened with it, not drowsy or uncontrollable.

"Shut up, Arse and let us in."

"You know the rules, no ID, no entry."

Glimmer rolled her eyes, shoving her card in front of his face. Arsan hummed and examined it while Glimmer grumbled something along the lines of "Been like three years, and he still pulls this shit."

"I suppose I'll have to let you go. But if you pull the same shit you did last year-"

"Ya da da, I'm out."

Glimmer flicked her wrist, and Arsan's eyes finally pulled up to scan Bow and Adora.

"Bow, I don't even need to see your ID."

Arsan winked, but Bow just pushed in aside playfully. He didn't seem to have the same attraction to Arsan as he did with Mr. Hawk. Perhaps Bow just preferred the whole "illegal" aspect of a crush on Sea Hawk.

"Hold up, you must be Adora."

It was more of a statement than a question, Arsan's eyes narrowing onto her.

"Yup! That's me!"

She sounded way too perky for a party.

Tone it down, Adora. New people, act cool.

"I mean, yeah, that's me."

She tossed her hair as she heard Glimmer slap herself. Arsan just threw himself into laughter, clutching his stomach and looking back at Glimmer.

"Oh, she's precious."

"Downright adorable," Glimmer deadpanned.

"Ooh, I like that! Alright, show the ID Miss. Adorable."

Glimmer tossed it to Adora, who caught it and smiled, holding the card next to her face as if it was a 'Wanted' poster.

"She checks out, get in."

Adora quickly stepped in as Arsan shut the door behind him, eyes fervently flicking up and down the hallway.

"Nothing?"

Arsan nodded, his tone a bit darker.

"I think we're in the clear."

Adora looked to Glimmer confused.

"It's practically tradition for Dryl members to crash our parties. We get them back though, it's just annoying. The whole color scheme just goes out of whack."

Adora gawked at the room. It was dark, the only light reflecting off the roof like a blue ocean, and green decorations were scattered all over the place. People were everywhere, all covered in aquamarine, or chartreuse, or-

Well, every shade of green and blue possible, a lot of aquamarine though. She tried to avoid the couples hidden in the dark of the corners, focussing instead on the music crashing around them.

"Very...under the sea," she spoke a bit louder than usual so Bow and Glimmer would hear her.

"Our House leaders are named Mermista and Sea Hawk, I think it's fitting."

Adora nodded in agreement, it was very fitting. Bow waved them over to a stand in the corners, stocked up with various drinks.

"You guys want one."

Glimmer knocked him aside, pouring herself a shot. Adora blanked at her, shocked.

"What? I gotta get in the mood."

Glimmer downed the small glass and shook herself, as if she was preparing to run a marathon or something. Bow poured himself a regular drink and glanced over to Adora.

"I'm gonna start with something tamer. You want one?"

Adora eyed the alcohol nervously before shaking her head. She'd seen what alcohol could make people do, and she wasn't particularly interested in how it would make her behave. Not at the moment, when everyone and everything was so foreign to her.

"I'm good."

Bow nodded and raised the glass to his lips, seeming to scan the room full of people.

"Come on, I'll introduce you to everyone."

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Adora was surprised that most people already knew her name. She knew that article had gone around, but she didn't think the entire school revolved around Glimmer and her family. Well, they did seem to hang on to Catra's every words, and both the girls were practically celebrities...Maybe Adora had made a stupid assumption, why wouldn't the world revolve around them?

"Make way, darlings, Double Trouble has arrived!"

DT pushed through the crowd to meet Adora, Bow and Glimmer.

"DT, you really need to pick a side," Glimmer crossed her arms over her chest as Adora scanned them. A glittering blazer that

seemed to be both blue and green, a black leotard, and sheer stockings, all suited with black studded boots. They looked like a bedazzled stripper, in the best way possible.

"Today was a Salineas day, though a little birdie told me Dryl would drop in."

DT winked, walking a few paces over to the drink stand.

"You know, the interview you did was kind of low."

Bow stood cooly in the corner, carefully sipping his drink. DT didn't turn to him as they responded.

"Nothing's too low for me, Twinkles."

Glimmer muttered a string of curses, paired with "I hate her for calling me that. One just sees the colorful hair and goes, 'GLIMMER, that's what I'll name her!'"

Adora chuckled under her breath as DT hung their cup by their fingertips.

"Don't you look delicious?"

She blushed slightly, looking down on herself.

"It's basically all Glimmer's, I'm just borrowing it."

"Adora! It is YOURS! YOU GET TO KEEP IT."

Glimmer shook her vigorously by her shoulders, causing Adora to get dizzy.

"Woah, calm down tiger."

Bow pulled her away by her shoulders, a squirming Glimmer yelling in protest.

"Hm, angry drunk... And what about you?"

DT sipped from their cup, face expressionless. Adora held up her cup of water.

"Stone cold sober."

DT laughed, swirled their drink, and then sipped again.

"Oh, I'd pay to see you drunk."

They sauntered off, presumably to chat with the other guests. Adora hung back by the wall, watching Bow and Glimmer laugh on a table. She smiled as she watched them, noticing the affectionate glances they both casually threw at each other. A part of her ached, wanting that kind of bond with someone.

Suddenly the music cut out. It was so abrupt that everyone kept dancing for a bit before realizing.

"Knock knock, bitches."

Adora whipped her head around to see a smug Catra, coupled with her little group and a pleased Kyle who had cut the cable.

"We can't have ONE FUCKING PARTY in peace, can we?"

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Drunk Catra?

Glimmer jumped down from the table in frustration, dragging an amused Bow behind her.

"Sorry to burst your bubble, but you're really unwanted here."

Glimmer huffed like a petulant child, her fists balled.

Arsan grabbed the cable from Kyle, re-hooking it up with Bow's assistance. Who knew the guy was a tech master?

Within a few minutes Catra had may her way over and the music was playing again.

Adora gaped at her old friend, speechless...literally speechless. She wore skintight leather pants, a long-sleeved maroon turtleneck with a boob window, laced up biker boots, and a cropped white puffer. The look was simple, yet effortlessly jaw-dropping. Then again, Catra seemed to have that effect with all her outfits, including the school uniform. So Adora really shouldn't have been surprised. Catra raised her sleek sunglasses (because she even pulled off wearing sunglasses in the dark), and tightened her pulled back ponytail. The look was very clean, the way her hair just tied back yet still held so much volume.

"So..."

Her eyes scanned Adora up and down, an unreadable expression on her face.

"What'd I miss?"

"Aren't you, not meant to be here. You're in Dryl."

Adora knew Catra wasn't in Salineas, both from her clothes and Glimmer's remarks, so she had to be in Dryl.

"DT's here."

Catra shot a look at her friend, but her eyes seemed a bit buzzed. Had she already drank before coming?

"DT isn't committed to either side. They aren't welcome here, but at least they aren't in Dryl."

"Why would I commit when I can have the pleasure of both?"

DT seemed to enjoy the small exchange that was happening, tuning in and out of the conversation.

"Leave, Catra."

"No. Remember last year... Dryl's finals party."

Catra raised an eyebrow at Glimmer, who seemed to shrink back slightly. What on earth happened at last year's party to make drunk Glimmer timid.

"Fine. An eye for an eye. You can stay, as long as Arsan lets you. It's his dorm after all."

Glimmer seemed smug, pulling Arsan from the dance floor to presumably kick them out, but the boy was shockingly pissed.

"Arsan, can Catra and her Dryl cronies stay?"

Glimmer added a slight edge to her voice, but Catra didn't seem the slightest fazed, just meeting Arsan's eyes.

"Yeah! The more the merrier," Arsan got swallowed by the dance floor once again and Glimmer groaned.

"Thanks, Sparkles."

Catra touched a hand to her chest, her voice so sincere it was obviously fake. Adora felt like stepping in and asking Catra to leave, but it felt useless at this point. Glimmer wasn't even trying, and she had the strongest will on the planet.

Catra stepped over to the table, downing a shot in a similar fashion to Glimmer. Adora walked to face her, examining her face slowly.

"You're staring," Catra muttered. She poured herself a second drink, quite a bit of Vodka being tipped in. That was a strong one, often, but not always used by Shadow Weaver.

"Are you drunk?"

Catra glared at her, meeting Adora's eyes coolly while raising the cup to her lips. She gulped, never breaking eye contact.

"And?"

Adora pushed around the table as people began approaching it to pour their own drinks.

"You already came here buzzed, do you really need more?"

"You're not my babysitter Adora. I can drink as much as I want."

Catra didn't sound too drunk. Adora could only tell through her eyes, both murkier and a bit dull in color.

"I'm not trying to babysit you Catra, I just...care."

Catra stepped back, just a slight shake in her leg.

"Well don't."

She turned away, probably to find Lonnie or DT. Adora sighed. She wasn't trying to guilt trip Catra, or control how much she was drinking. She just...knew there was a reason. There was always a reason.

"Adora!"

Bow approached her, out of breath and flushed. Adora looked back to see Glimmer flinging Bow's jacket around like a prop.

"Come dance with us."

Adora was ready to protest, happy to sit in a corner and simply observe, but Bow didn't take no for an answer. He grabbed her hand, his grasp warm around her wrist, and pulled a reluctant Adora to the crowded centre of the room.

"I don't like it!"

She felt like an uncoordinated ugly ducking, surrounded by beautiful swans.

"It's easy silly!"

Glimmer grabbed her hands and started moving in tune with the music. Adora followed along, still slightly uncomfortable but starting to loosen up.

By the time she'd reached the fourth song, Adora was lightheaded, as if she'd sucked helium from a balloon. She hadn't had a drop of alcohol, but she found herself getting more and more comfortable with each passing minute on the dance floor.

"Hey, Adora."

She whirled into the purr behind her, a pair of mismatched eyes gazing into her own.

"Hey, Catra."

"Dance?"

Adora turned back to see what Bow and Glimmer were doing. She grinned as she saw Glimmer videoing Bow taking a series of shots, yelling words of encouragement as she likely posted it to her Instagram story.

"Why not?"

Catra smirked, holding out her hand. Adora nervously grasped it, and Catra pulled their bodies close together. Adora struggled to contain her blush and the urge to wrap a hand around Catra's waist, keeping her body parts very much to herself.

She's probably not even into you, and YOU AREN'T FRIENDS.

"You look nice all jazzed up, like a princess."

Catra really wasn't helping with the whole blushing problem here.

"I don't get you. One minute you tell me to stay away and the next you're asking me to dance with you?"

"I don't get me either.... Princess, let's...leave it at that."

Catra seemed a bit out of breath, and Adora worried for a second before realising she was probably just messing with her. Then again, the dance area was pretty crowded, it would be easy to get tired.

"Is there water around here...I'm..thirsty."

Catra blinked, a bit dazed, and Adora's worry started too heighten. She hurriedly looked around for Lonnie, Kyle or Rogelio, but they all seemed absorbed by the crowd.

"Catra? Catra!"

Adora reached out her arms to steady her before Catra fully slumped into her.

"No, no, no, no, no."

Adora picked up the smaller girl easily, she had no idea where the bout of strength came from. Quickly moving off the dance floor and into one of the bedrooms, Adora checked Catra's pulse. She exhaled in relief, she'd only passed out. Should she get one of Catra's friends? Adora gnawed her lip nervously, looking back at the unconscious girl. No, she wasn't going to risk leaving her

unattended in the room, she'd just call Glimmer or something. Adora reached for her phone, before realizing she'd left it in the dorm.

"Why are you such an idiot?" She muttered quietly to herself, flipping on the lights in the room. The brightness seemed to wake Catra, for she stirred in confusion.

"Heyyyyy, Adora!"

Oh, she was most certainly still drunk. Except this time it was very clear, unlike the past two hours where she seemed completely normal.

"Are you feeling better, do you want me to get Lonnie or someone?"

Adora checked the girl's forehead, relieved she seemed to be a normal temperature.

"No, I want you!"

Adora blinked in surprise before remembering the girl was just drunk. She was likely to say stupid shit right now, but it was still odd.

"You know, I'm gonna call Scorpia!"

Adora quickly grabbed the phone from a loopy Catra, distantly wondering who this Scorpia was.

"Who's Scorpia?"

Catra laughed hysterically, clawing to free her tight ponytail. She ended up breaking the hair elastic with her nails and pouted as if on the verge of tears.

"My favorite hair tie, whyyyyyy?"

She stomped her boots on the ground like a child, and Adora couldn't fathom that this was the same girl flirting with her on the dance floor...if whatever that was constituted as flirting.

"Catra, who's Scorpia?"

Adora had to know now, there was a pit of curious fire lingering in her stomach, burning her up from the inside and out. Was Scorpia some sort of ex?

"Ohh, she's my therapist."

Adora sighed in relief, not really sure why she cared so much. Well, it was good to know Catra was seeking therapy. Shadow Weaver wasn't exactly nice to her.

"But she's also a teacher at the big bad school," Catra whispered to Adora from behind her palm as if she was admitting some huge secret. Giggling, she leaned back. Adora wasn't sure she really wanted to investigate the meaning of those words.

"Right. Well, I doubt you would want yourself to call Scorpia while drunk, so I'll just hang onto this for now."

Adora held up the phone in front of her eyes, Catra watching it intensely and nodding her head in approval. Adora carefully put it in one of her hidden jacket pockets as Catra began fanning herself.

"I'm hot."

She started taking off her coat and boots, but Adora caught her wrists as she began to pull off her shirt. Catra pouted.

"I don't think you want to do that."

Catra giggled, the sound infectious.

"You know what else is hot? You."

She poked a finger at Adora, who blushed for about the fiftieth time that evening. Dammit, how could a severely drunk Catra manage to make her flustered? Adora let go of the wrist still caught in her hand, standing up.

"I'm going to open a window. You stay right here, okay?"

Catra nodded.

"I'll be a good girl."

Oh for fuck sakes. Adora brushed off the comment and the way she said it, pulling open the window while keeping half an eye on the restless girl.

"Now it's cold."

Adora moved to grab Catra's coat, and close the window, but Catra shook her head.

"I want you to make me warm."

Adora bit her tongue, hard.

She's drunk, she's just drunk.

"I want a hug."

She reached out her hands with a smirk, and Adora felt her face go crimson for the thoughts she'd just had. Adora gave her a hug, squeezing her for this might be the first time they'd hugged since they were children. Catra clung to her, and Adora resisted doing the same.

"Okay, let's go find your friends. They can take you back to your dorm."

"Noo, I don't wanna see people, ew."

Adora knew what she meant. She wouldn't want everyone watching her leave in a disheveled state, but the only exit point

was a window. Luckily, Arsan's dorm was on the first floor.

"Come on, we'll go through here."

Adora rethought her decision once she realized how disorientated Catra was, but it was too late now. She let the unstable girl use her hands for support as she swung her legs over the edge. Adora gauged the drop down to the grass, sighing when she saw the small drop. Even if Catra fell, she wouldn't get too hurt.

"Woah."

Catra dropped down with a soft thud, and Adora expertly pulled herself over, once again providing stability as the girl wobbled.

"Adora, I think I'm gonna-"

Catra didn't finish her sentence, hurling into a nearby bush. Adora turned the other way, feeling queasy herself when she'd barely eaten anything.

"Feel better?"

Catra spat in the other direction.

"Not really," she groaned.

At least she foundered a bit sober, even if she still relied on Adora for physical balance. They reached the door to the dormitories, Adora debating if it'd just be easier to carry her.

Deciding it would be, Adora swung Catra on her back, the limp girl void of a reaction. Adora clutched the white puffer in her other hand, the fabric faintly smelling of mint and musk, along with the laced boots.

Darting up the stairs, Adora was wary of not making Catra dizzy with speed.

"What's your dorm number."

Catra hummed in amusement as Adora kept climbing.

"Ya know, I really don't remember."

Adora sighed. She'll just have to bring her back to her own dorm and possibly sleep there for the night.

"Are we going to sleep together?" Catra mused.

"You are going to stay in my dorm until you feel well enough to return to your own," Adora amended. Turning her key (at least she remembered to bring that along), Adora flicked on the lights and placed Catra on her bed. She quickly answered Glimmer's long string of texts asking (more like screaming) where she was.

Catra got drunk, she's in our dorm with me.

Glimmer didn't respond and Adora turned her phone off, moving towards the bathroom as Catra lay on her bed.

"Where are you going?"

"To change?"

Adora slipped off the slightly heeled boots, carefully placing them by the rest of her shoes.

"Stay."

Adora sighed, unable to say no. She jumped on the bed, grabbing some makeup removers. If she was going to stay, she could at least take the makeup off before she slept in it.

"Ooh, do me too!"

Catra clapped her hands together as Adora swiped her face.

"Okay, but I'm not changing your clothes. I'm pretty sure you'd slaughter me for it tomorrow,"

Adora joked.

"My turn!"

Catra squealed as Adora threw out the wipe, and before she knew it the girl's head was placed in her lap, eyes shut peacefully.

Adora opened and closed her mouth, finally deciding not to reposition her. After all, she looked so comfortable. She carefully removed the girl's makeup, careful not to disrupt her calmness. Once Adora had finished, she realized the girl had fallen asleep, her chest rising and falling at a steady pace. She smiled gently to herself, and slowly moved to tuck Catra underneath the covers.

Watching her sleep was peaceful, and almost addicting, but Adora quickly snapped herself out of it.

Don't be creepy.

She sighed, moving into the bathroom to change before heading in the lounge room to sleep, shooting Glimmer a final "Where are you?" message and falling asleep.

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That's Rough (Buddy)

Adora yawned, stretching her arms out to hit a face.

"Oh!"

Adora gasped as Glimmer yelped in pain, nearly rolling off the couch from the force of Adora's push.

"Glimmer! Were you watching me sleep?"

Adora accused the girl, who was rubbing her cheeks.

"No, I wanted to know what the fuck Catra is doing here! And in your bed too."

Adora narrowed her eyes at the sparkly girl, whose hair was messy and who still had her clothes on from last night on. She looked a right rumpled mess.

"She's not 'in my bed,' Glim, she's just sleeping there. And have you slept at all? You look....manic."

Manic was putting it lightly, if Adora was being frank.

"Okay, so maybe Bow and I drunkenly made out, but I remember barely anything and I feel too odd to ask him about it."

Adora screamed, but Glimmer quickly shushed her, covering her mouth with a palm.

"Oh my god. This happened, and it isn't the first thing you tell me?"

"Well I have absolutely no idea what happened last night, all I really remember is going in for it. I don't know, I'm scared we went further. I think I might've been knocked out for an hour, but I woke up here and I look over to tell you, but it's not you, it's

Catra! I'm telling you Adora, the heart attack I almost had, I literally had a flashback to one of those awful 'family' holida-"

"Glimmer, calm down. I sent you a text about Catra last night, but I guess you weren't very active on your phone."

Glimmer blushed and Adora moved to get off of the couch and stretch. She tapped her phone, not surprised to see it was almost eleven. She must've ended up going to bed at like three.

"Ugh, my head hurts like a bitch."

Adora smirked, filling up two glasses of water. She grabbed some aspirin from the cupboard and handed it along with a glass to Glimmer, gulping greedily from her own. She had a headache, and she wasn't even drunk.

"Thanks."

Adora smiled, finishing her own glass and refilling it. She grabbed two more and filled them up, grabbing some aspirin for Bow and Catra. Glimmer groaned and lied down on the couch, probably about to go to sleep. Adora let her go, heading into Bow's room to put the glass on his bedside table. She eyed his neck nervously, spotting a hickey. Adora trotted back out, hoping for Glimmer's sake that they hadn't gone all the way. It'd be horrible if neither of them remembered it. Taking a deep breath as she approached her own room, Adora wondered if she should knock or not.

Well, it was her own room, and she was just planning on slipping in and putting the glass beside her bed.

But this was sober Catra, not drunk Catra. Two very different people.

Adora opened the door, trying not to overthink. She avoided looking at her, placing the glass down carefully with the pills.

"Adora?" Catra murmured sleepily, blinking her eyes slowly and squinting at her.

Well, shit.

"Uh, morning?"

Catra kept blinking at her, and Adora could visibly see the realizations and theories flicking in her eyes.

"Fuck. Oh shit,"

She sat up, but Adora winced at how fast it was. She quickly caught the back of Catra as she nearly collapsed back into the bed.

"I'm in your room, right? Oh god, why am I in your room?"

She groaned, fighting against the sheets as if she wanted to leave the bed, but physically couldn't.

"Just relax."

"Adora. What did I do last night? You have to tell me."

Catra grabbed at her arms, but Adora just clasped them, putting them back down on the bed.

"Calm down, I'll tell you everything later. Please, just go back to sleep."

Catra didn't have to be told twice, already passed out as Adora silently left the room.

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Adora sat down and opened her books, her body fed and run completed. She still hadn't seen Bow, Glimmer or Catra, each presumably sleeping. Well at least Glimmer was, Adora pulled the blanket higher up on the girl next to her, adjusting her glasses and taking a swig of her coffee as she began her to-do list for the day.

"Okay. I somehow got the effort to walk here, but if you don't tell me what happened right this second, I think I'll fall down."

Adora looked up to see Catra by the door frame, her clothes wrinkled and hair a mess. But she still looked amazing, she could never have a bad hair day.

"You look uncomfortable, do you want to borrow some clothes or-
"

"No. I'll just go back to my dorm and change, thanks."

Adora tried not the visibly sigh at the cold tone. She knew not to get her hopes up that they'd be friends after last night, but she couldn't help it.

"Okay."

Catra looked at her, a bit apprehensive, and Adora spoke to break the odd silence.

"You didn't do anything too stupid, calm down. Just acted a bit like a baby, tried to take your clothes off, vomited and passed out a few times. No sweat."

Catra exhaled when Adora shrugged, pulling a few white lies to cover up the other remarks Catra had made. Those were obviously a mistake, she didn't need to make things even more weird between them.

"Thanks...for looking after me. I didn't mean to ruin your night."

Catra averted Adora's eyes, and she just shrugged again, a bit disappointed, but not really surprised.

"It was fine. Just...don't do it again."

Adora set back to doing her math equations, not bothering to say goodbye as Catra left the dorm.

"Ouch, that was rough."

Adora looked back to the lump under the covers in shock.

"You were awake?"

"Duh. I was gonna say something when I woke up, but then she walked in."

Adora supposed it was better that Glimmer didn't show her alertness. Those two couldn't stand being in the same vicinity as each other.

"You really hate her, huh?"

"Only because she hates me. I'm not gonna kiss ass to anyone that treats me like shit."

Glimmer folded the blanket over her head, as if wrapping herself into a makeshift cocoon. Adora nodded, understanding Glimmer's view. She wondered why Catra turned on Glimmer so easily, when they had initially started out as friends.

"You feeling better?"

Glimmer stuck her head back into the fluffy blanket, burrowing it deep inside.

"As good as I'll ever be. Hangovers are the worst," she groaned. Adora peeked a glance at Bow's door before responding in a hushed tone.

"At least you're not thinking about yesterday. By the looks of it, you went to town on Bow's neck last night."

Glimmer turned a shade of red as Adora chuckled, moving on from Math to English. She needed to analyze a certain section of the text in preparation for Monday. She also had to review the filmed version of the play for comparison, but she couldn't be distracted by Glimmer for that.

"You know, since you're doing nothing...."

Adora mused aloud, arranging her highlighters by their meaning. Blue for character related quotes, green for concepts, pink for language mechanisms and yellow for significant stage directions.

"Adora, if you even think about suggesting homework right now," Glimmer grumbled into the blanket.

Adora shook her head, at least it was worth a try. But apparently there was no need for Adora to entertain Glimmer, as Bow stepped out, his shirt gone but pajama pants still intact.

"Do I leave?"

Adora whispered to Glimmer, keeping her eyes on a disorientated Bow.

"Please don't," Glimmer practically begged. Adora stayed put, acting industrious with her head in the Frankenstein book. Her eyes scanned the words, but she wasn't absorbing any of it, instead tuning into the surroundings.

"Morning, Bow!"

Glimmer sounded bright, way too bright for someone hungover.

"Hey, Glim."

Bow yawned, but he sounded...normal? Adora and Glimmer both flicked their gazes to each other before returning to him.

"Does he...not remember?"

Glimmer whispered softly to Adora, who examined the boy from head to toe. Maybe he didn't remember, but sure enough he'd notice the marks on his neck and would wonder where they came from.

"Say Bow, remember anyone-"

Glimmer hit Adora from behind.

"Anything from last night?"

Bow reached a hand about his neck.

"Actually, I was about to ask one of you where this came from."

He pointed to the spot, and both Adora and Glimmer nervously gulped, glancing at each other.

"Bow-"

"It was Arsan!"

Adora was interrupted by Glimmer, who spat out the boy's name. Bow's eyebrows raised in surprise.

"Arsan?"

"Yeah. You guys hooked up, but I don't remember much."

Bow scratched his head.

"Huh. I mean, he's pretty cute, but I'm not one to go for two brothers."

Glimmer nodded, while Adora just stared at her.

"It didn't seem like it meant much to either of you."

Bow nodded, seeming to buy the story.

"I don't think Arsan remembers anything from last night, so..."

Bow looked at her, and Adora dutifully stuck her head back into the book. If Bow asked her anything she'd be incapable of lying to him.

"Do you reckon I should just leave him in the dark? I mean, it feels kinda wrong."

Adora felt her own cheeks heat up for Glimmer, and her face was hidden by the book.

"What, what, nahhh? Pfft, Arsan hooks up with someone new every other day, doubt he'll even care."

Bow nodded slowly, seeming to buy into it.

"I'm gonna go shower before we head down to eat."

Both girls nodded furiously, and Bow threw them a suspicious look before returning to his room.

"That was close."

Adora closed the thin book and lightly slapped it on Glimmer's head.

"Ow! What's that for?"

"Lying to Bow!" Adora angrily hushed at Glimmer, who was still rubbing her head.

"I don't want to complicate things, I'm sure he didn't even mean it."

Adora blinked. Glimmer's words sounded awfully similar to Adora's thought process this morning.

Well, you aren't actually friends with Catra. And she was drunk, she clearly meant nothing when she flirted with you. Knowing Catra, she probably didn't even consider it flirting.

"Alright. Maybe I can understand," Adora murmured into her book, grateful Glimmer didn't decide to speak the question hidden in her eyes.

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Blue Haired Satan

Each day moved past slowly, but as Adora reviewed the weeks it felt like a blur. Already she was midway through the term and buried by everlasting homework, tests and assignments. At least she could rely on P.E to be a constant breeze. No homework, no tests, just fun, really. And her fitness levels were almost at its peak. Adora found her daily runs becoming easier, and she'd even watched a few videos on how to use weights. She hadn't actually built the confidence to actually use them, but at least she'd done some research.

"Adora, you need to download Instagram, or Snapchat, or something."

Adora looked at her phone while they walked towards the gymnasium. Shadow Weaver herself had promoted Adora becoming active on social media. And Shadow Weaver hated anything that could possibly lead to a distraction from her studies.

"I don't even know what I would post. I'll just be one of those blank stalker profiles."

Glimmer grabbed Adora's phone from her hands, and the taller girl yelled in protest. Adora tried to reach for it, but Glimmer was done within minutes. Bow stood in the centre, trying to separate the girls as some sort of peacemaker. Everyone stared as the small group squabbled past them, but no one decided to comment.

"And, done!"

Glimmer tossed the phone back to Adora, who caught it greedily.

"I'll just delete it, you know."

Glimmer huffed and stomped her feet on the ground.

"Please, just keep it. You don't even have to use it."

Adora knew that was a lie. Glimmer would probably send her updates every week or something to check Instagram. But then again, Adora herself was obsessed with the app. Every so often she'd nag Glimmer to look through fitness and study hacks on Glimmer's phone, doing an occasional stalk of everyone's accounts.

"Fine. I'll keep it."

"Yay!"

Glimmer hugged her from the side and Adora squeezed back, taking a selfie of the three of them to set as her profile photo. She quickly changed her username from @glimmersbitch to @adoragray.

Glimmer grabbed the phone again, Adora peering over her shoulder. She was going through Glimmer's own following list, requesting and following their classmates. Maybe Shadow Weaver would be appeased now, she was getting frustrated that Adora wasn't "promoting her identity across the market." Apparently all past presidents were well known in the media before they earned the title.

They walked in the gym, finding Mermista and Mr Hawk already setting up as more students filtered in. Adora was ready to shrug her jumper off, when she realized they had...a portable whiteboard? Not only were those things practically archaic, but it was phys ed, what did they even need it for? Unless they were learning a new game with complicated positions or something. Adora's interest piqued at the thought, soccer and basketball were her favorites, but she'd be open to something new.

"Morning Mermista!"

Adora pulled them to take a seat in the front row. Last time Glimmer took them to the back, and Adora couldn't see or hear any of the rules. She acted like an idiot for the entire game, it was

horrible. If they needed a literal whiteboard for this one, Adora had to be in the front.

"Don't talk to me."

Mermista's words sounded venomous, but she couldn't be disliked.

"Someone's grumpy this morning."

The dark brown eyes narrowed in on them, and Mr Hawk quickly squeezed her shoulders from behind.

"Excuse my love, she's a bit cranky. Didn't get her beauty sleep."

Mr Hawk grinned at them, and Mermista rubbed her temples in annoyance. The bell finally rung, prompting them to start the lesson.

"Alright kids. I'm sorry to say, but we aren't gonna be moving around this lesson. Instead, you will face the honor and pleasure of listening to my fantastical voic-"

"Sea Hawk. No."

Mermista sighed as Mr Hawk drooped. She grabbed a whiteboard marker, writing up some words on the board.

"SEX E-"

Oh. So...they weren't going to be learning a new sport? Adora suddenly felt idiotic for not only bringing herself, but dragging Bow and Glimmer to the front as well. She felt Glimmer softly press down on her foot in annoyance, and offered a half grin.

"Heh."

She chuckled, and Glimmer just groaned into her hands.

"The curriculum is a bitch, we know."

"Today, I thought we'd begin with a wonderful chat about sex. Now class, this word has a very bad stigma attached to it, which I would like to eradicate. To do this, we will go around the room, saying various terms, such as penis, vagina-"

Adora snickered at the shade of red Mermista had turned, out of embarrassment or frustration she didn't know. Perhaps both.

"Yeah, we aren't doing that. I'm pretty sure they know what sex is Sea Hawk."

"How could they know? They're practically children."

Sea Hawk turned to them, and Mermista just raised an eyebrow.

"He does realize he's only a few years older than us...right?"

Bow leaned over and whispered to Adora, who shook her head. To Sea Hawk, they seemed to just be kids.

"They're going to be seniors next year, Hawk. They aren't children, and we don't need to teach them what sex is."

Mermista erased the words on the whiteboard, replacing it instead with the term 'STI.'

"This is the bullshit we need to teach them."

Glimmer groaned, putting her face into her hands.

"Can't we just kick a ball?"

Mermista sighed, "I wish, kid. I wish."

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"That was the worst lesson of my life, and I take Chemistry."

Adora and her friends walked out in relief, thankful that the class was finished. Bow pulled out his phone, and Adora did the same. She looked through the new follows she'd received. A few

hundred, and it'd only been like an hour. Checking her other notifications, she realized Glimmer had tagged her in her story. Ah, that explained the random follows she'd received.

"Can my day get any worse?"

Bow groaned, pocketing his phone again.

"What's up?"

Glimmer touched his back in concern and Adora looked over worriedly. If Bow was sad, everyone was sad.

"My dads want to meet up for coffee this weekend."

"What's so bad about that?" Adora asked the question harmlessly, but Glimmer shot her a warning look. Sometimes, Adora couldn't help but feel a bit left out of the loop. It wasn't anyone's fault, she was still new...But Glimmer and Bow knew each other so well. As much as she wanted them to get together, a tiny selfish part in Adora's heart hoped they wouldn't. It would be amazing, but what if it didn't work out, and their group got torn apart? Or if they got super affectionate, and suddenly she was just a third wheel everywhere they went?

Adora quickly mentally slapped herself. It was selfish and mean to think this, she would support Bow and Glimmer's potential relationship no matter how it affected her.

"It's fine, Glim. My dads are great parents, but they just have...expectations for me."

Adora could understand parents' unrealistic expectations and demands of their child, but she didn't want to make this about her.

"They want me to take over the museums one day. All my other siblings ditched overseas, so I'm the one stuck with them."

Bow sighed softly, and Adora's heart ached for him. George and Lance were some of the worlds' best historians, but maybe not the best parents.

"I don't know how I'll break the news that I want to be an architect. Or an engineer, though I'm not talented enough for that."

"Shut up Bow. You blitz every physics and maths test, what are you on about?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes and punched him lightly in the arm, amusement blushing on both their faces.

"Naw, thanks Glim."

Glimmer's blush intensified as she rubbed the nape of her neck in an attempt to hide it. Adora plainly smirked at the reaction. She could be so oblivious sometimes.

"Thank god the stupid essay is over. If I have to reference Victor the psychopath one more time I think I'll fry my own brains out."

Adora snickered as they entered the classroom, taking their regular spots near the back.

"I don't know guys, I actually kind of enjoyed the novel."

"You're a dork, Adora. Of course you enjoyed the book."

Adora opened her mouth on mock defense.

"I am not a dork!"

"Afraid I have to agree with Sparkles here. You're the biggest dork I know, Adora."

Catra had momentarily turned in her chair, Lonnie looking over at her in question. Adora just opened and closed her mouth like an idiot, unable to think of anything to say in response. Catra just

raised an eyebrow, chuckling lightly to herself before engaging in a conversation with Lonnie.

"Catra just agreed with me. The Catra who hates my guts, that's gotta prove I'm right."

Glimmer shuffled in her seat, smug as a cat while Adora huffed like a child.

"Calm down guys. Adora you are a dork, but you're cute enough to pull it off. Glimmer, stop being rude," Bow scolded from between them.

Glimmer looked ready to knock out Bow in the boxing ring, but luckily Netossa waltzed in right at that moment, Frosta on her heels.

"We're actually ahead of schedule, so I thought I'd choose a fun book for us to study before diving into Oral Presentations."

Oh fuck. Adora hated public speaking with a passion, she did not have the energy to speak for even a few seconds in front of their entire class.

"Wow, no excitement? I'm offended."

Netossa held a hand to her heart as if wounded while Frosta swung her little legs over the table, swinging them wildly.

"You know, I'm actually starting to rethink my decision..."

Right at those words the entire class became animated. Netossa smiled in satisfaction, opening her iPad and sending an email through to all of them.

"I was gonna just give you hard copies, but the school's budget didn't allow it. The novel not being on the formal curriculum and all. So, I found an online supplement."

Adora flicked open her own iPad, along with the others, to find an attached email. She clicked on the download, amused yet excited to find the chosen novel.

Pride and Prejudice

A classic, and one she had read several times with Catra. Shadow Weaver detested the book, but Adora distinctly recalled Catra's love of Austen's biting and sarcastic narration of the tale.

"Don't moan and groan, it's not too bad once you understand the context."

Netossa hooked up a presentation to the large screen, background on the era and time period, as well as social classes popping up. Adora knew all of this already, but she was happy to revisit the topic. She glanced to her left towards Catra, wondering if the girl remembered them stealing a copy of the book from Hordak's personal library.

"As usual, we'll start with a brainstorm. Don't worry, there's no formal essay or assessment on this. This was just me trying to find a way to kill some time until the other classes caught up."

Adora smiled at Bow, the two stress heads of their small group. They were free of English for a week at least.

Netossa sat on the desk, absentmindedly handing her wand for Frosta to play with. The small girl waved it around, simultaneously hammering at the air.

"Let's start small. Who has actually read the book?"

Adora raised her hand, along with Bow, Glimmer and a few others...including Catra.

"Good, a fair few of you then. So, who can summarize the plot for me, just so everyone's in the loop?"

Glimmer began talking, not bothering to wait for Netossa's approval.

"An overbearing mother tries to sell off her daughters to rich men, and her second oldest, Lizzy, doesn't really like being treated like cattle auctioned to a farmer."

Netossa laughed light- heartedly, and though Glimmer's summary was blunt, Adora had to admit it was fairly accurate.

"Well said, Glimmer."

"Let's see..."

Netossa's dark eyes flicked around the room, until her eyes finally locked on Adora and she smiled.

"Adora, you've read the book?"

She nodded reluctantly. After the initial Frankenstein project that landed her in a sticky mess with Catra, she'd diligently kept her head down in class.

"Care to share your thoughts?"

While Catra herself didn't look back at her, Adora noticed Lonnie's gaze momentarily pass on her before looking back at the front. Adora wasn't able to catch her expression though, the girl fervent and Adora wrapped up in how to articulate her thoughts.

"Well, I enjoyed the book. I think that the modern audience finds it difficult to understand because it's a contemporary novel. You need to catch Austen's wit in the storytelling and the context behind the whole thing to thoroughly enjoy it."

Netossa smiled, sliding through to the first slide on the powerpoint, which practically restated everything Adora had just said.

"Couldn't have said it better myself. Today, we'll go through everything there is to know about Pride and Prejudice. The history, the social laws, all the boring work. Tomorrow, we'll get into the grit of it. I'm thinking we head towards a class debate?"

"Yes! A chance to just argue and bite each other's heads off? I'm in."

Glimmer turned to high five Adora, who gave her a look. Doing an oral presentation was difficult enough, but a debate. That was a whole different story.

"Netossa, can't you just not give us extra work?"

Lonnie groaned into the table, and Adora found herself agreeing with her. Writing five essays was so much more preferable to participating in a debate.

"You know, I think a debate could be fun. I already have a few ideas for teams."

The blue haired satan looked around the room, eyes lingering on Adora and Catra.

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Good Luck Girls

Adora got off her weekly call with Shadow Weaver, tying her hair up into the regular ponytail. She'd decided to skip her run today, opting for a recovery day since her legs were still burning from yesterday. It was difficult, and initially she was going to just push through it...But the inability to literally walk forced her to skip the workout.

"Adora?"

She finished tying up her hair, looking back at Bow in the doorway. Glimmer was still showering, getting ready for the long day of school ahead of them.

"Yeah?"

Bow looked nervous, and that made Adora nervous.

"I've already asked Glimmer, but...would you mind coming with me to meet my parents this weekend?"

Adora smiled in relief. Was that all Bow was nervous about?

"Of course, Bow."

His mood brightened instantly and he thanked her, moving to the lounge room to pack his bag for the day. Adora spritzed a light dose of perfume on her jumper. Vanilla, jasmine and a hint of honey. It was her second favorite scent.

She tossed her bag over her shoulder, calling for Bow and Glimmer to hurry up, they'd only have ten minutes to get some food in before English. Days where they had P.E or English first were the most anxiety inducing for Adora. She couldn't bare to leave the dorm without them, but Glimmer was notorious for cutting it down to the last minute.

"Hurry up!"

Adora yelled out for the tenth time, stress diffusing when Glimmer finally stepped out in her rumpled skirt and blouse.

"Calm down, I'm done, I'm done!"

She yelled in defense as Adora tapped her foot impatiently against the ground.

"Good, I'm not shedding a minute off my perfect attendance record."

Glimmer rolled her eyes and Adora grabbed her arms, practically dragging her to the door where Bow stood waiting.

"Why did the school obsessed psychopath have to be our new roommate?" She turned towards Bow, who just shrugged, ever the impartial party.

"Netossa is always late herself anyway, what does it matter if we are? Adora, let go of me."

Adora seemed to realize she was still holding Glimmer's wrist in a death grip, and quickly released her friend, apologizing.

"And just so you know, we're going to the mall next weekend. Dryl's having their own little celebration for the end of half-way assessments. I think it's time to repay the visit they gave us."

"I second that."

Bow bit into the apple he'd swiped from the cafeteria. Adora had taken to stealing protein bars every lunch for her mornings, since they only really ate in there two days out of the week.

"Besides, you are in tragic need for some clothes. The ones in your closet are all faded and worn in."

"What? I like minimalism okay?" Glimmer just hummed in disbelief as they rounded the corner. Adora was so busy trying to defend herself she practically walked into a wall.

Oh, it wasn't a wall. It was Catra.

"Sorry," she murmured, picking up the book that fell. Catra didn't respond, taking the book from her with Lonnie brushing past Adora to get to her.

"What's her problem?"

Adora leaned near Glimmer, mumbling under her breath.

"Catra's weird."

Adora silently agreed. She was weird, yet everyone gravitated around her like she was a magnet. Adora couldn't help falling into the same trap, her eyes scanning the tanned girl as she sat down. Both the pants and skirt abandoned for the sports uniform, but Adora didn't recall Catra taking P.E. Then again, she obviously knew next to nothing about the girl who was once her friend. Adora quickly shook herself out of it before she started getting into the 'creepy staring' zone, and moved to sit in the usual place where they sat. As Glimmer had predicted, Netossa was late, and Adora couldn't help but notice the jumper Catra wore. The word 'BRIGHTMOON' was printed on the back, with the number nine bolded at the forefront. The purple fabric looked soft and faded, and a slight too big on Catra's frame, reaching to the end of her shorts.

"Catra," she whispered, trying to get the girl's attention. Two annoyed eyes turned to meet hers, one the color of honey and the other as bright as a jewel. For a 'genetic defect' Adora thought Catra's eyes were fucking cool.

"Yes?"

"Is that your jacket?"

Her eyes darted to the outer layer she wore before returning to Catra's face.

"Yes."

"Do you play a sport."

"No."

Adora frowned.

"Then how is it your jacket?"

Catra rolled her eyes again, but the action held a little less venom than Adora knew she'd intended.

"Must I explain everything to your idiot brain?"

"Yes. I'm very dumb, please explain."

Catra sighed, about to elaborate when Glimmer cut in. The girl threw her an icy glare as Glimmer started talking.

"It's mom's, she was on the Volleyball team when she attended school here. I have dad's from when he was on the Rugby one."

"I did play sport earlier anyway, so I actually do have my own jacket."

Catra's words were mumbled and lost under the classroom chatter, but Adora heard every word.

"Really, which ones?"

For whatever reason Catra didn't respond, Adora shrugging the coldness off. She moved onto her next query.

"I thought your mum established the school, it has her name and everything?"

"She owns the school, inherited it from my great grandparents."

"Oh."

Adora felt a bit stupid for not realizing that earlier, but her embarrassment was saved as Netossa walked through the door,

shutting it behind her.

"Catra, wrong uniform. I know you don't take P.E."

Netossa was the only teacher who pulled up Catra for the slight modifications she made to the uniform. A shirt button down, the skirt a bit high, jewelry, impractical shoes. Nothing missed Netossa's eye.

"Yeah well, I'm on my period. I need comfort, not a dress code."

Netossa pursed her lips, but didn't argue the sassy response, opting to launch into the content for the class.

_____

"Get excited class, because we are done with the boring framework of sewing!"

Ms Ella clapped her hands together in excitement, Adora taking her seat across DT. She'd been enjoying Textiles, oddly enough. It still wasn't her best subject, in fact it was her worst, but it was fun. Shadow Weaver had suggested Adora dropped it several times after seeing her questionable grades, but for whatever reason, Adora decided to stick with it.

"You've sewn a basic camisole, but now you get to do some collaborative work."

Adora cringed at the thought of the camisole she'd stitched. It was atrocious, the alignment so wrong it barely fit her. Bow managed to fix it, and he didn't even do Textiles!

"For this project, you'll be in pairs. You get to choose whatever fabric, style, article of clothing you want, but it has to align with your client's needs and expectations."

Adora caught DT's grin at her, and suddenly became nervous. When DT had that look on their face, they meant trouble.

"Here's the basic outline."

Ms Ella attached her screen to the board, showing an extensive document of various requirements and details they'd have to fill out. Frosta had decided to adopt the seat next to Adora for the lesson, watching her mom in confusion. Adora had taken a liking to the young girl, and Bow found her adorable, but Glimmer got frustrated at the child. Adora quietly smiled to herself, thinking of how Frosta would hide Glimmer's school materials during English, and how Netossa lectured her daughter every time.

"Oh, and don't even think about organizing yourself into groups. That's my job."

Ms Ella flicked to another screen on her computer, featuring a list of all their names and who'd they be working with.

"Ooh, Flutterina, what a darling."

DT pushed themselves out of the chair, winking at Adora and Catra.

"Good luck, girls."

Adora gulped, looking down to see her suspicions confirmed. Yep, she was paired with Catra. Netossa and Spinnerella really seemed to have it out for her. Literally every group project set by them entailed the two girls working together. Adora nervously turned back to Catra, finding the girl's expression unfazed.

"Can't say I'm surprised."

Catra pulled out the chair beside her, indicating for Adora to move. She quickly gathered her supplies and walked around the large table, taking DT's old spot.

"Let's get this done as soon as possible, I'm not gonna be stuck working with the world's worst sewer for too long. You're going to pull down my grade average."

Carta groaned, making a copy of the file, as Adora looked down in embarrassment. She wasn't exactly wrong, but it still stung.

"Okay, first question," Catra started.

"What is the client's garment choice?" Adora finished.

"Well, what should I make you then?"

Adora shrugged as Catra leaned back, examining her in the chair.

"I don't really mind."

Catra rolled her eyes.

"Well you need to. You're the client, be demanding."

Adora thought about it, spinning to face the table and rest her elbows on it.

"Okay fine. I'll decide, but we're just gonna pretend you wanted it all along, yes?"

Adora nodded, glad she didn't have to think of 'demands' for Catra.

"What do you want?"

"I'd say a leather jacket, but that might be a bit compl-"

"I'll do it."

Adora didn't even know what she'd just signed up for, but she didn't want to take it back now. Catra turned and raised an eyebrow at her.

"You're going to make me a leather jacket?" She arched an eyebrow at her, and that did nothing to ease Adora's newfound determination.

"Yes."

"You could barely make a simple camisole, how will you manage a leather jacket?"

Adora didn't like being bad at things, and she especially didn't like being the worst at it. Besides, Catra would rock a leather jacket, she'd like to see her in one. She met the skeptical eyes, watching the expression shift as Adora turned to meet her gaze.

"Watch me."

_____

She Was...Everything.

"Can you just stay still for one goddamn second?"

Catra growled as Adora squirmed again. The day had passed, and now they stood in Adora's dormitory, getting each other's measurements so they could begin making and cutting the patterns for their respective pieces.

"I can't help it, you're tickling me!"

Adora giggled again as Catra's measuring tape brushed past her hips. She literally couldn't control it, the sensation was too much to handle.

"Alright you big baby. Do me?"

Adora put on her glasses, grabbing the measuring tape as Catra glanced at her curiously. Adora looked down slightly on the shorter girl, wondering if she should get on her knees or find some sort of ledge for Catra to stand on. Glancing around the room, she just bent down. It'd save them time rather than build a wobbly kind of platform.

"Since when did you have glasses?"

"I don't know, Shadow Weaver got ma-"

Adora paused, rethinking whether she should mention this to Catra. She decided against it, but the other girl stared at her imploringly.

"I got them when I was twelve."

Catra looked like she was going to say something, and Adora momentarily waited. But the moment passed and it was just them awkwardly looking at each other, Adora from the floor with Catra standing over her. She quickly looked back down, raising one of her legs into a lunge so she could access Catra's waist.

"Okay, lift your shirt up."

"Excuse me?"

Adora smirked slightly, glancing up.

"I need to get your waist."

Catra blushed and Adora's grin widened. She quickly attempted to stifle it, but they both knew it was there. Focussing on the yellow tone of the tape measure and not the strip of toned stomach exposed to her, Adora gently wrapped the tape around the thinnest section, following the instructions of her book exactly. She looked up when she heard the softest gasp escape from Catra.

"You good?"

Catra nodded hurriedly.

"Yeah, just...cold hands," she mumbled. Adora didn't think her hands were cold, but she supposed she couldn't really tell, them being her own hands and all.

"You want it to be cropped, I'm assuming?"

Catra nodded, seeming to be at a loss for words.

"You can drop your shirt now."

Adora turned from writing down the measurements and saw Catra blush slightly again, dropping the shirt. Adora stood to move around to Catra's backside before pausing.

"What is it?"

Adora bit her lip slightly and blushed, thankful Catra couldn't see her properly.

"I have to take the bust measurement, but I think you can do that yourself."

Now they both reddened, and Catra gently grabbed the tape held out to her, measuring herself. She repeated them to Adora, who quickly wrote them down, keeping the heat of her cheeks suppressed.

"Alright, now the arms."

That was quick and easy, Ms Ella had given them a special measuring tape for it when she found they were making jackets.

"And shoulders."

Adora moved to behind her again, requesting the girl to hold up her hair so it didn't disproportion the measurement.

"Your room smells nice," Catra said to fill the tense silence. Adora couldn't help but softly sniff herself.

"Really? Never noticed. What does it smell like?"

She had trouble pinning where exactly to measure from, asking the question to stall rather than genuine curiosity.

"Vanilla...A bit floral too and...sweet? I like it."

"Catra, I think you're just smelling my perfume. But thank you."

Catra quickly turned and Adora had to move the measuring tape away before she got tangled in it.

"No, you smell like watermelon."

Adora raised an eyebrow at her, both surprised and amused at the defiant girl in front of her.

"What?"

Catra was unabashed, pulling Adora's jumper (along with a very surprised Adora) to her nose.

"Oh, there it is." Catra released her, a bit of relief in her eyes.

"I'm still confused."

The other girl seemed to suddenly realize what she'd just done, and the blush deepened. Adora found herself throughly enjoying watching a flustered Catra.

"Back when we were kids...you smelled like watermelon...and well...you smell like it now too."

Adora made a mental check of this, because no one had ever told her she smelt like watermelon.

"Watermelon was your favorite fruit," she realized, looking up at Catra.

"Yeah, it was."

The 'was' lingered in the air, before Catra broke the silence.

"Alright, your turn. And if you even giggle once, I'll be knocking you unconscious."

"Fine by me," Adora whispered softly under her breath, unaware Catra had heard it.

"What?"

"Nothing! Nothing."

Catra narrowed her eyes as Adora straightened herself, holding her arms out straight. Catra bent to get near Adora's waist, but didn't have to go on her knees. Adora breathed slowly, trying to calm her senses as she lifted her shirt. The brush of soft fingers caused her to tighten her abdominals, trying to focus on the pain rather than Catra's touch. More skimming, and a bit of stalling, and-

The door swung open to reveal Bow and Glimmer, both talking hurriedly with books still in hand. Both their bodies and voices

paused when they noticed Catra and Adora, in the centre of the room.

Adora glanced down, whatever tension had built diffused by Bow and Glimmer's presence.

"Adora? Catra?"

Both Adora and Catra sprang away from each other quickly, even though they technically were doing nothing embarrassing. It was a school project, nothing bad.

"Oh hey guys."

Adora kept smoothing down her shirt, avoiding eye contact with both Bow and Glimmer, who seemed to keep glancing between her and Catra.

"Right, well...I think I have everything I need."

Catra moved to pick up her books and Adora frowned in confusion.

"Hang on, I still need to do your arms."

"Yes, arms." Her eyes glanced at Adora's before returning back up to her eyes.

"You know, I think I'll be able to do it myself. It's fine."

Catra backed away from her, turning her head to see Glimmer staring at both of them.

"Watch it, Sparkles."

With that, she left the dorm, but it took Glimmer a few seconds longer than necessary to slowly close the door. She exchanged a look with Bow, and Adora chose to look past it.

"What was that?"

Bow smirked at her, leaning against the one of the thin turrets on Glimmer's four poster bed.

"What? We needed to take measurements."

Adora busied herself, opening her laptop with her heartbeat echoing around her. It closed, and she looked up to see Glimmer's palm on top of the device.

"That was not 'taking measurements.'"

"Um, yes it was."

Adora whacked Glimmer's arm away, reopening her computer.

"You could've literally taken your measurements yourself."

She grabbed the measuring tape and wrapped it around her waist, giving Adora a pointed look. She blinked.

"Oh."

Adora was so dumb she actually didn't think of that, and apparently neither did Catra. It must've simply slipped their minds. It had been a busy day, after all.

"I don't know why you're getting all worked up, are you jealous?"

Adora looked up at her teasingly, but it didn't illicit the reaction she desired.

"I'm not kidding Adora. Don't play with Catra."

Adora rolled her eyes, looking over at a silent Bow.

"I'm not playing with her, I'm just doing my Textiles project."

Glimmer mumbled something under her breath, which Adora didn't catch, and left to go into the lounge. Adora watched Bow quietly approach her.

"Catra's a sore spot for her. I know you didn't do anything wrong, but to Glimmer, Catra took a piece of her mother away....I think she's afraid she'll take you away too."

Bow wasn't angry or disappointed at her, his eyes clean and neutral. But Adora didn't know how to respond. Luckily for her, Bow wasn't expecting one. He walked off in the direction of the Lounge, shooting Adora a final glance before shutting the door. She sighed, closing her laptop gently. She hadn't done anything wrong, so why did she feel like she did? Why did she feel as if she betrayed Glimmer?

_____

"Adora?"

It was dark, the moonlight bouncing off their window and faces, but Adora was wide awake. She turned around, facing a pair of soft colored eyes across the room. She hadn't spoken to Glimmer since her outburst. Both of them had steered clear of each other, Bow being middle ground between them. It wasn't exactly a fight, but Adora wasn't about to apologize for doing her work.

"Yeah?"

Their voices were quiet, careful not to wake Bow or any neighboring dorms. Glimmer sat up, wrapping the soft throw on the edge of her bed around her and waddling over to Adora's side. She sat down on the edge, and Adora sat up, hugging her knees to her chest.

"I'm sorry for overreacting..."

Adora rested her cheek on her knees, looking sideways at her friend, wondering if she should say something.

"It's okay. Bow told me."

Glimmer didn't seem the slightest surprised at that, leaning against the light blue plaster by Adora's bed.

"I figured," she murmured, and Adora scorched across the bed to sit beside her.

"She won't take me away, you know."

Adora's voice was soft, cautious around Glimmer.

"She's Catra, of course she will."

Glimmer didn't sound mad, but there was poison when she murmured the name.

"Catra's been my friend since I was a child, Glim."

"I know, I can't take that away from you."

Adora gave her a soft smile, moving closer.

"That doesn't mean I'll stop being your friend. And besides...we aren't really friends anymore."

"Yeah, I think just about everyone knows that."

Adora breathed a tentative laugh, and Glimmer joined in, the laugh growing substance and becoming lighter.

"We really aren't compatible, huh?"

"Actually, according to your zodiacs, you kinda are."

Adora paused, wiping a few tears from her eyes, and looked at Glimmer.

"Zodiacs?"

"Have you never heard of astrology? Star signs?"

Adora gave her a blank look, tilting and shaking her head. Glimmer gasped.

"Oh my god, give me your phone."

Adora yanked the thing off the charger and handed it to Glimmer. She unlocked it quickly and typed something into the web.

"You're a Capricorn."

Glimmer held up a page to her face, and Adora's eyes skimmed down it.

Stubborn, Hardworking, Disciplined-

"I am not money-orientated! Or work obsessed!"

She pushed the phone away as Glimmer laughed.

"You're really just proving them right with the whole stubborn thing. It's based on your birthday, and determines stuff like your love language, method of communication and other things. Catra's a Scorpio, and apparently, those are compatible with Capricorns."

Glimmer shrugged, and all of a sudden, Adora's interest was caught.

"What are you?"

"A Sagittarius. Bow's a Virgo."

Adora had absolutely no idea what that meant, but she'd look into it later. Probably during one of her homework breaks or something.

"So...what is going on with you and Catra?"

Adora peeled her cheek away from her knees, facing forward with her chin resting on them instead.

"It's...complicated, to say the least. My..mother, Shadow Weaver, taught both of us when we were young. We grew up in the same orphanage."

"Mom did mention the place Catra grew up was horrible."

Adora scoffed. Horrible was an understatement.

"Catra was my best friend in the Horde."

Glimmer looked at her when she said the word, and Adora forgot she didn't know what it meant.

"It was the name we called it, because the owner was called Hordak. Odd name, I know."

Glimmer waited patiently, and Adora took a slight breath. She hadn't talked to anyone about this, not that there was really anyone to talk to.

"Back there, we only had each other...It was us against the world. She was...everything."

Adora burrowed her face into her knees for the last sentence, feeling very vulnerable.

"Argh, what are you guys doing, I'm trying to sleep?"

Bow stood at the entrance of their doorway, rubbing his eyes and scratching his head with a dazed expression. Adora caught a glimpse of his face as his expression shifted, and he slowly drifted towards the bed. She could tell Glimmer was making some sort of gesture towards her, but she didn't know what.

"I sure wish I got to know the Catra you're describing."

Adora thought of the young girl in her memories. They were both in a state of perpetual fear, smothered by adults and bullies...yet that never seemed to burden their friendship. Her memory was shattered by the thought of the Catra she knew now. Cold, callous and snarky.

"Me too."

Bow perched on the edge of the bed, and Adora shifted again to welcome him in. If she was sharing her life story to Glimmer, she

didn't want to bother with repeating it to Bow.

"What about Shadow Weaver?"

Adora gnawed on her lip in contemplation.

"Maybe another night."

Glimmer and Bow didn't push like she expected them too, letting the topic slide under the rug.

"Well, that's my newsflash for the night. Anyone else?"

Adora glanced over at her alarm clock, realizing it was two o'clock in the morning, and they still had school the next day. Somehow, she wasn't tired, but she knew she would regret not getting enough sleep in the morning.

"I'm an open book. Mommy problems and 'sister' problems, so...that's that."

Glimmer sarcastically shook her hands next to her face, and both Bow and Adora laughed softly. They could tell Glimmer was deflecting the pain with humor, but sometimes that's what you needed. Adora knew.

"My dads will expose me soon enough, so stay tuned."

Bow winked and they laughed again, Adora aware he was mimicking Glimmer's tone to lighten the mood.

"You know, I could really do for some ice cream right now."

A spark lit in Bow's eyes and he turned to Glimmer as she turned to him. Adora looked at them suspiciously.

"Then let's get some."

———————

Plant Kink?

"You know, when I said I wanted ice cream, I didn't think we'd actually get it!"

Adora's hushed whispers were dutifully ignored as Glimmer led her to an old statue.

"Light Spinner. She was an old student here, a teacher too, but she turned sour."

Adora stared at the masked woman's face, there was something familiar about her, but she didn't really know what.

"Why's there a statue of her then?"

Glimmer shrugged, pulling down on a broken finger. Adora's eyes widened as the statue moved , shaking the ground beneath them slightly.

"Don't know. I think she died helping the school, or something like that."

"Hurry up! It's starting to get cold."

Bow was right, the heat from summer was beginning to fade, getting replaced by a chilly autumn breeze. Adora's shorts and tank top weren't doing much for her, and she was suddenly envious of the large fluffy robe Glimmer adorned.

"Okay, we need to be quick. This way."

Glimmer crawled through the dirt, Adora hot on her heels with Bow behind her. She was glad she didn't have a flashlight, or she'd likely see the details in the dirt surrounding her. The damp muddy smell was a lot easier to stomach in the darkness.

"Ugh," she muttered as she pulled herself out the other side, knowing she'd need another shower after this little adventure. She

got to her feet, looking around at the benches and cooking materials around her. Various ovens, pots and pans, and large industrial freezers.

"We don't have every flavor in the universe, but we happen to stock most."

Glimmer greedily pulled out tubs and tubs of ice cream, and Bow shamelessly scoured through them all.

"Yes, Cinnamon Crunch!"

Bow hurriedly yanked some spoons from a draw, and Adora gawked at how familiar they seemed to be with the kitchen.

"Well, what'll it be for you then?"

Adora scanned through all the options, her eyes catching on Watermelon, recalling a certain conversation from earlier in the day.

"Raspberry Lemon."

"Ooh, nice choice."

Bow tossed her a spoon from across the room, and Adora pulled the lid off her container. She wrapped a nearby tea towel around it to protect her skin from the cold, digging hard.

"Oh, smell me!"

Glimmer gave her a weird look, understandably, as the sticky ice melted on Adora's tongue, an initial sweet fizz before the sour tangy lemon filled her mouth.

"Just do it!"

Glimmer leaned and sniffed.

"Well, what do I smell like?"

"Dirt, but also flowers, a bit like a garden."

Adora rolled her eyes, annoyed the dirt was ruining Catra's hypothesis.

Bow abandoned his ice cream tub on the bench, leaning in to smell her.

"Hmmm, you mostly smell like your perfume...but maybe there are some natural fruity undertones. Nothing that's distinctly watermelon though."

Glimmer watched Adora with a curious gaze, and Adora was about to ask her what she was thinking, when they heard a thump.

A hand pulled Adora off the bench, and she landed with a quiet thud, bending down to hide themselves as the bright white industrial lights flared on.

"Shit," Bow tried to glance around to see who the person was, but they didn't seem to be revealing themselves.

"Ice cream tubs?...Who's there?"

Is that Perfuma?

Adora's eyes shot to meet Bow and Glimmer's who both had a similar realization.

"Alright, out with it. Who's raiding the ice cream?"

Perfume ducked in between various benches, and Adora just gave up. Maybe they wouldn't get detention if she revealed herself?

"Adora? Are you...eating three tubs of ice cream by yourself?"

Adora looked down at the nearly empty small tubs, about to answer with a affirmation of Perfuma's theory, when both Bow and Glimmer popped up from behind the bench.

"Evening, oops, I meant, morning Perfuma."

Bow gave a cheesy grin, laying on the suck ass performance. Adora was slightly impressed, though she knew she'd do a better job of getting them off the hook.

"Should've known it'd be you three. Deten-"

"Hang on. What are you doing here?"

Perfuma turned a bright shade of orange at Glimmer's question. Adora didn't know too much about the kind lady, she visited them on a weekly basis for a routine inspection of their rooms, and acted as a mentor if they needed assistance with anything, but she wasn't a teacher or anything. Adora didn't have regular lessons with her, more of just polite hallway conversations when they ran into each other.

"You know, just the nightly stroll, and I heard some rattling-"

"The walls are sound proof."

Adora was surprised at how Glimmer was speaking to her, as if they were two classmates rather than a Dean and student. But it didn't seem tense or unnatural, rather Perfuma seemed comfortable with it. Maybe she was like Netossa, and didn't like the barrier between mentor and student.

"Fine, I came for comfort food."

Perfuma avoided their stares as she meandered over to the freezer, yanking out her loose bun to send tumbling crumpled hair down her back.

"Is...something wrong?" Adora asked hesitantly, hearing a slight sniff from the freezer.

"No, no. I'm fine!"

Adora looked over to Glimmer, who was mouthing some incomprehensible. Adora mouthed back What?

"Uh, if it's okay with you, we'll just leave now."

Bow nervously pushed Adora, who reciprocated the action on Glimmer, all of them rushing to get out before Perfuma got her wits back.

"Actually, wait. I have a question for you."

Adora held her breath as the woman turned around, spoon and tub in hand.

"Do you think it's reasonable to break up with someone because they live with a Plant Golem?"

Adora blinked, having no clue what she just said.

"Uhhh, no?"

Glimmer answered for all of them, and Adora slowly released her breath.

"Did...someone break up with you...because you own a...plant golem?"

Adora couldn't help but be intrigued. She didn't know what a plant golem was, or anything that would be helpful, but Perfuma's case was...interesting, to say the least.

"Yes, she did."

She took a deep breath, chewing on the ice cream for a moment before continuing.

"I mean, it's been like a solid five years, and suddenly I'm out because she can't handle my plant obsession? Her words, not mine."

Perfuma sniffled, her ice cream stabs becoming increasingly more expressive. Adora and her friends just stared in silence, they'd never seen a teacher act so disheveled before.

"I mean come on! Who doesn't love a friendly Plant Golem? Would you break up with someone because they liked plants?"

Perfuma looked directly to Adora, whose eyebrows shot up.

"No, of course not," she spoke in her most sincere voice. She wanted to relate to Perfuma, but she certainly hadn't been in a relationship as serious as it sounded, or been broken up with due to a plant obsession.

"I'm sorry. It's just...unfair. What a prickly cactus."

The three of them nodded their heads sympathetically.

"You know, I spent hours trying to clear my energy from her, move away spiritually. But somehow, getting ice cream and talking to you three helped."

She smiled, polishing off the small tub and throwing it in the bin.

"Thanks, guys."

She left the room, as composed as she would've been every other day. Adora turned to Bow and Glimmer.

"What the actual fuck was that?"

_____

Expensive Hangars

The weekend rolled around fast, and Adora picked up her weekly call from Shadow Weaver on a gloomy Saturday morning. She looked over at her desk, smothered by various books and devices. Inwardly groaning, Adora make a mental to-do list. She'd already penciled in Bow's meeting with his dad's for the afternoon in her planner, but she wasn't sure when Glimmer had wanted to go shopping.

"Morning!"

She plastered a smile for her adoptive mother, and received a neutral one back. Adora's false grin quickly faded.

"Hello, Adora. I'm pleased with your results so far, they're excellent, save for Textiles."

Adora awkwardly blushed and turned away, deflecting the praise.

"I'd like to see you soon."

Adora paused, trying to think of what to say.

"Actually, I'm really busy right now. Lot's of assignments, homework and stuff. I could fly down sometime later in the year, but don't bother coming up here to see me."

The thought of Catra seeing Shadow Weaver popped up in her mind, and she made a note to make sure they never ran into each other.

"Very well. We'll organize a date later for you to fly down."

"Sounds good. Um, one other thing?"

"Yes?"

"I'm going shopping with my friends, I was wondering if maybe I could get some money?"

There was a ringing silence on the other end, and Adora wondered if she'd aggravated her, cringing back in defense. The words were ready to slip off her tongue, apologies and promises, but Shadow Weaver finally spoke.

"Yes, I suppose I can transfer you."

Adora slowly loosed her breath, thanking the mentor. Suddenly, she heard a laugh and thump in the other room, and smiled to herself, thinking of her friends.

"Um, I actually have a bit to do now, so..."

"Hmm. You seem busy. I'll be calling around the same time next week, Adora."

Adora nodded and cut off the call, taking a few deep breaths before exploring what Bow and Glimmer were doing.

———————

Adora looked outside at the weather, deciding to wear her puffer over a pair of leggings and crop. A simple outfit, but Bow had specified to not dress fancy. They were just meeting his dads in a coffee shop, nothing too special. She slipped on some platform sneakers and pulled her hair into a loose braid. Bow had adopted the activity of teaching Adora how to braid her own hair, she found she liked a few of the hairstyles.

"Is this alright?"

She spun herself in front of Bow, who just wore a pair of loose jeans, sneakers and a cropped tank. He pulled on a mid length leather jacket, spritzing on some cologne before turning to her.

"Perfect. Let's get Glimmer before heading out."

"How are we getting there?"

Adora walked backwards so she could face both her friends.

"They sent a car for us."

Did everyone in this school just have chauffeurs?

"Oh, hey Adora."

She paused as Catra passed by her, spinning to look back at her. Catra in day clothes was...different. It was as if she was about to go to the gym, sporting an all black look. Adora tried not to stare, her eyes refusing to take in the skin tight sleeved shirt she wore, complete with leggings. She could literally act in one of those badass spy movies. Pulling on a baseball cap, Catra loosened her ponytail.

"What's up?"

Adora finally got the nerve to respond. They had barely spoken to each other all week, ignoring Netossa when she berated them for working individually on their debates. Not so surprisingly, they were put on the same team. But it was easy enough to avoid each other. Catra had elected to be third speaker, Adora was first, and Lonnie was second. They actually won the debate, so Adora found it unreasonable for Netossa to be mad at them. Textiles was worse, though. They just sewed their different pieces in silence, which didn't sound all that bad...Until Double Trouble came around to check on them. Well, if Catra was going to greet her in the hallways, it definitely meant she needed something.

"I was wondering if you were available sometime tomorrow?"

Bow and Glimmer lingered behind her, and she felt their gaze bore into Catra. She didn't seem to care though, looking directly at Adora without a single fear.

"Why?"

Catra rolled her eyes, crossing her arms over her chest.

"To do a fitting for our project, why else?"

A part of her deflated, and she didn't even realize she was being hopeful.

"Oh, right, sure. We can meet in the classroom, I think it'll be empty."

"You can be such a dummy sometimes. Grow a brain."

Catra sounded mean, but her words held a bit of lightness. She walked off, and Adora caught the wink she threw Bow and Glimmer.

"Let's not talk about it."

"Agreed."

———————

"Bow!"

There was a communal cry of joy from the back corner of the room, and Adora's eyes snagged on two warm friendly faces. A part of her was screaming at the fact that she was meeting the Lance and George, but right now, she had to remember they were just Bow's dads. She didn't make to make this like some weird meet and greet. Bow would probably think she was using him to meet his dads or something, and she didn't want him to think of that.

"Well, well, this must be the infamous Glimmer!"

The taller man pulled in Bow for a hug, while the slightly shorter one glanced over at Glimmer and Adora. Adora wondered why this was the first time Glimmer had met Bow's parents when Bow and her had been friends for years. Storing it in her mind for later, Adora put on the most genuine smile she could conjure.

"And who is this? Bow, you don't have a girlfriend, right?"

Adora mentally groaned. Did she just give off 'straight' vibes or something? This was the second time someone had mistaken her and Bow to be romantically involved.

"No, this is Adora. She's new this year and was assigned Glimmer and I's dorm."

George and Lance laughed, and Adora gave a slight wave. Sitting back down, George gestured for them to take seats around the small table.

"What would you kids like to eat, this one over here already had about five cuppas."

George nodded his head jokingly to his husband, who just shook it off.

"He's exaggerating."

Lance rolled his eyes at his husband and Adora smiled at the pair of them. They seemed nice, but Bow was only half heartedly laughing at the jokes, something seeming to itch at him.

"Listen dads, since I'm here, and I only really see you like once in a blue moon-"

"That's not true, we see you like every month," George interrupted.

"You last saw me at Christmas, and that was over FaceTime while I spent it with Angella and Micah."

George and Lance looked confused for a moment before looking down, seemingly ashamed of themselves.

"Oh."

"Yeah, well, a lot has changed."

Adora watched the couple exchange a look before facing forwards expectantly at their son.

"I-uh-"

Bow stuttered, eyes darting around the room. Adora's gaze caught Glimmer's hands as she rubbed Bow's back, careful to keep the interaction away from the fathers' eyes.

"What is it Bow, don't tell me you've gotten a bad report card."

Lance laughed nervously at his own joke, placing his hands at the table.

"Oh, I know what it is."

George looked over to Lance as Bow's eyes flicked up in worry.

"You do?"

Lance exaggerated a wink, and Adora looked at them both in confusion.

"You two are dating, am I right?"

Lance must've caught the comfort Glimmer was providing, and the duo heated up instantly, Glimmer snatching her hand back. Adora inwardly smirked, hiding it as she felt it begin to spread over her face. Oh, this'll be interesting. Glimmer quickly opened her mouth to cut off the suggestion when Bow answered first.

"Yes! Yes, you caught me! Hah, hah..."

His laugh died off, and Adora looked over at him in shock as he grasped Glimmer's hands, their fingers intertwining as he raised them for his dads.

"God Bow, don't scare us like that. I actually thought it was something serious!"

George sighed in relief at their clasped hands while Lance swooned.

"Oh, I just love young love. You know, there's this masterpiece of a poem-"

"That's great dad, but we really don't have to hear a recital."

Adora caught Glimmer's eyes from behind Bow, and made a slight tilt of her head. Glimmer just widened her eyes before they both turned back to the front.

"So, tell us the details then. How long have you been dating?"

George called over a waiter, ordering some coffees as Lance leaned against the table towards the 'happy couple.'

"Uh, we're reaching our three month anniversary soon."

Adora just knew the two of them were making some sort of contact under the table, Glimmer was probably pinching him or something.

"How exciting, you know I always rooted for you two."

Lance winked again as the coffees came around. Adora thanked the waiter quietly, taking a sip.

"Adora, what a splendid name. You know, an ancient warrior had the allias of Adora once."

"Oh, you're talking about She-Ra?"

Lance turned to his husband and Adora looked at him in surprise. She didn't know she had the same name as some old warrior.

"Really, I've never heard that?"

George hummed in affirmation, stirring some sugar into his coffee.

"So, what subjects are you taking?"

Adora put down her mug to meet two pairs of warm brown eyes, George's slightly darker than Lance's. She rattled off her list of subjects, careful not to ramble too much.

"And are you dating anyone?"

She wasn't the least bit surprised that Lance had asked the question, and chuckled when George slapped his arm.

"No, I'm very, very single."

They continued to quiz her on several topics, and Adora was glad that they didn't think of asking about parents, or her family at all for that matter. Bow and Glimmer provided their own input on various cases, such as a recount of how they met and the classes they were taking together.

The coffee mugs remained empty on the tables as they talked, and slowly but surely, Bow seemed to loosen up.

"We better get going Lance, our flight's in two hours."

Glimmer looked ready to protest, but Bow quickly agreed.

"I'll call you guys soon, maybe we can do a fam call or something?"

George smiled, hugging his son.

"Arra's away on one of her expeditions, but we'll try."

George reached to hug Glimmer and Adora, as Lance spoke to Bow.

"I'm so glad we still have you around. The others are running around like headless chickens, but we can always count on our Bow."

Adora had to force herself not to cringe as Bow forced a laugh.

"Yup, that's me! Dependable Bow!"

Lance slapped a hand on his shoulder and Bow threw them a look of concern over his shoulder. They left the coffee shop, Adora wrapping her puffer tighter around herself as the wind brushed her stomach. The weather was so odd here, one minute sunny and the next freezing.

George and Lance left with a few more waves as Bow, Adora and Glimmer piled into the sleek black SUV. At least the windows weren't tinted on this one.

"Post this photo at the coffee shop, Adora. You look good in it."

Glimmer handed her a phone, and Adora looked down at it in astonishment. She didn't even know Glimmer had taken it, her head turned to the side as she smiled at Bow, who was cropped out of the frame. Glimmer was right, the photo was splendidly candid, the unique art of the coffee shop on display behind her.

"Maybe I will, send it to me."

Glimmer smirked at her, and Adora smiled while playfully rolling her eyes, pulling her own phone out.

"And sent. Bow, we're going to the mall, right."

Glimmer looked across the spacious car to their friend, who sat silent by the window.

"Oh, uh, yeah sure. The mall."

He called out the last part to the driver as Glimmer turned to Adora, exchanging words through their eyes.

He's not alright, let's go home.

It's late, the mall will close soon. I'll talk to him.

A pause as Adora thought over Glimmer's prospect.

Alright, but the minute he's sad, we're leaving.

Duh.

Adora nodded, and they quickly left the car as it came to a slow stop. Bow steered the conversation very far away from the fact that he told his dads he was in a relationship but Glimmer, and Adora knew Glimmer was itching to ask him about it. Approaching the large glass like structure, the doors automatically pulled open for them. Adora looked around wide eyed at the place. Soft music played through the speakers, and there were fountains in every wide open corridor. Light danced all around them, shining through the windows as the rain faded, a rainbow beginning to take appearance.

"Wow," Adora gasped, absorbing the lit up shop names and clear marble tiles. And this wasn't even the only floor, there were elevators going up and down as people browsed.

"Behold Alwyn Central, the Fashion Supreme!"

Glimmer waved around her arms as Adora spun on the spot. A shoulder quickly wrapped around her as people began walking rapidly past them.

"Probably best you don't gawk in the same spot. A shopping centre is pretty fast paced, you're acting like you've never been in one."

Bow joked, but there was truth behind his words. Adora looked down, slightly abashed.

"I haven't."

She looked up to see Bow and Glimmer gaping at her, and suddenly felt stupid. Why had she never experienced things everyone seemed to have done? Why did Shadow Weaver lock her away in a room?

"Sorry."

"No need to apologise."

Glimmer and Bow looked at each other as Adora tried to read whatever language they were speaking in.

"That just makes this shopping trip all the more exciting."

Glimmer winked at her and smiled gently, Adora beginning to relax as they walked around.

"What's your budget?"

Adora looked down at her bank account, eyes widening. Shadow Weaver had given her an incomprehensible amount to spend, she didn't even realize she had that kind of money lying around in her savings. She flashed her phone to Bow and Glimmer, who looked at each other with an evil glint.

"Oh, so we essentially have no limit?"

Adora shook her head, raising hands to defend herself as both Bow and Glimmer's eyes sparkled.

"No, no. I never said thaaa-"

Her words were extended as the pair grabbed either arm and pulled her down the wide open walkway. She quickly shut her mouth, deciding that yelling would only draw attention to them and cause people to think she actually needed help or something. Her devious so-called friends yanked her into the first store, so fast Adora barely caught the name of it.

Glimmer momentarily let go of her, looking through various racks with expensive looking hangars (yes, they looked expensive, velvet soft things with embroidery and all).

"What's your preferred style?"

Adora stared at her, awkwardly standing and looking around at the furnished store.

"My style?"

"What vibe do you like, what do you want to wear?"

Adora thought about it, musing over the various 'styles' she'd been exposed too.

"I guess I like comfort? Uh, I'm not really sure, Shadow Weaver picked out all my clothes for me."

Glimmer smiled gently and Adora softened, feeling a little less embarrassed. The sparkly haired girl guided her to the rack, letting Adora flick through the clothes herself.

"I like this?"

Glimmer showed no judgment as Adora tentatively pulled out a pair of leather shorts, the material soft and lined with some tan smooth fabric. Presumably satin, or some fusion of it.

"I like it too."

Glimmer picked it tenderly from her hands, and Adora let her, moving back towards the rack with ease. She selected a few more items, some more bold than others, and Glimmer added all of them.

"Okay, I think I'm done here for now."

"Good, let's get you in the fitting rooms and then we can pay."

Adora nodded as they meandered over the the large circular booths, curtains wrapping around each stall. Glimmer's thoughts seemed preoccupied, and Adora knew it had something to do with Bow. She hadn't seen him in the store, but they both knew he was there somewhere.

"Go find Bow, I can handle myself."

Glimmer smiled, thankful, and Adora swished the curtains shut, changing into the clothes.

She looked...different. In only a few weeks she seemed stronger, more toned. She can't believe she didn't even realize. Apparently the morning runs were doing more than simply brightening her mood. And Adora had booked a private mentor session with Mermista to finally learn how to use the gym equipment. She found herself actually looking forward to doing extra credit.

She stared at herself, the shorts fitting perfectly along with a sleek white turtleneck. She'd gotten one with long sleeves, but she found herself surprisingly fond over the sleeveless version too. She swapped the short red leather jacket for a denim one, but neither seemed to complement the shorts. There were always other shops to look in, perhaps they'd have a jacket for the shorts. Swapping the outfit for another, Adora slipped on the short satin dress Glimmer just forced her to try. She didn't mind it on the rack, but it looked....surprising on her. Not quite hating it, Adora peered into the mirror. The dress was a silky maroon, chosen to blend in with Dryl's color scheme. Glimmer had mentioned that their security was always strict, more than Salineas' at least. She had already designed the perfect outfit to match the dress in her head. Mid length chunky black boots, sheer tights, and a long leather coat. Perhaps a bag to match, though she was pretty sure she'd lose it if she had one.

Coming back out of the change room, Adora held in her right hand the 'yes' items, and the select few 'no' items. Most of the ones she'd chosen were just the basics, as Glimmer had called them. Plain and simple, but the base to any well developed outfit.

Swiping her card and thanking the shop lady, Adora left with a smile, happy with the purchases. There was an unspoken tension between Bow and Glimmer, their voices and laughs slightly strained. Adora debated on whether she should push it, but decided to let it go for now. It was probably better if she just cornered one of them alone to ask about what happened.

The next store specialized in athletic wear, and Adora felt like she was in some sort of heaven. Stacks and stacks of sneakers, entire floors filled with comfy tracks and oversized coats. It was a dream. She loved the tight leather look (especially on certain people), but most times she just preferred comfort. It was the reason why she wore her sport uniform every day, even when she didn't have P.E.

"Bow, I think we'll be in this one a while."

Adora grinned at them.

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Adora Meets Social Media

They arrived home in the late evening, bellies full
from their fast food dinner and bags stacked with clothes. Adora was the primary shopper, but they did happen to run into a few items Glimmer and Bow loved for themselves. But despite the laughs and photos taken, the tension never quite dissolved. Adora chewed on her lip as she hung her clothes, mind wandering as she marveled at the soft fabric, the quality of work that now belonged in her closet. She didn't know whether to approach the topic or not. With the sound of a soft click, indicating Bow was in his own room, Adora decided it was now or never.

"Glimmer, what happened? At the mall today?"

Glimmer's face fell slightly, and Adora felt a bit bad. It didn't seem like something good.

"I asked Bow why he lied to his dads, and well...It was messy. I don't really know or remember how, but I ended up telling him about...that night."

Adora thought back to the hickey on Bow's neck.

"Oh."

"He got mad at me for lying, said that it didn't actually mean anything, so why did it matter....He said that we were just drunk and stupid, and that it wasn't either of our faults."

Adora dropped her clothes, rushing to Glimmer's side as a tear slipped out from the sad pale eyes.

"He said that- that it wasn't the kiss that jeopardized our friendship, but the fact that I lied about it."

Adora hugged the girl close to her, feeling warm tears seep through the fabric of her shirt. She'd never been in love to actually face rejection, if Bow's words could even be considered that. After

all, Glimmer didn't confess to feelings, right? Maybe he was just protecting her... or himself? From what, she wasn't entirely sure.

"You and Bow have been best friends forever, I don't think one lie will ruin that."

"I don't know Adora," Glimmer sobbed softly, burying her face into Adora's shoulder.

"He doesn't want me like that, he just wants to stay friends, and I can't! I can't Adora, it hurts."

Adora momentarily leaned back to grab a napkin for Glimmer, wiping the girl's tears.

"He never said that Glimmer."

"He might've well had."

"I don't know how you feel, Glim, but I know it hurts." She braced herself for her next suggestion.

" I think you should tell him."

Glimmer patted dry her red cheeks, shaking her head quickly at Adora's suggestion.

"Now? That'll just make it worse, no way!"

"You said it yourself, you can't live like this."

Glimmer sighed, turning slightly away from her to the wall.

"It is. Everyday, I feel like my chest is bursting open when he smiles at me, or laughs...It's amazing, and I think of being with him...But then I think of losing him, and it's as bad as living in friendship."

Adora's own chest ached at Glimmer's dilemma, and a pang of jealously blew through her at the thought of having someone so...special.

"If you're not ready to clear the air, let's at least fix the friendship. I can't live with the tension and be the middleman like I was today."

Glimmer nodded and Adora smiled slightly, glad her friend seemed a bit hopeful.

"The best thing to do is apologize to him, so maybe start with that? Just say you freaked out when you saw his neck that morning, and didn't want to make things awkward."

"Yeah, yeah that's good."

Glimmer nodded in relief, hugging Adora again.

"What would I do without you?"

Adora laughed, releasing her friend.

"I honestly don't know."

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Adora rolled over in her bed, stuffing her face inside the warmth of the pillow as her alarm rang loud and clear.

"Adora! Turn it off."

Glimmer groaned from the other end of the room, chucking a pillow on Adora, who reached out a hand to slap the device. Pushing herself upwards and slowly crawling out of the safety of the bed, Adora swiped open her phone, body drained for no particular reason. She felt guilty for skipping her daily workout, but it was needed. She was so tired last night she did absolutely no study, and now her mind was hyperactive with the thought of tests and assignments looming. Flicking open Instagram, Adora was surprised to see a DM from...Catra?

She didn't even think Catra followed her, why did she DM her? Heart rate accelerating ever so slightly, Adora swiped open the

message, sent at eight o'clock last night.

catrabrightmoon: When did u want to meet for tomorrow?

Adora looked at the girl's profile, finger hovering over the follow button. Was that weird? Maybe it was, but then again, Catra had sent her a message. But the message was school related, she wouldn't have sent her it otherwise. Scrolling through the various other notifications, a few hundred likes on her photo, Adora curiously tapped on her own post. She searched Catra's name in the search-bar, heart fluttering when she saw her name pop up. What the hell did that mean? She liked her post and sent her a message, but she hadn't followed her? Adora sighed, wondering how Catra always managed to sneak into her thoughts. She quickly typed out a reply, not wanting to forget and leave her on 'read.'

adoragray: I'm cool with anything, maybe 1?

She exhaled, clicking back on Catra's profile and eyeing the follower to following ratio. What if she didn't follow her back, that could be embarrassing. She was overthinking it, but maybe she'd just reciprocate the like by liking one of Catra's recents. Smiling in satisfaction, she clicked on the recent post, put up two days ago. It featured Catra lying in her bed, closing her eyes as the sun shone on her flawless freckled skin. Adora blushed, noticing the sheets wrapped around her, indicating she wasn't wearing any clothes. Quickly liking it, trying not the think about her actions, Adora went back to her own post, scanning the comments.

doubletrouble: damn darling ;)

glimmerbrightmoon: FUCK YOU'RE HOT

bowandarrows: literally glowing ily <3

arse.an: I like the art.

Adora smiled, the blush only worsening at her friends' exaggerations. Of course they were going to hype her up, it didn't

mean anything special. She passed through her friends' comments, getting to the randoms.

julesx: Is this Glimmer's or Catra's gf?

'Neither', Adora thought, but she didn't bother replying. It was kinda fun to see the speculation.

damjon: hot

seleniaquartz: ship with glim

lainey.clause: mommy, sorry, mommy, sorry?

Adora frowned in confusion at that one, reaching over to Glimmer to look at.

"Glimmer wake up, what does this mean?"

She shook the sleeping girl hard, and Glimmer growled at her.

"What!"

Adora shoved the brightly lit screen in her face, pointing at the comment.

"What does that mean? I'm not good with lingo."

"Clearly, since you just called it lingo," Glimmer grunted from her bed. She squinted, finding and reading the comment before emitting a breathy laugh and sinking her face back into the pillow.

"It means people think you're attractive Adora."

Adora shrunk back, flattered but skeptical. Glimmer was probably just being nice, it definitely meant something else. She kept scrolling through, finding variations of the same comment. Now people were calling her daddy too? She didn't have a child, what? A few just said 'hands', and that was even more confusing.

"Hey, a lot of people ship us." She chuckled at the number of comments mentioning Glimmer.

"We even have a ship name, Glimmadora."

Glimmer seemed unresponsive, and Adora finally put the phone down, noticing as likes and comments kept filtering through. She was surprised that many people were actually interested enough to follow her, but it was probably due to being associated with Glimmer, and apparently some thought her to be friends with Catra. Adora scoffed, that definitely wouldn't be happening anytime soon. Putting her face into her hands, Adora felt the headache that came with the study she had to do. She slowly looked back up, eyes moving around the room at the mess. It was probably best she did some cleaning first, then she'd dedicate the night to school. Leaving it to Sunday night was risky, but she had other things to do first.

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Nothing?

Standing outside the classroom was enough to Adora into a frenzy, her heart beat echoing in her ears as she reminded herself that this meant nothing. Why was she getting so worked up, she saw Catra like every day, this was nothing special? Sure, she was seeing her alone, in a classroom, to do a fitting...but that was insignificant. She needed to calm down, or Catra would smell her fear and prey on it. It's what she did best; manipulation. And being manipulated by Catra was the one thing Adora couldn't avoid.

"Hey, Adora."

She took a breath, glad she wasn't facing the beautiful demon, and slowly turned, keeping her face neutral.

"Should we go in?"

Catra tilted her head towards the door, and Adora pushed it open, waiting for Catra to go first when the other girl waited for her. Adora gave up, walking in first as Catra followed. Adora's eyes panned down to the hangar Catra held, but a cloth covered the item.

"It's not done yet. I need to make sure the shoulders and arms fit before I finalize it, since we didn't get those measurements the other day."

Adora nodded, trying hard to forget the afternoon they spent in her dorm. She thought of her own project, Catra's leather jacket, sitting unfinished on her sewing machine, and felt slightly ashamed of herself. Catra managed to get on top of her workload, why couldn't she?

"Sorry I havn't finished yours yet, I thought we had another week or so."

"We do, I just....had a burst of inspiration."

Catra murmured the last few words, hesitating to meet Adora's eyes, whose were fixated on her. It did indeed look like she had lost sleep, her eyes a bit tired and hair slightly messy. Adora didn't mind it though, Catra could pull any look off.

"Okay, jumper off."

Adora obeyed, slipping off the new grey hoodie she'd bought the previous day. She noticed Catra's eyes scan it before looking back at her.

"Shopping spree?"

She wasn't aware Catra noticed when she bought new items or not, but apparently she did.

"Yeah, I needed some clothes."

Catra nodded, unveiling the artifact of clothing she held in her hands. Adora tried not to gasp at it, a gorgeous oversized letterman jacket. She'd seen them in movies, but never thought of having one herself. She stared at it, soft white fabric with dull red accents. Catra pulled out various stitchings of another bag, Adora catching one with a blue letter 'A' and various other designs. She swiped through them, one eye still marveling over the jacket.

"This is amazing, how did you get these?"

The stitching was flawless, Catra must've paid a hefty price for such unique patches. She looked over to the girl, who pinkened slightly.

"I made them."

Adora stopped, stunned.

"Woah."

Must've been a heck of a lot of inspiration if Catra had made a perfect jacket and patches to be sewn onto it.

"These are really good Catra, you could make a brand."

She watched her move around the other end of the table, their eyes meeting as Adora stood stunned by the item. She wasn't nearly good enough to judge the technique on this work, but the ideas were trendy yet unique. A slight twist on what everyone else made.

"Thanks, I..would like too. Someday."

Catra rubbed the back of her neck, as if...shy? Was Catra even capable of being shy? Adora smiled, finding it a bit cute. Running her fingers across the laid out jacket, Adora felt awed by it. It was stupid really, it was only a jacket after all.

"I havn't used the machine on some parts, I didn't want to risk unpicking it all, so be careful. And I think there are some needles in there somewhere too, so let me put it on you."

Adora definitely knew the struggle on unpicking machine sewing, so she nodded. Catra knew her own work well enough not to accidentally stab Adora with a pin. She carefully guided Adora's right arm into the sleeve, Adora's skin tingling with the gentle touch. She bent down, resisting a chuckle but releasing a smirk when she noticed Catra going on her toes slightly to reach her. The girl narrowed her eyes slightly at her.

"Zip it, Blondie."

Adora's amusement didn't falter, but she forced her smile to fade. She was always the taller of the two, recalling being the one to reach the high cupboards for snacks when Hordak wasn't watching. But when they got caught, somehow, it was always Catra who took the blame. The thought of those memories were quick to wipe the amusement from her mind.

Adora's entire body tingling and fluttering at Catra stood behind her, pulling the back of the jacket on carefully. The soft inner lining brushed against Adora's skin, light yet insulating. She wondered where on earth Catra had sourced this fabric from, it

was exquisite. Catra moved around to the front, and Adora looked down as the girl slowly buttoned her up. They looked up slowly at the same moment, a flush rising to Adora's cheeks as she noticed the proximity. Catra quickly took a step back, eyes roaming over Adora in the jacket. Looking around the wide open classroom, Adora realised she'd do just about anything to get a mirror right about now.

"Well? How does it look?"

She took a slow turn as Catra's eyes stuck to her, and even more heat rose at the expression on her face.

"Good, yeah, it...fits well."

Catra muttered, grabbing the patches off the table and pulling out a pin cushion.

"Stay still, I don't want to prick you."

Adora nodded slightly, letting Catra weave around her, feeling the pressure of the patches being placed against the jacket's fabric. The silence beginning to eat at her, Adora spoke the first thing that came to her mind.

"Where's your cat?"

It was such a random question that she felt Catra pause behind her. Adora inwardly cringed, why did she have to ask about her cat?

"Melog? She's at home, no pets on school grounds."

Catra went back to placing the patches around, and Adora exhaled, only for Catra to pause again.

"Have you been stalking me?"

"What?"

Catra stood, her infamous smirk returning as she circled back around to face Adora.

"Online. I've never told you about Melog?"

Adora averted her eyes, thinking of a quick lie. She had noticed Melog from Catra's Instagram feed, but she didn't want to give her the satisfaction of being correct.

"No, Glimmer told me."

Rather than seeming embarrassed. Catra just scoffed, a needle hanging out of her mouth which Adora just realized.

"Right, uh huh."

She seemed unconvinced, but at least Adora didn't blank and stutter.

"There, done."

Catra dusted her fingers and Adora stayed perfectly still as the artist examined her work.

"It suits you."

"Your inspiration...Where did you get it from?"

Adora let the words slip before she overthought it, waiting patiently for Catra to answer. She didn't, only winked and leaned against the work table.

"A designer never reveals their secrets."

Adora stepped a fraction closer, careful not to move her torso too much or she'd be stabbed.

"I think I might know."

Her eyes involuntarily scanned down Catra's face, and in return the other girl raised an eyebrow.

"Oh? Do you now?"

Adora tried not to get drunk on the scent, deciding to sit down before she did something stupid.

"Yeah, I do."

Catra broke off their internal staring contest , switching her gaze to the side as Adora looked at her neck.

"I can't seem to figure you out," Adora watched Catra's eyes turn back to her, the light hitting the gold one to melt it into honey.

Catra leaned forward, resting her chin on her palm as Adora thought about it. With any other individual, she'd consider whatever they were doing flirting. But Catra didn't flirt with Adora, she played with her. She told her to stay away while drawing herself closer, she tried to get rid of her while occupying her mind to manipulate. It was sick and mean, but Adora couldn't help falling into it. A beautiful trap, masterfully layer

"I'm not a puzzle to be solved, Adora. I'm a human."

"You're Catra. That's a different species on it's own."

A wickedly tempting species.

"And you think you're so easy yourself? You don't think that you confuse me?"

Adora blinked, she hadn't thought of herself as being tricky. She didn't play mind games to wrap someone around her finger.

"Don't act so innocent Blondie, I know."

"Know what? I'm not trying to manipulate you."

"And I am?"

"Yes! This, this is manipulation."

Adora pointed between them, at the body language, the proximity. It was all a game, and she had to snap out of it before she got caught.

"Is it? Is it really?"

Adora jerked back slightly, a bit surprised by the nonchalant attitude.

"If it isn't, then what is it?"

Catra stood while Adora remained sitting, the shorter girl suddenly taller than her. Catra tucked a loose stand of Adora's ponytail behind her ear, the hand lingering on her cheek.

"Nothing. It's nothing, Adora."

She let go, Adora rendered speechless for a moment, by both the touch and words. She held Catra's gaze, unwrapping herself from the jacket without breaking eye contact.

"I suppose it all meant nothing then?"

Her voice was deadly calm as she handed the coat back to Catra, who took it with a straight face, not breaking the eye contact either.

"It meant nothing when you broke it."

Now Adora was just confused. What did she break? Was Catra implying their entire friendship was worthless to her? That those years in The Horde were nothing?

"Bye, Adora."

Catra left the room as Adora just sat there, in a desert of utter confusion.

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Wise Chats

"So what does that mean?"

Adora was flopped across Bow's bed, scrolling through Catra's Instagram feed as Bow leaned against the bed frame, a book about archery or something like it propped up in his lap.

"Why are you reading about Archery anyway, it's a bit random."

"Mr. Hawk said we're starting the unit on it soon, it's my best sport."

Adora looked up from her scrolling, a smile framing her face.

"Huh, fitting. Bow is good at archery."

Bow narrowed his eyes in mock annoyance, swiping away Adora's phone in retaliation.

"You're hilarious, and you have a massive crush."

Adora involuntarily blushed, reaching for her phone.

"I do not! Give it back before you like something!"

She grabbed like a child, jumping up to her knees as Bow scrolled through.

"Oops, my fingers slipped."

Adora tackled Bow as he double clicked on a post, Bow laughing as she finally got hold of her phone, examining the damage done. She wasn't really mad at him, but she was slightly annoyed.

"You dick, that post was like from a year ago!"

"Calm down, she has so many followers she won't realize one like."

"She will if it's from me."

Bow didn't argue that, looking slightly apologetic as Adora sighed, slumping back down on the bed.

"No way to do damage control now, I just have to live in shame."

She sulked in exaggeration, grabbing the pillow and smothering her face. Bow pulled it off quickly, jumping on the bed to sit next to her. Adora wasn't sure where Glimmer was, she wasn't in the dorm when she returned. It was likely due to the prospect of being alone with Bow.

"You know, I think you want to be friends with Catra."

Adora sighed, propping herself up on elbows to look at Bow, mulling over his theory.

"Why do you have to be right?"

"It's a talent."

Bow winked and Adora chuckled lightly at her friend. As much as she hesitated to admit it, seeing Catra around so much and yet being so far away from her was...painful. It was if she was a stranger, someone erased from her life and redrawn back in at the last second. Adora had spent years thinking of Catra, wondering what happened to her after she left...and now she knew. And she didn't want to leave things so weird and hostile between them. She wanted to be Catra's friend.

"I don't know what to do, Bow. I want to be her friend, but she doesn't want to be mine."

Bow hummed in contemplation, looking at Adora as if she was a tricky math problem or something.

"I'm not sure that's necessarily true, repeat the words Catra said. The ones about something being broken."

Adora responded quickly, that specific line repeating like a record in her head.

"It meant nothing when you broke it."

Bow leaned back against the wooden beam connecting to his bedframe, and Adora turned curiously to him.

"Did you make something together? I don't know like an object or something significant in the orphanage?"

Adora mentally flicked through her stored memories of the Horde. There wasn't really any resources available to make something of note.

"I don't recall."

"A deal, a promise or something?"

Adora was about to respond with a "no," when the thought reappeared in her mind. Being dragged away to the office, informed of Shadow Weaver's decision to adopt her....And the promise she made to Catra that she'd come back, that she would be there for her.

"Oh fuck."

"What? What is it?"

Bow came to attention as Adora was dragged out of her thoughts.

"I promised I'd be back, that I'd stay. She was scared, terrified actually, and I promised, I- I-"

Adora yanked her hair tie, the ponytail beginning to give her a headache. She ran her fingers through her hair, thinking back to Catra's young face. The belief that her friend was coming back, and she never did.

"Do you know where her dorm is? Catra's?"

Bow placed his hands on her shoulder as Adora frantically moved, grabbing her jumper in a frenzy.

"Adora. Adora, look at me."

Her panicked eyes found Bow's dark stable ones, and she just stared at him.

"I know you want to try and work things out now, but you're panicking. You can't see Catra like this."

Adora heaved, trying to get enough oxygen.

"But I left her Bow, I left her and I didn't think twice about it."

She pushed the sobs away, she wasn't allowed to cry. Shadow Weaver told her not to. And Shadow Weaver would slap her if she knew she was crying for Catra, for what she had to endure by herself.

Fuck Shadow Weaver.

The thought was thrown out of her mind the second it entered it. She didn't leave Catra for Shadow Weaver, right? She was a child, but still, she had a choice, she always had to choice...and she left.

"I don't know what to, I don't- "

She clung to the firm hands on her shoulders, feeling arms wrap around her. She clung to them, trying to make sense of it all, trying to figure out how to fix it.

"Let it out, all of it."

Adora kept fighting the urge to cry, her eyes welling and throat dry as she choked on her own tears.

"No, I can't."

She felt a sudden stiffness in Bow, and panicked that she'd done something wrong to upset him. Could she do anything fucking

right in the world? She just had to disappoint everyone, didn't she?

She tried to reach back, but Bow kept her in the embrace.

And then she collapsed, unable to hold herself together anymore.

———————

"Feeling better?"

Adora opened her eyes slowly, wiping away the residue built up and quickly pushed herself up in an effort to reach Catra, to apologize. Bow peered softly at her as Adora lifted herself up, disorientated and groggy.

"I need to-"

"You need to relax."

Bow gently helped her sit up, and she rested against the back of the bed, head pounding.

"I feel awful."

Bow grabbed a glass of water from his desk and handed it to her. Adora slowly sipped the drink. The tension wrapped around her mind, slowly. The headache was a living creature, its heartbeat pounding in her brain and squeezing her stomach.

"I know you want to see Catra, but please wait until tomorrow. You need to sort out your thoughts and feelings."

Adora sighed, putting down the glass and rubbing her temples.

"You're right, as usual. I'll wait until I make up my mind on what to say. It seems like she has a lot of built up hurt."

Bow nodded, seeming to release a breath and Adora smiled, thankful for him. She glanced out the window, only to realize it was dark...and she had done a fraction of the homework due for

the week. She groaned into her hands, the headache doubling in its strength.

"I have so much shit to do, and it's-"

She checked the time on Bow's clock, internally screaming.

"Eight o'clock? At night? I'm fucked."

"No, Adora. Stressing is going to do literally nothing for you. Rest for a bit, you can always just take a day off and catch up tomorrow."

"But then I'll just have more to do and it's a never ending cycle."

"Adora, you're not a machine. You need to rest."

Adora leaned back, knowing he was right, but not wanting to admit it.

"Fine. I'll rest for an hour, but I have to get my work done. I have to."

Bow pursed his lips in disagreement, but nodded, and Adora leaned back against the bed frame.

"Where's Glimmer, have you seen her?'

Bow looked down as Adora turned to him.

"No, we haven't spoken the whole day."

Adora gaped, she knew they fought, but she figured it would be resolved by now.

"Bow, would you have told Glimmer if you remembered and she didn't?"

She kept her tone soft, not wanting to aggravate or accuse Bow of anything.

"Yes. It's wrong to lie about stuff like that. Even if it was to protect our friendship."

There was something about the way he said "friendship" that snagged Adora's attention, but maybe it didn't mean anything.

"Bow, do you...like Glimmer? As in, more than a friend."

Bow looked at her, and she knew the answer before he spoke it.

"Is it that obvious?"

Adora smiled, wanting to tell him Glimmer felt the same. She didn't of course, it wasn't her feelings to share. And she wouldn't tell Glimmer about Bow's feelings either...but that didn't mean she couldn't nudge them closer together.

"But she doesn't want that. Why else would she hide the truth of what happened?"

Adora remained silent, unsure how to go about this exactly.

"You never know, Glimmer can have weird reasoning sometimes."

Bow scoffed at Adora's statement.

"I don't think there's any other explanation."

There is. Just fucking ask her.

"Well you two need to sort it out. I can't live in this awkwardness forever. Besides, you shouldn't crack open your friendship over petty shit like this, you'll only regret it."

Bow sighed, glaring at her.

"Why must you be right?"

Adora was smug as she crossed her arms over her chest and looked at him.

"Who's the wise on now, huh?"

———————

Pretty Catra

Adora examined herself in the mirror, for once liking what she saw. Sometimes you had a great vision for an outfit, and then in theory it looks stupid....Thank fuck this wasn't the case.

The boots, although a tad uncomfortable, perfectly matched her sheer tights, which complimented the smooth wine coloured dress and large leather jacket. Adora smiled at herself in the mirror, opening her new bag of makeup products. She didn't really know how to apply any of it, but that was what YouTube and Glimmer was for.

It took about half an hour just to get the eyeliner even, but it was worth it. Somehow, the whole color scheme of her outfit made her eyes seem slightly grey, rather than the clear blue she was used to. She didn't really mind it, but it was definitely different.

"Let's curl your hair."

Adora looked to Glimmer in the mirror, noticing the sparkly eyeliner she wore. Matching the jet black sparkle, Glimmer adorned a skirt and white dress shirt, a maroon sweater vest hanging off her frame and wearing matching boots to Adora. She pulled on a coat, propping the hood on to hide her hair.

"We really don't look like ourselves," Adora said as she stared at their outfits in the mirror. Glimmer nodded absentmindedly, plugging in a curling iron. She pushed Adora to sit on the edge of the bath tub.

"Dryl's hard to deal with. Last year I knocked out their security guy. Mom had to pay for damages."

"Gods, so that's why you were all cut up about last year."

Adora remembered the Salineas party, recalling that Glimmer was an 'angry drunk.'

"Have you spoken to Catra yet?"

"Have you spoken to Bow?"

Adora deflected the question with one of her own. She didn't know why, but every time the opportunity arose to ask Catra the question she bailed. They'd just gone back to ignoring or fighting with each other, and she didn't like it. But tonight was it, she was going to talk to her, actually talk to her.

"I have, actually."

Adora tried to look up at her, but the curler in her hair wouldn't permit it.

"Oh? And?"

"We're friends, just friends. I didn't confess anything, but I made up some bullshit and he pretended to buy it."

"Pretended to buy it?"

Adora grabbed the earrings in her reach, putting them in her ears delicately as Glimmer continued curling her hair. She nudged her to turn so she could do the other side of her head.

"I've known Bow for years, he didn't believe me for a second. We both know it, but I think we're just gonna gloss over it. Pretend it never happened, you know?"

Adora said a 'mhm' in response, careful not to bob her head.

"Maybe steer away from the alcohol tonight, unless you want a repeat of last time."

She partially turned and winked to Glimmer, who rolled her eyes with a smile.

"A party while sober? That's just awkward."

"You don't need alcohol to have a good time. But if you want a great time, then I guess that's the way to go."

Glimmer finished, and Adora stood to brush through the curls with her fingers. She liked it, the once bouncy ringlets cooling to become soft and wavy.

"Thanks."

"For once, we'll actually be on time."

Adora looked down on her shorter friend, slightly taller due to the chunky platform on their boots.

"That's because we're purposely arriving late, Glim. The party has already started."

"Oopsie?"

Glimmer shrugged, and Adora just gestured for her to follow as they left the bathroom, phones in hand.

"What are we saying for ID?"

Glimmer tossed her something out of her purse and Adora swiftly caught it, looking down and smirking.

"Really? Fake ID's for Dryl, that's an effort."

"What can I say? I go all out."

Adora scoffed, pocketing her new ID as they approached the door. Bow rushed out, swiping a hand through his hair.

"Black nails for the night?"

Adora looked down on Bow's nails, suddenly remembering to put her own rings on. She glanced at the stack, opting for silver and slipping on a few for each hand.

"We look so cool."

"We look like Dryl."

Adora corrected him as they left the dorm, careful not to run into anyone who would know they were in Salineas before they walking in the dorm.

"Who's dorm is it in?"

Adora whispered to Glimmer, who slid on a pair of sunglasses as she walked. Adora stared at her friend, wondering what an idiot she was for wearing sunglasses as they walked indoors down the dorm corridor.

"Catra's."

Adora blinked, suddenly coming to the realization that she'd never actually seen Catra's dorm. Every time they'd worked together it'd been in her dorm, and she never thought to question why.

"Is it...sound proof?"

"Obviously. Why else is the party in her and Lonnie's dorm?"

Adora nodded, shaking that fact off and the thoughts that carried along with it. They came to a stop against another generic door, but a student clad in black stood in front of it. Their security seemed a lot more professional than Salineas'.

"Evenin' lad. We just want to get through to the party. We're close friends of Catra."

Bow spoke for them, his greeting accompanied by a wink.

"ID."

They each pulled out their fake cards, Glimmer quickly swiping the glasses off as she avoided eye contact.

"Pass."

He opened the door for them, and they quickly rushed in, just in case he suddenly changed his mind. Glimmer pulled her hood off as Adora marveled at the room around them. A clear glass window substituted an entire wall, showing off the height at which the dorm was placed. Adora found herself wishing their own dorm wasn't on ground level with boring regular windows. The entire dorm was dark or dimly lit in certain areas, everyone's black and maroon clothing blending in like shadows. Adora looked around, hoping to see Catra somewhere. She almost instantly spotted her, the girl wearing a black, pleated leather skirt with fishnet stockings and maroon thigh high boots. She also wore a matching dark belt, more for accessory than practicality. Adora barely got to look at her torso before grabbing a nearby shot. She was certainly unable to talk to Catra when she was wearing that.

"What happened to the noble sober Adora who claimed you could have fun without alcohol? Barely five minutes in and you're already downing a shot."

Glimmer smirked at her, but the alcohol did nothing to keep Adora's eyes off Catra. She wore an exquisite bralette, twined with both maroon and black lace with a detailed neckline and thin straps. Adora had to force herself to look away before she got intoxicated by more than just the liquor. Perhaps she'd just wait a bit before approaching Catra, get herself mentally ready.

Their eyes caught each other's from across the room and Adora cursed, grabbing another shot.

"Woah, you might want to slow down. Have you even had alcohol before Adora?"

Glimmer had poured herself a drink and was sipping it while Adora vaguely wondered when Glimmer had the time to pour a drink? They'd been there for like two minutes. Then again, Adora had already downed two shots. She looked back to spot Catra, but she wasn't there anymore. Adora sighed in relief, glad yet still a bit stung that Catra had chosen to avoid her for the night.

"Hey, Adora."

Adora poured herself another drink before turning to face Catra, her feet feeling only slightly unstable.

"Heyyy, Catra."

At least she wasn't slurring, she just felt very, very happy. And a bit dizzy.

"You moved fast, huh?"

Adora watched Catra look down at her cup and sighed, feeling her own two feet weren't offering the support she needed.

"You look good, like really good."

Adora made a symbol with her hands, sipping more of her drink. Catra seemed to look around.

"Where did your silly little friends go, I'm not getting stuck on babysitting duty."

Adora pouted.

"Unfair! I babysat you last time, the wholleeeee night. It was just you, and me."

She pointed to Catra and then herself.

"God, you're a lightweight, of course you're a lightweight."

Adora chugged the rest of her drink, grabbing a bottle of pretty pink liquid when she felt her hand get slapped away. The same hand, a very pretty hand, pulled her away from the table, but Adora didn't seem to mind it. Pretty Hands could pull her wherever she wanted.

The lights suddenly flicked on, and Adora squinted. Too much light, too soon. She looked at the disheveled bed and inhaled the scent of mint and musk, her favorite scent. She watched the

pretty girl fix the bed up with a dazed smile, looking around at the rest of the room.

"It smells yummy, whatcha cooking?"

The girl turned to face her, smiling a bit.

"Nothing? Come here."

She tapped the bed and Adora skipped over, sitting in her lap instead. The girl flushed a bright red, but didn't move.

"I'd rather sit hereeee instead."

"Doesn't the bed look a lot comfier?"

Adora shook her head.

"Nope!"

The pretty hands gently unwrapped Adora's hands from around her neck, but Adora didn't budge.

"Alright, we have to do this the hard way then."

Adora hummed and swung her feet happily as Catra lifted her bridal style and gently laid her on the bed.

"Where's your phone?"

"I don't knowwww," Adora giggled, feeling the weight of her phone in her jacket pocket.

"Adora."

"Catra."

She giggled when she said her name, watching Catra search her body with her eyes for the phone.

"Where is your phone, Adora? I need it to call your friends."

"Go use your own phone, you meanie. " Adora stuck her tongue out at her. Catra sighed, but Adora only pulled her phone from her pocket and moved it out of reach as Catra leapt for it.

"I can't, my dumbass left it in the other room. Pass me yours."

"Hmm, I'll do it if you play a game with me."

Catra seemed to debate it as Adora wiggled her eyebrows enticingly at her.

"What game?"

"You answer a question of mine, and I'll give you the phone."

"Or, I could just take your phone?"

Catra leaned forward to snatch it, but Adora stuffed the cold metal device down the front of her dress. Catra instantly leaned back.

"Now you can't."

Catra sighed, settling herself on the bed while Adora thought of her question.

"Do you likeeee me? Like do you like me, like even if I broke my promise to you?"

The pretty eyes blinked in surprise at her as Adora flopped on the bed. Adora's gaze darted between the two colors in a bit of a trance. Gold, blue, gold, blue, gol-

"I mean, I don't hate you. That's kinda impossible."

Adora sat on her knees, right in front of Catra, and blinked at her.

"But do you like me?"

The pretty girl just stared at her before finally looking in another direction.

"No, I'm not doing this because I like you."

Adora pouted, flopping back on the bed.

"Heh heh, your room's pretty."

"Thanks, yours is too."

"Why are you so pretty? You'd be even prettier with the leather jacket I made you, I worked realllyyy hard on it. Kept picturing you wearing it to keep me motivated."

Adora waved a finger at the pretty girl, who just quickly looked away.

"You're delusional as a drunk, you know that Blondie?"

Adora sighed, snuggling into the warm, pretty scented sheets.

"Do you think you can stand?"

"Maybe, but only if I hang on realllyyy tight to you."

Catra rolled her eyes, pulling Adora up with her hands. She instantly latched onto Catra, not wanting the scent to fade from her memory. Wrapping a firm hand around Catra's waist, Adora leaned on her.

"Woah, that's a tight grip."

"I have great control over my finggersss."

Catra promptly ignored that comment and propped up the girl, carefully venturing into the dark abyss, also known as a party.

"Catra, did you-"

Adora was beginning to fade in and out of conscious, hearing Lonnie's voice in the back of her mind.

"No, it's not like that, she's drunk. Make sure no one gets any photos, I don't want-"

Adora's eyes shut closed, and she sunk into two strong hands.

_____

Repaying the Favour

Adora reached over as the alarm replayed in her head with a persistent ring, stuffing her face into the pillow. It sounded different, but the pillow was likely just distorting the sound, or she was going mad. One of the two. She debated getting out of bed, but the second it crossed her mind her head pounded and she couldn't fathom getting out of the warm, safe haven. A haven that smelt like-

Adora slowly opened her eyes, rolling over to see a slumbering Catra besides her, flawless as ever.

Without thinking, Adora screamed.

It didn't only hurt her ears and throat, but she quickly shut her mouth as the headache pounded through her again, a reverberating drum. When she realized Catra was blinking her eyes open, she scrambled to get out of the bed, but Catra just pushed her back into the mattress.

"Relax."

The relaxed girl simply burrowed her face into her pillow as if Adora wasn't there, as if they literally weren't sleeping in the same bed right now. Adora panicked when she couldn't recall anything from last night, literally only stepping inside Catra's dorm. Dorm, not room, and downing a shot. How much did she drink?

"What happened?"

Adora massaged her head as she heard a breathy chuckle beside her. She turned her head to see a snarky smile on Catra, who was propping her head on her palm.

"You got drunk. Barely had two shots and you were all over the place."

Adora turned red as she thought of what she might've done the night before. Two shots? Really? Was that honestly the most she could handle?

"Where's my friends?"

"Sparkles and Arrows? I actually have no idea. I went to go find them, but you made that awfully difficult. Passed out and I couldn't handle your dead weight in the crowd."

"Sorry I ruined your night."

Adora didn't like the thought of Catra babysitting her like she was some toddler, but the other girl just shrugged.

"I ruined yours a few weeks ago. Guess I had to pay it back sometime or another."

Adora supposed she was right, she had to babysit Catra at the Salineas party. It was ironic how she had looked after her last night.

"How bad was I?"

"Pretty bad."

Adora looked at her confused, while Catra just smirked at her.

"Why'd you say it like that?"

"Oh, no reason."

Adora just kept looking at her, and Catra just licked her lips.

"It was your word of the night. Pretty hands, pretty eyes,"

Catra leaned closer, eyes scanning Adora's face.

"Pretty lips."

Adora turned beet red as Catra backed away, wishing she could quite literally evaporate into thin air. Catra just laughed at the embarrassment.

"We all do stupid shit when we're drunk, it's fine."

She turned away, rolling onto her back as Adora snuck a look at her.

"Why did you sleep here?"

She remembered how she ditched her own bed to let Catra sleep in hers, but Catra seemed to have no problem sleeping next to a passed out drunk last night.

"It's my bed, I wasn't gonna sleep on the couch someone else was passed out on."

Adora shrugged.

"Fair enough, I guess."

She turned back to look at the ceiling, still unable to comprehend whatever the hell happened last night.

"Did you get drunk?"

Catra sighed, slowly sitting and moving out of the bed. Adora looked away when she saw the oversized shirt she wore, and a glimpse of the very short shorts as Catra stretched upwards.

"You didn't give me a chance too. I had about one glass before you were flailing around."

Well that's that.

"Did I do anything really stupid? Like I don't know, strip or something?"

Catra tapped her chin in mock thought, seeming to mull over the night.

"Let's see... You sat on my lap, made some pretty bold statements, but nothing too bad I guess. I've done worse."

Adora wasn't sure if she wanted to know the bold statements Catra was referring to.

"You did mention something though, a promise."

Catra's back was turned to her, facing the window so Adora couldn't study her expression, only the tone of voice. She direly hoped she hadn't fucked up her apology.

"Oh, uh. It's about the promise, you know.. the one I made?"

Catra was silent, and Adora decided to continue.

"I just...wanted to apologize. I know it was ages ago, but I really do feel bad for leaving and...and not returning."

Adora stared at the stoic figure, before Catra simply turned, picking up her phone from a nearby table.

"That promise was made when we were children, you don't need to give me some pity 'sorry' for it now."

Catra's voice was as cold as ice, morphing into the shape of a dagger that pierced into Adora.

"It's not a pity apology. I am sorry, Catra."

"It's fine Adora. Just forget it."

Adora bit her tongue as Catra left, opening and closing the door softly behind her. A tear slipping out of her eye, Adora fought the urge to sniffle. Her hands automatically moved to brush it away, and she walked into Catra's bathroom to make sure the trace of tears had been eradicated.

Satisfied, Adora grabbed her coat off the bench, opening the door to find the exit. As she walked out the room, the urge to find

Catra was violently forced down. She needed to get out of here, the pathetic attempt at an apology was stupid.

Of course Catra didn't take it seriously, she wouldn't either if she was in her position.

Adora sighed, stuffing her feet in the uncomfortable boots without a bother to lace them up. She left the dorm, running fingers through her hair while finding various texts from both Bow and Glimmer. Walking into the dorm, Adora sighed in relief at the sight of Glimmer alone in her bed. Thank fuck she didn't go at it with Bow again, she couldn't handle dealing with that bullshit a second time.

"Morning."

Glimmer's face reappeared from the pillow, and Adora realized she actually barely saw Glimmer and Bow the entire night. According to Catra, she was stuffed into the room like a child.

"Where were you?"

"Catra looked after me, where were you?"

Adora raised an eyebrow along with the question, and Glimmer just waved her suggestion off.

"I played beer pong with DT for most of the night against Bow. I tried calling you to come play with us, but you didn't answer."

"What if I was dead in a ditch, would you have kept playing beer pong?"

Adora's voice was light, not really serious with the question, and Glimmer laughed.

"Going M.I.A at a party is nothing special, we didn't really think that much of it."

Adora was still new to parties, but she could understand Glimmer's reasoning. Everyone was drunk and running off with each other, Glimmer probably thought she had just turned her phone off or something. Speaking of phones, Adora didn't know where her own one was. She'd have to find that later, wherever the hell she had stuffed the thing.

"Ugh my mom called."

Glimmer was flicking through her phone and Adora looked at her sympathetically.

"I'll see what she wants later, probably gonna shit on me about my grades or something."

Glimmer suddenly turned her phone to Adora, showing a post that she had put up earlier in the night. It was a picture she'd taken of her and Glimmer before she'd gotten her hands on the alcohol, the point of view being slightly above their heads to show off the outfits.

"I didn't know you were going to post this. Tag me."

"I already did, thought it was cute."

"It is. We look good."

Glimmer liked it, commenting something Adora knew she'd check later (once she found her phone) before setting it down.

"We only have a month left of school, thank fuck."

Adora looked up in surprise, eyes flitting to the calendar stuck on their door. She could barely believe they were already approaching the end of term break. Just a few more tests to go before she could somewhat relax.

"That was fast."

"Just wait till next term, we have all our sport days. You'll love it."

Adora's eyes were already shining with the thought of sport carnivals and competitions. She could hardly wait.

_____

THREE DAYS

"What did your mom want?"

Adora was slightly worried about Glimmer, shutting off her laptop when she saw the weary look in the normally vibrant lavender eyes. They'd been talking for a long time, about an hour or so. Adora had hoped it was just a catch up call, but Glimmer's face suggested otherwise.

"She wants to take us to the holiday house this time. For the entire two weeks."

Adora looked over to Bow to see how he would react, but he just turned towards Glimmer with a neutral expression.

"The whole two weeks?"

"She invited you guys to come too, but two weeks is a fucking long time. I tried to negotiate for a few days, but dad managed to get some time off work. Apparently he has a break before his next project."

Adora didn't know too much about Glimmer's dad, but she was curious to meet him. Glimmer mentioned that she rarely saw either of her parents, let alone both at the same time. And two weeks was a long time.

"Is...Catra coming?"

Glimmer gave Adora a pointed look.

"Yes, we are all being forced to come. Well, not you two, but Catra, yeah."

Adora didn't know how to react to that piece of information.

"Which house are we at?"

"Snows."

Bow smiled, sitting next to a disheartened Glimmer.

"At least it's the good one?" He turned to Adora.

"The Kingdom of Snows house is like a cabin. A cabin mansion really, as big as their summer house."

Adora was glad she managed to delay her reunion with Shadow Weaver until the Semester Break, it was clear Glimmer would need her friends to deal through the two weeks. Besides, the snow sounded fun. Warm and cozy.

"Come on, Glim, it'll be fun. We can have a fire, make s'mores, and Adora hasn't even been there before, she won't know how to ski or anything."

Glimmer began to warm to Bow's words, a smile blooming on her face.

"You're right. It will be fun. I'm sure we'll barely have to deal with lectures."

"Exactly."

Adora came around her other side, giving her friend a small squeeze as Bow rubbed comforting circles on her back.

———————

The days began to run by in a blur of tests and assignments. Adora had recollected her leather jacket back from Ms. Ella, receiving her first 'A+' in Textiles for the year. Smiling down at her grade and filled out criteria sheet, Adora handed the jacket to Catra.

"Happy early Birthday."

"You definitely don't remember my birthday. It's ages away from now."

Catra took the jacket from her in surprise, and Adora was momentarily distracted from her single good grade for Textiles.

"October 28th. How could I ever forget?"

Catra was wordless at that, running her hands over the smooth leather as she handed Adora the gorgeous letterman jacket. She touched the soft fabric with reverence, almost feeling unworthy to wear it. It could honestly be sold for a good few hundred dollars, and she was getting it for free.

"Do you remember mine?"

"19th of Jan."

Catra murmured the words, and Adora almost missed it. Almost. Looking over at her past friend, memories of eating grey sludge and swapping torn presents surfaced to her mind. She debated bringing them up, but decided against it. The Horde held some special memories, but she wasn't about to recall the darkest parts of both their lives.

"Are you coming? To the holiday house?"

"Yeah, Glimmer invited me. But I won't if you don't want me to come-"

"No.. No, it's fine. You can come. Just don't come near me."

The bell signaled their release, and Adora watched Catra walk out of the door with an air of sadness. She barely spoke to her, and the apology seemed to do nothing for their broken friendship.

"Don't sweat it, darling. She'll come around."

DT's voice had lost its sassiness, holding something a little more sympathetic. Adora smiled at them as she walked out the door,

hoping that on some level, they were right.

_____

"We only have three days of school left, we only have THREE FUCKING DAYS. DID YOU HEAR THAT ADORA? ONLY THREE DAYS!"

Glimmer violently shook Adora by the shoulders, her blonde ponytail becoming loose with the motion. Adora steadied herself using Glimmer's shoulder, looking into the manic purple eyes.

"Glimmer, it's fine. It's gonna be fine. Bow and I will be there literally at every moment."

"Two weeks with her. All she's going to do is comment on my grades, tell me to fix my clothes and-"

"Glimmer, Glimmer!"

Adora was just about ready to slap her friend's face just to get her attention.

"It's going to be alright. It's a holiday, you should be excited."

"Oh I am, I am. We're going to have baking contests, and I'm going to see Dad, it's going to be great."

"It is. Don't let your mom bring down your mood. A holiday is to relax, not stress."

Glimmer scoffed.

"Ironic you're the one saying that. We practically need a whole extra suitcase for your study kit."

Adora followed gaze to her desk, thinking she just might be right. That stack certainly wouldn't fit in her suitcase with clothes.

"What? I can't take two whole weeks off studying. I hope there are some good trails up in the snow."

"Don't tell me you're doing that god awful run on your holidays?"

Adora gave a sheepish smile, scrunching her shoulders with a shrug.

"I can't help it! It's like a drug."

Glimmer whacked her with a pillow and Adora laughed, rubbing her slightly sore stomach.

"Relax for once you maniac!"

"I will, I will! You better have good ice cream there."

"Ice cream in the snow? You really are a psychopath."

"Ice cream is ice cream, no matter where you eat it."

Glimmer opened her mouth to protest when Bow walked in.

"THREE DAYS TO GO, THANK THE HEAVENS!"

Adora shushed him, wondering what on earth possessed Bow to yell in the dorm.

"I think our neighbors are going to kill us in our sleep."

The others giggled along with her, trying to keep their excitement to themselves as they laughed. Weirdly enough, Adora found herself really looking forward to having a break from everything.

_____

Never Have I Ever...

Going on her usual run and workout felt right, despite practically the entire school still being asleep. Putting on her socks and sneakers, Adora started her warm up.

"Be back by seven, that's when mom said she'll pick us up."

Adora nodded to Glimmer, who wasn't completely passed out for once. Adora's eyes snagged on the empty suitcase, realizing why Glimmer had woken up early.

"Still haven't packed?"

Glimmer made a face at her as Adora chuckled, adjusting her hat. She left the dorm, putting her watch on to track the activity and her heart rate.

The run was brisk, nothing too heavy considering she wanted to hit the gym and get some sets in. She grabbed her gym bag from her locker, putting the keys in her pocket as she approached the glass door to enter.

"Catra?"

She remembered seeing Catra in the gym towards the start of the term, but she hadn't seen her since. Adora just assumed she had stopped going or was trying to avoid her.

"Long time, no see."

Catra huffed as she got off the bicycle machine, wiping a few bead of sweat as she chugged from a water bottle. Adora just stared, trying to find words.

"Yeah, been a while since I've seen you here."

"Lonnie took a P.T course a while back for extra credit, so she has some stuff I can use in our dorm."

Adora looked at her, slightly confused.

"P.T Course?"

"Yeah, have you never heard of it?"

Adora looked at her with a dumbfounded expression.

"A Personal Training Course? You learn about muscle groups and movements. I don't know too much about it, mostly sorta know through Lonnie's old textbooks."

The thought of learning about the gym academically excited Adora, making her all the more curious.

"Has Lonnie finished the course?"

"She finished like a year ago, why?"

The question slipped from Adora's mind like water, as if Catra would comply with her request to have a look at Lonnie's textbook. It wasn't like she was going to take a PT Course anyway, she was on track to become President.

"Never mind, it's nothing. Is Lonnie or any of your other friends coming?"

"No. They're doing something together, separately."

Adora gave her a quizzical look at the tone Catra had muttered in.

"They invited me, I just-"

"You were forced to come by your mom?"

Catra's eyes jumped to hers, and Adora could tell she'd just supplemented Catra with a lie.

"Yeah, I guess."

Catra shrugged and Adora let the subject drop. Her mind seemed to be preoccupied, but Adora didn't want to pry.

"I'll see you later."

Adora nodded, watching Catra put her AirPods back in and hop back on the bike. Adora debated just leaving the gym, but decided against it. She wasn't going to leave just because Catra was here, she actually wanted to get a workout done. Stepping up to the weight rack, Adora began loading the bar. Her head turned as she felt eyes on her, but she didn't look away when she noticed Catra staring. She could stare all she liked, Adora wasn't going to be intimidated into leaving the gym. Somehow, Adora pulled some confidence out of herself, winking at Catra as she ducked under the bar to begin her squats.

That oughta make her look away.

———————

Adora dragged her suitcase behind her, trailing after Glimmer with Bow following close behind her. The one perk of being on the ground floor was the short walk to the parking lot, where Angella stood. The woman was as radiant as ever, glowing skin with eyes that matched Glimmer's and hair that flowed down the length of her back. She looked too young to be a mother of two, Glimmer had once told her people mistook them for a pair of sisters when she was younger. Apparently teen pregnancy was such a scandal for the modern era.

"Hey guys, load up the stuff in the trunk."

Adora looked around for Catra, coming to the realization that she hadn't arrived yet. Angella had two cars for them, both the trunks slowly opening as Angella came to approach them. A pair of men gently took Adora's belongings off her, and she turned her attention to Angella.

"Morning!"

"Good Morning! Are you excited for the holidays? I remember looking forward to them every year, even when I had stacks of homework."

Adora painted on a smile to try and compensate for Glimmer's scowl.

"Not everything is about you mom."

"I wasn't trying to-"

Angella paused, taking a breath as Adora awkwardly viewed the interaction.

"There's snacks in the car, help yourself to whatever you'd like."

She abruptly turned back around and slid into the back of one of the vans. Glimmer grabbed Adora and Bow's wrists with a death grip, walking towards the other van. Just as they reached the van Adora caught a glimpse of Catra approaching them, clad in a pair of grey tracks, a sports bra and a puffer. She raised the sunglasses off her eyes and onto her head as she neared them, Adora lingering by the door while Glimmer and Bow were already inside. One of the men swiftly took her items off her, Catra eyeing Adora as they did.

"Aren't you going to be a little cold in that?"

Adora had never been to the snow, but she was fairly sure it was cold.

"I'll probably change when we get there, but don't worry your cute little head over my clothing choices. Where's my mom?"

"In there." Adora bobbed her head towards the van in front of them, and Catra nodded.

"I'm guessing Sparkles and her boyfriend is in there?"

Catra looked over at the car behind Adora, who thought of correcting Catra but decided against it. Catra knew Glimmer and Bow were just friends (at the moment), she just couldn't handle calling them by their actual names.

"I'll see you around?"

"Sure."

Catra wiggled her fingers as a form of 'goodbye,' walking over to the other car. Adora scoffed to herself, shaking her head as she swung open the door to see two bright faces pressed against the glass. She forgot they could still see outside, no matter how tinted the windows were.

"What was that?"

"What was what?"

"Why did you stay to talk to her?"

Adora shoved Glimmer over as she got in the car, Glimmer shoving Bow as a result.

"Why are you interrogating me?"

Glimmer huffed, letting Adora go, who just sighed and buckled herself up. She wasn't going to hold this over Glimmer, she wanted to have fun. This holiday was going to be fun, maybe even peaceful. Nothing was going to go wrong, she simply wouldn't let it.

———————

"Let's play a game."

They were two hours in. Bow had taken a nap, and so had Glimmer, but Adora was wide awake. She found herself enjoying the silence, but she was still open to playing whatever game Glimmer had in mind.

"Truth or Dare?" She turned to consult Bow, who grimaced and shook his head.

"In a car? How boring. Save it for drunk nights in the cabin."

Glimmer nodded as Adora smirked, leaning against the handle of the car door as Glimmer kept rattling off names of games she'd never heard of.

"Make a list of the ones for the cabin Bow, or I'll forget."

"Spin the Bottle won't work, there's literally only three of us, and that's just weird."

"Yeah no, definitely not Spin the Bottle."

Adora felt kind of useless just spectating the conversation, but she had no valuable games to suggest.

"Oh, Never Have I Ever?"

"That'll be better drunk of course, but we can still play it now. Like a prelim or something."

Glimmer finally turned to Adora, explaining the rules of the game.

"We're gonna go around asking questions, and if you've done whatever the person says, you put a finger down. Here's an example."

She held up five fingers as Bow tapped his chin in thought.

"It's an example, say anything."

"Never have I ever eaten a sandwich."

Glimmer rolled her eyes at the statement, but put down a finger. Adora nodded, understanding the nature of the game.

"Okay, I think I got it."

"Good, I'll go first. "

Adora held up her hand as Glimmer took a minute to come up with something.

"Never have I ever walked in on someone having sex."

Adora shook her head, thanking the stars she hadn't, but Bow slyly put down a finger. The two girls whirled on him at once.

"Who?" They shouted in unison, instantly lowering their voices so the driver wouldn't get annoyed. The partition didn't do all that much to block out noise.

"Sea Hawk and Mermista," Bow whispered the names as if he was telling a secret. Both Adora and Glimmer gasped.

"Where the actual fuck did you-"

"The fucking chem lab."

"I have class in the chem lab!"

Adora nearly screamed at the thought of her teachers doing that in one of her classrooms.

"Did you like, see everything."

"Fuck no. It was dark and I walked into the wrong lab, thinking it was the physics classroom. When I saw them I literally bolted."

Adora and Glimmer blinked, looking at him in shock.

"I didn't even think Mermista liked Mr Hawk. She seemed like repulsed by him."

"Well clearly that's a front."

Glimmer leaned back in her seat, and Adora almost felt numb at the thought. Poor Bow.

"Bow, your turn."

Adora had already thought of her question, but the choice of whether to actually say it or not was confronting.

"Never have I ever had so much tension with someone I made literally everyone in the room choke on it."

Bow said the words in one breath, both him and Glimmer turning to Adora with an accusatory glance. Adora kept all her fingers up, wondering why the fuck they were looking at her like that.

"What? Who?" She genuinely didn't know who they were talking about.

"Catra?" Bow deadpanned at her, while Adora jerked back in surprise.

"That's not tension, that's just Catra being Catra."

"Put the finger down Adora."

"No, it isn't tension between us. It's fueled up anger."

Glimmer wrestled Adora, the seat belt only just holding her back. She yanked Adora's fist and forced her finger down, Adora struggling and kicking her feet.

"Fine, fine. You two just want to get me out of the game," she narrowed her eyes at their dodgy little tactics, their question pulling the trigger for her own.

"Never have I ever had a crush on my best friend."

She found it funny how both Bow and Glimmer glared at her with daggers shining in their eyes, yet didn't look at each other to realize. The idiots weren't putting their fingers down though, making Adora's job even harder.

"Let's not look at each other and do it, maybe even close our eyes?"

"None of us have had crushes on our best friend so-"

Glimmer spoke with another pointed glare.

"I have."

Adora let the lie slip between her lips, Bow and Glimmer turning to her in shock as she put down a finger.

"No way you had a crush on Catra in the orphanage. You were like toddlers."

"I was a very horny child. Now come on, surely you had crushes on your best friend before, just close your eyes and do it."

She hoped this stupid lie paid off, she was sick of living with two heartsick puppies who couldn't man up and confess to each other.

Glimmer made eye contact with her, and Adora tried to communicate as best as she could.

Tell the truth. Please.

The pair closed their eyes, and Adora nearly yelped in excitement as both their fingers went down. It was adorable seeing the blood rush to their faces as they opened their eyes, looking down at each other's fingers.

"You-"

"No, you-"

Adora nearly squealed of happiness, wiggling around like a child in her seat. Bow and Glimmer didn't seem to notice, completely absorbed in each other. Suddenly feeling like she was intruding, Adora opened her phone to try and give them the semblance of privacy. Nope, she still felt odd being present in the car as the

love bugs gazed into each other's eyes. Well, if she was going to be creepy, might as well take a photo. She knew Glimmer would appreciate it later.

Thankfully, the car came to a rolling stop, and Adora nearly gasped when she looked outside at the fresh sheets of icy goodness covering the surroundings.

"Wow," she breathed. Quickly unbuckling herself and getting out of the car, she stepped into the crunchy surface beneath her. Glimmer and Bow hadn't gotten out yet, but Adora didn't expect them too for a while. They'd probably chat for a good ten minutes before coming inside. She held out her finger to pick up the cold substance, ignoring the chill she felt from the wind.

"This is so cool."

"You're acting like you've never seen snow before."

Adora looked up from the ground at Catra, who swapped glasses for a beanie and had zipped up her puffer. Her cheeks and nose were slightly pink from the cold, but she looked cute. Catra suited everything, even puffy pink cheeks.

"I haven't."

Adora continued to marvel at the soft cold surface beneath her, unbeknownst to a very stunned Catra next to her.

"Have you been anywhere?"

Adora turned to her former friend, embarrassed when she saw the shock on her face. Was her upbringing really that weird? Was it so odd she was never exposed outside her comfortable home?

"No," Adora was defensive, mistaking Catra's anger for mockery.

"That fucking bitch."

"What?" Adora dusted herself off as she stood, peering at Catra with curiosity. The shorter girl balled her fists, her face scrunching slightly.

"Locked you up for what, seventeen years?"

"I-"

"Don't Adora. Don't make excuses for her."

Catra held up a palm to pause Adora's statement, and she quickly closed her mouth. She hadn't seen Catra angry for her in years. Maybe at her, but never for. This seemed to be an odd mixture of the two.

"I wasn't going to make excuses for her, but maybe there's a reason she kept me from the world," Adora didn't even really believe herself, but she felt an odd sense of duty towards Shadow Weaver. The woman had raised her, gave her anything she wanted along with opportunities. How could she blatantly disregard that?

"You'll always be the same, won't you?"

Adora opened her mouth to defend herself, but Catra just walked past her without a second glimpse. She smiled thinly, watching the girl stomp through the snow.

This'll be a riveting trip.

———————

Fire of Hope

Adora gaped at the house. It was gorgeous from the outside, of course; a wood paneled exterior and a sleek black roof...but the interior was something else. The design was exquisite. Adora remembered Bow's love of architecture, knowing he must love it. Her eyes caught on the smooth, wide door, hearing the heeled footsteps of Angella walk in. She removed her leather gloves, and Adora distantly wondered if they were doing anything to actually keep her fingers warm.

"It's my favorite spot. The hill is a good few miles from the village, and the village itself is so secluded no one really knows about us. No reporters, no media, just-"

She paused, taking a breath as her eyes fluttered closed. Adora looked at the panel of glass spanning around them, providing a view of the snow capped mountains and a forest a short distance away.

"Refreshing."

Adora nodded, still feeling a bit uncomfortable in the ex-movie star's presence. Angella was a millionaire, and she felt a bit lacklustre, even just standing next to her.

"There aren't any chefs here, meaning we'll be cooking for ourselves."

Adora followed her over to the round wooden table, a firewood oven beside it. Angella walked over to it, opening the drawers to access plates and other cutlery. Adora hesitantly followed, wondering where Catra had went. Strands of cotton candy hair tumbled down as Angella stared down at the plate, looking at it with dismay.

"I can't even cook, what kind of mother am I?"

The question was to herself, a mutter of a breath, but Adora very clearly heard it. Had Angella somehow forgotten she was in the same room as her? The sound of heavy footsteps echoed around them, too slow and methodical to be Catra's. Adora quickly spun in her stool, facing the one and only Micah Brightmoon.

"Micah!"

Angella ran so fast the plate nearly smashed onto the ground. Adora's quick reflexes saved the expensive china, her hand flying out to catch it. She smiled as the couple embraced, Micah tucking his head into the shoulder of his wife. Though Adora felt like she was intruding on a private moment wherever she went, she firmly stayed put on the seat. It would be rude to leave without introducing herself to Micah. Besides, she didn't even know her way around the place. She'd likely end up lost in the maze of the cabin (it was more of a mansion, if she was being honest).

The famous pair finally broke apart, Micah's dark eyes meeting Adora's light ones for the first time.

"This must be the famous Adora I've heard all about?"

Adora bounced off the chair, assuming Glimmer had talked about her in one of the phone calls to her dad.

"That's me! Nice to meet you, Mr Brightmoon."

She shook the man's hand, noticing that he had a similar handshake to Glimmer. She'd never actually shaken her friend's hand, but if she had she imagined it'd feel somewhat like this.

Why do I make the oddest observations?

Micah smiled gently at her, seeming to sense her nerves.

"No need for the formalities, just call me Micah."

Adora nodded, returning the smile while Angella leaned her elbow against her husband's shoulder.

"Would you like me to give you a tour, Adora? I thought Glimmer would handle it, but I havn't seen her or Bow."

Angella seemed to be asking Adora a question without actually even asking it. But Adora didn't even have an answer for her.

"No, I'm sure it's been a while since you guys have seen each other."

The couple gave each other a loving glance, and that cemented the thought in Adora's head. She'd just fumble her way around the place, it'd be criminal to split them up after months of no contact.

"Oh, I'm sure Catra can give you a tour. I don't want you to get lost trying to figure this place out."

No, no, that was definitely worse than being lost in here. It was very clear Catra wanted nothing to do with the three of them these holidays, she'd probably slice open Adora's neck if she had to show her around. Ready to protest and just say she'd figure it out herself, Adora opened her mouth. But Micah beat her to it.

"Catra, get down here!"

His voice boomed around them, bouncing off the walls. Listening to the slight creaking as Catra ran down the stairs, Adora retreated back to her stool near the kitchen island.

"Dad?"

Catra flung herself on Micah, wrapping her arms around his neck. She looked happy, content, and Adora's heart warmed at the sight. She deserved it, after everything she endured at The Horde.

"You didn't tell me you were already here?" Catra released Micah from the hug, directing the question at both her parents.

"I didn't know," Angella responded.

"I wanted to surprise you, but you being your grump self-"

Catra lightly punched her father in the stomach, and Micah exaggerated the pain, doubling over as Catra and Angella laughed.

"Had to go and run off upstairs."

Once again, for the umpteenth time this day, Adora felt like the odd one out. She didn't really mind though, it was good to see that Catra had found a home. After spending years thinking of her, Adora felt some part of her close at the thought that she had a family.

"Catra, you know Adora," Agnela began. Catra turned too meet Adora's eyes, before looking back at her mother.

"Yes?"

"Can you show her around, I can't seem to find Bow and Glimmer."

There was a pause, and Adora severely struggled to resist the urge to cringe. God, this was awkward.

"Sure. I'm starving, are we getting any food?"

Angella looked to her husband worriedly, but he just smiled reassuringly at her.

"I've made lunch, but we can order for dinner."

Angella nodded, looking back at Catra, who simply agreed.

"I assumed you'd want to share a room with Glimmer, Adora, but if you'd prefer a separate one-"

"No, I'm cool with Glimmer."

Angella nodded, yelling out a command to the drivers bringing their suitcases in.

"Bow is in his own room, of course, and Catra?"

"I'm fine with my own room too."

Angella pursed her lips, nodding with a fleeting look at Adora.

"Yes, well, go show Adora around. I'm sure you're eager to settle in after the journey."

Angella smiled and winked at her before returning by Micah's side. Catra nodded her head for Adora to follow her, beginning to climb the wide spiral staircase. She didn't want this 'tour' to be silent and awkward, but she didn't know how to make it somewhat normal.

"There's nothing really interesting downstairs, just the massive kitchen, dining table and a fountain."

Yes, because that was really nothing.

"There's three floors. All of them have at least one bathroom, but other than that they have different facilities."

Facilities? This really was a mansion.

"This is the gym, I think you'd appreciate it the most."

Catra smirked as she leaned against the door frame. Adora peered into the room, the wall removed to show a sleek balcony and outlook of the scenery. It was a full setup: weight racks, equipment, stacks of yoga mats. And clean too, it smelled faintly of lemon.

"Do you workout often?"

Adora looked back at Catra as she asked the question, a pathetic attempt at civil conversation but an attempt nevertheless.

"I aim for five a week, but sometimes life gets in the way. You probably workout non-stop."

"Why do you say that?"

Catra turned away from her, approaching a different area of the house.

"No reason. You just seem like a fitness freak."

Adora debated just ending it there, but instead chose to extend the conversation.

"It helps occupy my mind. Keeps the fog away."

Catra looked back at her as she approached a large clear room, surrounded by iridescent tiles.

"The indoor pool. We have a standard lake that gets frozen over every winter, but its good for ice skating."

The room was magnificent. A glasshouse that surrounded a pale blue pool of water. She hadn't been formally taught how to swim, more taught herself in the backyard, but this pool actually inspired her to add it to her workout schedule. Catra briefly showed her the shower rooms before they left the glasshouse, moving their way around the first floor.

"Guest bedroom, guest bedroom, here's the games room."

The entire 'games room' looked about as big as a standard apartment in New York. Multiple pool tables decked the floor, along with a few table tennis tables and various other machines.

"Bowling-"

"Does this house lack anything?"

Catra paused and turned around to face her, tapping her chin in authentic contemplation.

"Nope, no it doesn't."

"You changed clothes," Adora randomly realized. She still wore the tracks, but sneakers were swapped for uggs and she'd thrown on a jumper under the puffer. Catra shrugged as Adora looked her up and down.

"I said I probably would. I never say things I don't mean," she answered tightly.

She was right, she had said that.

"Martial Arts, Storage-"

She paused, peering into the storage room full of various...armory?

"Melog!"

Adora caught sight of a large furry grey cat, darker stripes running along her coat. The bright blue eyes met hers in curiosity as Catra scooped her up. Adora watched the girl tenderly nuzzle the cat's fur, while Melog continued to stare at Adora over her owner's shoulder.

"Dad must've picked you up from home, huh?"

Catra seemed to notice the cat's gaze, gently placing her pet back on the floor.

"She doesn't like strangers much, took Glimmer a while to-"

Catra cut herself off as the grey cat tentatively walked over to Adora. She leaned down, reaching out a hand for Melog to judge and decide for herself. It didn't take long for the cat to make her verdict, licking Adora's hand in approval, providing the girl with the opportunity to stroke her.

"Just happen to make everyone fall for you."

Adora's gaze switched from Melog to Catra, wondering what the fuck that sentence meant. Catra seemed slightly abashed, as if

she hadn't meant to say it aloud.

"What's that supposed to mean?"

Catra stared at her, and Adora held it, unwilling to let the subject drop.

"It means that you're a people pleaser."

Adora blinked, of course Catra hadn't meant it any other way. Why would she?

"That's the bar. Adults only, apparently. But there's no key, so..."

Her voice trailed off, the bar looking very enjoyable to be in when you're drunk. Lights scattered around the room that dimly lit the place. They approached another set of stairs, more spirals that danced around in Adora's mind as she followed Catra.

"The recreational room. Rock climbing wall, trampolines, you name it."

Adora gazed at the tall wall in front of her, looking back at Catra who she caught staring at her with narrowed eyes.

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

Rather than answering the question, Catra offered one of her own.

"Did you ever think about me, like, after you left?"

Adora met her eyes with as much sincerity she could offer.

"Everyday."

Catra scoffed, but her eyes never left Adora's.

"Why didn't you write, or I don't know, try to contact me?"

Now Adora was confused. She did write to Catra, almost every day in the first year she left. Shadow Weaver always comforted her when she'd cry over a lack of response, murmuring that Catra wasn't worth her tears.

"I did. Shadow Weaver said you ignored me."

Catra took a few steps closer to her, as if to judge whether Adora was telling the truth or not.

"Shadow Weaver is a liar. I never received any letters from you, I'd wait every damn day at supper and they never came."

Her voice was deadly stoic, almost as if she wasn't surprised. Maybe she wasn't. Anger bubbled up in Adora, keeping the information stored to ask Shadow Weaver in their next call.

"I don't know what to say."

"Did you miss me? Did you feel anything? Or was it all perfect in your little Adora bubble?"

Adora opened and closed her mouth several times, rethinking the words on her tongue.

"I'm sorry I got adopted before you, but you have no right to hold it over me like this. I was six, what did you expect me to do, turn down the offer? Would you have? Go on, be honest."

"Yes! I would've, and you didn't."

"Then you're an idiot, Catra."

"For protecting my friend? No, Adora, you're just a coward."

The memory of the orphanage burst in her head, but she swallowed it down. It came sometimes, in flashes, but every time it did she felt like throwing up.

"If it was you instead of me, I would've let you go. Without a second thought."

"That's because it wasn't. It was you, Adora, it's always been you! She's obsessed with you, it's sick."

"She's given me everything I ever needed, I have to be grateful."

Catra didn't speak, and the pair just stood in front of each other for a single long minute.

"But you're not."

The harshness was gone, replaced with a simple truth.

"I-"

"You aren't grateful, and you beat yourself up over it every day."

"There's a lot of things I beat myself up over."

"Am I one of them?"

"Yes," Adora breathed without thinking twice about her response. She let whatever came to her mind fly out of her mouth.

"Is there any hope for us, for our friendship?"

Adora thought she may break if the answer was 'no,' but she knew she had to try.

"I want there to be, I just don't-"

Adora didn't register the rest of her sentence, flinging her arms around Catra in a hug. She slowly felt hands clasp around her back, sending a shrill down Adora's spine and a fire to her heart.

Try

The girls slowly broke apart, staring at each other as if they'd seen a ghost. They might as well have; that's exactly how it felt to hug her. Like she was reaching into some hidden, deep part of herself and filling an empty, vast cave.

"The-the tour. You need to see more."

Catra's words were broken and Adora let go of her, feeling a bit fuzzy yet light. Exhilarated was the right word to describe it.

"Right. The tour."

Adora nodded but neither of them moved from their places in the room. Feeling the need to say something, Adora was ready to open her mouth when she felt the presence of two people near them.

"Glimmer? Bow?"

Adora turned to face them fully, a flash of a smile on her face at their clasped hands.

"Finally."

Her words could be taken many ways, but it summarized her thoughts pretty damn well.

"Hey. Sorry we took so long."

Glimmer very obviously winked at her, and Bow nudged her in the side, whispering something which she giggled at.

"You are dating, right? I can confirm that for sure?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes but Bow responded to her with a clear answer.

"Yes. We are, as of now, in a relationship."

Bow blushed at the words as Adora made a silent squeal in excitement, rushing up to hug them.

"You have no fucking idea how hard it was knowing you two liked each other."

Bow and Glimmer hugged her back before Adora let go, beaming at both of them. But Glimmer narrowed her eyes, looking past Adora's shoulder to Catra.

"Ugh, forgot she's here."

"Hey, she's my friend, or potential friend. Don't be mean."

Glimmer gaped at her, glancing between Adora and Catra.

"Wait, what?"

"I'll explain everything, but don't-"

"Don't waste your breath Adora, these two will never like me."

Catra brushed past them on her way to the door, and Adora yelled out her name to stop her from leaving.

"I get it, I wouldn't like me either if I was Sparkles."

They all went silent at that as Catra gave a half-baked smile, something shining in her eyes.

"I'll let the lovebirds take over the tour."

Catra raised two fingers to her head and flicked them as a gesture, wrapping a hand around the door frame as she left. Adora moved to go after her but Glimmer blocked the path.

"What the fuck was that?"

Adora sighed, deciding that she should talk to Bow and Glimmer before running after Catra.

"Sit down, we're going to be here for a while."

_____

"Holy fuck."

Bow and Glimmer stared at her aghast as Adora finished telling them a recount of the conversation, Glimmer more-so freaking out while Bow silently studied Adora.

"That-That's a lot. Like a lotta lot."

"I know."

"Wait, so you're going to be friends now?"

Adora lifted herself off the ground, catching Melog's eyes as she passed by the Rec Room. The cat paused slightly before she continued, and Adora turned to start pacing around the room.

"I honestly don't know. I asked if we had hope to be friends, not if she actually wanted to be friends right now. What if she wants to be friends like in a year, or in college, or-"

"I think she wants to be friends now, Adora."

Bow cut her off, finally speaking after being silent the entire time. Adora whirled around, beginning to walk in the other direction.

"Really? Do you really think so?"

Bow glanced at Glimmer, who glanced at Adora.

"Yeah, I think so."

"And that comment she made before leaving? Was that-"

"That was nothing. I tried to be Catra's friend for years when we adopted her. All she ever did was bully me. I'm sorry Adora, you can be friends with her, but there's no way I can."

Adora settled herself in front of Glimmer, doing her best 'puppy eyes' possible.

"Please, pretty please. For me?"

She clasped her hands together as if begging, but Glimmer huffed and rolled her eyes.

"Nope."

Adora turned to Bow with the same expression, hoping he'd be more open towards Catra.

"She has until the end of these holidays to prove she's not just fucking with all of us."

"Deal. But you have to promise to actually try, and invite her to things."

Bow nodded, still slightly hesitant as Adora pounced back on Glimmer.

"Try."

"No."

"One chance"

"I've given her plenty."

"Just one. Tonight. Please, Glim."

Adora knew Glimmer's stubbornness had weakened enough for one night the minute her eyes turned to her own.

"Fine. But if she screws up one time-"

"Off with her head, ya da da da."

Adora flapped her hands, grabbing both her friends around the necks for a group hug.

"You guys are the best, I love you."

"We love you too, Adora," they said in unison, and Adora swore she heard the smile in their voices.

"Okay, I'm gonna find Catra to...clarify."

"Adora, do you know your way around-"

"I'll figure it out!"

Adora yelled to them as she ran out the room, jogging up the stairs. She didn't know for sure if the main bedrooms were on the last floor, but the second floor didn't feel very 'bed room-ey.'

She walked upstairs to find herself in a library. A gorgeous library, with rolling ladders and clean wooden bookshelves covering every surface of the walls, but not what Adora expected. She kept walking around, her eyes catching on a golden handle. Could it? No way. She decided to knock first, just in case.

"Who is it?"

Adora sighed at the sound of Catra's voice, glad it wasn't Angella and Micah's room.

"Adora."

The voice was silent on the other side, not telling her to come in nor go away. Adora took that as a somewhat good sign, cracking open the door in case Catra freaked out. But it wasn't what Adora expected. Catra was still on the bed, a book in her hands as she glanced up at Adora.

"I'm sorry about Bow and Glimmer."

"Don't be, you don't have to apologize for them."

Catra looked back down at her book, calmly flipping the page as Adora stood by the door.

"Do you maybe want to hang out with us this evening?"

"It's already evening."

Adora looked outside to find Catra was indeed correct. The stars were brighter in the snow, it was beautiful.

"Well, tonight?"

Carta met her eyes, closing the paperback and putting it down on the table beside her.

"I think it's best if we don't do this Adora."

Adora reeled back, looking at her aghast.

"What? Try?"

Her tone was incredulous as she looked at a peaceful Catra, seeming to have come to this decision abruptly.

"Glimmer and Bow will never accept me. There's no point-"

"No point? Catra, I thought you missed me, I thought you wanted to be my friend?"

"I do, Adora! But your friends don't want me around, and I'm not going to ask you to choose. I already know who you'll pick."

"One night. An hour at least. Just...try?"

She grabbed the girl's hands, Catra looking down at them as Adora stared at her friend.

"I'm not asking for much, please?"

Catra looked up, her gaze softening slightly as she met Adora's eyes.

"Okay. One night."

"Yes!"

Adora squeezed her hands, hoping that everything would just work. Just for tonight, no fights, no explosions, just...happiness.

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Truth, Dare, Or Drink?

Eating with Angella and Micah was awkward enough, but when the parents left the kids downstairs to spend some time together, Adora thought she was literally going to throw up. They sat at the dinner table, eyes flying around with awkward eye contact happening every few seconds or so. Glimmer cleared her throat and Adora took it as a cue to say something.

"Whatcha wanna do?"

She stretched out her limbs in an effort to fill the space, nudging Bow beside her with a foot.

"Uh, bar?"

Some alcohol right about now would probably help.

"I agree, let's get drunk."

Adora and Bow got out of their chairs, Glimmer and Catra following with deathlike expressions. Adora narrowed her gaze at both of them, but didn't make the comment. At least they weren't fighting.

Bow darted up the stairs ahead of them, Adora watching as he cleared them to go to the bar. Glimmer opened the door, the room dark until Adora found a light switch. As soon as she flicked it the dim lights brightened the room, albeit only slightly. Catra instantly moved behind the bar, drumming her fingers against the mahogany before pulling out various bottles.

"Where's the fun in just drinking?"

Catra winked, and Adora thought she just might die.

"Catra, no. Where'd you even get a dealer around here?"

Glimmer's tone was firm, but Catra just blinked at her, expression deepening all the more.

"What are you on about? I was thinking 'Truth, Dare, Drink'?"

Bow looked at his girlfriend, who smiled and nodded at his suggestion.

"What's that?"

"You'll figure it out pretty quick, don't bother explaining."

Catra unscrewed the vodka, pouring it into the shot glasses with a delicate expertise that actually made Adora suspicious. Did she like do a bartending course or something?

Catra put them on a diner's tray. Carrying it in one hand to the place next to the wall where Bow and Glimmer had situated themselves. Adora still had no idea how this game was played, but the name seemed simple enough. She'd figure it out eventually, she hoped.

"I'll go first," Glimmer eyed the shots Catra put in front of them warily, Adora catching the suspicion and nudging her friend.

"I didn't spike the drinks, Sparkles. I'm dirty, but not that dirty."

Catra settled herself against the wall, and Glimmer appeared to relax slightly. Maybe she saw some truth in Catra's words, it gave Adora some hope.

"Adora, truth or dare?"

Adora looked over to Glimmer with mock betrayal.

"I don't even know how to play this game and I'm picked first?"

She punched Glimmer lightly, trying to decide which route she ought to take.

"Truth."

Glimmer pondered for some time, all of them watching her quietly as she mulled over what to say.

"How long have you known that Bow liked me and didn't tell me?"

Adora struggled to remember, maybe in the middle of the term? She knew it happened during their fight somewhere. It felt like eons ago.

"Maybe a few weeks? And don't get all spunky with me, I didn't want to break my trust with you or Bow by telling the other."

The feisty girl wiggled her nose at Adora playfully, huffing in a corner before Bow gave her an affectionate peck on the cheek.

"Okay, Adora. Now you choose someone and ask them to choose between a truth or dare. If they choose truth, think of a question to ask, if they choose dare, then well, choose an action?"

Bow paused in his instructions, thinking of the right words to say so Adora understood what he meant. But Adora got the basic gist of the game. She already had in mind who she wanted to ask.

"Catra, truth or dare?"

Catra leaned against the wall, exposing the length of the neck as she thought over the words.

"Dare. Do your worst, Blondie."

She made a little motion with her hands and Adora sat up to attention, thinking of a suitable dare for Catra to perform.

"Let me go through your search history."

She held out a palm, but Catra downed the shot so fast that Adora's head spun. She smirked as Catra wiped her mouth, face pinching at the taste of the alcohol.

"Oh, now I'm really curious."

Glimmer peered at her adoptive sister with glinting eyes, looking down at the jet black device in her hand. Catra seemed to clutch the thing tighter, eyes darting between Adora and Glimmer.

"I drank the shot, so don't even try."

Adora made a mental note to try anyway when Catra fell asleep, knowing Glimmer would very much be eager to join her.

"Okay Arrows, truth or dare?"

"Truth. There's no way I'm taking a dare from you."

"Boring."

Catra faked a yawn, staring at Bow as she cracked her knuckles. Adora sunk back further into the wall, watching the interaction with baited breath.

"Do you love Sparkles?"

Adora nearly flinched at the name, hoping Glimmer wouldn't tackle Catra for it. But her friend seemed so accustomed to the nickname she barely showed a reaction. Her stare was stuck on Bow, as if waiting for the answer.

"Yes," Bow didn't miss a beat.

"Platonically, or romantically?"

"You only get one question, and I've already answered it."

Catra rolled her eyes, indignant to Bow's reply.

"Glimmer, truth or dare?"

"Dare, obviously," she smiled with a flick of her short candy colored hair as Bow stroked his make believe beard.

"Give Catra a hug."

The lavender eyes crossed between her adoptive sister and the shot glasses, as if in a moral dilemma.

"Oh, come on. How hard is it too hug?"

"Too hard."

Glimmer made up her mind, reaching for the glass as Catra exhaled.

"Thank fuck Sparkles. Nearly gave me a heart attack just then."

"Catra?"

"Oh for fuck's sake. Why me again?"

"Because I'm mean. Go on, truth or dare?"

"Ugh, truth. I don't feel like moving."

Glimmer seemed to have the question all ready to go, not hesitating to pause and think.

"Would you die for Adora?"

This caused the air to leave Adora's body, feeling as if her life depended on Catra's response. Thankfully, she didn't ponder on it too long.

"Yes. What a stupid question, I thought you could do better Sparkles."

Rather than gritting her teeth like Adora expected, Glimmer was silent as she blinked at Catra. Adora smiled to herself, feeling elated at the mindless answer Catra gave.

"Sparkles, truth or dare?"

"Oh come on, what about us?"

Bow pointed to himself and Adora, but the girls just waved them off, in some weird internal competition.

"Dare."

Catra smiled, and the look was pure malice. It made something in Adora tighten, probably her fear of whatever Catra was about to say.

"Walk into Mom and Dad's room right now. No knocking, no sound."

"Fuck THAT."

Bow and Adora burst into laughter at Glimmer's animated response, the girl grabbing a glass and drinking up.

"Alright, I guess you win for now." Glimmer narrowed her eyes at Catra, who just smirked at her wordlessly.

"Adora?"

"Dare."

She was beginning to get sick of the truths, they seemed too thought provoking when it was this late at night. Besides, she could handle a dare.

"Ugh, Bow, help."

Bow winked at Adora, making her wonder what the fuck he'd thought of as he leaned to whisper the idea in Glimmer's ear.

"Oooh I like it!" She nodded and turned back to face Adora.

"Bench Press Catra."

Glimmer was smug as Adora looked at her dumbfounded.

"Like...her weight?"

"No, like her."

Adora looked towards Catra, eyes scanning up and down. It was likely she could bench press her, but how? This seemed like a dare for the two of them, rather than just Adora. Catra shrugged as Adora's eyes moved up to meet her's.

"I'm down."

Catra didn't seem the slightest phased, letting Adora make the decision.

"Alright, but we are going to the gym. I'm not doing it on the table."

Glimmer nodded, a smile creeping onto her face as they temporarily abandoned the bar for the wide open gym.

Adora looked nervously at the equipment, hoping that she wouldn't drop Catra. That'll just cause a world of problems.

"Are you sure you're strong enough?"

Catra's eyes moved to Adora's arms, staying there longer than necessary.

"Yeah, I'm sure," Adora responded, looking at Catra's thin frame. Looks could easily be deceiving though, Catra could secretly have a lot of muscle. That would actually make her heavier, even if it doesn't physically show. Adora took a breath and straddled the bench before leaning backwards and positioning herself. She did a few reps with the empty bar to make sure her muscles were warmed up as Catra stood beside her.

"Drop me and you're dead."

Adora chuckled in a breath, internally terrified that she would actually drop her.

"Uh, how do we do this?"

"Can you guys like help?"

Adora yelled out to Bow and Glimmer, who were snickering by the entrance as Adora and Catra tried to figure out how to position themselves.

"Nope! It's a dare, no help offered."

Adora grumbled under her breath, shooting a dirty look at the couple whispering by the door.

"What about you grab my calves and back?"

Adora nodded, suppressing a blush as Catra used another bench to gain height over her laying down. Twisting her body, Catra moved over her and Adora latched onto the places she suggested, trying to keep her breath as level as she could.

"Yeah, I should not have agreed to this while tipsy."

Adora remembered the shot Catra had taken, trying not to laugh as she moved her elbows down. She was right, Catra looked light but she had muscle. Quite a lot of it actually. She caught a glimpse of the girl's face as she brought her down near her chest, her arms crossing across her torso and eyes squeezed shut. Using all her strength, Adora pushed back up again, completing the rep. At least she wasn't sweating...Oh nope, she was. She had to get up now without dropping her. This was possibly the hardest part, there was no way Catra could safely get to the floor by herself. Adora began to lower her down while engaging her core to sit up, cradling Catra on the bench.

"It's over, you can open your eyes now." Adora spoke the words gently, though she kinda liked seeing Catra scared. The girl opened her eyes one at a time, blinking at the light.

"We are never doing that again."

Adora let her get down, looking up at a grim Bow and Glimmer with a wink.

"Oh, I'd do it again to wipe the smirks off their face."

Her comment provoked Catra to turn as look at the pair before turning back to Adora with a shy smile.

"That I can enjoy."

The group made their way back down to the Bar, the tray of shot glasses still mostly full.

"Bow, truth or dare?"

Adora felt like payback, hoping Bow wouldn't be a bitch and choose truth.

"Dare."

Alright, he chose dare, now what? Adora thought about it, what could she make him do that would even top Glimmer's dare for her. Without a request, Catra leaned in and whispered in her ear, sending ripples down Adora's skin. How was she so casually hot? It was honestly a talent.

"Make Sparkles pierce his ears."

She leaned back as Adora thought over the suggestion. She liked it, she liked it a lot.

"Let Glimmer pierce your ears."

Bow's eyes widened, eyes turning too Catra in disbelief.

"Here I was, thinking you were cute! That little performance in the gym was clearly an act."

"I am not cute!"

Adora laughed at Catra's squeal, she seemed absolutely outraged at the thought of being cute.

"A cute demon, you are."

Catra huffed, crossing her arms over her chest in defiance as Glimmer laughed with Adora.

"Well? Are you two a bunch of wimps, then?"

Glimmer and Bow eyed each other nervously, each one tilting their head to the side as they looked at the other.

"I mean, you would look hot with it?"

"Fine, get the needle."

Glimmer dashed from the room, probably to 'get the needle' as Bow had instructed her. Glimmer shortly returned, wearing a pear of gloves, a bar of soap, a lighter, a needle and a pair of earrings.

"Can she just do one?"

Adora looked to Catra, who shrugged, letting Adora decide. She glanced at Glimmer's nervous expression.

"Okay, you can just do one."

They both exhaled in relief, Glimmer wiping Bow's ear with an alcohol swab and positioning herself. Bow sterilized the needle with the flame, passing the scorching tool to Glimmer who had meanwhile marked the piercing with a pen. Bow looked shit scared, making Adora feel slightly bad for making them do this. Then she remembered the unprovoked attack made against her and Catra earlier, and her sympathy evaporated. Glimmer placed the soap behind his ear, taking a breath as the needle sunk into Bow's ear. Moving quickly, Glimmer substituted the earring for the needle and stuck the backing into it.

"Yes, no blood!"

Bow turned to hug her as Glimmer poked her tongue out at the girls.

"Hah hah, suck it!"

Bow scanned across them, clearly wondering who to pick. Adora hoped he wouldn't choose her, she needed a bit of a break.

"Catra."

"Truth, truth, very much truth, please."

She waved her arms in surrender, cracking a laugh out of Bow. Bow looked between Glimmer and Catra, Adora picking up on his thoughts. She did a slight shake of her head to get Bow's attention, but he ignored it.

"Why don't you like Glimmer and I? If it wasn't for Adora, you'd be throwing eggs at us right now."

Catra moved to get the shot glass but Glimmer pulled the tray out from under her, Catra glaring as she leaned back.

"Not for this one. Answer the question."

"I was abused before I got adopted, did you seriously expect me to play 'happy adopted child' bullshit?"

Glimmer was taken aback, and Adora quickly recognized the defensive look in Catra's eye. She was so used to seeing it in the orphanage, the need to protect herself. She didn't need to feel that right now, Glimmer and Bow won't hurt her.

"But you were nice, you were my friend before school started-"

"I was. Because I thought maybe it could be good. You were....her replacement."

Catra looked towards Adora, who blinked at the words. Glimmer was Catra's supplement for some time, it made sense. In a strange unfamiliar setting, Catra might've felt comfort in living with a friend, as she had with Adora in The Horde.

"But you didn't need me, you already had Bow. That became fucking obvious when school started."

"Catra, you can have more than one friend. Just because I was friends with Glimmer doesn't mean you couldn't be friends with me too."

"Yeah, well tell that to a therapy starved eight-year-old. I don't know, maybe I realized that Sparkles wasn't Adora, and your friendship, well-"

"It reminded you of her."

Adora was speechless, gaping as Catra avoided her eyes.

"So your logic was to bully us?"

"Lonnie and the others were already doing it, and I was put in her dorm. I didn't want to be an outcast in the school, so I decided to..."

"Own it," Adora finished quietly. The silence was deafening, and Catra was on the verge of breaking it when Glimmer jumped on her, pulling the girl into a fierce hug.

"You fucking idiot. Took you what, like nine years to finally admit the truth?"

Adora heard the cry in her voice, feeling herself tear up as Catra hugged back.

"I realized, I realized years ago after my sessions with Scorpia...But I was a stubborn bitch." Glimmer laughed, still not letting go.

"And so was I."

Glimmer finally released her, moving back beside Bow who smiled at them with Adora.

"Okay, Catra, your turn."

Catra didn't bat an eyelid.

"Blondie, truth or dare?"

"Dare."

Adora met the challenge in her eyes with a clear response. She wasn't going to back down, it would be too satisfactory for Catra, even if she had already backed down herself.

"Hmmm...Go outside and jump in the lake."

Adora knew Catra had already taken a shot, but she couldn't be drunk enough to suggest this. Glimmer made an outburst from next to her.

"Are you crazy? She'll literally die."

Catra pushed the tray of shot glasses towards her, clearly expecting Adora to take one. But she was in a defiant mood.

"Adora, you aren't actually going to do this, right?"

Adora brushed off Bow and Glimmer's looks at her, moving towards the door.

"Woah, hang on, are you serious?"

Now Catra looked at her in pure shock, as Adora moved out the door, debating if it was better to jump in with clothes or without clothes.

As she reached the front door she paused, hearing the sound of footsteps and voices follow her into the foyer.

"Why the fuck did you dare that?"

"I didn't think she'd be hellbent on doing it!"

Ignoring the hushed argument, Adora let steely determination seep into her, unlocking the door as the wind pushed against her. The cold was biting, and her hoodie and tracks weren't really doing much to protect her from it.

"Adora, you really shouldn't. Fine, I won't make you drink a shot."

Adora turned to Catra who stood in front of the door, some hardened resolve in her eyes. Who knew why, but somehow she saw this as a way to prove herself. It started as a competition, but now, something in her needed to do it. Maybe to show Catra she was willing to freeze her ass off in order to be friends?

"I know, but I'm going too anyway."

She moved past her into the open air, boots crunching in the snow as she moved towards the frozen over lake. It glistened in the moonlight, reminding Adora of liquid mercury with the silver lining. The lake was beautiful, it'd be a shame to crush it.

Oh well.

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Irreplaceable

It was important she didn't swim in it, or she'd lose the hole and god knows what would happen then. Biting her lip, Adora reconsidered. Nope, it was too late now.

Her fingers numb from the cold, she absentmindedly grabbed a fallen tree branch, getting on her hands and knees to break through the thin layer of ice. Luckily it'd only been snowing for the past week or so, the ice wasn't even thick enough to stand on. Adora had to spread her limbs out to avoid just falling in.

"Holy fuck, you're insane."

Catra breathed from behind her, but Adora didn't turn to face the others. At least she knew she had back-up in case things went...south.

The surface finally cracked, and Adora gasped as her hand fell into the icy liquid. It wrapped around her skin like a claw, as if pulling her under. Adora had to look down to check that an animal hadn't grabbed hold of her, but no, it was just the water. With a deep gulp, Adora pried off her boots and hoodie, preferring to get less warm items of clothing drenched for when she had to hike back up the hill to return to the house. She gently slid her legs into the small hole, cringing at the icy claws grabbing up at her. Catra was right, she really was insane.

Carefully twisting and lowering herself into the water, Adora dunked her head, hearing the last of her friends' cries as she fully submerged into the freezing water. Her entire body numbed as she swam back to the surface, searching for the small opening that she'd gone in

Fuck.

Her hands met a solid wall of ice, ice that seemed a lot thicker when she was underwater compared to being on the surface.

Pounding on the cloudy wall, Adora struggled to hold her breath, opening her mouth and exerting her energy on trying to get her friends' attention. Why did she feel a random urge to prove herself? Why was she such an idiot? The banging slowly became weaker as she drifted in and out of consciousness, the black lake beginning to fill her....

Adora woke to attention as the ice split open, a hand grabbing her around the waist and pulling her to the surface. She reached for air, gasping as her vision faded in and out. Her savior pushed her onto the icy surface, and Adora kept gulping down deep breaths, trying to get air to fill her lungs again. She wiped the water from her eyes, looking down to see Catra heaving herself out of the water, also breathing deeply. Adora began to speak when she realized she couldn't move her mouth. She was completely numb from the lake. Catra pointed towards the nearby land, and Adora understood, carefully shifting herself across the ice.

"Oh my fucking god, oh my fucking god!"

Glimmer was practically screaming, her face red and splotchy as tears ran down her cheeks. Adora nearly collapsed into her, Glimmer bearing most of her weight as she struggled to get to the house. Adora was shaking uncontrollably as she staggered, her limbs still unfeeling and weak when Glimmer wrapped a blanket around her. She didn't know where Catra was, and it was eating at her.

"Cat-Ca," she stammered as Glimmer flicked on the automatic fireplace.

"Bow's with Catra."

Adora burrowed deeper into the blankets, Glimmer saying things she couldn't hear.

"Adora! Take your clothes off."

Adora nodded, beginning to take her shirt off and tracks, Glimmer helping her redress herself and wrapping the large fluffy blanket

around her once again.

"You scared me to death, don't you dare do that again!" Adora was barely processing her words, still thinking about the feeling of hands wrapping around her and pulling her body up to safety. Catra, she needed to see Catra. A distant bang sounded somewhere in her head, and the door opened short after, featuring a frozen Catra also wrapped up in a blanket.

The girl tackled Adora to the floor, their blankets wrapping and tangling them together as Catra latched onto her.

"What the actual fuck was that?"

Her voice was strained from the cold, but Adora managed to hear her.

"I tried to get her to change first, but...."

Adora peeked behind Catra at Bow and Glimmer who sat by the piano, watching them fondly.

"Don't you dare scare me like that again!"

Adora softly shushed her, hearing the rasp in her voice as she struggled to speak. Catra obeyed, staying silent but unyielding to leave Adora's side. Bow eventually managed to get her off for enough time to change into dry clothes, but the two sat by each other for long minutes as they thawed.

"Why did you do that?"

"Why did you dare me to do that?"

Catra rolled her eyes, rocking into her with a nudge. Adora laughed, almost rolling over to her side if it wasn't for her balance.

"I didn't think you'd actually do it. I just wanted to see you take a shot for chickening out."

"That backfired."

Catra chuckled.

"Severely."

"Are you feeling warmer?"

Bow and Glimmer approached them with two steaming mugs. They definitely did not need half an hour to make hot chocolate, but Adora ignored that fact. Adora clutched the mug like it was a lifeline, the steam instantly warming her face.

"Thanks, I needed it."

"Don't you dare think of doing something like that again, or I'll personally drown you in the lake."

Adora would've laughed if it wasn't the spark in Glimmer's eye. That girl did not look like she was joking.

"I don't know what possessed me, sorry guys."

Bow sighed, moving to sit in front of them.

"Don't be sorry, just don't do it again."

Adora nodded at his words. Whatever that weird impulse was would have to be swallowed down. Glimmer yawned, resting her head against the piano which prompted Adora's eyes to move to the clock.

"It's nearly morning, we should go to bed."

"Are you two thawed enough?"

Glimmer already looked ready to pass out, so Bow asked the question for her. Adora still felt stiff, but both Bow and Glimmer were tired.

"It's fine. You guys go to bed, we'll go in a bit."

The pair nodded, getting up and softly closing the door behind them, leaving Catra and Adora alone with the fire as their only source of sound. Adora stared at the embers, wondering if she should speak the words in her mind.

"You know how you said Glimmer couldn't...replace me?"

"Yeah?" Catra's murmur was soft as Adora turned to look at her, the light of the flame coating her features.

"I couldn't replace you either."

Adora turned back and nuzzled her face in the fur, feeling Catra's eyes fall on her.

"Thanks, that...means a lot."

Adora nodded, beginning to feel her eyelids droop. The fire was almost like a spell, putting her to sleep...

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Mad MILF

"Catra! Adora!"

The room was still dim, the fire still on while her body felt sore from sleeping on the ground. Aching limbs and joints, Adora turned her attention on the woman standing before her.

"Angella?"

The sound of heeled boots reverberating on the wooden panels was enough to wake Adora up completely, causing her to slowly lift herself, her body still weak but at least not numb. She wiggled her fingers and toes, relieved to find they were back to functioning fully. She spun herself in the blanket to see Catra blinking up at them, wrapped in the blanket like a burrito.

"Did you girls sleep here?"

Adora knew Angella was purposefully ignoring the tray of shot glasses across the room where the Bar was, and she appreciated the lack of comment.

"We jumped into the lake."

Angella looked about ready to scream, moving closer to check their foreheads with disbelief.

"While drunk?"

Oh, guess she was going to acknowledge the alcohol then. Dammit

"Actually I was sober, and Catra only had a shot-"

Adora was cut off with the subtle hit from Catra, Angella's eyes intently turning towards her daughter.

"Let me get this straight. You got drunk-"

"One shot Mother, relax."

"You had alcohol," Angella amended reluctantly, "and jumped into a freezing pool in the middle of the night? Am I supposed to be proud or something?"

"Geez, where's the love here, you know we did freeze our asses off last night."

Catra was so nonchalant about it, brushing off Angella's anger as if it was a piece of fluff on her clothing. Adora wisely decided to stay silent.

"What on earth prompted you to go jump in the lake?"

Catra shrugged, meeting Adora's eyes for a second before answering.

"Don't know, really. It looked pretty, and you said yourself, we were drunk."

Angella narrowed her eyes with pursed lips at her daughter.

"I thought you said you had one shot?"

"Oops, maybe I had a few more."

Angella sighed, massaging her head with her hands as she took a few breaths. Adora wordlessly thanked Catra for not throwing her under the bus, mouthing thank you to her. Catra just ignored it, looking up at her stressed mother.

"And how are you feeling now?"

"Good. Sore, but good."

Angella sighed, muttering something incoherent under her breath that neither Adora or Catra were able to detect.

"I thought we'd go skiing today, but it's best if you two rest. Did Bow and Glimmer happen to be with you when you jumped into

the ice cold lake?"

Was Angella still mad? She sounded very passive aggressive, but Adora wasn't very good at reading people.

"Yeah, they helped us warm up. I think they went to bed though, I don't really remember."

"They went to bed," Adora confirmed with a nod at Angella.

"Alright. Why don't you two head up to your beds and Micah and I will bring some breakfast up to you?"

Adora smiled at her, thankful yet guilty she was being a nuisance to them. It was Angella's break too, she didn't deserve to deal with her and her antics.

"Thanks, Mom."

Angella smiled at them, about to leave when Adora stopped her.

"You and Micah don't have to stay with us the whole day. You looked excited to go skiing."

Angella looked at her, eyes flicking back again to the shot glasses.

"I'd like too, but I think it's best-"

"Lock up the cabinets, we'll be good."

Catra interrupted her, looking at Angella with pleading eyes. Angella examined Catra, unable to make a decision.

"We'll see. Maybe after lunch we'll head out, but I need to make sure you're both in perfect condition. No damaged goods."

"No damaged goods," Catra repeated. It seemed to be a familiar phrase for them. Angella threw them one last fleeting smile before leaving. Carefully unwrapping herself from the blanket, Adora moved to stand up.

Yep, literally every muscle was tight and stiff, but she was still able to move. Catra extended a hand, prompting Adora to haul her up to her feet. But Catra wobbled and fell right into her, nearly pushing Adora into the wall in surprise.

"Sorry, felt a bit dizzy."

Adora nodded as Catra steadied herself, still clutching to Adora's forearms for support.

"Better?"

Catra nodded, finally releasing her as they walked towards the exit. Adora's felt something soft brush past her and quickly looked down to make sure she didn't have brain damage and was hallucinating. Thankfully, it was just Melog, who stared up at her with big blue eyes.

"Hey, Melog."

Adora reached down and scratched the cat behind her ears, emitting a soft purr from her.

"Are you a cat whisperer or something, I've literally never heard her purr with anyone but me."

Adora looked back at Catra and shrugged, continuing to let Melog enjoy the treatment. Catra stretched, reaching on her toes as she picked up the discarded blanket and tossed it over her shoulder.

"I'm going back to bed, come with?"

"What?" Adora blurted, wondering if she was having hearing issues or something. Catra smirked, wrapping the blanket around her neck.

"Upstairs? It's where all the bedrooms are, including yours."

Adora felt heat rise to her cheeks, following Catra up the stairs. She'd forgotten that the third floor held the library as well as the

bedrooms. It was all it was reserved for.

"Right, forgot."

Catra chuckled lowly as they approached the top, Adora glancing back at Bow's room, wondering if he was actually there. Catra gave her a knowing look before opening her own hidden door and slipping inside, leaving Adora outside Glimmer's room. It was probably best she knocked.

"Come in!"

Adora opened the door to see Glimmer sprawled on the mattress, the sheets a mess around her. Her own bed was illuminated by the light of the window, as pristine as ever.

"I'm surprised Bow didn't sleep here."

Glimmer patted the spot next to her limp body, slowly moving to get up and face Adora.

"It's been like a day, do you think we're animals or something?"

Adora chuckled, tucking herself under the sheet as Glimmer slowly leaned back.

"How was sleeping on hard wood for ya?"

"Horrible. I was already sore from the ice, but now it literally hurts to move."

"Guess no workout today then?"

Adora chewed her lip, avoiding Glimmer's eyes as she glanced out the window with a guilty expression.

"Adora! You shouldn't even be considering it."

"I know, I know. But it helps me feel put together? Like I feel incomplete, there's a hole in my heart."

Glimmer looked ready to whack her with a pillow, but restrained herself at the last moment. She'd probably remembered Adora wasn't in her best physical condition.

"You have a serious problem."

Adora laughed, her sternum aching as she moved. God, it even hurt to laugh? She'd be knocked out for days at this rate, maybe even weeks. And it was her holidays too. A soft knock sounded outside the door, interrupting them as Glimmer called out.

"Come in," she clearly expected it to be Bow, but it was Angella instead. Adora wasn't complaining though, the goddess held a plate of toast stacked with eggs, avocado and bacon. Adora recalled the mutter she made earlier about being unable to cook, but this seemed to prove otherwise. Even if it was just toast and eggs.

"For Adora. Glimmer, I hear you're perfectly fine, so I'll be seeing you downstairs."

"But can't I keep Ado-"

"Nuh uh. You barely spoke a word last night at dinner, I'd like to see your face these holidays."

Angella waited as Glimmer paused to give Adora an apologetic look. Reaching over to give her a hug, Adora was surprised when the girl whispered in her ear.

"I'll bring some life saving medicine up later. Trust me, you'll be fine by tomorrow."

She let go, reluctantly pulling herself off the bed to join her mother as they left before leaving to go downstairs. Adora just shrugged to herself, digging into the meal.

_____

Slopes

Glimmer was right, that medication was more than just simple drugs. Adora woke up the next day feeling almost as good as new. Albeit, her chest was slightly sore and it was a bit more painful to take deep breaths...but everything else seemed fine.

"Glimmer, what the hell was in those pills you gave me?"

Her sparkly friend didn't share her secrets, only giving Adora a wink that made her awfully suspicious. Deciding to let it go because whatever she gave her worked, Adora sat down at the table. She expectantly looked at the stairs, waiting for Catra to come down them in her usual fashionable manner.

"What do you think guys, up for a ski trip? Adora, if you're not feeling better, don't lie, we'll just-"

"I'm fine, just a bit sore is all. Nothing I havn't handled after a brutal upper body day."

Angella laughed as Micah came around with a stack of pancakes, wearing a chef's hat with a 'Kiss the Cook' apron.

"Payment please?"

He turned to his wife, who smacked his chest playfully, about to pull him up when Glimmer made a noise.

"I do not need a demonstration of how I was born, thank you very much."

Angella smiled and released her husband, who returned back behind the counter with a chuckle.

"There she is, the Beauty Queen."

Micah clapped his hands together as Catra dragged herself down the stairs. She threw a look at him with a hiss.

"Sheesh," he held his hands up in surrender as a very sleepy Catra dumped herself in a chair at the table.

"There you are sweet pea."

Micah placed a table of pancakes in front of Glimmer with a kiss on her forehead. Adora looked imploringly at the fresh stack sitting on the bench, knowing it was greedy of her to want both eggs and pancakes. Feeling a pair of eyes on her, Adora looked up to meet Micah's soft dark ones. They resembled Glimmer's, even if the color of hers matched Angella's.

"Go ahead, there's plenty."

Adora launched herself at them, everyone laughing as she grabbed a plate to help herself.

"What about you, Cats?"

Angella's soft question reached the ears of all, and Catra soon joined Adora in stacking her plate.

"Not hungry?" Adora asked casually, looking at the measly stack on her plate. Catra leaned over and drizzled some syrup on it, delaying her response.

"I don't like food in the mornings, makes me sick."

So that explained why all Catra ever ate for breakfast in the cafeteria was fruit.

"You good for skiing today, Catra?"

Catra twisted her neck around, Adora returning to her place at the rectangular wooden table.

"Sure, it's been a while."

Adora dug into her food, not even realizing when Catra claimed the seat opposite her.

"You don't know how to ski, right?"

Adora looked up to see her methodically cut slice through the pancake, raising it to her lips.

"Nope, sounds fun though."

Adora slowed down, feeling her stomach begin fill up. It was best she didn't consume too much, she'd just end up spewing in the snow.

"If anyone decides to post something, don't tag the location." Angella directed her statement to the entire table, all nodding. They certainly didn't want the paparazzi interfering with their holiday, that would only cause more issues.

"Glimmer tells me you're a natural athlete Adora, I'm sure you'll pick it up in no time."

Adora looked down, twisting the ends of her ponytail at the kind comment.

"Oh, Glimmer's exaggerating. I'm not an athlete, I don't even play any sports."

"Yeah, but you run like ten kilometers almost every day and still find the energy to do a full ass workout," Glimmer supplied. Adora wasn't even aware she knew her workout routine. Angella raised her eyebrows at Adora with interest.

"Really? That's pretty impressive, do you have a position on one of the teams."

Adora shook her head, raising another piece of pancake to her mouth and chewing in thought. She finished her bite quickly so she could respond.

"No, I missed the try outs at the start of the year. I don't even know how to play most sports anyway."

She caught sight of Catra's fists clenching on the table, vaguely wondering what that was about.

"You sound pretty active, I'm sure I could get you a try out application if you wanted?"

Adora waved her hands, but Glimmer answered verbally.

"You should, you'd actually be really good. Beat the dicks out of the Prime Elite bast-"

"Glimmer," Angella warned.

"Maybe. I'll think about it, I don't even know what sport I would play."

Feeling eyes on her, Adora looked up at Catra, who appeared to be studying her.

"Basketball. I could definitely seeing you playing Basketball."

Adora hummed, recalling the singular time Shadow Weaver had permitted her to using the television. A basketball game was on then, and she did find it interesting.

"I'll think on it."

———————

"WoAHHH!"

Adora squeezed her eyes shut as she toppled into a heap of snow, groaning as she pushed herself up. Glimmer's faint laugh from behind her caused her to turn around and stare daggers into the girl.

"You have to keep your legs sturdy or else you'll wobble all over the place, like Bow is doing."

She pointed over to Bow, who expertly slid down the nearby hill, coming to a stop at the end. He slowly moved towards them as

Adora accepted Glimmer's hand.

"It's these stupid things," she lifted her feet attached to the skis, almost toppling over with the movement.

"How do you manage to even move with them on?"

"I already told you, take small sideways steps. Like this, especially if you're going up a hill."

Glimmer slowly inched towards the hill, literally going at a snail's pace. Bow finally reached them, removing his ski goggles.

"Got the hang of it yet?"

"I thought this would be fun, but I'm useless at it."

She bent down to pick up her 'stick thingys,' as she'd named them, moving in the same way Glimmer was towards the hill.

"And it's so slow to get up, I do not have the patience for this."

Bow laughed, climbing up the hill alongside her. They paused, Adora feeling more than uncomfortable with the number of people stopping to spectate them. It was more to spectate Glimmer than anything, but she seemed accustomed to it, or at least presented herself that way.

"This ski slope is one of the less popular ones, Mom thought we wouldn't have to shut it down."

"It's because of the holidays. Everyone wanted a get-a-way."

Adora nodded with Bow's statement. At least there was no paparazzi, people just momentarily staring at them wasn't the worst to deal with.

"Let's just hope none of them leaks the location," Glimmer murmured under her breath, catching another camera subtly pointed at them.

"Where's Catra?"

Adora realized she hadn't seen her since they got their equipment set up, which was about half an hour ago.

"Show off's over there," Glimmer pointed to the tallest hill, where a figure slid down in record time. Adora wondered if she should approach her or not. Though it seemed like they were all friends, she hadn't really spoken to her the previous day. They'd been in the same house, yet Catra spent all her time in her room while Bow and Glimmer acted as Adora's personal assistants for the whole day. It was pretty cute actually, Bow acted as a scribe, writing notes on her iPad for her while Glimmer fed her the regular doses of medicine.

Adora was snapped out of her thoughts as Catra approached them, unbuckling herself from the skis to avoid side stepping.

"How's the baby slope going, Princess?"

Catra smirked as Adora avoided rolling her eyes.

"I'd much prefer snow runs over this."

Catra stared at her, lifting her goggles and unclipping the helmet.

"You are such a dummy."

Adora stuck her tongue out at the nickname, eliciting a laugh out of Catra.

"If everyone else is going to take photos of me, I might as well do it myself."

Glimmer huffed, pulling out her phone to take a selfie with Bow.

"Here, let me help."

Adora turned at Catra's voice beside her, suddenly realizing she was on top of a hill.

"You've got a strong core, so make sure it's locked in tight as you're heading down."

Adora nodded, tensing as Catra moved around her. The mint and musk seemed lost in the wind, but Adora still managed to catch it when Catra brushed past her.

"The narrower your feet are, the faster you'll go."

"I'll keep them very wide, then."

Catra bent down, pointing to the top of the skis while looking up at Adora.

"When you need to stop, slowly twist your feet inwards. Make sure your legs are in full control, and don't get ahead of yourself."

Adora squeezed her eyes shut, about to push off when she felt a slight pressure on her arm.

"You can't do it with your eyes closed," Catra smirked at her, not letting go until Adora opened her eyes. She pouted at her, scared for no good reason. Catra rolled her eyes, but the smirk didn't fade.

"Fine, if I go with you will you do it?"

Adora nodded her head like an eager puppy, Catra buckling her skis back on and adjusting her equipment. Raising her own set of goggles on her eyes, Adora readied herself.

"This is not because I like you," Catra muttered, snapping her goggles on her eyes.

"Yeah, sure."

Adora jokingly flicked her wrist at her before taking off, the wind pulling a few strands hair into her face. She wasn't able to put it in a ponytail with the snow gear, hence the flying blonde pieces in her face. Remembering what Catra had told her, Adora gradually

positioned her feet inwards to form a wedge, coming to a slow stop at the end. Catra slid next her barely a second later, and Adora was so elated she unbuckled herself from the skis herself to pull her friend into a hug. Catra took a second to respond back, returning the hug as a joyous Adora jumped in the snow.

"I did it!"

"You did," Catra looked to her with an amused expression.

"Take a photo with me, I wanna post."

Catra raised off her goggles and smiled with Adora as she opened the camera. Taking a few photos, Adora quickly posted them to her feed without a second thought.

"Do you want me to tag you?"

Catra shrugged, clipping herself out of the skis.

"Sure."

Adora nodded, tagging Catra in the photo and uploading it.

"Hey, I still don't follow you," Catra pulled out her own phone and Adora quickly got the notification of a new follower. Adora followed her back, tucking her phone back into her pocket and putting her gloves back on.

"Woo hoo, she didn't die!"

Bow raised his hand for Adora to hi-five as Glimmer pulled her in for a hug.

"You must be a pretty good teacher, Glimmer and I couldn't get her to do it."

Adora watched Catra's eyes flick to her's before back to Bow.

"Nah, she just decided to focus this time around."

Catra shook off the compliment, checking her watch for the time.

"What is it?"

"One. We should find Mom and Dad for some lunch, I'm hungry."

Glimmer agreed along with Bow, both of them packing up their ski equipment to put back in the cars.

"But I just got it!" Adora whined, taking her helmet and goggles off. It was refreshing to have the wind push against her hot face.

"We'll be back later, come on."

Catra tilted her head towards the car and Adora followed. Her phone buzzed, and she opened it to see an incoming call from Shadow Weaver. Adora glanced up at Catra who peered at her expectantly, quickly declining the call and putting it back in her pocket. Shadow Weaver could wait just a little longer.

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Lies.

"Where should we head for lunch, kids?"

Bow pulled up a local restaurant's Instagram profile, passing it around the car. Micah was driving theirs while Angella drove the other, the teenagers spread amongst them. Adora scrolled through the restaurant's feed, nothing really appealing to her but she couldn't be bothered searching for another place.

"Good enough," she passed it back to Bow, who nodded.

"Are you sending it to Glimmer?"

Adora was nervous about Glimmer, Catra and Angella being locked up in a car for half an hour, but it wasn't her place to express that. Though Glimmer and Catra appeared to be on somewhat good terms, she didn't really know what would happen when Angella was thrown into the already dangerous mix.

Adora looked over nervously to Bow as they arrived at the restaurant, anxiously waiting for Angella's car to pull over behind them.

"Do you think they'll be fine? What if they're not fine? What if-"

"Adora, chill. They've lived together for years, although that was when they didn't really talk to each other...." Bow trailed off, doing nothing to ease Adora's nerves as the girls stepped out of the car.

"Why do you look like you're not on a holiday right now?" Glimmer raised an eyebrow at her, making Adora plaster on a synthetic smile and wave her arms.

"Me? Anxious? Nooo, why would I be anxious?"

Glimmer nodded slowly, very obviously in disbelief at Adora's antics.

"Right, well are you going to go inside, or are we going to feed these people more photos?"

Glimmer's eyes shifted over to the crowd dining outside, all of which instantly turned back to their meals when she looked.

"Do we have a reservation?" Catra asked Bow the question, looking over at his phone.

"Duh."

Bow waved them to come inside, flashing his screen at the restaurant manager who led them to a small table.

"Well, what are you guys feeling?"

Angella rested her chin atop her hands, eyes passing over all of their faces.

"I wouldn't mind the soup. Good for cold weather."

Adora typed it out on her phone, everyone going around and requesting specific dishes. She also ordered some snacks for them to share; bread rolls and other appetizers.

"Did you enjoy skiing?"

Adora realized she actually hadn't seen the supervising parents the entire time they were there, about to ask them 'why' when Catra beat her to it.

"If you were around us, you might've known."

Angella frowned at the tone as Adora shifted in her seat. Why did family fights always break out at dinner.

"Tone, Catra. We're in public. Last thing we need is another headline like last time." Angella pointedly looked over at Glimmer, who conveniently avoided eye contact.

"We don't have the paparazzi around here. Just nosey people wondering if we are who they think we are."

"Still. I have enough to deal with, and this trip is meant to be relaxing for all of us."

Catra and Glimmer silently huffed in their respective seats, but cooled it at Angella's warning gaze. Adora glanced back down at the buzz of her phone, wondering why Shadow Weaver was being so persistent. She pursed her lips at it, knowing it would be rude to take the call while with the whole family. She quickly clicked the side of her phone, turning it off until she was ready to face her adoptive mother.

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Adora collapsed onto the bed, her muscles tired from the hours of skiing. They'd returned to the slopes after lunch, staying until the place actually closed and they were forced to go back to the cabin. It was nice though, even if Adora still fell a few times.

Pulling out her phone, she braced herself to open it up.

6 missed calls.

Six? Adora suddenly worried that something bad had actually happened to her; what if she was in hospital and Adora was out skiing ignoring her calls? Feeling guilty, Adora opened up the notification to call her back.

"Adora!"

"Are you alright? You called six times."

The old woman smiled through the camera at her, making Adora feel slightly unhinged even if she returned it without batting an eye.

"I'm fine, Adora, thank you."

Adora loosed a breath, waiting for her to continue.

"I just wanted to...check-in. You arrived in the Snow Kingdom a few days ago, correct?"

"Yes."

Adora recalled the call where she'd asked permission to go. Weaver had only really let her because of the publicity, but as long as she allowed her to go, Adora didn't care.

"And I noticed you've been seeing Catra? Are you two on friendly terms?"

Shadow Weaver's voice sounded light, but Adora detected the deeply ingrained anger laced into it. She had to be careful when talking about Catra. Shadow Weaver had spent years beating her oldest friend out of her mind. The first few times Adora even mentioned Catra she was locked in her room. Shadow Weaver had deemed her ungrateful for being adopted when she asked why Catra couldn't come too. In hindsight, Adora was glad she wasn't. Seeing the way Angella and Micah treated her made her feel relieved she wasn't taken in by Shadow Weaver.

"Yes...We're friendly."

Shadow Weave nodded slowly, Adora averting the eye contact by staring at the image of a snow capped mountain on the wall.

"That's permitted, I suppose. She has a wide following on social media platforms."

Adora only just refrained from looking away entirely when she realized Shadow Weaver had been stalking Catra on the internet. That was likely how she discovered their newfound friendship in the first place...the post Adora put up earlier.

"But don't let her distract you. She's a menace that girl, always detracted your potential."

Adora thought about arguing before firmly shutting her mouth. Defending Catra did nothing to help either of them.

"You have potential child, and Catra exploits it. Don't let her get into your mind."

Adora nodded, feeling guilty for not saying anything but also scared to open her mouth.

"I know. I'll get to where you-I, want to be."

"President Gray, remember the vision we built for you."

Adora nodded, feeling anxious as the phone call became longer. She had a question in her mind, but she didn't know if now was really the best time to approach it.

"Shadow Weaver?"

"Mom, Adora."

Adora cleared her throat awkwardly, repositioning herself on the couch.

"Mom, uh, why did you hide my letters?"

"What letters?"

Adora stared into the woman's face, in utter disbelief that she didn't remember.

"The one's you said we're mailed to Catra years ago? Those letters," Adora waited, half expecting Shadow Weaver to miraculously conjure them up in front of her.

"Oh, those letters. I discarded them years ag-"

"You discarded them? You-you didn't send them, at all?"

Adora was hoping they'd gotten lost in the mail, but this was so much worse.

"I see Catra has invaded your mind once again."

The softness in her voice only elicited more rage from Adora.

"Why didn't you send my letters?"

"I told you, Adora. Catra distracts you, and she's doing it again."

"Catra isn't doing anything. This is you."

Adora had never dared to yell at Shadow Weaver, but something in her sparked at the thought of her throwing out those letters. She'd poured her heart, her thoughts, into every single one of them. And the blatant disregard, the unfeeling coldness...

It choked her.

"Discarding the letters only improved your focus. You accepted that Catra was gone and moved on. Exchanging words would only ruin you, Adora."

Adora was fuming, her chest rising and falling with rapid breaths.

"I've got to go."

"Adora-"

"I'm fine, I just have stuff to do. Heaps of homework and other bullshit I don't want to do."

Shadow Weaver was about to speak but Adora quickly hung up, falling back on her bed. Standing up to her on FaceTime was taxing enough, she couldn't imagine actually saying those things to her in real life.

"Adora? Are you alright?"

Adora slowly sat up again, answering Glimmer's soft call by the door.

"Yes, I'm fi-"

"No. No you're not."

Adora sighed, looking down to push away to urge to crack her phone against the wall.

"No, no I'm not." Her voice broke as Glimmer pushed open the door, walking soundlessly towards a tearful Adora.

"I heard you yelling from Bow's room."

Bow's room was across the hall, that must've meant everyone heard it. Adora just burrowed her face into her knees, embarrassment mingling with anger which just collided with sadness.

"It's okay you know," Glimmer's voice was soft.

"You can hate her."

"I can't, she's given me everything. I'm mad at her, but I could never-"

Glimmer hushed her, pulling her closer for a hug as Adora squeezed back tight.

"Hey, are you alright?"

Adora leaned back from Glimmer's embrace to see Catra leaning against the door frame, a look of...concern shaded in her expression. Adora let the tears drip onto her legs, meeting the girl's eyes and telling a whole story through her features. Catra slowly approached her, cautious as if waiting to see what Adora's response was. The blonde remained motionless, letting Catra decide what she wanted to do. Glimmer gently moving to the side, Catra wrapped her arms around Adora. Feeling her so close, so familiar, was enough to send Adora over the edge. She nearly choked on her own sobs, wiping her tears so they wouldn't seep through the fabric of Catra's shirt.

"Do you want to leave?" Catra sounded afraid, not letting go of Adora who sniffled at the question.

"Leave?"

"I...heard some of your conversation. I can understand if you...if you don't want to-"

Adora clinged all the tighter to her, putting a halt to Catra's words.

"Why on earth would I let you go now, when I spent years trying to get you back in the first place?"

"It's just, Shadow Weaver-"

"You're my best friend Catra. I don't want to be controlled by her."

Catra didn't speak for a moment, pulling back to look Adora in the eye. Adora met her assessing gaze with one holding as much conviction as she could muster. It seemed to be enough, for Catra instantly latched onto Adora, an unfaltering grip.

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Workout bUdS

The following day was relatively painless. Shadow Weaver had thankfully left Adora alone, and she didn't really feel like going back out into the snow, preferring to just finish off her run and try and knock some holiday homework out of the way.

"Micah and I have a few meetings we'll have to run in the study today, so I was thinking you guys could head into town and have some fun?"

Angella sat down at the table with a steaming mug, glancing around at the seats where they sat.

"Actually, we were thinking a study day would do some good," Glimmer retorted in a not so polite tone. Angella seemed annoyed at the snap, but appeared let it slide. She was likely in favor of Glimmer actually doing her work for a change.

"That's fine, you guys can sort it out. If you need a ride into town the car's outside. Catra, you can drive."

Catra stuck her tongue out at Glimmer, who huffed like a petulant child in her seat.

"Why does she get to drive?" Glimmer whined at the still mocking Catra.

"She's older, and you crashed the first car we got you."

Angella moved to load up the dishwasher, prompting for them to hand their breakfast plates over.

"You crashed a car?" Adora looked at her friend with fresh eyes.

"I may have had a teensy tiny car accident, it was noth-"

"She bowled over a 'Stop' sign," Catra finished. Adora gawked at her friend, marveling at the fact that her license was still intact.

"Stop looking at me like that, I'm a great driver now."

Adora turned back to others, not entirely convinced.

"Well, we'll head out now."

"Your office isn't in the house?" Adora was surprised at Angella moving to grab her purse and keys.

"Oh, no. It's back in town. We usually head out here for business work actually, it's the most private town to be discreet."

Angella flashed a smile one last time and the only sound left was the shut of the door and the distant noise of an engine purring to life.

"I'm gonna go for a run, probably do a workout. Anyone down?"

Adora glanced around, not really expecting anyone to come but feeling rude for not offering and being perceived as selfish. Glimmer had invited her here after all, it was mean to just ditch without at least asking.

"Fuck no."

"Do you have anything better to do?" Adora pushed, finding herself actually longing for some company on the run.

"Yes, literally anything. Anything is better than running."

Adora rolled her eyes at the comment. Glimmer hated running with a passion, she found it inconvenient, but that girl literally had the power of teleporting. Adora could list the amount of times she'd turned around and Glimmer was magically behind her, it was starting to freak her out if she was being honest.

"Bow?"

"Probably not, I'm planning on fitting in some archery today. Don't want to get the muscles too sore."

Adora nodded, the excuse valid enough.

"I'll come."

She nearly fell off her seat, her ponytail flicking as she looked over at Catra.

"Really?"

Catra shrugged in response, a slight smile spreading on her face.

"Sure, why not? Been a while since I did some cardio."

Adora nodded, swallowing the flutters in her stomach. Now was not the time to deal with that.

"Cool, we better leave soon. I think it'll snow soon."

Catra nodded, the pair of them abandoning the table. Adora caught a mischievous smirk on Glimmer's face as she leaned in to whisper something to him. She threw her friend a suspicious look with narrowed eyes, wondering what devious plan her sparkly haired friend had gotten up too now.

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"You're telling me-"

"That you-that you-"

"Do this, every fucking day?"

Catra leaned against a nearby tree, hands tucked behind her head as she took a few more breaths. Adora paused her tracker, throwing a half smile at the puffed Catra. She herself was tired, but that was more due to the layers she was wearing in the cold, and the crisp air that was cutting through her lungs.

"That was all uphill too!"

Catra lay down to sit on the snow but Adora stopped her by tugging on an arm.

"Don't. You'll only find it harder to get back up. Besides, we've reached the top now, it's all downhill from here."

Catra still groaned, Adora feeling her stomach flip for no excusable reason. In all honesty she was impressed. Catra had done more than half of the run without much of a struggle, but the last few kilometers seemed to have broken her down. Still, Adora couldn't complain at the sight of-

Nope, not going to go there.

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

Adora snapped herself out of the internal argument she was having, noticing Catra was looking at her.

"Nothing, no reason, let's keep going!"

Adora pulled her friend by the sleeve, continuing the run while essentially dragging Catra along.

Arriving back at the house caused Catra to practically collapse at the doorway. Adora panicked for a moment, hoping she hadn't just over-exerted her friend. Rushing to get some water, Adora bent down to pass it to her.

"Can't...reach."

The panic only growing, Adora held her by the shoulders, mentally slapping herself for her dumb choices.

"Catra? Catra, are you alright? Do you want me to call someone?"

Adora grabbed out her phone, ready to dial Angella when Catra emitted a breathy laugh. The sound only grew, Adora's eyes narrowing as Catra doubled over, clutching her stomach.

"Oh wow, I didn't think you'd fall for it."

Neither of them had really gotten sweaty from the run, so Adora felt all the more satisfaction when she poured the glass of water on Catra's head. The girl hissed, shaking out the droplets from her head which splashed into Adora.

"Ugh, water!"

She undid her ponytail, raking hands through the wet messy hair as Adora stared.

"What are you looking at, dummy?"

Catra looked up at her and Adora quickly snapped out of it with a blush. What was wrong with her, why was she acting like an idiot?

"You're all...wet."

Catra stood up, pulling her soaked layers off before throwing a glance at Adora, who kept her eyes strictly on her face.

"I know. Just had to get me drenched, didn't you Adora?"

Holy fuck she couldn't do this. Adora tried to fill the pause with something, anything, to say, but her mind completely froze. Catra broke it with a laugh, nudging Adora as she climbed the first few steps of the staircase.

"I'm just messing with ya'. Come on, you said we still have a workout to do, right?"

Adora swallowed, nodding as Catra continued up the staircase, heading for the gym.

"What's the plan, then?"

Adora leaned back on the wall, still struggling to get a grip around herself.

"Uh, I was thinking legs?"

Catra gaped at her with incredulity.

"We just did a run and now you want to work legs. Your agenda is to demolish me, isn't it?"

Nope, that's definitely your agenda Catra.

"Yep, that's the plan!"

Adora moved towards the weight rack, deciding to stick to a full dumbbell workout rather than using the machines. It would be too time consuming for both of them to wait for each other on them, dumbbells were definitely better.

"We don't need to work on any glute activation because of the run, so that's a plus."

Catra folded her arms and rolled her eyes, coming closer as Adora lay down the equipment in a neat row.

"You look pretty strong, you think you can handle fifteen?"

Adora lifted up the dumbbell, Catra taking a moment longer to nod than necessary. Dumping the pair next to her own set, Adora wrote down a circuit Mermista gave her a few weeks ago.

"Anything you're unfamiliar with?"

Adora knew not to underestimate Catra's strength. Though she was lithe and slim, she still held a lot of hidden muscle that people normally wouldn't pick up on.

"Deadlifts. I know how to do them in theory, but I never get them when I'm actually doing it."

Adora nodded, she'd spent a solid half an hour just going through deadlifts with Mermista, and she still wasn't an absolute master at them.

"I like to think of a band around my hips as I shift back. Try to keep your weight pretty even and focus on engaging your muscles, specifically your core."

Catra looked slightly amused, Adora wondering what she said as Catra did a rep. Adora walked around, examining her form for corrections.

"Good, just keep your back even."

Without even thinking Adora helped structure Catra's form, placing a gentle hand on her lower back while raising her shoulders slightly. She heard a soft gasp and quickly let go, worried she'd made Catra feel uncomfortable.

"Sorry-"

"No, it's fine. I don't want to injure myself by accident."

Adora nodded, scratching the back of her head in order to keep her mind distracted.

"Ready?"

Catra met her eyes evenly, wiping the sweat off her brow.

"Ready."

_____

Mission Failure

The remainder of the day was fairly sedentary. Adora forced herself to crack through some equations for both Math and Chemistry, but let her practice essay slide for another day. She did still have two weeks, though that meant all her work had to be perfect.

"You started that Textiles project?" She asked Catra offhandedly when she came into the kitchen for some water. Adora could've studied in the library, but she preferred the circular dining table. Bow and Glimmer would come down every so often and force her to give herself a break. It was better than being trapped in an ambient, yet secluded library.

"Yeah, last night actually."

"What are you making?"

The project was to fuse a vintage art style with current trends. Adora still had no idea what she was going to do, but Catra seemed to have understood it pretty well. Then again, Catra was the best student, especially in Textiles.

"I'm making my Halloween costume, but I'm not telling Spinny that."

She took a long drink of her water as Adora wondered what costume she was planning on making.

"It's gonna be 80s, a bit retro."

"Ooh."

"But the cut is gonna be pretty similar to one of my dresses in my closet. Short, low-v, some statement boots, you know the drill."

Adora nodded, a flush of heat rising as she imagined a dress like that on Catra.

"I still have no idea what to do," Adora sighed into her Math homework with a glum face. Catra walked around the island and twisted her computer towards her.

"Hey, what are you-"

She spun it back, showing an image of a war like figure, holding a sword. The picture was scraped through a vase rather than being of an actual person, but Adora was still fascinated by it.

"That's She-Ra."

Adora felt the name was vaguely familiar before remembering it was Bow's dads that told her it, sometime a few weeks ago.

"Her civilian name was Adora, so, it would be pretty fitting."

Adora looked at the image in thought. It was pretty archaic, the figure wore old plates of armor fashioned into a skirt and a headband.

"Just find a way to make it relevant, add some spice."

Spice, yeah, she could do that.

"Thanks, that actually helped a lot."

Catra shrugged her words off, sauntering back up to the stairs.

"Duh, I'm a genius." She called out before vanishing up to her room. Adora quickly wrote down some ideas before her creativity decided to dry up.

Long, tied back ponytail-extensions

Mask

Sword

Flowy, skirt thing

Sleeveless

She tucked the note into her planner for further evaluation later in the week, glancing over at the window to see it was practically dark and she hadn't eaten anything. When she walked upstairs to find the others, she nearly walked right into Catra, who stood by the last of the steps.

"What did they do?"

She could tell by Catra's face that Glimmer and Bow were up to something. They had been acting odd the whole day, saying funny sentences before running off and giggling to each other like a couple of school kids.

"For whatever reason, they've moved Glimmer out of your room and into Bow's," that was pretty expected, but Adora could've handled a heads up from the two.

"And they put us in the room opposite."

Wait, us? As in, Catra and Adora.... living in the same room? Adora felt memories of The Horde bubble up at the thought, but decided not to let it cloud her mind.

"Why?"

"Who knows."

Adora knocked on their door, leaning back on the frame as Glimmer swung it open.

"Hello?" Adora asked, glancing behind at Bow who lay on the bed on his phone.

"Hi! Like your new room?"

Adora didn't nod nor shake her head, trying to ask Glimmer a question through her eyes. But the girl wasn't registering, the pale eyes just waiting for her response.

"Why are you acting odd?"

"Have either of you checked your socials today?" Bow called out from his phone, sitting up in alarm.

"What happened?"

The others poured into the room as Glimmer peered over his shoulder.

"The photo Glimmer posted, it...sparked something."

Adora quickly pulled up the photo, checking the comments rather than the image itself. Most of the comments were asking if Bow and Glimmer were officially dating, but neither of the pair had responded to it.

"We want to be private until we're back at school," Glimmer explained as she turned from looking over Bow's shoulder to looking over Adora's.

Adora and Catra in the back....

DOUBLE DATES!!!

omg adora and catra

Bow and Glimmer not even realizing what's happening behind them like-

time to go get run over

Even more confused, Adora flicked back to the image, zooming in. Nothing was even wrong with it, Adora didn't get what people were talking about. The photo merely featured Catra kneeling before her, placing a hand on Adora's stomach while looking up. Adora could see how it may be perceived as "suggestive" but she very clearly recalled Catra telling her to brace her core as she slid down the slope, referring to the positioning of her skis while doing so.

"Your photo only added fuel to the fire," Glimmer added. Adora glanced up to see them all scrolling through their phones. Her photo was pretty average, just her and Catra smiling for the camera.

AWWW

These two gonna surpass my love for glimbow unless those two idiots get together soon

catradora

CATRADORA<3

ship

They look so happy aw

Adora looked up at Catra when she snorted, a smirk on her face.

"Catradora? That's the ship name."

"I think it's pretty cute, better than Glimbow or Glimmadora."

"Glimmadora is awful," Adora admitted.

"No, but a lot of people call us Glow, Glim. That's pretty cute."

"Yeah I like Glow, the worst is definitely Glimmadora."

Catra laughed, putting down her phone.

"No, no, the worst is Glitra."

Catra's eyes twinkled at the word when Glimmer smacked her face into the bed, nearly crying tears of laughter at the name.

"I completely forgot about that!"

Adora looked between them, aghast.

"People shipped you two?" Adora was utterly shocked at that fact, not only were they like sisters, but the two despised each other up until this weekend.

"Yep, don't ask me why. I just came across it on Twitter one day and was like, 'the actual fuck is this?"

"Just wait, Adora. Watch, you'll post a photo with Bow and suddenly everyone will think he's cheating on Glimmer with you." Catra smiled at her and Adora returned it, putting her phone back away.

"Why don't we add some fuel to the fire?"

They all turned to Catra curiously, who smirked at them.

"Why?" Glimmer asked.

"Because it's fun. Why not?"

She turned towards Adora, who shrugged.

"Sure, but how?"

Catra pulled out her phone, opening the front camera and positioning herself next to Adora. She leaned in and before Adora could even register anything the mint and musk was filling her senses. Feeling the sensation of a kiss on her cheek, Adora was half tempted to turn, but knew to keep her feelings to herself.

"Wow, great acting."

Catra showed the photo to Adora, who near blushed at the sight of the photo. Her face was pure surprise, but something shone in her eyes.

"You fine with me posting that?"

"Sure."

"Let me see," Glimmer asked. Adora had almost forgotten the other two were there with them. Catra showed them the photo with the approval of both.

"And posted."

Adora instantly received the notification that she'd been tagged in the photo, but left it to look at the comments later.

"We have to get dinner," she reminded them. The others tucked their devices away, except for Bow.

"Already ordered, it should be here in ten."

Adora flopped back on the mattress, sinking into it like the thing was a heavenly cloud.

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She really didn't know what had possessed her, but somehow, Adora felt compelled to sketch out the design of her new project. She hadn't thought about it since she initially thought out those first few notes, but inspiration apparently decided to strike her right as twelve o'clock.

Angella and Micah had only come back from their meetings during dinner, and barely said two words to them before heading up for the night. Adora felt kind of bad for them, seeing the weary look in Angella's eyes indicated that something deeper was going on. She didn't know whether to mention it to Glimmer and Catra or not, but decided against it. It wasn't her place to get caught up in sticky family drama.

"I'm out."

Catra placed her phone on the charger stand, climbing the rungs to her bed. Adora smiled, the layout of the room reminding her of that in the Horde, albeit, this one was a lot fancier and more spacious. Catra had her own bunk on one end with a wide desk filling the bottom. Adora couldn't help but catch sight of the

designs and sketches pinned up to her cork board, the sewing machine light still on.

"You left your machine on."

Catra lifted her head from the pillow, about to get down when Adora hopped off her own desk and did it for her.

"Thanks."

Adora gave a slight smile, shutting off the main light and turning on her soft lamp.

"Night, Catra." She called out. The girl's eyes flicked open and moved down to hers. Adora almost lost her breath at the familiar sight of those luminescent eyes, blue and gold, glinting in the dark.

"Night, Adora."

The time seemed to creep by the hours rather than minutes, and Adora only finished her sketch at two in the morning. About to shut off and go to sleep, her eyes couldn't help but snag on the pitch black phone sitting on the charger. Catra's phone. She glanced up at the sleeping figure in the bed, wondering if the charger was perhaps too close for Adora to venture up and get it. Slipping out the door, Adora gently opened Bow and Glimmer's door.

"Adora?"

Adora wasn't the slightest surprised to see Glimmer in her bed, eyes glancing up from the screen to look at her. She didn't know what time Glimmer usually went to bed, but she was always up after Adora put her own lights out.

"Is Bow awake?"

Glimmer shook her head in response.

"Do you know how to hack a phone?"

A worrying smile spread across the girl's face, and Glimmer genuinely looked terrifying with her face solely illuminated by her screen. Slowly shutting her laptop as not to wake Bow, Glimmer crept out of the bed, gesturing for Adora to go towards her own room.

"You get the phone, but I'll wait out here. The floorboards creak, stupid wooden house."

Glimmer sat down slowly on the wood, and Adora nodded.

"One small issue. Her phone is literally right next to her. Like the charger is right beside her, honestly, all that radiation probably isn't good for her."

"Just be as silent as possible and she won't notice."

Adora hoped so, Catra literally had cat-like reflexes. Her ears could hear anything, in fact she was barely keeping her voice audible when talking to Glimmer.

"Okay. If she catches us, we're dead."

"Then don't let her catch us."

Glimmer shooed her and Adora put a finger to her lips, indicating for her to stay silent. Slowly opening and shutting the door behind her, Adora stared at her slumbering friend.

This really wasn't necessary, she didn't have to violate Catra's privacy and go through her phone for no good reason. It was kind of mean, but she had to know what made Catra take that shot so fast the other night.

Adora took a slow breath, trying to regulate her heart rate as she approached the ladder. She climbed the first step, and the creak was so loud she was certain Glimmer had heard it. Cringing, Adora climbed up the next step. At least that one was silent. She

peeked at Catra, who hadn't moved an inch, her chest still rising and falling at a steady pace. Adora climbed up the third, and then fourth rungs, leading up to the last one. Eyeing the phone near Catra's head, Adora reached the top. She stilled, waiting to see if a reaction was going to come out of the girl, but she continued to peacefully snooze, head still facing Adora. Leaning over, as slowly as she could, Adora wrapped her hands around the phone, about to make a run for it when a hand wrapped around your arm.

Shit.

Adora looked down slowly, meeting the shiny eyes in the dark.

"And what do you think you're doing?"

Adora decided to just sprint, grabbing her phone off the charging table and ready to leap onto the ground when Catra flipped her onto the bed, pinning her arms down beneath her. Adora didn't even know how she managed to pull her onto the actual bed, all she knew was that she was spinning.

"Who would've thought five years of specialized combat training would've done me some good?"

Adora was about to question that when Catra pried the phone out of her hands, swinging a leg over Adora's hip to make herself comfortable.

"I thought I took a shot to avoid this?"

Adora was stunned into silence, unable to speak. It was very, very wrong that she was very, very turned on right now.

"No words, huh?"

Catra smirked with a shake of her head, getting off Adora and onto the bed. The minute she got off Adora's senses returned to her as she quickly moved to get off the mattress and down the ladder, thankful the darkness was hiding her red face.

Catra's eyes didn't leave her own as she slipped out of the room to meet Glimmer.

"Did you get-Wait."

Adora looked back at the ruffled Glimmer, wondering was she saw in her. Trying to slow her rapid heartbeat, Adora took a few deep breaths.

"What happened?"

"She-She caught me, and, well, took the phone back. Let's go to bed, I think she's mad." Adora left out the taunting, deciding it was irrelevant and unnecessary to tell Glimmer about. She also decidedly ignored Glimmer's arched eyebrow at her bright red face, pushing past to find some open air.

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Adora Strips

Even though Adora had spent practically the entire night worrying about how awkward the following day was going to be, Catra seemed perfectly fine with acting like nothing had happened.

Adora found it extremely strange, to say the least.

"Wow, I'm tired. What about you kids?" Angella provided some conversation as they walked back into the house, the sun already set and curtains automatically drawn.

"Very tired."

Glimmer pretended to yawn (though Adora found it fairly convincing), provoking her mother to ruffle her hair and head up to her room. Micah hadn't come with them today, and Adora vaguely wondered why. She thought about asking Glimmer and Catra, but they didn't seem to know either. Both the parents were acting a bit strange this entire holiday, but Adora just chalked it up to them being worn down and sick of supervising four teenagers.

"People really went nuts for the post I did yesterday. I've gotten a good few thousand messages asking about it."

Adora checked her own phone, finding a pretty similar result. It was odd, ever since she posted with Catra, more and more people were following her. She didn't think even a single person would be remotely interested in her or her life. She also saw a message from Shadow Weaver, but she quickly deleted that before it clouded her mind.

"So, what are we doing tonight, then?"

Catra plonked herself down on the couch, removing her boots and jacket. The others joined her, Glimmer going through a list she and Bow had written down on her phone.

"Beer Pong?"

"Nah."

"Midnight ice skating?"

"Do it next week, the ice isn't thick enough yet." Glimmer nodded at Bow's remark, continuing to file through various games which Adora had never heard of. She sometimes felt a bit frustrated at the fact that they all knew what these activities were and that she was so goddamn sheltered she didn't, but the anger was quickly bottled up and put away to unleash at a more suitable time.

"Poker?"

"Good, but make it interesting. Shot Poker?" Catra suggested, but Glimmer shook her head.

"Mom locked the stuff away, we'll have to wait a week until she uses it and forgets to lock it up again."

"Strip Poker?"

Bow made eye contact with his girlfriend, and the pair seemed to agree before the rest of them did. Glimmer ran upstairs to the game room, returning with a silver lined briefcase Adora always thought held money.

Sadly, it didn't.

Instead, lay rows of chips, each column a different color. A set of decks sat fresh in the centre, along with a chip labelled 'Dealer.'

"Adora, have you played poker before?"

Shaking her head, Adora kept her gaze fixed on the cards.

"Here's how you play."

Glimmer ran through the instructions of the game, though Adora didn't really get it. It seemed odd, and highly based on luck and how well you could lie, but luckily for her, she was fairly good at

deceiving people. She'd also mentioned the possibility of getting naked, but Adora didn't really mind having to strip to her underwear. It was basically the same thing as wearing a set of bathers, right?

Glimmer acted as the dealer, but was able to play as well. She handed them each two cards, and Adora snuck a peek, seeing a pair of Queens.

"Okay, toss in your blinds."

Adora chucked in a red piece, Glimmer had mentioned it equated to a sock or piece of jewelry.

Flipping over the cards, Adora re-examined the pair already sitting between her fingers, deciding the best she had so far was just the pair of queens she already had. She glanced around the table, keeping her face carefully stoic as she studied the others.

Bow seemed deflated, that probably meant he had shit, but Glimmer struggled to hide a smirk. That meant she had something worthwhile.

They were soon nearing the end of the first round, and the betting had been minimal. No artifacts of clothing as of yet, but Glimmer seemed tempted to raise the stakes. She didn't, which tipped Adora off that she was waiting for the final card. Flipping it over, Adora struggled to keep her face neutral when she caught sight of another Queen.

"Okay, show your cards."

Adora lay her pair proudly on the table, not all that surprised to see a pair of sevens in Glimmer's hands.

"You win."

Adora did a small victory clap as they tossed in a few items. Catra had put in three rings, the amount she'd bet, Bow put in a sock just for the blinds, and Glimmer had lost both sets of earrings, a

few other pieces of jewelry and a single sock. She huffed in annoyance as Adora smiled in glee.

"Wow, you really lost to a newbie, Sparkles?"

Catra chuckled at the huffy girl, who shot a glare at her.

"Wait 'til you go one on one, she's mad."

"No, I'm just competitive." Adora winked, exchanging the pile of clothing for the chips they were worth and adding it to her growing stack.

"Next round," Glimmer started handing out the cards, Adora picking up her fresh pile.

The following round was fairly slow, Catra winning some small pieces before Glimmer won the next. Bow was conservative with his chips, and every time he bet a few everyone withdrew. Bow wasn't one to lie, but they'd never really know his cards if they all folded.

They got about an hour in, and thanks to Adora's lucky shot at the beginning, she'd only lost a hair tie so far, blonde strands sitting loose around her shoulders.

"Let's raise the blinds, make it a shoe"

They each pulled off a shoe they were wearing, Adora feeling the slight breeze in the house hitting her foot as she removed the warm ugg boot. She opened her hand, resisting a smile at the double diamonds in her palm. Glimmer opened up the cards, revealing three more diamond in a row.

A Flush. That'll be hard to beat.

"Adora, you're up first."

She could pass, or she could bet. But she didn't have too long to do it, it was best to act like she was pretending to bluff. Putting on

a nervous face, she hesitantly placed down a red chip.

Start small, draw them in.

Her strategy working wonders, everyone played to stay in the game. Glimmer flipped the next card, but Adora didn't even need to look at it, she already had the Flush in her palms. Still, she looked between her own two cards and the ones sitting before them all, before passing. Bow passed too, but Catra threw in another red. Glimmer folded, Bow matched Catra, and Adora quickly put down a red chip as well.

"You know, I think there might be some wine or beer in the fridge. Pretty sure Micah tried to disguise it with an orange juice sticker."

Glimmer rolled her eyes with a laugh at her dad's dumb attempts to hide the alcohol, momentarily getting up to go to the fridge. The alcohol was confirmed with a shout of affirmation, Glimmer pouring them each a glass and passing it around.

Adora took a swig, the heady sensation almost instantly filling her.

"Don't give Adora more than a glass, she'll end up spewing."

Adora rolled her eyes, giving a dry laugh at the joke.

The second last card flipped over, Adora deciding to be bold and throw a blue chip in.

"And she's ready to give up the shoe, ladies and gents!" Bow commentated, also putting a blue chip in.

"I raise you." Catra tossed a green one in. Glimmer said that was an artifact of clothing. Bow quickly folded, but Adora decided to take another gulp of the wine before choosing.

"I match you."

She put in one of her green, examining herself for what she could hand over. She wore a jumper, leggings, and tank, so, not very much. Looking over at Catra, she realized the other girl was wearing a pair of jeans, the leather jacket Adora had made her (wait, she was actually wearing it?) and a tight brown knit. A similar amount as Adora, but she also had a belt on her, and that still counted as an artifact of clothing (even though Adora really considered it an accessory).

Glimmer got up to the final card, asking for any last bettings. Adora looked up at Catra, trying to decipher whatever it was she had on those cards. She passed, starting to get a bit nervous at the smirk Catra gave her.

"Just for fun," Catra leaned back and flipped another green on the table, the chip spinning before laying flat. Adora assessed her, deciding it was now or never. She put in a green, deciding she was going to have to finish off her glass of wine before Glimmer forced them to show their hand.

"Full house, baby." Catra fanned out her cards, Adora swearing under her breath as she revealed the Flush.

"Catra wins," Glimmer announced, as Catra looked up at her.

"You heard her. Strip."

Adora rolled her eyes, taking off the puffer and her shirt to just wear a sports bra on the top. It wasn't that bad, the worst thing about it was the cold. She met Catra's eyes, but the girl avoided hers, glancing at the table in front of them. Adora restricted herself from frowning in confusion, wondering what the hell that meant.

"Come on, things just got interesting."

Glimmer winked, and the game continued.

_____

"I'm Not Main Character Material"

The following days of the first week trickled by slowly, but Adora wasn't complaining. Angella and Micah had taken them horse riding, which was awfully cold for both the horses and kids, yet nevertheless enjoyable.

Catra, of course, was a natural.

Adora distantly wondered why she wasn't on any sport teams, considering that she was decently fit and could ski, as well as horse ride like a professional. She thought about asking the question several times, but it never lingered in her thoughts long enough to where she actually carried out on it.

It was now Sunday, and Adora realized she'd done every bit of homework except the Textiles project. Catra on the other hand seemed to have finished her Textiles work, but hadn't done anything else. Sitting down at the breakfast table, Adora finally mustered up enough courage to ask the others the thoughts weighing down on her.

"I was thinking..."

"Wow, you think?" Adora glared at Glimmer before shooting a betrayed look at Bow who'd snorted into his orange juice.

"That maybe I should learn Basketball," she continued.

"If I like it and I'm decent, maybe I'll try out for the team."

"Yeah, you would suit the Basketball uniform."

Adora wasn't sure if that was a compliment or not, but she took it as one anyway.

"Do you know how to play Basketball?"

She asked around at all of them.

"I played for a year or two. Not really good, but I know the basics," Catra shrugged and Adora nodded.

"Same, I got kicked out for biting a girl, but she stole the ball off me."

Adora had begun to realize just how feral Glimmer was over the holidays. She'd crashed a car, knocked out a security guy, and bit a girl during a friendly game?

"Stop looking at me like that, she deserved it!"

Adora hummed in sarcasm, finishing her oats and standing up for a stretch.

"You'll be great Adora, I can already see you on the court."

Adora smiled at Bow, hoping maybe she would be good at the sport.

———————

"Would you look at that, we barely even had to teach her."

Bow marveled as Adora dribbled the ball up the court, doing a layup that scored a goal.

"Nah, beginner's luck," she quickly brushed off the compliment. Adora was fairly certain that everyone in the Basketball team would be ten times better than her, considering everyone who went there was rich and seemed to have private tutors in about everything (even P.E).

"Arsan's on the team, so at least you'll have one friend."

"So is Lonnie."

Adora looked over to Catra, languid on the small set of bleachers in the indoor court. She blew on her nails, having filed them for the past twenty minutes.

"I'm not exactly friends with Lonnie, but at least it's someone I know."

She didn't know very much about Lonnie if she was being completely honest, only that the girl seemed to be Catra's sidekick at school.

"Lonnie's nice; way too nice to be friends with me. But that doesn't mean she'll like you."

Catra met her eyes, putting the file down and straightening up.

"Gee, thanks. Makes me feel so welcome." Adora rolled her eyes, shooting another goal with ease.

"Well, she never actually said she doesn't like you, at least not to me. And I complained about you like every day of the week last term."

Adora approached her slowly, spinning the ball on her finger like Glimmer taught her. She caught Catra stare at her hands and smirked.

"You really are obsessed, aren't you? Had to complain about me every damn day."

Bow held up his hands for Adora to toss the ball at him and she did, keeping her eyes locked on Catra, who simply rolled her own.

"Don't get so ahead of yourself, Blondie."

Adora cocked her head to the side before abruptly spinning on her heel to face Glimmer.

"So? Do you think I'm good enough?"

"The coach is Mr Hawk, you'll get in easy."

Adora smiled, feeling a slight surge of confidence.

"Why don't you do a sport Catra? I can already think of two you'd be the best at."

The question was random, but it had been floating through Adora's mind for days and she wanted to know the answer.

"I was on the Ski Team Freshman year and Volleyball last year, but I wanted to take a break this time around. Who know? Maybe I'll pick something up next year."

Adora shrugged, her logic seemed fair enough.

"Besides, I wanted to try other extra-curriculums."

"Like what?" Adora was genuinely interested. She never knew Catra's interests in The Horde, they were all kind of forced to just read and write everyday by Shadow Weaver.

"Like putting together this year's annual fashion show."

"Hold up, you're the designer this year?" Glimmer gaped at her sister in shock, and Adora's interest heightened. Catra pinkened slightly, a bit bashful.

"Wait a second, there's a fashion show at this fucking school?"

"Duh. It's awesome. Each year a student designs and recruits a whole team of people to show off a collection. The designer isn't usually announced until a few days before the show, but I guess we got the inside scoop."

She nudged Adora as Bow walked over to them, looking at Catra in awe.

"It's a big deal. Usually a senior gets chosen, you must've impressed the panel."

Catra shrugged as Adora still tried to wrap her head around the concept.

"I try. And I found out right before holidays, you guys are actually the first to know."

Woah.

"How long do you have to set it up?"

"It's hosted in the third term holidays, so not very long. But I get to choose a whole production team. You know, designers, set crew, anything I need."

"That's fucking cool."

Adora sat down next to her, knowing Catra is going to make this fashion show incredible.

"I still can't believe you're the Head this year. What's the theme, or can you not tell us?"

"I'll leave that for a surprise. Literally no one but production is meant to know the theme until you get the invites."

"Invites? Just how exclusive is this."

Adora kept flicking between Glimmer and Catra, realizing this must be a pretty huge deal considering it was selective in who attended.

"Well I get to choose which students come, perks of being the Organizer. But the rest of the invites are usually given to important alumni, a few celebrities and families of the people involved."

"You better invite me," Glimmer pointed at Catra, who just smirked.

"If you ask nicely, maybe I will," she teased. Glimmer looked at Bow, as if expecting him to force Catra to invite her.

"She'll invite you, relax."

"Is that your main focus for the year then?" Adora returned the topic back to Catra's extracurriculars for the year.

"It is, but DT roped me into being into being in the stupid play this year. They tried to make me audition for the lead role, but there was no way I was doing that."

A play? Adora decided she'd better keep an eye out for the newsletter from now on, she seemed to miss all the fun stuff in this school.

"What is it?"

"Macbeth."

Adora vaguely remembered the story. Something about three moody witches, a power-crazed protagonist and a ghost? Maybe a dagger too? It'd been a while since she studied it.

"I have the privilege of being Lady Macbeth. Everyone says she's the true villain, but I think she's just hot."

Oh, then Catra will fit the role perfectly.

"Agreed." Glimmer nodded her head at Catra's opinion.

"So what role is DT playing? Macbeth?" Bow asked, at which Catra laughed.

"No, they aren't even in it! They're helping Netossa coordinate the entire thing."

"Being in the play sounds kinda fun, Glimmer why don't we do something?" Catra crossed her legs, turning to Adora.

"They're still looking for a few parts, I think. Hecate, Banquo and Macbeth if you guys are interested?"

"Ooh, I'll try out for Banquo!" Bow grinned in excitement, turning to Glimmer who shook her head.

"Nah uh, I can't act to save my life. I'll just be part of the set crew, draw the cute backdrops and stuff."

Catra pulled out her phone, texting DT that she'd just recruited some new members.

"Surely you go for Macbeth Adora." Glimmer prompted with a charming smile. Adora shook her head with a no.

"No thanks. I'm not main character material."

"No, I think you'd do Macbeth justice." Catra momentarily glanced up from her phone to look at Adora, and her heart warmed at the thought that Catra seemed to think she'd fit the bill...Even if it was for a bloodthirsty maniac.

"Alright, I'll try out. But I doubt I'll get the part."

"Don't worry, you will."

Catra finished sending out her message and re-pocketed her phone, seeming to either ignore or not notice Adora's soft stare at her.

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GF Pasta

Adora spent the next two days religiously practicing Basketball. She'd become an addict, watching more and more videos to make sure she actually got on the team and didn't just embarrass herself. Alongside Basketball was procrastinating on finishing her Textiles homework.

Catra folded her arms and gave Adora a look when she saw the unfinished project and a neglectful Adora scrolling through Instagram.

"You know you're going to be rushing last minute, right?" Adora waved off her concern, pointing over at Catra's desk with incomplete Business Studies homework.

"Talk to the mirror."

Adora's sassy comment only made Catra scoff, pushing gently for Adora to move over on her bed. Adora mindlessly shifted, only noticing Catra was next to her when the girl pulled out her own phone.

"If we're both going to procrastinate, might as well do it together?"

Adora nodded at the comment, going back to her phone, even though it was a lot harder to focus on it when Catra was lying right beside her. She was close enough that Adora got a hint of her favorite mint and musk scent, and it was kind of making her go insane. Why did she feel the unnecessary need to be-

No, wear attractive scents?

It was honestly a disservice to the community. How could anyone focus when she was around?

"You two up to help us make dinner? Mom and Dad are going out to the office today, so Bow and I thought we'd try out a new

recipe."

Adora was snapped from her thoughts by Glimmer who stood by the door. It took her a few seconds longer than necessary to respond.

"Sure, we'll help." Adora finally got her wits around her, replying and quickly getting out of the bed. Catra being near her seemed to dull her senses, she needed to get out of this weird proximity. Moving quickly, Adora was surprised to turn around and see a confused frown playing on Catra's face. It was slowly wiped off when Adora held out a hand to help her off the bed.

"You coming?"

Catra nodded, still giving her a bit of an odd look as she reached for Adora's palm. Did Adora do something bad? Was Catra upset at her or something?

Their hands held for a moment longer than needed, but Adora didn't really mind. Catra gently letting go, they headed downstairs after Glimmer.

Adora instantly laughed at Bow in a chef's hat and apron, wearing the same set Micah wore when cooking for them. Glimmer followed the instructions written on the apron, kissing Bow on the cheek as they walked into the spacious kitchen. Catra instantly jumped on the tabletop, crossing her legs as she peered into Bow's mixing bowl.

"What are you making?"

"The entree. It's almost done!"

Bow took his bowl over to a tray of meat, coating the marinated pieces in whatever batter he made and Glimmer turning on the heat on the stove. Catra passed the three recipes to Adora, the pair of them sharing the pieces of paper.

"Shallow fried chicken for appetizers, spaghetti for mains and...a soufflé'?"

"Souffle's," Bow corrected.

"Glim and I already prepped the spaghetti and we're cooking the chicken now, so why don't you two do the soufflé's?"

Adora scanned through the recipe, shrugging and looking at Catra.

"Sure, why not?"

"I haven't cooked a day in my life, so you get to play at being boss."

Adora winked, tying a spare apron around herself and tossing one to Catra.

"Alright, then. I'm actually pretty good in the kitchen, Shadow Wea- I...enjoyed cooking." Catra's eyes flared, but she let Adora's slip up go, getting down from the bench top.

"Do the back, will you?"

Adora nodded, gently finishing the knot at the back of Catra's waist, careful not to pull too tight.

"Okay, what's first."

Adora ran through the steps. They seemed simple but she knew the technique required would be hard.

"Get the ingredients, you know the kitchen better than I do."

Catra nodded, bending down and pulling various bowls and utensils from the cupboard.

"Okay, we need to separate the eggs."

Adora cracked them, trying to block Catra's gaze from distracting her. She grabbed various other ingredients: vanilla and salt, and chucked them into the mixture, instructing Catra to whisk it.

"I hate being told what to do."

"You're the one that called me 'boss,'" Adora reminded her. While Catra mixed the yolks, Adora worked on the egg whites, using the electric whisker until they were stiff and fluffy.

"How are you two going?"

Bow set down the pan with a flourish, crackling pieces of chicken glistening in the light.

"Ooh-"

Glimmer slapped away Adora's hand, lightly scolding her.

"Wait until everything's ready. Then we get to have a little buffet!"

"Okay, okay. I'll keep my hands away."

She retracted, slightly scared of her short yet aggressive friend. Glimmer pointed the rubber flipper at her, throwing a threatening gaze before she returned to her food.

"We have to cool it for a bit."

Catra nodded, leading her to the corner of the kitchen with an industrial fridge.

"You seem to have the cooking skills you claimed?"

Catra phrased the words into a question, causing Adora to pause with her head in the fridge. She slowly moved away, as not to bang her head against it, knowing the underlying cause of her 'question.'

"I do," Adora chose to evade. She didn't really want to steer into Shadow Weaver territory, especially not when her and Catra were

getting along so well.

"She didn't treat you too bad, right? I mean, you were her favorite...surely she didn't-"

"She didn't," Adora let the simple lie slip out. She saw the look on Catra's face, the eyes tense over Adora's childhood. And she didn't feel like burdening all that with Catra, with making her worry about Adora's wellbeing.

Catra was visibly relieved, even though Adora's own chest tightened with the lie. She didn't like doing that to her friend, but it was necessary to keep the peace.

"Good. I'm glad you were, I don't know...happy."

Adora smiled, closing the fridge door when she realized it was beeping.

"I'm glad you were happy too, or at least safe."

Nodding her head towards the door, the pair headed back to the main kitchen. A scent wafted through the air, though scent probably wasn't the most accurate word to describe it. Rather, it smelt like something was....burning?

"Bow, the pasta!"

"Oops!"

Adora and Catra walked in right on time to see Bow frantically turning off the gas, taking the lid off a pot to unleash a flood of steam. Adora coughed, waving her hand through the air as the fire alarm beeped.

"You burnt pasta? It's pasta Bow, pasta!"

Bow drained the murky water, the smoke only becoming more prominent as Catra stood on the table to reach the fire alarm. Glimmer had miraculously opened the doors in record time

(seriously, how did she do that?) and Bow just gave them all apologetic looks.

"At least the sauce is good?"

Catra snickered, Glimmer fuming as the smoke went down. The angry girl stalked over to Bow, who cowered in the corner as she flapped the towel at him.

"Argh!" She waved her fists about in frustration as Adora chuckled.

"What do we do now? That's all the pasta we have."

"Well, the soufflé's are actually coming out pretty good, so we'll have desert?"

Glimmer bit into a piece of fried chicken passing the pan around. Apparently she'd given up on trying to save it for their 'buffet.'

"It's fine, we'll just order pasta from out. Everything else is good." Bow suggested, Glimmer ripping a bite off the chicken as she glared at him.

"That sounds good, I'll order."

Catra whipped out her phone, probably finding a restaurant or something to get takeout from.

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Adora stared down at the food laid before her, sniffing it suspiciously. Catra said the only restaurant open had run out of regular pasta, so they had to make it using the gluten-free version. Adora didn't know much about gluten-free food, but the pasta had come out green. That's right, literal vomit colored.

"I'm sure it's not that bad."

"I can't believe we paid them for green pasta."

Bow rolled his eyes, taking a stab of a meatball and a forkful of pasta. The table yelped at him to stop, but it was too late. The food was already inside his mouth. They all watched in fascination, surprised when his eyes widened and he nodded vigorously.

"It's good! It's really good."

Adora was still hesitant, but she slowly raised a small mouthful to her nose. He seemed to be telling the truth, the food smelled pretty decent. Opening her mouth, Adora put it in before she could think twice. Gluten-free food was likely to be better than the grey sludge she and Catra had to endure in the Horde. To her immense delight, it was spicy. Spice with bolognese? An unappreciated combination.

"He's right. It is good."

Adora ate more, watching Glimmer and Catra slowly dig into the meal. Adora finished it quickly, not even realizing how hungry soufflé making actually was. It'd taken her and Catra a good hour to finish it, but luckily that was the same amount of time it took for the food to arrive. Apparently living thirty minutes away from the town had its disadvantages.

"I'll get the soufflé's."

Adora jumped up from the table, moving over to the bench for final prep. Dusting some sugar on the top and adding some cut up strawberries, Adora lifted the tray from the table.

Setting it down in the middle, Adora ignored the instant shouts of praise to go and retrieve some vanilla ice cream.

"That looks so good, how did you even make it rise that much?"

Glimmer looked to both Catra and Adora, waiting for a response. Catra shrugged, pointing to Adora with her fork.

"Don't ask me, she's the genius behind it."

"Luck, really. Sometimes my cooking turns out shit, but other times it comes out alright."

Her eyes met Catra's across the table, some last few words spilling out before she could stop herself.

"Guess Catra's my lucky charm."

Adora got up to put her dish away, strategically moving to hide the expression she knew was on her face. The silence was deafening, and Adora just knew Bow and Glimmer were frantically exchanging looks behind her.

"Cats are meant to be bad luck, so I don't reckon. But thanks."

Catra had always hated her name, even if Adora loved it. She remembered the bullies haunting her about it in the orphanage, calling her a mismatched freak, a stray cat or even telling her to go back out on the streets.

"Why do I have such a stupid name?"

"Can't be worse than Adora."

"I love your name."

"And I love yours."

"Adora? Adora!"

The plate nearly fell out of her hands when Glimmer's voice protruded her thoughts. Adora blinked, slowly drifting back towards the table.

"You alright?"

Catra leaned across, plucking a dish from the board as she looked at Adora with soft eyes.

"Yeah, fine."

Adora placed the tray in the centre, leaving one for herself. The desert looked so perfect sitting in front of her, she was almost sad to dig in and ruin it. But everyone else already had, so she might as well.

"Mmm, forget being a P.T, you should be a chef."

Catra's words almost distracted Adora from watching her lick the spoon, but not quite.

"Who said I want to be a P.T?" She finally managed to struggle out.

"Oh, you don't?"

Adora shook her head, almost an automatic response. She wouldn't mind being a PT, but Shadow Weaver had imprinted the idea of being President in her mind for years.

"What do you want to do, Adora?"

Glimmer piped up from the other end of the table, licking her bowl clean with sticky chocolate covering her mouth. Bow handed her a napkin as Adora answered.

"I want to be President."

"Really?" Catra was watching her with an unreadable expression, but Bow had asked the question.

"I think. I know you want to be an architect Bow, but what about you Glimmer?"

"Mom wants me to take over the school someday, so maybe I'll do that. But for now, I want to own a graphic design company."

Adora knew Glimmer was invested in Art, but she'd never actually seen any of her work. She was fairly sure Glimmer was talented though, the girl spent hours locked up in her room when she had her 'idea's spilling,' as she liked to phrase it.

"Catra?"

"I want to have my own label. You know, be a business owner and designer."

"You'll have no issues achieving that."

Adora leaned back in her chair, already envisioning Catra in a power suit, sitting in some penthouse office with rows and rows of sketches surrounding her. It really didn't take much imagination, Catra was practically there already.

"God, it's ten and I'm already tired?"

Glimmer ticked in disapproval.

"No stamina."

Adora rolled her eyes, getting up to stretch on her tiptoes. She noticed Catra's gaze but dutifully ignored it, shaking her out of the ponytail as she walked near the stairs.

"I'm heading to sleep. Last night really knocked me out."

She didn't hear a response, proud of herself for not worrying about the fact that Glimmer and Catra would be together without supervision.

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Stars

"Adora, your fabric arrived!"

Adora practically sprinted down the steps, nearly tripping and banging her head on the wood. She had about sixteen hours to finish her project before they returned back to school for the new term, and she still hadn't come close to finishing it. She grabbed the bag off Catra, who simply held it out for her to take.

"Hello. Goodbye," she took the bag off her hands, ignoring the stupid smirk plastered on her face as she ran back up the stairs.

"I told you not to rush!" Catra called out from the foyer.

"I don't see that Business report finished on your desk!" Adora called out a quick retort, almost out of breath as she reached the room. She just had to knuckle down, and sew this stupid project.

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"Made much progress?"

Adora nearly sewed through her hand out of surprise, flicking off the machine and glaring at her distractor with beady eyes.

"You're not helping."

Catra brushed off the comment, coming around to examine the work. Adora swiped her hand away, Catra looking at her confused.

"I do not want my shitty sewing to be judged by Miss Head Designer, thank you very much. You can leave."

Adora jokingly dismissed her, shaking her hand towards the door as Catra came around the opposite end of the desk.

"You and your mind maps."

Adora was confused for a second before glancing back, following Catra's eyes to the line up of diagrams and definitions hung up on her side of the room. She was quite proud of it actually, in the same way an artist would be of their work.

"We have exams soon," she said by way of explanation.

"We have weeks before exams."

"Never too late to get started."

Catra pointedly looked down at Adora's sewing machine, and the blonde huffed like a child.

"Come downstairs with me. Sparkles and her boyfriend won't leave me alone."

Catra's whiny tone caught Adora's attention as her eyes traveled towards the door with temptation.

"What do you mean?"

"They want to braid my hair. Braid my fucking hair Adora."

Adora snickered into her hand before recalling a particular time in the gym where Catra had worn her long wild hair in a braid. No, two braids.

"But I've seen you in braids, why don't you like them now?"

"I wear braids for two reasons. One, I want to crimp my hair or make it extra wavy. And two, I need to keep it out of my face. It is purely for practical purposes, and would ruin my whole look."

Adora scanned down at Catra's outfit. A baggy pair of pants, another fitting turtleneck, and a puffer that looked way too expensive. She seemed correct on some level, braids were probably better suited to slouchy jumpers and leggings or something.

"Okay Fashionista." Adora rolled her eyes with a smirk, returning to her work.

"Adoraaaa," Catra whined again, jumping and sitting on the table when Adora ignored her.

"Hey, careful!"

"You're annoyingly focussed."

"You are not very conducive to my focussed environment," Adora leaned back in her chair, staring at the glinting eyes in front of her. The light hit them perfectly, a warm sunset glow shining on Catra's face. Adora couldn't help but stare at them, looking at the pure golden one before switching back to the royal blue.

"I not trying to be."

Catra's voice was soft as she carefully swung her legs off the desk and walked around beside Adora's chair.

"You're tense."

"Of course I'm tense, I have to finish this goddamn thing before we get back to school!." Adora waved her hands about in the air, so consumed in her stress that she didn't even notice Catra walk around behind her.

"Shh, calm down."

Soft hands pushed down on Adora's shoulders, and instantly her skin sparked.

Friend, friend, she's just a friend.

"If I helped you with your project, would you spend the evening with us?"

"Yes." Adora didn't even have to think about her response. She'd been so consumed with this project that she'd blatantly ignored

everyone for the whole day. It was mean, and she didn't like neglecting her friends, especially when it was still their holidays and Glimmer had invited her to spend time together away from the school.

Adora felt her shoulders loosen with Catra's touch, leaning her head back in the chair to peer up at her favorite pair of eyes. Catra looked down at her, briefly pausing before continuing again.

"Thank you." Adora's voice was sincere, and they both knew she was thanking Catra for more than a massage in that moment. She smiled back gently, slowly stopping but not quite letting go. Adora didn't mind really, happy for Catra to use her shoulders as a hand rest any day of the week.

"No problem."

They lingered for a long second before Adora's wits came about her.

Project. She'd enlisted Catra's help for her project.

"Right, uh, well, tell me what to do then."

Adora brushed off the awkward tension, deducing that it was just her overthinking. Catra could never see her like that, it was impossible. Whatever happened wasn't a moment, it was just Adora's mind playing games against her.

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"Ugh, I need a drink."

Adora whipped around, looking at a bemused Catra on the other end of the room, shutting down her laptop and switching off the machine.

"A drink? Why not like coffee or something."

"I'm more creative when tipsy. Not heaps, just a bit."

Adora's eyes flicked back to the clock settled by her bed. It was late, Glimmer and Bow had already gone to sleep. And the bulk of her work had been done, all that was left were beaded detailing which had to be hand stitched, and that equipment was back at school. She was forced to relax.

"Why do you need to be creative at twelve o'clock?"

Adora spun in her chair, decidedly packing up for the night. At least, packing away her work.

"Because the theme just came through my inbox."

"I thought you already knew this year's theme?" Adora just assumed Catra was referring to the fashion show she was running this year.

"I knew the choices they had, but the judging panel still has to vote on their favorite one. Of course the hardest fucking theme just had to win."

Adora was dying to know what the theme was, but if Catra was authorized to, or wanted to tell her she would've by now.

"Look, you're the most talented person I know. They could give you literal shit to work with and you'd make it stunning."

Catra smiled wearily at her, running anxious fingers through mangled hair. Adora tried not to divert her attention to her hands, keeping eyes trained on her face instead.

"Thanks, but I still don't know what to do."

Catra groaned into her hands, and Adora bit her lip as she mulled over the suggestion. Maybe one last night of fun would do them both good before returning to the stressors of life. She did want to get her mind off of Shadow Weaver and her taunts, and the project had been pressing down on her the entire week.

"Come on, let's go get drunk."

Catra looked up, and Adora already knew tonight was going to be trouble.

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"Shh, you're gonna wake up the whole house!"

Catra giggled as Adora ran down the stairs, a slight flush to her face from moving after a whole day of sitting.

"Years of Hordak at least taught us one good skill."

Adora held up the pin she'd used to pick Angella's lock, dangling it as she walked backwards into their room.

"Stealing that dick's chocolate definitely made up for years of torture."

Adora snorted, a clear exaggeration, and they both knew it. Catra unscrewed the vodka, taking a straight hit as she closed the door behind her with her leg.

"Come up to my bed."

Catra passed the bottle to Adora, who also took a long drink before answering.

"Why?"

"View's better from top bunk, duh."

"Course," Adora screwed the bottle, tossing it on Catra's large mattress as she climbed on top.

"You coming?"

Adora hung her hands on the sleek wooden rails, looking down at the girl lingering by her desk.

"Yeah, I'm just getting my sketchbook."

Adora nodded to herself and leaned back against the bookshelf behind her, taking another drink as she examined Catra's collection.

"You like mystery and fantasy, don't ya?"

"What?"

Catra's voice was a lot closer, prompting Adora to shift and watch her dump a large book and a pencil case on the bed, followed by the lithe girl.

"Your books."

"Oh, yeah. Villain origin is also good, but that's a niche one."

Adora nodded, propping herself up on a pillow as Catra unloaded her array of pencils and fine liners. She often used her tablet to design, but she seemed to opt for the classic method this time.

"Are you just going to watch me then?" Catra carefully pulled a pencil out of its place, eyes flicking up to Adora in the dimness of the room. None of the lights were glaringly bright, except for that of the kitchen. Adora thought it suited the aesthetic of the house well, but was awfully inconvenient.

"Yup." Adora had never seen Catra in her creative element before, Catra never sketched in Textiles or even around people as far as Adora knew. She felt kind of privileged, being able to watch that pensive gaze slide over her features as she drummed the pencil against her thigh, tucking a loose strand of hair behind her ear. Adora almost felt she was looking at a piece of art itself, the image of Catra before her.

"You're staring," her gaze lifted to meet Adora's, reminding her of when Catra had first said those words a few months ago.

"Sorry, you just look really pretty like that-" Adora waved her arms to emphasize, "all zoned out and stuff."

Catra smirked at the word pretty, causing Adora to nearly panic all the more.

"There you go with the pretty talk again. One drop of alcohol really ruins you, huh Blondie?"

"You know what else ruins me?"

Adora winked with a laugh, causing Catra to roll her eyes and return to the sketchbook.

"I don't think I want to know."

Adora watched, as if mesmerized, when the pencil hit the paper. It all happened so quickly yet slowly, the long lines and measurements being taken. Catra worked in methodical but chaotic steps, going through a very clear process but randomly gasping or exhaling softly when she had a thought. Adora watched the steps in a trance, speechless until Catra finished the design and flipped to the next. In fact, Adora could barely even see what Catra was working on, only the movement of her hands as they blessed the pages.

"You're really good. Like really good."

"Thanks."

Catra took a pause, ripping out one sketch to open back up to a fresh page. She grabbed the bottle from the bed, unscrewing it and taking a few gulps before shaking herself off.

"Can I see?" Adora eyed the piece of discarded paper, tempted to just grab it.

"No, don't even try. These things get locked up until they reach the eyes of my sewing team."

"Are they final sketches?"

"Nah, just a base. I'll probably go over it again with Spinny or something."

Adora nodded, getting herself into a more comfortable position to watch Catra draw.

"It's odd, I never let anyone watch me draw or even really show them my sketches, yet...."

"Yet what?" Adora was all the more curious when Catra's train of thought paused.

"Yet I don't really mind with you watching."

Adora waggled her eyebrows playfully with a mischievous smirk.

"Is it because I make you comfortable."

"Not with that face you don't," Catra snorted into her hand and playfully knocked a pouting Adora.

"You're such a dummy."

"I'm your dummy." Adora boldly quoted Catra from all those years ago, the other girl's eyebrows raising as she recognized the words.

"Yeah, yeah you are."

Her words weren't really joking but Adora barely realized, feeling as if she was light as air.

Catra held their stare as she took another pull from the bottle, wiping her mouth and returning back to work.

"Woah, it's getting to me."

"The alcohol?"

"No, you."

Catra said it so casually that Adora nearly brushed it off. They both seemed to realize the impact of her words after they hit, Catra opening her mouth as Adora cut her off.

"Feeling's mutual."

They sat in silence for a moment as they each processed the other's words.

Did she mean that romantically? She couldn't have, we're just friends. We've always been just friends, even if she's an extremely hot friend.

Catra returned back to her work, Adora watching her as she casually glanced out the window.

"Hey, it's snowing!"

Catra glanced up to review Adora's statement, smiling at the snow.

"The week I got adopted they brought me here. It's like a 'bonding centre' or something I swear."

"Really? The week you got adopted?"

Catra nodded, softly closing her book as if decidedly giving up on thinking.

"I hated the entire family when we got here. But Glimmer was nice during that trip, she kinda reminded me of you. Micah also gave me his old jacket that year, found it in the storage room."

Adora examined Catra's face in the soft light, the nostalgia in her eyes, and she smiled.

"Let's go outside."

"What?"

Adora pointed, raising up to her knees.

"Right now. We haven't been outside when it's snowing."

Catra looked up at her friend in contemplation, chewing her lip. She quickly grabbed the bottle, taking another drink before flinging it to the side and grabbing Adora's hand.

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"Well, would you look who it is?"

Adora and Catra paused in their pursuit, spinning around to face two smug faces as Bow and Glimmer leaned against the doorframe.

"Tsk tsk tsk, getting drunk without us? Adora, I'm offended."

Glimmer walked up to them, snatching the bottle from Adora to take her own drink.

"You two already drank like the entire bottle!"

Bow grabbed the vodka from his girlfriend and took a swig himself, Glimmer folding her arms across her chest judgmentally.

"And sneaking out too? I feel betrayed."

"Are we still joking, or?" Adora whispered to the two of them, unable to tell if Glimmer was seriously mad at her or not. Glimmer rolled her eyes, grabbing Bow's arm and pulling him behind her as they walked down the steps.

"Grab another bottle!"

Catra shurgged, pulling the pin from their collective study table for her and Adora's detour.

"Make sure you don't wake the parents, we have to be really quiet."

Adora motioned for Catra to wait inside so she could slip into the cabinet and take the alcohol, the blue and gold eyes shining in the

slight darkness.

Bow and Glimmer had thoughtfully left the door wide open for them, but were no where in sight. Adora was about to call out to them when she felt the bottle slip out of her hands. Catra winked, taking another drink while walking backwards. Adora remained in the slight shelter, almost scared by the softness of snow.

"Come on dummy, let's go ice skating!"

Ice skating, what's that?

Adora tentatively held a finger out, almost cringing until she realized the ice was simply melting on the heat of her hands.

Ooooooooooo

"Catra, look!"

Adora stuck her tongue out, catching a snow flake that dissolved on her tongue.

"Prettyyy," Adora twirled around, her boots crunching on the ground beneath her as she caught more droplets. Catra giggled at the scene distantly, but for once Adora wasn't fixated on her. Rather her vision was going fuzzy from both the alcohol and momentum of spinning.

"You're gonna get sick, idiot!"

Catra paused Adora in her twirls, the blonde feeling her body warm up from the activity.

"As entertaining as that was, it'd be funnier to see you try and skate."

Catra twined their hands together, yanking an obedient Adora behind her towards the frozen lake.

"Wheeee!"

Adora jumped on the ice without hesitation, sliding over the smooth surface as Catra slowly approached it.

"How have you not fallen over?"

"I dunno!"

Adora called out across the ice, feeling as if she was floating on air. It was a strange sense of euphoria, the wind biting her skin and the vast sea of stars above her. It almost felt surreal. What made it even more unbelievable was the girl in front of her, chuckling as she watched Adora trip over herself slightly as she realized the weight of this experience. At least she wasn't so drunk she couldn't think straight, at least...she hoped. Catra held an arm out to her, Adora taking it without hesitation as she spun her on the ice. Adora couldn't help but laugh, tipping her head back to stare at the sky. It looked familiar.

"We could make an ice show, Blondie."

Catra dipped Adora, the blonde feeling weightless as Catra looked over her.

Her. It's her.

"Your eyes...they're like stars," Adora breathed the words, almost out of breath but needing to get this observation out of her head.

"What?"

Adora couldn't help but stare, the soft gold of Catra's left eye shining against the deepness of the blue. The darkness of the sky behind her only accentuated the quality of them, the slight glow they held.

"Each one lights the other up, like....stars."

Adora pointed upwards, but kept her eyes glued to Catra who still held her in the dip. An expression passed over her flushed face, Catra opening her mouth to say something.

"Adora!.....Catra!"

The faint voices snapped her out of her daze, Adora recognizing Bow and Glimmer calling out to them from a distance.

"Let's go find them, I'm getting cold."

Catra nodded distantly, slowly picking Adora up to her feet but not quite letting go of her waist. Adora brushed it off, thinking maybe the observation was a bit too heavy to just launch on her.

You compared her eyes to stars, I'd get weirded out too.

"I reckon Glimmer just wants us for the alcohol, that greedy glitter bomb."

Adora glanced at the glass bottle dangling in Catra's hand, twisting out of the hold but slinging a hand across her shoulders.

Why do I have to say the worst things?

She's going to be so freaked out.

Fucking drunk Adora. aRGhhHHH!

Adora was so tripped up on her own thoughts that she actually tripped over a small block of ice, Catra being pulled down with her from the weight of Adora's arm around her neck.

"Woah-"

Adora's words instantly cut off when she felt the weight of Catra pressed against her, a tinge rising to her cheeks. She was flat on top of her (well, that wasn't exactly true), slowly lifting her neck as her head pounded from the velocity of the fall. It didn't exactly help to see Catra splayed under her, wild messy hair becoming soaked by the snow beneath them. And her eyes....

God, she's stunning.

Neither of them moved, their breath fogging in the space between them. Adora was scared to lean forward, but even more terrified to pull away.

"Tell me how pretty I am now, Princess," Catra breathed. Adora froze, paralyzed by her words as shivers raised on her skin. She was fairly sure they weren't from the cold, but she'd use that as an excuse for now. A snowflake landed on Catra's cheek, Adora watching as the delicate thing melted slowly. She gently brushed it off, fingers tempted to find themselves in her slightly damp hair.

"Very, very pretty," Adora murmured, almost to herself as she marveled over Catra like a piece of artwork. She hadn't even realized she was leaning in until her lips were mere seconds away from Catra's.

"There you two ar-"

Adora nearly crushed Catra from surprise, head whipping around to a frozen Glimmer in front of her. Both girls turned a piercing crimson, Adora swiftly rolling over and getting to her feet as Bow rolled around the corner.

"Watcha doing, friends?"

"Ice skating."

"Snow."

Catra and Adora both whipped around to face each other at their conflicting alibis, before turning back to the couple in silence.

"Same thing," Catra waved it off, marching through the snow as Glimmer continued to gawk, whipping her head between Catra and Adora.

Well that damn sobered me up.

_____

Anytime

Mild TW for Anxiety/Panic Attacks- Stay safe <3

Adora groaned as she sat up, not only her head but also her limbs aching.

Did she get drunk last night?

She was pretty sure she did, considering that she was sprawled on the large couch rather than in the soft confines of her bed. Rubbing her neck, she looked around, slowly coming to her senses. At least she wasn't in Catra's bed this time, thought something did happen last night...she just couldn't exactly put her finger on what.

"Catra?"

She was slightly concerned about the positioning of Catra's head, her neck literally dangling off the end of the couch. But was it weird if she adjusted her?

Yes, yes it's very weird.

"Catra?" She hissed, using her forearms to shift closer and tap the girl on her shoulder. She didn't budge, Adora rolling her eyes to herself. Of course Catra was a heavy sleeper, she always was the last to wake up in the Horde. In that aspect, she was pretty similar to Glimmer, and they were both stubborn as fuck. Adora bit her lip, just knowing the damage that position could do to Catra's neck. It would be awfully painful....

Oh for fucks sake.

Moving as slowly as possible, Adora gently raised Catra's head, keeping her neck supported. Flashbacks of the night started to filter in; snow, ice, stars?

Catra's eyes flew open and instantly all of Adora's memories flooded her, beating down on her like bricks.

Holy shit. No, surely that was a dream. Definitely.

"Morning," she whispered, careful not to agitate a cranky hungover Glimmer. Catra probably didn't remember anything, and Adora didn't want to make things awkward when they were just becoming close again.

It's best if I just ignore it. If Catra wants to bring it up, I'll let her.

"Couch?"

Adora bit back her flush at the rasp in her voice, forgetting that her hand was still placed under her head. She slowly removed it, letting Catra get a bit of a bearing as she leaned back.

"Yeah, I think we got drunk."

"Think?"

Catra's gaze floated across to the discarded bottles in the corner, Adora following it to also realize just how much they drank that night. She picked up her watch from the floor, checking the time to make sure it wasn't too late yet. They still had to pack and get ready before leaving back to the school. Thankfully, it was only eight, Angella said to be ready by ten.

"Ugh, my head."

Glimmer performed her morning routine, lifting her head from the pillow just to stuff it back in again out of frustration. Adora was fairly used to it by now, having lived with her for a few months.

"Do you two remember anything from last night?"

Glimmer's question was muffled, but Adora heard it plain and clear.

"Nope!" She avoided Catra's eyes stretching and slowly moving off the couch towards the kitchen.

"Neither."

Adora wasn't sure to be disappointed or relieved at Catra's words, frowning slightly as she bent down to get herself a bowl and a glass. The first thing she had to do was get some pain relief medicine, her head was literally weighing her down.

"What are you guys thinking for breakfast?"

"I'm alright with anything, thanks."

Adora nodded at Catra's response, deciding to just make them all some simple toast. She didn't have time to make pancakes or anything special like that, though she had thought of it.

Did Catra sound stiff, or is that just me?

Adora pushed her thoughts away, checking her social media platforms in case she posted something she shouldn't have. After all, she knew Shadow Weaver would be constantly monitoring her feed, probably had all her statistics too. That was the reasoning behind her endorsing Catra and Adora's friendship, or at least online contact.

"Adora?"

"Huh?"

Someone clapped in front of her face, causing Adora to jump back in both fright and shock. Her eyes flew to Catra's who watched the interaction like a hawk.

"Glimmer!"

Bow scolded his girlfriend as Adora shook off her goosebumps. It was just a clap, albeit a fucking loud one, but nothing more. She

was fine, she was safe. Nothing was wrong, she wasn't in trouble, she hadn't gotten a bad grade. It was fine.

"You alright?"

Adora was so concerned with her thoughts she nearly jumped again at Catra's soft touch on her shoulder.

"Yeah, yeah, I'm fine."

Adora avoided her eyes, but Catra continued to examine her, making Adora cough and turn away under the intense scrutiny.

"The toast!"

Adora moved over to the toaster, realizing that was why Glimmer had clapped loudly. Her hands were shaking slightly, they hadn't done that in a while.

Stay still Adora, stop shaking. STOP BEING WEAK.

"I need to go to the bathroom."

"Do you want me to get the-"

Adora didn't hear the rest of Bow's sentence, her heartbeat echoing in her ears. She just needed to get away, needed to calm down before something bad happened. Closing the door behind her, Adora instantly sunk down into the ground, holding her head in her hands. The hangover was bad enough, but a panic attack? Now? For literally no reason? She clasped her hands together firmly, trying to steady herself with the breathing practices recommended on websites. But it didn't help, nothing fucking helped. A knock sounded at the door, so soft Adora wouldn't have even heard it if it wasn't for the vibrations she felt from leaning against it. She didn't respond, hoping it was Angella or Micah and they'd leave thinking it was occupied.

"Adora, it's me."

She took a breath at the voice, unable to decide if she should open it or not.

She did.

"Oh my god."

Adora wasn't able to register anything apart from the arms pulling her closer and the comforting smell of musk and mint.

She held on tight, focussing on anything but the compulsive shaking and tears threatening to fall.

Why are you like this?

"Let it out."

Adora didn't require the instruction, but it helped her ease into the softness of the hug, the familiarity of it. Time was lost, Adora continuing to cling to Catra until the shaking slowly lessened, and they were just hugging each other. Pulling back, Adora wiped her eyes, dreading the part that came after this.

"She -" Catra paused, taking a breath that caught Adora's attention.

"She does it to you, doesn't she?"

Adora didn't bother trying to speak, knowing the words would only get lodged in her throat. So she nodded instead. Rather than getting angry or annoyed as Adora expected, Catra only exhaled with a shake of her head.

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"I didn't want to annoy you." Adora's own voice cracked, another tear slipping out that she quickly wiped away.

"Adora you never were, never are and never will annoy me."

Adora hadn't realized how much those words would affect her, causing her to latch back onto Catra like a lifeline.

"Thank you."

Catra held on tight, burrowing her face into the crook of Adora's shoulder.

"Anytime."

_____

Besties

"Hey, DT sent me the audition script for Macbeth. Do you still want to do it?"

Adora paused on the sewing machine, mulling over Catra's proposition. On one hand she would probably find it difficult to manage exams with memorizing lines, but it was unlikely she'd even get the role. She might as well try, if she played even a background character or something it'd be fun.

"Sure, forward it to me."

"Cool," she turned around to Bow and Glimmer.

"I sent it to you as well. Sparkles, DT said they directly sent the info to you."

"Yup, they did. The set is going to look amazing, we'll crush Elite Prime this year."

She slowly crunched her hands together, a furious venom in her expression that slightly frightened Adora.

"Speaking of Elite Prime, we need to prepare."

"Woah, hold on. Who even is Elite Prime?"

Adora had heard those words floating around the school for a while now, and knew they were a rival boarding school on the other end of the woods. But she didn't really know why the two schools hated each other so much.

"The all boys boarding school, I swear they're all clones or something."

"No legit, they act like a pyramid scheme or something. They even tried to make Catra join when she scored the winning point last year."

"We are not talking about that." She turned to Adora. "It was really fucking weird. They even called me their sister."

Adora snorted, finding herself even more intrigued by this cult-like school.

"The fucking Principle, Horace Prime, keeps trying to take ownership rights of our school. It's driving Mom crazy."

"Wait, how can he even do that? Mom's held the school in the family for generations."

Glimmer shrugged at Catra's question, Adora finding herself just getting increasingly confused.

"Hold on, you mentioned something about preparing. What for?"

"Every year, you know we have an annual games tournament. Each sports team will verse their one. Like, for example, our basketball team will verse theirs. Whoever wins scores more points for their school, and at the end of the comp one of the schools win the whole thing."

"Speaking of basketball teams, have you heard back from Mr Hawk?"

Adora shook her head, putting aside the scrap piece of cloth she was working on. She'd tried out for the team barely two days coming into school, and it was now the end of the week and she'd heard nothing about the outcome.

"He said he'll tell me by Monday, but it's already Sunday so I don't think I'll get in."

Catra laughed, twisting herself on Adora's bed.

"Honestly, he probably forgot, remind him in your next class. The man would accidentally set fire to the school if Mermista wasn't around."

Catra wasn't wrong, both Sea Hawk and his brother had a certain affinity for flames. The last Salineas party had nearly resulted in the dorm getting burnt down, Double Trouble was loving it.

"Yes, but he's a hot man, so it works."

Glimmer shot a glare at Bow, who looked up with a bit of a guilty expression.

"Oops?" He shrugged, but Glimmer just shook her head slightly with a roll of her eyes.

"Great, the fucking dads want to see me again. They specifically invited you along too Glim."

"At least you guys are actually dating now?" Adora tried to look on the bright side of things, but only Bow seemed to appreciate it.

"Hey, I finally thought of our name!"

Catra put down her phone, sitting up to attention at Bow's words. Adora herself was intrigued by this 'name.'

"The Best Friend Quad. Get it, because there's four of us?"

Catra rolled her eyes, almost looking too Adora for permission.

"We are not calling ourselves that."

"Mhm, sure." Bow winked to Adora, who hid her smile with the sleeve of her jacket. She'd started wearing the one Catra had specifically designed for her, deciding that it was worth breaking a few school uniform rules to wear something specially made just for her.

"Are you gonna tell your dads that you want to be an architect this time? Or at least not a historian?"

"Wait, you want to be an architect?"

Catra piped up from Adora's bed, looking at Bow with interest. Adora seemed to forget she didn't spend the first few months of term with them (in fact, she spent it despising them). She'd settled into the rhythm of their group fairly well.

"Yeah, but I don't think my dads are too keen for it. I'm their only hope left of becoming a historian."

"Fuck that. They lived their dream, why shouldn't you live yours?" Catra shrugged, Bow smiling kindly at her statement along with Adora, who very firmly agreed with her.

"Yep, Catra's right, for once."

Catra looked up from...filing her nails? (When the hell did she get a nail filer?), and hissed at Glimmer, who just giggled.

"I want to get some chocolate from the cafe, someone come with?"

"Oh, I'll go!"

Glimmer death stared her boyfriend, Bow looking to Adora with a look of disarray.

"Did I do something?" Glimmer crossed her arms and pouted at Bow, not really supplying him with a firm answer but suggesting one.

"Adora, you come with me."

Adora had the weird sense that Glimmer had purposely chosen her to come with, ignoring Bow's offer. Still, she slowly sat up from the chair, throwing one last glance at Catra and Bow before shutting the door softly behind her.

"So, what is it?" She was desperately curious to know now.

"What's what?"

"Why did you drag me out to come walk with you?"

"Nothing."

"Bullshit, I'm not stupid."

Adora was hoping Glimmer would cut the crap already and get to it.

"You know, my first crush was Bow."

Adora raised an eyebrow, turning to face her friend as she walked.

"And?"

Glimmer shrugged with nonchalance, slipping hands into her dress pockets.

"Nothing, nothing..."

Adora nodded slowly, narrowing her eyes with suspicion while she waited for Glimmer to evaporate.

"I think it's just a universal experience, you know?"

"What is?" Adora was really just clueless at this stage, what the hell was Glimmer getting at?

"Having a crush on your best friend."

"Glimmer, I hate to burst your bubble, but unfortunately, I don't have a crush on you."

Was this all Glimmer wanted to know? If Adora had some secret pining for her or something?

"Awww, I'm your best friend?"

"Who else is?"

"Your girlfriend?"

Adora blinked, nearly doing a full spin on her heels.

"I'm painfully single, sorry to disappoint."

"Oh sorry, my bad. Your soon-to-be girlfriend."

Glimmer winked, Adora shifting her head in both confusion and surprise. Who was Glimmer talking about, exactly?

"I honestly have no idea what you're talking about. I'm not even talking to anyone. Wait, does someone in the school like me?"

"You really are dense, aren't you?"

Adora frowned, a bit of excitement dissipating.

"CATRA! Who the fuck else, Adora?"

Glimmer threw her hands up in exasperation, quickly lowering her voice when the two girls realized she was just yelling Catra's name in the courtyard. Adora just blinked again, a bit shocked Glimmer thought they'd be romantically involved.

"Oh. Wait, so you think I have feelings for Catra? You think Catra has feelings for me?"

"Was that not clear, or something?"

"I just...never thought about it like that," Adora mumbled, tucking a strand of loose hair behind her ear.

"Are you just conveniently missing that little cozy snow moment during the holidays?"

If Adora was being honest, she was. That "cozy snow moment" could ruin everything she and Catra had built over the past three weeks, and she didn't really want to make things stiff and weird between them. They were drunk, probably attracted to the body heat of the other in the cold, and they sorta just fell on each

other. It's not like they actually kissed or anything, nor were any actual emotions attached to it.

"Are you saying you feel absolutely nothing for Catra, then?"

Adora thought about it for a moment. Yes, Catra was undeniably attractive and Adora was attracted to her, but they were just friends, that's all they'd ever be...Right?

"No, I never really said that. She's pretty, like really pretty, but I don't think I'd jeopardize our friendship for a chance at a relationship. Besides, I don't think either of us actually sees the other in that way, not like how you and Bow see each other."

Glimmer gaped at her, mouth hanging and everything.

"You really are the dumbest person I've met, you know that, right?"

_____

Oblivious Jock Phase

"What'd he say?"

Glimmer was hopping from one foot to another as Adora walked out of the gym, having stayed back to ask Mr Hawk about her trial.

"I'm on the team!"

She grinned, holding up the blue and purple singlet and jumper. Glimmer squealed, grabbing the items from Adora with greedy hands.

"They really improved the quality of these things."

Adora nodded, touching the soft material with reverence as Glimmer passed it back. Bow hooked a chin over her shoulder to look over at it.

"Why does it say 'GRAYSKULL' though? My last name is just Gray."

"It's the name of the team, well all sport teams. We call ourselves the skulls."

Adora nodded slowly, beginning to come to terms with it a bit.

"I like it, has a good ring."

Adora supposed she could agree with Bow, the word seemed to roll off her tongue, Grayskull.

"I got my audition tonight."

She paused at her locker, Glimmer waiting as Bow waved goodbye to turn back around for his next class.

"Exciting, Bow said his is tomorrow."

Adora nodded, exchanging her water bottle for a set of books and technology.

"And I have my first training session on Friday. Mr Hawk said I need to 'bond' before next Wednesday."

"Ah, yes, when the Prime shit arrives. They stay on our campus for like two weeks while the games go on."

"Where do they stay, where's the extra accommodation?"

Adora swung her door shut, nearly jumping into the crowd of hallway walkers when Catra leaned on the other side of it.

"Hey, Adora. Sparkles."

She gave a nod to Glimmer, who was on Adora's other side, and who very pointedly gave Adora a look. Adora had barely gotten any proper sleep the night before, a bit too consumed in what Glimmer had suggested in the afternoon. But she'd come to the firm decision that everything that happened between her and Catra was plainly platonic, and she couldn't really change that.

"The extra rooms are in the woods. We bring out these tents, nice tents, but still tents."

Adora nodded, wondering if she'd have to reroute her runs for the next few weeks. She wasn't keen on running into enemy territory at 5am every morning.

"DT wants me to come to your audition, so I'll meet you there?"

"Why do they want you to come as well."

Catra shrugged, beginning to walk backwards without any fear of being hit by another student in the busy corridor.

"Who knows?"

"Ready?"

Catra nodded, both of them heading into the auditorium, which Adora had never actually been in.

"Woah, this place is big."

Big was an understatement, the gauzy fabric curtains that framed the stage and gold embellishments on balconies made it seem a lot more dramatic than just a simple school building.

"Darlings!"

Adora's eyes finally caught onto the figure standing on the stage. They approached closer, Double Trouble giving a flick of their long blonde hair as they passed Adora a piece of paper.

"I have it on my iPad."

She held up her device, DT waving it away and insisting on the piece of paper.

"I don't know what extra notes you've put on that script, I'm giving you a clean one to work with."

Adora guessed that was fair, even if she hadn't bothered to annotate the script that was emailed to her.

"Right, so do I just get to watch?"

Catra seemed to just answer her own question, about to sit down on one of the cushioned seats when DT called out to her.

"For now, but don't get too comfortable there kitten."

DT winked at Adora, the blonde a bit confused by both the words and gesture.

Adora didn't understand any Shakespearean language in the original play, but DT had adapted it to suit the modern language. That made her job just a bit easier, even if she had to deal with

bicoloured eyes glinting at her from the darkness while she performed.

Saying the lines by herself was simple enough. She and Catra were familiar with plays, having made and written their own to pass time in the orphanage. DT was perfectly poised and neutral, reading out the lines of Banquo for the scenes they were going through.

"Catra, darling, come here."

It was more so a statement then a request, and they both seemed to understand that.

"I thought my audition was over? If someone else wants the role, I'm happy to-"

"No kitten, you're the Lady Macbeth. I just want you to run through Act 1, Scene 5. The whole ending has been adjusted, so it's important you two have perfect dialogue."

"Wait, you changed the ending?"

DT just scoffed with a slight laugh.

"As if Lady Macbeth and her husband die, that's just boring."

Adora turned to Catra, wondering if she had any idea of this alternate evil Macbeth universe DT had created. She didn't seem to.

"It's going to be fantastic! Instead of going mad with power and offing themselves, they unite and kill everyone! And then, I'm going to leave it on a cliffhanger, where the power couple wants to attack and control the entirety of Europe."

DT themself looked 'mad with power,' Adora thought vaguely.

"That's why it's important that you two bring the heat, though I doubt that'll be difficult."

Adora chose to ignore the mumbled few words as DT walked off the stage, Adora following the stage cues set out on the page before her. Catra did the same, Adora approaching her to begin the scene.

"My beloved wife, a set of witches have fore told our future!"

"And is it in alignment with my own prophecies?"

Catra, or as Adora would label, Lady Macbeth arched an eyebrow as Adora pulled back from their hug.

"They predicted me to assume the role of Thane of Cawdor, and it came true."

"What else have they prophesied, partner of greatness?"

How does she make everything sound good, literally anything.

"I am to be king, and you are to be my queen."

Adora glanced down, realizing she had to pick Catra up and spin her around as 'two infatuated lovers' do. The set actions were awfully descriptive. Still, she followed through, Catra slightly surprised but not resistant at the movement.

"Our future starts now, my love."

Adora didn't let go as the twirl ended, gently placing Catra back on her feet but a hand hidden on her waist.

"We must take care of Duncan."

"He comes tonight."

"Then he must not live to see the morning light, nearly as radiant and scalding as you."

"Oh, Macbeth, you make me blush."

Wow she's actually blushing, how could I forget what a good actress Catra is?

"Smile with teeth of daggers and put poison in our words."

Catra loosed a breathy laugh, looking down for a moment before returning back to Adora.

She's beautiful-

No, nope, we are not going there.

But what if we should?

We really shouldn't.

"You should take to your own advice, my king. Your expressions are an open book."

Adora nearly broke character, thinking Catra could tell what she was thinking when she realized it was just part of the script. She glanced down, following the instruction to brush a hand against Catra's cheek.

It was electrifying, the pull to bring her closer overriding every logical thought in her mind.

Is Glimmer right? Do I...like Catra?

"You are the brains behind our power, I am merely a puppet willing to subject to your commands. Excuse me if my naivety disappoints you."

"On the contrary, it's endearing."

The look in Catra's eyes, the tone of her voice, it was beginning to make Adora feel heady. It was like that musk and mint was messing with her senses.

Holy shit, I have feelings for Catra.

"And scene."

Adora instantly let go, a state on panic overcoming her. This was not good, she's her friend, and Adora didn't feel the need to complicate things.

Or is it just because of Shado-

No, nonsense. Of course it wasn't Shadow Weaver influencing her, Adora had been avoiding her calls for the past two weeks. She was honestly expecting her to just fly out to see her at this point.

"You alright, Adora? You look...frazzled."

Adora took a breath, pushing aside her thoughts to examine later. She just nodded at Catra, turning to DT who held a mischievous glint in their eye.

"Congratulations, you're our new Macbeth!"

"I got the part? Just like that?"

"Darling, you had the part before you even walked into this room."

Adora gaped, wondering if there was really such a low demand to be in a Shakespearean play.

———————

"Glimmer, you're right."

Adora sat down on the couch with a sigh, Bow coming out of his room when he heard the door unlock. Adora couldn't stop thinking about Catra, about the way she delivered her lines, her eyes, her hair, her...everything.

"Mhm, of course I am...What exactly about though?"

Adora smiled with a slight laugh as Bow perched on the end of the couch. Rubbing her palms into her eyes, she groaned in

annoyance. Seriously, a crush on her longest friend was uncalled for at this time.

"I have a crush on Catra." She could practically feel the look Bow and Glimmer exchanged, even if she didn't see it.

"Sorry, what was that."

She narrowed her eyes, spitting out a crude laugh at Glimmer's joke.

"I have a crush on Catra! Happy."

"Oh, so her oblivious jock phase has passed then? That's good."

"Okay, sass." Adora rolled her eyes at Bow's comment, wondering exactly how long her two friends knew about her crush before she even did.

"Well it's one step closer."

"Closer to what?"

Adora stared at Glimmer, finding herself a bit frightened at the expression which shadowed her face.

"A RELATIONSHIP! What else, Adora?"

"Oh, yeah, just one slight problem with that. CATRA DOESN'T LIKE ME LIKE THAT."

She waved her arms around to emphasize, glad the walls were thick between dorms.

"Fucking hell, the phase is back."

———————

Training and Tension

"What if they don't like me?"

"What do you mean what if they don't like you, they already know you."

Glimmer was getting increasingly frustrated at Adora's obliviousness to everything around her, but Adora obviously couldn't help it if she was an academic dumbass.

"No, but they definitely don't like me."

Glimmer rolled her eyes, stopping Adora with her hands on her shoulders as they neared the gym doors.

"It's gonna be great, I already know you're gonna be the best one on that team."

"Awe, you think?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes again, Adora beginning to become jokingly offended by the repeated action. She'd already rolled her eyes about four times on the way from their dorm.

"Yes. I think. Now have fun, you're already late because your stupid poof wasn't perfect."

Adora laughed, waving goodbye to her friend as she pushed open the doors. Ugh, she hated meeting new people, or interacting with people she already kinda knew but didn't know, you know?

"Ah, Adora! Welcome lass," Mr Hawk called out to her with waving arms. Adora blushed slightly, raising her hand for a slight wave when she realized the entire fucking team was just staring at her late self.

"You don't wear team jerseys to training."

Lonnie looked at her (very judgmentally) with a flat tone, Adora feeling even more embarrassed when she noticed the training shorts and jumper everyone wore.

"Ah, no big deal Lonnie. Just shows she's getting in the spirit for Wednesday!"

Mr Hawk grinned openly at her and Adora felt a bit of knotted up tension release inside of her.

"Let's start with some warm up drills, Lonnie I want you to teach Adora as Team Captain."

Lonnie grumbled something under her breath that made Adora feel a bit sick. She already seemed to have one team member that didn't like her, and she was the team captain.

"Don't even think about stealing another thing from me."

Adora paused at the fierce look in her moss green eyes.

"What?"

"Like you don't know." Lonnie scoffed, getting some equipment and tossing (violently throwing was a better phrase, Adora thought) the supplies to her. Adora didn't dare protest, deciding it was better to just muscle through Lonnie's anger than ask her what her problem was.

"So uhm, Mr Hawk said something about drills?"

"Like this."

Lonnie showed Adora a few moves, in such quick succession Adora could barely remember the first one.

"Got it?"

The question seemed rhetorical, but Adora was ready to ask anyway.

"Uh, what was the first move again, sorry?"

Lonnie over exaggerated a roll of her eyes, glaring at Adora as she did the move again. Adora was just plain confused, Lonnie had never expressed a stark dislike or hatred towards her when Catra did, so why was she so mad now?

Adora hesitantly followed, bending down on the ground to perform the exercise while trying to keep her gaze off of Lonnie.

"Do you have an issue with me?"

She couldn't help it, the girl was practically killing her with her stare.

"Nope, I'm fine."

It was such a clear lie, but Adora just decided to ignore it, somewhat glad she wasn't looking at her anymore.

_____

The rest of the training passed by in a blur, Adora purposely missing the snide remarks Lonnie sent her way every time she made even the slightest mistake, which thankfully wasn't very often. But by the end, Adora was beginning to get fed up. She'd been putting up with all of Lonnie's drama for an entire hour and a half and she couldn't do that for a whole year, it'd drive her crazy.

"Can you tell me why you're mad? Please, I want to be your friend."

"You just need to be everyone's friend, don't you?"

Lonnie grabbed her bag, not even looking at Adora who watched everyone filter out of the locker room.

"Stop with the weird comments, did I do something to you?"

"It's not me you did it too."

Adora realized she wasn't getting anywhere with this girl, ready to just get her shit and leave when a breath from Lonnie caught her attention.

"It's Catra."

The words were almost to herself, but Adora was glad she heard them.

"This-this is about Catra?"

Lonnie narrowed her eyes at Adora, swinging the bag over her shoulder.

"Who else?"

Adora blinked, realizing there really only was one person this could be about.

"Wait, but why are you mad at her, or me or whatever?"

"Ever since you showed up it's like I lost her."

Adora wasn't really sure how to respond to that. Catra had spent a lot more time with Adora, Glimmer and Bow since the ski trip, but Adora almost forgot about Kyle, Lonnie and Rogelio, who maybe felt neglected in that past week.

"Oh, I'm sor-"

"Ugh, don't apologize."

Lonnie abruptly sat down, holding her head in a hand while her other waved out to Adora. The blonde just stood there, a bit wary of Lonnie's sudden mood change.

"I'm mad at Catra, not you."

"But you-"

"I know what I said, alright. I just-I don't know, miss her?"

Lonnie shrugged, almost looking to Adora for advice. Adora quickly sat down beside her, thankful the girl wasn't burning lasers with her eyes at her anymore.

"That's understandable, you guys were close."

"Not really."

Adora was surprised at the soft words that slipped out Lonnie's mouth. Those two lived together, and were hardly apart.

"But you're always together?"

Lonnie scoffed, making Adora feel as if she'd somewhat crossed a line.

"No. Sure, she'd talk to me and joke with me but we weren't close, not how you two are."

"I doubt that's true, I've only moved here a few months ago."

"Yeah, but in those few months she managed to be more your friend than she ever was mine."

Adora looked back down at her hands, stunned into silence. Was Catra really so distant with everyone else but her?

"I'm..sorry, for being mad at you. Just forget that ever happened."

Lonnie finally looked up at her, the marble green eyes offering a conciliatory smile that gave Adora a twinge of sadness.

"Welcome to the team, newbie."

———————

"Good, you're back."

Adora dumped her bag on the couch as Catra jumped up from Glimmer's desk.

"Why are you using Glimmer's desk?"

Adora peered over at the various pieces of paper and scattering of pencils littering the surface before Catra quickly blocked her view. Not that Adora really minded, she looked cute; hair in a messy bun, an oversized jumper (was that Adora's?) and a pair of shorts on.

"She isn't using it, she prefers Bow's bed."

Catra smirked, Adora glancing over her shoulder to see Bow's bedroom door closed before returning back to Catra. As much as she loved Bow and Glimmer's newfound romance, she was glad she had another friend to distract herself with.

"Wait, Catra, I need to ask you something."

Catra groaned, rolling her shoulders at Adora's request.

"No, let me go first, I've been waiting the entire ninety minutes you've been gone to ask."

This caught Adora's attention. What was so important Catra was waiting a whole hour and a half to ask her?

"Fine, you win. Shoot."

Settling back into the couch, Adora lifted her feet to rest on the table as Catra cleared her throat.

"Well, uhm... I-"

Was she nervous? Adora never thought she'd live to see the day Catra was nervous to ask her something.

"I've already asked Bow and Glimmer, but you're important so-"

"Why am I important?" Adora rested a cheek against her palm, raising eyebrows at Catra who gently pushed her shoulder with a hand.

"Because you're special, dummy."

This caught Adora by surprise, the blonde reeling back a bit as she processed her words with widened eyes. Catra instantly backtracked, making Adora's hopes slightly deflate.

Of course she didn't mean it like that, why would she?

"I mean, you're special because you're the masterpiece."

"The masterpiece of what, exactly?"

"The show! My show."

Adora blinked, looking at an excited Catra that tucked her knees under herself while she waited for Adora's response.

"You want me?"

She quickly realized what she said and corrected herself before Catra could realize.

"-to be the centre piece of the fashion show? As in, the one heaps of really famous people will be watching?"

"Yes, I know it sounds like a really big ask, but you kind of..inspired the dress that inspired the rest of the line."

Adora blushed, hiding it with her hands at the thought that Catra used her for inspiration. To smother her smitten expression, she asked the first question that sprung into her mind.

"Does that mean I can see the collection?"

"Absolutely not. Bow and Glimmer asked that as well. You guys get to be blindfolded while my team does the fittings."

Adora scrunched her face at the word 'blindfold.'

"Don't worry, I'll be doing you myself. I trust no one else to execute the vision I have in mind, so no one else is working on your piece."

Adora nearly gulped. Catra doing her, while she was blindfolded?

Out of that territory Adora, out, out!

"So, what did you want to ask me?"

Adora blinked out of her thoughts, focussing back on the question she needed to ask Catra. It'd been sitting in her head from the moment she talked with Lonnie.

"Why are you ignoring your friends?"

She nearly cringed at her own tone, and at the way Catra reacted. She opened her mouth to come across a bit softer, rather than accusatory, but Catra didn't permit her the chance.

"What?"

Her voice was sharp, arms crossed and gaze direct.

"Lonnie and the others, why don't you sit with them anymore?"

She made an attempt to sound a bit more gentle, but it was clear Catra was being defensive.

"Are you saying you don't want to be my friend anymore?"

"When did I ever say that, of course I want you to be my friend."

"Then why the need to question me about my choices and who I want to distance myself from?"

Catra's tone was cold, but her eyes boiled with suppressed anger. Adora knew better than to further aggravate her.

"I'm not, just...have a chat with Lonnie. I think you'll find yourself surprised."

They held each other's gaze, Adora noting the hardening of Catra's eyes.

Don't put your walls back up.

Don't give me a reason to, Catra shot back at her in her gaze.

Adora slowly looked away, getting off of the couch.

"I'm going for a shower, I'll see you later."

Adora didn't intend to give the impression that Catra should leave her room, but it may have come across that way for Catra instantly moved toward's Glimmer's desk to pack her stuff up. Debating whether to intervene or not, Adora decided to let it go. It was late, and she didn't feel like getting even more involved with Catra and Lonnie's friendship. Sighing softly as Catra shut the door without a second glance, Adora wasn't the least bit surprised when Bow and Glimmer rushed out of his room.

"Something happened, but the walls were too thick to hear."

Adora offered a weak smile, settling back into the couch to give them a rundown as Bow and Glimmer positioned themselves in front of her.

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The Boarding Games

Adora woke on Wednesday morning a nervous mess. Her fingers were trembling so much she could barely tie her hair up.

"Get it together Adora, you have to perform. Don't choke now."

She spoke softly to herself, trying to ignore the message that beeped on her phone.

Shadow Weaver.

Adora had been purposefully avoiding her phone calls with her, keeping them as brief and rare as possible, but that never stopped her from sending her daily texts. Unable to resist, Adora swiped open her phone.

Go and win today, my star.

She let out a breath, tension within her rising while she also felt welcome relief. Putting the phone down again, Adora was surprised to see another message filter through.

I trust you to rid yourself of distractions during this critical time.

Adora knew who Shadow Weaver was talking about, and despised the fact that she was partly correct. The thought of eliminating Catra from her life was unthinkable, but the girl was causing Adora to lose sleep almost every night.

The first few nights following their argument were difficult, mostly because Catra was too stubborn to talk to Lonnie. But then Glimmer had given Adora the brilliant idea of asking Lonnie, who was very hesitant but thankfully agreed. Catra had approached Adora about a day ago, slightly mad that she'd gone to Lonnie (how did she even know when Lonnie didn't tell her?) , but they managed to work everything out (sort of) in the end. Now Adora was losing sleep over the thoughts of Catra, which often passed her mind even when she was having a simple conversation with

her. Looking in the mirror, Adora noticed her own blush forming on her face and lightly slapped herself to shake out of it.

She's really messing with your functionality you horny idiot.

"Ready for the big day?"

Adora's eyes caught Bow leaning against the door frame and she smiled.

"You make it sound like I'm getting married," she joked, finally mustering the strength to tie her hair up.

"They're coming around ten, we're meant to welcome them but last year people threw eggs, so we aren't doing that this year."

Adora snorted, knowing "people" definitely consisted of Glimmer. She was likely the main perpetrator, it seemed like something she'd think of doing.

"Be honest, how good are their sport teams?"

Bow took a breath, causing Adora to emphasize the "be honest" part of her question.

"Pretty damn good. They're the only team that can hold a candle to us."

Adora loosed a breath, the statement doing nothing to calm her nerves.

"You shouldn't be scared though, we smashed them last year, we can do it again this year."

Bow gave her a grin, easing Adora slightly.

"Mornin'."

Adora looked over to see Catra stroll in, taking a bite out of one of the cafeteria's croissants.

"How are you so calm right now?"

Catra shrugged, swallowing as she stuck a hand in the pocket of her coat. She'd donned Angella's old jacket again, only this time navy and indigo streaks coated her cheeks, along with stark white and black eyeliner. She looked good, but that was frequently the case.

"I'm not, I just don't externalize my inner conflict. Scorpia told me so."

Adora had briefly heard of Scorpia, but more in passing conversation. Catra did mention she was her therapist, the first time she was drunk, but there was another detail Adora felt she missed.

"Scorpia's coming today, isn't she?"

Oh, that's right. Scorpia was one of the teachers at Prime Elite.

"Yup, she spent our last session focussing on the fact that she'll actually see me rather than what we were meant to be doing."

"You do your sessions online?"

Adora should've guessed that was the case, but it didn't cross her mind.

"Duh. How'd your audition go?"

Catra turned her attention to Bow, Adora following along to hear his response.

"I got the part!"

Adora grinned with slight relief, it'd be great for all of them to be working on something fun together with DT, at least it provided them with a break from their exam stress.

Well, more like Adora's exam stress, she seemed to be the only one freaking out. She'd even coerced Glimmer into helping her make an exam study timetable so she'd be able to fit all her new extra-curriculas with academics.

"I get to hold a dagger. I tried to make DT change it to a bow and arrow, but they refused."

Bow's recount of his audition carried them out the door and into the courtyard, Glimmer not with them because Angella asked her to welcome the crowd. Bow said she'd made Glimmer do it as a 'peace offering.'

"As much as I love sports, it's going to be so fucking boring just watching this year."

"Honestly, I don't think volleyball will win this year without you."

"Neither do I."

Adora laughed with Bow at Catra's blunt comment, reaching the cafeteria just in time for breakfast.

"Oh, we missed them coming in."

Bow looked over in dismay at the lineup of green and silver buses near the gates. Adora frowned, she was kind of looking forward to seeing them enter the cafeteria, but she supposed she'd be seeing them nevertheless.

"Scorpia!"

Catra waved over at a white haired woman standing in one of the corners. At first, Adora was severely intimidated by her, the girl looking very strong and watchful, but a grin quickly brightened her face when her dark eyes spotted Catra. She moved towards them, giving Catra a hug while her eyes momentarily flicked too Adora.

"This must be the Adora I've heard so much about?"

Catra talks about me! Wait, what does she say?

"Hi!"

Adora gave her cheesiest smile and waved, but Scorpia's eyes didn't brighten as they had the moment she'd seen Catra.

"Hmm..."

She trailed off in thought, causing Adora to raise her eyebrows at Catra who just avoided eye contact.

"And this is Bow, Glimmer's boyfriend."

Scorpia nodded at Bow in response to Catra's introduction, her gaze temporarily paused from examining Adora.

"Hey guys!"

Adora turned around to see Perfuma, her face slightly flushed from the heat in the room.

"Are you excited for the games?"

"This year's going to be boring because I'm not in it."

Catra rolled her eyes with a puff, causing Adora to laugh at the genuine tone. She had to admit she did want to see Catra play in the games, especially since she was already so competitive in every minor activity she participated in.

"Oh, hello!"

Perfuma turned towards Scorpia, a cheery expression on her face. Adora noticed a slight blush form on Scorpia's face and turned to Bow and Catra to see if they noticed it. Catra didn't seem to, but Bow exchanged a look with Adora to confirm he saw it.

"H-hi, I'm Scorpia, nice to meet you."

The pair of teachers shook hands with a bit of a linger, making the students feel only slightly uncomfortable.

"We're gonna just...go."

Adora nodded her head towards the table, but neither Perfuma or Scorpia seemed to hear her.

"How long do you reckon?"

Bow looked at Adora, who thought over the question for a moment.

"I'd give it a solid month."

"Agreed."

Adora looked behind to ask Catra if she noticed the flirtation between the two teachers, but her eyes were solidly fixed on the table they were heading towards.

"You alright?"

Adora's eyes caught on a man at the front of the room, her question finishing abruptly as she noticed him. He was frightening, to say the least. A long protruding chin and sharp cheekbones cutting through pale sallow skin, he looked nearly sickly. The lime green eyes met her own grey blue ones, and she quickly looked away, ignoring the prickle she felt on the back of her neck.

"Horace Prime, I'd be careful around him. The guy is dodgy but no one's found anything solid against him."

Adora understood now why Catra hadn't looked around the room, feeling Prime's eyes trail her as if she was being showered with dirty water.

"Careful, he may try to kidnap you too," Catra murmured as they sat down next to each other. She seemed to have caught on

Prime's gaze, and was now looking directly at him.

Adora turned to look at her, but Catra's eyes didn't leave Prime's until the man finally diverted his attention away from Adora. A sinister smile spread across his face, unpleasing to just about everyone in the room. He slowly turned away, back towards Angella, who sat beside Glimmer with a rather nervous look on her face. Standing up, Adora focussed her attention on Angella as she tentatively grabbed a microphone.

"Staff and students of Brightmoon, please join me in welcoming Prime Elite for the final Boarding Games."

Wait, final?

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The Blight of Horace Prime

"What the fuck?"

Catra looked at Angella imploringly, the entire group rushing over to the head table as soon as she finished speaking.

"I haven't told you yet, but I'm resigning."

"Sorry, what?"

Glimmer stood dumbfounded in front of her mother, gaping as Adora just kept shaking her head. No way could Angella resign, Glimmer said this school had been founded by her entire family. It was practically her legacy, how could Angella resign?

"I'll discuss the details with you all tomorrow night, nothing's been officially finalized, but everything's already set in action. Next year, a new figure will be taking full custody over the school."

Absolute silence filled Adora's mind.

No. Not the school she initially hated but grew to love, the school that was her home. She nearly felt betrayed, but they all knew there was more to this story. Angella may not reside in the school full time, being an International Business Owner and Director, but she'd give it all up for the school, Adora knew. She didn't want to give it up, it was someone else. The pale lavender eyes were soft, almost a shade of shame.

"I don't want to cloud your mind with concern, you have a big day tomorrow Adora, try not to get worked up over this until I explain everything. I mean it."

She directed her last few words towards the entire group, and her very last ones more so to Glimmer, who stood in silence, completely stunned.

Adora readied herself nervously, wishing she didn't skip her morning run. She wanted to conserve her energy for the game, but she was beginning to think the extra adrenaline was hindering her. She couldn't get her nerves to settle for more than a minute.

"I don't know if I'm gonna be sick or if I'm just nervous. What if I end up chucking when I'm scoring a goal? What if I just fail and everyone blames me, and then I get kicked off the team and-"

"Adora, calm down!"

Glimmer shook Adora by the shoulders, but that really did nothing for either of them.

"You're freaking out so now I'm freaking out goddammit!"

Bow chuckled, wrapping a hand around Glimmer's shoulder while looking at Adora with steady brown eyes.

"You're going to be great, don't stress."

"But what if-"

"You're one of the best players in that team, Blondie."

Adora turned around to face Catra, who gave a glimpse of a smile. Somehow, a simple look from her calmed everything that was jumping in her stomach.

"Besides, even if you do 'fail,' it's not the end of the world."

Catra gave her a half smile and shrugged, causing Adora to scoff as she remembered their childhood. Those were words she rarely heard from Shadow Weaver.

"You got this."

Catra reached up and hugged Adora, making the blonde wish she held on for a bit longer when she quickly pulled back.

"Thanks."

A looming presence overshadowed her peripheral, causing Adora to subtly turn her head in order to see who was behind her. She couldn't say she was exactly thrilled to see that it was Horace Prime.

"I've come to wish the Brightmoon team the best of luck."

Something about the way he talked put Adora off. Maybe it was the way he extended his syllables, or the slight hiss of his tone, but it was fucking creepy. But at least a creepy man distracted her from fears of letting her team down. Adora didn't really want to respond to him, especially since the entirety of her team (besides herself, of course) was still getting ready for the game, and she was the only one of them actually out at that moment.

"Thank you."

She dodged his eyes, opting to look at the silver green crest on his suit jacket.

"You're Adora, correct me if I'm wrong?"

Adora just knew by the tone of his voice that he already knew he was correct, he'd seemed to have enquired about her.

"Yes."

"And you're...friends with Catra?"

She wasn't a big fan of how he said Catra's name...then again, she wasn't a fan of anything he did.

"Correct."

Catra answered for her, making Adora feel less uneasy with her best friend beside her.

"Wonderful to meet with you again, Catra."

"Can't say I feel the same."

Adora vaguely wondered how Catra was so bold when talking to him, just the sound of his voice made Adora want to run away.

"You're fierce, a delightful challenge."

Now what the actual fuc-

Catra didn't respond, but Adora felt heat rise over her.

"I'd like to get some training in before the game begins, if you don't mind."

Adora finally met his eyes, hardening her features so he got the hint to piss off.

"Of course."

He did a slight tilt of his head, but it was condescending rather than respectful. Adora glared at his back as he walked off, shaking off his presence that had distracted her.

"He's so off. I'd be careful on the court today, Adora. The guy's hungry for talent," Catra mumbled under her breath.

"Why is he so obsessed with you? The dick barely looked at us."

Adora nearly laughed at Glimmer's sincerity as she pointed to herself and Bow leaning against the wall.

"Trust me, you're lucky."

———————

"Oh my fucking god, that was amazing!"

Catra squealed, instantly jumping on Adora as she came off the court. She held on for a moment, Adora relishing the hug, before hugging Lonnie as well. Adora was glad Catra managed to still be friends with Lonnie, even if she didn't hang out with them as often as she used to. And Adora herself liked Lonnie, she was nice when she wasn't judgmental.

"You practically slaughtered the other team."

Bow commented as Adora sat down, fanning herself in a pathetic attempt to regulate her temperature.

"Thanks."

She grabbed a bottle of water Glimmer held out, drinking about half of it before pouring the rest on her head. Looking up, she noticed Catra was staring.

"I'm hot, okay?" She justified her water wastage, grabbing her gym towel and undoing her hair out of the ponytail.

"You sure look it."

Adora rolled her eyes at the dry tone, scrunching her wet hair with the towel.

"When's soccer happening?"

"In about two hours."

Adora was glad her game was in the morning. Not only was that her best time of the day, but it assured she wasn't restless and nervous for longer than necessary.

"You're really good."

Adora watched the boy approach her, holding out a hand to shake her own. She took it hesitantly, deciding that maybe this student was alright. The others had turned their faces away the moment they lost.

"Thanks, you're pretty good yourself."

The boy smiled in excitement.

"You think?"

Adora slowly nodded, eyes darting to her friends before returning back on the boy's face. He seemed...different from the others. While other students were glassy and stand offish, he seemed more open and outgoing.

"Yeah."

"Thanks! I'm Warran."

"Nice to meet ya, I'm Adora."

She smiled at him, glad that not everyone in that school were mindless clones. Her eyes scanned passed Warran to spot Mr Prime watching their interaction. Her skin prickling again, she nodded her head towards the door, non-verbally suggesting they leave the Basketball stadium.

"Are you a Junior?"

"Yup."

"Cool, us too."

Adora spoke for herself, Catra, Bow and Glimmer, her friend group being awfully silent. She made awkward small talk, asking questions around Basketball while also trying to find out why Warran was still talking to them. She didn't mind that much, he seemed nice enough, but what was his ulterior motive for speaking with them? Surely he wasn't just interested in being friends.

"How do you find Prime Elite?"

Catra finally jumped in, giving Warran an assessing look.

"Uh, I find it-"

"Warran."

Adora was ready to slap this stalker at this point. Why the fuck was he always around her?

"Good Afternoon, Lord Prime."

Warran instantly stood to attention in front of Prime, raising a hand to his forehead as a sign of salute. Adora tried to exchange a look with her friends, but Prime was watching her too closely. Still, she felt Catra watching her for her reaction.

"I see you've found company in a few Brightmoon students?"

"Yes, sir. Apologies if I've offended you, sir, I won't occupy any more of their time if you wish me not to, sir."

Adora was finding herself very, very disturbed by the behavior Warran was exhibiting. Not even two minutes earlier was he laughing and talking casually with Adora, and the second Prime arrived he's behaving like a cadet or something.

"No need to apologize Warran, the purpose of this year's games is to assimilate the students of Brightmoon into our methods of learning."

Assimilate? As in-

"Wait a fucking minute, don't tell me you're taking over our school?"

Catra looked the exact way Adora felt. Horrified. What was even more terrifying was the slow grin that diseased the man's face, holding pure, untainted evil.

"Why who else would be so qualified to?"

Adora was definitely going to be sick. This was too much, it was enough the school was going to have a new Principle, but the fact that it was him...She couldn't even think properly, could barely form words as she just gaped.

"I look forward to getting to know you all a bit better in the forthcoming year."

Prime rested a long hand on the base of Warran's neck, and a shadow of fear (or so Adora thought) crossed the boy's face. She slid a neutral expression over her own one to hide the confusion, knowing she needed to question Warran a bit further.

Prime slowly let go, leaving the students alone in the hallway.

"No fucking way, absolutely not."

Glimmer waved her hands around like a madman, and Adora was very much inclined to join her.

"I can't believe this."

Bow raked hands through his hair, looking at the rest of them aghast. Adora just stood, mouth slightly parted in shock.

"Guys, guys, we're seeing Angella tonight, she'll explain everything, we'll get to the bottom of this."

Adora's words were strong but her breath was shaky. This seriously couldn't be happening.

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Prime's Speakers

"Out with it then!"

Glimmer was livid, and Adora made sure she stayed very far away from her, for her friend looked ready to smash glass or some other fragile object. Bow didn't even try to calm her down, and Adora didn't blame him.

"Go on, explain why the fuck he's taking over our school? You know, the school that's been in this family for generations."

Angella didn't respond or even acknowledge Glimmer at first, silently holding a hand out for them to take seats in the room. Glimmer huffed indignantly, yanking out the chair so hard Adora was sure her arm was going to fall off. Luckily, it didn't, and they all took a seat.

"There's a reason I ask both you and Catra to avoid reading the news on your phones, but today I'll make an exception."

Both girls instantly pulled out their devices, Angella had indicated that something had happened that was news-worthy.

"Yo-you lost the movie job because-"

"A sexual predator was hired."

Catra finished Glimmer's sentence, all of them looking up at Angella who hung her head.

"The man covered his past exceedingly well, and myself as well as my team didn't monitor the well-being of our actors well enough."

"It wasn't your fault this man did this. You shouldn't be held entirely responsible, your name shouldn't be dragged in the mud."

Adora looked at Angella worriedly, seeing the burden, the pressure the news was having on her. She could see it in her

stance so clearly; tense shoulders and weary eyes.

"I can't help but feel guilty, this was my movie after all. I should've paid closer attention. But now production is closed and we're facing a lawsuit. The press has called attention to the school, and now people are speculating whether I'm fit to run it, given the nature of the incident."

"People think you're a predator? You?"

Adora was at a loss for words at this news, feeling heartbroken for Angella.

"Prime's been after the school for years, and he...gave a good deal. I don't have the commitment to this school, handling a lawsuit and the financial depreciation of the business. I need to sort myself out before I jeopardize the position and reputation of Brightmoon even more."

Glimmer's anger seemed to diffuse, all of them looking down onto their laps at Angella's justification. Adora knew she was right, they all knew Angella was making the appropriate decision, but it all felt wrong.

"Isn't there any way we could save it?"

Angella gave a sad smile, tucking a strand of Glimmer's hair behind her ear.

"I wish we could, but as long as Prime's reputation is stronger than mine, I believe the media will root for him. I will focus on regaining my position, after I've stabilized the situation and sorted everything out. But I predict that I'll have to bargain a heavy deal with Horace once he has ownership."

Adora frowned, knowing everything, the entire fucking thing, was bullshit.

"That man is definitely sketchy though, how can people think he's a good Principle?"

Angella faced her, meeting Adora's argument with one of her own.

"Elite Prime has one of the highest academic excellence results in the world, only comparable to our's. His students are gifted, and his school has withstood a lot of challenges. The media is favorable towards him because he originated from a poor family, and grew successful with his own talent and work, investing that talent back into the youth with the establishment of his college. I'm not saying he's a better equipped principle than me, but my family was wealthy before my birth, and the media already believes I'm not deserving of my credentials."

Adora furrowed her eyebrows, suddenly despising the media for the damage they've done. Angella sighed softly, looking away momentarily.

"I want there to be solution, but there isn't one at this point in time. I truly am sorry."

_____

"We need to talk with Warran."

"What?"

Adora looked over at Glimmer in alarm, it'd taken them about an hour to finally rid themselves of the boy only a day prior. The only reason he left was because a purple haired lady (Entrapta, Adora guessed her name was), recruited him to help her build an EKS, whatever the hell that was.

"Warran. That creep's hiding something, and I want to expose him."

Adora glanced over her head at Bow, who's eyes widened in his own surprise. Glimmer's voice was unyielding, as was her expression.

"Alright, let's find Warran I guess."

Bow responded, the group heading into the cafeteria just in time for dinner. Thankfully (but sadly), Warran sat alone at a table, his silver blonde hair recognizable as soon as they walked in.

"Evening, Warran."

Catra slid into the seat next to him, while Glimmer and Bow took the opposite. Adora went on the other side of the boy, smiling at him. She did a quick check to ensure Prime was in fact eating in the staff cafeteria, rather than lurking around the student one.

"Oh, good evening! "

He looked excited to see them, making Adora feel a bit bad that they were solely using him for information.

"Listen Warran, I really like you."

Catra was the master manipulator out of all of them, and the most charming, so she was appointed as interrogator.

"You do?"

Catra leaned forward and nodded with such sincerity even Adora was almost fooled.

"I do. You're different from everyone else at your school."

"I am."

Warran looked down, as if ashamed.

"But that doesn't mean you should be an outcast, not when you're so unique."

"You're right."

Warran slowly nodded with a mumble at Catra, who mimicked his body language expertly.

"Of course I am."

"But no one from my school likes me. I try to be nice to them, but they've named me 'Wrong.' You know, like wrong in the head?"

"That's so awful of them, you don't deserve that. You're not wrong, they are."

"Exactly!"

"They're the ones acting horribly, aren't they?"

"Yes, yes! They're the ones that conform."

Adora met Glimmer's eyes, knowing the pause from Catra meant she'd picked something up.

"Conforming only eliminates individuality, doesn't it, Warran?"

She tilted her head, unable to break eye contact with him.

"It does, that's the whole purpose behind the speakers. I hate the speakers."

Warran shook his head in fear, causing Adora to become slightly alarmed.

"What do the speakers say Warran?"

Warran didn't respond, as if frozen. Catra answered by gently touching his forearm, tilting her head down slightly.

"You can trust me, I'm your friend, we all are."

Warran glanced around at all of them, everyone plastering comforting smiles to put him at ease.

"They never go off, never. The speakers, they...they tell us things. They tell us of the supremacy of Lord Prime, of his great feats."

"What else do they do Warran? Let it out."

Catra's voice was soothing, her thumb rubbing softly against Warran's arm.

"I-I can't. It's too much, Catra, I can't."

Adora was becoming increasingly concerned with Warran's well being. The boy was almost shivering, his breath rapid as if in a state of panic. Adora knew they were beginning to attract attention, and Catra knew too for she met Adora's eyes.

Should I push?

Adora slightly shook her head, finding herself morally unable to put Warran in more distress than he already was. Catra gave him a hug, the small group exchanging a silent conversation through their eyes over his shoulder.

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"Guys, I think we found some deep shit."

Catra exhaled as she closed the door behind them. They hadn't dared discuss Warran's information in the hallway, not when Prime Elite students crawled past them every two seconds, operating as if robots. It was strange, Adora noticed they called each other "brother," rather than their actual names.

"I'd ask Scorpia about it, but she and the other staff don't live on campus. They probably don't hear whatever these speakers are saying, or what the dean faculty are doing when monitoring the students."

Catra paced up and down the room as Adora slumped on the bed, looking towards Glimmer.

"Even if what Warran says is true, how do we prove it? No one is going to believe him over Prime, we need concrete evidence."

"Like what?"

Catra finally sat down, resting her head on Adora's shoulder. Adora tried to swallow the swarm of butterflies in her stomach, telling herself now was not the time for gay panic.

"And will it be bad enough to get Mom out of press trouble?"

Glimmer bit her lip worriedly, clasping her hands on top of her head.

"We could break into the school? Set up cameras and-"

"They have the best security team in the world, it's like President Protection level security. We'd only end up building a worse rep for the school, they'll frame it as 'Angella's Delinquents Commit Crime at Prime Elite!'"

Glimmer spread her hands out to elaborate, altering the pitch of her voice as she read out the headline.

"I mean, I could actually attend the school?"

Catra's voice was soft as she slowly lifted her head, facing them all in the silence that followed.

"Nope, nope, absolutely not."

"Are you out of your mind?"

"No way are we doing that."

All three of them protested simultaneously, making Catra shout over them in order to get their attention again.

"Think about it. I go to the school undercover, we set up cameras and mics in my uniform. I'll pick up everything they're doing, and bam, Prime's out, Mom's back in."

"One thing, Prime Elite is boy's only, no girls."

"Prime's wanted me to join his school for a year, ever since he saw me play last year. He sent me multiple emails offering

scholarships and shit."

"No, this is absurd."

Adora shook her head in disbelief. Catra's choice or not, she wasn't going into that madhouse.

"Listen, it's either we go with my idea, or we all find out what the fuck he's doing when he becomes our Principle next year."

Flat silence followed, Adora beginning to realize they were running out of options.

"I'll come with you. He seemed obsessed with me too."

"Absolutely not."

"I'm not letting you go unless I come with."

"Adora. No."

Adora met Catra's steel gaze with one of her own.

"I'm coming with you Catra, no discussion. We either do this together or we don't at all."

Catra pursed her lips, looking to Bow and Glimmer who decidedly stayed out of it. She slowly turned back towards Adora, her hardness cracking.

"Fine. We'll both go and get traumatized then."

"Perfect!"

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Eager

"You two want to do an exchange? In the middle of the year?"

Adora nodded vigorously with Catra as Angella scanned the two of them with assessing eyes.

"What are you up to now?"

"Nothing, Mom. We just want to experience life at another prestigious boarding school."

Angella raised an eyebrow, about to comment something when Prime interrupted her.

"I think it's a splendid idea."

He clasped his hands on the table, a grin opening on his long face.

"I would prefer-"

"Nonsense Ms Brightmoon. The two girls will be leaving with my school the moment the games are done, we'll organize the paperwork right now."

Adora was becoming a bit concerned with how eager Prime was, pulling out a laptop from his briefcase to print out the documents.

"Don't worry, we'll be back in time for next semester. It's just an exchange."

Angella was silent but held eye contact with Catra, as if trying to figure out what the two of them were planning. But Adora and Catra stayed perfectly stoic, having agreed not to even look at each other during the meeting. Angella could sniff out lies like a dog, they weren't risking anything.

"I suppose if Horace approves."

She turned to him, Adora noting the glance that held distaste. She felt a bit bad, knowing Angella was resentful with letting them go to his school, but it seemed to be the only viable option. Go to the madhouse, get evidence of what happens in the madhouse, report the madman, and come back safe...Can't be too hard, right?

"Oh wait, hold on. Your records list a number of Brightmoon extra-curriculers, there's no way you girls will be able to complete these on another campus."

Oh shit, Adora hadn't even thought of that. How can she play basketball and be in the play while at Prime Elite? Catra had it worse, being the Head Organizer for the fashion show as well.

"What nonsense. Adora can join Elite's Basketball team, and I'll give you a small traveling expense to perform both your duties at Brightmoon once a fortnight."

"Now that's awfully expensive Horace. You'd need to expend on a jet or helicopter almost every week."

Angella seemed relieved, but Prime waved her worries off with the flick of a hand.

"Anything to gain these gems as a pair of assets to my collection."

Hearing those words made it very difficult for Adora not to turn towards the door and sprint down the hallway right at that moment.

"Then I guess it's settled."

Angella clasped her hands on the table, nodding at the girls with tight lips and a dull expression. She was obviously reluctant to let them go, but she didn't seem to have much of a choice in the matter, given Prime and the girls were favorable towards the exchange.

"I hope you two are content with your decision, because there's no undoing it now. You've locked the idea in his brain," Angella

murmured to them as they walked out the room, a hand on each of their backs guiding them out the door. Adora exhaled audibly as the door closed behind them, slowly turning towards Catra.

"Holy fuck, we're going to Prime Elite."

Adora nodded slowly, letting Catra's words sink into her mind. She hadn't even consulted Shadow Weaver on the exchange, but considering Prime Elite's reputation, she doubted she'd disapprove.

"Let's go tell the others, we have work to do."

Adora nodded down the hallway, Catra following her down the broad corridors.

"We'll need to bug the uniforms, set up the cameras, pack-"

"Adora, chill. Bow and Glimmer are already working on it."

"What, they are?"

"Duh. What do you think they were doing during this meeting?"

Adora wasn't sure actually, but it was a bit presumptuous to already start working on the uniforms when they hadn't even gotten confirmation that they were accepted into the school yet.

"We have two weeks to get a plan together."

Adora unlocked the dorm, opening it for Catra to go inside before herself.

"How's the tech coming along?"

Catra called out to Bow and Glimmer, who lay sprawled on her bed amongst various cords and cables. Bow had his tongue stuck out in concentration, Glimmer holding two cables for him.

"I'm afraid I'll be requiring your sewing expertise."

Catra groaned, rolling her head back as she lounged in Glimmer's desk chair.

"Why must I be so useful? I've been cracking my head open sewing for my fifty million other projects, and now I have to sew cameras in as well?"

Catra rested the back of her palm against her forehead in mock exhaustion. Glimmer interrupted her pity party with a pillow to the stomach.

"Ow!"

Catra flung the thing back at her, causing Bow and Adora to laugh at the interaction.

"You're gonna pay for that Sparkles!"

Glimmer squealed, as if only just realizing the gravity of what she'd done. Adora meanwhile examined the uniforms Bow and Glimmer had been working on.

"I am definitely gonna get this dirty."

The soft silver white material was too fine for the likes of school life. Not a shade of black covered it, just accents and dashes of both grey and lime green. It was quite garish, if Adora was being honest. Seemed somewhat artificial and robotic.

"Are you sure you two actually want to do this?"

Bow called out to the fighting sisters, who slowly dropped their pillows to the floor. Catra's eyes met Adora's, her cheeks flushed and chest rising rapidly from the pillow fight with Glimmer.

"Oh, I'm sure."

Adora broke their eye contact, turning to Bow who asked the question.

"Me too."

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The following two weeks slid through their fingers like silk. Adora tried her best to enjoy the games, but she couldn't shake the feeling of Prime watching her, as if a predator stalking their prey. She'd even had a nightmare about him, about his pale white claws and menacing grin hunting her down. It wasn't pleasant, and it didn't help that Shadow Weaver was overjoyed to hear the news. Albeit, she wasn't thrilled when she learnt Catra was joining Adora, making the girl feel as if maybe she should've left out that key detail to keep things steady between them. Already she was having doubts over whether she actually wanted to be the President of the nation, she was beginning to think that maybe her interests lay elsewhere from politics...

But there wasn't time to mull over that now. It was something she'd have to spend a bit more time considering before breaking the news to Shadow Weaver.

"Adora, you don't look so good. Are you alright?"

Glimmer looked over at her in concern, Adora staring blankly at the textbook she was supposed to be reading. She shook herself out of whatever daze she was in, taking her ponytail out in an attempt to stop the pounding in her mind.

"Yeah, no, I'm fine."

She hadn't told Glimmer about her sleepless nights, didn't want to stress her friend out or disturb her own sleep. Besides, if she woke Glimmer up in the middle of the night, she'd likely kill Adora herself, or tell her to not attend Prime Elite, and that certainly wasn't an option.

"Are you sure? You look...pale."

"I'm fine, Glimmer!"

Adora didn't mean to lash out a bit, but she couldn't help it. Glimmer retreated slightly, but didn't leave Adora's desk.

"I just have a bit on my mind, that's all."

The neon silver uniform lay hung up on her door, glaring Adora in the eye.

"I can't help but think that I should be the one doing this."

Adora flicked her head to Glimmer, about to argue when Glimmer spoke again.

"Like it's my legacy, my family that's on the line. I'm a coward for putting you through that."

"Glimmer, for all we know Prime Elite just plays rhythmic songs through their speakers to boost motivation or something. I doubt I'll be seriously harmed during this, you're not a coward."

It didn't matter that Adora barely believed herself, that she was getting visions in her sleep. She wasn't going to tell Glimmer that.

"I just, I don't know."

She covered her face in her hands, causing Adora to stand up and give her a hug. She needed one herself too.

"Thanks," Glimmer said as she released her, wiping a few loose tears from her cheeks. Adora gave a half smile, her head feeling marginally lighter.

"Anytime."

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A Lavish Prison Cell

"Oh god."

Adora thought she was going to be sick. She'd already woken up at five in the morning and gone for a run without eating a single bite of food. How on earth could she feel nauseous if she hadn't even eaten anything?

"It's fine, it's fine, we're gonna be fine."

Adora gave Catra a meek smile, adjusting her hat and pulling on her favorite letterman jacket. Catra smiled, Adora catching it and smiling back.

"What?"

"Nothing, you just...look good, in the jacket I mean."

Is she blushing?

"That's all you, this thing is better quality than anything I've ever bought from a store."

"Wait 'till you see the piece I'm working on for the fashion show. That'll show you quality."

The pair travelled through the courtyard, arriving with the rest of Prime Elite students where they waited for the busses to arrive.

"What time is the flight, again?"

"I think ten. Did you get your timetable?"

"Yup."

Catra pulled out her phone, scrolling through before showing it to Adora. Grabbing out her own device, Adora compared the two.

"That bastard didn't put us in any of the same classes."

"What? No way."

Catra grabbed the phones from Adora, while the blonde felt red hot rage towards the disgusting boney faced man. He did this on purpose, of course he did. She and Catra shared multiple subjects together, there was no way they didn't end up in any of the same classes.

"I'm going to fucking-"

"Morning, ladies."

Catra was cut off by the snake-like voice that crept up behind them.

"Are you excited for your visit?"

Adora wasn't sure how to respond, but luckily Catra did.

"Yeah, elated." Her flat tone seemed to reach deaf ears, for Prime grinned widely.

"Wonderful. Your rooms are all organized and ready."

"Who are our roommates?"

Adora assumed Catra and her would be in the same room, but after the timetable fiasco, she wasn't so sure anymore.

"Oh, no one. My school prides itself on everyone becoming their own...entity, so segregation is key."

Adora glanced at Catra, who was giving her a major 'what the actual fuck?' look.

"And in addition to that, we have the funds to allocate full sized dorms to each and every individual, rather than cramp them in tight, claustrophobic rooms."

Adora knew he was criticizing Brightmoon for it's dorm style, and she wanted to bash his head into the ground more than anything,

but she restrained. Settling for narrowing her eyes at the man, she looked towards Catra.

"If you don't mind Mr. Prime, we have some last minute duties to take care of before we leave."

"Of course. Just one thing Ms Grey."

"Yes?"

"You'll address me as Lord Prime for the duration of your stay, and in reciprocal, your fellow classmates, or 'brothers' I would say, will address you as their sister. Both of you, actually."

Adora was genuinely speechless. She just stood there in absolute confusion as the man walked away, Catra matching her expression precisely.

"You know, I'm beginning to think this was a stupid idea."

"Beginning?"

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"Well, this is it then."

Adora looked around her dorm, chucking her hat on the bed and messing up her hair with her fingers while walking around.

"It's not...bad?"

Catra being optimistic? Did they poison the air in here or something?

"I guess. It's nothing compared to Brightmoon, sort of a lavish prison cell."

Catra snorted, Adora slowly circling back to face her. Looking at Catra was a whole lot more pleasant than empty grey walls.

"That's honestly the best way to put it. A lavish prison cell."

Adora rolled in the rest of her belongings from the hallway, dumping it on the cheap metal bed.

"Let's go check out your room."

Catra pulled out her keys, nodding as Adora locked her cell.

"Great, I'm on the basement floor."

She passed the keychain to Adora, who took a look.

"Might not get a window, considering the likes of this place," she murmured under her breath. At least they weren't too far apart, Adora was only three floors above. The elevator doors opened to reveal two bright faces smiling at them, though Adora considered their expressions more creepy than welcoming. Who the hell just smiles silently in an elevator, like big fat flashy smiles? Absolutely no one.

"Good evening, Sisters."

They passed by them, barely waiting for a response.

"This school is really fucking weird."

Catra's whisper was audible only for Adora, who instantly spotted the cameras in the elevator. Sure, that could be for security purposes, but Adora wasn't so trusting to believe Prime would respect people's privacy. He makes his students call him Lord, he probably has a god complex or something.

"Agreed," Adora whispered back, pushing the button. The doors slid open shortly after, to not a very nice looking floor. Adora's own hallway wasn't magnificent or anything, but this looked hardly livable. Torn plaster walls, smudged green carpets, and harsh white lights. Not only that but the music that played through the speakers, it was hauntingly magnetic. Adora couldn't help but tune in, missing Catra's statement.

"Sorry, I missed you."

She turned towards her friend, asking her to repeat whatever she'd said.

"I...forgot."

Catra seemed surprised at herself, Adora shaking herself to remember why they were here again.

Right, Catra's room.

Catra's door was the last one in the hallway, which was oddly short, and closest to the speaker. The music was garishly loud near her door, protruding most of Adora's thoughts.

Something seemed off. She felt fuzzy, but she couldn't exactly identify whatever it was. Catra fumbled with the key for a few seconds before finally opening the door, nearly forgetting to bring her stuff in with her until Adora noticed it. She quickly shut the door behind them, though it did little to drown out the hallway music. Thin plaster walls weren't very useful.

"You seem to have a better interior than me, at least."

Adora looked around, thinking Catra had it a lot better than she did. A flatscreen television, lounge and proper bedroom. Wondering around, Adora even realized she had her own personal hot tub, located in the spacious bathroom. No windows, but who needed scenery when all this was there?

"You good?"

Adora noticed Catra rubbing her temples, leaning back onto the couch.

"Yeah, I'm fine. Just anxious."

Adora sighed, sitting next to her.

"Same. What if it's all for nothing and Prime's just your average creepy man?"

"We'll have to take the risk to find out."

Adora nodded, trying to ignore that impending music. Maybe she could drown it out with some of her own. Prime had taken their phones away, but Glimmer managed to get them a spare to communicate with herself and Bow while in the school. It wasn't Adora's own playlist, but hopefully the music was good enough to block out the hallway tune.

"Hey, you're tense."

Adora looked at her quizzically.

"Uh, yeah? So are you. In fact, you're hardly tense."

"Not true."

"I've never seen you stressed, never."

Adora looked her dead in the eye, suddenly realizing that her own words were completely true. Catra had seen her in every emotion possible, but Adora had only seen reflections of Catra.

"No one has really. But I'm a human, of course I get stressed."

Adora could see it now. Not in Catra's nonchalant voice, or her ever vibrant eyes, but in her body language. Shoulders raised for protection, hands wrapped around her arms in a self hug. Adora tended to do the same when she felt anxious in public. Smiling softly, she got up and walked around the couch.

"What are you doing?"

"You're stressed," was Adora's only explanation.

"Can I?"

She rested her palms at the base of Catra's neck, waiting for a response.

"As long as you don't tickle me, I could really use a massage right now."

Adora smiled, the temptation to now tickle Catra sliding into her thoughts. But she didn't, deciding a tickle fest wasn't what either of them needed right now. She carefully worked herself into a pattern, moving her thumbs in slow circles while pushing down slightly with pressure. Catra's shoulders slowly relaxed as Adora put a slight more pressure, causing the softest groan to slip Catra's lips. Adora's cheeks heated at the sound, glad she'd opted not to look down at Catra's face. After several minutes, a clawed hand rested on Adora's, the bright eyes fluttering to meet Adora's flustered face.

"Your turn."

"N-NO, I mean I'm good. Yeah, no, no need for that, I'm not tense. Nope, not tense at all, I'm completely fine-"

"Adora, shut up."

Catra patted the couch seat, standing up to swap places with Adora. Gulping nervously, Adora slowly sat down on the chair as if she was facing her death. In a way, she kind of was.

Death by Catra's sexiness.

Yep, that was probably the best way to describe it. Catra chuckled lowly, soft yet strong hands placing themselves on Adora's shoulders.

"You're tenser than Melog when strangers come over."

"No I'm not!"

Adora really needed to just stay quiet, her nerves were running too high from the proximity. Mint and musk invaded the air, time seeming to move in slow motion as Catra's hands kneaded through Adora's muscles.

"Wow, Blondie, you're really wound up huh?"

Adora didn't bother responding, settling into the sensation. While the massage did wonders for her shoulders, it didn't aid the creeping headache in the back of her head. Adora squinted in slight pain, only to have the ache dulled by hands stroking her hair. Eyes flying open, she met Catra's who just smirked.

"Helping the headache?"

How on Earth did she know? Adora's lips parted slightly in surprise before she nodded, careful not the disturb the gentle claws raking through her hair.

"Thought so."

Catra slowly moved back down again to Adora's neck, before pausing slightly.

"Did she give you these?"

Her voice was deadly silent, causing Adora to reach back and run her fingers over the faded scars. Time had done them well.

"It's fine, I deserved them."

"You didn't." Catra's remark was almost instant, making Adora look up at her. The look in her eyes, fiercely wild with a killing calm, it nearly scared her. The gaze softened when Catra noticed Adora looking at her, and before she knew it arms were wrapped around her, completely enveloping her in Catra's scent. Adora froze before slowly relaxing into the embrace.

"Thank you. For coming with me."

Catra's murmur was soft and quiet, but it did wonders to Adora's heart.

"You think I'd let you do this alone?"

She resisted turning to face her, knowing that would be far too much for her to handle right now.

"I wanted to."

"That's because you do everything alone."

Catra laughed softly before slowly righting herself. Adora instantly missed the scent, the familiar yet foreign comfort that accompanied it.

"I'm independant, what can I say?"

Adora smiled, turning the music on her phone off. She didn't want the battery to completely die, especially when the only chargers around were for the ancient school issued laptops Prime had given them. But that meant the droning hallway music invaded their ears once more.

"Come on, we better head up for dinner."

As nice as Catra's room was, something felt very odd. She grabbed her friend's hand, leading them out the door with caution.

"Warran?"

Adora stopped abruptly in the door frame, Catra bumping into her.

"Oh, hi guys. Why're you here?"

He had a dopey look about him, but Adora couldn't really understand why or how. He was probably just tired from the flight or something.

"We're doing an exchange."

Adora knew they probably should put on the uniforms Glimmer gave them so her and Bow could track and monitor Catra and Adora, but she couldn't be bothered right now. It felt like such an

effort to go upstairs, change into new clothes just to change back into her pajamas later in the evening. She'd start anew tomorrow.

"Exciting, I'll give you guys a tour after dinner."

Warran smiled at them, Adora thankful it wasn't as creepy as the elevator guys. And he wasn't calling them sisters, which was a bonus.

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A Steady Weight

Tiredness bore down on Adora like a weight. She wasn't sure if it was the grey mess of spaghetti, or the weariness of the whole day, but all she felt like doing was sleeping.

"It's only eight, why am I so tired?"

She asked the question to herself, but to her surprise, Catra responded.

"Same. It's probably from traveling or something, I doubt Prime's poisoning the air."

She chuckled at her own joke, Adora smiling lightly. Of course it wasn't Prime who was doing this to her, it was her own damn body's fault for being so fatigued.

"Hey, do you mind if I sleep with you tonight?"

That question broke through Adora's thoughts in a clean slice, instantly waking the girl up.

"Me?"

She averted Catra's gaze, fearful she was going to heat up like a bright red tomato if she did.

"Yeah, I just...I don't know, feel lonely?"

Adora nodded vigorously with understanding.

"The beds are a bit small, and we'll have to dodge the hallway cameras, but sure."

Catra smiled shyly and Adora quickly looked away, drumming her fingers against her knees while her head spun.

Could she like me?

Don't be ridiculous.

But what if she did?

Then you'd ignore it. School comes first.

Adora's eyes glazed over, all too consumed by the argument occurring in her head.

Before she knew it she'd finished her food, Warran smiling worriedly at them before departing over to his own quarters for the night.

"Are you guys involved?"

He whispered over to Adora as she gave him a hug, who nearly shrieked at the unreachable thought of Catra being involved with her. It was obvious Adora had feelings for her, who wouldn't? Catra was funny, breathtaking, charming, witty, extraordinary, beautiful, intelligent-

"Adora?"

Warran blinked at her, and Adora quickly shook off her thoughts to answer him.

"No, nope, just friends."

Her heart ached only slightly to say that, but it quickly brushed over.

"Well, I guess that's good then. Dating is forbidden."

Warran shrugged in disappointment, making Adora wonder if perhaps Warran liked someone in the school.

"Yeah, it is good."

Her mind spun, too occupied with both conspiracies of Warran and thoughts about Catra.

"Come on Adora, we got to dodge the rush before everyone head back to their rooms."

Nodding in assent, Adora let Catra grab her hand, trying to ignore the sparks that ran across her skin at the touch.

God, it was dangerous, the effect she had on her by merely grabbing her wrist.

"How do we do this?"

Catra paused at the corner, finally turning to Adora. She hadn't let go of her hand, the two clasping onto each other for several moments before they both realized and quickly let go, twin blushes blooming on their cheeks.

"I doubt Prime watches the videos himself, so whoever is monitoring it won't realize we've both gone into the same room if we've done it separately."

Adora kept her eyes trained on their surroundings, watchful for anyone walking up and down the corridors. The music had been playing all night, soft like an enchanting lullaby but loud enough to be heard over the chatter of the school. Nothing of actual interest was played over the speaker as of yet, though, which probably wasn't the best outcome. Adora wanted to find some dirt on Prime so Angella could maintain her position.

"Here's the plan. I go down first, open the door, and close it."

"How will I get in then?"

"Listen for a sec, will you? I'll put the keys on the ground, just enough for you to grab it and open the door. Just wait a few minutes in between, the cameras don't have a good enough view of the door numbers so they definitely won't know we're in the same room."

Catra decidedly nodded, Adora giving her one last look before coolly strolling down the hallway, as nonchalant as could be.

Sliding the key in without a second glance, Adora slipped into the room, a fresh wave of air hitting her face. Thoughts continued to assail her mind at lightning pace, whirling around her like a never-ending storm.

A glance over at the bed, such a narrow, small bed, sent her into some kind of frenzy. She could barely handle Catra touching her wrist, how on earth could she share a bed with her and actually get any sleep? Nope, that definitely wouldn't do, she'd just have to sleep on the couch. That way, her thoughts wouldn't get distracted.

.....Well they would, Catra was still in her room, but her quality of rest wouldn't be as debilitated if they didn't share a sleeping space.

Making the final decision, Adora heard the soft click of the door as Catra walked in. Adora barely heard her footsteps, which was impressive considering she was literally waiting for her.

"You alright? You look a bit pale."

Catra leaned a bit closer, as if to examine the state of Adora's health, but Adora quickly leaned back. She didn't want to run the risk of Catra realizing just how nervous she was.

"I'm fine, just nervous for tomorrow."

That excuse seemed to cover it up, for Catra nodded in understanding.

"I was thinking I could sleep on the couch? That bed looks a bit small for the both of us."

Adora chuckled nervously, scratching the back of her neck awkwardly as Catra looked back at the bed.

"Oh, okay. Yeah, I guess you're right."

Was she...disappointed?

Of course not, get a grip Adora.

"Can I use your shower?"

Catra stretched, the skin of her midriff slightly exposed as she reached upwards. Adora diverted her attention to the suddenly fascinating blank grey wall.

"Yep, no problem, I'll use it after you."

She didn't miss Catra's smirk though, one that taunted her before she pulled open Adora's suitcase. Raising an accusatory eyebrow, Adora crossed her arms over her chest.

"Sorry, I'm gonna need to borrow something."

Adora didn't mind in the slightest, gesturing for Catra to go ahead while she redid the bland sheets with her own fresh blue ones. A little color ought to liven up the room a bit.

_____

The pain of staying awake was delightful torture.

One part of Adora despised the inability to close her eyes and retrieve the rest she'd been craving throughout the day, but another part of her, a more prominent part, rather enjoyed the flips in her stomach and buzz in her mind. Sure, the music was still playing in the back of her head like a rhythmic drum, dulling her senses as if it was a lullaby, but the thoughts of Catra flittered around too. Those didn't seem to calm down for even a second, no matter how tired Adora was.

She rolled over, the lumpy couch folding beneath her as she squinted at her phone. Turning the brightness down, she checked the time and saw a few texts come in from Glimmer. Internally swearing, she caught a look at the low battery signal. This goddammit emergency phone was their only viable source of communication, and the only way Adora actually knew the time.

It was strangely disturbing, the lack of clocks around the campus. She put the phone back down, only after sending Glimmer a quick text to inform them that they were fine. It was already one o'clock, and she had to be up at five for her run, that is if she could even leave this fucking prison yard to exercise.

With an indignant huff, Adora glanced over to the sleeping form of Catra, quickly turning away when she reminded herself how weird it is to watch someone sleep. It was too hot in here, the air congealed despite the crisp weather. Fanning herself in a struggle to cool down, Adora kicked the sheets off herself, tossing around the couch to try and get somewhat comfortable. It was so late she might as well give up and just stay awake, maybe she could just go for her run now. Actually contemplating it for a few minutes, Adora was on the verge of getting out of the bed to exert some of the pent up energy she had stored inside of her.

What halted her chaotic thoughts was a sound.

Was that a glitch in the music or something?

Adora decided to push it aside, believing it to just be a figment of imagination. But then it happened again. A whimper, soft but desperate. Moving as quietly as possible, Adora crept over to investigate. It felt a bit wrong, on some level, to pry, but she couldn't help herself. Moving over to Catra laying in the bed, Adora watched her for a few moments to discover if she was making the noise. To her lack of surprise, Adora was correct. Catra scrunched up her face tight, Adora catching sight of her hands fisted in the sheets. Something rose inside of her, a need to protect was the best way to surmise it, but she knew it went deeper. At least she thought it did. Seeing Catra squirm, as if in pain, Adora felt the need to wake her up. A flash of her own nightmares projected in her mind, and she instantly knew Catra would prefer to be awoken then suffer the consequences of a poor quality sleep tomorrow.

"Catra?"

She perched herself on the end of the bed, leaning over to whisper gently. The girl didn't respond, too caught up in whatever was happening in her subconscious. Beginning to worry, Adora shook her again in hopes that she wouldn't go into sleep paralysis or something like that.

"Catra, Catra, wake up!"

She whisper shouted, nudging and prodding at her friend to try and wake her up, but the girl's eyes held shut and Adora was starting to deduce that Catra was incorporating the shakes as part of her nightmare. A tear ran down her cheek, light cast on it by the moonlight from the window. Adora nearly broke, desperate to get any reaction from her.

"Catra, you have to wake up."

Her words were so hushed that she wasn't sure she was even speaking to Catra, her mind running in circles about what to do. She'd read somewhere in Glimmer's Psychology textbook that waking someone up while they're in a vivid dream was dangerous, but she was getting desperate. Messed up in all her thoughts, Adora almost missed the gasp she frantically heard.

"A-Ad-No-Wait!"

She was out of breath, Adora stunned by the wide eyed stare she gave her. Her arms were numb, Catra's nails digging hard enough in her skin to draw blood. But Adora didn't care, not one bit. Catra could slice open her entire arm and Adora wouldn't give a single fuck, because the look on her face...the look of complete and raw terror, was enough to pull Adora away from all her scattered thoughts.

"Catra," she breathed, the pair of them just staring at each other while Adora tried to determine what to say.

"Ar-are you alright?"

Catra's lips parted slightly, as if about to say something when she couldn't speak. She just shook her hand instead, still clutching to Adora's arms. Wordlessly, Adora opened up the bed sheets and slid in next to her, wrapping a hand around Catra's shoulder. The girl froze for a moment before slowly settling in, wrapping a hand around Adora's torso. Adora was able to hear both her own heart pounding and Catra's among the soft music in the hallway.

"It's alright, I have them too."

Catra raised herself up slightly, staring wide-eyed at Adora as if lost for words. Her expression, so blank and clueless, was foreign for Catra. Adora was used to the witty remarks, quick responses and glares, that this was completely uncharted territory. Worse was that she couldn't even read her friend's eyes. They shone with the light dancing off of them, but beyond looking beautiful they told Adora nothing of Catra's emotional state. The silence stretched for eons before Adora decided she'd just have to offer the comfort of a body rather than a listening ear. At least the bed was a lot comfier than the lumpy couch.

"About Shadow Weaver?"

Catra's question snapped Adora out of a haze, her voice so quite she'd almost missed it.

"Her...And Hordak too."

Reliving her worst memories through vivid dreams wasn't as fun as it sounded, but it was better than experiencing the real deal. She loved Shadow Weaver, how could she not? The woman had practically raised her, been there when her legitimate mother fled, when her father washed his hands of her. Other than Catra, Shadow Weaver was the only reliable source of refuge for Adora, and the only parental figure to depend on. Still, she never interfered with Hordak's punishments, and never hesitated to apply them herself, of course that was behind closed doors and shut windows.

"Mine are about him."

Adora peered down, catching a tear escape Catra's eye before she quickly wiped it off. Adora quickly looked back up, knowing she hated when people saw her cry or breakdown, and wanted to give Catra the same space she would've liked.

"Hordak?"

"No, they used to be, but lately..."

She paused, as if waiting for some confirmation of something. Adora remained silent, letting Catra take her time to continue.

"Horace Prime. His voice, that bathtub...I don't know, I barely remember."

Her words were muffled, disorientated while she adjusted herself. Adora felt the comforting weight of a hand wrap around her stomach, and her grip on Catra tightened slightly.

She couldn't provide clarification for Catra's nightmare, but she could be a steady weight beside her.

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Questions

The day was confusing to say the most. Adora wasn't really sure to make of it. Catra was out of the bed before she'd even woken up, which was surprising to say the least (even if Adora skipped her morning run for a lie in).

English was fair enough, boring with a lack of class discussion, but nothing particularly distressing. The only uneasiness that had been nagging in the back of Adora's mind was the weird music that haunted her every minute. It was quite literally a permanent fixture of the school. The sound was rarely disrupted, only when the bell rang.

"Adora, may I speak with you?"

Oh fuck, this is the only thing that could make her day even worse. A so called 'casual' conversation with Lord Prime himself.

"Of course."

Ever the people pleaser, Adora couldn't help but be polite, feeling uneasy tension roil through her stomach as Prime led her towards his office. The room was vast, and so spotless the light reflected off every surface. It was strange, the lack of personalization. One would expect portraits, a scattered desk, maybe a few personal belongings. But none of that was there, the table completely bare and polished to the maximum. She nervously perched herself on the edge of the chair, aware of every move and step Prime took as he took the office chair in front of her. Clasping his hands together, elbows bent on the desk, he met her fierce gaze. Adora could fidget, squirm and mentally scream, but she wouldn't drop eye contact with this man. That was only a relinquishment of power, of dominance.

"I'm an inquisitive man, Adora. Why did you and Catra spend the night together?"

Adora blinked, a bit aghast at the bluntness of the question. She almost stetted for words, for a response to pull herself out of this.

You haven't angered me, just curious is all."

None of your fucking business.

Adora slapped the thought away before it projected from her mouth.

"Catra was feeling tense, first night here and all. And I was a bit lonely, that's all."

She shrugged for an act of casualness, tried to diffuse the seriousness of the fact that they'd broken Prime's precious little rules on their first night at the school.

Why am I the only one being questioned anyway?

"If that's the case, I can arrange for you and Catra to have accompanying rooms. There's no need for law breaking here."

Law breaking? Was he seriously calling school rules a law?

"That's not necessary, we won't do it again."

Prime pursed his lips, both of them understanding that Adora only spoke lies in his presence.

"Very well. I'll let you off with a warning."

Adora slowly released a held breath, giving a 'teacher' smile, as she liked to call it, before leaving the disgusting man's presence.

Who was even monitoring the cameras to notice that?

———————

"What the fuck?"

"I know."

Adora picked at the food, her appetite dissolving as she recalled the conversation with Prime for Catra. A weight suddenly rested on her shoulder, Adora tensing at the suddenness of the affectionate gesture.

"Sorry you had to deal with that by yourself."

Adora refrained from shrugging, wanting to keep Catra's head on her shoulder for as long as possible.

"It's fine. You can do the next round," she joked. In reality, she hoped Catra never had to face that fucker's face alone.

Catra offered a meek smile, knowing the lightness of Adora's words were only a mask to shade the seriousness of the situation. Still, she went along with it, winking and spitting out a quip of her own.

"What do you have next?"

"P.E, then Math. You?"

Catra momentarily paused and took a look at her timetable.

"Textiles and English. I'll meet you at lunch?"

Adora nodded, straightening her loosened tie while smirking at the one dangling far too loosely around Catra's neck.

"You know they're gonna catch you for that, right?"

Catra wrapped her fingers around the ends, her rings glinting off the light. Adora rolled her eyes at the snarky attitude, as impervious to the 'laws' as any feral criminal.

"And? What is Prime gonna do about it?"

"I wouldn't push your luck."

Adora caught onto the stares that passed them by, strangers inquiring into why not only two girls were enrolled at their school,

but also the fact that they actually spoke to each other for more than a few brief awkward moments.

"Come on, let's go. Our brothers are getting suspicious."

Catra smiled at the tone, but she looked ready to argue for whatever reason. Something prevented her from lashing out. Her mouth opened and closed for a second before she resigned herself to Adora, waving a quick farewell before leaving.

Walking into the classroom wasn't strange, Adora had suffered through Chemistry and English, but those had a different energy to Phys Ed.

"Warran?"

The cheesy boy flashed a grin at her, making Adora feel a bit more comfortable. He might be a bit odd, but he wasn't dangerous, at least better than the rest of the students in the school.

"Who's our teacher?"

Warran was prepared to respond when a woman strolled through the doors, decked in a jet black baseball cap and gym clothes.

Scorpia.

She recalled the woman's penetrating presence, her watchful gaze of Catra and Adora in the dining room, monitoring them without interference. She was intimidating...At least she looked it; with magnetic eyes, white blonde hair, and a figure which dominated the entire room. Adora resisted the urge to gulp in front of her, beginning to get the sense that Scorpia wasn't much fond of her friendship with Catra.

"Mornin' kiddos!"

Well that was unexpected. Gaping around at the rest of the room, Adora looked at the wide grin etched on Scorpia's face, her arms

open and welcoming.

"Morning, Scorps!"

Warran enthusiastically responded, beaming up at their teacher without a single fear hidden in his eyes. It was different from every other lesson, where students were mostly subdued and conditioned into monotone, robotic responses. This...Well, this was as close as it'd get to being back at home.

"Have I got a lesson planned for you."

She threw a playful wink in their general direction, a moment of flash surprise flying into her gaze as she met Adora's eyes.

"Adora?"

She sounded neither ecstatic or disappointed, an even middle ground in her tone. Adora met the coal black eyes, unsure if they were welcome or closed off.

"Yes?"

Scorpia looked skeptical for a second, but the expression shifted so fast Adora wondered if she hallucinated.

"Okay team, get into pairs."

The rest of the class didn't nearly match Scorpia's energy, shuffling around with bland looks on plastered on their faces for the purpose of fulfilling a teacher's commands. Adora shrugged at Warran, a silent question. He responded with the shake of his head, grinning widely at her.

"Hey, Adora, can I have a quick chat? I need to get you on my roll."

She held up a tablet, the bright screen unreadable due to the glare.

"Sure."

Scorpia headed towards the gym doors, making Adora feel only the tiniest bit nervous. Why on earth did they have to leave the gymnasium for a 'quick chat?'

"What's wrong?"

"Oh, nothing, just that you're friends with Catra."

Her stare latched onto Adora as she folded her arms in front of her chest. Adora blinked in confusion, this was about Catra?

"Sorry, what?"

She looked at her, dumbfounded at the odd protectiveness.

"Listen, kid. I've been Catra's therapist for five years, I've heard a lot about you. Like a lot."

Well that was intriguing. Curious slicing through her, Adora felt the urge to prod into what Catra had said about her over the years.

"Nope, don't even think about it."

"About what?"

"Anything and everything she says is strictly confidential. Even if I was permitted to tell you, I wouldn't. I. Don't. Like. You."

The emphasis on her words hit Adora like a knife to her chest.

"I haven't even done anything to you."

"It's not me I'm talking about."

The layers in her voice, the shade of darkness that smothered her expression, it only made Adora feel uneasy.

"Catra and I are friends now Scorpia."

"Not according to her last ses-"

Scorpia halted, the silence ringing in the air like a clear bell, almost a signal to Adora.

"She-she's still mad?"

Her thoughts darted back to the previous night, the closeness as they grasped each other in the dark, the only remnants of security in these hollow walls. To think that it was a lie, that Catra was pretending...No, that couldn't be true. Those moments, feelings, everything...It was impossible for it to be a lie, to be a mask of friendship while resentment and revenge simmered under.

"Speak to her yourself."

Scorpia was brisk, as if afraid of letting another piece of precious intel slip. Adora had heard enough though, excusing herself from the pathetic teacher's presence. Scorpia was more of an enemy than a mentor at the moment. Adora didn't fancy being targeted for the entirety of the lesson. A better use of her time was rumination, perhaps even searching for Catra or finding some goddammit way to fix the mess of their friendship she hadn't even realized was there. An overwhelming sense of guilt overcame her, quite suddenly that she had to actually pause and hold the hard cement wall beside her.

She'd been 'friends' with Catra, helping her with homework, getting drunk together, messing around in Textiles, and yet...she hadn't realized the underlying tension. Hadn't realized the bitterness Scorpia seemed to have detected that she hadn't. Guilt got stirred in with anger; hot and blistering.

Sure Adora might've been blind to whatever issues Catra may have had with her, but why not bring it up? Why let it boil beneath the surface of their short-lived friendship?

She had questions, so many. They came at her like bullets, in such rapid succession her hands shook as she reached for her keys. One thing was sure though, the only clear objective in her mind..

Find her.

_____

Her.

The click of the door did nothing to soothe the uneasiness that burned in Adora's stomach. She wrapped her arms around herself, trying her hardest to be nonchalant while also protecting herself.

From what? Catra won't hurt you.

She moved to unhinge herself from the awkward position when her gaze caught on her emergency contact phone, the bright screen lighting up with a message from...Shadow Weaver? How had she even gotten the number. She skimmed it, momentarily diverting her attention from the sound of footsteps entering the room.

"I had the worst fucking day possible, you won't believe it-"

Her voice cut off but Adora barely even realized, deleting the message and turning it off before Catra's attention followed towards the message.

"Hey, Adora? You there?"

Her arms instinctively coiled around again, her grip tightening on the skin of her waist, the stiff fabric of the collared shirt.

"Yeah, yeah."

Her voice was too mechanic, she couldn't lie to save her life. Catra played along though, jumping on the couch while loosening her tie.

"God they're uptight. Lucky me, I had Prime as a sub for English."

This was perhaps the only piece of information Adora could distract herself from. She turned over to catch Catra rolling her eyes, leaning back on the couch. She looked hot, Adora couldn't help but marvel at the magnificent structure of her face for a moment, practically built like an ancient goddess or-

Zip it. Not the time.

Adora straightened herself, tuning in to hear the rest of Catra's complaints.

"You'd think principles would just sit up in their office and pretend to do work, but the bastard actually elected to be one of the teachers. He barely even taught actually, spent half the bloody lesson making me button up my shirt, confiscating my expensive custom made jewelry, doing all sorts of atrocious things to my uniform. I mean, honestly, the ugly thing is bad enough. I made it barely tolerable with my touch ups and the dickhead had to go and fuck it up!"

She was in such a state of pure annoyance she actually ripped the tie off her neck, scrunching it up like a measly wad of paper and shooting it across the room to bounce harmlessly off the wall. She made a huff of indignance, a petulant child fed up with the laws of a school.

"So, what's wrong with you then?"

Catra swiveled around to examine her, the eyes scanning over Adora's draping limbs on the sofa.

"Me? I'm fine, fine, completely cool."

She gritted her teeth at the words, in a slight struggle to get them out with a smile. Catra narrowed her eyes, leaning closer. Her face was so close to Adora's that the awkward girl moved back slightly, but Catra kept coming until she was backed into the pointy end of the couch. Adora looked at her wide eyed, flicking between the gold and blue in a bit of a frenzy.

"You are truly the worst liar on this planet."

Catra leaned back in a fit of laughter, Adora blinking as she shook off the butterflies having a party in her stomach.

How could she do that, and so easily too? Just lean forward and stare at her and suddenly Adora became a slushy pile of goo, pliable to Catra's will.

"Go on then, spit it out. Who pissed you off so much that you're sitting like that?"

Catra smirked as if holding back a snicker, waiting for a response.

"You, actually."

The clarity of her voice brought about an immense shock to Adora herself, who watched the shift in expression on Catra's face.

"Me? What did I do now?"

Catra looked around the room frantically, like a celebrity who'd just been dumped on some reality dating show.

"Lie, that's what."

Adora unknotted herself from the tight stance, meeting Catra's eyes with steely blue ones.

"Scorpia seemed to slip up. Said you mentioned being mad at me in your last session."

Catra looked perplexed, but their entire friendship over the past few months seemed to be false if she had underlying resentment the entire time.

"But I never said that, is that exactly what she said? Wait, why was she even-You know what, never mind, just answer the question."

"She said we aren't friends according to your last session."

Scorpia's voice rang true and strong in Adora's mind, which it should considering she'd been sitting here listening to it for the past four hours.

A light dusting of pink spread across Catra's cheeks. Embarrassment, perhaps? At the fact that Adora had uncovered her true feelings? Her heart sunk as she thought of Catra plotting some plan against her and her friends. Was that the whole reason behind befriending them in the first place?

"Adora, that's not wha-"

"Then what is it? Huh?"

Adora stood up, needing to exert her restless energy in some way. She paced in the small room, hands held up over her head as it spun replaying once cherished memories from their time together. Getting drunk in the snow, strip poker, setting glitter bombs in Glimmer's room, making a treasure hunt out of Bow's arrows...Was it all just an act then? A ploy?

"Of course I don't hate you, dummy."

The softness in both her voice and the words were enough to send Adora careening off the edge.

"Then what? Why aren't we friends, or at least, why don't you consider us friends?"

The thought of Scorpia lying suddenly flew across her mind of dizzying thoughts and conspiracies. But Catra didn't even deny her own words, only defended them.

Catra moved from the couch, approaching Adora who now rested against the table. At least the cement stone counter was sturdy and ice-cold, able to absorb some of the heat that washed through her.

"I don't get you, I hate it."

Something fractured in Catra's piercing gaze but it quickly mended itself, hardening to chips of jeweled ice.

"Right. So you get to go around accusing me of lying about our friendship off of one silly thing Scorpia said, but when I try to defend myself you hate me?"

Gone was the gentle voice, of someone striving to calm Adora. But she preferred this, opted for a screaming match over being consoled like a difficult child.

"I hate not knowing you, of feeling like you're some maze I'm constantly lost in. Did I ever say I hate you? No, but you definitely hate me. Scorpia made it clear enough."

"Where the actual fuck did you get that idea? Scorpia was ambiguous. Think, Adora, why would I spend months around you if I hated you?"

Adora shrugged, pressing further back into the counter for a solid weight. It soothed her skin like a balm, let rational thoughts pass back through her; even if it was for a second or so.

"I don't know, I just said I don't get you. That includes your motives."

Adora began to peel herself off the stone, trying to find a fresh spot to lean against when Catra caged her in, two clawed hands barring Adora against the counter.

"I don't hate you, get that into your thick skull."

Adora flared slightly at the insult but didn't let it brush against her too much.

"So, what did Scorpia mean then, when she said that to me?"

Even if Catra didn't hate her there was something behind Scorpia's words, a cryptic message Adora felt the urge to decode.

"Figure it out yourself."

Catra began raising her arms, ready to retreat. But Adora had wasted half a day thinking about that question, she wasn't about to spend a whole night doing it again. Seizing the opportunity, she grabbed Catra's wrist and spun her against the table. Now she had the upper hand, was able to mimic whatever power stance Catra had assumed before.

"No. You're telling me. Right now."

Some weird influx of confidence overcame her, driving the words from her tongue.

The pair locked eyes, Adora finding it difficult to control her heartbeat as the silence stretched on for a few long moments.

"You want to know why I don't think of you as a friend? Really?"

Catra's voice was quiet, but not soft. In fact it was sharp, each word spelled out clear for Adora to hear.

"Yes."

Adora's heartbeat was so loud she feared she'd miss Catra's response. She took a few long breaths in a measly attempt to steady it.

"Because you're more."

Out of all the words Adora expected to hear, this wasn't it. She blinked, watching Catra's eyes stay fixed on her own, on her face to judge the expression.

"You're funny, and you're gorgeous, and you're so fucking dumb that I-"

The blush intensified, and Adora felt her own spread across her cheeks. Catra gave a soft chuckle, finally looking down for a second.

"I just-"

Adora didn't let her finish, closing the words with her lips on Catra's. She melted into the moment, arms swiftly moving from the stone edge to Catra's neck and hair.

It was breathless, and a complete blur of musk and mint and emotions and-

Her.

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Can You Keep A Secret?

Catra moved down to Adora's neck, skimming the sensitive skin with her teeth as she went. Chills spread over Adora's body at the touch, but the moment Catra's lips left her own she was finally able to think coherent thoughts, rather than a jumble of words and the taste of her.

"Wai-"

Adora didn't get much of a motivation to finish the word, distracted by Catra working her way down when she instantly paused. She didn't hesitate to pull away, looking up expectantly at Adora. It took a few seconds for her thought process to return back to a functioning state, but she finally managed. She drifted back to the reality, where she and Catra were kissing-

Oh god. She and Catra were kissing.

She skimmed over that minute detail, skipping over to the fact that this was occurring in a cement cell, with cameras in every public area possible.

"Prime?" She breathed softly, the word a curse in this context.

"Don't say his name when you look like...that."

Adora didn't fail to miss Catra's eyes flick from her eyes to her lips, feeling her face heat up by the intensity of the gaze.

The heat was unbearable, the closeness of their bodies. Catra leaned, teasing Adora with a smirk painted on her lips. She reached out, fingers expertly weaving themselves through Adora's tie, which was very much wrapped around her neck.

"Prime can fuck off. There's only one thing going through my mind right now," she taunted, looking up at Adora with flecks of mischief in her eyes.

"Oh yeah? And what's that?"

The courage wasn't beaten out of Adora by Catra's look, in fact she felt emboldened by it.

"You."

Still she didn't close the gap between them, it was like a game. Adora hummed in contentment as their lips grazed across each others, almost touching but not quite there.

Slowly, almost tentatively, Catra undid the knot at the base of Adora's neck, slipping the silky rope off before working her way to the back of Adora's head. Her fingers rested there for a moment, Adora's stomach jolting with every delicate touch Catra placed on her.

Finally, Adora closed her lips on Catra's, her patience running out. She felt the smile against her lips, Catra pleased she'd won their little game. Adora smirked back, feeling her hair fall down her shoulders as Catra got rid of the hair tie.

"This is dangerous."

Adora couldn't help but glance around the room, though her concentration didn't last very long when Catra pulled her closer, their bodies completely against one another.

"Does it look like I care?"

It didn't, it really didn't. Adora returned to Catra's presence, engulfing herself in the scent and warmth of her.

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What eventually interrupted them wasn't Adora's nagging conscious or the looming threat of stone walls, but rather a FaceTime call from Glimmer.

Catra picked up the phone after about fifteen missed calls and was ready to fling it across the room when Adora quickly pried it off of her.

"Heyyy Glimmer, what's up?"

Catra gave her a look, standing behind the phone in front of Adora so Glimmer wasn't able to see her yet.

"Where's Catra?"

"Catra? She's right here."

It was only when Adora said those words when she realized why Catra was adamant on Glimmer not seeing them. It was bad enough that her own hair was loose and shirt rumpled, but Catra too was....suspicious, to say the least.

"Well can I see her?"

"Yep, uh huh."

Adora nodded, making eye contact with Catra over the top of the phone.

"You're acting odd, did Prime brainwash you already or something?"

Glimmer leaned into the camera, a comical sight. Her face looked around as if she was trying to glean every inch of the room, even thought she really couldn't.

"Why're you all red?"

Bow was suddenly in the frame too, leaning on top of Glimmer's head to observe Adora.

"I'm not!"

Cool it, you're too defensive.

Adora resisted the urge to make a face at Catra, remembering that Glimmer could still see her.

Why don't we just tell them?

Catra's eyes widened in alarm, making Adora feel just a bit hurt. Was Catra ashamed of liking her or something? But Catra instantly saw the hurt in Adora's eyes, waving her arms about to clarify.

Tell them, and it goes everywhere.

Understanding dawned on Adora. If Glimmer and Bow knew, then the news would go everywhere, even if they asked them to stay quiet. They'd probably yell, someone would hear them, the press would get to it, Prime would get to it, and all privacy was gone. Adora would prefer they stayed silent for a bit too, considering she had Shadow Weaver to deal with. She would likely pull Adora out of the school if she knew what was going on, and that was the last thing Adora wanted.

Okay.

"What on earth are you doing?"

Fuck.

She'd been looking up too long, communicating with Catra silently.

"Nothing, there's just camera's everywhere, so Catra and I can't really talk properly."

It was only partly a lie, but Adora still couldn't shake off the guilt when Glimmer nodded in understanding.

"So? Anything?"

Bow tackled his girlfriend for the phone, practically bawling her just to get it. Adora chuckled at the pair, squabbling over the phone like a few toddlers or something.

"He plays weird music, and he's one of Catra's teachers, but nothing too out of the ordinary. We're coming back next weekend to rehearse for DT's play, though, so maybe we'll have more info then."

Glimmer nodded, she seemed a bit disappointed but didn't say anything discouraging.

"At least you're not dead, though you are acting funny."

Bow squinted his eyes at her, leaning closer to the camera.

"Are you surreee you're not some Prime bot? What if he replaced you with-"

"I'm fine, Bow!"

Adora laughed at his expression, and that seemed to put both Glimmer and Bow at ease.

"You better have something juicy by next week though. Break into his office or something."

Glimmer lightly scolded her, but she was right. They were here to act as spies rather than students. Rules didn't apply at the moment, even if Adora was conditioned to follow them. She put down the phone, raising her eyebrows at Catra.

"They are right, you know. It's not point being here if we aren't going to do something useful."

Catra waved it off, settling down on the couch.

"It's been like two days. We know the teachers are clueless, so we just have to somehow get to Prime. We've still got a few weeks before the exchange ends, it's fine."

Adora sighed, sitting down beside her.

"Yeah, I know. We'll figure it out."

She smiled shyly at her, holding the stare for a second longer than necessary.

"I guess we're a secret now, huh?"

Adora leaned back, keeping her eyes steadily focussed on Catra.

"I think it's cool," Catra shrugged, but she held a sly smile on her face.

Adora wanted to lean in, to continue what Glimmer had interrupted, but then her stare snagged on the discarded bag of books on the table. She'd missed all her lessons, and hadn't done any homework. Groaning, she picked herself up and walked over to the table, a weight on her head.

"What are you doing?"

Adora sifted through her materials, digging out Chemistry.

"Homework?"

Catra walked around the couch towards the bench, propping herself on it while crossing her legs.

"Guess my name is homework then."

Adora smirked, unable to take her eyes off Catra in front of her.

No, homework Adora. Homework.

"I recall you having a fashion show to finish?"

She'd caught her in the perfect spot, Catra's snarky expression melting off her face.

"Fuck you," she spat out jokingly.

"I mean, if you want too so badly..." Adora winked. Catra rolled her eyes, throwing a pillow at her half-heartedly while grabbing her sketchbook.

Fittings

Adora wasn't so happy to roll into Math, considering she had a double period of it, and it was eight o'clock in the morning. She'd found herself to be incredibly sluggish while at Prime Elite, unmotivated to get out of bed earlier than what was necessary.

"Ah, another day of science!"

"Isn't this Math?"

Adora looked up at the teacher, having being seated in the front row. She was eccentric, to say the least. Looking at her certainly wasn't boring, but she hardly looked like a math teacher. If Adora had merely seen her on campus she'd think her to be an art teacher or something.

After all, what Math professor had long purple extensions, a matching jumpsuit, and brightly colored eyes?

"Oh, right, Math. The backbone to science!"

Was she just planning on relating everything back to science?

"Alright, my little Newtons, solve this theorem for me."

She pinned something up on the board, something that confused the fuck out of Adora. Everyone just looked at her blankly, except for Warran, who was scribbling something down on his tablet.

"This?"

Adora knew Warran was quite intelligent, a bit of a dork really. But she'd grown to like him, found him to be the only good one in this entire school.

Besides, he was in most of her classes, so it was good to actually have a friend, or at least something close to it

"Yes! Correct!"

She wrote up the answer on the board and pulled out some odd recorder contraption.

"Eight fourteen, Mr. Warran."

She mumbled something else to herself, probably the answer Warran had just shown her, and typed into her laptop.

"Excellent Warran, this will be perfect for my new invention."

She smiled gleefully to herself, knotting up her hair as she sat down.

"Uh, what are we doing?"

Adora leaned across to whisper to Warran after a few minutes, when Entrapta hadn't given them any instructions.

"Math is mostly self driven, she doesn't really teach us anything, but she wrote the textbook, so I guess that's something?"

Adora nodded slowly, thankful she was half-decent at the subject. She'd be able to figure it out if the textbook was explained well enough.

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"How's the designs coming along?"

Adora talked around her apple, something to distract herself from the harsh sour flavor. The food around here didn't hold a candle to Brightmoon's cafeteria, even simple fruit couldn't be ripened in this dingy sewer school.

"They're coming, at least there's that. I think I've got your piece ready, I just need you to get fitted. We might have to do that this afternoon?"

The fact that Catra had made a piece of art inspired by her still swept Adora off her feet sometimes. She nodded slowly, wondering what the clothing would actually look like, and if it would even suit her.

"Also, look what I found."

Catra slid something under the table, her eyes meaningfully meeting Adora's.

Be careful. There are eyes everywhere.

The sign that bolded Prime Sees All! Glared at her from behind Catra's eyes. She purposefully dodged it, returning back to the plate of disappointing food.

"The teachers here are odd."

Adora was mostly thinking of Entrapta, with her genius mind and candy colored hair, but the eyebrow Catra raised at her provoked thoughts of Scorpia. Catra didn't seem defensive or accusing at the statement, but more than curious.

"Mostly Entrapta," Adora amended. Netossa didn't prefer being called a name of 'respect' as most superiors did, but Entrapta didn't really act like much of a teacher at all. There was quite a clear distinction that one couldn't fail to ignore between the two teachers.

"Haven't had Math today, we had a sub yesterday."

Adora nodded, picking at the green pasta on her plate. There was a funny looking meat on it, one which she opted to avoid.

"How's Scorpia?"

Adora opened her mouth to say the first thing that flew into her mind, but thought better of it. Catra watched her carefully, almost suspiciously as Adora decided on a careful selection of words.

"Enthusiastic, assertive, protective- Not sure what else to say."

She shrugged with careful nonchalance, dodging the bullets from Catra's eyes.

Sugar coated opinions and chosen words. Adora wasn't a fan of Scorpia, and they both knew it. Catra just didn't know why.

"Blondie." While her tone was stern, like a mother reprimanding her child, the affectionate nickname softened the accusation.

"Alright, so maybe she did threaten me only slightly in gym, and then made me ditch my classes for the rest of the day. So what?"

Talking fast was usually the best approach to dodge confrontation, but Catra caught every word that slipped from Adora's lips. She always did.

"I'll chat to her."

The grit in her voice, something smooth with an underlying edge. It frightened Adora and it wasn't even directed at her.

"Nah, don't stress. I don't want to make drama."

Her words fell on deaf ears, for Catra's eyes were frosted over with unyielding fierceness.

Woah, all that for me?

Adora swallowed her awe, readying herself for the doom of Chemistry.

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The pair didn't get around to the scheduled fitting that day, their classes moving at such a rapid pace they received fresh bouts of homework every night. Adora found herself longing for home, even more so when she attended her first Basketball team meeting.

"Thank fuck we're going back tomorrow. Even if it's just for a few hours."

Adora groaned into the stiff mattress, every muscle aching with the reps Scorpia made her do the previous day.

"Tell me about it."

The sound of a chair scraping back alerted Adora of Catra's presence, especially imminent as she leaned over her on the bed. Adora flipped over to her back, craving her touch like medicine to a forgotten wound. She didn't realize how much she missed the closeness of Catra, the contact, until the opportunity presented itself right in front of her. Catra held back, waiting for the slight nod of Adora's head to reach out and gently tuck her hair behind her ear. Adora relished the moment, the feeling of her hand brushing across her cheek briefly. They had barely gotten a moment together since their kiss, only stolen glances and weary smiles. This school tired them out, drained them of whatever energy they had left after a hard day's work.

At least Prime wasn't so prominent anymore, locked away in his office and out of Adora's head.

"I missed you."

Catra purred softly at the words, continuing to brush out Adora's hair in soft movements.

"I missed you too, Princess."

The old nickname fell to Adora's ears like golden ash, a forgotten memory reawakened. That night was interesting to say the least, when a drunk Catra had called Adora a 'princess' for no good reason. Somehow, the name made a reappearance now.

"Then what are you doing so far away?"

Adora raised a brow, almost daring Catra to come closer. Catra accepted the challenge, unexpectedly swinging a leg over Adora's

torso on the bed. Her eyes widened slightly, not only at the gesture but the feeling. Ripples running across her skin, causing chills to rise and her stomach to flip as if she was doing a handstand. Not an unwelcome feeling, but certainly foreign...well, not that foreign.

"Better?"

Something in Adora caused her to maintain an even tone.

"Not quite," she lost track of her voice when Catra leaned forward, loose hair acting as a curtain as she pushed Adora's shoulders down.

"Now?"

She rested her forehead against Adora's, eyes fluttering shut as they breathed each other in. Adora hummed in contentment, unable to even form a coherent thought, let alone speech. Catra grazed her lips across Adora's, barely, before lifting herself up. The light of the room flooded Adora's vision with a glare, as she stared up at Catra, still comfortably nestled on her hips.

"Come back."

It was more of an order than a request, but Catra only smirked.

"We have work to do first. "

She smirked, jumping back down onto the ground and holding a hand out to Adora who frowned.

"Unfair. You can't tease me and then expect me to do homework."

Catra laughed slightly, grabbing a slip of fabric from her desk.

"Not homework."

She held up the fabric, swinging it around with that effortless grace she did everything with.

"What are we doing then?"

Adora couldn't hide her own smirk, Catra strolling around to come behind her. That same, now familiar, addicting scent invaded Adora again. A scent that was always welcome. Warm hands slid along her shoulders, Catra leaning forward and wrapping her arms around Adora in a slight hug before pulling back ever so slightly. The fabric wrapped along Adora's vision, covering her eyes before being secured at the back of her head.

"Oh?"

Catra moved back, but her hands remained placed on Adora's shoulders, guiding her to a spot in the room.

"Don't be so dirty minded, I'm simply fitting you."

"I wasn't thinking of anything dirty," Adora smiled slyly at the silence that followed, though it was not awkward or uncomfortably. She could practically hear Catra's eye roll.

"I'm taking your top off."

Adora froze slightly the minute the words entered the atmosphere, and felt Catra's instant pause too. The way she'd said it wasn't inappropriate or sexual in any way, rather quite matter-of-fact and diligent. Adora knew this was the best way for it to work, measuring with clothes on produced errors. And she couldn't do the fitting alone, she wasn't even allowed a glimpse at the artifact she would be adorning.

"Right, um...yes."

Catra still didn't move to undress Adora, causing the blonde to wonder what she was doing. Finally, after a minute long silence (yes, Adora counted), Catra cleared her throat.

"Um, okay."

Did she sound...nervous? The thought of Catra being nervous was too weird for Adora to even consider. But what else could it be, what else could stall a silence for a whole fucking minute?

"You can do it yourself, I mean, take off your clothes?..."

Her voice trailed off, Adora jolting slightly.

"I don't think I could blindfolded. Just end up making a mess of myself then."

She laughed half-heartedly, holding her arms out wide. Trusting Catra felt like second nature, like slipping into an old and worn, yet comfortable set of pajamas. A strange thought, but eerily accurate. Adora strongly felt that once you face the brunt of the world with someone, the forces of society, it was very difficult to detach from them. Catra could dangle her on the edge of a cliff and Adora would still trust her.

That peace didn't leave her when Catra's hands skimmed her hips, gently tugging the white shirt out of her pants.

No, she didn't feel the slightest bit uncomfortable when Catra's deft fingers loosened the buttons on her shirt, when the chill of the room hit Adora's skin like a burn. Nor was she tense when she stepped out of her pants and into a gauzy-feeling, soft material. But the comfort of Catra's presence and the knowledge that they were alone did nothing to soothe the knot in her stomach, or the heat scalding her insides.

Adora took a few deep breaths to calm her body down, ignoring the soft touch of fingers that guided her hand into a sleeve, the smooth but unexpected movement of Catra weaving her fingers through Adora's hair and pinning it with a clip. Though Catra placed an icy cold piece around Adora's neck, an item hard and unyielding, it did nothing to sharpen Adora's senses...or the unravelling thoughts spinning in her mind. An uneasy disappointment filled her when she realized it was over, when

Catra slipped the blindfold off her head and she blinked into the harsh fluorescence of the room.

"Don't look!"

Catra's voice was tense with alarm as Adora blinked into focus.

"Then why'd you take the blindfold off?"

It took about everything in her not to inspect herself, though she may have caught a hint of black in her peripheral vision.

"I need to see if it matches," Catra replied simply. She moved forward, her eyes narrowing in stern concentration. Adora found the expression endearing, the way her forehead crinkled slightly as she stepped forward, her eyes solely fixed on the art draped around Adora's body. She moved around, as swift as water, pinning various sections together or adjusting bits and pieces. Finally she moved back, and stared intensely at Adora's eyes.

Not so much in, it wasn't much of a romantic or longing gaze. More so she was examining them, as you might the color of a stone. Adora didn't dare break the trance she was in, was even scared to blink as it might distract her.

"Not quite," Catra murmured, mostly to herself. Adora didn't bother asking, just obeyed. That examining gaze moved down slightly, too Adora's collarbone. Catra tutted to herself, shaking her head and writing something in her tablet.

"Now I have to get another bloody shipment in, fucking fantastic."

"Sorry?" Adora felt weirdly obliged to apologize, did she not suit the piece or something? Catra was startled by her voice, as if she'd genuinely forgotten Adora was a person and not some frozen mannequin to inspect.

"Don't be," she muttered, still a bit distracted.

"You're perfect, it's the goddamn accessories that don't reach my standards."

The way she said the words so offhandedly sent Adora into a bit of a tizzy.

You're perfect.

She pushed the airy, light sensation she'd just felt aside, trying not to grin like an idiot.

———————

Home

Seeing DT's face was like returning to limbo after a trip from hell. Not quite sunny or celebratory as being sent to heaven, but still a reprieve from worse off conditions. Adora was itching to hug Bow and Glimmer, but first she had to finish this rehearsal.

"I need more darling. Look starved for power."

Her patience was slipping by the moment. Due to rehearsals now only occurring once a fortnight, they lasted an agonizingly long two hours, rather than the regular sixty minutes. Adora didn't hate playing the leading role, and enjoyed adopting a Shakespearean tongue, but after being away from her friends for so long, rehearsing became a chore.

"Have you even gone over the script?"

DT looked down at their own copy, rolling their eyes in disdain. Adora smiled shyly, shrugging her shoulders.

"Sorry," she said sheepishly. DT didn't even meet her half-apologetic eyes, calling out for Catra.

"Kitten, you've been in the bathroom for fifteen minutes, get your ratty ass out here!"

Double Trouble didn't look mad or annoyed with the distracted pair, rather more concerned. They narrowed their eyes, watching as neither one of the girls met the other's eyes.

"Okay ladies, let's run it from the top."

Adora hesitantly ran through her lines, knowing there must be a reason behind why DT chose this specific scene. Catra followed suit, but neither one of them looked at the other for more than a few seconds. It felt too real, too comfortable, to act like a pair of lovers.

Less like acting and more like broadcasting their infatuation with each other for an audience to marvel at.

"Yeah, no. Stop."

DT waved their hands at them, shaking their head with tightly pursed lips.

"What the actual fuck was that?"

Adora tried not to gape, stammering in defense.

"We were just-"

"Nup."

"But it-"

"Nope, nope, not it."

DT refused to take their half-assed excuses, closing their eyes and pinching the bridge of their nose.

"We are two months out from the show and my leading pair have lost their sparkle."

DT muttered quietly to themselves, Adora briefly exchanging a concerned glance with Catra.

"Sorry, sparkle?"

DT sighed, as if exasperated by questions from a toddler. Adora was mildly offended, but didn't say anything.

"Yes, don't act like we couldn't all feel the tension between you two from a mile away."

Adora actually wanted to debate on that. The only 'tension' between them was anger and bitter resentment built up from years of distance and a lack of communication. She felt like mentioning this slight fact, arguing her case with the annoyed

director, which she hadn't felt like doing in quite a while. But still she let it go, catching a glimpse of the stress written on DT's face. Being a student director, handling auditions and getting schoolwork done couldn't be easy. Adora felt a bit guilty then, for not doing her due diligence to the play and instead treating it like some silly side project.

"We'll do it again. This time with the sparkle, I promise."

She fueled as much earnest as she could into her expression, all of it genuine when she noticed the hope scrawled out in DT's expression.

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"Fucking finally!"

A puff of glitter was showered over Adora and Catra's heads before the pair were tackled by an energized ball of cotton candy and a sharp point was digging in at Adora's side.

"Ow, Bow!"

She detached herself from the group hug, rubbing her ribs while eyeing the shiny set of arrows on Bow's hip.

"Archery season?"

Bow grinned, like a lantern lit up inside of him.

"Yup!"

Adora couldn't help but grin back at him, feeling herself get warmer and friendlier the more time she spent at her home. It was almost as if her mind was defrosting.

"You look paler, is he feeding you right?"

Glimmer stared Adora down, scanning her from head to toe before moving on to Catra.

"We're fine, Glim. Prime seems to be normal. A prison of a school, but nothing illegal, right?"

She turned to Catra for confirmation, who automatically nodded her head.

"Adora's right, Prime's actually not that bad. I wouldn't hate having him as a principal next year."

Catra shrugged pulling out her phone and lying on Adora's bed. Glimmer stared at her, mouth agape.

"What the fuck has he done to you?"

Within a moment she was over Catra, pulling at her eyelids to stare directly at her eyes.

"Bow, c'mere, look at her. Her eyes are all funny."

Adora hung back, watching the scene with slight amusement. Catra swatted her sister away, but Glimmer didn't move in the slightest.

"They look normal to me."

"No, no, no. This one is a bit duller, and they're both looking a bit mossy."

Adora snorted at the interesting word, 'mossy.'

"Adora will notice, come look."

Adora reluctantly walked over, looking at a very frustrated Catra who was forced into stillness.

"Look alright to me."

She shrugged, not wanting to look at her girlfriend (were they girlfriends? Adora assumed they were girlfriends) for too long in the company of others. One longing glance, one subtle smile, and the news would be all over the place. For now, just for now, Adora

preferred to keep it private, and Catra had agreed. Glimmer just frowned at her, crossing her arms over while Catra let out a slightly strained chuckle.

"I'm fine guys. Let's not waste the ninety minutes we have left here."

Adora agreed, holding out her arms for Catra to latch onto. She gratefully hung on, Adora having to gently let go when there arms lay clasped around each other for slightly longer than necessary. If Bow and Glimmer noticed, they didn't say anything.

"So, what've you found then?"

Adora chewed on her lips, memories of the school shifting around in her mind.

"Not much, to be honest. The food tastes horrible, like crunchy? And the circulation there is horrible, probably due to the lack of windows. The place is really just a cement block with technology wired through it."

Catra nodded along, watching Adora intently.

"Yeah, and he doesn't really like us socializing? It's a bit odd, especially when he's nosey about what we're doing all the time."

"How does he have the time and energy to monitor what every student is doing all the time?"

Bow's question caused the pair of girls to glance at each other for a second.

"Actually, it's more or less just us. He's kinda obsessed with you."

Adora nodded at Catra with a bit of curiosity. It was true, whenever he was around them he barely took his stare off Catra, and he was conveniently her English teacher. Catra seemed a bit distant after the observation was made, as if lost in thought.

"Oh, another thing!"

This was the message that had been crawling through Adora's head since the minute she entered the goddamn school.

"He plays weird music."

Bow was instantly intrigued by this, his dark eyes rapidly meeting Adora's.

"Music?"

"Yeah, 24/7 actually. I've never heard it turned off."

Bow seemed pensive, his tongue sticking out slightly as he looked upwards for a few seconds.

"Could you get me a sample of it? A good recording?"

Adora nodded, a spark of hope zapping her into motion.

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Full Circle

The following week was tiresome, both girls so busy and occupied in their agendas they barely spent any time at all together. The only constant that remained (a rather recent constant), was Catra slipping into the folds of Adora's sheets late into the night. Some nights Adora didn't even feel her presence, only woke to a pair of bright eyes looking up at her or the feeling of Catra against her. Adora didn't mind of course, in fact rather welcomed the company, but Catra moved in silence, and never lingered for too long.

"Stay, it's the weekend," Adora asked of her on Sunday morning. Catra twisted her neck around, not quite facing Adora to meet her eyes, but enough for the blonde to read her face.

"Can't, I'm meeting Prime."

This nearly jolted Adora out of the bed completely, her torso flying upright to gawk at Catra.

"Why on earth are you-"

"Getting some extra help. He's a good teacher, 'kay?"

Her tone softened slightly as Adora stared, stricken. She'd gotten that recording of the music for Bow, but hadn't had the opportunity to send it to him again. Luckily they were going back home next weekend, so she can hand it over to him then. She didn't fully trust this school's mailing system.

"Since when were you besties with Prime?" Adora snorted, trying not to sound accusatory.

Still, Catra's eyes flashed, a dull green in the murky lighting. Adora narrowed it down to her own dodgy eyesight, seeing the blue and gold hue return to normal moments after. Catra chuckled lightly, but it was forced, anyone could tell.

"I gotta go."

"Will I see you later?"

Adora narrowed her eyes at the stacks of work staring at her from her desk, along with a missed call from Weaver.

"Probably not. I've got some stuff to do."

Adora was about to ask what 'stuff' in particular, when she was met with the soft click of the door shutting, the lock latching into place.

Moving methodically, distracting herself from the weird mood Catra had been in lately, Adora moved towards the bathroom. It was distracting, the green lights around the mirror that clouded her vision. She pressed her fingers against the lights, watching the green slip over her finger and back to shooting out a harmless laser beam.

She shook off the drowsiness, splashing some warm water onto her face.

Ugh, it was ten o'clock in the morning and she was still dead from the night's sleep. Mildly strange, but not really when Adora considered all the activities she was attending throughout the week. All that work was bound to wear the body down in some way.

Running through her morning routine was simple enough, until Adora had finished breakfast. The tablet and various other devices glared at her with venom, the harsh brightness causing Adora to squint slightly so she could actually read the text and interpret the questions. After a solid hour, Adora decided to take a quick break.

Unfortunately, that was also the time that Shadow Weaver decided to call her again.

"Adora!"

She crooned over the phone, Adora pinching the bridge of her nose at the dull headache in the back of her head.

"Hi." She wasn't all that bothered by her curtness, and was fairly sure Weaver wouldn't care either. The old hag was only concerned with what Adora could do for her reputation, how she could reinvent herself and reenter the law industry.

Though Adora wasn't quite sure when this realization settled in, she was pretty sure she'd understood it perfectly.

"I haven't called you in eons, how are you?"

Adora drummed her fingers against the phone absentmindedly, distantly thinking of the time that had passed since their last call. Prime Elite didn't have optimal service.

"Adora?" She ensured again, jolting Adora out of a slight trance.

"Uh, yes, sorry. It's been a while, hasn't it?"

She kept her voice light, sweet and pliable as it had been for far too long. Abiding by Shadow Weaver's law was a lot less punishing then going against that, she'd learnt that firsthand from Catra's experience with rebellion.

"It has. I intend to visit soon, in a few weeks."

Adora sat upright, focussing her attention on the haggard face behind a veil in front of her.

"You've booked a flight?"

"Of course, and accommodation is prep-"

"I appreciate the effort Shadow Weaver, I really do, but I've been super busy."

Adora blurted out excuse after excuse, anything to get out of being under her adoptive mother's scrutinizing gaze for the

entirety of two weeks. But the deadly silence that followed was a million times worse than any shouts or yells.

Silence meant thinking, silence meant planning, and worst of all; silence meant devised manipulation.

"You interrupted me."

A realisation, statement, not a question.

"N-no."

Adora cleared her throat, mentally berating herself for stuttering.

"Yes. You did."

More silence. Well, silence that surrounded the pounding of Adora's heart in her ears. It was worse than watching a horror movie with Bow and Glimmer.

"I'm flying down on the sixth, and I'm staying for the entirety of your holiday. End of discussion."

Adora felt like throwing her phone against the wall. But that would be unreasonable, surly, a childish reaction.

No, she couldn't do that. Instead, she'd offer a tight lipped smile, and grit her teeth behind her lips.

"Hey Adora, I'm back."

Catra called out into a near empty space, with a half empty mind occupying it.

"Adora?"

"Oh. Hi."

Adora still hadn't completely excused Catra for her bluntness earlier. The bitter tang of betrayal hadn't left her, even though Catra was merely visiting Prime for English help. She sighed,

rubbing her hands up and down her thighs anxiously. She shouldn't exert her annoyed energy on her, Prime was her teacher after all. What harm was there in seeing your teacher for help, especially when Adora knew Catra wanted to blitz English in her exams? Oh god, exams that were mere weeks away and which Adora hadn't even thought of before now. Shit.

"How are you feeling?"

Catra turned to face her on the couch, her face worn. Adora hoped she wasn't still getting the nightmares. She wasn't able to sleep with her every night, but she tried on most.

"Drained. You-"

Adora cut herself off as Catra moved closer, kicking her shoes off and swinging a leg over Adora's hip all in one swift movement. Adora tried not to wonder how many times before she'd done that. Instead she narrowed her attention on the feeling of Catra's legs settled over her hips, and the dark familiar scent that overwhelmed her.

"I'm feeling numb, and I'd like you to do something about it."

Catra traced a finger down Adora's neck, hooking her finger on the collar of her shirt.

God, who allowed her to do this? Adora shivered at the playful touch, the warmth of Catra against her. She didn't like this, she didn't like the control placed over her. Even if it was Catra. Adora supported Catra as she twisted their bodies, gently laying Catra down on the couch while settling above her. A giggle and a few breaths escaped both of them as Catra's head hit the soft surface, and Adora stifled it with a kiss down her neck.

"Fuck," Catra panted, legs tightening around Adora's waist. She smirked as she continued, lips never leaving the soft skin as she worked her way down.

"Feeling something now?"

Catra's groan was all the response she needed.

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The night was splendid, but Adora couldn't shake off the feeling that someone was watching her, bumps raising on the surface of her skin as she forced herself to leave Catra's room. She struggled to open that door, to take another step further away in such a dangerous space. But she had to, Prime would detect every odd movement of theirs, would find any excuse to pull Adora in for an interview. Frankly, Adora wanted to avoid Prime as much as possible. The only thing that convinced Catra to let Adora go was spending a few hours in the hot tub. Adora had helped her set it up, ignoring Catra's teases as she tried to coax her in. The water looked clean enough, though turned a bright green when the lights were flicked off. They'd just narrowed it down to lights in the tub, though Adora didn't recall seeing any. She barely took a step into her room when the sharp sound of running caused her to stop.

"Adora! Adora!"

She was hallucinating, definitely. But no, how could she? There was no way Adora's mind could fabricate the sheer terror, the alertness in Catra's voice.

A figure tumbled into her, skin hot and slightly damp as small rivers crawled their way down from the dark strands of hair.

"Catra? Catra talk to me."

Adora hid the tremors in her hands with cool-toned words. She knew firsthand that panic never helped you comfort or help someone. At least, it'd never helped her.

She gently guided her through the doorway, only taking her eyes off her's for a second to make sure no one was watching them.

"Oh my god, oh my fucking god."

Catra was squeezing Adora's hands now, tight. The girl could barely make it through the door before collapsing on the too small couch, the rough surface softly pricking Adora's legs.

None of that mattered though, not when those eyes held that much fear in them. Adora just waited, letting Catra suffocate her hands with her own, gently rubbing her thumb over the red raw skin. After a few minutes, or perhaps it was a few hours, Adora noticed a shift; slight but present. Catra's pulse gained rhythm, her skin began to cool, and her eyes lost that wide, utterly terrified spark.

"Catra?" Adora whispered, her voice so fragile she was surprised at herself.

"Hello, Adora."

The hands held tighter. Adora felt something else tighten in her stomach, something she didn't particularly enjoy.

"What happened?"

She tried to pry her fingers out, especially when Catra's grip continued to tighten. Thankfully her nails had been cut, but the rings on her fingers pushed harder into Adora's skin, like tiny needles trying to get at her.

"Him," Catra responded by way of explanation. But Adora had forgotten what she'd asked, for the pause was so long, and her fingers were losing feeling.

"What?" She breathed, very confused. Halting her work on untangling their fingers, she looked up to meet her girlfriend's eyes.

Only, they were different. Washed over with a slimy sheen of lime, and glowing strangely in the dim light of the room. Adora instinctively yelped, not only at the difference, but the expression. Catra's lips were spread into a thin smile, head tilted as if some puppet controlled with strings.

"What the fuck? Wh-what happened to you?"

Adora desperately wrenched her hands out, finally. She rubbed her skin, ignoring the red cuts on her fingers to focus on Catra.

"Come, Adora."

The girl blanched, why was she calling her as if she was some pet? And in that voice too...methodical, robotic, it made her shiver.

"No. I don't know what happened, but I'm fixing it."

Catra laughed then, her head rolling back on her neck. The sound...that's what scared Adora. Like nails on a chalkboard, knives caressing her back.

"I'm already fixed. Prime's saved me."

Adora just stared, the green in her eyes growing brighter. None of this made sense, nothing about this was logical. Slowly, with caution, Adora stood. Catra mimicked her, raising herself and watching as Adora took a step away.

"I need you to come with me Catra, I'm going to get help, and then everything will be fine again. I promise."

The last two words cracked something in her even disposition, for the green dulled a bit. But the crack was quickly resealed, and Catra clasped her hands together.

"Oh no, I can't let you do that."

Adora slowly pulled out their communal phone, turning her sound off and calling Glimmer. But the girl didn't pick up, and Catra's eyes landed on the device.

"Prime can do great things for you Adora. Forget Brightmoon, let's just stay here." The voice softened for a moment, almost genuine.

Adora shook herself out of it, slowly moving towards the door. She needed to get out of here, find some help before retrieving Catra.

"Yeah, that sounds great. Uhm, I need to run to the bathroom, so why don't you just...wait here, 'kay?"

Adora was getting closer, but Catra's intelligence didn't fade.

"Lies." She hissed. And then she morphed, leaping onto Adora without hesitation.

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Are You Freaking Out?

Adora was ready to scream, more out of the suddenness then pain, but a hand smothered her mouth, roughly. Catra straddled her, the towel dropping as her wet clothes dripped on Adora's shorts. Her head pounded, she'd must have hit it when being tackled. But pain was the least of Adora's thoughts when Catra had a manic look in her lime-green eyes, and her free hand held Adora's wrists above her head. The girl writhed in an attempt to get free, Catra leaning closer.

"You're mine, Adora. We belong together, here."

Adora just stared, wide eyed, unable to determine what happened to Catra. Was it really her speaking, or was it Prime?

Catra let go of Adora's mouth, playing with the ends of her blonde hair instead.

"Catra, please. Tell me what happened."

Adora begged, her voice just above a whisper.

"I realized the truth, I discovered the greatness of Prime."

The unabashed awe, complete reverence of that vile man...it made Adora feel sick, tears prickling her eyes.

"Let go of me."

She breathed the words softly, slowly so Catra heard every damn syllable. Something flickered across her face, and her hands shook violently as if she was fighting against something. This peaked Adora's worry, for her hands rattled against the hard wooden floor and Catra's face contorted with something akin to pain.

"I-I can't, no I won't!"

Her voice broke, not robotic but raw. Adora saw a crack of hope in that, a crack of the Catra she knew.

"Please."

She met her eyes, forced herself to stare at that perfectly controlled expression. She'd stopped struggling, but the hands slipped, if only for a second. But that was all the time Adora required.

"Hurry," her voice was glass about to break.

Adora didn't have to be told twice, only grabbing her backpack full of essentials. A banana, charger, and her Brightmoon devices. She'd gotten new ones at Prime Academy, but it was safer to leave those here. She grabbed her ID out of her packet as she ran, squashing her feet into runners and closing the door firmly behind her. She locked it, hoping that Catra wouldn't try to pursue her. The hallway was dark, lit up, but barely.

Adora sprinted, uncaring of who might be watching through the cameras, following her every movement. She reached the elevator first, banging the button while furtively glancing around. Fuck, the elevator wasn't working. She swore silently, pulling out the spare phone to try Glimmer or Bow while running to the staircase.

"Hello?"

After the fifth call, a muffled voice responded on the other line. Adora nearly cried, so relieved she skipped a step and almost tripped.

"Thank the stars, I'm in trouble."

"Where are you?"

The voice was more alert now, Bow or Glimmer's Adora couldn't even tell. She was too glad that someone was there, that someone knew she was in danger.

"Something went wrong, I-I don't know. I need to leave, right now."

"Woah, woah, explain."

"I can't, I'm running."

If it wasn't for all those early morning runs, Adora wouldn't be able to sprint full speed while somewhat talking on the phone, albeit her sentences were broken and barely coherent.

"It'll take at least an hour to get to the school, even if we leave right now."

"Fine, but I'm gonna catch a bus or something now. I need to get out."

She reached the large stone gates, eyes snagging on the thumbprint password protection on it. It likely had some heavy tech secured, something that would alert security if she set it off. She chewed her lip, deciding if it was worth it to just make a dash and run before they caught her. There was no time to think of a better solution. Flinging her backpack over, Adora scrambled up the hard wire, the sharp points ripping her skin and hands as she went. She shook even more, palms worn and sore from the fight with Catra and climbing the gate. Instantly the steel glowed, that hideous lime green color. Adora didn't wait to see what would happen, grabbing her bag and holding the phone to her ear again as she ran.

"Hello? Hello?"

The voice was calling to her again, and Adora was thankful they hadn't hung up.

"I'm out, down Despondos Avenue now."

She made her way through the hidden side streets, where mansions lay dormant every few meters. There was no point trying to sneak into one, it's where they'd look first...If they'd

even bother to look. If she was lucky they wouldn't even care, just carry on with their business and forget she went there for those few short weeks. But she wasn't going to get that lucky, she never was. It didn't matter, she supposed, she'd have to return to retrieve Catra.

"Okay, try to stay there for a bit, we'll get Mom to send a flight out now. She'll kill me, but she'll do it."

Adora mumbled a quick thanks, the phone hanging up shortly after. Sirens wailed in the distant...though, they sounded odd.

They aren't sirens, that's why.

No, they weren't. It was that hellish music, back on repeat, in a rhythmic form. Must be the gates crying for help, alerting its stupid asshole master that someone tried to leave that prison. Adora dug herself further into the trees, turning her location on for Angella to find her. Tiredness weighed down on her like a weight, but it was one she couldn't succumb to. Not with the events of the night. Catra's face kept appearing, like a ghost. The hazy green glow of her eyes, that piercing laugh...Adora couldn't shake it off.

What the fuck had Prime done to her? One minute she was slipping into the bathtub and the next...

Adora tried to think of something else, a plan perhaps. But her mind simply wouldn't allow it. No matter how much she tried she couldn't shake off Catra's face. It did something to her, tied her stomach into a knot and pulled her heart out of her body. Going to Prime Elite was a bad idea, they never should've considered it.

The minutes didn't pass by quickly, but they slowly turned to hours, and the sirens died out as the night extended. Adora stretched her knees, muscles and joints aching from staying still and silent for so long, with only the sound of her heartbeat for company. She supposed that preferable over animals, but she yearned for some sort of distraction.

Just as her eyelids began to pull down, an incomprehensible weight attached to them, the sound of chopping waves caught her attention.

No...not chopping waves, rather an engine, and blades to carry it. She looked up, seeing nothing but the glint of steel in the fresh night air, as a helicopter landed meters away from her. Adora waved her arms frantically, thankful for some contact at last.

"Adora, what happened?"

"Are you hurt? Injured? Got any brain damage?"

Bow talked in great mouthfuls, prodding Adora's arm while looking up imploringly. Adora could barely see their figures in the dark, only catching the alarmed purple eyes that belonged to Glimmer.

"I'll explain-or try to, later. Right now I just want to go home." Her speech was slow, mind barely operating at a reasonable level. Luckily her friends understood, supporting Adora as they made their way back to the vehicle.

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The following morning was painful, to say the least. The adrenaline supporting her was worn off, leaving her body drained and sore from the night's events. Adora tried to lift herself off the bed, sunlight blocking her vision. She felt helpless, tired and weak. And she despised every damn moment of it.

"Morning," Bow strolled into the room, carrying a tray with what looked like food.

God, food. She could use some of that right now. Tears nearly rolled down her cheeks at the sight of eggs and toast, a luxury she wasn't permitted at Prime Academy. She'd rather die than face that miserable grey sludge she'd lived off of for weeks.

"Thank you," she replied, wiping her eyes while feeling like an absolute child. Can't make her own food or even get out of bed,

what use was she now?

"You alright?" Bow tentatively perched himself on the end of the bed, Glimmer's face peeking through as she cracked the door open.

"I'm alright."

She met the other girl's eyes, silently inviting her to come in. Glimmer looked relieved, joining Bow on the end of the bed. Adora didn't like the animosity, both of her friends tiptoeing around her like she was some glass doll about to break.

"Do you want anything else?"

They were waiting, she suddenly realized. Waiting for a story, something for their minds to digest, a puzzle for them to solve. She ought to give it to them, they deserved it after everything they did for her.

"No, I think I should explain."

She cleared her throat, slowly raising herself to sit while she took a sip of water. It was an awfully vulnerable position, being rumpled and weak while they were both dressed and nourished.

"Last night..." She didn't know how to phrase any of it, hadn't begun to think of what to say. She didn't know everything herself.

"Well the first thing you should know is that Catra was put in the basement dorms. Her room was a lot larger than mine, and it also included a...big round bath tub."

She averted their enquiring gazes, pushing forward with the story while her throat didn't close up.

"Anyway, last night, she wanted to use it, for the first time. It was night, I was saying goodbye to her so I could back to my dorm for the night."

She paused, a bubble of pride raising inside herself for not completely messing up the story. She was careful not to mention the fact that Catra and her were now romantically involved. One story was enough for now, she decided.

"As soon as I reached my own door, I saw her. She was wearing a robe, her hair and body was wet, and she was really freaked out."

"What did she say?"

Adora thought back, feeling like it was an eon ago rather than a few hours.

"Nothing important, just yelling my name and saying 'oh my god' a million times. She was loud though, and she held my arms like she was clinging to sanity."

She mumbled the last part, glancing down at the now bandaged (when did that happen?) arms and hands.

"I obviously started getting worried, so I let her into my dorm to sit down and talk. We waited about half an hour, and she calmed down, but then..."

She didn't like this part, but Glimmer gently prodded her.

"I honestly don't even know what happened. She was calm, so I thought I'd ask her what happened. I look up, and-"

"And?"

"Her eyes were green. Not plant green, or normal green, bright neon green."

Glimmer tilted her head, utterly confused, and suddenly Adora felt a lot warmer. Her friends were startled, she wasn't the only confounded one, her reaction was understandable.

"I can't remember much after that, she was gripping my wrists really tightly, wouldn't let go. Then she started spouting rubbish

about Prime saving her, and talking with this weird metallic voice. It wasn't Catra, I know it wasn't."

She shook her head firmly. Even Catra in her worst and nastiest state would never act like this, and her eyes were literally glowing, not the cool kind, but the supernatural kind.

"What?" Bow said after a few moments.

"I sorta freaked out, but she broke out of it. It was only for a second, but it was something. She had me pinned, I couldn't get out, and then...she let go, and said 'hurry.' Her eyes were normal then, but she was shaking so much. It looked painful."

A lump grew in her throat, and Adora had to swallow it down before it threatened to attack her. They were all silent for a moment, Adora trying to shake the image of Catra out of her mind while her friends digested the information.

"Hold on, did you manage to get that recording Adora?"

Bow's voice wasn't exactly urgent, but it held a bit of hope.

"Yeah, why?"

"Send it to me."

Adora obeyed, pulling out her phone and sending the video she'd taken about a week earlier. Bow replayed it on his phone, plugging his headphones in.

"Fuck."

Bow wasn't one to swear, so this shocked both Adora and Glimmer. Bow didn't answer their questioning gazes though, tackling his monitor at full speed and pulling up all different kinds of software.

"What's he doing?" Adora whispered to Glimmer, scared that she'll break Bow's newfound concentration if she spoke any louder.

"My guess is as good as yours. I never understand what he does on his computer."

The two girls waited after that, exchanging subtle glances every time Bow gasped or muttered something under his breath, words a completely different language to Adora's ears.

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"Holy shit," he said finally, turning in his swivel chair to face them.

"What is it?"

It was now lunchtime, and Adora had mustered enough energy to take a shower and put a fresh set of clothes on. It felt somewhat good to settle back into her own corner of the room, and she was feeling slightly less stressed as she tied her wet hair into a bun at the top of her head.

"Come over here."

Glimmer and Adora didn't bother asking why, knowing they'd find out in a few short moments. Bow rearranged his screen, pulling up multiple tabs and setting them along each other so the girls could sort of decipher what he was about to explain to them.

"In short, the music is designed to put you in a hypnosis."

"What's that?"

Now both Glimmer and Bow turned to gawk at Adora, who shrugged.

"Sheltered kid, sorry!" Adora held her hands up defensively, and Bow quickly explained.

"It's sort of a spell, I guess. You know what a spell is right?"

Glimmer softly snickered as Adora rolled her eyes, replying with a slow affirmation.

"It makes you a bit drowsy, more open to obeying orders and suggestions. It's sometimes good, can help people quit bad habits, but Prime's done something a bit different."

He motioned to his PC, his index finger following a large curve of a graph.

"See this? It's not meant to be there. In a regular audio clip, the curve looks like this-"

He gestured to a different graph, the lines more stable but jagged.

"This audio is designed to entrance people, put them in an ever-complying state of hypnosis. Basically, it tricks you into feeling to weak to resist whatever Prime or his teachers tell you to do."

No wonder none of the students got in trouble.

Adora gaped at it.

"Is that not illegal?" Glimmer spoke up, as astounded as Adora.

"It is in this case. No one consented to be hypnotized or even knew."

"It makes sense. Yesterday Catra went to get extra help with Prime, and she was acting a bit odd. Defensive over him."

Glimmer shivered at that, and Adora silently agreed. She was disgusted at Catra defending Prime too.

"What about you, Adora?"

She blinked in surprise.

"What about me?"

"Did you get any symptoms? Headaches, dizziness, feeling weary."

Adora thought back to her time at the Academy.

"You know, I did feel rather tired, but that was mostly because of the food-"

"The food? Oh god, the food!"

"Uh, you good?"

Bow looked like a worn out stressed ball, eyes popping out of his head.

"I need a sample of it to prove it, but I think Prime might've mildly poisoned you."

"Mildly what?"

"Poisoned. It means-"

"I know what it means," Adora snapped, swatting away Bow's hand as he went to explain.

"He might've drugged you, small doses that keep you complacent and mollify you. Like, food that keeps you boring, and dulls your senses."

"My senses were certainly not dull when Catra and I fucke-"

Adora stopped herself, but it was too late. The words were already out of her mouth, along with a snort she'd emitted with it.

"ADORA FUCKINGGG GRAY OH. MY. GOD," Glimmer's shouts could probably be heard by the entire school. Adora actually had to cover her ears.

"I'M FREAKING OUT, ARE YOU FREAKING OUT?"

Bow frantically stood onto his desk chair, clutching Glimmer's arms while she clutched his.

"IM FREAKING OUT, I'M DEFINITELY FREAKING OUT," Glimmer jumped up and down with a high pitched squeal.

"Jeez, guys calm down," Adora was tempted to slap both of them, only so they'd stop 'freaking out.'

But the only thing she managed to accomplish from speaking was directing her friends' attention back to herself.

"YOU BITCH, WHY DIDN'T YOU TELL ME?"

Glimmer's voice was slightly lower now, but still a yell. Without warning she tackled Adora, waving her arms about sporadically. Adora righted herself quickly with a laugh, clutching Glimmers wrists and holding them until she calmed down a bit.

"Because you have the loudest mouth in the school, which you proved like a minute ago."

Adora raised her eyebrows, Glimmer's cheeks getting red as she remembered her reaction.

"Oh, that's why."

At least she was talking normally now, Adora taking it as a cue to release her wrists with a sigh. Bow stuck out his arm in front of his girlfriend.

"Come on, you owe me twenty."

He wriggled his fingers expectedly, and Glimmer grudgingly grabbed her sparkly phone from the table.

"There, transferred."

Adora looked between them quickly.

"You betted on me and Catra getting together?"

Bow and Glimmer just looked at her blankly, their following word in unison.

"Duh."

Gym Junkies Unite

"No way, nuh uh."

Bow glared at her from across the table, arms firmly crossed as he stared her down. Adora merely rolled her eyes, not the least bit intimidated by his interrogating gaze.

"You can't make me."

"Oh yes I can. And I will."

Glimmer unlocked the door just then, which was probably a good thing because Adora was just about ready to punch his face at that point. Usually, she was at odds with Glimmer, never with Bow. An odd situation, she found.

"What's going on?" Glimmer called out, noticing them facing each other across the wide table.

"Adora wants to come with us."

"It's either I come with you, or I tell Angella. You choose."

Adora leaned back, turning her neck to glance at Glimmer.

"Yep, she's coming," Glimmer replied instantly.

"I don't mind telling Angella," Bow shrugged. Now it was Glimmer that stared daggers at him. She walked around the table and lightly smacked his head.

"Let her come, it is her girlfriend after all. I wouldn't let someone else come and rescue you."

Bow chewed on her words, softening slightly which gave Adora a glimpse of hope. She threw a thankful look at Glimmer.

"Look at her, she's injured. She needs to rest. And Prime is obsessed with her too, remember? We don't want both of them under his weird influence."

Glimmer pursed her lips tightly, and Adora's gratitude turned to stone. They couldn't seriously be considering going on a rescue mission for Catra while leaving Adora in the stupid safety of Brightmoon's pretty pastel pink walls.

"You do have a point, we need her to be safe."

Adora sighed angrily, exasperated at the two of them.

"Can you not discuss me when I'm right in front of you?"

Her patience was dwindling, sooner or later she'd crack. Maybe she already had. She spent the whole day arguing with Bow about it, who'd agreed to skip classes to look after Adora.

"I'm fine, look."

She stood from her seat, perhaps a bit fast for the room spun in her vision. Shaking it off, she clapped her hands together, a wide smile stretching on her face. She smothered the cringe she felt as her hands slapped together, palms burning from the force of the action.

"Yeah, no. Sorry Adora, you're not coming."

"That's it!"

Adora tried to run for the door, but her legs simply wouldn't carry her. She could barely lift them into a steady jog. Glimmer quickly caught her around the waist, and suddenly they were back at the table. Adora shook her head, staring at Glimmer with beady eyes.

"If you tell my mom, she'll take at least another week coming up with a 'safe plan to avoid harm,' one that'll be legal."

Glimmer was right, Angella certainly lacked the impulsive charm Glimmer seemed to possess. And every minute Adora knew Catra was at Prime Elite was another minute of torture.

"We'll tell her at some point, but after we have evidence and Catra is back. She can handle suing Prime and getting the bastard in jail. The boring shit."

"Look, we'd let you come if you were fully healed, but you're not. So it's either we wait for you to recover, or we do it without you now. Which is more preferable."

Bow knew the answer to his own question and they all goddamn knew it. Adora grunted through gritted teeth, annoyed that they were both right.

"Fine, I'll let you go without me. But if you aren't back by one, I'm coming. Oh, and you have to give me my school work, I don't care if I'm still recovering."

Glimmer had forced Adora to ignore her assignments and missing essays so she could heal, but she felt restless with nothing to do. It was like having an itch that can't be scratched.

Adora watched them reluctantly nod, Bow quick to usher her back into bed.

The pacing had paused momentarily, while Adora had gone for a shower to distract herself and restlessly did pushups along with various other exercises on the floor. But now it had resumed, the books abandoned on her desk nearby. She checked her watch another time, watching the seconds increase until it finally hit one o'clock.

She took a breath, unsure if she should try to contact Glimmer or not. Glimmer had strictly advised her not to, as it would be easier if Glimmer directly contacted her when required, but Adora was itching to press down on that button. They could very likely be in

trouble...Or maybe the mission was going splendidly and Adora calling Glimmer would just distract them and ruin it.

Well she certainly wasn't going to revisit the academy without at least calling first, so Adora decidedly pressed down on the screen.

"Good Evening, Adora."

Chills. Adora shivered at the voice, at the fact that he held Glimmer's phone. Her heart dropped into her stomach.

"Where are they?"

She struggled to maintain sanity in her tone, to sound sharp and collected rather than a fucking mess, which was exactly what she was right at that moment.

"Student phones are confiscated at Prime Elite. Although, you and Catra were never fond of that rule."

Adora felt her blood heat at the mention of Catra, the fact that her name was leaving his lips in that smug voice. What shocked her was that he knew. All this time she'd thought she was sneaking her devices around and he knew.

What else did he know?

Adora shivered again, erasing that question from her mind.

"Good night Adora."

His voice took a sharp tone, the farewell labeled as a warning in Adora's mind. But that didn't change anything, now she knew she had to get to her friends. The only question was how?

Prime Elite was located three and half hours away from Brightmoon, and that was the distance measured by flight. It was one o'clock in the morning, she'd never find a school pilot at this hour, and she couldn't afford to wait until morning. She racked her brain for a solution, the pacing never-ending.

Giving up, Adora just rushed to the first dorm she could think of.

Really, it was the only dorm she could think of, and she damn hoped she'd find a solution.

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Adora unlocked the door carefully, slipping inside the cold, dark dorm. If it wasn't for Catra's forgetfulness, she wouldn't even have access to the room. She felt a bit odd, slinking around the abandoned room to try and find Lonnie's. The darkness stared back at her, Adora ignoring the blank glass wall as she searched the dorm.

"Can I help you?"

Adora was so startled by the voice she tripped over herself, flying over and onto the couch. She cringed outwardly at herself, raising her torso to spot Lonnie leaning against the wall, clad in a pair of shorts and a t-shirt. The girl stalked over to her, a slight smirk plastered on her face.

"I need your help."

Lonnie's smugness fell right off her face, she must've spotted something urgent in Adora's expression.

"What happened?"

Adora quickly clambered off the couch, feeling stupid and clumsy for falling all over herself. The only person more intimidating then Lonnie was probably Catra, but they scared Adora in vastly different ways. Lonnie was more of a role model, an icon in Adora's eyes. The girl was by far the best on the basketball team (and just about every other sport team), dominated everyone in P.E, and is one of Catra's closest friends. She was friendly to Adora now, but they were nowhere near the status of 'friends.'

"I can't explain right now, I just need some help and I didn't know where to go."

"Who? What?"

Adora didn't need to elaborate on her questions.

"Catra; Prime Elite."

Lonnie's eyes widened a fragment as her mouth slammed closed. She nodded firmly.

"What do you need?"

"Someone who can fly a plane."

Now Lonnie gaped.

"Weird request, I know. But I need to get there now."

"Fine, but only if I can come."

Adora didn't even hesitate. Lonnie had beat her numerous times during the Boxing unit in P.E. Horace Prime would be lucky if he only received a punch from her.

"Done. You know someone?"

"Sure, you know him too."

She pulled open the door, her statement giving Adora's mind something to chew on. What 17-year old just knew how to operate a flying vehicle?

Lonnie stopped by Arsan's dorm door.

Oh. That 17-year old.

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Puff and Co.

On the few occasions Adora had spent getting to know Arsan Hawk, she'd learnt two things.

The first one was to never believe whatever outrageous story he'd tell her. Both the Hawk brothers seemed to be exceptional liars with devious imaginations.

The second, was that he was a carbon copy of his older brother (and her phys ed teacher), Sea Hawk.

"You're kidding, right?"

Lonnie gave her a shrug as she rapped gloved knuckles against the door. The dark haired girl insisted on dressing in all black, and Adora only caved because arguing about it was every minute more that her friends were in Prime's grasp.

"Did you have to knock so loudly? Whole bloody corridor can hear it," Adora muttered under her breath. She was pissed Lonnie had won their little clothing fight, but not enough to broach the topic again.

"Well someone in there needed to hear it, so."

Lonnie raised her eyebrows in a self explanatory manner, and Adora rolled her eyes at the fact that she was right.

"Who's Arsan's roommate anyway?"

Adora's question was answered for her as the door swung open. Swung open to reveal Double Trouble, adorned in a bright green onesie and hair wrapped up in a disheveled bun. Adora had to stifle her snort, but DT was quick to register it. Their eyes landed on Adora's with a glare.

"Anyone who interrupts my rest gets slaughtered Puff, so wipe that little grin off your face."

Adora quickly shut up, looking over to Lonnie who just shrugged again.

"Where'd 'Puff' come from?" Was the brunette's only response.

"How am I supposed to know where my nicknames come from?"

DT rolled their eyes, stepping aside while gesturing for the girls to enter through the doorway.

"Don't think I haven't spotted your ridiculously adorable outfits, it was the first thing I saw."

They fixed up their hair at a leisurely pace, and Adora was getting a bit antsy at the slowness of everything. This was a time of urgency, not languid gestures and snarky comments.

"I'll get Arsan," Adora mumbled, angry but too worried and tired to express it.

"Why's she sour?"

She heard DT's hushed voice fade out as she wondered through the small corridor, finding a closed door with a big letter 'A' plastered to the front, the red letter blazing in a fire. Adora snorted to herself, deciding to knock before she barged in. With a lack of response, her manners flew out of the window. Catra, Glimmer and Bow needed help now, she couldn't just fluff around. She pushed open the door, finding a lump of a person squashed under the covers.

Of course Arsan Hawk slept like the dead.

She didn't hesitate for a second, grabbing a cup of water on a nearby table and tipping the cold substance over his head. The boy yelped instantly, leaping out of the covers while his eyes scoured for the culprit.

Adora just stared, one eyebrow raised at his pajamas.

"Are those...ships on fire?"

She shook her head, deciding she didn't care enough for an explanation.

"Put some clothes on, all black. Lonnie tells me you're a pilot?"

"Well yes I am," he smiled proudly.

"Good, we need one."

He blinked, obviously a bit rattled at being disturbed in the middle of the night.

"Don't just stand there, hurry up!"

She waved at his with her arms before briskly leaving the room. Lonnie, DT and Arsan...An interesting 'Dream Team.'

But they would do. DT could act their way through just about anything, Lonnie had her fists, and Arsan could fly a plane. Adora didn't even have a plan in her head, she had no idea what Prime had prepared, and no idea who'd she even be up against to save Catra and her friends.

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"Oh my god! Oh my fucking god! Arsan!"

Lonnie shrieked as the plane rattled again, and Adora refrained from doing the same.

"I thought you said you knew how to fly?"

DT also looked on the verge of just jumping out of the plane, and Adora didn't blame them in the slightest.

"I do, I do! Just not this specific type of plane."

Adora felt her ears ringing at his calm tone.

"Do you at least know where we're going?"

She yelled over the sound of the engine (and Lonnie's relentless screaming).

"Oh, yeah! Definitely!"

Adora refrained from yelling at him, instead opting to look out the window at the dark inky mass of sky. Why did it have to be nighttime? When you couldn't see a goddamn thing and the wind was howling your way? Her head thudded against the window, and she quickly brushed away the lone tear that had fallen from all her stress.

"Hey, Arsan!" Lonnie called out suddenly, her screaming had ceased.

"What?"

"Move."

Lonnie's voice was pure ice as she shoved the boy over, Arsan swatting her as she did. That had little to no effect on Lonnie though, who instantly adjusted the controls.

"Wait, you knew how to fly a plane too? Why didn't you tell me?"

Adora tried to lean forward but her seatbelt wouldn't allow the movement.

"Middle of the night, I was tired," she shrugged, continuing to maneuver the steering wheel and turn on the location systems.

"But you were yelling your head off for-"

"Zip it, Puff. Do you want me to get you to Catra or not?"

Adora's mouth snapped shut in surprise. She didn't respond, catching Lonnie's small smile in the rearview mirror.

"Yo, we actually aren't all that far off." She tapped a few buttons on the map, Adora staring at it with no idea of what was actually happening.

"Instead of sulking in the back corner, I suggest you get those two to help you come up with a plan," Lonnie jerked a thumb at DT and Arsan.

"Yeah, you're right."

Adora racked her head for ideas, finally coming up with something after a few seconds of silence.

"DT, you're in charge of distracting Entrapta. I know she looks after security and all the tech stuff. Can you do that?"

DT waved a hand at her with a scoff.

"I don't know or care who she is, I'll do it. Anything for Kitten."

Adora smiled, turning to face Arsan.

"Arsan, Lonnie; you two are getting Bow and Glimmer. I doubt they're in the same place as Catra, that's too easy. I also need you to collect evidence, film whatever you can and take photos. DT, you too."

She watched Lonnie nod firmly in the mirror, her hope expanding.

"I'm going for Catra."

"By yourself?"

"She cracked. Only for a second, but still. I'm gonna try and make it happen again, for longer this time."

They sat in a bit of silence, everyone stewing over what was to come.

"Oh, another thing I should mention. Catra and I are-"

"Dating?"

"Lovers?"

"Girlfriends?"

Adora blinked, looking around at all of them who had spoken. DT's golden eyes glowed in the dimness of the plane.

"Uh, yeah. How'd you know."

She wrapped a cord of hair around her finger, playing with the ends as she averted their eyes.

"You're about as subtle as an elephant, darling. It was destined from the day you arrived," DT winked, reclining in their chair.

Adora felt herself heat up. Was she really that easy to read? First Bow and Glimmer, but at least they were her roommates and best friends, but DT, Arsan and Lonnie....They'd barely seen her talk to Catra.

"It's alright, Puff. It's cute."

Adora shook her head, meeting Lonnie's green eyes in the mirror.

"Call me Puff one more time and I'll slice your head off."

Arsan and DT just snickered from beside her, and she swiftly shut them up with a punch in each arm.

_____

Save The Cat.

A/N: Gonna give a bit of a !TW! because this chapter isn't the nicest :/ I kinda despised writing it, so pls read with caution.

"Fuck, Puff. This is a jail."

Lonnie gazed incredulously at Adora, gaze flicking between her and the large stone gates. The neon jewels gleamed in the midnight, the ends pointing like daggers.

"You seriously lived here for a month?"

She spoke again after hearing a lack of response from Adora, who's lips pressed together and jaw tightened.

"Yes, I did."

She looked back at DT and Arsan, who had similar expressions to Lonnie painted on their faces, and pulled the hood even closer over her head.

"Come on, all of you do P.E, you can scale a wall."

"P.E is very different from spy training, Adora."

She just rolled her eyes, pulling her leather gloves tighter around her fingers. She placed a hand against the wall, muttering "excuses" under her breath while doing so. The suction grip instantly latched on. Not enough to provide full support, but good enough for her to get some sort of grip.

"Just use these for support."

She wrapped a hand around one of the steel bars, pulling herself onto the gate with a steady hand. She didn't bother looking back to watch if her friends were doing the same, she knew they would.

Moving up the wall was hard, but it didn't take long. As soon as Adora reached the roof she helped the others, pulling rope from her backpack and securing it around one of the pointy pillars. Lonnie was next to join her, securing another rope to help DT and Arsan.

Once they were over, Adora examined the concrete slab in front of her. A concrete slab that held over two thousand brilliant students who'd all been helplessly mind-washed by a psychotic genius.

"Careful where you step, he might've upped security since I escaped."

The others nodded, and Adora nodded for them to continue walking along the top edge of the gate. It was a safer bet than jumping onto the actual school property.

Once they reached the entrance she sighed, slightly more relaxed they'd breached the entrance with no real trouble. Arsan may have fallen once or twice, but no real damage was done.

"Okay, here's where we split," she whispered, keeping her voice as low as possible.

"I don't know exactly where everything is, but here are the main spots."

She'd drawn a horribly rough looking map in the plane, and now pointed to various important locations on it. Prime's office, Catra's room on the basement floor, her old dorm, Warran's room (if they needed an ally or someone to help them out) and the security base.

"Darling, I won't even need a map, ta-da!"

Adora hurriedly shushed DT, who slapped their hands over their mouth apologetically. Still, they pulled out a...disturbingly accurate uniform of Prime Elite.

"Oh, then you'll have no trouble going undercover," she blinked.

When the fuck had they made that?

She shook it off, it didn't matter. As long as it benefitted this 'mission,' it was good.

"Alright, we all know what we're doing?"

She looked around at all of them, meeting each and every pair of eyes that gazed steadily into her own.

"Good. Let's go."

_____

Adora scoured the rooms, finding all of them too suddenly be identical. She could barely navigate this place and she'd lived there for a month. Panic and worry started to fill her mind for the sake of her friends.

Bracing herself, she pushed open Catra's door, surprised to see it unlocked. Not only unlocked, but slightly ajar.

The minute she'd entered Catra's space Adora felt her skin raise. It smelled of her...Her and something else. Something venomous, like a toxic gas or a weird chemical. Adora pushed past it, glad to know that Catra was still residing in the room and she didn't have to hunt around the school for her.

Adora trailed past the couch, flashbacks pouring back into her mind. The times they'd spent there, close together, in the middle of-

Not now Adora. Keep your head straight.

She waved off the emotions, fisting her hands so tightly her knuckles were white.

Pushing past, Adora approached the bathroom, the walls lit in a soft glow. Again, the door was slightly ajar.

Pausing, Adora held her breath. Catra was in there, she sensed it, could hear the faint humming that reminded her of a deranged child. She recognized it, a song they used to sing to each other when they needed help; rescuing from a bully or even Hordak himself. Adora didn't bother to knock, gently pushing her way into the glowing room.

"Catra?" She whispered softly.

Her eyes met sharp green ones, oddly neon in the soft light of the room. She sat languidly in the spacious bathtub, head tipped back in a seeming state of bliss.

"Hello, Adora."

The words cracked like glass against the floor, breaking something that Adora didn't even realize existed inside of her.

"What has he done?"

She whispered more to herself than Catra, in a state of pure shock. The girl rolled her neck, shifting to get out of the tub. She wasn't naked, no.

In fact, she was fully clothed...In Prime's uniform. The white collared shirt stuck against her skin, the tie loosened and pants dripping as she exited the bath. No accessories, tamed hair and glowing green eyes...she barely looked like herself. Adora took a step forward, every fibre of her being screaming at her to flee; run; abandon.

She didn't. Wouldn't.

"Catra. Listen to me. I know you're in there."

She laughed then, a crazed sound.

"I never left."

What the fuck happened in the last twenty eight hours?

Adora reached for her, but Catra caught her arm, twisting it so rapidly and painfully that Adora gasped.

"I'm healed Adora. My mind is a diamond. And it's thanks to my Lord."

Adora felt sweat form, and mentally thanked Mr Hawk for the karate unit in P.E. She hooked her leg around the back of Catra's knees, knocking down to the floor and twisting out of her grasp.

"No one breaks you Catra, not even a brain washing demon like him."

She spat the last word, and it angered something in Catra. The girl kicked Adora with the heels of her feet, causing her to flop onto the ground. Catra grabbed her opportunity, rolling and picking herself up from the floor. She grabbed something from a nearby bench, and before Adora could comprehend what was happening two metal chains were tightened around her wrists.

"He was expecting you. His Lordship will be glad."

Adora's eyes widened, fear running through her body as she struggled. Catra straddled her, raising Adora's cuffed hands above her head.

"I missed you. But now you're back, and we can be together. Prime will let us."

Something glistened in her eyes, and it frightened Adora more than the eery tone of her voice.

"Come, I'll take you to him."

Adora shook her head, silently screaming 'no' as Catra moved off of her. She grabbed Adora by the waist, hoisting her and dragging her out of the bathroom. The blonde struggled, kicking and waving her restrained hands in an effort to get out of there. Catra climbed back on her, shocking Adora into silence. Still, it only took a moment for the shouting to resume, Adora wriggling under

Catra's weight. A hand gently pulled through the strands of her hair, the humming returning.

Her hands drifted through Adora's hair, reaching the nape and twirling the few golden locks there. Adora paused, fractured by the look on Catra's face.

And then the hands tightened, like a band around Adora's throat. Adora tried to scream, but she couldn't, her airways were blocked.

"There we are, that's a good girl," Catra murmured softly, pausing the humming. Adora stopped wriggling, stopped trying. And that was the trick. Catra released her neck, but kept running her hands through Adora's hair, a gentle threat.

"He'll be here soon, he'll bless you."

A sickness violated Adora's stomach, and she forced it down.

"Catra please," she gasped, throat still raw.

The hands returned to the base of her neck, relaxed, but still there.

"Do it."

Adora felt like screaming at herself for saying that, but it worked. A least a fraction. Catra's gaze flickered, and Adora hoped she'd spotted a flash of gold there.

"No, He'll wish to see you."

"Fine, I'll do it myself."

Adora raised her chained hands to her neck, pressing the sharp metal against the soft skin of her throat. Hands quickly fled from her throat and found Adora's wrists instead, refraining her.

"What are you doing? Stay," the eyes flashed again, and hope sparked inside Adora. She was there, somewhere.

"Nope."

She pushed against Catra's skin, watching her vision fade and sharpen as she struggled against Catra.

"Adora, no!"

Her voice, it was coming back. Adora could barely see, could only really feel wetness at the base of her throat, but she heard it.

"Adora, fuck, what are you doing?"

She stopped, she stopped everything. Adora didn't plan on putting herself in that danger, but it worked.

"Who put these on you? Why are you bleeding?"

Her vision was still grey, and she felt her body falling.

"Adora!"

She held on, gasping for bandages while soaking up the blood with her hand. She hadn't cut muscle, veins, or anything important, but her neck still hurt like a bitch. Gentle hands returned to her throat, different to the last time they were there, and the blood slowed marginally.

"You aren't going anywhere, Blondie."

Adora thought she might cry at that name, at the now familiar voice.

Her vision strengthened, the blood eventually coming to a momentary stop as she regained full consciousness. Bandages were thrown at her throat, hastily wrapped but they did the job, for now at least.

"Catra?" She could finally see well enough to recognize the shining eyes looking down into her own.

"Hey, Adora."

She held her to her chest, up until Adora felt well enough to sit up by herself.

"We need to get out of here."

"I don't know what the fuck happened, but I agree."

Now that Adora could look at her, really see her, she noticed Catra's weary eyes, the wet hair messy and scrambled on her head. It was more of a relief than anything.

Standing up, Adora held out a hand for her, gingerly touching the bandage around her neck. Catra wobbled, before collapsing completely in Adora's arms.

"Woah, you okay?"

"Fine, yeah, I'm good," Catra reassured her. She used Adora as a support, trying to balance her weight. Watching her struggle, Adora wasted no time.

"Adora! What are you-"

"Quiet, we need to get out of here, and fast. We're both weak and I'm injured. Easy targets."

She glanced at the door, deciding the window was a safer option. They could run into anyone down the hallway. She held Catra on her back, clutching her close.

"Yeah, which is exactly why YOU SHOULDN'T BE CARRYING ME."

Catra whisper yelled right in Adora's ear, who cringed.

"More we argue, longer we're here."

That shut her up quickly, giving Adora a smirk on her face. Those months in the gym were finally paying off, Catra was just like another barbell on her back.

Adora unscrewed the latch on the window, flinging it as open as it could go.

"Ugh, I'm gonna be sick," Catra groaned as they landed softly on the grass. Adora rubbed her thumb soothingly on the back of her thigh, a pathetic excuse for an apology for what Catra had to endure.

"We'll be home. Soon," she promised, running as lightly as she could across the ground. They crossed the field easily, Adora beginning to think they'd make it out unscathed.

"Hello Adora."

That voice, that fucking voice. She stopped abruptly, a man made of plastic, rigid in front of her.

"Prime," she spat, glaring up at him. The breeze pushed past her, droplets of humid rain beginning to fall. She'd told the others to meet her by the plane, the plane that was blatantly hidden right on the empty field behind Prime. She tried to swallow her fear, fear that he'd see her escape route.

"I'm afraid I can't allow you to leave Adora. It's too late."

His words meant nothing when he stood like a statue, a stoic expression walled on his ugly face. Adora bit down her sneer, meeting his green eyes with a venom of her own.

"So what? You'll kill me?"

Her heartbeat sped up at the smile that spread on his face, one of pure horror.

"Not quite. I'll give you a pleasant stay in the incubator."

The what?

Adora's eyes snagged a glint of something in the dark, something neon. She watched Prime's fingers, watched them open slightly to

reveal a small green computer chip. She tore her gaze away, her peripheral vision catching a few blurry figures jumping into the plane. She couldn't decipher how many, but definitely more than two.

"Sorry, the incubator?"

As much as she wanted to leave, she also wanted information.

"A delightful steam bath, I'm sure you'll enjoy it."

His smile widened, a large hand gripping Adora's arm. She looked down at it, the contact, and something inside her was set loose.

Without a second to hesitate, she jammed the heel of her foot onto Prime's leather toes, watching his firm stance crumble. Not quite satisfied, she drove her shin into his crotch, watching the creature double over in pain.

"Darling, hurry."

DT appeared from the shadows, wearing the replica of the uniform they'd shown her earlier. Adora blinked in surprise, but DT didn't give her any time to think, pushing her towards the plane. Shaking off her confusion, Adora took her chance. She'd only bought a few minutes away from Prime, they needed to get out. Fast.

They reached the plane quickly, Adora panting as she carefully dropped Catra into the seat. DT slid the door behind them, ushering to Lonnie to start the engine.

"I'm sure glad we didn't park inside the school now."

"Uh huh," Adora was still breathing heavily, her hands shaking compulsively. She quickly turned around, glad to see Bow and Glimmer sleeping against the seats.

"Good job guys, we got everyone."

Relief filled a part of her, and she sighed, collapsing into the seat.

"Where'd you even come from DT, I didn't see you?"

Adora looked around at them, who smiled and held a phone.

"I was videoing everything, that man is going to spend a good, long while behind bars. "

They winked, and Adora could've tackled DT out of happiness. Now they had evidence, solid proof.

"What happened to you?"

Arsan's eyes flew down to the bandages wound around her neck. Adora had almost forgot they were there.

"These? Oh, uh, Catra did it."

She didn't want to explain the whole story to them. It just felt...private. Something she'd share with Catra, and Catra only.

"Well, you don't look good. You're pale, and injured. Rest."

Adora forced her heavy eyelids to stay alert, shaking her head.

"No, no, I'm-"

She stifled a yawn, tiredness sinking down on her.

"Fine-"

She didn't get to finish, DT grabbing a pillow (from where?) and placing it behind her head. The softness was inviting, welcoming.

"Guys, I need to-"

"You need to relax. You're very weak."

"I am not-"

Her eyelids drifted down and someone restrained her from sitting back up.

"Sleep, Adora."

That was all the instruction she needed, Adora's tired muscles and body sinking into the seat with weariness.

———————

Dr. Mara Despondos

"Lie down."

Adora was instructed before she'd even gotten the chance to stir or set herself up after sleep. She blinked her eyes open, daylight flooding her vision.

"Who're you?"

Her words were groggy, throat still sore from the last night's (was it last night?) escapade.

"Dr. Despondos, but please; call me Mara." The voice was gentle, but still firm. Adora instantly felt she could trust this woman, a feeling she'd rarely encountered.

"I'm Adora."

The kind lady chuckled, and Adora finally mustered enough strength to lift her head and turn towards her. A hand quickly supported the top of her spine, and relief instantly shot through Adora.

"I know."

Adora examined the face behind the trusting voice, and found it to be pleasing. Sunny blue eyes, a different hue to Adora's own, and deep brown hair that complimented her skin. Mara smiled, the expression brightening her already warm face.

"Where am I?"

Her throat was raw, voice cracking with confusion as she tried to swivel her head. She found she couldn't.

"A hospital," Mara answered bluntly. Adora refrained from rolling her eyes. This lady was being lovely to her and here she was, resisting the urge to act like a sassy brat.

"Uhm, which one?" She played with her hands, it was easier than looking at Mara directly.

"The Brightmoon Hospital."

This caused Adora to meet Mara's eyes, her eyebrow raised in amusement.

"Owned by Angella Brightmoon?"

"Micah, actually, but yes. It is owned by the family."

Adora nodded, she should've know they owned a whole ass hospital. She was glad, at least she knew she was being taken care of by people she could trust.

"Why am I here, exactly?" She sort of knew, but she wanted a full rundown of what was wrong with her body.

"Your neck's severely bruised, and cut. That's your primary injury, but you're also suffering from a continuous lack of sleep and multiple minor fractures in your arms and legs. Nothing to worry about, you'll be ready to leave in a week.

A whole fucking week. Thoughts of Adora's mountain of schoolwork flashed through her mind.

"You're friends have kindly dropped off your schoolwork. They instructed me to call you as soon as you were awake. Would you like me to?"

Adora was immensely confounded by the question. Why was she asking her permission to call her friends when they asked her to? She slowly nodded, and Mara mirrored her.

"What about Catra, where's she?"

A distasteful look finally crossed over Mara's features. Adora found it didn't suit her, and something sunk in her stomach.

"Catra requires special care at the moment, we don't know what happened to her. She keeps...glitching, as if she's hardwired to do something she can't."

Adora thought of the flickering neon eyes, and her heart froze.

"A chip? I think Prime might've put a chip in her. Her neck."

She didn't know the logic behind it, but it was the only viable reason behind what Prime was clutching in his fist. A programmed chip he was planning to put in Adora.

"I'll let my colleagues know."

She chuckled slightly, trying to break the tense air with something light.

"If you told me someone had a computer chip a week ago, I would've sent you to the psych ward. It's crazy, what he's done."

Mara sounded as if she was talking to herself rather than Adora, her gaze fixated down on her lap before she shook herself slightly.

"Sorry, I was just...an old student of his."

She looked back up, a watery smile on her face. Adora found something hidden in her eyes, clouded over with blue, but she decided not to pry.

"Well, now that you're awake, I'll be able to conduct some examinations to see how you're going. My wife, Light Hope will be coming soon, now that you're awake."

"Why?"

Adora definitely didn't know a 'Light Hope', so why was this lady coming to visit her?

"She's Angella's lawyer. Ms Brightmoon wishes to press charges against Prime, as she should, and wishes to reclaim ownership

over the academy."

A light swelled briefly inside Adora. At least something good had come out of this 'mission.'

A knock sounded on the open door, but the figure interrupting didn't bother to wait for a response. An old woman barged in, robed in a big fuchsia coat and...flowers?

"Mara, dearie!"

"Morning Razz," Mara smiled at the old lady, who peered at Adora through her large black rimmed glasses.

"Ah, this is Adora! I knew She-Ra would be great, and my she is. Almost as good as you, dearie!"

The woman, Razz, pinched Mara's cheeks. Adora looked at Mara with a questioning gaze, but the doctor only shrugged and offered an equally confused look back at her.

"How are you, dearie?"

Razz clasped her small hands together, looking at Adora with an expectant smile.

"Uh, doing better, thank you?"

The end of her words tilted up into a question, for she had absolutely no idea who this strange old woman was.

"I'd like to do some tests on Adora now, Razz, if that's alri-"

"No, no, no! I'll do them dearie!"

She waved off Mara's hand, who looked a bit taken aback when Razz adjusted Adora's position on the recliner, removing the supportive cushion that propped her up. Adora tried not to wince, she didn't want to hassle Mara and Razz too much, she'd be fine after a day or so.

"Razz was my professor back in college, and when I graduated med school, she somehow appeared here. I didn't even know she was a doctor," Mara said by way of explanation.

"Though, I never mentioned talking about you to her." Now Mara looked at her old professor in a bit of confusion, but she quickly brushed it off. Razz didn't even acknowledge the statement, wisened and experienced hands feeling around Adora's neck easily.

"Razz careful, it's only been a few days."

Adora blanked at this. A few days? A few fucking days?

"I was unconscious for days? As in MORE THAN ONE?"

The homework she must've missed, her friends. How was Catra? How were Bow and Glimmer? A sudden desperation to escape the warmth of the bed overpowered her.

"Yes, dearie! Not to worry, Razz will fix you up in no time. Razzle Dazzle!"

Adora was utterly perplexed by Razz, and was even more confounded when the old woman stepped away and her neck pains were next to gone.

"I-Razz-I feel-"

"Not to worry, anything for you dearie!"

Razz reached over with a loving smile, tenderly tapping Adora's cheek.

"I'll be back, the First Ones are expecting me!"

She scrambled off the bed (Adora didn't even recall her climbing on it) and scurried out the room with purpose.

"What did she say? First Ones?"

"Razz babble. Sometimes she says stuff that doesn't really make sense. I think she actually might've mentioned your name actually, called me 'Adora' the first time we met."

Mara did a few quick checks of her own, prodding at different areas on Adora's neck.

"She's damn good at her job though. You're almost back to functional."

Mara smiled again, setting herself down in the chair against Adora. She lightly looked over her arm, eyes stopping at a dark mark left near her bicep.

"What happened here?"

Adora glanced down, remembering Primes grimy fingers wrapped around her arm for a fraction of a moment.

"Him. He tried to take me, do the same thing to me that he did to Catra."

Mara frowned, her eyebrows creasing with some pent up frustration. She rolled up her own sleeves, multiple bruises lining along them.

"Me too. He never put a chip in me, I don't think he'd discovered that kind of tech when I was a student. But he-"

She paused, deciding not to continue. Adora watched her swallow, feeling her own lump grow in her throat.

"I put some balm on your scars too," Mara added gently. Adora instantly tried to reach behind her to feel for them, but her pain restricted her. She winced, and Mara tutted.

"Careful. I used one of my own personal remedies on them. Something I cooked up a few years ago."

She grabbed a mirror, reflecting it so Adora could see. The jagged lines had faded significantly. Still present that you could see them, but only if you examined her skin very closely.

"Thank you," she said quietly. She hoped Mara wouldn't ask for an explanation or some kind of story.

She didn't, and Adora was thankful for the silence.

"I'll call your friends after an hour, give you a bit of time to yourself if you'd like?"

"No!"

Adora coughed slightly, realizing how fast the word flew out of her mouth.

"Call them now please, if that's alright? I don't need any time by myself."

Mara nodded in understanding.

"Is there any news on Catra? When can I see her?"

She asked the question right before Mara opened the door. The doctor looked back at her, eyes shining in the light.

"Soon. I'll let you know."

Adora nodded, feeling rather tired again.

"Thank you," she said quietly, and she meant it.

_____

Conversations and Interrogations

"I can't believe that happened."

Bow recounted the whole story for her, right from the beginning. Adora just listened in shock as he explained the holding 'room' he and Glimmer had been shoved in. Apparently Prime had been expecting her, and when Bow and Glimmer arrived he'd chosen to utilize them as bait.

"Describe it again, what did it look like?"

"Green, black, massive. There was a wall of mirror separating us, the weird music over the speakers, and no windows."

Adora tried to visualize it, realizing it definitely wasn't a classroom.

"Strange."

"Extremely," Glimmer chimed in.

"Did Mara tell you Light Hope's coming?"

"Yeah. I feel pretty useless doing nothing in bed, so at least I can give some information that will put Prime behind bars."

Adora played with the crisp white sheets, ruining the neat crease lines in the fabric.

"You've already done so much, your body deserves a break."

Bow perched himself on the arm of Glimmer's chair, wrapping a casual arm around her shoulders. Glimmer leaned into him slightly, as if it was a natural response, and Adora felt a pang at the thoughtless affection. She missed Catra, desperately. They'd just gotten a chance to be more open about their relationship.

"I've written down some stuff, but every time I try to concentrate for more than a few minutes my brain freezes. I just can't stop

thinking about him, about everything. Most of all Catra."

"They're conducting surgery on her tonight, to remove the chip," Glimmer said offhandedly. Adora nearly leaped out of the bed, sitting up straight at that news.

"What? Why has no one told me this?"

Bow shot a scolding look at Glimmer, who's mouth opened in guilt. Adora looked at her imploringly, waiting for a response.

"They probably feared you'd react like....well, this."

Adora grabbed a nearby bag, using it to take deep breaths when Bow snatched it off of her.

"You'll accidentally suffocate yourself doing that," he threw the bag across the room, fluffing Adora's pillows while forcing her too lay down.

"Surgery in the spine, in the neck? That's the worst kind. What's the survival rate on that? Glimmer, pass me my phone!"

Questions shot around her head as fast as they flew from her lips.

"Adora! Adora!"

Glimmer slowly lowered Adora's arms, which had been flailing around in distress.

"Catra is the daughter of the owner of this hospital, she's being treated by the best surgeons."

Glimmer had a point, but even the best surgeons could make mistakes. And one mistake could cost Catra her life.

"Yeah, it's going to go perfectly, don't worry."

Adora clutched both their arms, which had been held out in front of her for support.

"Thanks guys."

She tried to smile up at them, a flood of doubts threatening to crack through her walls.

———————

Another knock sounded at the door, and Adora flinched out of fright. She shook off her nerves, suddenly remembering Light Hope was appointed to see her.

Smoothing down the frizziness of her hair and regaining a semblance of composure, Adora answered.

"Come in!"

A tall woman entered, flicking on the lights briskly. Adora tried not to blink too much, she hadn't realized she'd been sitting in darkness for so long.

"Good Evening Adora. My name is Light Hope."

The woman approached her bed, giving Adora a further chance to judge her. Long navy tailored pants, and fresh white shirt, and a matching navy coat, the sleeves cut to form a cape silhouette. Light Hope had stern features, but soft silver hair that flowed down to her waist. She'd pinned it back, dark blue eyes finding Adora's.

"I'm sure we don't need to go through formalities. We both understand why my presence if required here tonight."

She sat primly in the cushioned chair, setting a tablet on her lap. Adora vaguely remembered Mara mentioning that Light Hope was her wife, and Adora couldn't begin to imagine the two of them together. Maybe the contrasting personalities somehow fit. She was sure many people couldn't picture her and Catra together, even she couldn't for some time.

"Yes, I agree."

"Let's cut down to it then?"

Adora nodded, matching her firm presence in order to distract herself from thoughts of Catra. Glimmer and Bow had said her surgery was tonight, as in...right now.

_____

"Is that everything?"

"Everything important."

Adora had smartly committed the parts that were more intimate than others. She didn't want a recount of all of their conversations and actions published in every paper and magazine. Still, she'd told Light Hope a fair bit, more than enough to give Prime a sentence. The woman narrowed her eyes, as if scanning Adora with them.

"I'm not a fool to believe lies Ms Gray, so please; continue."

"That's all there is to it."

"I'm a lawyer. Your body language tells me a lot, but your tongue can tell me more."

Adora refused to look away from the cold blue eyes, that would only prove Light Hope was correct. And she was, but there was no way Adora was telling her everything. That was private, she had a right to keep her and Catra's interactions to herself.

"I don't think you understand. Anything and everything you tell me is invaluable. It could be the difference between a one year sentence or a five year sentence. Do you want to be the reason Prime is walking free for longer than needed?"

"Look, you're right. I'm not telling you everything about what Catra said to me, but that's because it was a private conversation and it's not going to interfere with the case."

"Can you at least inform me of the nature behind the relationship?"

Adora didn't hesitate.

"We were friends. Just friends."

"I find that hard to believe."

"Well then that's your problem, not mine."

"You speak in past tense. Add words that aren't necessary."

Adora was getting severely irritated with this woman.

"I don't need an English lesson right now. I've told you what you need to know, you can leave."

Hope ignored her, charging on a firing path with only one goal in mind. Discover everything.

"Not quite. If you and Catra had a platonic relationship, why did you sleep in the same bed?"

"Have you never slept over with a friend? I've slept in the same bed as Glimmer, and she's dating Bow."

"According to your social media profiles, you're attracted to women?"

"And? Look, I have no interest in being interrogated right now."

"Catra is also confirmed to have an interest in women. I just want the truth from you Adora, there's no harm in it. I need to know everything about everyone involved in the situation in order to present my case to the best ability."

"What does my relationship with Catra have to do with Prime?"

"You mentioned that you believe Prime used Catra as 'bait' to attract you to his school."

"It was actually Bow and Glimmer," Adora corrected. Hope was twisting her words, and she knew it.

"Of course, my mistake."

"Is that it then?"

"To what extent did you say Catra and yourself were romantically involved?"

"I never said-"

"Oh, didn't you?"

This woman was a master at gaslighting, and it was pushing down on every nerve left in Adora's body. She remained utterly calm too, her face barely changing expression as she spoke.

"If you're so fucking nosey, then fine. Yes, Catra and I were somewhat romantically involved, but it was never public, and I'd much rather I announced it before some gossip magazines do."

She was practically fuming with annoyance, but that didn't deter a hint of a smile appearing on Light Hope's face.

"Wonderful. I'll ask again, to what extent were you romantically involved?"

"What? I-"

"Have you two had sex?"

Adora actually got out of the bed, her feet wobbly and head slightly dizzy from moving so fast.

"Excuse me, but this is highly inappropriate. If you aren't going to leave, then I will."

"Ah, so you have?"

Adora glanced at the bedside lamp, gauging how much trouble she'd be in if she flung it at Hope's ridiculously meticulous head. She didn't, if only for Mara's sake. How was such a kind woman married to her?

"Thank you, Adora. That's all I desired."

Hope nodded curtly at her, head bowing slightly. Her satin white heels clicked against the polished wood floor as she walked.

"Good night, I'll expect to visit soon."

She firmly shut the door behind her, Adora just gaping at the wall.

Without a single moment of hesitation or thought, she flung the lamp at the door.

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Odd Talents

"Can I see her? Please? Even if she's not awake, I just need to make sure she's-"

"Yes."

Adora was stunned into silence, Mara checking something off a clipboard.

"I'll take you to her now, don't worry Adora."

She held out two palms, providing a solid support as Adora lifted herself off the mattress. She'd barely slept the past night, but the few hours made a difference. Her muscles were stronger, and she wasn't dizzy anymore. Just a bit weak, something Mara said was a side effect from the painkillers.

"Thanks. How is she?"

"I don't know actually, I wasn't assigned as her doctor."

"So who was?"

"Micah."

Adora blinked, she was fairly sure that Micah was an overseas entrepreneur, working on multiple brands and projects under the Brightmoon name.

"He's a doctor?"

"Surgeon, but yes. I did tell you he owns the place right? Why wouldn't he work here?"

Mara snuck a sly smile at her as they walked, and Adora shrugged. Sometimes rich people just owned establishments and didn't step foot into them.

"Thought he was some business mogul," Adora mumbled, not realizing Mara was listening.

"Oh, yeah. He does that too, this is more a sideline job. I think he put off traveling when he had young kids, but once Glimmer and Catra started attending the school..."

She trailed off, the rest of the story able to be assumed. Adora nodded, heart fluttering as Mara knocked on a light oak wood door.

"Come in," a weak voice answered.

Adora let Mara push the door open, but the doctor didn't enter the room with her, letting Adora go in by herself before slowly enclosing them together. Adora waited a few beats.

"Hi," she said shyly, eyes bouncing around the room.

"Hey," Catra answered meekly. She scrunched her legs together, folding her arms over her knees. Slowly, Adora moved towards the edge of the bed. She didn't dare sit, but she was closer.

"I missed you."

Tears made their way to her eyes, and she forced them down. Seeing Catra, her gold and sapphire eyes back to their vibrant hues, it was cracking something inside of her. Warming her heart again.

"I missed you too," she said softly. She looked tired, bags under her eyes and hair ragged, but Adora didn't care. She was back, she was Catra. Then she heard a sniffle, and Catra put her head down quickly.

"You came. You didn't just...leave."

Adora took a step closer, coming around the side of Catra's bed.

"Of course I came. I can't leave you, not again."

Catra looked up at her, their eyes meeting for the first time. Adora nearly lost her breath as she saw them, shining under the bright lights of the hospital. She let the tears run, hand flying to her mouth as she stifled a sob.

"I didn't think I'd see-"

She took a moment.

"I'd see you again."

She witnessed a few of Catra's own tears come out, through a blurry film of vision.

"Too far," Catra mustered. Adora instantly moved closer, climbing onto the bed and slipping herself under the sheets. She wrapped an arm around Catra, that wonderful familiar warm sensation growing in the base of her stomach once again. The butterflies had been dormant for far too long. Catra hugged her as Adora squeezed her shoulder, the two of them silently sobbing for an endless stretch of time.

The tears finally receded, leaving Adora to feel wet and mangled, but she didn't care in the slightest. Catra momentarily lifted her head off Adora's chest, turning to look at her.

"I like your heartbeat," she murmured, gaze falling from Adora's eyes to her lips. Adora didn't miss the drop, her own eyes drifting across Catra's face, soaking in every feature of hers like a sponge.

God she's gorgeous.

"Nah, that's you."

Had she said that out loud? Adora didn't really care...No, she certainly didn't care when Catra was looking at her like that.

"You have the oddest talents."

Adora's head now lay in Catra's lap, her girlfriend's fingers weaving in and out of her hair.

"Uh huh, and what are they?"

Adora looked up to find a smirk on her face, an eyebrow expertly arched. She rolled her eyes with a lazy smile.

"Not those talents, but you're definitely the master at that too."

Adora grinned at her, tempted to wink. She didn't, instead continued on her trail of thought before she forgot.

"I meant the fact that you can look hot doing just about anything."

Catra snorted, wrapping a lock of hair around her finger.

"Go on."

"Not if you're gonna gloat."

"I won't gloat."

"Yes you will."

Catra released the piece of hair, letting it fall back down on her legs.

"Yeah, you're right. How can I resist gloating when the Adora Gray calls me effortlessly sexy?"

Adora scoffed at the tone.

"For the record, I did not say 'effortlessly sexy.'"

"It still proves you like me."

"I did not say that because I like you!"

Adora opened her mouth in mock defense, earning herself a laugh from Catra.

"Alright, go on though. I wanna hear this."

Adora settled her head further in the girl's lap, Catra giving a pointed look as she did.

"It's something I kinda noticed from the beginning. Like you're a fashion genius and all, but you could literally wear a trash bag and make it look hot."

"That sounds like a rather generic compliment."

"But it's true! There you were like a green eyed demon, and half the time I was thinking fuck she's hot."

Catra snorted again in a small fit of laughter. Adora light hit her stomach, mockingly annoyed that Catra wasn't taking her statement seriously.

"I don't think anyone else would think of me like that, but thank you," she said finally, wiping a few tears of laughter from her eyes.

"Have you seen your Instagram comments? People have made edits of you!"

Catra smirked down at her, tucking a free piece of hair behind her ear. Adora narrowed her eyes suspiciously.

"Oh you know you're hot, you just want me to say it," Catra shrugged, the smirk expanding. Adora grabbed a cushion, shoving it in Catra's face with a roll of her eyes.

———————

"Sorry to disturb you," Mara spoke as they drifted down the corridor, once again approaching Adora's room.

"It's alright, I get it."

Micah and a team of specialists had to conduct a few tests on Catra to ensure she was psychologically sound. Adora was fairly sure she was, but doctors had their own procedures they needed to carry out.

"Light Hope...She had-"

"Look, I know she's your wife and all, but some of the stuff she said yesterday..."

Adora trailed off, wondering if it was right to speak against Mara's wife. She certainly wouldn't like it if someone started saying mean things about Catra in her presence.

"Hope can come off a bit...strong, to put it lightly. But she's a good person, Adora, and she does have your best intentions at heart, even if she comes off a bit cold and intrusive."

Mara didn't seem to take any offense, lifting a bit of weight off Adora's shoulders.

"On our first date, she asked me my intentions behind bringing her flowers."

Mara smiled fondly at the memory, Adora feeling one of her own lightly spreading across her face.

"Let's say I wasn't surprised when she told me I was her first girlfriend."

They reached Adora's door again, her legs feeling a lot more strong than they had when she first walked over.

"You should be good to be released tomorrow at 10am, but I've the teachers and I agree you should have at least 2 days of no classes. Just recovery mode. I've also got a list of neck excersises I'd like you to do, but I'll go through them with you before you're discharged."

Mara looked up from her clipboard, her eyes assessing Adora's reaction.

"2 days is plenty, I wouldn't mind going straight to classes though. I kinda miss it."

Mara didn't look perplexed at the prospect that Adora wanted to return to class, but she didn't consider it.

"I'll be asking Bow and Glimmer to look after you, your body could use a good break Adora."

Another kind smile opened up on her face, the lady surprising Adora with a quick hug before leaving.

_____

Chops.

"Hey, I have something to show you."

Catra came around Adora, seeming to appear out of thin air. Bow and Glimmer looked over at her curiously, but Catra only had eyes for Adora, sitting down next to her on the table.

"Nah uh, this one's for my muse, and my muse only."

Bow mock pouted, Glimmer pulling him out of his seat with a sassy tug. Adora quirked an eyebrow at her girlfriend, eyes scanning her momentarily. Catra had spent most of their allocated "rest" time finalizing designs for the show and coordinating backdrops and other various design elements.

"Muse, huh?"

Adora waggled her eyebrows at her, earning herself a small whack from Catra.

"Shut up and listen to me, dummy."

Up until now, Adora had been doing her fittings with a blindfold, and they were only a few weeks out from the show. She was glad Catra was finally clueing her in into the piece she was going to wear.

"I'm only showing you this because I need you to practice your walk, oh and I need to make sure you're comfortable wearing it."

She said the last bit out in a slight rush, causing Adora to be a bit suspicious.

"Why would I not be comfortable wearing it?"

Catra looked down busily, opening up her tablet while nervously biting her lips.

"Catra?" Adora pushed. She blushed, Adora narrowing eyes in suspicion. She'd reach over and grab Catra's device for herself to just look at, but she knew Catra would most likely scratch her eye out if she even attempted to take a look in her design portfolio.

"What the fuck am I going to be wearing?"

She leaned on the table, Catra raising a palm, telling her to 'wait.'

Adora obeyed, Catra finally relinquishing the tablet and sliding it across the table. She conveniently avoided Adora's eyes as she looked down.

Holy-

"Catra."

"Adora."

"You can't be serious," Adora couldn't help but stare at it. A beautiful design, but one she could never pull off.

"Oh, but I am."

"This isn't me, I can't wear...that."

"Firstly, it's not a 'that,' it's a creation. Secondly, it's not meant to be designed for you, it's to fit the theme."

"Which is?"

"Can't tell ya, sorry love."

Adora ignored the flutter she felt from the endearment, pushing it aside to focus on the discussion at hand.

"You literally said you based your whole design off me."

"I did."

"So you think this creation represents me."

"You if you had...style," Catra shrugged. Adora was flabbergasted at the insult, opening and closing her mouth in shock.

"I have style!" She defended, looking down at herself. Currently, she wore a cropped sleeveless hoodie, sneakers, and leggings. Athleisure definitely counted as style, in Adora's opinion.

"Mhm, sure you do."

Catra made a few finishing edits on the drawing, her condescending tone causing Adora to feel quite affronted.

"It's okay, you're still cute. Even more so now that you're all grumpy."

"I'm not grumpy," Adora mumbled. But she most definitely was.

"I actually based a lot of this design off She-Ra, you know-"

"The warrior who went by the alias Adora, yeah yeah, I know."

Adora found she was getting a bit sick of hearing of this 'She-Ra.'

"Is it ready yet?"

Catra looked up and faced her, eyes pausing on Adora's blue ones for a few seconds.

"Huh?"

Adora gestured to the tablet sitting in front of them.

"The actual thing, is it finished?"

"Oh, no. Almost, though."

Catra flicked off her tablet, crossing her legs on the seat.

"I'm bored. I hate no classes."

"Are you? You've been drawing and sewing every minute of the day. Starting to think you'll leave me for your sewing machine."

Adora was still slightly sour at the style related comment, but she tried her hardest not to let it show. Catra saw right through it though, smiling at her as she got up and wandered around to the back of Adora's chair.

"Suffering from lack of attention huh?"

She hummed, looping her arms over Adora's shoulders and around her neck. Carefully, the cut on it still sensitive to touch.

"Maybe," Adora leaned slightly into the touch, annoyed at herself for being so soft.

"Sounds like someone likes me," Adora was too enraptured by that scent to disagree. Catra planted a kiss on Adora's head, the touch promising something more, something she'd receive when they were alone.

She drifted back into her seat, flicking through her phone.

"People are going nuts for us. I thought it was bad when Bow and Glimmer got together but wow-"

She paused, eyes widening as she shook her head. Adora scooted her chair closer, looking over her shoulder.

"What are they saying?"

She knew some of it, saw the floods of new followers, likes and comments after Catra posted a photo implying their relationship.

"Nothing too out of the ordinary. I just didn't expect this many people to care about who I date, they never did in the past."

Adora still didn't have the courage to ask about Catra's past relationships. It somehow felt invasive, even if she knew Catra would willingly tell her if she knew Adora was interested to know.

Catra frowned again at her phone, pulling a cord of hair with annoyance. She shook it out, putting her phone on the table while Adora watched, eyes fixated.

"You're staring," Catra spoke without glancing at her, hands still running through the long dark waves.

"I know. You look pissed, I'm trying to figure out why."

Catra finally stopped, looking back at Adora with startled eyes.

"How the fuck do you read me that well?"

"It was kind of obvious, don't give me too much credit."

Catra knotted her hair up in a low bun, pulling her sleeves down her hands before rubbing them together.

"It's my hair. That's pissing me off."

"Phew, thought it was me."

Adora placed her palm over her heart in relief, Catra raising her eyebrows with a smile.

"You perpetually frustrate me. But right now, my hair is annoying me more."

Adora shrugged, mindlessly taking out her own device.

"Then cut it."

Catra was silent for a few moments, Adora barely realizing until she turned back to look at her.

"Wait, you're gonna do it?"

"I was just thinking about it. It's just-"

Catra paused as Glimmer and Bow came back near their table, the two of them eyeing the pair of girls cautiously.

"I don't care if you're done or not, I needa eat."

Glimmer plonked herself down on the chair, Adora letting out a breathy chuckle as she delved into her plate of macaroni and cheese.

"Fair enough," Catra swung her leg around the chair, straddling it while folding her arms across the top edge. Adora's eyes watched the movement, her face heating up when Catra caught her. But she only nodded her head slightly, offering a signature wink before moving on as if she didn't just fire up every nerve in Adora's body.

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"Voila," Catra entered the dorm, doing a spin as Adora held up a palm. She was deeply invested in a algebra question, and Catra had been far too much of a distraction since she entered Adora's life. She distantly heard a few mutters and mumbles from her back, but promptly ignored them. It was already eight o'clock, if she wanted to try and go for a walk tomorrow morning she needed to get to bed on time.

"Yes?" She propped her leg back on the floor, taking off her glasses and turning to face Catra.

As soon as her eyes landed on her Adora's jaw very nearly dropped, her gaze hungrily taking in the new cropped hair and face framing pieces. It was so well done Adora debated if Catra was a secretly talented hairdresser, or if this was just her being unreasonably attractive. Probably a combination of both.

"I-Oh my-It's-" she was at a loss for words, Catra's smile slowly becoming wider until she looked like the Cheshire Cat.

"You like it?"

Adora shook her head, simultaneously annoyed by her cheekiness and still in awe at how good she looked.

"I love it," she finally got out. Right at that moment, Glimmer exited Bow's room, running a comb through her hair. The brush fell onto the ground with a thud as she took Catra in.

"You are definitely too hot for me," Adora said, unable to even look at her textbook anymore.

"I disagree," both Glimmer and Catra said at the same time. They both turned to look at the other, Catra raising her eyebrows and crossing her arms against her chest.

"Should I be worried?" Catra teased, a light grin still on her face. Glimmer didn't look the slightest abashed, tilting her head while matching Catra's expression.

"We already share the parents, what's one more thing?"

Catra wobbled her head and stuck her tongue out at Glimmer, her sister mimicking the expression. Adora cleared her throat, causing their attention to flick back onto her.

"The thing wants you both to leave. I have homework to do."

Catra waved the excuse off, settling down in Adora's bed. Glimmer followed suit, Bow wondering out of his room to see what all the commotion was about.

"Oh my god, you look so cute!"

He squealed in reaction to Catra's new hair, sitting next to Glimmer on her bed.

"I am not cute. Call me that one more time and watch what happens."

Bow discarded the threatening glare, continuing to gush over Catra's hair as if he was looking at a newborn kitten or something.

"Why'd you do it anyway?"

Glimmer grabbed an art magazine from her bedside table, flicking through it while she spoke.

"Prime-well..."

The mention of Prime instilled ice in the air, freezing all of them in their places.

"He sort of used it," she looked down, playing with her rings. Adora once again abandoned her books and glasses, joining Catra on the bed. She looked up again, with a bit more determination.

"Dragged me sometimes by my hair. It just felt dirty, you know? Being washed in that water, tied up with plastic."

Catra still hadn't talked about what happened at Prime Elite, and Adora didn't dare push her. This was the most she'd heard in the past week, and only this small amount turned Adora's stomach to lead.

"That man deserves hell, I swear that motherfucker will pay."

Something darkened in Glimmer's eyes, something that was foreign for Adora to witness.

"Agreed," she said firmly, wrapping a comforting arm around Catra.

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Shades of Blue

The final week before Catra's show was something Adora had never witnessed. She'd been dutifully ignoring Shadow Weaver's calls, texting her one word responses. She'd found 'exams' to be a good excuse.

She didn't feel guilty because she technically wasn't lying. The memories of Prime had abandoned her mind for some time, her head to heavy after the long days to even contemplate everything that had happened in the last month or so. Instead she threw herself into her studies and friends, Catra doing the same with her fashion.

"Another day down," Adora finished ticking off the date on her calendar, her chest racing as she noticed the English exam was less than three days away.

"I've only done four practice essays, I'm fucked."

A deep groan was stifled as she flopped onto the messy beds, her hair coming loose and she scrunched her face into the sheets.

"Four? I've barely finished doing one," Glimmer momentarily glanced up from her project, before looking back down at her workspace on the floor. She'd given Adora full use of the desk, claiming to prefer the pale pink carpet.

"That's cause you spent fifty hours doing art, Glim," Bow paced up and down, his lips moving but quiet mutters coming out of his mouth. Adora looked at him intently, trying to catch a glimpse of what he was reading aloud to himself.

"Bow?"

"Can you all shut up? I need peace."

Catra had taken off her headphones momentarily, glaring at them from her corner in Adora's bed.

"I wore the Adora's fat overhead ones and I can still hear you blabbing. Thought this was meant to be a study session?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes, making a gesture with her hand.

"If you want so much quiet, go back to your dorm," Bow answered.

"Lonnie's out, I don't want to be alone," was Catra's only reply. Bow's mouth opened and closed, the piece of paper he was holding waved about as he expressed his incredulity.

"She's moody, let her be. Whatcha reading Bow?" Adora responded, wondering back over to her desk.

"Oh, uh, I'm meeting my dads tomorrow."

Adora exchanged a look with Glimmer, Bow clutching his piece of paper even tighter.

"I'm going to tell them I want to not be a historian. For real this time."

His lip quivered, about on the verge of tears, and that only started a similar response in Adora.

"Bow! I'm so proud."

She got up from her desk and approached him, wrapping her arms around his tense frame.

"Thanks. I just hope they'll still love me, you know, not disown me or anything."

"They will," Glimmer assured him, also getting up from her work area.

'And even if they don't, I will."

Adora floated back to her desk as Glimmer wrapped her arms around Bow's middle, the couple embracing for a few quiet

moments.

"Adora, I need you," Catra called out, a bit too loudly due to her headphones. Adora gave a lopsided grin, jerking her thumb at the girl nestled in bed behind her.

"Hear that guys? My lady needs me."

Catra shook off her headphones, widening her eyes meaningfully at her.

"Coming, I'm coming. Sheesh," Adora clambered on the bed, walking on it before plunking herself besides Catra.

"What?"

"Stay still."

Adora didn't bother refuting the instructions. Catra had been like this all week, and Adora understood, the Fashion Show was coming up, and it seemed like a big fucking deal. Everyone knew Catra was the Head Organizer now too, Angella practically broadcasting it on television. That just meant more pressure, and no one liked pressure.

"Thank you. I need you tomorrow night for a final fitting, " Catra muttered, dismissing Adora to return back to her desk.

"Final fitting?"

Catra glanced up again, surprised to see Adora still beside her.

"Oh, yeah. The piece is finished, we just need to make sure it fits well."

Adora nodded slowly, quickly tucking both of Catra's loose bangs behind her ears. The movement must've disturbed her, for the focussed eyes flicked up slightly in annoyance.

The urge to retreat crept up on Adora, but she firmly stayed put, ready to take anything Catra would say to her. She was moody, but Adora wasn't going anywhere because of it. The eyes softened slightly, Catra taking a moment to drop her tablet pencil and tuck Adora's loose hair behind her ears. Wordlessly, she nodded, and returned back to her work.

_____

"It's...strong," Adora said finally. On the mannequin it looked brilliant, the fabric shapeshifting in the dim light of the room, small hidden diamonds flashing at her from various angles. It was stunning, but she knew she'd look awful in it. It was better suited to even Catra herself, dark hair and bright eyes.

"Strong? Really? That's the best word to describe it?"

Adora leaned over to run her hands over the surface, only for Catra to slap them away.

"No touching. You are literally going to just put it on, and then take it off."

Adora huffed like a petulant child, watching Catra carefully take it off the mannequin.

"It still doesn't look like it would be designed for me."

Catra's sharp gaze cut through hers, throwing a look that sent a very clear message.

Well I'm the designer, and I say ITS FOR YOU.

Designer intuition is often wrong.

Is not.

You'll see when I put it on.

"Adora," Catra broke out of their silent conversation, her tone biting.

"I'm just warning you. It's all dark and sexy, and I am definitely not dark or sexy," she ignored Catra's expression as she spoke.

"You see this?" She pointed to silk blue accents wrapped around the sleeves. It reflected elegantly when she shifted the outfit, light shining on them.

"Yeah?"

"I spent days contacting manufacturers for fabric that looked like this, and it took weeks for it just to arrive. Why do you think I searched endlessly for this hue of blue?"

"I feel like you're my teacher right now."

"Do you know?"

Adora stayed silent, eyes snagging back on the silver blue material.

"Because this fucking color, this blue, is yours, Adora. It's your eyes. This belt has an 'A' in it, if you look closely."

Adora peered down, the intricate silver belt unable to decipher. Catra pointed out the letter to her, and Adora felt something sting her eyes.

"The design is based off your namesake, and the cut is entirely based off your figure and what flatters you. So don't even think about giving me this shit. This is your piece. You gave me the inspiration for it."

Catra was red in the face, flushed with both anger and from speaking so passionately. It brightened her features, the light in her voice, the way she pointed out and explained small details no one else would think twice about. Adora just gaped, unable to comprehend or even think of some response.

"Well?"

Catra waited, her eyes expectant as her cheeks cooled. Adora quickly shook herself out of it, launching herself at Catra with the speed of an athlete, which she technically was.

The girl squealed in horror and surprise, flinging the clothing piece onto a nearby workbench before it got squeezed between both their bodies.

"Watch the creations, Blondie!"

Adora just smiled, holding Catra closer to herself in satisfaction.

_____

Prime Puppet

"Catra, darling, why so stressed?" DT purred as they rounded the corner, Adora chewing on her lip like gum as she sped up.

"I don't know anything, this is gonna be awful-"

"Adora, calm down! You're freaking out, so I'm freaking out, and WHEN I'M FREAKING OUT I DON'T KNOW WHAT TO DO!"

Catra's voice raised as she shook her folio at Adora, the large black thing overshadowing her like a slate of cement.

"But it's Textiles! The last one left too."

Adora direly wished she could skip time in that present moment. Her final exam for the semester, and then she'd be done for a blissful few months. Catra didn't look nervous, but Adora knew she was on edge with the Show coming up in only a few short weeks.

"How are you so chill DT? The play's in a few months, and I'm definitely not ready to ditch my script."

Catra mumbled , her words barely registering past the large black folder. It was practically half her size.

"You won't need to, not yet. And I've got my timeline all mapped out."

"Organized fucker," Catra grumbled under her breath, clutching her folio tighter to her chest. Adora resisted the urge to snicker, knowing she'd only earn herself an elbow to the stomach.

"Come on ladies, we've got this."

DT winked at them a final time, the doors of the examination hall coming closer, and closer, and closer...until all of a sudden Adora was right in front of them.

"I'm fucked."

Catra grinned beside her.

"So's the world, it's alright."

_____

Adora flopped onto her bed, groaning in happiness into the soft sparkly pillow. Catra sauntered in after her, dusting her hands off as she kicked the door closed.

"That was aggressive," Adora mumbled, twisting her neck in curiosity. She spotted Catra leaning against the wall, a chunky leather boot resting against the cream colored door.

"I'm in an agressive mood."

Adora flipped onto her back as Catra approached her. She was tired, but she was never too tired for this. Especially when Catra had that goddammit snarky smile spread across her face.

Adora sweared she was carved by the gods themselves.

"Oh?" She breathed, Catra straddling her on the bed. Her centre tightened, something igniting in her chest as Catra pressed closer on her body. Adora instinctively rested her hands by Catra's hips, slipping under the hem of her fabric to rub small soothing circles on her skin.

"You love to torture me, don't you Blondie?"

Adora sighed in content, murmuring something that could barely be deciphered by her own ears. She thought she might've heard Catra purring, if it wasn't for the bang of the door closing.

"Adorraaaaa!"

Bow singsonged as he entered the room, his eyes momentarily closed before they flew open to reveal....well, Adora and Catra.

The pair just stared blankly at him, the thought to detach didn't cross either of their minds. It took Bow a moment longer than necessary to realize, and when he did-

"OH FUCK NO, NOT AGAIN."

He bolted out the door, sending the girls into a fit of laughter. Catra rolled off of Adora, wiping tears from her eyes.

"Poor guy, he's already had it rough with Sea Hawk and Mermista," Adora got out in between breaths. Glimmer walked in with raised eyebrows, Bow shielding himself and his eyes behind her.

"Stop traumatizing Bow, the both of you."

She rolled her eyes with a bit of boredom, but a lightness lined her features..

"Get ready, we have a post exams party to head too."

"A post exams party?"

Glimmer yanked Adora with her arm, earning herself a raised look from her friend.

"Duh?"

Adora looked back on her girlfriend, who dodged her eyes suspiciously.

"Catra?"

The laughing had ceased, came to such an abrupt halt yet Adora hadn't noticed it.

"I think I'll sit this one out, you guys go ahead though."

An instant frown pierced Adora's lips as she watched Catra glance at her phone.

"You sure? I'll stay with you."

Glimmer let go of her arm, letting Adora drift back down to the bed. Catra gave her a sympathetic smile, shaking her head slightly.

"Nah, it's alright. Go ahead, I'm fine I promise. Just...need to make a call."

The frown deepened, but she trusted Catra enough to leave her by herself for a few hours.

"Okay, if you're sure you're alright with that? I'll come back soon, you can stay here if you'd like?"

Her hands quickly drifted towards the array of cushions spread along the duvet, propping and fluffing them up to meet Catra's needs.

"Thanks, I could use some alone time."

Adora nodded suspiciously, oddly familiar with 'alone time.'

"If you're sure. What do you plan on doing?"

Glimmer joined them on the bed, Bow slowly peeking out between the cracks of his fingers.

"I think I'll have a chat with Scorpia," Catra said, meeting Adora's eyes again. Adora took a breath and nodded, feeling a hand latch softly on her shoulder.

"God, you're not gonna see your girlfriend for a few hours, get over it!"

She joked, shaking Adora's shoulder slightly. The blonde forced a chuckle, throwing Catra one last look before getting up to peruse her closet.

A party hadn't occurred in a while. It didn't feel like they were celebrating much, but at least Prime was soon to be locked behind bars...If that Light Hope woman managed to do her job and stop snooping into every damn person's-

"Whatcha wearin'?"

Bow appeared next her, having come to take a peak at Glimmer's clothes. The pair of them loved to share clothes.

"Not sure."

Her eyes skimmed the different colors of fabrics, gaze finally landing on a white turtleneck and her favorite letterman jacket.

"How was meeting your parents, by the way? Sorry I couldn't come."

She pulled out the articles of clothing, opting for her turtleneck with cutouts over the plain regular one. Leather pants or black shorts? She glanced outside the window, weather looking breezy but not too cold.

"It's alright. They were weirdly chill with the whole 'I don't want to be a perfect son' thing. They actually said they'll help sponsor me to build my own architecture business one day."

Adora's head whipped around in surprise, seeing Bow's eyes shining in the bright light of the small room.

"Oh my god, Bow! That's amazing," She grinned at his expression. The thought of Shadow Weaver briefly passed her thoughts, but she shoved the idea of being President out of her mind. She didn't need to ponder on that.

"I know!"

Envy pulled at her, but she wouldn't be a puppet to her emotions. She was glad for Bow, truly and sincerely.

"Definitely leather pants,"

Bow glanced down at her hand, which was clutching the long neatly ironed pants. She looked down in surprise.

"Okay," she put the shorts back down with a shrug, leaving the shared wardrobe to head into the bathroom.

_____

The party could've bored Adora to death, to say the least. It wasn't very different to the ones she experienced prior, and she enjoyed meeting her friends again after a bit of separation, but it just felt...off. Everyone was distant from her, talking tentatively and walking on eggshells when she was near. She'd thrown a look at Glimmer, but neither her or Bow seemed to know why everyone was acting so odd. Finally, DT arrived.

"Evening, darling," they purred, sipping from a red cup. Adora gave them a hug back, glad someone out of her immediate group of friends was treating her normally.

"Hey DT."

"Why so glum? Chin up."

They lifted Adora's chin with a mocking smile, but Adora didn't mind.

"Catra's not here," she tried to avoid pouting.

"I was wondering where Kitten was. Come sit."

Adora was pulled over to a set of armchairs, DT continuing to inhale the drink as if their life depended on it.

"What's happened now?"

They leaned back in their chair, stretching their legs into a languid position as their curious gaze wondered over Adora's face. She

couldn't tell if they were just fishing for gossip or genuinely concerned, but if she gave a piece of information, they'd reward her with some of their own.

"Law suit against Prime, it's a big deal."

DT scoffed, tipping their head back in a shrill laugh.

"Darling, everyone knows that!"

She stared at them blankly, was that why everyone was giving her weird looks?

"Really?"

"It's a headliner. Angella Brightmoon Fights for her Legacy!"

DT spread their fingers wide in the air, as theatrical as ever.

"Oh, sorry. I haven't been in the news much."

She shrugged, silently declining the drink offered to her. DT frowned at her lack of energy.

"Apologies honey, I didn't know you didn't know."

"No one's asked me any questions about it, so I just assumed it was private."

DT just mumbled under their breath, Adora forced to lean in to hear them.

"Anything Light Hope's involved in does not stay quiet. She's one of the best lawyers in the country."

They polished off their drink with a swig, Adora refraining from rolling her eyes at the mention of Light Hope. That conversation would most definitely remain private for now.

"I'm gonna go check on Catra."

Her leg bounced with uneasiness as she excused herself, DT making a gesture with their hands that signaled their understanding. She waded through the small crowd, not that it was difficult. People backed away from her as if she'd contracted a disease or something. Remembering Glimmer and Bow, she quickly sent them a text telling her she was returning to the dorm.

"Back so soon?"

The voice settled the uneasiness in the pit of her stomach, and she shook off her coat with relief.

"Party was boring without you to look at."

She smirked with a wink, catching a hint of Catra's blush in the darkness.

"What've you been doing?"

Her legs slipped under the sheets of the bed, Catra instantly nestling into her side as she yawned.

"Designing. Best to do it when I'm tired and emotional."

Adora looked down, tilting Catra's chin up at her to get a proper look at her face. Even in the dimness, she could detect the faint redness in her eyes.

"I shouldn't have left you tonight, I'm sorry."

She sighed, her heart sinking a bit at the thought of Catra crying alone in the dark.

"Don't be. I'm not a child, Adora, it's fine."

Her voice had a slight edge to it, but Adora let it slide, not willing to engage in a fight right now. Silence stretched between them for some time, Adora gently rubbing circles with her thumb on Catra's back.

"Stressed? The show's soon."

"Very. And Mom wants me to make a statement about Prime. A public one defaming him. Light Hope's been pushing."

"Why don't you?"

A thoughtless question, Adora realized as she felt Catra tense under her arm.

"Why don't I? I don't know? Maybe because he fucked with me and I don't want to expose myself as a weak Prime puppet to the entire fucking world? Maybe because I don't want to be babied and coddled and scrutinized by the media? Just maybe because I'm sick of being involved in this entire fucking MESS?"

Her voice had gradually gotten louder, and her face stung painfully as she turned away. Adora was too struck by the bitterness she couldn't speak, only stared with her mouth slightly agape.

"I turn eighteen in a few months, why the fuck am I dealing with this adult bullshit now?"

"I'm sorry," was the only thing Adora could think to say.

"Whatever I say, do, post, think will be up for debate. I just-"

She climbed out of the bed, running her hands through the newly short strands of hair.

"I'm sick of it, I'm sick of everything."

"I'm sorry," Adora said again, void of anything else to say. She kept murmuring the phrase, wrapping her arms around Catra's tense shoulders. The girl relaxed instantly, albeit only slightly. She whispered in her hair, fervently wishing there was something she could do, some way she could help.

———————

Anything for My Dearie

"Adora, what're you wearing for the Gala?"

Glimmer whined as they sat backstage, Adora watching DT rehearse Catra's lines with her.

"The Gala? Is that soon?"

Glimmer stared at her agape, holding up her phone with a digital poster loaded up on it.

"Uh yeah!"

She nodded her head indulgently at her, Adora scanning the print on the document.

Holy shit. It was only a month away.

"Fuck, I haven't even thought about it. What are you wearing?"

"I was going to a consultation tonight with my designer to help figure it out. You'd better come with me."

"Sorry, Glim, but I can't afford a professional designer. I'll just buy something from the store," she shrugged, but Glimmer's reaction told her that she'd just said something highly inadequate.

"Oh no, no, no, NO! Adora, you do not wear something from the store to the gala."

The blonde looked at her friend with raised eyebrows and narrowed eyes.

"Your privilege is really showing right now, you know?"

She meant it lightheartedly, but something inside of her nagged. Everyone in this school was famous, or special, or kids of special people at least. She was nothing compared to the students here.

Glimmer's expression melted slightly and she took a seat beside her.

"Look, it sounds pretentious, but this Gala goes in the media, it's everywhere. You're going to have to entire world judging whatever you wear."

"So what do I do? I'll just skip it."

Her heart sunk slightly, everyone had been talking up the gala ever since she'd come to the school.

"No, that's stupid. I'll bring you with me to my consult, free of charge."

She winked, and Adora quickly shook her head. She refused to be a charity case to her rich friends.

"No, no, that's fine. Getting your designer to make me something unique will probably be too expensive."

Glimmer waved it off with enviable ease.

"Nah, it's all good," she winked but Adora continued to just shake her head.

"Let me put something towards it, I'll get a part-time job!"

She had seen an advertisement for staff needed at the school gym. Apparently they didn't have enough staff to monitor it during after school hours, so now they were looking for students. She was fairly sure Mermista would hire her without a doubt.

"Sure, if you want to. But really, it's no stress."

Adora nodded, glad she was at least making some sort of contribution towards the funding of her outfit.

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"Dearie, dearie! Come in, come in!"

The door opened to...Razz?

Yes, it was Razz. The same Razz from the hopsital had now appeared before their eyes, adorning a silk robe and slippers too big for her knobby little feet.

"Razz? You're a fashion designer?"

"She's the best in the city, designs the clothing for everyone in the family."

Glimmer hugged the woman with familiarity, and Adora hesitantly did the same when the kooky old woman held out her arms for her.

"She was at the hospital, an experienced doctor," Adora whispered in confusion to Glimmer. Surely you couldn't spend majority of your life building two careers. One was difficult enough.

"Come, now Mara, we do you first."

Razz led Adora to the back of her shop, Adora marveling over the ribbons and lines of fabrics swatches around the place.

"What about Glimmer?"

She couldn't even see her friend now, Razz had pulled her to a colorful corner of the room. One that was partially hidden with gauzy pink curtains.

"Absolute privacy during consultations, Mara, dear," she giggled, and Adora paused in telling her she was Adora, not Mara. It wouldn't make a difference.

"You know that," she lightly tapped Adora's nose, brandishing an ornamental tea pot with the fresh scent of vanilla permeating the air.

"Uh, okay?"

Adora gently accepted the tea, taking a sip before even asking what kind it was. It was sweet, with a tint of caramel and the distinct flavor of licorice. Somehow, it worked. Adora had never tasted anything like it before.

She glanced around the enclosed space, Razz taking the comfortable seat in front of her, with an opalescent table separating them. Already there were sketches laid out before her, and Adora frowned in confusion, leaning into the soft violet cushions that surrounded her.

"I thought Glimmer didn't tell you I was coming with her?"

Razz hummed, clearly lost in her own ideas to give Adora any mind.

"Oh, no, dearie. Of course not."

Unlike most designers, Razz didn't have a single piece of technology in her studio. Just stacks and stacks of old paper, some tea stained, and others covered in rose petals.

"How did you manage to make all of these so quickly if you didn't know I was coming?"

"Oh but I did."

She tapped a long withered finger against her head and winked at Adora.

Yes. She winked.

"Now, violet or buttercup?"

"Excuse me?"

Adora was all the more perplexed at this weird quiz. Razz had spontaneously pulled out a clipboard, and looked up at her expectantly, as if the odd question was the most dire query in the world.

"Quickly, dearie. Violet or buttercup?"

Her tone wasn't urgent, but the wide eyes blinked through the frame of thin wired glasses.

"Violet, I guess? Wh-"

"Honey or lemon?"

"Lemon," Adora said without thinking. She quickly shook her head, wondering where that response had come from. She gulped down her tea, wanting it to scald her throat so she could recollect her thoughts.

It didn't. The fluid rather soothed her throat, drifting through her body with a steady calmness.

"Blue or gold?"

"Both."

She couldn't choose between those two. They were both perfectly exquisite.

"Ooh!"

She furiously scribbled something down, grabbing a few of the sketches from the table and clipping them onto her big clipboard.

"Sunrise or Fireflies?"

"Sunset?"

"Mhm mhm..."

A few more strokes of her pencil and she turned the clipboard towards Adora, showcasing the-

The most elegant design Adora had seen. For herself at least.

She was expecting something very weird, with stray violets coming off a headband or maybe a weird patchwork of blue and gold squares...but this was simply perfect.

"Woah."

Razz didn't let her reach out and touch the paper, but she could examine it well enough from her seat.

"Can I take a photo?"

Razz nodded and Adora pulled out her phone, sending the image to her friends as well as Shadow Weaver. She knew her adoptive mother would want to see what she plan to wore.

"What color would it be?"

Razz didn't speak, just shoved her way through the sheer curtain and sticking her head back in when Adora didn't instantly follow suit.

"Come on dearie! We don't have much time."

Adora quickly got up from her seat, not realizing Razz expected her to follow.

The brilliant woman led her through rows and rows of fabric and various materials, combing through a good few and muttering to herself before finally yanking out a soft periwinkle blue tulle, a matching silk to go with it.

"Ah hah!"

She pulled out a shiny silver thread, and other silver beads to decorate the fabric with. It was breathtaking, the quality of the fabric and materials. She'd never felt anything quite so pure...but it felt wrong.

Not the design. When she glanced back at the artwork it was perfect. It was the color scheme.

The blue was too delicate, the silver far too ethereal.

Razz's face fell as she watched Adora's expression.

"Oh no! What's wrong, Mara dearie?"

Adora smiled gently at her, feeling the fabric another time.

"It's Adora, Razz."

Razz blinked hard, staring at Adora all the more through the glasses.

"Adora? Adora!"

If Razz could scream, this was it. Some odd yet thrilling piercing noise that shot through the air like glitter.

"Oh no, no, no! Not for Adora!"

One minute she was there, standing in front of her, and the next she was out of sight. Adora just stayed where she was, too scared she'd end up lost if she tried to find Razz or even Glimmer.

Razz returned shortly, her arms filled with rolls of a pearly white cloth and various gold chains.

"This! This for Adora, dearie!"

She reached out and touched it, already knowing the fabric was practically made for her. The glowy, yet subtle sheen of ivory, the feathered heaviness of the roll. This one was her's.

"Perfect. Thank you, Razz."

She beamed down at the older woman, who reached out and simple pattered her cheek.

"Anything for my dearie."

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Hey Pretty

When the holidays finally approached them, Adora's anxiety began to peak. She hadn't seen Shadow Weaver in a good few months, and in just a few short days she'd be arriving on her doorstep, ready to spend some long lost "bonding" time with her adoptive daughter.

"Adora, calm down! She can't be that bad, right?"

Glimmer looked at her with an expression of both concern and distress. Adora had been waking up almost every night this week, clad in sweat and on the verge of a breakdown. Being the one to live with her, Glimmer had been taking the brunt of her stress with her.

"No, she is very much that bad."

Bow handed her a glass of water, taking the seat next to Glimmer on the couch. Adora ran her hands through her hair.

"Have you told Catra-"

"Sh, sh, sh, do not make me more stressed than I already am," Adora waved a threatening finger at Bow, who sighed and turned to exchange a look with Glimmer.

"You know you have to tell her, right? She can't find out by Shadow Weaver just suddenly running into her on school grounds."

"I'll tell her...eventually. I need to figure out how I'm gonna deal with it first."

It was strange to think that she used to live with that woman, that Shadow Weaver was her entire life at one point. Now she'd much rather the woman stayed at a distance than come visit her.

"Hey guys."

Adora shot up at Catra's voice, the girl casually walking into the lounge and swinging the door closed. She took a bite out of a muffin, a blueberry one by the looks of it.

"Why so stiff?"

She talked around the mouthful of food, meeting each pair of eyes that averted her own. Adora felt her latch onto her own, and she couldn't bear to look away.

"What's happening?"

A sense of urgency carried through the room, and Adora knew she had to tell her. It was already overdue. Shadow Weaver had booked the tickets for her flight a week ago, and Adora had been avoiding Catra for that entire week. It was driving her insane.

"ShadowWeaverIsComingToBrightmoon," she said in one breath. Catra blinked, taking a moment to decode her words.

"Shadow Weaver?"

Adora nodded.

"Is coming? To school, to this school?"

She looked just about ready to hurl up that single bite of muffin, and Adora wouldn't blame her the slightest if she did.

She didn't dare to speak, but she felt three pairs of eyes watching her and that was worse.

"Uh, yes? Only for three days though."

Now she couldn't dare herself to look directly at Catra, only fleeting glances that told her everything she needed to know.

She was scared. Deathly terrified, and so was Adora.

"Room. Now."

Adora didn't need to be told twice, watching Catra get up and leave without a moment of hesitation. She closed the door behind them, taking a deep breath to gather whatever shreds of strength she'd saved.

"How long have you known?"

"A week."

"What day is she coming?"

"Tuesday."

Catra swore under her breath. It was currently Thursday. They had about four days to prepare for her.

"And what the fuck took you this long to tell me this? What excuse is it now, huh?"

She scoffed, massaging her temples with closed eyes. Adora couldn't think of a single response to her question.

"There is none. I screwed up, okay? She sprung it on me."

Catra's eyes flew open, a little less bright than they were before.

"Yeah, you're right. You did screw up."

Adora couldn't help but be a bit affronted, taking a shallow step back from the girl. Catra instantly softened, loosening her expression and dropping her hands with an apologetic gaze.

"Sorry, I'm being a bitch-"

"Yeah."

Adora didn't wait for the rest of whatever Catra wanted to say, finding her feet moving towards the entrance door. She needed to go to the gym, do a run, whatever.

It had been a while since she'd had a regular training regime. She'd gone on recovery walks, small runs to test herself, but she hadn't felt the compulsive urge to just throw herself into a workout in a long, long while.

Catra didn't try to stop her as she left the dorm with her bag and water bottle, opting for a weights session over cardio. The weather wasn't in her favor, the sun was glaring at her even from the shelter of a window.

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The gym was mostly empty, except for...Scorpia?

Adora remembered her last conversation with Scorpia, and a sour taste filled her mouth. She didn't quite like her, but she'd been staring for too long and now the woman's eyes caught her own. She couldn't just ignore her now.

"Scorpia," she said matter-of-factly. No saltiness, no judgment, she didn't feel like being explicitly rude.

"Adora," Scorpia nodded back at her, and Adora suddenly felt silly for walking over here in the middle of the gym while Scorpia was in the middle of her reps.

"Uhm, I'm gonna-"

"How is she?"

Scorpia interrupted her, the question escaping her throat as she stared at Adora with wide eyes. Adora required no further elaboration to know who she was enquiring about.

"She's been better. But not horrible."

Scorpia nodded again, a bit of relief making its way into her dark eyes.

"Sorry about earlier. I'm just protective, and Catra spent years getting you out of her system."

"She did?"

Years was a long time. But Adora was never really over Catra herself, even when she arrived at the Academy.

"Years on you, and she's still not over Shadow Weaver."

Adora couldn't meet her eyes at that revelation.

"Adora?"

"What?"

"What are you hiding?"

"What?"

Adora was so caught off guard she was sure she'd misheard Scorpia.

"You're not looking at me directly, your hands are hidden from my view, your body language claims you're hiding something."

Adora looked at the woman in front of her, whose expression was one of smothered smugness.

"Shadow Weaver might be visiting me soon. Here. On school grounds."

Scorpia's smug smile faded as she heard the news, her eyes falling.

"Adora. Do you understand what that woman-"

"Did? I know, she did-does it to me too," she snapped. She couldn't help herself, she didn't want Scorpia to assume Shadow Weaver's visit wouldn't affect her as well.

"Hey, hey, it's alright. I'm not blaming you or anything, she's a horrible person. You have nothing to do with it. Just...look out for each other, 'kay? Especially when she's around. She'll try to manipulate your relationship, and I know you don't want that."

"I don't," Adora mumbled, unable to meet Scorpia's gaze. It was the one thing she was terrified of. Shadow Weaver getting in her head and screwing up everything she'd built with Catra.

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"Hey Pretty," Adora sneaked up behind Catra, wrapping her arms around her cautiously. She wasn't sure if Catra was still angry with her or not, but the girl instantly relaxed in her arms, and Adora felt her heartbeat begin to slow to a regular pace.

"I'm not happy with you," Catra huffed, but she didn't resist when Adora hung her head over her shoulder.

"I'm sorry. I had a chat with Scorpia."

This forced Catra to turn her neck and look at her, both eyes slightly wide at the news.

"You saw Scorpia?"

"Yeah, she was in the-"

Adora was about to say "gym" when she realized she never actually figured out why Scorpia was in their gym. She didn't work there, and Catra didn't know she was around so she wasn't there to visit her.

"Yes?"

"The gym, she was in the gym, I'm just trying to figure out why."

Catra looked as surprised as Adora felt, her eyes narrowing in thought.

"Yeah, I got nothing for that. I haven't forgiven you...yet."

Adora pouted mockingly, squeezing her slightly tighter as Catra leaned backwards into her.

"What do I have to do to make it up to you?"

Catra hummed, Adora feeling the vibrations from her throat.

"I may have just a few ideas..."

She trailed off, Adora smirking as she grazed her nose along the length of Catra's neck.

"Is this one of them?" She murmured against her skin, planting a slow kiss on her jaw.

"May-"

She cut herself off as Adora continued, replacing words with a soft sigh.

"Mhm, that's what I thought."

Adora leaned back momentarily with a smile.

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Visits from Home

"It's going to be alright, it's going to be fine, everything is going to be-"

Her phone vibrated on the table, the screen illuminated by a familiar image. Adora felt her heart plunge as she quickly picked it up, her fingers shaking slightly. She took a breath before answering, not trusting her voice to be even.

"Hello?"

Silence for a second on the other line. When was the last time she'd picked up Shadow Weaver's calls so quickly? She couldn't quite remember.

"Adora! I'm on my way right now."

Her heart stopped beating altogether.

"Your plane already landed? You're here? In Brightmoon?"

She glanced at the door, half expecting Shadow Weaver to barge in right there that second, clad in her long black robe and silk mask.

"My flight was last night, I'll be there in about twenty minutes.

Twenty minutes. Twenty fucking minutes.

That's all the time she had left to prepare herself. She nervously tugged at her own hair, pulling the strands hard to distract herself.

"Right. Okay, twenty minutes. Sure."

"Where can I meet you? I'll drop my luggage off in the hotel and come straight to the school."

"Meet me? Oh, uh, in the courtyard. The one with the statue."

"Alright. I'll see you soon, Adora darling."

She fought the urge to cringe at the old pet name, recalling a time where she longed to hear it.

"Uh huh, see you soon."

She quickly hung up the phone before Shadow Weaver could say anything else, releasing a slow breath. Glimmer and Bow had left the dorm to give her some privacy for when Shadow Weaver arrived, and Catra....Well, Adora wasn't entirely sure where exactly she was, but it was probably her dorm.

She gently pulled the hair tie out of her hair, knowing Shadow Weaver wouldn't approve of the up-do. She always admired the flat smoothness of Adora's hair, the way it fell limp over her shoulders. And she always despised Catra's wild curls, the inability to tame or control them.

She rested the hair tie on her table, looking up at herself in the mirror.

Wide, frightened blue eyes looked back at her, her hair falling over her face. She was starkly reminded of her first day at the school, when she was shy and timid and scared of the goddamn world. The sudden urge to break the mirror overwhelmed her, and she had to take a slight step back to steady herself. Her eyes shot up to the reflection again, and this time she was greeted with something stronger, something with a bit more substance. The fear in her expression was replaced with anger, and that was a more preferable sight to behold.

She shook herself out of a daze, checking her watch for the time. Fifteen minutes, she needed to get ready.

The table had been cleared of her devices and sewing machine, a small vase taking up the space. She'd smothered Lonnie's old P.T books with a blanket, the item of betrayal locked in her closet behind rows of clothes and shoes. Everything had been spotless, all traces of fun and freedom eradicated.

She gently peeled off her jacket, the one Catra had made for her some time ago, stripping off her shirt to grab a more suitable one. Something plain and simple, something expected of her. Her eyes couldn't help but crawl towards herself in the large bathroom mirror, scars and old marks shining brightly in the bathroom light. She ran her fingers over them gently, the way Catra always did, and took another shaky breath. Each mark held a different story, she didn't have the time to recounter them in her mind.

She could do this, this was endurable. It would be a few days, and then she's gone. She'd leave Adora to the comfort of her friends in her new home.

Her old clothes were swapped for new ones, and she pulled the hairbrush through her hair roughly before leaving the dorm, ready to meet her adoptive mother.

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She clenched and unclenched her fists, the biting air pulling and itching at her face. It was warm, the sun bearing down on her as she struggled to stay in the shade. She checked her watch again, momentarily worried that something had happened to Shadow Weaver. She was already five minutes late, and Adora knew Shadow Weaver was never late. Without thinking, she pulled out her phone, ready to dial her when a cold chuckle surprised her. She nearly jumped out of her skin, her neck prickling as a hand wrapped around it affectionately.

"Adora! It's been so long."

She succumbed to her grip, forcing herself to lean in as Shadow Weaver closed in for a hug.

"Hi," she stammered awkwardly. How does one greet their caregiver after several months of ignoring them?

Shadow Weaver ignored her darting eyes, lifting her chin to examine her.

"My, my, my, look how you've grown. My darling Adora," she turned her cheek both ways before releasing her grip. Adora forced herself to unclench her jaw, trying to show an expression of poise, neutrality, and submission. Three things she knew Shadow Weaver would value above all.

"Come, I want to see this school I'm paying for."

She laughed, the sound cutting through the air as if innocent, but Adora knew better. It was a threat. She could translate it in her mind.

Let's see if it meets my approval. And if it doesn't? Well...

What happens if the school conveniently falls below Shadow Weaver's standards? Adora is pulled out.

She trotted awkwardly beside her, Weaver gliding while Adora struggled to keep pace. She wasn't short by any means, but Shadow Weaver always towered over her, physically and mentally. Perhaps emotionally too, if Adora was being honest.

They'd reached the dorm corridor, and so far hadn't met anyone of importance. Adora held her breath, knowing she wasn't entirely clear until they reached the privacy of her own room. Bow and Glimmer weren't coming back until nightfall.

But there was no such luck.

Just as they rounded the corner, mere seconds away from reaching the safety of that pale blue door, Catra brushes past.

Fuck.

Adora didn't know how to react. Catra was obviously distressed, holding her sketchpad with a pencil tucked behind her ear and uniform rumpled...Wait, why on Earth was she wearing her uniform on the weekend?

Adora itched to ask her questions, but their eyes met and she knew it'd be too dangerous. She was already moving past them, out of Weaver's reach when-

"Catra?"

Adora felt her skin prickle at her voice, the nostalgic way she said Catra's name. It was always long, each syllable enunciated to its maximum.

"Do I know you?"

Catra's voice held a bristle of its own. One that seemed to have developed over the long years of being in the spotlight, adored as the adopted child of two celebrities. It was a practiced tone, one Adora knew was specially reserved for people she deigned to speak to.

"Oh? I see. Still as insolent as ever."

That word nagged at Adora, and it wasn't even used against her. She was impressed at the blank stare Catra gave, untucking the pencil from her ear to spin it in her fingers absentmindedly.

That was distracting, to say the least.

Adora watched the ice blue and pale yellow eyes meet Shadow Weaver's dark ones, trying not to marvel at Catra's nerve. She was always the only one that could oppose Shadow Weaver, and Weaver hated it.

"Excuse me, I have places to be."

The pencil found its way back behind her ear, and Adora stared in awe as Catra pushed past them, her eyes flitting towards Adora for a fraction of a second.

Don't worry about me, Adora tried to communicate through her eyes in that split second, but she doubted Catra picked up on her silent message.

"Your report has arrived," Adora tried not to let her breath hitch at the tone. She hadn't much bothered to even glance at her grades since being entangled with the Prime drama, was too scared to even take a look.

"Perfect, as predicted."

Shadow Weaver clasped a cold hand around Adora's shoulder, and the girl resisted the urge to shiver and lean in at the same time. She could never figure out her emotions with Weaver around, it was too confusing to be in her presence for more than an hour at a time.

"I've already booked us a seat at a nearby caf-"

"Wait, I thought-"

"Adora."

That tone, the inclination, it shut her up instantly. She didn't even have to think, her mouth just closed with the hidden command. She'd interrupted her, and she'd never done it before. Adora felt her cheeks heat with embarrassment, her eyes avoiding the dark ones behind Weaver's mask.

"As I was saying, I've booked us a seat at the cafe," she continued. Her voice had resumed its original pace, and the small mistake Adora had made was ironed out by the crispness of Weaver's words. It was as if Adora hadn't said anything at all. She'd tidied up her dorm for nothing, forced her friends to leave their home for the day so they wouldn't have to meet her. Annoyance simmered on her skin, hot and penetrating. Before she could quench it with her fear, the words ran out of her mouth; disobedient and thoughtless.

"I tidied my dorm today. I thought you'd want to see the school, where I'm living?"

The question was innocent enough, if it wasn't for the anger mixed in her voice. Shadow Weaver paused, turning to face Adora

fully. She raised an eyebrow, lifting a hand to rest beside Adora's neck.

Adora fought the urge to flinch with everything in her, raised her eyes to meet the ones above her. The gentle grip tightened slightly, Weaver's thumb pushing Adora's chin up to examine her. She did this a lot when Adora was younger, but it had been some time since then.

"My Adora, you've grown some wings? Precious."

Her nail dug into the soft skin at Adora's neck as she spoke, the words coated in honey. To anyone else it sounded affectionate, but to Adora it was only condescending.

"If you would like me to come visit your room, then I will. But after we visit the cafe, I've already reserved us a table."

She released her grip on her, offering a flash of teeth before turning away. Adora waited a few seconds, glaring at her adoptive mother's back with narrowed eyes.

"Come Adora. We mustn't be late."

Back was the tone, and Adora could do nothing but simply follow her.

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Just a Pair of Besties

The following days passed by at an agonizingly slow pace. Each hour dragged, and it was a stark contrast to Adora's previous holidays, where she spent long days in the snow with her friends. Shadow Weaver had yet to spot Bow and Glimmer, and Adora desperately hoped it would stay that way until she left the following morning.

"And how's your dress? For that Gala event?"

Adora shook herself out of her thoughts, focussing back on the woman in front of her. They were currently seated a tea-place. You'd think the room would be adorned with champagne colored curtains and lace table cloths, with bite sized sandwiches and spongy cream cakes. Weirdly enough, it was quite the opposite. Instead, onyx chandeliers dripped from the maroon colored ceiling, blood red drapes substituted doors, and the lights were dimmed even at twelve in the afternoon. Adora forced herself to take a bite into the dense cake. It was rich and bitter, the heavy chocolate cream filling her mouth. She swallowed.

"I've already got it sorted. Glim-..a friend," she amended, "is helping me out."

She set down her cutlery decisively, meeting Shadow Weaver's eyes for the first time in the outing.

"I see, and what about my consultation? I haven't heard you mention this dress once."

Her gaze sharpened, tone like a blade. Adora didn't look down, for that was only admitting defeat.

"It's mine, and it's my event to attend. It doesn't concern you, mother."

Glaring would be taking it too far, so she settled for an eyebrow raise.

"Doesn't concern me?"

For once, Adora was glad they were in public. The dark eyes left Adora's to glance down at the unfinished cake sitting under her.

"Finish your food. I didn't raise a waster."

Adora permitted herself a glare at the cake, and clenched the thin desert fork with silent venom. She stabbed a piece, raising the bite to her lips, and chewed.

Shadow Weaver didn't smile.

"Good girl."

_____

"I hate her I hate her I hate her I-"

Adora silenced Catra with a frenzied kiss, pinning her errant hands to the wall behind her. She quickly broke it, meeting the cool blue and glowing gold in the darkness of the small closet.

Shadow Weaver had taken to visiting Adora in the night, she'd somehow acquired a key to the girl's dorm. Glimmer got so disturbed the first night it happened that she'd slept with Bow in his enclosed room ever since. Adora didn't blame her, but she missed her friend.

Hence why Adora now met with Catra in the middle of the night, in an old cleaner's closet.

Adora reached out and shoved a nearby mop in her peripheral vision, wanting nothing to distract her from the sight right in front of her.

"I hate her too," she breathed, eyes roaming Catra's face.

"That bitch needs to get the fuck out of here. And soon."

Adora chuckled, glancing downwards for a few seconds.

"You're hot when you're mad. Did you know that?"

"Yes."

Adora tilted her head, pressing Catra's wrists harder into the wall.

"Someone's cocky."

Catra matched her expression before expertly freeing herself from Adora's death grip and slamming the blonde against the wall, hard.

Catra leaned in close, lips brushing Adora's ear as that beautiful, tempting scent surrounded her.

"Something wrong with that?"

Adora felt her breath hitch and her heart skip a beat. Her mouth struggled to string together a coherent sentence.

"No, ma'am," she whispered finally, unable to meet Catra's eyes as she slowly leaned back.

"Thought so."

The smirk didn't fade, and neither did the heat of the moment. Adora moved closer to Catra as she leaned back, eyes never leaving her's. Catra teased, something Adora noticed she loved to do. She despised it, all the teasing did was remind Adora of the power this wonderful, wicked girl had over her. And that power freaked her the fuck out.

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"I'd like to meet your friends."

"My what?"

Adora nearly choked on her orange juice, slamming her laptop shut. This conversation required her full and utmost attention. No way was Weaver getting within an inch of Bow and Glimmer.

Adora had managed to keep a fair amount of distance between them, and it needed to stay that way.

"The pink girl and that other one. The boy."

"Their names are Bow and Glimmer," Adora gritted out. Shadow Weaver spoke with such disdain that it elicited something fierce within her.

"And Catra, too."

This time she actually did choke.

It took a while to recover, her throat burning with the sensation and orange juice clogging her nose. Shadow Weaver came around the table and hit her back in an attempt to help. It just made it worse.

"Catra?" She managed to wheeze, eyes watering profusely as the burning lessened slowly.

"Yes. I'd like to meet her, all of them. I have a final day here, I need to see what you're being influenced by."

"I have an arrangement with Light Hope today, and another with Madame Razz in the evening. I don't think we'll have time...unfortunately."

The 'unfortunately' was used to ensure Weaver couldn't detect any sort of relief.

But Weaver waved a clawed hand at her, chuckling in response.

"Nonsense, I'll sort it out. We can have a simple farewell dinner for me."

"Won't you feel like you're babysitting? Having dinner with a bunch of teenagers," Adora muttered under her breath, unsure if Shadow Weaver even heard her. But she did.

"No. It's settled, Adora. Tell your friends to cancel whatever useless plans they have."

Adora glared down at the table, resisting the urge to smash her glass of orange juice and ruin the ornate tablecloth Weaver had brought from one of her trips in Mystacor. That familiar grip fastened around her chin again, and Adora fought a wince. Her face couldn't help but lean into the touch, even relish it. Her eyes met her adoptive mother's and Shadow Weaver used her other hand to brush a few stray hairs behind Adora's ear. She'd made her wear her hair out today, had critiqued the ponytail. Weaver said the hairstyle made her look young and stupid. She disagreed, but complied.

"Come now, child, we mustn't be late for our day plans."

Adora grimaced as Weaver's touch released her, and something inside her stomach unknotted. She gulped involuntarily, raising herself out of her seat to call her friends...and Catra.

"Adora, I can-"

"I get it. I do."

Adora stood in the crevices of the hidden classroom, clasping Catra's hands who fought too held onto her's. It was late, and she knew Weaver was expecting her back at her dorm, but she couldn't ask Catra to do this over the phone. She hated herself for even trying to persuade her, especially when Catra was looking at her like that.

"Do you, Adora? Really?"

Her voice was soft, tone void of accusation but the insinuation was still there. Shadow Weaver had always had a soft spot for Adora.

She rubbed comforting circles on the back of Catra's hands, the motions calming her down as much as they were Catra.

"It's okay. I'll...deal with it."

The trip had been tolerable so far, Weaver was deficient of alcohol so Adora was safe. But dinner tonight, she didn't know how well she'd fare. At least it was the last night, and by tomorrow Adora will be able to return to normal. She hated sneaking around to meet her girlfriend, making her friends avoid their own dorm, barely seeing anyone except her fucking adoptive mother.

"Deal with it?"

Catra's eyes flashed, gaze darting to Adora's shoulders where the scars had been. Dr. Despondos' cream had been working wonders, they were practically invisible now, even if the weight they bore was still very much prevalent.

"I'm coming."

"Catra, you just said-"

"I'm coming. Come on, we've got to get ready."

Something had forced it's way into her voice, pure decisiveness. Adora had only heard it rarely, but she knew trying to argue with Catra was futile. She wanted to come to dinner, so she was coming to dinner.

———————

Adora's finger hovered over Glimmer's contact, hesitating on whether to call her or not. She bit her lip in frustration, torn between protecting her friends or protecting herself. She put the phone down, Bow and Glimmer didn't need to see that part of her life...not yet.

"You're gorgeous," Catra whispered from behind her suddenly. Warm hands slid around Adora's waist as her girlfriend planted a

soft kiss on her shoulder, not quite reaching her head. Adora smiled to herself, clasping Catra's smaller hands in her own.

"Thank you," she spun slowly to face her, a soft gasp escaping her lips as she did so. Catra was clad in a black blazer, the material a soft, lush leather. Her chunky boots gave her a few extra inches of height, but she was still shorter than Adora, who had boots of her own on.

"All black looks very, very good on you," Adora murmured. Her eyes drifted down to Catra's lips, painted a tasteful maroon. Understated, but powerful.

"Tell me something I don't know, Princess."

Catra winked, showing off the smokey eyeshadow that framed the blue and gold irises. Adora would never get sick of those eyes, not in a million years. She took a deep breath, taking in Catra a final time and trying not to shake.

"Hey," Catra whispered. The light-heartened, teasing tone had vanished, replaced with concern.

"I'm fine, I-"

"Promise?"

Catra slid her arms from Adora's waist up to the back of her neck, fingers twined in the soft strands of her hair as she pulled their foreheads together. Adora relished the contact between them, the heady scent of musk and mint as she softly closed her eyes. Her breath instantly steadied, the simple movement of Catra's calming every nervous fibre in her body.

"Promise," she replied. Her voice was clearer, sharper.

They stayed there for a few moments, time coming to a standstill as Catra's arms shifted from Adora's neck, fingers trailing down the sides of her bare arms to intertwine with her own hands.

Adora latched onto Catra like a lifeline, drinking in the moment like she was dying of thirst.

"It's gonna be alright. It's one dinner," Catra reassured her quietly.

"You don't need to come. I've managed her so far already, one more meal can't hurt."

"She wants to see your 'friends.' That's Weaver Code for 'bring Catra,' and we both know it."

"What she did to you...It was far worse than anything she did to me."

Catra took a step back slowly, Adora lifting her head to peer at her curiously. Tactfully, keeping her eyes locked on Adora's, Catra unbuttoned the low cut blazer, revealing twin gashes on her ribs, deep cuts that Adora didn't remember seeing in the dark heat of any of the rooms they'd been naked in together. She stared, mouth agape, eyes flicking between the symmetrical cuts.

"Who? When?"

Steel hardened her voice, instinctively reaching out and running her fingers gently over them. Catra inhaled sharply and Adora met her eyes quickly.

"Sorry, I-"

"No, it's not you. Well it is, but I-"

She paused, seemingly at a loss for words.

"Don't stop. Please."

Adora nodded, unable to stop the tears dragging themselves out of her eyes.

"Prime did it, and it hurt ten times worse than anything that bitch ever did. I can handle her Adora, now I know I can."

Her voice was quiet, but firm. And it gave Adora the steady confidence she needed. Nodding in agreement, Adora gently removed her hands from Catra's cuts, buttoning her blazer up for her, and taking her time while doing so.

The air between them burned, their gazes drinking the other in.

"We don't have much time, she's coming in a few minutes."

"Long enough for this."

Catra reached up and met Adora's lips with her own, the kiss fervent and desperate. They needed it for the night they were about to endure.

They eventually broke apart, Adora's lungs struggling for air and the taste of Catra lingering on her tongue. She quickly checked the mirror, raking hands through messed up hair and reapplying her lip gloss. Catra did the same, grabbing her bag off a nearby chair.

"Ready to act like a pair of besties?"

Adora held out her hand for Catra to take.

"We're lead actresses for a reason, love."

Adora chuckled as she locked the door behind her.

"Don't call me that in front of her."

"Oh? What'll I'll call you then? How about-"

"Catra." Adora interrupted her in a jokingly warning tone. She could already tell where Catra's mind was heading with that mischievous tone.

"Adora," Catra responded.

She winked, their hands parting as the fresh breeze greeted them. Adora's heart pounded as they approached a sleek black car,

windows tinted. It slowly rolled down, the grinning face of Shadow Weaver greeting them. Adora forced herself to meet her eyes, but Weaver was looking past her...at Catra.

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Sugar Mommy Catra

"Interesting company, Adora."

They were seated at the dinner table, dim red and burnt orange lights glowing around them. It felt too warm, the heat of Weaver's gaze upon her. Catra reached out and put a hand on her thigh to steady her, and it helped. Immensely.

"I rather like it, thank you," Adora responded tensely, every fibre of her body on edge, even with Catra's touch to soothe her.

"It?"

Catra's tone was light and teasing, but in the atmosphere, it just put Adora even more on edge.

"Sorry. Her," she amended. The stress of the circumstances were clearly getting to her.

"You two were always such good friends, weren't you Adora?"

Weaver's question corresponded to the both of them, but somehow she communicated it only to Adora. It was as if Catra had vanished from the table altogether.

"Always," Adora replied. She smiled as a waiter appeared at their table, ready to take down an order.

"I'll grab some breadsticks, the ragu bolognese gnocchi and a side of the.... fried arrow squid. Oh, could I also grab a vanilla coke? And the lemon slice for desert, but if it's possible, could that come out later?"

Adora said her order in one large breath, trying not to shake as she exhaled. The waiter hurriedly wrote it down, flashing a smile before moving onto Catra, but they didn't get to chance to as Weaver cut in.

"That's quite a large order for such a young girl?"

Weaver's tone bordered on condescending and warning. Adora resisted the urge to gulp, wondering what she should cut out.

"If it's too much for you to pay I'm happy to cover the bill?"

For the second time in the night Shadow Weaver acknowledged Catra's presence, sending a cutting glare at the girl. Adora wondered distantly how Catra managed to hold such a persistent, focussed gaze. She'd shake if Weaver looked at her like that. But Catra didn't only maintain the stare, she had the sheer nerve to smirk. A small, taunting one that held for barely a quarter of a second. But it was there, and Adora couldn't help but look at her girlfriend in awe.

Gods, she was incredible.

"Money has never been much of an issue for me as it has been for you Catra. Just because you seem to have some now doesn't mean you have to thoughtlessly spend it."

Shadow Weaver scoffed, as if she was squabbling with an infant rather than an incredibly brilliant young woman.

"Apologies. It just seems that you can't even afford to feed your daughter. I, for one, don't see 'food' as a thoughtless expenditure. Adora, order whatever the fuck you want. I'll cover it since she can't."

Weaver's eyes narrowed behind the thin maroon veil, ice shining in the dark green.

"It's not the money I'm concerned about. I just doubt Adora can finish all of that, she's mindlessly ordering whatever's on the menu."

Catra scoffed, throwing down her napkin on the table.

"Have you seen Adora eat? Like, ever?"

"Should I just-"

The waiter interrupted them, seeming to sense the tension. Only an idiot could miss it. Adora nodded apologetically to them, asking for a few more minutes in a quiet voice. Catra snorted into her napkin, genuinely amused by the fact that Weaver didn't think Adora could finish that much food.

"Sorry, you can't be serious? This is Adora we're talking about. She could eat a horse if she wanted to."

Shadow Weaver looked affronted, leaning back slightly in her chair while staring at Adora. She didn't speak, preferring to take neither side, though she was furtively rooting for Catra.

Without a second glance at Weaver, Catra nodded, politely waving the waiter back to their table.

"Hi, sorry about the confusion earlier, " she began, not even glancing at Shadow Weaver. She tilted her head towards Adora.

"My friend here will grab everything she ordered earlier, and I'll get the prawn linguine with a side of the pomegranate salad, a lychee soda...and the pandan and coconut creme brûlée for desert. Thank you," she finished, passing up her menu. Carefully and deliberately, Catra folded her arms across her chest, resting on her forearms as she nodded to Shadow Weaver to make her order.

"I'll take a Caesar salad."

Catra didn't bother to hide the roll of her eyes, and Weaver gave Adora a pointed look.

Such disrespect.

Adora didn't silently reply, distracting herself with a sip of the coke she'd ordered.

How do you expect her to respect you when I barely do?

She didn't look at Shadow Weaver as the traitorous thought slipped into her mind, only set her glass back down and shift uncomfortably in the chair. Catra didn't remove her touch from Adora's thigh, and the girl was grateful for it.

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The twenty minutes of tense silence before the appetizers came out was by far the worst twenty minutes of Adora's life. Weaver didn't even try to entertain small talk, even though Adora fervently tried.

"-and now we're in a play, it's Macbeth, you know, Shakespeare?"

She was practically out of breath, and almost out of conversation topics.

"And I'm the lead! Me? Can you believe it?"

She choked on her own fake laugh, coughing into her napkin.

The sound of her own chatter sputtered out and Adora abruptly pushed her seat back, wood scarping against itself.

"Excuse me. I'll be in the bathroom."

She squeezed Catra's hand under the table, silently telling her not to follow. Time alone was very necessary with how tense she was feeling. Catra seemed to accept the message, for Adora was able to slip away completely unnoticed. She took a deep breath, thankful the bathroom was empty, asides for herself of course. The mirror stared back at her as she scrutinized her appearance. Weary eyes, faded makeup, flushed cheeks. She was a mess, but at least she wasn't crying. She washed her hands, feeling restless and shaky. She needed a distraction or she was going to be sick.

This was weak, she couldn't be weak. This whole week had been so good, Weaver had barely gotten under her skin. She couldn't let that bitch win now. Clenching her hands against to cool hard

edge of the stone bench top, Adora took another breath, attuning her senses to everything around her.

Mindfulness; Bow claimed it to help, and she found that it sorta did. Raking her hands through loose hair, Adora fastened it up with an elastic, ensuring the small poof was clearly visible. She ironed down her dress with sweaty palms, taking a breath before-

Before slamming right into the door. Could she look anymore idiotic? Adora fought the blush that creeped up her cheeks, glad no one witnessed her walking into a door.

Trying it for a second time, she actually used her hands, making her way back to the table.

"You motherfuc-"

"Catra?"

Adora interrupted whatever it was Catra was about to say, the girl whipping her head to face her so quickly Adora nearly had to take a step back. Perhaps leaving them alone at a table together was not a good idea.

"Adora! You're back," Catra's voice changed instantly. A combination of both relief and surprise.

"Come on, we need to leave. Now."

Catra tugged on Adora's sleeve, the girl looking at her in bewilderment.

"Leave? We've only been served our appetizers thou-"

"You won't be leaving like this. It's embarrassing."

Shadow Weaver hissed, leaning across the table and waving a finger at Catra.

"You and your public image. After what you just said-"

"Watch your tone."

"I'm not scared of you anymore, don't tell me to watch anything."

Catra's eyes flashed with the low hiss. It may have been the hottest thing Adora had ever witnessed.

"Adora, I'll explain later. Can we please leave?'

Adora nodded, not making a move to return to her seat. Catra looked towards her gratefully, and Adora choked down the urge to grab her hand.

"No. Catra can leave if she feels she must, I won't let you ruin your image, Adora. Not with your future in front of you."

"My future will be fine if I leave a restaurant with my friend," Adora responded coolly. She held out a palm to help Catra out of her seat.

"Presidents don't act like this."

Was she...smug? Adora couldn't help but gape. Shadow Weaver really thought she had struck a nerve or something. As if Adora gave a single fuck about being President. She wasn't exactly sure where her future lay, but it certainly wasn't in running a country.

"Good thing I don't want to be President."

She couldn't help but smile at the look on Weaver's face; pure shock. Her eyes latched on Catra's small smile too, and her's only widened.

"Goodbye mother," Adora turned, her hand refusing to let go of Catra's even though she knew she should.

"Don't worry, I'll cover the bill."

Catra had the audacity to wink, and Adora was amazed for the umpteenth time that night.

Agree to Simp?

Adora laughed as they entered Catra's dorm, unbuttoning the blazer as quickly as she could. Catra murmured something in her ear, something vague and not important enough to pay attention to, for Adora completely missed it.

"That was incredible, you were incredible," she whispered along the delicate skin of Catra's collarbone, grazing her teeth against it ever so slightly.

"Mm, I know."

The arrogance was enough to crack any self control Adora had, as she pulled Catra's body closer to her own. The girl made a noise of mock surprise, and it did nothing to soothe the pride within Adora. She truly was incredible. In no world could Adora do what she just did; face a former villain and prevail.

"Have I ever told you how proud I am to be your girlfriend?."

Catra broke apart for a second, taking a second to lock eyes with Adora.

"I'm proud to be your girlfriend."

Adora couldn't help the blush that set fire to her cheeks, no, her whole body. That was the effect of those words, of Catra's entire presence, on her.

This witty, intelligent, beautiful woman that she got to call hers.

"I love you," the words flowed seamlessly from her mouth as she met Catra's lips again, the emotion within them twisting and twirling in between the two girls.

"I've loved you since the moment I've met you," Catra sighed, as they stumbled back further, into the bed.

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5 missed calls from Shadow Weaver.

Adora deleted every single notification from her phone, hating that she had to leave the warmth of Catra's bed for her run.

"You bitch, don't leave," Catra whined softly from the sheets, her eyes slowly blinking open. Adora leaned over, planting a kiss on her head as a form of farewell.

"I'm off for my run, wanna join?"

She teased, knowing a run at five in the morning was definitely not Catra's style.

"Go later, stay with me."

Those words pained Adora, even if she knew Catra meant them lightheartedly. She wasn't really leaving her, after all.

"Can't, I have work after. My first shift."

Mermista had hired her without a second thought, even though Adora had spent hours perfecting her resume and getting her interview skills up to scratch. She didn't want to leave a bad impression by being late to her first shift.

"Good luck, you'll do...mmgreat."

Catra's words faded out as she yawned, digging her head further into the pillow so Adora could only see the messy crop of dark hair.

"Bye, Gorgeous."

She planted a second kiss on Catra's hair, murmuring the words softly before adjusting her baseball cap.

"Don't call me that," Catra wriggled, but Adora knew better.

"You secretly love it."

"Do not."

"You're a bad liar."

"Ugh, fuck off."

"Gladly."

Adora ruffled her hair one last time, softly closing the bedroom door behind her as she creeped out the dorm.

_____

"Adora! It's been a fucking year since we've seen you."

Adora couldn't even register what was going on until something warm and familiar slammed into her, crushing her in a hug.

"Glimmer!"

"What's new, stranger?"

Bow smirked, hugging Adora over Glimmer, who was in between them. She laughed, stuck between her two best friends and she wouldn't want it any other way.

"She's gone!"

She singsonged the words in a trill, wrapping her arms around Bow and Glimmer.

"And just in time too, Razz wants us to come in for a fitting. You stink, by the way."

Glimmer finally released her form the embrace, checking the time on her phone. Adora hid a smile as she noticed the screensaver, a picture of her and Bow from when they visited the snow together. That was certainly a memorable trip.

She fanned herself with her hands, rolling her eyes.

"Duh, I just did a run and work. My shift was great, thanks for asking."

Bow handed her some deodorant, not in am impolite way, but rather a helpful one. She smiled to him gratefully.

"Already? That was quick."

"With the Gala so soon, we're her highest priority."

Glimmer grabbed her keys...wait, keys? Adora stared at the shiny black remote with a pink ball of fluff hanging off the keychain, along with a glittery violet 'G.'

"Glim, since when did you have a car?"

Adora knew she had a car, of course, but she thought it was at Glimmer's house, not school.

"Dad flew it out here for me."

"Why now?"

Glimmer had been at school for years, had her license for years. Why was her car only being shipped out now?

"It was getting repaired, you know, from when I-"

She blushed a bit, nodding her head and rolling her eyes.

"Oohhh," Adora clued in, remembering Glimmer's accident. She'd heard about it briefly, but it must've been pretty bad for her car to be in repairs for so long.

"C'mon, we've got an appointment to get to."

Adora pulled out her own phone to call Catra, telling Glimmer she'll be a moment.

"What's up, Blondie? You finished oogling everyone at the gym under the guise of 'work.'"

Catra sounded jealous, but Adora knew she was joking. No one could even come close to compare to her.

"Someone sounds jealous?"

She played along, smirking at Catra's scoff.

"Me? Never."

Adora shook her head slightly, the smirk plastered to her face. It was crazy what just Catra's voice could do to her.

"Ugh, I hope we aren't this embarrassing."

Glimmer whispered not-so-discreetly to Bow, who snickered.

"You are," Adora broke off her conversation with Catra to wink at Glimmer, who simply rolled her eyes.

"Wanna come watch me try on my Gala outfit? Glim, Bow and I are going into the city for an appointment with Razz."

"As tempting as that sounds, I've got to finish some pieces for the show."

"But I'm trying on pretty dresses! I'm in desperate need of your expertise."

Adora mock wailed into the phone, dramatically flopping back wards on the bed. Catra's laugh was muffled as Adora flipped over, kicking her feet in the air like a petulant child. She simply was a petulant child.

"I'm sorry, Princess. You can spam me with fifty million photos, or better yet FaceTime me. I'd come, but a trip to the city would take up the whole day."

Adora pouted, knowing Catra was right. Her oh so important, fashion-designer girlfriend had to stay back and finish work like the responsible talented, fashion-designer girlfriend she was.

"Fine," she huffed with a bit of a frown.

"Text me."

"Always," Adora replied, hanging up as Glimmer flashed the time in front of her. They had to get going.

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"Ah hah!"

Razz spun Glimmer around again, the girl nearly going cross eyed with the motion. Adora was fairly sure Madame Razz was the only fashion designer around with a spinning stand for customers. Glimmer regained her composure, looking at the wide, detailed mirror in front of them. Adora made eye contact with her in the mirror, giving a nod of encouragement. The dress was truly stunning.

Folds of soft, pastel pink tulle glittered in delicate ribbons over her shoulders; a regal touch that made Glim look like a queen. She oddly fit the part, maybe in another universe she was one. The fabric was a gentle blue, made of silk with embroiled sleeves. What intrigued Adora the most was the décolletage neckline which suited Glimmer perfectly, framing the studded jeweled necklace she wore, and the sparkly silver heels.

"Remember dearie, it's not done yet. The skirt must be hemmed, the back is all wrong and-"

"It's gorgeous, Razz."

Glimmer interrupted her, bending down slightly to meet the old woman's eyes.

"Thank you, I love it."

Razz's wide pale eyes watered slightly and she blew harshly into a napkin, bringing Glimmer in for a hug.

"Oh dearie, you've gotten so big, just a second ago you're a tot and now you're queen. Oh it's-"

Did she just call Glimmer a queen? In a literal sense? Adora let it slide, Razz called her 'Mara' half the time.

"I know, Razz."

If Glimmer thought something was amiss, she didn't comment on it, simply continuing to embrace the old woman.

"You look amazing, Glim," Bow couldn't stop staring at her, making Adora smile to herself. People in love are cute, she thought to herself.

Glimmer blushed, untucking her hair from behind her ears.

"Ya think?"

"I know."

She waved a hand with a very unlike Glimmer giggle.

"Thanks!"

Adora mock rolled her eyes before squeezing them tight.

"Get a room."

"You think this is bad?" Bow snorted.

"Next time I'll record you and Catra and play it back to you when you aren't so love drunk."

Adora opened and closed her mouth, both shocked and abashed.

"I am not love drunk!"

"Tell it to the wall, honey," Glimmer raised her eyebrows at her before turning back into the dressing room with Razz to change back into her regular clothes.

"Am I really love drunk?"

Adora flopped besides Bow on the fluffy couch, taking a sip of the hazelnut latte Razz made for her.

"Just a bit. It's alright, I think I am too."

"Yeah," Adora admitted in a soft voice.

"I reckon we both are."

"Agree to simp?" Bow held out his hand with a wink, Adora clasping it for a handshake. She chuckled lowly, nodding her head.

"Agree to simp." She let go, sinking into the cushions.

"We are so done for."

"Yup, I love it."

"Me too."

She barely had any time to get comfortable on the couch before Razz called for her in the dressing room.

"That's my cue."

———————

"Oh my," was the only thing Adora could think to say when she saw the outfit laced on herself. It was...godly, to say the least. Maybe even heavenly.

That beautiful pearl fabric wrapped around her body like it was made for her, dripping in thin gold lining that glowed when it hit the light. An elegant cowl neckline Adora never envisioned herself pulling off, with a low back that had delicate gold chains falling

past her shoulders. What was Adora's favorite was the accessories. Twin cuffs on each wrist, and golden vines that twined up her bicep. It was rather regal, she felt like some angel warrior in the piece.

"The belt's almosttt finished, Adora dearie, but do you like?"

"Like? I love it."

She opened her phone to see a message from Catra (she'd received several from Shadow Weaver, but she persisted to ignore those).

Catra <3: how's the fitting going?

Adora: Lovely

Catra <3: show me.

Adora opened her camera to take a photo before pausing. She wanted to show Catra, but a part of her sort of wanted to keep it a secret. Surprise her on the night. Besides, she had no idea what Catra was wearing. She didn't even bother to ask because Catra despised anyone knowing what her outfit was before she wore it. Dirty little hypocrite she was. Adora sent her response.

Adora: nope >;)

Catra <3: y not?

Adora: I want to surprise you

Catra <3: oh? rly now?

Adora: Yup

Catra <3: i'm impatient

Adora: You can wait. I'll show you if you show me yours

Catra <3: ur funny. like that's happening.

Adora: No double standards. Your impatient ass can wait.

She put away her phone, stepping out of the change room to show Bow and Glimmer.

———————

Not a Choice

"Alright, I need help."

"Agreed, you do."

Adora not so subtly rolled her eyes at Glimmer's joke, putting her tablet down on the bench as she settled into the warmth of their couch.

"Glimmahhhhh," she cried, shaking the girl's arm dramatically.

"Fine, fine. What could the Great Adora possibly need from me?"

"I need to plan a party."

"I'm listening," Glimmer straightened to attention instantly, and Bow opened the door of his room, peeking out to look at them.

"Me too."

"Bow, were you listening that whole time?"

"No," but his blush gave him away.

"What's the party for?"

"Catra's birthday. I doubt she's even thought about her birthday, not with the fashion show so close to it."

"Yeah, she's obsessed with that thing."

"You'd be the same for an art event, Glim, don't even."

Bow came around to perch himself on the arm of the couch.

"I was thinking a Halloween party, you know, where we can dress up and stuff."

"OOoh, yes!"

Glimmer opened her phone, tapping frantically into it.

"What're you doing?"

"Telling Arsan. The boy's kinda clueless, but he and DT are the best for throwing parties. He'll organize the drinks and food for you."

"Good, cause I had no idea how to get that stuff."

Adora was relieved she wouldn't have to carry the whole burden of planning this party. Just thinking about everything she'd have to do was giving her a headache, and she had a basketball game in a few days.

"I've already made a Pinterest board for decorations-"

"Oh, I'm handling music."

Bow cut in with a smug smile, Glimmer elbowing him so hard he almost fell off the couch.

"No! I do music," she whined.

"You do music every time, let me have a turn."

She humphed in her seat, folding her arms across her chest.

"I'll manage the guest list," Adora said. It was quite frankly the only thing she felt capable enough to handle. She'd already planned out her costume, the gold 'Shera' inspired outfit she'd made for her Textiles project.

"I was thinking it should be a surprise party," Adora chimed in. Catra would probably refuse to take a night off from her work, even if Adora was handling everything, so she'd simply force Catra to celebrate her own birthday.

"Ooh, I like it. I haven't seen Catra off guard since she was twelve."

Adora frowned. 'Catching Catra off guard' wasn't exactly her intention.

"I don't want her to think this is some cruel party joke, she won't think that, right? It's just- she won't organize this for herself, and I doubt she'd even let me organize it for her if I told her."

Adora played with the silver threads of a tassle on the end of a cushion, meeting her friends' eyes.

"I think she'll understand that it was a kind gesture on your end," Bow answered after some thought. Adora felt relieved, hearing what sounded authentic to her.

"Okay, I hope so."

_____

"A party? Darling this is simply precious!"

DT cackled as Adora stood from her seat, crossing her arms defensively over her chest.

"What?"

DT wiped tears from their eyes, meeting her eyes once again.

"Oh, I remember when you were a young thing, all shy and sweet. And now look at you! Throwing a party, oh I'm so proud."

Adora refrained from rolling her eyes. Yes, she could admit she was definitely a different person when she arrived at this school, but DT didn't have to get fake sentimental right now, did they?

"Yes, yes. Are you gonna help me, or not?"

"That depends. Have you memorized your lines?"

Adora chewed her lip, rocking back and forth on her heels as she stared at the ground.

"Not even Act One?"

DT sounded...hurt, and that pinched Adora.

"I'm a procrastinator, especially for memorizing stuff."

DT raised their eyebrows skeptically.

"If you memorize half the play by Friday, I'll help you out with Catra's party. Deal?"

Adora didn't hesitate.

"Deal."

———————

"What are you doing?"

Catra peered at Adora from her desk on the other side of the room. They'd chosen Catra's room for the night. Bow and Glimmer wanted to have a "Bake Off," and it was better they stayed out of their way for...well, that.

"Memorizing my lines. You should too, wanna practice?"

Adora waggled her eyebrows at her with a smirk, propping herself up on the bed with an elbow. Catra scoffed with a shake of her head.

"Nerd. I'll be memorizing those opening night."

"You can't be calling me a nerd right now? Have you looked in the mirror this past month?"

Catra had been working night and day on the Show, the only time she got to spend with Adora was when they both studied in silence together.

"Shut up," Catra tossed a pillow at her. Adora batted it away like a dodgeball, rolling off the bed to tackle her girlfriend. Wrapping her

arms around the back of Catra's shoulders, the other girl squealed, making Adora all the more amused. Catra was ticklish, how could she forget?

"Off, off!"

Catra wriggled in an attempt to break free, but Adora didn't budge until she was sure she'd had her revenge. Giving her a quick kiss on the cheek, Adora finally let go to return to the bed.

"Oh no you fucking don't."

She barely had time to compose herself before Catra had jumped on her back, Adora yelping in surprise. The pair tumbled onto the bed in a mess, laughing like two hysterical idiots.

"Keep it down, would ya? I've got plays to sort through."

Lonnie rolled her eyes, looking at the pair with a small smirk.

"Careful, you two are almost worse than Kyle and Rogelio."

"Ugh, they have got to have set a record for P.D.A or something; don't compare them to us."

Catra looked offended, staring at Lonnie aghast.

"Yeah, at least we keep it behind closed doors," Adora laughed.

"Well you're reaching their level. Keep it down."

Lonnie made a signal to indicate she was watching them, the pair of girls nodding their heads innocently.

"Sometimes I forget that girl is the same age as us."

"She has the essence of a twenty-five year old."

"More like a fifty-year old."

Adora crossed her legs under her, picking up both her phone and script book. Catra did the same with her own phone, taking a quick photo of Adora and showing her.

"Can I post it?"

Adora shrugged, it wasn't a special photo, just her in grey sweats and basketball jersey. In fact, she thought she looked horrible in it, hair all messed up and cheeks blazing red.

"I guess so, but I look shit."

"You look hot."

Catra didn't waste a single breath correcting her, posting the photo quickly.

"Glad to know you think so."

Adora smiled smugly. Of course she knew Catra was attracted to her, but she liked to hear it. What could she say? Words of affirmation were her thing.

"I've got to say, that bitch Light Hope sure knows how to do her job."

Catra turned her phone to Adora, showing a text from Angella.

Mom: We've almost got it, get your bags ready for a celebratory holiday!

"Wait, we've won? The case?"

Adora kneeled up in excitement, grabbing Catra's phone to look more closely at the text.

"Looks like it. Prime's two days away from behind bars."

Adora collapsed back into the bed, clasping her hands over her head.

"Woah."

Catra joined her, mimicking the pose.

"Uh huh."

"So? Where's the holiday?"

Adora smiled slyly at her, turning her body to look at her properly.

"Hmmm... Beach? Rainforest? Not snow, we already did that."

She tapped her chin in thought just as another text from Angella came through.

Mom: Glimmer wants Paradise. What do you think?

"Paradise? What's that?"

Adora frowned in confusion as Catra typed back a response.

Catra: paradise is g. adora's coming.

Angella: Not with that tone she isn't.

Catra: sorry *ahem* may adora come with us? she'll behave, i promise.

"Paradise is a flower house. It's in the middle of a lavender garden. Heaps of bees, but very pretty, and the lavender ice cream is worth it."

Adora was already excited. They just needed to push through the rest of this year and there'd be a whole 'paradise' awaiting them. Seven weeks.

"You know what's happening next week?"

"Hm?"

Catra was absentmindedly responding to a text while listening to Adora. Finishing her sentence, she put the phone down.

"Your birthday."

"Oh, yeah."

She sounded a bit flat, giving a one shoulder shrug as Adora neatly tucked a few loose strands of hair behind Catra's ear. It was covering her eyes.

"Well? What do you want?"

As much as Adora liked the idea of completely surprising Catra and wowing her with a present, it was a stupid idea. No one liked surprise gifts, least of all a girl who could attain anything she wanted.

"Nothing, you're enough."

"None of that. I'm getting you a present, so give me some options."

"Seriously, Blondie. There's nothing I want you to waste your money on. We'll go out for lunch or something. Not this month, but after."

Catra pulled herself off the bed, tying her hair into a bun and resuming her position at the desk. Adora had come to the conclusion that Catra organizing a fashion show was worse than herself trying to revise for exams. That girl did not take a break. She smiled to herself as Glimmer popped into her mind.

"Take a break Adora. You're driving me delusional with these stupid schedules."

At least the fashion show would be done in just a few more days.

"You need to take a runway walking course, by the way."

Adora nearly fell off the bed altogether. A runway walking what?

"You're joking, right?"

"Nope."

Adora met her eyes, trying to restrain herself from laughter. Catra looked completely and utterly serious.

"People audition to be in this show, Blondie, you don't even have to do that."

Adora felt like mentioning how she never even asked to be involved, but thought it was better to stay silent.

"Fine. Who's running it?"

She wondered if a special instructor was coming in to teach them or something. It was probably necessary she did some training, she could barely walk straight in a two inch heel, let alone the gorgeous sapphire stilettos Catra had shown her last night.

"DT, duh."

Adora groaned, flopping backwards into the bed. She shoved a pillow over her eyes to muffle the noise.

"They're not that bad. I could've hired some professional coach to come in, but I wanted to spend the extra money on make up and hair professionals."

Adora gave her a stony look, uncovering her face.

"I'm never gonna hear the end of it with DT. They'll eat me alive."

Catra rolled her eyes at the complaint, a light smile lining her face. She got up from her desk, straddling Adora who's groan only intensified.

"Calm down you big baby. It's one lesson, you'll live."

Adora only pouted, not conciliated in the slightest. Just as she was going to argue, her phone vibrated next to her. The screen lit up, revealing a string of messages from Shadow Weaver. Catra's eyes wondered from Adora's face to the screen, the small smile slowly dropping.

"She's sent you something. More than something, it looks like."

There was an edge to her tone, but Adora ignored it as she reached out and grabbed the phone. Ever since she'd left, Shadow Weaver had been messaging her a slew of manipulative (well, manipulative was putting it lightly) texts.

Shadow Weaver: I don't want you near her Adora.

Shadow Weaver: She's changed you. She's a distraction.

Shadow Weaver: If you don't get that girl out of your life I'll-

"Fuck."

Adora clutched the phone closer to her as Catra tried to lean over her to take a look. She didn't need her girlfriend to know she'd catalyzed Shadow Weaver's reaction to Adora's newfound personality.

"Adora. What did she say?"

"Nothing, it's fine."

Nah uh, there was no way Catra was getting even a glimpse of these messages.

"Nothing's ever fine with that bitch. Show me."

"No."

Catra looked more affronted than angry, and that made Adora hand her the phone instantly. She was too soft; couldn't handle

that look of betrayal in Catra's eyes when she knew Adora was hiding something from her.

Her normally bright eyes began to dim as she skimmed the rows of texts, her frown deepening.

"She-I-what?"

She could barely sputter a coherent sentence, the phone slipping out of her fingers and falling onto Adora's stomach as she looked towards her girlfriend.

"This has been happening since she's left? And you never told me?"

Adora didn't reply, averting her gaze to the fallen phone that lay on her stomach. It moved up and down as she breathed. She tried to focus on that rather than Catra's piercing gaze.

"Adora."

Her voice was leaden with disappointment, and it was enough to bring tears to Adora's eyes.

"I'm sorry," she whispered, finally meeting Catra's gaze. Her face didn't help the steady flow that leaked from her eyes.

She looked utterly devastated. And it was Adora's fault, once again.

"I'm sorry, I'm sorry."

Adora shook her head as Catra continued to just stare at her with that look on her face.

"Why didn't you tell me she was doing this? Sending this stuff to you?"

"I didn't want to burden yo-"

"No, Adora. The real reason."

Catra looked close to tears herself, taking shaky breaths as she looked between the phone and Adora.

"I-I don't know. I don't know why I didn't tell you. I was scared."

"Of what?"

"That you'd make me choose!"

Catra looked so affronted that Adora fervently wished she could take that confession back. Of course Catra would never make her choose between her adoptive mother or being with her, but some part of Adora, a small insignificant part, had a sliver of doubt.

"You think I'd give so much of a fuck to make you choose between her or me? Oh, Adora."

She laughed then, something that reminded Adora of when they were enemies rather than friends.

"Clearly you don't know me as well you think you did."

Catra climbed off of her, heading towards the door. Adora opened her mouth to protest, but she feared she'd say something stupid and fuck it up again.

"Adora, dear, if it was ever a choice between me or that bitch, I'd beg you to choose her."

———————

Lonnie the Lifesaver

Adora raked her hands through her hair, a true and utter mess. She didn't even know what to do, where to start.

Had Catra just broken up with me?

No, don't be an idiot.

She never said anything about it being 'over,' but she seemed goddamn pissed. Pissed enough to leave Adora in her room. Catra never left anyone alone in her room. Adora slid down the side of the bed, fisting her hair to prevent the trembling.

Goddammit, stop being such a blubbering baby.

The voice, wrapped in Shadow Weaver's pitch and tone and criticism, made her shake all the more.

"Adora?"

A soft voice was outside the door, accompanied by two small knocks. It was Lonnie. Adora could barely speak a word, trying to keep the crying to a minimum. Lonnie didn't wait for a response, though, pushing open the door slightly before rushing in.

"Damn girl. Are you okay?"

The girl seemed a bit stiff at first, unsure how to deal with the situation with the state Adora was in. But she quickly adapted, reaching to pull Adora into a hug on the floor, running her fingers through her hair in an effort to calm the panicked girl down.

"Deep breaths, like on the court. C'mon, we've got this."

Lonnie had adopted her 'basketball voice,' as Adora liked to call it. Soothing, natural and warm. She used it in their games, and when they discussed plays. Adora appreciated the adjustment, it transported her to a different place; shiny wooden courts, the

adrenalin of scoring a goal. That was what she could use right now.

They stayed there for a few minutes, Adora counting her breaths like she did before a match, in the locker room. It helped. A lot.

"Thanks," she mustered finally, detaching herself from Lonnie with red cheeks and a little bit of embarrassment. Lonnie was a bit of an icon in her eyes, she didn't like the fact that she'd seen her in such a state.

"You're 'right. We've all gone through it," she replied with a shrug. She didn't ask about what happened, but Adora could tell she was desperate to know. And to be honest, she felt like she owed her a bit of an explanation. Especially when she had helped her out like that.

"Catra and I were orphans."

"I knew that."

Adora nodded slowly, clasping her hands together as she tried to recollect the narrative.

"We were best friends. We did...everything together."

"I didn't know that," Lonnie conceded. Adora looked at her with something akin to surprise. While she knew that Lonnie and Catra weren't as close as they appeared to be, she couldn't help but be affronted by the fact that Lonnie knew so little of her past.

"And Shadow Weaver. She was, no, is an uhm..."

Adora trailed off, unsure how to explain the situation.

She was a manipulative bitch who turned us against each other for years.

Well, maybe Adora was being a bit harsher than necessary. Shadow Weaver wasn't the sole reason Adora and Catra had a

strained relationship...At least, she didn't think she was.

"She kinda pit us against each other, and in the end, she chose to adopt me."

"And not Catra?"

Adora nodded, Lonnie whistling in response.

"Nothing happened after that. I didn't see Catra again for years, until..."

"This year? When you moved."

Realisation dawned on Lonnie's moss colored eyes and Adora briefly looked away as she remembered Catra and her's first interaction. She could see Lonnie remembering that moment too.

Smooth, freckled tan skin, and a messy head of dark locks. But those were only compliments to her assessing eyes, one a royal blue and the other a shining gold.

Probably just a coincidence, there was no way they both landed up here.

Adora watched the girl's eyes carefully, waiting for a spark of recognition, but she couldn't read the stare.

"Catra?"

Catra blinked at her voice, tilting her head ever so slightly. Adora stared at her, waves of memories threatening to ebb at her emotions.

"Catra it's me, Adora."

In the corner of her eye she saw Glimmer open her mouth, but Bow gave a slight shake of his head.

"I'm sorry, do I know you?"

Adora had always assumed Catra had pretended to not recognize her out of spite; some weird sort of pride, or even a joke to make Adora feel insignificant. But according to Lonnie, no one at Brightmoon, besides Glimmer, of course, knew very much about Catra's past at all.

"Well, Shadow Weaver just visited me for the holidays."

"Fuck."

Adora nodded. My thoughts exactly.

"And you can imagine how swimmingly that went?"

"Double fuck."

Adora sighed, feeling restless just sitting on the floor. She needed to run, or shoot hoops, or gym, or just something.

"They sorta went at it with each other, I'm not sure what about, I never got a chance to ask her. I took her side in the argument, naturally, and now Shadow Weaver is going mad. She's sending me texts, phone calls, emails."

"God Adora."

"And Catra just found out about the whole thing. She's mad I didn't tell her about all the shit Weaver's been sending me, but I just wanted to protect our relationship; protect her."

Adora didn't realize her voice had risen and quickly shut her mouth, collapsing back onto the floor. She lay down, looking up at the blank ceiling.

"Shit, that sucks."

"Yup... Any advice?"

Lonnie chewed on her lip for a moment, thinking.

"If there's anything I've learnt about trying to be Catra's best friend, it's that the girl does not open up easily. I've spent years trying to learn something, just anything genuine about her or her history. She never let me through, she never let anyone through...until you."

Adora turned her face at that, watching the pensive gaze on Lonnie's face shift.

"I had to live with her for a year until I found out she was in love with fashion, and that she's oddly fussy about how messy her hair looks."

Adora scoffed at that, recalling a moment where Catra had freaked out because her "bed hair" was too "clean" to look effortless.

"I once caught her teasing her hair and then brushing it, just so it had the perfect 'gritty to elegance' ratio."

Adora chuckled, imaging a frantic Catra obsessing with her hair every morning.

"But you cracked her so easily, and so naturally. It made me jealous."

"I remember."

Lonnie gave her a side-eye, nudging her in the ribs for the dry comment.

"What I'm trying to say, Adora, is that you get her. And she gets you. But the one thing that seems to stand between you two is a five foot eight woman that's traumatized both of you your whole lives. Big statement, but I think it's true."

"No, it is," Adora acquiesced.

"Why do you think Catra cares so much about the fact that you hid Shadow Weaver's messages from her?"

Adora wasn't sure what to say. She truly had no idea why Catra was so upset about it.

"My best bet is that she's insecure. About your relationship with that woman. She's scared of losing you to her, like she did all those years ago."

Adora stared agape at the ceiling for a few seconds.

"Lonnie, you're a lifesaver."

She offered back a half-smile.

"Anytime, Grayskull."

_____

Adora ran around the campus, trying to find Catra, or even a trace of her. She checked her phone, but Catra had cleverly turned her location off, and Adora was now lost in the maze of the school.

A flash of cropped white hair walked past, and though Adora despised resorting to her, Scorpia was her best bet at finding Catra.

"Scorpia! Wait."

The woman raised her eyebrows at Adora, perhaps in confusion or disgust. Adora couldn't tell.

"What is it Gray?"

"Wait, why are you even here?"

Adora had noticed Scorpia around the place way too often. She'd let it slide because she assumed it was to visit Catra, but she was never around during the start of the year.

"I'm dating Perfuma," she deadpanned. Adora gaped at her, before quickly shutting her mouth.

Keep that information for later, let's move on.

"Right, uh-wait, how long? No-wait, never mind... you seen Catra?"

Scorpia's eyes instantly softened at the name, her cynical gaze falling in a heartbeat.

"Wildcat? No, she skipped her session last night. I've been meaning to find her, actually.

"Great, me too."

Without thinking Adora instinctively grabbed Scorpia's arm, dragging the woman with her towards the corridor. She was surprisingly light for being so strong...or maybe she was just agreeing to go wherever Adora was taking her. Which was kind of a problem, considering Adora had not even the slightest clue as to where Catra would be.

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Closet Playdate

Chapter Summary

Disclaimer: This chapter contains some more *ahem* mature content. If that’s not your thing, feel free to skip past :))

"Where does she normally go?"

"To me."

"Oh."

That was about all they spoke in the half an hour spent roaming the school, desperately peering in every crevice and corner for a sign of Catra. Adora gnawed on her lip, trying to think of something interesting or worthy of speaking. Scorpia only gave her a sly look as Adora continually opened and closed her mouth.

"Heh, you look like a fish."

She didn't know whether Scorpia intended the observation to be condescending, affectionate or humorous, but at least she'd said something. And that was a start.

"Thank you?"

"Wasn't a compliment."

Scorpia continued to chuckle to herself, and the sound was unlike what Adora envisioned. For a strong, powerful, intimidating presence, Scorpia sounded a bit...juvenile. Almost like a child.

"Uh, sorry."

She wasn't entirely sure how to respond.

"For what?"

"I...don't really know?"

Small knots twisted in her stomach, Adora wrapping her hair around her fingers to distract herself. A light sigh came from the woman next to her and she looked to her expectantly.

"What?"

"Is my presence boring you or something?"

She fisted her sweaty palms and looked up at her defiantly.

"Yeah, loosen up or something. You're so stiff."

Adora scoffed incredulously, looking at Scorpia with a loss of words. Here she was, forced to collaborate with a not-so-friendly twenty-six year old, while they tried to find her missing, volatile, hot girlfriend. Who was already mad at Adora. Did Scorpia expect her to put on a performance or something of the sort?

"Me? Stiff?"

"Uh huh."

"You're the one that looks like a wooden ruler half the time."

Adora didn't know where she was heading with that statement, but the insult seemed to land, for Scorpia looked increasingly offended.

"Do I seriously look straight?"

Adora blinked, sputtering out incoherent words as Scorpia's eyes widened.

"Because I'm not you know, I'm literally dating Perfuma, she's-"

"No, no-that's not what I meant."

Scorpia seemed deeply relieved, taking a deep breath and steadying herself. Wide eyes, mouth open... She had looked close to a heart attack.

"Good insult," she relinquished once she recovered.

"Thanks."

"I might borrow it sometime."

"Sure."

Adora had no idea what the fuck was going on.

She was so confused that she couldn't help the bubble of laughter that climbed up her throat.

"Uh, Adora?"

Scorpia stared at her blankly as Adora continued to giggle, hysterical with the situation she was currently in.

"Are you high, orrr? Do I need to call someone?"

Adora gasped in breaths, clutching onto Scorpia's arm to steady herself as they stopped. She wiped tears from her eyes, looking up at the soft pink hue of the sunset.

"Oh my god."

"What?"

Scorpia looked around frantically as Adora's eyes widened. The melting pink and purple of the sky reminded her of the-

"Textiles room! Definitely."

Scorpia gasped, a smile eclipsing the normal placidness of her expression.

"Yes! Good idea, for once."

Scorpia complimenting her was strange, but Adora didn't hate it (who on earth would despise receiving a compliment?).

"I'm full of good ideas, thank you very much."

She made a noise of indigence as they headed towards the Arts building.

Just as they began walking Adora's phone buzzed, several phone notifications coming through at once. Scorpia took a glance over Adora's shoulder to take an uninvited look.

"Uh, you should probably respond to-

"Oh."

That one simple word communicated everything to Adora. She quickly pocketed the devil of a device, trying to think of something to tame the situation.

"I forgot she's your adoptive mother."

Scorpia looked like she was barely restraining a sneer, and Adora couldn't blame her. If Shadow Weaver wasn't her mother, she'd hate her too. But she couldn't, not with everything she had done for her.

"I haven't spoken to her in days."

"Do you want to?"

Adora looked down at the floor briefly, glancing back up again to be sure she didn't hit a door.

"I don't want her out of my life. But I don't want Catra out of my life either."

"What caused Catra to hide Adora?"

Scorpia's voice had softened, their pace slowing as Adora explained the story. She was sure to keep everything as objective as possible, including every detail she could remember.

"It doesn't sound like Catra necessarily wants you to leave Shadow Weaver."

"It doesn't?"

Scorpia shook her head, eyebrows crinkled in thought.

"I think Catra was concerned by the fact that you didn't tell her any of this. I think she's hurt because you didn't trust her, or thought she'd react badly to hearing that she was contacting you."

"It's not that I don't trust her, I just know the stuff Shadow Weaver has done to her. It's better she stays out of that shit, Weaver is my problem to deal with."

"Then I think you should communicate that with her."

"I tried."

"Rationally. In a conversation rather than an argument.'

"Oh." That shut Adora up real quick.

"Do you know what happened at the restaurant? Where Catra blew up?"

"No idea. I've been meaning to get to the bottom of that as well."

"Hmm," Scorpia mused in thought.

"I really need to have a session with her," she muttered under her breath.

"Aha!" Adora exclaimed as they approached the classroom, opening to door to a dark...and unfortunately empty room.

"Damn. She's not in here."

Scorpia silently pointed to a sliding mirror door, fractures of light peeking out from the cracks. Adora's face instantly brightened,

slowly walking over to the door. Carefully, ensuring she didn't startle the girl, Adora peeled back the wide mirror, trying not to make eye contact with the reflection of herself (it was a strange habit).

Sitting on the ground, knees drawn up to her chest and a strew of designs around her sat Catra, eye make-up smudged and hair more untidy than usual (and not in the most 'elegantly messy' way). But she still looked gorgeous as ever, and Adora couldn't help but look at her in awe.

"Ugh, go away."

Adora looked back at Scorpia, who quickly looked between the pair. Catra's words were clearly targeted at Adora, but it was Scorpia who took a step back out of the closet. She exchanged a cautious look with Adora, giving a slight tilt of her head. Adora reciprocated, giving a small smile as Scorpia slid the door closed behind her. She heard the faint sound of footsteps leave the room, and the door of the classroom shut shortly after.

"Did you not hear me? Or did you just ignore me."

Catra narrowed he eyes at her, wiping non-existent tears. Parts of her make-up had rubbed off and her eyes were still red.

"I heard you," Adora replied softly.

Catra rolled her eyes, sitting up straighter as Adora slowly slid down the wall. Now they were across from one another, sitting on the hard wooded floor with rolls of fabrics and paper surrounding them.

"Ignored me then? Lovely."

"I wanted to talk to you."

"And I wanted to be alone. But I guess we can't all get what we want."

Catra's word were venomous, but her heart wasn't in it. She didn't sound mean or threatening as she wished to be, but rather fatigued. She stood up, reaching to open the door. Adora looked up at her, quickly reaching up and grabbing her wrist to attract her attention. They locked eyes, sapphire and gold meeting stormy blue.

Hear me out.

I can't be bothered right now.

Please. Just listen.

Catra stayed silent for a moment, thinking, before finally sitting back down.

"Well? Speak."

Adora took a breath, she didn't want to screw it up again.

"I want you to know...that I didn't intend to hide or mistrust you in not telling you about Shadow Weaver's calls and messages."

"So why did you do it?"

"I didn't want to involve you. You're so busy with everything; school, the play, organizing the fashion show, I just-this would've only added to your stress."

Catra nodded, slowly, her eyes still narrowed in suspicion.

"Okay."

Adora blinked. Was that it? Was that all she had to say?

"Well?"

"Do you regret it? If you could go back in time and tell me, would you?"

"Yes," Adora responded without thinking. She'd do anything to ensure Catra didn't look at her the way she was looking at her now. The girl leaned forward, the intensity of her gaze almost startling. Adora leaned her back against the hard wooden cabinet as she came closer, gulping.

"I believe you," Catra said finally, with a large amount of caution.

"Do you forgive me?"

A beat.

"I do...And I'm also sorry."

Adora smiled softly, it wasn't often Catra said those words.

"I just had a hissy fit. You had every right not to tell me about those messages; I don't tell you every time Angella calls me."

Catra talked while looking at the ground, wrapping a short lock of hair around her fingers.

"I never had a history with Angella. I get it, really."

Their eyes met again, softer, familiar, and Catra leaned closer until their lips bridged the gap. Adora was quick to reciprocate, feeling like she'd just gotten access to water in a desert.

They broke apart after what felt like eternity, their breath hot in the darkness of the closet.

"Fuck, I forgot how good-"

Adora cut her off with another kiss, unable to get enough, feel enough. Catra shifted, not breaking contact, and positioned herself on Adora's lap, the pair up against the hard wood behind them. She groaned as her back hit the sharp edge of the furniture, causing their kiss to break briefly.

"You okay?" Catra whispered, keeping her face close.

"Yeah, just the fucking thing behind me."

Catra nodded, about to say something else when Adora cut her off again, puling their bodies closer. She gently started pushing forward, supporting Catra's back as she gently lay her down on the floor. Humming with satisfaction into her mouth, Adora settled herself over her.

"Much better."

That elicited a giggle from Catra, who hastily pulled Adora's shirt off, her light touch causing Adora to shiver. She could barely concentrate on the kiss, even less so when Catra's fingers reached to clasp of her bra and her mouth found it's way to Adora's neck.

"They really weren't joking about the makeup sex," Adora managed to get out her words in quick pants, sliding her own hands down Catra's body to reach her hips.

"Don't touch me or I can't focus." Catra breathed on her neck, her hands already fumbling around the clasp. She finally got it free, rolling the straps down Adora's arms as the air hit her skin. Adora chuckled lowly, her hands immovable from Catra's skin.

"Adora," she whined under her breath, moving her kisses down to Adora's chest.

"Do you really want me to remove my hands?"

No response. Adora made a noise under her breath, the sensation of Catra's tongue on her-

Well, her skin, unbearable to even process a coherent thought.

Slowly, as Adora tried to focus on anything going on around her, she slid the hem of Catra's shirt upwards, revealing her stomach. She was wearing an intricate shirt, one with several cross-overs and ties on her back which made it difficult to navigate.

"Here, dummy," Catra breathed, continuing to make her way down while freeing the back of her top which Adora struggled with.

"Thanks, love," Adora responded, throwing the headache of a garment aside. She brushed her fingertips over Catra's skin, making the girl lose all focus she had.

"Holy shit, when did you learn-"

She cut herself off with another noise as Adora reciprocated the neck kiss, working faster and harder than Catra had. She varied her pace, traveling fast but careful to take her time with the sensitive areas, quickly reaching Catra's stomach.

Luckily, the girl was wearing a skirt, which made Adora's life a hell of a lot easier. Simply flipping the cloth up, she ran her hands over Catra's legs.

"Wow, you're practically a mess down here," Adora smiled in amusement, unable to see Catra's face but only her chin as she looked upwards.

"Shut up and finish the job or I swear to-"

"So, so bossy," Adora hummed against her skin, making a few small kisses in her inner thigh.

"Gods, when you talk-I can feel every fucking syllable."

Adora licked the edges, her smile broadening

"Really? Wow, I didn't think-"

"Adora!"

Catra dug her hands into Adora's hair, the movement causing Adora to move faster.

Adora was done playing, feeling herself loosen as she tasted Catra, her mouth sore after so much movement.

"My turn," Catra murmured lowly. For the first time in her life, Adora was downright terrified by the look on Catra's face. She moved with far too much agility, barely recovering from her own orgasm before flipping them around, straddling Adora.

"I'm scared."

"You should be."

Catra ran her fingers down Adora's arm, that touch alone enough to make her skin crawl. But Catra hadn't even started, she merely extended the hair tie on her wrist to wrap around her other one. She quickly maneuvered Adora's hands to be above Adora's head, holding them down with a smirk.

"Oh."

Oh.

Adora's heart rate sped up. Sure, they'd had sex before, hurried instances with not much more than passion and intensity. But this was different, it felt different. Adora was aware Catra had more sexual experience than her, but they'd never really found to time to properly explore each other.

"Mhmmm. I'm taking one big tour of your body, Adora Gray."

Catra wasn't lying. She started at the top, giving Adora one hell of a kiss, before moving downwards. She'd already kissed her neck, but not her collarbone, or shoulders.

"I can't with the waiting," Adora whispered, struggling to keep still her her hands bound to each other.

"You're lucky you're not wearing a blindfold right now," Catra whispered in between kisses. Unlike Adora, who went straight in with her tongue, she tried a different approach. Catra slid in a

finger, moving at a steady rhythm before sliding another in. Adora couldn't help but jerk, but Catra was ready for that, holding her body down.

"Nah uh, I'm not done yet."

She kept going, switching her body so she was facing Adora's legs rather than her head. The blonde couldn't see much but Catra's backside, which made the sensations all the more sharp and vivid.

Catra bent down, kissing Adora's thighs as she continued to move her fingers.

Adora wasn't sure what was even going on at that point, her head rolled back hard against the flat wood. Catra finally stopped (or, rather, paused) and turned her neck. She raised her fingers, licking Adora off of them before bending down her head.

"I-this is-oh my god," Adora's voice shook as Catra finished, the feeling climbing up and down every single one of her nerves.

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Pretty Stilettos?

Time crawled past, inching it's way toward's the end of October, and subsequently, the end of the year.

"Come on. Give me a hint."

Adora lay down on the bed, reciting lines in her mind while her head hung upside down on the edge. Catra was settled on the carpet, organizing and rearranging time slots on her laptop. Most of her work was complete, she just had to arrange the order of events on the night.

"I already told you Adora. I don't need anything."

Adora groaned at that response, shooting a look at Glimmer, who sat near the coffee table with sheets of art designs.

"Hm?"

She answered to Adora's piercing gaze, putting down her sketching pencil.

"She does kinda have a point. We already have everything we want."

Glimmer shrugged, returning to her work. Adora rolled her eyes, way to show off their opulence. She needed Bow's assistance, he would probably have a similar issue when giving Glimmer presents.

"Useless. Utterly useless!"

She threw her hands up in exasperation before folding them across her chest like a petulant child.

"There, there."

Catra absentmindedly wrapped her hand around Adora's upside down head, planting a kiss to the side before returning her attention back to her work. It did little to soothe Adora's annoyance at the situation, and she planted her hands down on the carpet, kicking her feet off the bed and using the momentum to land on her feet gracefully.

"I'm going for a run."

She wasn't actually, but it didn't cause either Glimmer or Catra to bat an eye. Leaving the dorm, Adora pulled out her phone.

"Hey, is it ready?"

"I don't know anyone more organized than myself, darling. Of course it is."

Adora exhaled, glad at least something was sorted.

True to their word, DT had taken care of most of the party planning details, leaving Adora with the guest list and schedule to organize. The party was in three days, two days before Catra's actual birthday, which was one day before the fashion show. Adora knew Catra would hardly enjoy the celebration if it was planned on her actual birthday, so the festivities had to be premature.

The only thing left was Catra's present, which was severely bugging her.

"Have you been practicing?"

"I already know all the lines DT, I recited all of them for you last Thursday, remember?"

"I was referring to your, ahem, catwalk."

Oh. Adora had in fact been ignoring the moonstone studded heels locked away in her closet. Those shoes were more frightening than Prime himself.. Well, almost.

"Uh, definitely."

"Liar, liar, pants on fire," DT sing sang into the phone. Adora gritted her teeth. Since their first runway session, DT hadn't stopped taunting her with her inability to walk in heels. She had tripped last time, twice.

Thankfully, DT hadn't informed Catra of the incident, or else the poor girl's head would probably split in two. Catra did not need anymore stress then necessary. Adora would master her walk before the show...she desperately hoped.

"Meet me today at three. Bring the shoes."

Adora groaned, that was the last thing she wanted to do.

"No sooking. I'll see you in the theatre."

With that they swiftly hung up, aggravating Adora all the more. She fisted her hands, deciding to tackle the other issue she had on her hands.

Calling Bow, she quickly turned her location off for Catra. She doubted Catra would even check, but if she happened to it would make more sense to say she was jogging in a no service location than at the local shopping mall. Especially since Adora visited the mall as frequently as she wore those gorgeous opal heels.

"What's up?"

Bow answered quickly, a note of concern laced in his tone. Adora didn't call him often, mostly texting to communicate with her friends.

"I need help with Catra's present."

"Right and because I'm just Catra's best friend you decided to ask me for help?"

Bow was being sarcastic, the dry voice unsettling on him.

"Well I figured you run into this issue a lot, dating Glimmer and all."

"Issue?"

"What do you buy someone when they own practically everything?" Adora explained, getting on the bus to head to the shopping centre. Bow's laugh was muffled on the phone as Adora swung herself onto a seat.

"Where are you?"

"On the bus to the mall."

"I'll meet you there."

Adora felt her brows crease at his response.

"Aren't you at your dads'?"

"I'm at their Brightmoon house, not the forest one. It's a ten minute drive from the mall."

Adora nodded before forgetting that Bow couldn't see her. She quickly responded into the phone.

"Right, of course. I'll see you there then."

Bow responded with assent, Adora hanging up.

She racked her brain, trying to recall anything and everything Catra would appreciate. Giving her nothing was out of the question, and she was beginning to stress with her birthday so soon. She'd been saving for weeks, a bank account made purely for Catra's birthday. She wanted to get her something nice, worthy of her approval.

Meeting Bow at the entrance of the mall, she greeted him with e frenzied hug.

"Bow! Thank god you're here, I don't know what I'm doing, and I don't know what to-"

"Woah, Adora. It's only her birthday, calm down, you're not proposing yet."

Adora nervously chewed on her nails, an anxious habit she could never entirely eradicate, though she did try multiple times.

"Well? Help."

Bow guided her through the busy centre, his fingers drumming against his chin in thought.

"I've run into this problem a lot."

"I can imagine. You've been friends with Glimmer for years."

"Yeah, and Glimmer really does have everything."

"So? What did you do?"

They navigated themselves around quite easily, drifting in and out of stores while looking through the racks with no success.

"The thing with gifts, for me at least, is that it's never truly material. When I was younger, my dads would always let me choose an activity to do on my birthday. And no matter how extravagant my wish was, they obliged. If I wanted to watch a movie, they'd rent out the entire cinema just for us, if I wanted to go skydiving, they'd do it with me."

He shrugged as they waited in line for crepes, the stress had nauseated Adora to the point of hunger.

"I guess it carried through in my own gifts to Glimmer, and everyone I love. Last year, I bought her a new painting kit and drove her out to a secret location. A cliff. And I let her paint it, everything. We spent the whole day there."

Adora stood there, mouth agape.

"Gods, how can I compete with that? It's a wonder you two didn't get together as long as you did."

Bow laughed, the pair of them reaching the top of the line to order. Adora grabbed her classic, a French vanilla cream and strawberry. Bow went for a rich nutty chocolate.

"I dunno," he shrugged it off, taking a bite out of the dessert. Adora followed suit, the freshness of the cream clearing her mind and filling her stomach.

"I'd like to give Catra an experience, but I think she'd prefer something tangible. Something she can cling to and hold whenever she needed it."

Bow nodded in agreement, eyes glancing around at the stores surrounding them.

"I reckon you're right. She prefers something solid, weighty. In that case, don't go for a generic, off the rack clothing piece."

"What do you recommend then?"

Bow thought for a minute, his leg bouncing up and down, before pulling out his phone. He made a quick call, setting the device down before meeting Adora's eyes with a glint in his own.

"What?"

"Come on, we're taking a trip to Razz."

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"Razz is expensive," Adora pointed out as they drove.

"Not necessarily."

"Bow. Have you seen the bill for my gala dress. The only reason she's making mine is because Glimmer insisted on paying for it."

"Adora, Razz doesn't ask for payment. For all her services."

This caused Adora to almost fly out of her seat. The luxurious fabrics, the time, the effort, the creative talent, how could Razz even think of giving her business free of charge?

"You're joking."

"Dead serious. Glimmer and her family choose to pay her that much money."

"Well I'm not going to exploit her kindness."

Bow chuckled, turning on the radio for some background music.

"I didn't say pay her nothing. Just give her whatever you've saved for Catra's birthday."

Adora did have quite a bit saved, it would be a fair sum to give Razz for her troubles.

"I guess you've got a point."

"I've always got a point," Bow flashed a smug smile, provoking a light shove from Adora.

"Ah, here we are."

He pulled into the parking lot of Razz' warehouse, stopping the car and grabbing the keys.

Adora paused him, grabbing him arm gently.

"Thanks Bow. Really. You didn't have to help me."

"Naw, don't go soft on me."

Bow shed an imaginary tear and wiped it dry, eliciting a chuckle from Adora as they entered the building.

"Mara, dearie!"

"Good to see you too, Razz," Adora bent down with a smile to greet the old, yet lively, woman.

"Oh, and Bow!"

Razz reached up to pat Bow's cheek, the boy bending down to meet her halfway.

"How's Arra? Lance and George?"

How was it that Razz didn't confuse Bow with his sister, and fluently remembered his parents' names, yet confused Adora with Dr. Despondos?

"Good, they all miss you, Razz."

Razz smiled at the comment before promptly pulling Adora into one of her consulting rooms. She drew the sheer curtains around them, fluffing Adora's pillow and sitting her down.

"Now, Adora dearie. You want a present for Catra?"

Adora had opened her mouth to explain herself when Razz had taken the words from her herself.

"Uh, yes. How did you-You know what, never mind. Yes, I do need a present for Catra."

Razz nodded.

"Adora, dearie. I cannot think of your present for Catra."

Adora's heart sunk, the sliver of hope she thought she had dead.

"Ah, don't worry dearie, Razz is here to help."

The small woman winked, patting Adora's cheek before leaving the room and returning with a sketchpad half her size.

"I don't understand?" Adora met Razz's expectant gaze with a questioning one.

"Precisely. Draw Catra."

Razz spread her arms with jazz fingers, pressing the pencil into Adora's hand.

"I'm not an artist," Adora answered. Great, now Razz was confusing her with Glimmer. She tutted at that, pointing a bony finger at the large piece of blank paper.

"Catra's essence, dearie. Go on!"

"Like her...vibe?"

"Yes dearie!"

Razz nodded with a toothy grin, gesturing for Adora to draw something, anything. The blonde bit her lip in thought. What came to mind when it came to Catra?

Rumpled uniforms

Messy eyeliner

Snow capped mountains and bare leaved trees

Dark mulberry wine

A flicker of light in darkness

Blue, and gold, of course

Stilettos

A pencil tucked behind your ear

Snakelike vines twining down an abandoned castle

Everything and anything fashionable

Moonlight; stars

Beautiful chaos.

Adora drew it all, nothing made sense, yet everything did at once. She wrote Catra's name at the top, handing the finished work to Razz, who took it eagerly.

"Just what I needed."

Razz pointed to three depictions: the blue and gold, crawling vines and roses, and the stilletos. She fused her hands together, Adora only cocking her head at the odd gesture.

Grabbing the sketchpad, Razz tore another piece, mysteriously scribbling before turning the page around for Adora to see.

"Woah."

The image was vividly stunning, so detailed Adora looked at the woman in utter awe. It was even colored. The drawing composed of a fashion model, one Adora had seen countless times in Catra's own sketches and designs. The figure was bare, save for her legs, which each adorned a stiletto. Not regular stilettos, though. These ones had thin straps criss-crossing over the foot, before wrapping around the heel.

It didn't end there, the straps- alike to the vines Adora had drawn- danced around the figure's calf, rosebuds peaking out in various spots, before curling at the ends.

The shoes weren't even identical. One a crushed cobalt, and the other a glinting gold. It rendered Adora speechless.

"For Catra?" She finally mustered. Razz nodded, obviously pleased with Adora's reaction.

"It's perfect. I thought you couldn't formulate my present for Catra?"

"I didn't, dearie. You curated this. From here." Razz gestured to her heart, her expression holding a knowing smile.

Bond With The Shoe!

"Darling, you can't look down. Chin up."

DT strolled over, wearing an exquisite pair of diamond heels which looked positively painful. DT walked effortlessly though, a stark contrast to how Adora was walking.

"If I look up, I'll fall."

"God, Adora," DT rolled their eyes in exasperation before an expression of realization graced their features.

"I know!"

They pulled the silk scarf weaved into their hair out, the icy blonde falling in cool, sharp waves.

"DT..." Adora warned. The glint in their eyes was beginning to make her stomach twist and turn. She raised her hands in mock defense, but there wasn't much she could do. The weight of the shoes had her firmly rooted to the spot.

DT walked behind her, pulling the fabric over Adora's eyes. She refrained from the urge to scream. Everything was black, and her feet were unsteady. She almost tripped without even taking a single step

"Okay, now trust the shoes, darling."

Adora gritted her teeth, trying to reach for something to hold on too. The ground was swaying far too much.

"I barely trust myself, why would I trust shoes?"

The best solution was to bend down and sit on the floor, but DT held her forearms, preventing her from doing so.

"You've got to have a cosmic connection with the shoe," they whispered, sparkles of excitement carried in their tone.

Adora scoffed, still grappling for something to grab onto for support.

"Cosmic whaa-"

The ground was moving all the more, her face mere inches from colliding with the smooth wooden floor until-

Until she caught herself?

There was a slight drop, but not a fall. She carried herself back into an upright position, frowning at DT's dark chuckle from behind her.

"Bond with the shoe!"

"Double Trouble!"

Adora didn't have much time to recover from her shock, heart beating wildly and hands trembling. DT held no sympathy or remorse, shoving her once again, this time from the side.

Adora wobbled, but didn't crash, the sharpest point of her heel acting as a balance before she could topple over.

"I seriously don't get-"

"That's the fun of it," DT struck again...and again, and again.

The shoes continued to persevere, Adora beginning to wobble less and less.

They shoved another time, and thrice more following, each one rougher and nastier.

But Adora failed to fall, and slowly, shove after shove, the ground ceased swaying.

"Bravo, darling," DT clapped while Adora struggled to catch her breath. She didn't think she'd be sweating in this class, but her expectations were very much defied. Rivulets traveled down the side of her face as she panted, DT pulling the scarf from her eyes.

"Woah," she blinked. Colour and vision filling her senses once again, Adora didn't slightly tremble in the stilettos.

"Walk."

She obeyed, tucking loose strands from her ponytail behind her ears and facing the velvet red curtains with fervent determination.

She walked, no, strutted, down the clean wooden panels, the sound of her heels hitting the floor a rhythmic symphony that echoed around the stage. A slow clap shortly followed.

"Wonderful, stunning, magnificent!"

DT applauded her, setting a wide grin on Adora's face. She quickly walked back to them, enveloping the person into a hug.

"Thanks, DT," she said, releasing them. DT smiled, slightly pink.

"Anytime, darling."

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Adora chewed her nails, pacing up and down in the lounge as she thought over and over again.

Catra's party was tomorrow, she'd be picking up her present from Razz, yet she couldn't shake off the feeling that something was amiss. It was Catra's present, it just...lacked something.

The design Razz had made was perfectly exquisite, and Adora had taken a big role in designing the shoes, but she couldn't shake the feeling that it wasn't truly coming from her. She'd chickened out and palmed off the hard work to Razz. Adora took a seat on the

couch, thinking of something she could make for Catra...something she designed and created.

Her eyes flicked about the room, looking feverishly for inspiration. The dorm reminded her more of Glimmer than everything, bright pink cushions and lilac curtains, the only touch of 'Adora' was her letterman jacket, strung over the couch as it had been for a few days. Her eyes snagged on it, reminding her of a time too long ago where Catra created it for her.

A knock sounded from the door, echoing through the short, narrow hallway. Adora tried not to jump, still fixated on the jacket. She quickly got up to answer the door, a smile crawling its way on her face at the sight of Catra. Adora didn't miss a beat, tackling her girlfriend with a hug bigger than the sun.

"Oof, geroff me," Catra's voice was muffled as Adora dug her head into the crevice of her shoulder, soaking up the musk and mint she'd missed in the few days she hadn't seen Catra. She knew Catra's demand wasn't serious, for the girl squeezed her back and laughed as Adora finally released her hold.

"Come in," Adora took her hand, leading them through to the lounge past Adora and Glimmer's bedroom.

"Fuck, I'm stressed."

"Yeah, you sure look it," Adora said with a snicker. Catra narrowed her eyes, flinging a pillow at Adora's head. She caught it with a smirk, settling the periwinkle cushion comfortably behind her head to spite Catra.

"Shut up," Catra huffed, tucking her legs under her on the couch. Adora gave her a cheeky grin, moving closer and wrapping an arm around her with affection. Catra snuggled herself closer, eyes fluttering closed for a long, peaceful moment.

"I missed you," Catra whispered, wrapping her arms around Adora's middle with a smile.

"I missed you too," Adora planted a kiss on top of her head, wrapping a wavy piece of hair around her finger as she stroked. It was longer now, nearly shoulder length.

"How's the planning going? Not long now."

Not long at all until the fashion show. Catra sighed, eyes finally opening as she looked up.

"It's...going...Can we talk about something else?"

Adora nodded, resting her chin on Catra's head as she soaked in her presence.

"You wanna talk about your birthday?"

Adora knew Catra would be suspicious if she told her she had plans organized a month ago, but if it seemed spontaneous she wouldn't think a thing of it.

"Sure, I do love talking about myself."

Adora chuckled as Catra raised herself to meet her at eye level. Rotating her body and crossing her legs on the couch, Adora faced her.

"I've decided-"

"Oh, you've decided?"

Catra raised an eyebrow with a teasing smirk.

"Yes, I've decided that we are going to go fishing!"

Catra's jaw dropped while her eyes widened.

"Fishing? In...water?" She gulped, going a bit pale, and Adora couldn't help but fold in laughter.

"Nah, I just wanted to see your reaction," she wheezed, wiping tears from her eyes. Catra did not seem amused, lightly hitting

Adora's knee.

"Not funny. What are we actually doing?"

Adora waggled her eyebrows.

"It's a surprise. But keep the entire day free."

"Bold of you to assume I want to spend my whole birthday with just you." Catra tilted her head, her tone dripping in sass.

"Yeah, well it's true."

Adora shrugged and winked, a knowing smile painted on her face.

"Ugh, so full of yourself."

"Says you!"

"Eh, fair."

Catra flicked her hair in Adora's face, provoking the blonde to tackle her. Catra squealed, both girls in a mess of giggles as they rolled off the couch onto the floor.

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Spoons

Adora hugged a quick goodbye to Catra for the night, her gaze snagging on the worn leather jacket. Catra had worn it almost everyday, and now the fabric had faded and was close to tearing in certainplaces.

Adora tried to control the sharp intake of breath, but her face did little to hide her thoughts.

"Why do you look like you just solved the worlds hardest math equation?"

"Because I just did...in my head...I'd been thinking about it for a while."

Catra narrowed her eyes in suspicion, scanning Adora up and down like a human lie detector. Adora tried not to gulp, hoping she'd buy it.

"Right, uh huh."

Catra nodded slowly before turning around, Adora softly closing the door behind her. She quickly called Bow.

"Bow, I've got it!"

"Got what?"

"Catra's present, duh."

A pause.

"Did we not figure that one out a few hours ago with Razz?"

"Yeah, we did, but it didn't feel like enough for Catra, so I thought of something to go with it."

"Which is? Hang on, I'm with Glim, I'll put you on speaker."

"Hey Glimmer," Adora smiled, taking a seat at her desk while opening her sketchpad. She hadn't designed something in a while, the past few Textile classes centered around making a pencil case.

"Adora!"

Glimmer's muffled voice came through the phone and Adora suppressed a laugh.

"Okay, now tell me. What is it?"

Adora raised her shoulder to meet her phone, allowing both her hands to be free as she grabbed a pencil lying on her desk.

"You know the leather jacket I made Catra?"

"The one that looks fifty years old, yeah."

"Well I was thinking I could make her a new one, but cooler."

She drew a figure outline, sticking her tongue out in thought as she tried to envision the jacket. Leather, definitely, but not a replica of the one Catra currently owned. She'd make it baggier, a looser fit, yet still cropped to reach her waist. Adora wanted this coat to have buttons rather than zips, and she wanted to sew patches similar to the ones on her own letterman jacket Catra had made for her. She grabbed her own one for reference, the soft threads stitched seamlessly onto the dusty red fabric.

Adora thought of Catra, and the objects that had came to her mind when she was brainstorming with Razz.

Certainly a 'C' for her name, and a grey cat for Melog, maybe something dark and edgy...Catra adored dark and edgy. Maybe something maroon?

"Ooh, good idea. Her current one is so musty now, if you didn't make it for her she would've donated it ages ago."

Adora paused in her sketch, finding this observation startling. She'd never thought about it. Why else would Catra wear that tattered, faded things so goddamn often when she could so easily afford something worth twice the money? Because Adora had made it for her.

"Yeah...yeah."

She spoke absentmindedly, running through the last minute reminders for Glimmer regarding the party as she finished the sketch. She planned to give Catra her present on her actual birthday, rather than her party, so she still had a few days to finish the jacket and collect the shoes.

Adora fastened her hair into a more secure ponytail, pulling on her 'focus' glasses (as she liked to call them) and getting to work with more precision and deftness than she had ever applied to any of her studies.

_____

The day of Catra's party spun around quickly, and Adora had organized almost everything.

Shoes; check. She'd picked them up from Razz an hour ago, the intricacy of the laces and shimmering gold enough to knock the breath out of her chest. She didn't know where Catra would wear the shoes, but when she'd asked that to Razz the old woman only offered a knowing smirk.

Guest list; check.

Clean Apartment; check (sorta-she was working on that one)

Leather jacket; almost check (she was very nearly finished)

Cake; check

Halloween decorations; check

Food and drinks; check

Outfit; check.

Glimmer was going as the Queen of Hearts, and Bow was dressing as Frankenstein. Adora had never been to a Halloween party or even celebrated the occasion, but she supposed the 'She-Ra' costume would be fitting enough, even if it wasn't exactly 'frightening.'

Pulling the article of clothing out of her closet, Adora scanned the costume. She could hardly imagine herself in it. Gold cuffs, a solid tiara?

She closed the doors, checking the time. She had carefully allotted two hours for getting ready, and had gotten DT to do the dirty work of keeping Adora occupied. The poor girl was likely to get extremely frustrated with DT hovering over her for the next two hours, but if there was anyone who could do the job, it was them.

Adora methodically cleaned the remainder of the dorm, strategically shoving messes into closed rooms and doing a quick vacuum of the place. The drinks were in an icebox on the table, with a few bottles of vodka and shot glasses lined up on the kitchen counter. She quickly finished off the snacks and put away the valuables before checking the decorations and playlist for the night. Everything seemed to be in order, now all she had to do was get ready.

Adora slipped into the form-fitting costume, feeling so unlike herself she barely recognized her own face in the mirror. Sure, she had designed and created the costume herself, but she never actually intended for herself to adorn it. The dress was so short, it barely reached her fingertips by her side. She was lucky she'd sewn matching bike shorts into the outfit, and a cape long enough to hide everything that needed to be hidden.

She finished off the touches to her makeup, painting gold on her eyelids and a bright red on her lips. She blinked in the mirror after

fixing her eyeliner for the umpteenth time. She envied Catra and Glimmer who swiped eye makeup on so effortlessly.

"Adora?"

Putting on the hair curling iron, Adora answered the shout from the living room.

"Yeah?"

It was Bow.

"Are ya ready?"

"Almost," she yelled back. Luckily her hair was thin, it wouldn't take her long to curl it. She was after loose waves anyway, something to flow down her back like those archaic images of She-Ra thousands of years ago.

"Hurry up. I'm dying to see your costume."

Adora smiled to herself whilst rolling her eyes, Glimmer charging through the bathroom door as she did so.

"A knock would've been nice."

Adora raised an eyebrow while meeting Glimmer's eyes in the mirror.

"Sorry, I'm just desperate to use the rollers. And I brought you this."

She winked, pressing a shot glass filled with vodka into Adora's free hand. She smiled down at it, glad that Glimmer recognized vodka as her favorite form of alcohol.

"Thanks, I'll have it after I finish my hair."

Glimmer nodded, starting on her own. She'd sprayed it black and red, providing a striking contrast to her usual cotton candy vibe. She suited it though, the makeup flared and dramatic, with a

perfectly flamboyant gown to match. As Glimmer pinned her hair up, Adora finished curling her hair, the soft waves pushed back with the golden crown she placed on her head.

"Gorgeous," Glimmer smiled. Adora met it evenly.

"You too, Glim. Come on, we gotta get the place ready."

Unlike Catra's dorm, their's wasn't soundproof, but it'd have to do. The furniture had been scattered into hidden corners of the dorm, bedrooms soundly locked (unless, of course, Bow, Glimmer, Catra or Adora wanted to use them).

The doorbell rang, promptly five minutes following eight thirty. Adora took a breath, opening it to reveal Flutterina, along with a few of her friends.

"Hey!" Adora waved, hopefully not too awkwardly, and Flutterina bounced a small smile back at her, fuchsia eyes sparkling in the dimly lit corridor.

"Come in," she welcomed them, taking a present from each guest. Sighing in relief, Adora exchanged a glance with Glimmer. At least no one had thought Catra's surprise party too lame to attend...in hindsight, that was probably an irrational fear, Catra was pretty goddamn popular.

A knock echoed again, this time coming from Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio. The brunette winked as Adora opened the door, a smirk playing on her face, and a eye patch covering her other eye.

"Nice costume," she raised an eyebrow. Adora returned the gesture, scanning Lonnie up and down. She'd come as a pirate, adorning a loose cream button down with a denim corset, and flared leather pants that were cropped perfectly to accentuate the chunky brown boots on her feet.

"Likewise."

She let them in, collecting more presents to set aside in her room. Feverishly checking her watch, she quickly sent a text to DT.

Adora: People are coming, bring Catra in about thirty minutes.

DT: Good. She's antsy as fuck, defs sus.

Adora swore under her breath. She didn't want Catra to suspect anything until she opened that door. The party would be an utter failure if the whole 'surprise' element was compromised.

Pocketing her phone, she grabbed a drink from the makeshift bar. Bow was entertaining a few people with some bartending tricks he'd learnt, playfully flipping and catching the shaker tin before pouring a colourful drink into a glass.

"Who knew bartending would be so hot?"

Glimmer sounded like she herself was a few drinks deep already, fingers twisting gently in Bow's curls as she leaned into him. Bow didn't seem to mind a single bit, blushing at the touch before offering her a sip.

"Ugh, get a room," Adora jokingly rolled her eyes at the couple. Glimmer made a face, one which Adora returned while taking a hearty gulp of whatever Bow had just poured into her glass. It tasted good, like creamy pineapple with a shot of vodka. Her phone buzzed, a call from DT coming through.

"DT?"

Music was already being blasted as more people arrived, the space quickly getting filled. Adora had to cover her ear to hear DT on the line.

"I'm coming now. She just realized your location was off."

Adora swore under her breath. She'd forgotten to turn it back on after getting Catra's present. Now she just seemed even more suspicious.

"Fine, there's enough people here anyway. And she'll need a bit of time to get dressed anyway."

Adora had already thought of something Catra could potentially wear. The retro costume she'd made for her project. She knew Catra had been waiting for an opportunity to use it.

She hung up, telling Bow and Glimmer that Catra was coming. The three of them instantly dispersed into the mass of people, asking guests to hide until Catra arrived.

Luckily, they cooperated, and soon the music was turned off and lights dimmed. Adora got into her position by the door, tracking Catra on her phone. She would be there in a few minutes.

Her heart drummed against her chest, the sound reverberating around her entire body until finally, the door cracked open.

"Adora?"

Catra had earned her own key to Adora's dorm, the sound of metal clinking against each other as she tucked the keychain back into her pocket.

"Adora, this isn't funny, y'know."

Adora nodded to Glimmer, who switched on the lights.

"Surprise!"

Jumping up, Adora met Catra's amused expression.

"Hah hah, you got me," she clapped slowly, tone washed with sarcasm. The crowd had gone back to their activities, the surprise over. Adora only gave a smile, pulling Catra into a hug before lifting her up so Catra could swiftly wrap her legs around her torso.

"I sorta did, didn't I?"

She peered up at the still entertained Catra.

"Mm, sure."

"I'll take that."

Catra adjusted the crown atop Adora's head, tucking the loose blonde strands behind her ears before planting a soft kiss on her head.

"Got me worried for a sec there."

Adora feigned shock, squeezing Catra a bit tighter.

"The oh-so-nonchalant Catra...worried about me? Who would've thought you'd go weak."

Catra scoffed, unwrapping herself from Adora and settling her feet on her ground. She flicked the crown off Adora's head.

"Better get rid of that thing, it's getting to your head, Princess."

Adora laughed lightly at the tease, picking the prop back up before entwining her and Catra's hands.

"Come on, I've got your costume in your room."

———————

"I've got a game idea!"

Glimmer sing sang her way into the lounge, Adora a small group of others lounging with drinks in hand.

"Alright, out with it."

Bow made space for her on the couch, Glimmer chucking a handful of spoons and a deck of cards onto the table.

"Spoons!"

"Spoons?"

Adora looked at the weird assortment of items with a bit of fear and confusion.

"It's a game," Glimmer tried to elaborate.

"Yeah, I gathered as much."

"There's six of us here, and five spoons."

Adora took a quick look around. Her, Catra, Bow, Glimmer, DT, and Lonnie.

"Everyone gets four random cards, and one person is chosen to be dealer. Everyone's objective is the same; get four cards of the same suit. The dealer will grab a card from the top of the pile of remaining cards, and if it doesn't match their requirements, they pass it to the next person, and so on. When someone does get four of the same suit, they grab a spoon," Bow gestured to the table.

"Then everyone else is allowed to grab a spoon, and one person is left spoon-less. They gotta take a shot."

Adora nodded, the game seemed harmless enough. Certainly better than Truth or Dare.

"Okay, let's play."

Bow acted as dealer for the first round, dishing out four cards to each player and arranging the spoons into a line in the centre of the table. The round begun, Adora concentrating with every sober braincell she had left.

She started out with two diamonds, one club and one heart. Therefore, diamonds would be her suit of choice. She discarded a few cards, gaining a third diamond in the second pass. A third pass occurred, followed by a fourth, and then-

"Spoon!"

Lonnie yelled the word out, and everyone scrambled. Adora dropped her cards, sticking her arm out into the frenzy to retrieve a coveted spoon.

She did, only just. Glimmer was knocked out of the game.

"Fuck's sake. It was my idea to play, and I'm the first one out! Insanity."

She threw up her arms in annoyance, Bow offering a conciliatory pat of mock concern. Adora took a breath, that was too close, she needed to be faster next time.

"Is that sweat, I spy?"

Adora looked up to meet Catra's eyes, who were peering at her inquisitively. The bight red glittery eyeshadow she had on was jarring against her bright eyes.

"You won't be so cocky once I get you out."

As much as Catra was Adora's girlfriend, the pair both had inbuilt competitive spirits.

"Once you get me out? We'll see Blondie."

Catra's eyes flashed, and Adora readied herself for the next round. Lonnie was dealing.

She'd been dealt one of each suit. A heart came by in the first pass, she quickly accepted it, readying herself for the next pass until-

"Spoon!"

This time it was Bow, he must've been dealt three of the same suit from the beginning. Adora felt a shove in her side as she tried to reach, pushing back to get the spoon.

"Low move."

"I want to win, can you blame me?"

Adora felt a part of her heating up and Catra's arrogance, a fire lit which wasn't easily doused. DT was out this time, and Catra was dealing.

This time, when Adora herself yelled 'Spoons!' She was sure to grab two instead of one, hoping Catra and her cocky attitude would get knocked out. She wasn't, rather Adora had just eliminated Bow and Lonnie, the latter of which shot her a dirty look.

"If you two wanna fuck, just go get a room, no need to take it on the rest of us just tryna play a game."

She huffed, rolling her eyes. Adora's jaw dropping, unable to form words.

"I can practically smell the tension," Lonnie pursed her lips.

"I think sex is the last thing we want to do right now, I want to win."

Adora met Catra's eyes, her gaze heated.

"I mean, I wouldn't mind sex right now, but I'm winning first."

Adora blinked, she wasn't really expecting that response.

"Right, uh...fucking hell, now you got me in the mood."

"After."

"This is the grossest thing I've heard all day, hurry up and be done with the game already."

Glimmer shot each of them with a withering look, the single spoon laid perfectly in the centre of the table.

"I'll deal."

"Nuh uh, not with your dirty cheater tendencies."

"You know what, for the purpose of fairness, I'll deal."

DT shuffled closer, grabbing the deck. It seemed fair enough, neither one of them could sabotage the other.

"Ready, set...Go!"

_____

A Fresh Perspective?

"I can't believe you posted that Glim!"

Adora was beside herself in stitches, Catra watching with a growing smile on her face. She was utterly adorable when she laughed like this, uncaring and free.

"You're staring so hard, I might think you're in love with me."

Adora's tone was light and teasing as she propped her head up on her hand, waggling her eyebrows at Catra.

How could I not be?

Instead of saying what she felt, with Bow and Glimmer to spectate, she played the comment off.

"Keep dreaming, love."

Adora huffed with indigence, eliciting a smirk from Catra.

"It was hilarious, you're wrestling over a fucking spoon!"

Glimmer was beside herself in tears, the sight so annoying Catra shoved her in her side. It didn't help much, for Glimmer just rolled around on the bed, replaying the stupid video over and over.

Catra looked at it from her own phone, feeling the presence of Adora as she leaned on her shoulder to peer at it.

Vanilla, jasmine....a hint of watermelon. Her forever favorite.

The mortifying video presented both girls wrestling on the ground, trying to reach the last spoon, that had been knocked off the table in their initial frenzy to get it. Catra was atop Adora, pinning down her arms while trying to reach for the small metal item with her foot, while Adora was struggling against her and batting Catra's foot away from the spoon.

"I'm blaming it on the alcohol," Adora muttered, eyeing the spoon that was carelessly tossed on her bedside table the following morning. After winning, she'd spent the whole night gloating like the pain in the ass she was.

"I second that," Catra murmured. She recalled being concerned that Adora would damage her reputation and status at one point and chuckled to herself quietly. Now millions of people online witnessed her tumbling on the ground to get a spoon and she didn't give a single fuck. It was liberating.

"Thanks," she turned her head to look down at Adora resting on her shoulder, and something warmed inside of her, something fuzzy and comforting,yet completely bewildering. She'd been getting a lot of those feelings since Adora was around, but she didn't mind, not in the slightest.

"For last night, you must've cracked your head open organizing it."

Adora twisted her head to look up her, ash blue eyes smiling.

"I had some help. Those two, DT, and Arsan."

Catra turned her eyes towards Bow and Glimmer, giving the pair a smile of appreciation. She glanced at her phone to check the time, sighing as she clicked it back off.

"I'd better run, things for the show."

Adora wrapped her hands around Catra's torso, squeezing tight. Catra's heart fluttered in response to the touch, but she knew instantly what Adora was doing.

"Nope, just a few more minutes."

"You had me all of last night, Blondie, and you'll get me in approximately seventy two hours."

Fuck. Seventy two hours. That's all she had left, and she still needed to sort out the decorations (the fuckwit delivery man had given them the Gala ones prematurely instead of the fashion show ones), run a dress rehearsal, and organize lighting and sounds. It didn't sound like much, and it wasn't, but each task would be time consuming and her skill level wasn't nearly as proficient as it should be. Sure, she could design a few dresses, get a team to help her sew it, but directing a whole ass fashion show? Do all this coordination shit? That wasn't exactly her thing.

"Hmph, fine." Adora finally let go, lifting herself to meet Catra's eyes. Even with fucked up hair, smudged eyeliner and a stupid dopey grin (which Catra secretly adored), she was the most gorgeous thing alive.

"See ya guys," she slid off the bed, nodding to Bow and Glimmer, who had been preoccupied talking about something else. Catra quickly tucked a lock of knotted blonde hair behind Adora's ear, holding the side of the face while she gave her a quick kiss.

"Don't miss me too much," she whispered before letting go.

"I will," Adora had called out right after Catra closed the bedroom door, but she still heard it. And she smiled.

———————

God, the nail biting was making a return. Catra could hardly even get to sleep, her eyes refusing to close and her heart refusing to slow down. Thoughts, reminders, voices, memories, to-do lists, all floating in the back of her mind, and the doona suddenly too thick and heavy. She lifted the weight off of herself, but it didn't help much. She couldn't stay still to save her life. She checked her phone

3:32AM

Approximately seventeen hours until it happened, the thing she'd been anticipating for the past six months. All the top designers

would be there, ready to spectate, scrutinize and critique. She wasn't cut out for this industry, they'd eat her alive.

No. You're a good designer. You know you're a good designer.

But was she? Really? Did anyone actually think she deserved this role?

Don't be an imbecile, of course you deserve it. You earned it.

Catra refrained from screaming, for Lonnie's sake. At least one of them should get some sleep, and besides, she despised anyone seeing her in such a helpless state.

Fucking hell, this room was too small, she needed to get out.

Pulling her uggs over her feet and shoving her phone in her pocket, Catra carefully unlatched the window clasp, opening it to be hit but a cool breeze.

She gulped in the air like medicine, pushing it open wider so she could get out. There wasn't a balcony outside her room, but there was a roof.

Her feet landed on the flat surface, Catra moving to the edge so she could dangle her legs over the edge.

It was strange, to be alone after being around people for so long. She loved it, of course she did, but moments of solace were necessary to keep her spirit intact. Most thought her to be an extrovert, and she was for the most part, but being alone, on top of a building, with no one beside her...it was nice. She laid down on the smooth cold surface, looking at the sky.

A sea of stars, glittering down at her with their beady eyes. She scoffed, it was as if they were mocking her from up there. She was amused by the irony of it all, that tonight of all nights, the stars were shining. Dazzling constellations illuminating a black canvas.

And now she was just reminded of what today meant, and the whole peacefulness of the moment was irrevocably ruined. It was nice while it lasted.

She climbed back through the window, shutting it firmly. The bed was still unwelcoming, sheets ready to grip her until the morning. She didn't want that, not right now.

Cracking her bedroom door open, Catra peered into the dismal hallway. After the few moments of stillness, she craved a distraction. She bit her tongue in thought.

Adora?

But no, she shouldn't. Just because she didn't want to sleep didn't mean she should disturb anyone else's.

Still, her selfish desires won, and she left the dorm in search for Adora's.

Pulling out her set of keys to Adora's dorm, Catra quietly unlocked the door. Her eyes instantly drifted to Adora's bed, the girl covered by a blanket. Catra approached the bed, watching for a moment. She looked so calm, completely undisturbed.

Catra didn't feel like taking that away, it wasn't fair. She'd have to deal with her sleeplessness herself. No need to drag anyone down with her.

Planting a soft kiss on Adora's head, Catra moved back towards the door.

"Woah, who's there?"

Catra smiled to herself at Glimmer's warning tone, still groggy from being woken up. If she didn't say anything Glimmer would most likely think she was dreaming and go back to bed.

"What were you doing by Adora's bed? I saw you near her, she's got a girlfriend, you know, so back off! And even if she didn't,

what creep lingers by-"

Catra finally turned around, her smile transformed into a grin.

"As entertaining as that little spiel was Sparkles, it's just me, said girlfriend"

"Oh. Oops."

Glimmer rubbed her eyes, squinting in the dark. She patted the end of her bed, gesturing for Catra to sit down.

Why not?

"What are you doing here at," she checked the time, "three fifty four in the morning?"

"Couldn't sleep," Catra mumbled in a breath. She took a look over her shoulder at Adora's sleeping form.

"Thought I could...get some company, I guess. I dunno, but she's out cold. It'd be plain mean to wake her up."

"Adora's a saint, she wouldn't mind. Me though? If Bow woke me up, he'd be dead."

Catra slipped off her uggs, folding her legs underneath her.

"I'm surprised you haven't killed me yet?"

Her tone was half joking, but something sincere was weaved into it when she met Glimmer's pale lavender gaze.

"Disturbing your beauty sleep and all, frightening the shit out of you," Catra added to try and soften her earlier statement, or question rather.

"Nah, it's fine. You're stressed, I get it...sorta. And you didn't want to wake me up, I just did."

Catra let out a breathy chuckle, sarcastically voicing her thanks for Glimmer's mercy.

"What you said earlier...about being surprised I haven't killed you yet?"

Glimmer's voice trailed off, asking a question through lifting the pitch of her voice.

"I mean...I was pretty fucking awful to you, back then."

"A few months ago?"

Catra fought the burning red in her cheeks, averting her eyes from Glimmer.

"Yeah. If I were you, I don't think I'd be able to forgive someone. I guess I'm just surprised you did."

Glimmer shrugged, leaning back into the bed frame.

"Yeah, I'm surprised at myself too. But you're not so bad, once you soften your claws."

Catra laughed, moving to sit next to Glimmer in the bed. It more more than big enough for two.

"Could I... maybe-"

"Don't even need to ask. We're sisters, Catra."

Catra smiled to herself, nodding before tucking herself under the covers.

Sisters...like family.

"Night, Catra. Wake me up again and I'll slaughter you, and don't you dare hog the bed."

Catra chuckled again, tying her hair into a bun. Something told her she'd be able to get sleep now.

"Wouldn't dream of it."

_____

"Catra?"

A weight was near her, something steady and solid. She opened her eyes, searching for whatever presence she had felt. It was Adora.

"Hey, Adora."

She rolled over, hugging her pillow even tighter.

"When did you come here?"

Catra groaned, feeling a tonne of bricks had just been dropped on her head. She glanced at the clock. Great, a whopping three hours of sleep, and on the most important day of her life too. Technically she didn't have to wake up until around nine, but it was probably better she woke up earlier anyway.

"Around four in the morning. Couldn't sleep, so I tried to find you, but you were knocked out cold. Glimmer wasn't though."

She rubbed her eyes, adjusting to the sudden brightness in the room. Adora must've opened the curtains.

"You could've slept in my bed."

Catra grinned, sitting up as Adora folded her arms.

"Someone's jealous," she observed in a mocking voice.

"You really have no reason to be, I'm in a bed with my sister."

It was rare to see Adora so openly possessive...strangely hot.

"How're you feeling?"

Catra shrugged, grin vanished from her face.

"Fine, I guess. I don't know how to feel."

"You've still got the whole day."

"I know, probably why I'm not shitting bricks right now."

That was a lie, she was shitting bricks, even with a whole day to prepare herself.

"Lie. You've been shitting bricks for the past month."

Damn, that blonde knew her too well.

"Fine, I have. But it's like I'm so used to being stressed I can barely feel it anymore?"

She pushed herself out of the bed despite her body's urge to crawl back in. On any other day she would, she'd hide and bury herself in those covers, but she couldn't do that today.

"That's not good, I know because I take Psychology."

Adora seemed smug with her knowledge of stress, which was both endearing and insufferable.

"Selye's GAS Model states that your body undergoes the alarm, resistance and exhaustion phase when stressed. I'm sensing a lot of exhaustion from you hon."

Catra resisted the urge to knock her off the side of the bed. She, Adora, couldn't seriously be acting like a stress master right now?

"Filthy hypocrite," she groaned, mustering the courage to rise from the warm comfort.

"Sorry, I have a psych assignment due," she blushed and Catra's annoyance dissipated. It was dangerous, the things Adora could make her feel.

"Yeah well, I frankly don't give a fuck if I'm in the exhaustion phase. I could collapse and it doesn't matter. As long as the show

goes without a hitch."

She raked her hands through her hair. Yuck, it needed a desperate wash. Her eyes caught on Adora's which were fixated on her hands.

"Yes?"

The blonde seemed to shake herself out of whatever trance she'd been in, coaxing an infamous smirk from Catra.

"Nothing, your hair just looks nice. But that's nothing new."

Her hair? As in the gross mess on her head? Looked nice...after being unwashed for about a week? She laughed.

"Thanks, but no."

"Seriously, though," Adora followed her into the bathroom.

"It's dirty as fuck, Adora-"

"No, I'm not talking about your hair."

Catra frowned in confusion, what was she talking about then?

"You shouldn't put your whole life on the outcome of this show. I know it's important for your future career and all, but it's not gonna be the the peak of your life."

"I'd cry if this show was the peak of my life, but it's the biggest thing for me right now, Adora. Excuse me if I'm stressed about it. You're not my therapist, so stop acting like it."

She folded her arms defiantly, meeting Adora's concerned gaze with a stiff one of her own. What she despised more than anything was being told how to think, act or feel. Adora was beginning to cross into that territory.

"No, but that doesn't mean I can't be worried for you. Be stressed, I get it, but try not to kill yourself with it."

"Too late for that," Catra muttered under her breath. She braided her hair into twin plaits, it was just long enough for that now.

"Just...take it easy today, 'kay?"

"I will."

"Promise?"

Her defiance melted into acquiescence like butter. Adora was giving her the fucking puppy eyes, she couldn't be angry at that.

Stupid golden retriever.

She sighed, meeting her eyes again.

"Promise. I'll try to chill out today."

"Thanks."

A bout of gratitude overwhelmed Catra all of a sudden. She'd never have thought someone would care this much about her and her wellbeing, rather than what she had to offer. Angella was always caring and warm, of course, but she hardly got to see her mom across the year. She reached up, asking Adora for a hug, for which the blonde instantly responded.

"Thanks, I guess."

"No thanks necessary."

A Starless Constellation

Catra looked at herself in the mirror, eyes running over every blemish of fear and trying to rectify it. She couldn't look scared, they'd eat her alive if she acted like a child. Adjusting the lapels on her outerwear, she took a few deep breaths.

A deep navy blazer, with silk black trims and embroidery, paired with matching pants, and shoes to die for. If she was being completely honest, the shoes were her favorite, a classic satin black with a deep red sole and a neatly tied black diamond bow fashioned at the sharp edged toe. And of course an elegant v-shaped necklace with a diamond drop that delicately slipped down the centre of her torso, meeting the neckline of her sheer corset. She was an image of utter class, and complete confidence...it was a shame she didn't feel like either of those things.

Her hands shook as she fastened the last button on her cuffed sleeves, spraying herself with her signature scent to try and mask the anxiety. She could do this, she'd been working up to it for the past year or so.

"You can do it, Catra."

She whispered to herself in the mirror, eyes piercing her own. It was time, she had to leave.

"Woah, you look..."

"Good? I know."

She smiled at Glimmer, who hadn't started getting ready. She was about an hour early, but she needed that whole hour to make sure everything was organized. Besides, it'd take twenty minutes just to drive to the place. All the guests arrived in limousines, but she knew she wouldn't be able to relax in one by herself. It was her preference to drive, at least she'd be temporarily distracted. And she hadn't used her car in a good few months.

"Did you make the suit?"

Glimmer closed whatever art magazine she'd been flipping through to properly examine Catra's outfit.

"Duh, Sparkles. Not the shoes, or jewelry for obvious reasons, but yeah. I did make the suit."

She fastened on some last minute simple, yet sophisticated diamond studs. They were a gift from Angella for her sixteenth birthday, along with the car.

"I'm out, I'll see you in a bit."

"See ya, good luck."

"Don't need it," Catra called back, grabbing a few rings off Adora's bedside table and shutting the door softly behind her. She carefully slid the rings on her fingers, standing outside the door for a moment. Usually Adora was the one borrowing Catra's jewelry, but Catra liked wearing Adora's rings. It made her feel as if she was with her, in some sort of shape or form. She wasn't, of course. Adora was already at the venue, getting her hair and make-up professionally done for the runway.

Shoving her phone in her pocket, she slipped on a pair of sunglasses. Sunset was the fucking worst time to drive.

A smile adorned her face at the sight of her car. She couldn't think of a single thing she loved more than it....well, maybe there were one or two 'things.'

A matte black Audi R8 LMS GT2, it was her baby. Catra opened the driver door, settling herself into the dark leather seats and putting her phone in the charging compartment. She set up the GPS with the location of the destination, turning on the engine and putting the car into reverse to leave the carpark.

Driving with one hand, she swiped her fingers across the screen to call Adora. She picked up instantly.

"Hey," her voice was breathless.

"Hey, Princess," Catra turned onto the road, approaching the exit gates of the school. She sent through a virtual request to leave the premises; a feature Angella had installed to ensure students were leaving the school at appropriate times. The gates swiftly moved aside, allowing Catra entry onto the highway.

"I'm freaking out, are you freaking out?"

"I was about ten minutes ago, but driving's helping me calm down."

"Catra-" she whispered into the phone, the tonal shift catching Catra's attention instantly. She distantly listened the robotic voice of the GPS instructing her to take a right in five hundred metres.

"Yeah?"

"This outfit is wayyy too much on me."

Catra snickered, she'd forgotten that Adora had never seen seen the garment before. During all their fittings she'd been blindfolded.

"Love, it was modeled after you."

"You can't seriously believe this creation, this masterpiece, resembles me? Awkward, clumsy, completely inelegant Adora?"

"Look at the masterpiece, dummy, properly. We've already talked about this, I don't need to explain it to you again."

Catra's words sounded harsh to her own ears, but she didn't like it when Adora devalued herself. That dress was literally made for her.

"Yeah, yeah, I know. The color really does match my eyes."

"Have you put it on yet?"

"Nup, they're rubbing glitter oil on me. Glitter oil, Catra. It smells like cupcakes."

Her incredulous whisper rose an octave, encouraging a wide grin from Catra.

"When they put it on, send me a photo. I've been imaging you in that outfit for months," she took a sharp left, the sun reflecting off her glasses.

"Sure. I've gotta go, they're glaring at me."

Catra assumed Adora was referring to the backstage crew, or perhaps DT, who she'd entrusted to coordinate part of the schedule.

"I'll leave you to it. See you soon."

She hung up, turning her playlist on instead.

"Turn right onto the M1 in 1.2 kilometers."

Catra's smile broadened. The freeway, her favorite. It was the only chance she got to show off her car's engine, and the speed.

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She watched the lights turn off as she locked the car, taking a gulp as she looked up at the obsidian building. A brilliant sign was lit up, featuring the fashion's show theme: A Starless Constellation, and....Catra's name. Her anxiety intensified, and she nervously spun Adora's ring on her index finger with her thumb.

Holy shit it's actually happening.

She skipped the assembled rows of red velvet rope stands, entering the wide golden doors to climb the glass staircase.

When she'd first visited the place to map out the decorations, she was struck speechless. Ropes of diamond hung above the

staircase, the bright white light reflecting off the stone to cast the illusion of a rainbow. She could hardly stop staring when she first laid eyes on it.

Her mind could barely conjure an image of how it will look with the decorations fitted into the space. Luckily, she didn't have to, because she got to witness it first hand.

"Holy shit," she breathed to herself, raising her sunglasses to rest atop her head.

"Catra!"

Her head spun wildly to the sound of that voice, her mom's voice.

"Mom!"

Angella approached her from across the room, her golden heels clicking against the polished marble floor.

"You look incredible, Catra."

She held the side of her face with two hands, the warmth in her gaze causing Catra to redden. Praise from Angella was scarce, but always genuine.

"Thanks mom, you too."

Her eyes scanned up and down to survey the outfit, as Catra religiously did at most events for most people. She struggled to remember what actually happened at events, yet she could always imagine what an individual wore to it. A strange talent.

Angella's outfit matched the theme perfectly, but that was no surprise. The woman did create it, after all. Golden stiletto heels with diamond encrusted straps(Catra doubted even she could pull off such a spectacular shoe), a strapless fishtail navy gown that cut off around her ankle in the front (to show off the shoe, of course), but extended into a trail in the back, paired with an impressive v-neckline To substitute for sleeves she wore a silk

mesh blended bolero (Catra had a similar one in maroon), and a simple moonstone necklace.

"The crown is a bit much, don't you think?"

Catra joked as her eyes landed on the subtle diadem weaved into Angella's blush and lilac coloured hair. She knew why Angella wore it, the stone in the centre was the perfect companion to the necklace, but it was still comical that she wore a literal tiara.

"Well I figured I am technically a queen of a school," Angella tried to justify herself to Catra's utter amusement. She smiled with raised eyebrows.

"Sure, Mom. Where's dad?"

"Backstage," she nodded her head to behind the runway. Catra didn't really understand the physics behind a floating lit up glass platform in the centre of the room, but as long as it looked cool (which it very much did). She made a mental note to ask Bow about it later. He'd know, being an architecture nerd and all. She smiled to herself at the thought of him seeing this place, he'd go fucking nuts.

"The decorations look-"

"Dazzling?"

"Sure," Catra did a 360 turn to fully admire the place. Black velvet curtains with threads of silver weaved through them, a moonstone and glass Murano chandelier hanging from the centre of the roof (it resembled the moon perfectly), chairs neatly wrapped it navy silk...she couldn't have asked for any more.

"I'm gonna go do my final checks backstage."

"Alright, just make sure you're back here in around twenty minutes, that's when the guests are expected to arrive."

Catra nodded, taking a gulp as she entered through the backstage door. In all honesty, the guests were the most terrifying aspect of this thing. She'd spent a whole week memorizing the names and faces of each and every one, along with their professions and history. Some of the most bloodthirsty journalists would be attending, including Tung Lashor and Peekablue, the ultimate nepotism baby (his father is the director of one of the biggest labels in the country). He would be sure to scrutinize every fucking detail of her work. The last time she'd met him was at a musical premiere two years ago, and he'd commented that the fabric of Catra's dress looked as if it was made from his "great grandmother's tablecloth." That dickhead wouldn't have a single thing to criticize about this show, not if Catra could help it.

She whistled when she spotted Adora among the collection of models getting their hair styled, the girl so breathtaking Catra couldn't take her gaze away.

"Looking good, Blondie."

Her makeup was done, deep blue and creamy pearl eyeshadow tastefully painted on her eyelids. The eyeliner was striking, and fierce. It was exactly what Catra wanted, with a tiny diamond stud at the point on each wing to accentuate the look. The rest of her makeup was dewy and light, gentle enough to soften her striking eye makeup.

"You weren't joking about the body oil, you're glowing."

"You look..."

Adora's words seemed to get stuck in her throat as she took Catra in, which only make Catra smirk.

"Yes?"

Adora struggled to keep her eyes on Catra's, causing the grin to widen.

"Really hot."

"I try."

Her confidence was a mask for her mess of nerves. It was an adequate shield.

"Are those my rings?"

"Uh huh. You're always stealing mine, so I'm repaying the favor."

Adora shrugged, looking down at her manicured nails. Catra took a proper look at her hair. It was tied back into a high pony tail, gel slicking it down except for the two front pieces she wanted braided to create a headband. Extensions were put in, making the ponytail longer and fuller as it cascaded down Adora's back.

"This thing is giving me a tension headache."

Adora pointed to the mass of blonde behind her head, eliciting a chuckle from Catra.

"I want you to look like a warrior, the ponytail acts as a vehicle for that message," Catra offered as an explanation.

"Darling, you look truly magnificent."

Catra instantly smiled at the sound of DT's voice, turning to face them. They themself wore a black suit with a coattail, paired with an iridescent sea-foam colored tie, and matching reflective heels.

"Thank you, thank you."

She bowed her neck in appreciation, DT taking a look at Adora.

"Do you like my work?" They gestured to the blonde sitting in the chair.

"Did I communicate the vision?"

"Perfectly. Thank you."

Catra gave them a smile of thanks, DT pulling a pair of diamond rope earrings and giving them to Adora to put on her ears.

"I don't have them pierced?"

"They're clip ons, darling."

Adora nodded, Catra watching as she fastened them onto her ear lobe.

"Where's the necklace?"

Catra scanned Adora's vanity, spotting nothing of interest.

"Right hereeee," DT sing songed, revealing a velvet box from behind their back. They opened it to display thin snakes of silver weaving and twisting to finally encircle a stunning pale blue diamond in the centre. Similar to Catra's own necklace, a thin rope of silver dropped from the bottom of the diamond to align seamlessly with the neckline of the outfit.

"You cannot seriously be trusting me to wear that?"

Catra took the gloves DT offered, slipping them on her hands so she could take the necklace from the box. It'd taken her a month to source the perfect stone, and another two weeks for the jeweler to create it. She wasn't risking fingerprints.

"Yup," she responded to Adora's question, opening the clasp and gracefully securing it around Adora's neck. She looked in the mirror, meeting Adora's eyes before looking down at the stone.

"It matches perfectly."

She high-fived DT, who she'd driven mad with finding this goddamned rock.

"For the theme of a 'Starless Constellation,' all these diamonds kindaaa look like stars," Adora looked inquiringly at Catra, who shrugged

"The theme is a contradiction in itself. You can't have a constellation without stars, and it can't be starless if there's a constellation. If the theme gets to be confusing, why can't my fashion show?"

She'd cracked her head open for ages trying to figure out what the theme meant when really it meant nothing at all. She'd narrowed her limitations down to having no fabric with diamonds or silver threading, but the jewelry could display the 'constellation' aspect of the idea. Adora's necklace held a pale blue stone, which she envisioned as a planet, with vines of silver surrounding it, representing a constellation.

"A show deficient in diamonds would be so dull," DT agreed.

Catra slung an arm around their shoulder, peeling the gloves off and slipping the soft cloth items back into DT's pocket.

"I agree."

DT flicked their wrist, checking the time.

"Time for you to leave kitten."

They untucked Catra's arm from their shoulder, tapping Catra's nose and winking at Adora before disappearing into another section of the backstage area.

"Ugh, I need to do my final checks."

Catra pursed her lips in annoyance at leaving Adora. Even just her presence managed to somewhat settle her nerves. Catra's eyes found the hangar holding Adora's garment, and she smiled.

"You're gonna look incredible," she breathed.

"I sure hope so."

Catra let out a small whisper of a laugh, gazing at her for a moment.

"I know so. God I wish I could kiss you right now."

She really did, but messing up the makeup wasn't worth it. She didn't even want to risk touching Adora.

"Me too," her gaze met the floor before flicking back up to Catra.

"Okay, now I really gotta go," Catra approached to give her a hug before quickly retracting at the last minute. Nope, no touching. She didn't feel like having glitter all over her suit.

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"Catra! Back just in time."

Angella latched her arm onto Catra with a firm grip, eyes widening and tone warning. She gave a sheepish smile, she was only two minutes late. Everything appeared to be in order backstage, they were ready to rock and roll.

"Catra, this is-"

"Lykra Spells? It's been a dream of mine since I was young to meet you."

That was an utter lie. Catra didn't know who the fuck Lykra Spells was until last Tuesday. But the woman bought it (obviously, Catra was an experienced liar), laughing indulgently.

"Oh, you flatter me, but the honor is mine. It's not everyday you meet raw talent. And you, Catra Brightmoon, are raw talent."

Eugh, could she be anymore fake?

Still she spread a charming smile on her face, grabbing two champagne flutes as they came around and offering one to Spells.

"It's not everyday you get complimented by your idol," this evoked another giggle from Spells, who looked at Angella.

"I must say, Angella, you truly do have the most well-mannered daughters."

Catra resisted the urge to snort. Her? Glimmer? Well mannered?

Angella looked to be hiding a laugh too, smiling widely.

"I'm truly fortunate. Come Ms Spells, we have much to discuss regarding your daughter's enrollment."

Angella, ever the businesswoman, linked her arm through Lykra's, leading her away from Catra and towards the lines of seat pushed towards the edge of the runway.

"Ah, Lykra Spells. I did a deal for her once."

Catra turned to face the man beside her, Micah.

"Dad!"

She jumped a little in surprise, giving him a quick hug before returning to her examination of the guests milling around.

"Good to see you, Cats."

Catra hadn't run into him backstage, but she was glad she got to saw him now. It'd been months. She was about to enquire about his latest trip to Mystacor when-

"Is that my little diva? Catraaa, sweetie!"

Catra was yanked backwards into the arms of her aunt, Castaspella.

"Hey Aunt Castaspella," she wheezed out, the air collapsed from her lungs. She heard Micah's distant laugh as her aunt released her.

"I was just asking Glimmer where you were, hiding from me are you?"

"Nope," she laughed awkwardly, "just been busy, you know... planning this whole thing."

Castaspella tucked her in for a second hug with a laugh.

"It's so cute, how grown up and professional this all is."

Catra refrained from mentioning the budget of this entire event. Castaspella didn't intend to be condescending, she was just used to a younger Catra.

"I've been working on it for ages..." Castaspella turned to look at it all, affording Catra the chance to make a half-assed excuse about 'checking on the speakers' and ditching her presence.

"There you are Wildcat!"

Catra sighed in relief. Scorpia was much better than her judgemental aunt.

"Evenin' Scorps," she adjusted the blazer of her suit, fixing her hair up from Castaspella running her hands through it.

"You really outdid yourself."

Catra blushed, glad that Scorpia liked it.

"Really?"

"Look at the place? It's amazing Wildcat. I'm fairly certain the only thing that'll top it is the designs."

She winked nudging her as her dark eyes flitted from decoration to decoration.

"Naw, thanks. It..means a lot."

"I'm proud of you Catra. This is huge."

The blush deepened. She felt tears hide behind her eyes but forced them down. Now wasn't the time for waterworks, her

makeup would get severely smudged.

"It's about time we saw the one and only Head Organizer."

Catra whipped her head around to face Bow and Glimmer, both grinning from ear to ear.

"I'll leave you to your friends," Scorpia gave her a last fleeting smile before disappearing into the crowd. Catra watched her link arms with Perfuma, and smiled at the couple.

"It's about time you two arrived."

She hugged the two of them, watching in amusement as Bow's eyes enlarged when he took in the space.

"This place is. fucking. amazing."

"You're telling me," Catra nodded. Glimmer wore a black jumpsuit with silver cuffs on her wrists and a diamond studded cape with-

"No way, are those actual constellations?"

Catra spun her sister around for closer inspection, spotting Cassiopeia and Ursa Major.

"Pretty cool, huh? I try."

Catra spun her back around, nodding in appreciation.

"Very cool."

Bow wore a navy velvet tux, with a cropped button black button down shirt, , of course, a bowtie, and a glinting silver watch.

"I better go mingle a bit more, it's my job as hostess."

Catra rolled her eyes, sticking her tongue out for effect. Bow and Glimmer gave her a final smile before wandering off, probably to find their parents and friends.

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"Esteemed Guests and Alumni of the Brightmoon Institution, I warmly invite you to take a seat."

It's happening. Oh god it's actually happening.

Catra downed the rest of her champagne; it was her second glass.

She'd stay down here for the first ten or so minutes, before quietly heading backstage to make sure everything runs smoothly for the rest of the show. DT's voice reverberated around the room as they spoke.

"May I please present this year's Head Organizer for Brightmoon's Annual Fashion Show, Catra Brightmoon!"

That was her cue.

Catra approached the glass staircase with careful steps, keeping her speed fast, but not rushed. The sound of applause and her heart thundering drowned out every other noise in the room. She turned on her microphone, the thing fitted around her ear and tucked in the back of her pants. She knew the speech like the back of her hand, it flowed from her mouth like honey.

"Good Evening Everyone!" She smiled broadly, eyes shining as she faced the seats before her.

"Before we begin, I'd like to offer you a few reminders: please turn your phones off, I'd hate for them to be confiscated at any point during the show. Photography and videography is permitted, but please leave flash for media professionals only, thank you. If at any point of the show you interrupt or disturb other guests and working professionals, you will be escorted outside the premises."

She took a breath, steadying herself. No fuck ups...yet.

"And lastly, on behalf of the event committee and faculty, and of course, myself, I'd like to extend a warm thank you to all

coordinators, decorators, sponsors and friends who assisted in the production of this event. None of this would be possible without you."

Another round of applause occurred, and Catra joined in for this one, smiling at DT hiding in the wings.

"I present to you, A Starless Constellation!"

Catra turned in her most elegant fashion, walking down the steps again as the lights dimmed further. The lights on the stage glowed brighter, the chandelier above them acting as a pinnacle of brightness and partly illuminating the stage.

The backdrop faded from the academy logo to the video she'd organized a few weeks prior. The music began playing, everything seemed to be running smoothly. Catra took a seat on the balcony overlooking the stage, holding her breath as the first model stepped on the stage.

The piece she'd chosen to open the show had to encapsulate the entire essence of the collection.

A dramatic neckline, cinched waistline and flared leather pants had seemed perfect for the job. She watched the crowd's faces in anticipation, sighing in relief when she spotted smiles and stares filled to the brim with adoration.

They liked it. My designs. They liked it.

The next model appeared, and the smiles grew, and grew...and grew. They were fucking loving it. Camera flashes littered the scene, and Catra felt her heart rate begin to lower. She made her way towards the backstage, an untouchable smile permanently etched onto her face. Her expression only intensified when she got a look at Adora.

"Woahh...you look incredible."

Adora blushed in the mirror as she noticed Catra behind her.

"I kinda do, don't I?"

"Fuck yeah."

Adora kept her hands far away from the steel-like fabric that carved it's way up her body.

"Hey, and you mastered the shoes."

Catra looked her up and down, only slightly surprised Adora wasn't wobbling in the heels.

"Did you ever doubt me?"

Catra hesitated, and Adora laughed.

"I got some extra help," she said by way of explanation.

Catra didn't question she did, she stood with complete grace and confidence, filling with Catra with absolute certainty that she'll nail the walk when it was time.

She stood in awe at the scene surrounding her. Models adorned in her pieces, waiting to walk down the runway, stage organizers talking in communication devices with clipboards in hand, a live television displaying the crowd's reaction...it was unbelievable, and she was the centre of it all.

"What are you thinking?"

Catra snapped out of her thoughts, meeting Adora's expression.

"How fucking crazy this all is."

She gestured to everything around them, a smile beaming on her face. It was incredible, truly incredible.

"You deserve every bit of it."

She reached out and grabbed both of Catra's hands, rubbing her thumbs over them as she smiled. Catra couldn't help but blush.

"I'm proud of you."

Catra let out a breathy laugh at the sincere voice and message.

"Don't make me cry, Blondie, it'll ruin the makeup."

Catra sniffed, blinking quickly in an attempt to dry her eyes. She let go of their hands, gently adjusting the sleeve of Adora's outfit.

"Kill it," she met her eyes, winked, and left to stand by the wings.

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"They're loving the plum satin number you did," DT sidled up next to Catra behind the curtain. She smirked, folding her arms across her chest as she watched the crowd, hidden by the royal blue and silver drapes.

"I knew they would. That dramatic bow and train was genius, if I do say so myself." She flipped her short strands of hair jokingly.

"Mm, and the color too. It shifts perfectly between cherry and purple in this light."

"I know." DT laughed at her sigh of contentment.

"So cocky. Fair enough, I guess, I sure wouldn't shut up if this was my collection."

Catra fought the blush to maintain an image of sophisticated arrogance; her favorite demeanor.

"So you see my point then?"

DT nodded with a tilt of their head, hiding behind Catra as a model brushed past them.

"Adora's up next."

"I know."

Catra's attention flitted to the blonde's long, shiny ponytail, obscured by the stage director in front of her. He was saying something to her, probably some last minute instructions.

"Have you seen her walk yet?"

Catra shook her head.

"I don't doubt she'll nail it, she's a perfectionist in just about everything," she murmured quietly with a smile. Even now she could spot the fierce look of determination settling over Adora's features.

Catra had never been more turned on.

"You're right, it's a fabulous walk."

Catra hadn't specified the models to walk in any certain way, she preferred that they left it up to their own interpretation. She, did however, instruct them to match their walk to the style of their outfit.

Adora was signaled to leave the safety of behind the curtain, and Catra watched eagerly as she powered down the runway. The cameras went crazy, predictably. After-all, this was the masterpiece of Catra's show. A body suit that resembled liquid mercury, the light bouncing off Adora and causing a kaleidoscope of colors to appear. Soft steel wings curved out to broaden her shoulders, the fabric plunging into a deep neckline with cut outs in the side. The diamond stilettos, with a heel and platform composed of glass (with flecks of gold shining in them), perfectly accentuated the fluidity of the whole design. The midnight blue and grey colored mesh attached to the goldenbelt at her waist flowed seamlessly around her body as she walked. The centerpiece, of course, was the necklace, the color of the stone matching both Adora's eyes and the shades of the skirt.

"The sword was brilliant," Catra murmured to DT, unable to take her eyes off Adora for a second.

"A stroke of genius, I know. Thank the heavens for antique shops."

DT had bought an ancient relic a few days prior; a magnificent steel blade with a golden brushed hilt and an opal fitted inside the pommel. Catra was convinced the second DT pitched the idea to her. It suited Adora perfectly.

The minute Adora exited the stage the first model reentered, followed by the entire cast as they followed each other in quick succession.

"Bravo, kitten."

Catra let out a laughter of relief, pushing her palm against her rapidly beating heart.

"God, I feel like I can breathe again."

The models finally cleared out, Adora being the last, and Catra got the nod of approval from the stage director to make her final appearance on the platform.

As soon as she stepped out the audience erupted into applause, the deafening noise drumming against her ears. Catra couldn't help the grin that was plastered on her face. People began standing up, causing Catra to nearly die of happiness.

"Thank you, thank you!"

She settled the crowd after a few minutes, tears crawling their way up to her eyes and threatening to break through when she spotted her friends' and parents' faces in the crowds.

Lemonstar Jelly Ice

Adora was utterly mesmerized by her, Catra, the entire night. The only signs of nervousness were her hands, which shook tremendously as the show closed.

But that was nothing in comparison to the way she moved, with seamless fluidity and charm, among the various almuni and guests attending the event. Adora could hardly imagine putting together somethinglike this, the amount of coordination, dedication and creativity it would've taken. She could barely handle organizing Catra's surprise party, let alone this.

Catra didn't just execute it in an elegant manner, she made it look easy.

"I can't believe that just happened," Catra whispered quickly in her ear as they embraced.

"It was amazing, I can hardly believe you did all of this."

Adora hadn't gotten a proper chance to marvel over the decor and outfits the guests wore. She'd been sick to her stomach for most of the day, worrying that she'll screw up her walk and Catra would blame her for ruining her show. Thankfully, that didn't happen. Quite far from it, actually. She'd been complimented several times throughout the night how "spectacular" and "dazzling" she'd been on the runway. A man had even commented that she looked like an "intergalactic warrior alien" at one point during dinner, but she just smiled and nodded at the strange compliment. He himself looked like an "intergalactic warrior alien," with neon green sideburns and a suit that sparkled. Not to mention the strange gentleman wore diamond studded sunglasses inside the venue.

"This is really not my scene," she spoke to Glimmer beside her as dessert came around the table.

A dark chocolate and raspberry dome cake, with glazed white chocolate covering the dish, and flecks of gold and obsidian covering both the plate and dessert. To be quite honest, Adora hadn't enjoyed either the appetizer and main offered. Both were the smallest portions possible, and while they looked literally out of this world (all meals followed the theme of the night), they tasted quite strange. The appetizer was an interesting cubed delicacy, which went under the name of "Lemonstar Jelly Ice" and had about zero flavor. Apparently it was a famous dish from a country that no longer existed.

"Same here."

Adora looked at Glimmer in surprise. She grew up as the daughter of one of the most influential people in the world, how could she be unused to all of this?

"Really?"

"Yeah. Sure, Mom and Dad always held big, fancy events like these, but I sorta just hid in a corner with Bow for most of them. We snuck dino nuggets in one time."

Adora snickered quietly, imaging a premature Bow and Glimmer stuffing nuggets into the pockets and crevices of their glamorous outfits.

"Catra was always a natural though," Glimmer's violet eyes moved towards her sister, and so did Adora's. It was true, Catra seemed to fit in with the scene perfectly. She wafted around the room with a tray filled with glasses containing a clear blue drink, offering it to the guests herself while easily making small talk. She'd always been good at that, warming up to people quickly, socializing. Adora could vividly recall her making allies in the orphanage. Even when she'd have tantrums, yell at them, every single one of those kids still drew to her like moths to a flame. She was magnetic; utterly irresistible. Shadow Weaver was one of the few teachers who'd always favored Adora to her.

"Yeah, she is."

Catra drifted towards their table after making a joke at one of the other tables. It must've been pretty funny, for one woman was nearly crying with laughter, holding onto Catra's shoulder as she dried her eyes with a black silk napkin. Adora's stomach churned at the sight of the touch before she came to her senses and realized that the woman was probably triple their age, and that Catra was wearing a manufactured smile.

"Hey, Adora," she tried not to blush at the greeting, or more specifically, the way Catra murmured it.

"No hello for your favorite sister?"

Glimmer huffed from beside her, arms crossed due to being ignored.

"You're my only sister, but hello to you to Sparkles."

Glimmer flipped her off, but subtly. Last thing they needed was some dodgy reporter to snap a photo and put it on a cheap gossip magazine with the headline: "Brightmoon Sisters Feuding Again?"

Catra stuck her tongue out in response, placing two glasses of the blue beverage on the table. Adora only realized steam was rising out of the glass when it was set in front of her.

"What's this?"

"Spiced blue cider. This one's good, I promise."

Adora raised her eyebrows, picking up the slightly warm crystal glass.

"Oh? If you've promised it must be good, I guess."

She raised the drink to her lips and took a sip.

Catra was indeed correct. Flavors of honey and lemon filled her senses, with a pinch of blueberry that seemed to be infused in the beverage.

"Did I lie?"

Adora shook her head, taking another sip, and Catra performed her signature smirk.

"Where's Bow?"

Glimmer jerked her head to the other side of the room, where Bow was talking avidly with an eccentric looking grey haired man.

"He's just met Professor Hawk, Mr Hawk and Arsan's dad. He teaches at Bow's top preference college."

Adora nearly spit out her drink.

"College preferences have open?" Her eyes flicked between Glimmer and Catra, who nodded.

"Relax, you still have ages to apply and pick your preferences. But yeah, they just opened."

"Where does Bow want to go?"

"Crypto State, it's the best for architecture and arts."

"Are you applying there too?"

Adora directed her question at Glimmer.

"Yeah, it's my second preference. My first will probably be Beast Island. Only the best abstract artists have graduated from there, and Dad did too, though he was a business major."

Adora tilted her head up to look at Catra, who had crossed her arms across the top of Adora's chair.

"And you?"

"I'm not settled on anything yet, but I'm thinking Black Garnet."

Glimmer raised her eyebrows, leaning back as she looked at Catra.

"Black Garnet? That averages on a 5% acceptance rate."

"And Beast Island averages on a 7. What's your point, Sparkles?"

Adora's head was spinning so wildly, she could hardly focus on the conversation. She had hardly thought about universities, in fact she'd completely forgotten that at some point in the near-ish future, she'd be graduating from Brightmoon.

"Adora?"

She blinked, Catra nudging her lightly on the shoulder.

"Wha- sorry, I spaced out," she shook her head, feeling the beginning of a headache begin to take over. With a ponytail the size of a horse attached to her head, it was honestly a miracle she had lasted as long as she did without one.

"Yeah, I could tell."

Catra looked behind her at the crowd for a second.

"I'd better go back to mingling, I'll see you guys in a bit."

Adora nodded distantly, still distraught over her lack of thought about her future. Glimmer was too busy gulping down the hot drink to notice, and Bow returned back to the table shortly after.

"Sorry for leaving, he's just so cool," Bow gushed, taking a bite into the dessert.

"Cooler then me?" Glimmer asked jokingly.

"Obviously not. No one's cooler than my girlfriend." Though Glimmer was only joking, Bow's sincere reply made her cheeks redden slightly.

"I disagree, my girlfriend's cooler than yours," Adora rebutted to distract herself from the thought of college. She winked at Bow, who stretched a lazy arm over Glimmer's shoulder.

"Ouch, and I thought you were the nice one." Glimmer feigned to be hurt.

Adora shrugged with a smile.

"Let's agree to disagree before this gets ugly," Bow responded, ever the peacemaker of the group.

The rest of the night passed quickly, and Adora had to drag herself through it as the time slowly approached eleven o'clock.

_____

"I have to come and clean all this up tomorrow, and collect the designs," Catra said as she waved goodbye to the last of the guests. Now only Bow, Glimmer, Adora, Catra, and her parents remained. The room seemed so much bigger with the lack of people.

"I'm really proud of you sweetheart, we both are."

Angella brushed Catra's hair to rest behind her shoulders, and Adora's heart ached at the comforting touch. Angella looked to Micah, who smiled and gave Catra a small silver gift bag.

"For both tonight and tomorrow."

Catra accepted the gift, standing up to hug her parents simultaneously. Adora smiled and looked away for a moment, feeling as if she was intruding on a family moment.

"What's in the bag? What's in the bag?"

Glimmer playfully slapped Catra's wrist, trying to peer and see what the present was. Catra shielded the bag from Glimmer's eyes, swatting her arm away.

"You don't get to see," she made a face at Glimmer, who made one back.

"Wait for your birthday, Glim. Patience is a virtue," Angella smiled.

"Yes, a virtue I don't have," Glimmer grumbled in response.

"I'm dead tired," Catra yawned, resting her head on the back of the chair and closing her eyes briefly. Angella checked her phone before tucking it away again in her purse.

"We've got to pack for our flight tomorrow morning, but I think it's time we all go to bed."

Angella sneaked a card into Catra's hands, planting a kiss on her cheek while giving her a quick hug. Catra made a face, blushing profusely as Angella babied her, but Adora could tell she was secretly relishing it.

"Glimmer, I'm driving. I don't trust your judgment after even one drink."

Bow held his palm out for Glimmer's keys, the girl reluctantly handing them over.

"The lack of trust these days," she threw her hands up in exasperation, the group walking out the venue to greet the fresh night breeze.

Catra held out her hand for Adora to take, which she happily did.

"I parked in the staff area."

Both she and Adora gave their farewells to Micah and Angella, before heading off in the direction of the secluded car park.

"I don't think I've ever been in your car," Adora tried to remember a time she'd actually been inside Catra's infamous R8. She'd noticed it online multiple times, both on Catra's social media and in various magazines, but she'd never actually seen it in real life.

Catra pulled out her keys, tossing them in the air casually before catching them.

"Really? Well, you're in for a ride."

"I always am with you."

Adora bumped her shoulder into Catra's as they walked, swinging their arms between them.

"Ah, there she is, my one true love."

Adora let go of her hand to fist bump her arm.

"Rude, that spot's taken."

She tried not to stare at the car for too long, it really was magnificent. Perfectly suited to the girl who owned it. Catra quickly grabbed hold of Adora's waist, catching the blonde off-guard, and pressed her against the the side of the car, leaning in tauntingly.

"Oh yeah? By who?"

Adora looped her arms around Catra's neck, fingers playing with the chain of the silver necklace she wore.

"Mmm, perhaps me."

"Prove it."

Adora took the challenge, meeting Catra's lips with urgency. They'd barely touched each other all night in an effort to maintain their clothing and makeup. Adora was desperate to mess it up now.

Catra met her with the same intensity, swiftly unlocking the car and reaching for the handle to the door of the backseat.

"Sex in your car? I feel like I'm being played."

Adora whispered the words on her lips, Catra leading her inside.

"A grand total of three people have been inside my car, all of them being my family. Feel privileged, Blondie."

Adora's heart fluttered in response to that, leaning back against the soft leather seats as Catra closed the door behind them.

———————

HugsHugsHugs

"You really made a mess of me," Adora took a good look at herself in the mirror. Her hair had been wrangled free of the restrictive ponytail, eye-makeup smudged and feral (with a missing diamond stud), and half her clothes thrown on the bottom of Catra's backseat.

"You wish I didn't?"

"Not one bit," Adora instantly replied. She couldn't care less if she looked like a homeless space warrior. It was worth it.

"Well I don't look all that great myself."

No, Catra certainly wasn't in the impeccable state she was in before, but she made it work, naturally.

Adora, on the other hand, felt like she looked was worse than a mangled bird's nest. Her phone vibrated in her lap, and she quickly saw a text...well, her. Quickly muting the persistent bitch, Adora put her phone away.

Catra pulled into the school parking lot, removing the hand she'd placed on Adora's thigh to park properly and turn the engine off.

"Alright, out with it."

She leaned back in the driver's seat, folding her arms across her chest with an imploring gaze fixed to Adora.

"What?"

"Something's off, you're thinking."

"I can't think now?" She tilted her head at her.

"You don't very often, considering it took you this long to be with me."

Adora scoffed at the accusation, mouth agape.

"If I recall, you were the one that scratched my face and told me not to come near you. Sorry, was I supposed to consider that flirting?"

"Yes," Catra deadpanned. Adora made a face at her, but Catra wasn't deterred from her original question.

"No avoiding the topic. What is it?"

Adora glanced at the time displayed on Catra's dashboard, finding a suitable deflection.

11:53PM

"Hey, it's almost your birthday."

Catra looked at the clock, but didn't go for the bait.

"Don't even try."

Adora sighed, brushing her hands through her wrecked hair.

"Adora," Catra's voice had gone soft around the middle. She couldn't help but look at the shining gold and blue eyes.

"Catra," she responded in a similar tone, determined to distract from the focus of the conversation.

"You can tell me."

Adora sighed, leaning her head against the seat and closing her eyes. It wasn't that she didn't want to tell Catra the thoughts buzzing around her head, she just didn't know how. And it involved Shadow Weaver, which was never a good topic to bring up between them.

"Tonight...when you and Glimmer were talking about college and stuff..."

She played with the hair elastic wrapped around her wrist, avoiding Catra's stare.

"I dunno, it just, made me realize...that this ends, and everyone seems to know where they're going...except me."

"Hey, look at me."

Adora reluctantly faced her, feeling a bit embarrassed for her confession. It was silly for her to forget that there would be a life after Brightmoon, especially after being set on the idea of running for office one day. Adora found that she didn't want to do that anymore, it had never truly been her dream.

"First of all, plenty of people haven't thought about college yet, you're not in any way left behind in any of this. Counsellor meetings haven't even started yet."

Adora didn't even know what 'counsellor meetings' were, but she didn't voice this.

"Second of all, school is ending. Nothing else. Not us, not Glimmer or Bow, just school. And we still have another year, so don't stress."

Adora laughed, she felt like an idiot for getting so worked up when Catra was right, they still had a whole year together after this one.

"And third, no one knows what the fuck they're doing. I want to go to Black Garnet, sure, but I don't know anything else beyond that, like what to major in, or how college even works. You're not the only one confused about all of this."

Adora sighed, trying desperately not to let tears escape her eyes. Last thing she needed was to ruin Catra's big night by being a blubbering baby.

"She...wants me to do law."

Adora swallowed, hard, and turned to Catra. There was only kindness in her gaze, making the tears recede.

"Do you want to do law?"

Adora scoffed, but it came out a bit choked.

"God, no."

"Then screw her. It's your life Adora, don't let anyone else live it for you."

Adora couldn't help but reach over to hug her, wrapping her arms around her neck and pulling Catra close. Arms quickly enveloped around her as Adora continued to swallow down her urge to cry.

"Since when did you get all wise?"

Catra let out a huff of laughter, holding on tighter.

"Therapy teaches you a lot."

Adora crept into the dark hallway, tucking Catra's key in her pocket. Slipping into her bedroom, she tiptoed around the various items scattered around the place: a set of weights, a few design sketches, clothes...to finally reach the side of Catra's luxurious bed. It was double the size of Adora's, the velvet maroon sheets covering a slumbering girl. Adora crouched down beside her, placing Catra's coffee (an oat latte, no sugar) on her chestnut side table. She gently brushed the strands of hair covering her face, smiling to herself at the picture of utter contentment.

"Morning, Gorgeous," she spoke softly, turning on Catra's reading lamp to brighten the room a bit. A sleepy Catra slowly blinked her eyes open, surprised to see a fully dressed Adora kneeling before her, a bouquet of fresh peach roses in her hand. Adora adjusted her beige baseball cap in return, nudging the coffee cup closer to the birthday girl.

"Happy Birthday."

She'd already wished her last night in the car, and before saying goodbye to her in front of her dorm, but of course she had to say it again. It's not everyday you turn seventeen.

"Mmph," was all she said in response grabbing the bottom of her pillow and pulling it over her face to shield her eyes.

"Such a nice greeting, really appreciate it," Adora said dryly, but with a smile etched on her face. Catra's hand shot out of the duvet to reach for Adora, grabbing the fabric of her tan corduroy and white fur lined coat.

"Woah," Adora tried not to get her own coffee (regular cappuccino with two sugars; she preferred a bit of sweetness) on Catra's bed.

"Mm, you're warm."

Adora reached and placed her cup on Catra's opposite bedside table for safety, chuckling as the girl wrapped her hands around Adora as if she was a giant teddy bear.

As much as Adora would've liked to stay wrapped in Catra's arms, they had places to be.

"Come on, as pretty as you are in...is that my shirt?"

Catra smiled sheepishly, looking down at herself.

"It smelt like you."

Adora knelt down, sniffing the fabric on Catra's shoulder.

"I don't smell anything."

Catra rolled her eyes, pushing Adora upwards as she raised herself.

"Duh, dummy. No one can smell themselves."

She collapsed back into the bed, provoking Adora to poke at her in an effort to wake the grumpy girl up.

In response, Catra groaned, rubbing her eyes. She desperately grappled for the coffee, taking generous gulps.

"You're not human, I swear. No one goes to bed at one and wakes up this early, and in a good mood too."

Catra finished the rest of her coffee, but remained in the bed, rotating her torso in an attempt to get out of the bed.

"Five hours of sleep's plenty," Adora waved it off. She took hold of Catra's hands, interlacing their fingers and trying to gently pull her out of the bed.

"Sneaky."

"I just wanna hold my girlfriend's hands, nothing wrong with that."

Catra was slowly sliding out of the bed.

"I hate that this is working."

"Naw, you secretly love it, don't lie," Adora smirked when Catra didn't deny it. She managed to get her out of bed, disconnecting their fingers so she could wrap her hands around her in a hug. They stood there for a few moments, soaking each other in.

"Mmm...I don't wanna do today," Catra groaned as they stayed in the embrace.

"Why? It's your birthday," Adora retracted slightly to look at her properly. Catra never disliked her birthday in the orphanage, that was Adora. Adora's birthdays didn't cause her to have very many feelings, if she was being honest. The only difference was getting a second helping of ice cream at dinner time and a fresh set of stationary. Nothing special, so she hardly saw why people had

such strong feelings towards the day they entered the Earth....Well, when you put it like that...

"It's just, everyone expects you to be happy, and have fun, and hugging you and stuff."

"You love hugs," Adora raised her eyebrows at the current stance.

"From you. Not from strangers who think they have a right to touch me because they talked to me once."

"Wellll, breakfast is just gonna be us four, and then it's gonna be you and me for most of the day,"

Adora tucked her hair behind her ears, slowly removing herself from their embrace and spinning Catra towards her bathroom/walk-in closet.

"And dinner is gonna be us four again, plus DT, Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio and Scorpia."

She wrapped her arms around Catra's neck in an attempt to lead her into the closet.

"I guess that doesn't sound the worst," Catra admitted in a mumble.

"Great! Now go get ready because we have to leave in about..." Adora checked the time.

"Twenty minutes."

Catra laughed in response to that.

"We're leaving in forty," she joked (but not really).

"Forty it is!"

Adora nodded her head, pulling out her phone to text Bow and Glimmer, as well as call the brunch place.

———————

"Buckle up suckers, I'M driving."

Glimmer spun her keys around her finger, an obnoxious pink ball of fluff whizzing in the air. She pulled down her lavender tinted sunglasses with the biggest grin possible on her face.

"Oh god," Catra groaned, as the approached the bright pink Jeep. Adora snickered beside her at Bow's poor face. Glimmer just leaned against her car nonchalantly, as if modeling for a car commercial, waving to them as the girls approached.

"Dying on my birthday? Well, it's been a good seventeen years," Catra muttered dryly. Glimmer rolled her eyes at the joke.

"You guys make me sound like a road demon, I'm not that bad."

"A 'Stop' sign, Glimmer. A STOP sign."

Bow massaged his temples before reluctantly opening the door entering the vehicle.

"Yeah, well, it was a little small."

Bow muttered something incoherent under his breath, pulling his own pair of sunglasses on. Catra and Adora entered the back seat of the car as Bow punched in the directions on the GPS.

"Ah, I missed her," Glimmer hugged the steering wheel as if it was a child.

The car was really an embodiment of Glimmer herself, no one could deny it.

Bow adjusted the screen, putting some music on.

"Your presents' are in the trunk, Catra," Bow turned and gave Catra a wink, eyes darting to the back of the car.

"You guys didn't have to get me anything," Catra seemed so affronted that she actually blushed. Adora smiled at the sight.

"You get my present back at the dorm."

"Oh?"

In all honesty, the reason behind Adora being so alert in the morning despite 'going to bed' at such a late hour was simply because she didn't go to bed at all. She'd spent the whole night finishing Catra's new jacket, before picking up the pair of heels from Razz early in the morning.

"Now look Sparkles! A red light. That means you-"

"Stop! Yes, yes, I knowww!"

Adora laughed at Glimmer's red cheeks in the rearview mirror, the girl sticking her tongue out when she heard both Catra and Adora laughing from the backseat.

_____

"Breakfast was actually....nice. Good going, dummy."

Catra gave Adora a quick peck on her cheek as they entered Adora's dorm. Bow and Glimmer had dropped them back at the school before claiming that they needed ingredients to bake a cake for Catra's birthday dinner, heading to the grocery store.

"Did you doubt me?"

"Mmm, maybe a fraction."

Catra pinched her fingers together, causing Adora to make a face as she approached her from the opposite end of the coffee table.

"I'm surprised you're willing to dedicate a whole day to me."

Adora was profoundly confused by that revelation, and her expression said it.

"Why wouldn't I? It's your birthday."

"You're obsessed with homework, you dork. I doubted you could go a whole weekend of ignoring it."

It was true, Adora hadn't so much as glanced at her books since Wednesday, with the fashion show, Catra's birthday party, Catra's actual birthday...It had been a hectic few days.

"Well, you're more important."

Adora was almost astonished at the truthfulness of her own words. Barely a year ago she could hardly imagine prioritizing anything over a good grade...She realized now that there were more important things over school.

"Sheesh, me over schoolbooks? You must really be in love. Might as well put a ring on it."

Catra smirked with a waggle of her eyebrows, holding up her left hand. Adora matched her smile with one of her own, pressing the girl against the table and leaning in.

"Oh, I plan on it."

"Mmm, is that so?"

They were approaching their five month anniversary in a week or so, but Adora was fairly sure that not a single being could have such an effect on her as Catra did. No one would ever make her feel the way Catra did. Weightless, invincible, free.

She leaned in, but paused, not quite meeting Catra's lips. It was fun to taunt her once in a while. Adora smiled again, leaning back. Catra looked downright offended from the action.

"Come on, I need to give you my present."

Adora brushed her arm, slipping her hand into hers and interlacing their fingers as she pulled her onto the bed. The pair

kicked off their shoes, climbing on the soft mattress as Adora reached from underneath it to pull out a large black bag, a pencil drawing of Catra on it. She burst into a fit of laughter when she saw it.

"What the fuck is that?"

Adora frowned in confusion, looking at the bag.

"It's you, duh."

Catra doubled over in only more laughter, leaning on Adora's knee for support.

She wiped tears from her eyes, eventually regaining her posture.

"Awwe, don't be all sad," she said when she noticed Adora's confounded expression. She'd spent forty five minutes doing that drawing. Catra leaned forward and squished Adora's cheeks together lovingly.

"It's cute, I love your weird ass drawing of me."

She let go of her face, sitting back down. Adora let out a laugh of her own, glad that at least Catra seemed to like the effort she put into it. She wasn't exactly the best artist, but she tried. Adora used her to open the present, Catra obliging.

"This is a big bag, what on earth did you get?"

Adora made a hum, tapping her fingers together in suspense. Catra carefully pulled out the envelope placed on the top, setting it beside her with a glance at Adora.

"Should I read that now?"

Adora shook her head quickly. "If you do we'll both end up crying."

Catra nodded, tucking the card away and pulling out the shoe box first, unwrapping the cartoon kitten wrapping paper (Adora had spent ten minutes picking it out in the store) and pulling off the lid.

"Oh my fucking god."

Her mouth dropped open as she looked down, pulling out each shoe while looking back at Adora, completely aghast. Adora's humming intensified, as did her smile as Catra fell into shock.

"What-I-How did-"

Adora shrugged, Catra continue to marvel over the design of each shoe. They were truly exquisite.

"This matches my Gala dress perfectly," Catra murmured under her breath, but Adora still managed to catch the words.

"Do you like them?"

"Do I like them? Adora, they're everything I love...in a SHOE."

Adora felt proud of herself for picking a piece of attire for Catra, fashion extraordinaire, that she genuinely liked.

"They're like your eyes," Adora pointed to the contrasting colors.

"Wow, I totally didn't notice! Look! One's gold and the other blue." She pointed to each of her eyes as she spoke.

Her sarcasm wasn't lost on Adora, who made a mocking laugh with narrowed eyes.

Catra continued to run her fingers over the shoes, before gently placing them back into the box and retrieving the second item.

"What's this?"

Adora shrugged, prodding Catra to unwrap the second gift and discover the custom leather jacket.

"Woahhh, where the fuck did you find this?"

Catra ran her hands over the fabric, examining every aspect of the piece.

"Oh ya know, just made it."

Catra scoffed.

"Funny joke. No seriously, where's it from?"

"Not joking, love. I made it."

This managed to tear Catra's attention from the jacket to Adora.

"Holy shit, since when could you sew, like well?"

Adora fought off the heat rising to her cheeks at Catra's widened stare.

"Since I asked Mrs Ella to give me a few extra lessons."

She'd been visiting the textiles room after school for the past few days, Mrs Ella very willingly assisting her as she finalized the touches on Catra's birthday present. It didn't hurt that she convinced Mrs Ella to mark it as extra credit towards her grade average for the class.

"Wow, Blondie, I'm impressed. Didn't snap a needle?"

"Not a single one," Adora replied smugly. Catra faced her again.

"Thank you. Really."

Catra wrapped her arms around her in a hug, burying her face in the space between Adora's neck and shoulder. After a few moments, the pair finally broke apart, pausing briefly to hold each other's stare for a minute.

"Anything for you. Come on, we gotta leave soon."

Adora broke her gaze on Catra as her phone lit up with a notification beside her on the bed. She slyly switched the distracting thing off, flipping the device so the face of it couldn't be seen by herself, or Catra.

_____

The Crimson...Paintball?

"Really, the bus?"

Catra scrunched her nose as Adora nudged her onto the large vehicle. She rolled her eyes, quickly dragging her to a seat as the bus driver had no patience, hitting the accelerator and jolting them forward.

"Yes, the bus. And you have to audacity to call me a princess?"

Adora folded her arms across her chest, throwing a look at Catra, who simply threw it back.

"We could've just taken my car," she widened her eyes with a slight shake of her head.

"Now where's the surprise in that? If we took your car, you'd drive, and then you'd know where we're going." Catra only returned her words with a blank stare.

"So what you're saying is that you're dragging me out to be murdered in the woods?"

Adora was taken aback, unsure if she was joking or serious.

"What?"

"Not letting me know where I'm going...awfully suspicious... you already let Glimmer drive me today, and you look like that," she gestured up and down to Adora's outfit.

"...yep, you're trying to kill me."

"Catra."

"Adora."

The blonde sighed in mock exasperation, her arms across her chest tightening slightly.

She suddenly felt a nudge in the side of her arm, looking over to a mischievous Catra who had purposely knocked her shoulder into her's.

"Lighten up, Blondie. I'm only joking."

Her smirk intensified, the smile contagious, for one seemed to make its way onto Adora's face.

_____

"Adora Fucking Gray," Adora held her breath at the serious tone, hoping she'd made the right choice taking Catra here to spend the day.

"You know me too well," her unwavering grin only became bigger as they stared at the scene before them. Only the best, biggest and most dangerous Go Karting track in all of Brightmoon. Catra jumped up and down as they approached the entrance, her hair flying up and down with the wind.

"I've never been go karting," she revealed. Adora was utterly surprised by this. Catra had been to multiple holiday homes in various locations, been on sets of movies, met hundreds of celebrities, yet go karting was the one activity she'd missed out on?

"Not just go karting."

Adora nodded to the Paintball advertisement beside them, Catra's eyes widening so big Adora was pretty sure they'd fall out of her head. Her grip on Adora's arm tightened and she shook it vigorously, cheeks reddening.

"I've never seen you this...excited," Adora observed. Catra's head whipped around to look at her.

"It's just-I've never-"

Adora laughed as Catra tried to word a coherent sentence, leading them to the front desk to buy tickets.

"Hey, can we please get two tickets for go karting?"

The woman at the desk smiled warmly at them, her bright red lipstick offsetting her black and white referee top.

"Of course! Was that for one kart?"

Both Adora and Catra stared at her with questioning gazes, and the woman got the hint to elaborate.

"Will you be riding in one kart, together?"

The girls exchanged a look before releasing a bubble of laughter each. Adora turned to face the still smiling lady.

"God no. One each please, we'll ride separately."

"Of course! That'll be forty dollars, please."

Adora shoved Catra out of the way as she tapped her card on the Eftpos machine, throwing her a look. As if Catra was paying on her own birthday.

Sounds of fingers hitting buttons of a keyboard, and a small printer produced two cardboard wristbands. Adora thanked the woman as she passed them, putting Catra's on and Catra reciprocating the action for Adora.

"One last kiss before we murder each other?" Adora proposed, holding her arms out.

"Deal."

Catra raised herself on her toes, meeting Adora's lips for a few quick seconds before the pair finally pulled apart. She pushed her

hair back into a ponytail, rolling up the sleeves of her new leather jacket.

"Good luck, sweetheart." The words were nice, but anyone with ears could pick up on Catra's condescension.

"You too, honey. You'll need it."

Adora took off her hat, tucking it in her backpack along with her coat. Catra gave a taunting smile, which Adora only returned, and the couple separated onto their separate carts on the track. Luckily, there weren't that many people, just Adora, Catra, and three overzealous kids who looked like they'd consumed too much sugar.

"Hey, Adora," Catra called out over the roaring wind. Adora momentarily took her eyes off the red traffic light to glance at her girlfriend.

"What?"

"Eat my dust!"

Adora opened her mouth to shout a response, but the light turned green, and Catra sped off. Adora, quite literally, ate her dust.

"Game on," Adora started up her own cart, pressing hard on the accelerator. The first round only had three laps, and Catra was already fifty meters ahead of her on the first. And by playing dirty too, Adora gritted her teeth.

She quickly approached the first bend, and the blonde handled it swiftly, despite having never driven a car before. Catra was only twenty meters in front of her now...just a little more...

Adora couldn't help but relish the feeling; the wind pushing against her head, eyes watering from the fast motions, hands freezing on the wheel, and feet cramping from pressing on the accelerator too hard. It was blisteringly wonderful, Adora couldn't help but laugh as she came neck to neck with Catra's cart. The

two girls were far ahead of the three young boys, reaching their third curve around the track. Catra's gaze latched onto her as Adora passed her, the blonde quickly turning her head and sticking her tongue out...only to crash straight into the tires outlining the track.

"Sucks to be you, Blondie!"

Catra called out as she passed her, Adora groaning in frustration as she reversed and tried to catch up.

They had reached midway through their second lap, and Adora was still behind Catra. There was no hope for her to catch up unless Catra either crashed or her engine broke down, neither scenario seeming very likely. Catra was a natural at driving (what was that goddamn girl bad at?), controlling the small cart with ease. Adora wasn't too bad herself, but she wouldn't beat Catra unless-

Unless an idiot child was driving the cart on the wrong side of the track and knocked into Catra, veering both of them off course and leaving the path clear and empty for Adora to whizz through.

Well...

Adora did a quick check to make sure Catra wasn't seriously injured, but the girl was only scowling at the little boy, getting herself back on the track. Adora didn't waste a second, passing the line to progress to her third lap and pressing down on the accelerator with as much pressure as possible. Her knuckles tightened on the wheel, and she couldn't resist the urge to yelp as she passed the finish line, parking the car and unbuckling herself for a victory dance. Catra parked next to her, a glare etched on her face.

"I'm gonna punch that little boy."

Adora was wrong, the glare wasn't for her, it was for the child standing on the opposite end of the field, crying with a scratch on his knee.

"Come on now, Catraaa. Be a good sport."

Adora bent down, using her baby voice and pinching Catra's red cheeks. The glare was now fixed onto her.

"Scratch that, I'll punch you."

———————

"Hah! I still beat you."

"Okay, the first time was fair, but the second? You barely passed me by half a meter."

Catra snorted at that.

"More like half of a kilometer. Admit defeat, Blondie."

"Never. We still have paintball."

They approached the front desk again, the woman raising her eyebrows as they returned. Adora wasn't sure why she was giving them such a stunned look until she caught sight of the two of them in a dark window that acted as a mirror. She grabbed Catra's arm, nodding to the window.

Hair in complete disarray, Adora's already messy plaits were even more wrangled, and Catra's high ponytail drooping from the effect of the helmet and wind. Not to mention both girls were red and sweaty from the activity. Catra made a strangled sounding gasp, quickly taking her hair out of the ponytail and shaking out the roots. Adora didn't bother, simply slapping the cap back on her head and facing the woman.

"Hi!"

She beamed at her, leaning forward on the table. The girl returned the smile.

"Back again?"

"Yes. Could we have two paintball tickets please?"

The woman nodded and typed something on her computer, using the mouse to click on something on the screen.

"Our next session is in half an hour? Do you want to be on separate teams?"

Adora smiled at the thoughtful suggestion. She'd seemed to detect that Catra and Adora preferred to play against each other.

"Yep," she nodded her head as Catra came up beside her. The girl hung her chin on Adora's shoulder tiredly. Catra tried to sneak her phone to pay, but Adora saw her arm move and swatted it down, swiftly paying once again.

The customer service assistant handed her two wristbands. One was crimson red, the other an electric blue.

"Blue for you," Adora wrapped it around Catra's wrist as they walked, before putting her own one on.

"We have half an hour, let's get food."

Adora's gaze flicked from Catra to the menu of the food kiosk.

"Agreed, I need fuel before I beat your ass again," Catra responded. The place offered a similar variety of food as the cafeteria; nuggets, chips, sausage rolls.

The pair ordered their meals, eating in a few moments of peacefulness. Adora was frankly too hungry to make any conversation, and Catra seemed inclined to agree.

———————

"How did you actually manage to make that look good?"

Adora looked at Catra, mouth nearly dropping open at the sigh before her. The brunette, like her, wore a camouflage jumpsuit,

secured with a belt around the waist, combat boots, and a helmet.

"Aw, Adora, don't you know I pull off everything."

Catra winked at her in the mirror.

"Yeah, well I'd like to pull your clothes off right about-"

"Ladies, chop chop, your teammates aren't prepared to wait around all day!"

Adora jumped back at the shout, looking at Catra wildly. Was that....Huntara?

Catra met her stare and she could tell they were both thinking the same thing. No way was the worldwide famous chef secretly a paintball champion.

"As much as I'd like to take you up on that offer, Blondie, we'd better go."

She clipped the straps around her chin, Adora following suit by slapping the olive green hat on her head and nodding. Opening the locker door and shoving her goddamn phone in it took the weight off her shoulders, Adora both visibly and internally smiling as they left the bathroom.

A man stood at the edge of the room, holding a clipboard with possibly the most disdainful expression Adora had ever witnessed.

"Names?"

"Catra."

"Adora."

"Wristbands?"

They both stuck their arms out for inspection but the man barely glanced at their wrists for half a second.

"Right, I'll buzz you in. Blonde, you're on the Red Team so go down the red path. Shocker, I know, red team member goes down a red path."

He rolled her eyes and tapped his clipboard for emphasis.

"Uh, Freak Eyes, you're on blue team, go down the blue path, yeah you get it. Fuck that up and I'll be pissed, so don't."

He pressed a button attached to his uniform, the double doors swinging open to reveal an illuminated artificial cave.

Catra and Adora exchanged a look before stepping through the archway, the door swinging behind them.

"Yes! Fresh meat!"

Both girls yelled in shock, clutching to each other in the darkness as the voice reverberated around them.

"Uhh, I don't see a red, or a blue path," Adora said hesitantly. Neither of them had their phones to switch a light on, so they just waited in silence. The voice attached themselves to a face as a woman, Huntara, illuminated their face with a flashlight.

"Welcome to The Crimson Waste, kids!"

"Uh, Huntara, this is-"

"The Crimson Waste!" Huntara interjected. Adora was about to say "paintball" but instead just pursed her lips and nodded slowly. Catra just seemed amused beside her.

"Adora, you're on my team. Catra, you're on his."

Huntara narrowed her eyes, looking behind the girls which provoked them to whip their heads around. A man stood behind them, the light making his face look reptilian. Adora found that he strangely resembled a lizard. She gulped, but Catra displayed no fear, just looked the man up and down and performed her

signature smirk. The girl crossed her arms, but Adora's grip on her paintball gun tightened.

"Listen, girl, I'm Tung Lashor, the strongest paintballer to exist."

Catra laughed in the man's face, flicking his phone so it wobbled. He looked down at it, obviously caught off-guard.

"I'm sorry, what? Tung Lashor?" She laughed in his face again, absolutely fearless.

"It sounds even stupider the second time. Seriously, how'd you come up with that?"

"Uh Catra," Adora whispered to her girlfriend cautiously. The man's face had gone all red, he looked just about ready to implode. Catra didn't seem to give a fuck, though.

The man, Tung Lashor, snarled, pulling a whip (yes, a whip) from the belt fastened around his hips. Adora tugged on Catra's arm hurriedly, no sane person brings a whip to paintball. The brochure said this was a fun, family friendly activity. Whips certainly were NOT family friendly.

"Catra, I really don't think-"

"I like that whip, I think I'll be taking it."

Adora sighed, there was no helping this girl's fate.

"Do you even know how to use a whip, Wildcat?"

"Scorpia?"

Adora's jaw dropped, Scorpia was playing paintball with them? She internally groaned, the ice blonde girl was on Catra's team too. Adora was definitely going to die.

Another voice piped up behind them.

"Hi girls! Happy Birthday Catra."

"Perfuma?"

Adora was even more in shock at the Dean behind her. She waved merrily, the red wristband shining on her wrist.

"How hard can it be if this guy can use it?" Catra responded back to Scorpia, looking Tung Lashor up and down a second time.

"You know, I think it's all in the wrist. Maybe you can use a catchphrase when you use it, like 'whip!'" Scorpia flicked her wrist aggressively to demonstrate, but Catra just shook her head, placing her hands on her hips.

"No, I'm not gonna say whip when I use a whip. That doesn't-"

"Enough!"

Tung Lashor shot a paintball at the roof to grab their attention, but Catra didn't seem the slightest intimidated.

"I'm the reigning Paintball champion-"

"I'd disagree," Huntara coughed to interrupt. Tung Lashor just glared at her and hissed before continuing.

"I'm not letting some puney little girl talk all this shit about me."

Catra scoffed, her eyebrows raised so high Adora thought they'd lift off her face.

"Really? That's some brave talk for such a weak little-"

Tung Lashor snarled at the tone and words, aiming for Catra with a strike of his whip. Catra was prepared for it though, and with impeccable dexterity, dodged his attack while making one of her own. Adora could hardly witness it in the dimness of the walkway, only hearing a loud grunt before a heavy fall. Catra dusted her hands off, grabbing both the whip and his flashlight.

"Kinda embarrassing for you to get your ass kicked by a puney. little. girl, huh?"

He glared at her, Catra fastening the whip to her own belt.

"Thanks for the whip though."

Tung Lashor angrily lifted himself off the ground, trying not to wince as he did so. He quickly scrambled out the doors, Adora turning to Catra in complete awe.

"I cannot believe-What-How are you my girlfriend?"

"Heh, that was too easy," Catra waved her admiration off.

"Don't go all soft on me now, dummy. How can I destroy you if you're all sappy."

Adora flashed a smile at her in the darkness.

"You won't."

Huntara tapped Adora on her shoulder to follow her, the stronger woman pulling out her own paintball gun.

"We have five minutes to set up our battle strategy, then all lights are cut and we're left to fend for ourselves, and each other.

Adora followed her to wherever they were heading, which was a small dimly lit clearing.

"The only thing you'll be able to see is the paint. It's neon. Otherwise the suits completely blend in, you'll only see the illuminated wrist band," Huntara held up her own for demonstration. Adora took a look around at their teammates, a variety of faces. The only recognizable ones were Huntara and Perfuma.

"Team leaders dictate strategy. Tung Lashor was their team leader, and Catra just humiliated him, so my guess is she is now their

team leader. Adora, you know her best, how do you think Catra will play?"

"Dirty. Like really dirty," Adora quickly replied. She recalled Catra's demeanor at the beginning of the year, before they were friends, and sweat began to pool in her palms. That girl did not hold back when she wanted something.

"Alright, here's our game plan. In order to win the game, we need to steal their flag, and return it to our own, so we have both. They're obviously trying to do the same. We need someone to guard the flag, and two people to retrieve theirs. A backup is necessary in case one dies during the mission."

Adora tapped her chin in thought, trying to weave her mind into Catra's thought process.

"Catra won't sit around guarding the flag, she'll want action. My bet is she'll only trust herself to hunt our's, and trust Scorpia to guard their own. And she'll definitely aim to take me out herself."

"I agree, I've noticed a lot about you two. In a non-creepy way, of course," Perfuma chimed in.

"If that's the case, we need to throw her off her game. Since she'll come for the flag herself, Adora, you go after theirs. I think she'll expect you to be guarding ours, so you and Perfuma can tackle that task."

"Good idea."

Adora nodded, smiling at Perfuma, who returned the gesture. Huntara assigned herself to guarding their own flag, with the last three team members planning to guard Perfuma and Adora.

"Okay, Red Team. Let's crush them."

They each stuck their hand in the middle of their circle, chanting on the count of three. Just in time too, as a red light and siren flashed above them.

"Players, prepare yourself!"

The voice was robotic, Huntara nudging Perfuma and Adora to the front of the entrance. Adora took a few deep breaths in a flimsy effort to calm her racing heart, fist bumping Perfuma as they assumed their positions.

"And GO!"

Despite what Adora may have expected, it was deadly silent. She tried to make eye contact with Perfuma beside her, the pair moving into the darkness together.

Bang. One person in their team already down, and barely two minutes in. Adora bit her tongue to avoid making a noise. There were various obstacles and tricky turns they had to face to reach Blue Team's Base, as expected. Adora heard a gasp behind her, one that didn't belong to Perfuma, and quickly shot her gun in the direction.

She smiled in satisfaction as the person swore, their body revealed by the bright blue paint exposing them. Adora didn't relish the small victory though, keeping an eye out for Perfuma as she inched her way through he maze. Footsteps, the sound of shoes squeaking...someone wasn't trying to be stealthy whatsoever. Possibly making a quick dash for it in the hopes that they'd dodge any shots.

Unlucky for them, because Perfuma aimed, and fired. She missed the fist time, but not the second. The figure groaned, flopping to the ground in defeat.

Adora wanted to give her a silent high five, but there was too much distance between them.

They were closer to the base now, only-

Fuck. Another one of their team members fell down, and the shooter had clearly been aiming for her. She'd missed the shot by an inch, the sound of the paint bullet flying right past her ear

before hitting her teammate behind her. She tried not to panic, forcing herself to continue moving forward.

"Hello, Flower," Adora heard the whisper before Perfuma's gasp. They were hardly a few meters away from their base, but what was Scorpia doing here? She was meant to be guarding their flag, unless...

"Adora! Go," Perfuma gasped before the shot hit her, waving her arms for Adora to leave. Adora took aim and fired at Scorpia.

"Aw, damn," she dropped her gun in surprise.

Adora took a second, thoughts bouncing around her head, but silently obeyed Perfuma's wish. She didn't have much time to think, only relied on her instinct, which led her to the base camp.

And there was the sparkling blue flag...completely unprotected. That was simply too good to be true, Adora didn't buy it for a second. She fired her gun all around the walls, the paint splatting each one without hitting a single target. Strange. No one appeared to be here. But Adora only had one shot left, and she wasn't going to waste it. Gritting her teeth, she stepped forward.

Wrong move.

"Hey, Adora."

Fucking Catra. Of course Catra was guarding it. She probably knew what Adora would predict her to do and did the exact opposite. She didn't immediately shoot her though, her arm wrapped around Adora's throat and arms pinning Adora's to her back. Adora tried to steady her breath, thinking of something that might throw her off. She couldn't exactly shoot her in this position, but she might be able to push her off with the back of her gun. Bracing herself, Adora shoved her gun backwards, Catra momentarily releasing her. It was enough though, afforded Adora the opportunity to push her against a paint smeared wall, pressing her arms flat against the surface and kicking Catra's gun far, far away.

"Hey, Catra."

She didn't seem fazed, crossing her feet and leaning languidly against the wall.

"Is this the part where you kill me?"

Catra glanced down at Adora's gun, fastened underneath her arms.

"Or is it the part where I-"

Catra didn't verbally finish her sentence, jumping and wrapping her legs around Adora's waist, the momentum knocking both girls onto her ground. Adora tried to reach for her gun, but Catra used the whip to snatch it from her. She loaded the paint bullet, finger dancing over the trigger. Adora was helpless, pinned under Catra on the floor.

"Fuck you and your five years of specialized combat training," Adora groaned from beneath her.

Catra pushed her hair back with her fingers, shrugging. She leaned down, whispering in Adora's ear.

"If I recall correctly, you quite liked my combat training a few nights ago."

Adora's cheeks heated in the dark at the memory, but she didn't let it distract her.

"Unfair advantage."

Catra gripped the gun in one hand, and held Adora's hand down to the floor with the other. She winced as the bullet hit her stomach. It was deceivingly painful despite only being paint. The bright pink liquid seeped through the fabric, cooling her skin. Catra smiled, tucking the empty gun back into her belt when-

Bang.

"Huntara!"

The grin spread wildly on Adora's face as she raised herself, Catra getting rocked back onto her lap as she did so.

"And that's all of the blue team out. While you were so busy taunting your girlfriend, I worked silently."

"So you used me as bait?" Adora looked to the woman.

"Nice," she nodded. Huntara definitely knew how to play the game well.

Huntara gave them both a feral smile, plucking the blue flag from the stand. Adora looked at Catra in front of her, a smug expression spreading over her face.

"I win."

Catra made a noise of indigence, crossing her arms against her chest.

"Naw, don't be mad," Adora started. Catra's glare only intensified. Huntara had left to put the flags together and officiate the win, but the pair of girls remained sitting there for a moment, Catra unmoving in Adora's lap. Adora leaned forward, giving her a quick kiss to console the defeat.

"I'll need a bit more than that," Catra sulked.

"Mhmm," Adora smiled, leaning forward.

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Lies.(2.0)

"Thanks for tonight, well, all of today actually."

Catra gently grabbed Adora's hands, swinging their arms together between them. They'd just arrived back at Catra's dorm, the dinner celebration for Catra's birthday happily ending.

"It was nothing."

Adora shrugged it off, unable to help her blush at the genuine gratitude.

"Bow and Glimmer's cake was awful though. How would you think of making a cake with a literal slice of watermelon in the middle."

"Ehhh, I may have told them that you like watermelon."

"That's just cause you smell like it."

"Yeah, well when they said 'Watermelon Cake' I thought they'd make it shaped like a watermelon...not actual watermelon."

Catra snorted, kicking her shoes off and flopping on the bed. Adora chucked her phone on the stand on Catra's bedside table, a portable charger, resisting a yawn.

"I'm dead tired."

She shook her hair out of the loose braids it had been in all day, removing her coat and hat wearily.

"Same...You can go back to yours if you want."

Catra tossed a fuzzy ball into the air and caught it, still lying flat on the bed.

"Nah, it's late, and we live on different floors. The elevator is broken too, so there's no way I'm climbing stairs right now."

She started untying the laces of her sneakers, placing them gently near the door and collecting Catra's scattered ones besides them on the carpet.

"Wowww, the fitness obsessed freak opting to take the lazy route."

She propped herself up on her forearms, making a sarcastically shocked expression.

"Have you been brainwashed?"

Adora narrowed her eyes, sitting on the bed opposite her.

"Hah hah, don't worry, I'll still wake up at five and drag you on a run with me tomorrow morning. No need to fret."

She patted Catra's head, the words provoking Catra to fling a pillow at her.

"Ugh, do that, and I'll throw a brick at you instead."

Adora giggled, making Catra glare at her.

"Oh, you so like me."

"Do not."

"Do too!"

Catra didn't make a retort, allowing Adora to relish her small victory.

"Can I get the shower first?"

Catra nodded, gesturing to the bathroom while grabbing her own phone.

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When Adora returned, Catra was sitting, a strange expression settled on her face. Adora frowned slightly, scrunching her wet hair with the towel and sitting tentatively on the bed.

"I borrowed your shampoo and conditioner by the way. Pear and lemon, interesting choice."

She finished off drying her hair, tucking the damp strands behind her ears and placing the towel in her lap. Catra didn't respond instantly, but turned to face Adora.

"Yeah, that's fine. Uhm.."

She trailed off, not quite meeting Adora's eyes. Adora's frown deepened in confusion.

"What's wrong."

Catra shook it off, something else settling over her face as she glanced up.

"Nothing, I'm fine."

Adora gave a small smile, but she could still tell something was off. She decided to let it go for now, maybe Catra was just tired. They'd both had a long day, after all.

"Hey, uh, how have you been?"

Catra wrapped a short lock of hair around her finger, looking inquiringly at Adora, who was just puzzled.

"Me? I'm fine, why?"

"No reason, just wanted to...check in, I guess."

There was a pause, an awkward pause. Adora was baffled, she and Catra hadn't felt awkward with each other in months.

"What about you and Shadow Weaver? She's not being a pain, right?"

Catra waited expectantly, tossing the fuzzy ball up in the air again and catching it. Adora hesitated, opening her mouth before closing it. Now probably wasn't the time to mention it, when they were both tired and Catra was being stiff with her.

"Yeah, she's left me alone. It's alright."

"Promise?"

Adora didn't say the word back, averting her gaze.

Catra pursed her lips and nodded, placing the ball in her lap. Adora followed the movement, eyes landing to Catra's lap where the fuzzy ball had landed, along with...Adora's phone.

Fuck.

All of a sudden, she understood Catra's strange mood. Catra followed her stare to her lap, and raised her eyebrows. Their eyes met again, and Catra scoffed.

"Liar."

Adora took a sharp intake of breath at the tone. This was not good.

"Catra-"

Catra held her hand up to pause Adora, clicking the phone button to turn on the device. Dread pooled at the pit of Adora's stomach when she caught a glimpse of the message notifications, followed by previews of sixteen more.

Shadow Weaver: Adora, you need to consider your relationships.

Shadow Weaver: Catra's a distraction, you need to stay away from her.

Shadow Weaver: And you're leaving Brightmoon. For good.

"How long has she been saying shit like this?"

Adora swallowed, hard, blinking back tears.

"Since her last visit," Adora admitted softly. Catra's gaze broke.

"And you've just been hiding it?"

"It's my relationship to handle, Catra. I don't need to tell you everything, and you probably shouldn't have gone through my phone in the first place."

Catra elicited a biting laugh, looking at Adora incredulously.

"I did not go through your phone, Adora. It was sitting there, charging. I saw it light up with a notification, but I didn't care enough to go snoop. It was when fifteen fucking more messages came through that I looked over, and they're all from her."

"Still, you don't get to sit here and interrogate me about Shadow Weaver. It's none of your business."

Adora stood up, crossing her arms in front of her chest. Catra also stood from the bed, facing Adora.

"None of my business? She's instructing you to stay away from me, how is that none of my business?"

"Yeah, well she's been saying that for months and I'm still in a relationship with you, so obviously, I don't give a shit. And If I don't, why should you?"

Adora uncrossed her arms, balling them into fists by her side.

"It honestly scares me, that I'm around you practically 24/7, and I didn't know she was dictating you this much. You were acting completely fine."

"I am completely fine!"

"Oh, come on Adora. She's threatening to pull you out of the school, that's not fine."

"I've already talked with Angella, she said as long as I don't want to leave, Shadow Weaver can't pull me out."

"That's not the point. You hid this from me, all of it. And you lied to my face, just then."

"I didn't promise," Adora tried to defend herself.

"That's not the point-"

Catra paused, taking a breath and massaging her temples.

"Do you know what she said to me that night at dinner? What made me so upset I had to leave?"

Curiosity nudged at Adora, but she didn't say anything. Catra took that as a plea to continue.

"She told me that I will never be able to control you the way she can, and that ultimately, you will always belong to her."

Adora's mouth went very dry, her mind freezing.

"She talked about you like you were her damn property, Adora. It was sick."

"Why didn't you tell me? That night?"

Adora felt something collapse in her chest, and found herself unable to meet Catra's eyes.

"Because she still raised you. I didn't want to..I don't know...completely destroy your perception of her. She was a bitch to me my whole life, but she treated you differently."

"But you didn't tell me."

"I didn't want to demonize her for you. If you decide to hate her, that's fine, but I'm not going to try and influence you."

Adora tried to take a few deep breaths to calm the fire surrounding her brain, but it didn't help.

"So now what?"

Adora let the question hang in the air, trying to gain clarity on the situation.

"I think we should take a breath."

Any sort of calmness she'd tried to regain got thrown out the window. Catra didn't look at her, the carpet apparently posing for a much better visual.

"What? You are just gonna leave."

Catra clenched her jaw, seeming to drag her eyes up to look at Adora.

"I'm doing you a favor. I'm a distraction, right? Now you can go be President without me confusing you."

Adora took a step forward, and Catra didn't move.

"No that's not true," Adora took another breath.

"I know..I didn't mean that," Catra sounded exasperated. She rubbed her eyes.

"What do you want, Adora?"

Her eyes were wet as she looked at her, and Adora didn't know what to say.

"I-I don't know. Not this, anything but this."

She reached out, trying desperately to maintain a semblance of contact between the two of then. Catra let her intertwine their fingers, looking down at the touch.

"Me neither. But I'm not going to be the reason you cut her off. I'm not going to make you choose."

The tears slipped, from both their eyes, and Adora's voice broke.

"Catra, please. Stay."

Catra closed her eyes and turned their head, disconnecting their fingers. Adora tried to hold on, but her efforts were futile.

"I think distance is what both of us need right now."

"That's fucking bullshit."

"I can't brush this under the rug and pretend this isn't happening, Adora. You may be able to, but I can't."

"So what? We're over?"

Adora felt brittle, ready to break at any moment, but her voice was hard, questioning.

"A break."

The word was suspended around them, and Adora's mind.

A break.

"You should probably leave," Catra turned away for her, the suggestion barely a whisper. Adora let out a shaky breath of her own, trying to keep herself together.

"Bye, Catra."

She opened the door slowly, giving Catra the chance to change her mind, but the girl was faced away from her.

Adora slipped out of the room, counting to ten to avoid breaking down in the middle of Catra's small living room. She nearly jumped out of skin at the sight of Lonnie, sitting on a stool with a steaming mug of something in front of her.

"Hey," her voice was soft, the girl still in her clothes from earlier during dinner. Adora could tell by the look on her face that she'd heard just about everything.

"Night Lonnie," she quickly swiped her eyes, trying to give her a smile. It came out as more of a grimace.

"I'll...see you around," Adora murmured quietly, Lonnie nodded as she continued down the hallway.

_____

"Bow? Glimmer?"

Adora switched the lights on as she entered the dorm, the couple waking from their slumber in Glimmer's bed.

"Adora? I thought you were staying the night at Catra's?"

The sound of Catra's name was enough to destruct any composure Adora had maintained in the walk from Catra's dorm to her own. Bow and Glimmer jumped out the bed as the blonde crumpled into a mess on the floor, tears rolling down her face.

"Woah, woah, woah."

Bow's voice was gentle, giving Glimmer a concerned look as he held Adora in his arms.

"Words, Adora. What happened?"

Bow threw an even harder look at Glimmer's question, making the girl soften her voice.

"Sorry, uhm, let it all out."

Bow just rolled his eyes at Glimmer's attempt to be comforting, making Adora laugh in between her sobs.

"You're no use. Go grab a blanket from the lounge."

Glimmer hurried off, returning with a fuzzy pink cloak and wrapping it around Adora's shoulders. Adora couldn't stop the steady flow of tears, Glimmer pushing a mug of something warm into her hands to drink. Adora tried to sip slowly without gagging on the hot liquid, Bow continuing to rub comforting circles on her back.

The three of them sat there for eternity, until Adora managed to stop crying for more than a few minutes and finished the mug of what she now realized was hot chocolate. Neither Bow or Glimmer pushed for an answer, but she needed to talk.

"Catra and I are taking a break."

The finality of the words hit her, hard, and she tried not to burst into tears again. Bow and Glimmer seemed stunned into silence.

"What happened? You guys were more than fine at dinner tonight."

Adora placed the empty mug beside her on the carpet, burrowing herself deeper into the warm blanket.

"Shadow Weaver happened. She's been sending me messages for the past few weeks, putting pressure on me to leave the school and break my friendships with you guys. And my relationship with Catra."

"And you didn't tell anyone this?"

Glimmer's voice wasn't accusatory, just concerned.

"I thought I could handle it, so no. Catra found out tonight though, saw a few messages on my phone."

"And?"

Glimmer prompted.

"And I lied to her. She said she didn't want to be the reason I resented Shadow Weaver and said she thought it would be best if we took a break so I can figure out what I really want."

Bow whistled softly.

"Harsh."

Adora lay down on the floor, looking up at the pastel pink ceiling. A memory resurfaced in her mind, one from not too long ago.

"Why on earth would I let you go now, when I spent years trying to get you back in the first place?"

"It's just, Shadow Weaver-"

"You're my best friend Catra. I don't want to be controlled by her."

Catra didn't speak for a moment, pulling back to look Adora in the eye. Adora met her assessing gaze with one holding as much conviction as she could muster. It seemed to be enough, for Catra instantly latched onto Adora, an unfaltering grip.

I don't want to be controlled by her.

I don't want to be controlled by her.

I don't want to be controlled by her.

The words repeated over and over in her head, so many times she swore she saw them written on the ceiling above her.

"Now what?" Glimmer lay down on the floor beside her.

Adora inhaled slowly, drumming her fingers against her stomach.

"Now I call Shadow Weaver."

She didn't miss the look Bow and Glimmer exchanged.

"Not like this. Sleep now, call tomorrow. And afterwards, we're ditching to do something fun."

"Can't. I agreed that I'd help DT with the play-"

The fucking play.

Adora groaned. Not only were they now "on a break," but she had to perform Macbeth with Catra. It was too fresh to pretend to be lovers, too soon.

"I'm sure DT will understand if you miss their rehearsal," Bow tried to assure you. Adora choked up a dry laugh.

"Nope, they'll downright slaughter me. They've put too much effort in this play for me to be selfish and be a flake."

"Understudies?"

"Don't have any! Isn't that wonderful!"

Adora rolled around on the floor as a way to distract herself.

"Alright, well, don't worry about that for now. You need sleep, desperately."

Adora felt arms grab onto her blanket wrapped shoulders and hands latch onto her legs. Before she knew it, she was being lifted off the ground, and onto her bed. Bow and Glimmer seemed to silently communicate with each other, for both nodded before Glimmer climbed into the bed next to Adora.

"There is no way I'm getting sleep tonight," Adora grumbled. Still, she tucked herself under the covers.

"No, but you can maybe try," Glimmer sing sang, turning the lights off. Bow disappeared behind his own bedroom door, but instead of sleeping there, as Adora expected, he returned with his duvet and a mass of pillows.

He lay the blankets down on the floor beside Adora's bed, giving her a smile before climbing into his makeshift floor-bed. The considerate thought alone nearly brought a fresh set of tears to her eyes.

"Thanks guys."

"Always. It's what friends do."

Glimmer murmured quietly as she rolled over, shutting her eyes slowly. Bow did the same, and Adora tried to follow suit.

It didn't work of course, her body refused to calm down. But nevertheless, she tried.

RIP Watermelon Cake

Light cracked through Adora's eyelids, forcing her to awake. She snaked her arm around her pillow, holding it closer as she smelt Catra's hair. The thought made her smile, causing her to open her eyelids to see-

Her own, stupid blonde hair. She'd been sniffing her own hair. Adora jerked back from herself, groaning as she recalled washing her hair with Catra's shampoo and conditioner the night before.

"Argh!"

She drove a fist backwards into the cushion, completely forgetting that her friends were asleep beside her.

"Adora?"

Glimmer mumbled, causing Adora to fix her attention onto her friend.

"GLIMMAAAHH," Adora suddenly wailed, flinging a pillow onto the ground on poor, helpless Bow.

"BOWWW," she continued. Both her friends sat upright to attention, Glimmer looking a bit more pissed off than Bow did.

"Adora! Pull it together," Glimmer ordered.

"But-"

"But nothing. Catra said you were on a break-"

"I knowwww, I'm never gonna kiss her, or hug her, or talk to her-"

"A BREAK, ADORA. She did not break up with you, she still wants to be in a relationship."

Oh, so that's what a break is.

Adora had assumed she'd just ended their relationship altogether.

"Oh."

"You just need to sort that stuff out with Shadow Weaver, and the Catradora ship is ready to sail again."

Adora frowned, but nodded at Glimmer's plan. Sort out Shadow Weaver, sail the ship...Easy enough.

"But first of all, YOU NEED TO LET ME SLEEP."

Glimmer burrowed herself back under the covers, but Adora's slumber was already disjointed and low quality. There was no point in trying. Instead, she got out of the bed, making her way to the bathroom.

"What are you doing?"

Bow sat up this time, looking at her as she walked away from the two of them.

"Run," was all she answered with.

"Adora, I know you love your runs, but do you really want to when you've had maybe two hours of sleep?"

Adora yawned, sorta proving his point. She wondered to the fridge, Bow's words mulling over in her head.

And spotted that stupid watermelon cake. Her eyes latched onto it, and she yelled, grabbing the stupid thing and flinging it at the nearest surface she could spot, which happened to be a mirror.

"Yep, yup, never mind. A run is definitely what you need right now," Bow nodded furiously.

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Adora slowed her pace to a walk as she reached the twelve kilometer mark. She'd exerted all her pent up anger and energy,

but the fresh air was also helping her forget the events of last night, and made her breathe easier.

"Yo, Adora!"

A voice called out to her, causing Adora to turn back in response to her name. She gave Lonnie a small smile and waved back as the girl caught up with her, stopping momentarily.

"Morning, Lonnie."

"Can I walk with you?"

Adora nodded, she was about to call Glimmer just to hear another voice besides her own in her head, so Lonnie's company was appreciated.

"How's...Catra?" Adora found herself asking. Lonnie took a breath, looking ahead at the path as she talked.

"She didn't want to talk last night, or this morning. She's visiting Scorpia today though, and she's usually always in a better mood after a visit with Scorps."

Adora nodded. She couldn't really say she was surprised Catra had refused to talk to Lonnie, but she was surprised by how unfazed Lonnie was with her mood.

"Yeah, well I barely got any sleep, screamed, which woke my friends up... and threw a cake at the wall, so she can't be doing much worse than that."

Lonnie chuckled, pausing her fitness tracker.

"I don't know, I did hear some strange noises from her room last night."

This made Adora's smile widen a bit further, slowly becoming something less courteous and more genuine. They passed a

basketball court, Lonnie's eye catching the rustic metal of the hoops.

"Up for some one on one?"

Adora looked at the court in faint surprise.

"Yeah, sure."

The season had ended, but Adora already knew she'd apply to play the following year. The game provided a brilliant distraction.

"You're actually quite good," Lonnie admitted while wiping her sweat with the hem of her shirt, even though she'd still beat Adora by two points.

"Gee, thanks," Adora replied sarcastically, shooting one last three pointer before chucking the basketball back with the equipment.

"Praise from me is rare," Lonnie admitted as she took a seat on the bench to catch her breath. Adora sat down next to her, letting the wind push her hair back.

"Yeah, I know." She'd learnt that much about Lonnie on the court.

"You thinking about playing in college? I reckon you'd get a solid scholarship."

"I've barely thought about university," Adora admitted. Lonnie's eyebrows shot up at this.

"Shit, really? With your grades and stuff, you'd probably be able to apply anywhere and get in."

Adora looked at her in shock.

"You think?"

Lonnie took a swig from her water bottle, nodding furiously.

"Ask Perfuma to hook you up with the counsellor, she'll tell you everything."

Adora hummed in thought, thinking that would be the first thing she did back on campus.

"Do you know what you're doing after school?" Adora asked after a few minutes of companionable silence.

"Dunno, I'd like to get drafted or something one day, but parents want me to get a fancy degree and work in the business."

"So I guess that's what your plan is then?"

Adora sipped from her own water bottle, watching Lonnie, who laughed.

"Ah, fuck them. As if I'm gonna let my traditionalist parents stop me from playing professional basketball. If I want to do it, I'm doing it."

Adora couldn't help but be taken aback by Lonnie's brazen response, but she didn't act surprised.

"Yeah, nice."

"If I do decide to run a business someday, it's going to be based around health and fitness."

Adora recalled Catra telling her about Lonnie's PT course a while back. The thought made it's way into her head now.

"You did a P.T course some time back, didn't you?"

"Best thing I did. You'd love it."

Adora was intrigued by Lonnie's prediction.

"Really?"

"You like Biology, right?"

"One of my favorites."

It really was, Adora could learn about molecules and the mitochondria all day if she wanted to.

"Yeah, well the course has quite a bit of anatomy in it, and a lot of P.E stuff."

"Wow," it sounded like everything Adora would love.

"Do you wanna take a look at my old stuff?"

Adora was about to reply with an enthusiastic 'yes,' before realizing that she'd be going to Catra's dorm.

"I would, but I don't think your roommate would appreciate that."

Lonnie looked lost for a moment before the realization clicked, and she slapped her palm into her forehead.

"Oh, Oh! Right, sorry. I could take it to your's, maybe tomorrow?"

Adora nodded happily.

"That sounds perfect, thanks Lonnie."

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"Throws a cake on the wall and leaves us to clean it!"

That's the first thing Adora heard when she entered the dorm. She instantly winced at Glimmer's offended tone.

"Heyyyy guyssss," she tried to brighten the mood, but even Bow looked kinda pissed with her.

"Adora, we know-"

"Don't worry about it, I can manage,"Adora finished off before Glimmer completed her sentence. She didn't want to be someone that took advantage of her friends and acted like a spoilt toddler

who couldn't clean up their own mess. Glimmer and Bow didn't respond as Adora gently pried the cleaning materials off them, getting to work.

"Feeling better?" Bow enquired. Adora nodded.

"Much. I ran into Lonnie on the trail. She offered to show me her books from her PT course."

"That's great, Adora!"

She chucked most of the discarded cake in the bin, returning to the crime scene to continue cleaning.

"I think I'm going to try to get in touch with the counsellor...maybe figure out what I actually want to do."

"Damn, you're handling this way better than I could," Glimmer flopped onto a nearby beanbag, sipping her blueberry smoothie.

"I was a wreck in the morning, and it still...hurts. I'm just trying not to think about her."

Adora swiped the last of the cream smudges off the mirror, grabbing the window spray and a cloth to give it one final wipe down.

"Speaking of which, I need to call DT."

She pulled out her phone, ringing Double Trouble while continuing to scrub at the mirror.

"Adoraa, darling! I'd better see you in two hours."

A splinter of guilt weeded it's way into her heart at Double Trouble's excited voice carrying on the other end of the line, but she persisted.

"Yeah, about that. I've-"

She interjected herself with a slight cough to try and authenticate her lie.

"I don't think I can make it today."

DT's high pitched laughter rang loud and clear on the other side of the phone.

"Oh, Adora sweetie, I don't care if you're on your fucking death bed. I will drag you to this rehearsal and every other one this week leading up to opening night. In exactly seven days, I will be out of your ass and you can feed your half-baked excuses to any other poor soul that'll believe them."

Adora's mouth dropped as she threw a look to Bow and Glimmer.

"Are we clear?"

Adora gulped, dropping the cloth she was holding.

"Uh huh."

"Great! I'll see you in an hour, Macbeth." They hung up.

"I swear they can sniff out lies better than a dog with drugs," Adora hung her head in her hands, feeling the beginning of a headache work its way through.

"At least we'll be there for moral support?" Bow rubbed comforting circles on her back, and Glimmer gave her a side hug.

Fuck You Shadow Weaver.

"Okay, here we go," Adora whispered to herself, face tucked between her hands as she squinted at the phone. The mocking device lay below her, and she grumbled at it. The thing should be annihilated, it was the culprit for all this.

She opened Shadow Weaver's contact, finger hovering over the 'call' button, before she squeezed her eyes firmly shut and pressed down.

One ring, half another, and then-

"Adora." The voice greeted her ears, not the slightest mad or annoyed, but rolling with pure smugness.

"Shadow Weaver," Adora hardened her own tone, tucking her arms under her legs to avoid fidgeting.

"I've been expecting your call."

Adora's blood boiled at that, the arrogance that saturated her sentence.

"Listen, I'm on a break with Catra-"

"That's delightful! I knew you'd come to your senses, child. It was a matter of tim-"

"No. I'm telling you this so you know that she's not influencing, manipulating, or brainwashing me right now."

Silence. Adora's hand shook uncontrollably beneath her legs, and she involuntarily shivered as she conjured the next words.

"I don't want to be President, in fact it's the furthest thing I want to do with my life. I hate law, and I will not be pursuing it in university, no matter how much you want me want to."

Dead fucking silence.

"I told you this once before, but you brushed it off and ignored me, so I'm telling you again. You do not control me, you do not own me, in fact you have next to no authority over me, so don't think you can send me threatening and possessive messages."

She finished, waiting for Weaver to respond.

"And what do you want to waste your life with instead?"

She opened her mouth, but paused for a second.

"I have ideas, all of which I'm not inclined to share with you right now."

Cold laughter, which caused the hairs on Adora's arm to raise.

"I see. You're destined for greatness Adora, I'd hate for you to lose your talent because your preoccupied with what you want, rather than what you're meant for."

"Who says I'm meant to be a President? It's not something I'm passionate or even interested in. I just wanted to do it because you wanted me too."

Her voice had escalated, and she tried to lower it down.

"Calm down, Adora."

Her voice was steel, and Adora clenched her jaw in response to the firm tone. She was extremely thankful they were having this conversation over the phone than in person.

"No, I will not calm down, and you can't order me like I'm a puppet bent to your will."

She took a breath, her heart beating uncontrollably against her chest. If this is what it took to get Catra back, she'd do it. And the feeling of saying this, of finally asserting herself, was wonderful.

"Let's talk about this in person, no rash statements, Adora. I'll take you out of the school and-"

"You'll what? Take me out of my school?"

Adora shifted on the bed, her palms clammy and face heating at Shadow Weaver's words. She was consoling her as if she was a disobedient toddler, not a grown person.

"Brightmoon isn't right for you."

"You don't get to dictate what's good for me or not. That's for me to decide."

"Adora-"

"No!" She laughed hysterically, the pieces of the puzzle clicking together in her brain. Catra was right, of course she was. Shadow Weaver didn't want what was best for Adora, she wanted Adora to be her personal slave, she wanted to live through Adora. Adora didn't want to rule a country, no, Shadow Weaver did.

"Fuck you, Shadow Weaver."

God, that felt amazing.

Adora understood what Lonnie meant suddenly, how she didn't want her parents to control her future. She hung up the phone, and instantly blocked Weaver's number, chucking her phone across her bed as if it was diseased. She was scared, petrified, honestly. Her tongue had a mind of it's own, one that clearly didn't think properly, because she just swore at Shadow Weaver. A bubble of laughter climbed it's way up her throat, and she let it out.

Bow and Glimmer cracked their heads through the door, and Adora could instantly tell they'd been listening to the entire thing.

"You're my role model," Bow grinned.

"That was the most badass conversation I've ever heard," Glimmer's eyes were wide. Adora laughed again, her chest expanding as she beamed towards her friends.

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Adora spotted her, eyes latching onto Catra as she walked through the doors. Her heart sped up, and she quickly adjusted her ponytail before taking a breath.

"You know what you're gonna say?" Glimmer whispered beside her, holding a paintbrush slathered with brown paint. Adora nodded decisively. She'd done what Catra had asked of her, now they can close that distance put between them.

"Yup."

"Good. Don't fuck up."

Glimmer nodded, nudging Adora forward, who nearly tripped over herself in surprise at the shove. She threw a glare back at Glimmer, who gestured for her to keep moving. Adora took another inhale, a few meters behind Catra's turned back when-

"Oh, Adora! Thank heavens my Macbeth is here."

"Woah!"

Adora was yanked sideways into the red velvet wings of the theatre, spun around as DT wrapped a measuring tape around her torso.

"Nice to see you too," she mumbled, holding her arms up. She was fairly used to fittings now, the tape barely tickled her anymore.

"Now, I've heard about you and Catra, but I don't want that interfering with your performance."

Adora's face heated to a bright red as she glanced down at them.

"Wait, you heard about me and Catra? As in, people know?"

"Duh, people know. You two were practically attached at the hip and suddenly you aren't speaking? Well, I found out from the source herself."

DT smirked in Catra's direction, causing Adora to look over and accidentally lock eyes with the girl.

Both their faces went a shade redder, and Adora quickly looked back down. So Catra had been telling people about their...break. Something splintered in Adora at the thought of her publicly sharing it.

"Don't get all sooky, darling. I'm the Glimmer to Catra's Adora."

Adora was perplexed by that. "What?"

"We're besties," DT trilled with a shake of their head. Adora was abruptly spun around.

"Lonnie's her Bow."

"O-kay," Adora still wasn't getting the analogy, but she guessed DT was explaining that they were close with Catra

"And how are you holding up?"

Adora raised an eyebrow as DT raised themselves to stand.

"Why would I tell Brightmoon's biggest gossip how I'm feeling about my broken relationship?"

DT raised a palm to their chest, an expression of shock shading their face.

"Ouch, you wound me."

DT spun her around again, placing their hands on her shoulders and whispering in her ear.

"She's in love with you, don't fret."

Adora's heart fluttered at that, and for the second time that day, she was pushed towards Catra. This time, the girl was facing sideways to her, and sensed Adora coming. Her finger dropped from twirling her hair as she read the script, and her attention moved to Adora as she approached her.

"Uh, hey," she rubbed the back of her neck awkwardly, rocking back and forth on her heels.

"Hey, Adora." Catra's expression was neutral, Adora had no idea what she was thinking or feeling.

"Could we maybe, I dunno, have a chat? I mean, unless you don't want too, that's fine too! Just cause, you know, stuff-and-"

She detected Catra's amusement that cracked through the blank face.

"I'm going to shut up now." She laughed awkwardly to try and save the embarrassment, but she could spot Glimmer slapping a palm against her forehead via her peripheral view.

"Sure, Adora. Let's chat."

Catra nodded towards the stage door before walking towards and opening it without glancing once behind her to see if Adora was following. She was, of course, her fists clenching and unclenching nervously.

The room held various bright costumes, some overly medieval, and other's that were made of armor. Adora quickly took a seat, eyes distracted by the surroundings. Catra leaned against the vanity, casting a questioning look at Adora.

"Alright. Talk," she gestured before folding her arms in front of her chest.

"I spoke with Shadow Weaver today. On the phone."

Catra nodded slowly, waiting.

"I told her I didn't want to be a President, and that I don't want to leave Brightmoon...and I blocked her."

Catra paused, opening her mouth before closing it.

"And?"

"It felt good, like really good."

"I'm glad."

Catra took a breath, Adora waiting for a response as she glanced up and their eyes met.

"But I'm not ready to get back together."

Adora's heart deflated, her chest sinking.

"Why? I did what you asked. I told her to fuck off and that I want to live my own life."

"I'm proud of you, Adora, but I wasn't lying when I said I needed space. You lied to me about her messages for months, and I can't get over that in a day."

"Catra, I wasn't lying to you, I was protecting you. I know what you went through with her, I didn't want that to resurface for you."

"You don't need to protect me, Adora. You did it back in the orphanage, and you didn't need to. Now you're doing it again. Lying to me isn't protecting me."

"So what do I need to do? How do I fix it? I tried Shadow Weaver, but clearly that's not enough for you."

Catra shrugged, making Adora's annoyance build.

"You don't need to fix it...Just, be patient with me, alright?"

Adora scoffed at her unfazed attitude. Did she even care that she sacrificed her relationship with Shadow Weaver for her?

"Catra, do you even want to get back together?"

The blue and gold eyes shot up to her's, aghast.

"Of course I fucking want to get back together. I just don't believe you can get rid of Weaver that easily. It took years of therapy to erase the influence she had on me, I doubt it'll take you twenty four hours."

"So you want to wait years to get back together, then? Is that what you're saying?"

Catra raised her hands to her head, closing her eyes.

"No, god, no. I'm not saying we need to wait years, just that our trust can't be healed overnight."

Adora stood, stepping closer to Catra who didn't move. She gently pried Catra's hands off her face, forcing to girl to open them and look at her.

"What can I do to heal it then?"

Catra looked up at her, the pair staring at each other for a few, long seconds.

"Wait. And give me space."

Catra slipped out of Adora's small trap, exiting the door. Adora exhaled, squeezing her eyes shut and wiping them to avoid crying. Last thing she wanted was red eyes. She took another breath, leaving the room to meet her friends again.

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"Damn. Do you want me to talk to her?"

Glimmer gave her a slight squeeze as Adora returned. She sighed.

"Nah, I think that'll make it worse. I just need to...leave her alone, I guess. Do nothing."

It felt weird to do nothing, to just be passive and wait.

"I'm sure she'll come around. Just wait, in a week you two will be annoyingly all over each other again."

Adora resisted looking over at her for the fiftieth time at Bow's words.

"Yeah, sure," she mumbled, unconvinced.

"Okay! Final scene everybody! Macbeth, Lady Macbeth, get your asses here."

DT stood in the centre of the stage, their voice commanding the attention of the room.

"Painters, I want you to work on the castle backdrop, costume designers, I've got Macbeth's measurements for the opening outfit. Ensemble, assemble into your two groups. Macduff, you can sit this scene out, you're dead anyway."

Adora sighed, dragging her feet to meet DT and Catra in the middle of the stage.

"This is the scene when you fulfill the witches' prophecy and become King and Queen of Scotland."

Adora mentally swore. Did they seriously have to rehearse this scene? Right now? Catra herself looked on the verge of slapping DT.

"And, action!"

"Oh, Macbeth, what greatness we've achieved-"

"Energy, Catra! No slacking!"

"Oh Macbeth! What greatness we've achieved," Catra amended.

Catra grabbed the crown from Macduff's makeshift dead body and spun it on her finger. She stopped, raising the prop to Adora's head, when Adora's hands slid over her's, pausing the movement.

"No, Lady Macbeth. It is your brilliance and deviousness that is worthy of this crown."

Adora gently pried the crown off Catra's hands, detesting the thrill she felt at the contact, and snuck a hand around her waist.

"It is my mind that conjured the making of our power, but your actions that brought it to fruition, my Macbeth."

Adora, as instructed by the script, ignored her words and placed the crown atop Catra's head.

Her eyes stung as she dipped Catra, before leading her to the 'throne' raised on a platform towards the back of the stage.

"Oh Lady Macbeth! Your flattery is your greatest weapon. One of these days I fear you'll steal my life for your own victory."

Catra's cold laugh came through as Adora sat on the throne, and Catra placed herself on her lap.

Adora felt herself heat up, and noticed the blush that deepened on Catra's already flushed cheeks.

"How could I murder my most invaluable asset?"

Adora smiled against her will, trying to ignore the unfamiliar manner in which Catra sat on her.

"We shall conquer the world, my love."

"Nothing would derive greater pleasure from my heart."

"End scene!"

DT's shout allowed Catra to quickly jump off Adora, both girls' embarrassment intensifying when they noticed practically the

entire cast and crew watching them. Adora hadn't even realized it'd gone silent. She and Catra both averted the other's gaze, standing about a metre apart from one another.

"Again! From the top. Adora, be more loose this time, you looked as stiff as a chalkboard up there," DT grumbled. Adora inwardly groaned. This was going to be a long, long week.

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Purely Platonic?

Adora threw her book on the floor, sick of reading the same lines over and over again without actually absorbing them. Her head hung limply off the edge of the bed, eyes frosted over as she faced the front door of the dorm.

"Wow, never thought I'd see you abuse a school book."

Adora flipped herself upright, swaying from the sudden blood flow.

"It's my fifth time reading it anyway. If I don't know the quotes by now, I never will."

"Nerd," Glimmer scoffed. She put her feet up on the cotton candy colored ottoman, resting her hands behind her head.

"Where's Bow? I'm bored and we have a student free day tomorrow, so we should go do something."

"Ugh, the one time you want to be fun I have an assignment due. Bow's with George and Lance for a gallery opening they were invited to."

"Fancy. What assignment have you got on?"

"Art, duh. And I need to finish the sets by Friday or DT will actually chop my head off."

Adora chuckled at that, she'd never seen DT as distressed as they were. With opening night coming up in a few short days, they were actually minding their own business and staying out of the gossip hole they practically lived in.

"Guess I'm doomed to waste time by myself then?"

Adora flopped back over, the ends of her hair brushing the carpet.

Just as Glimmer began to respond, a knock sounded at the door. The girls exchanged a look with each other, Glimmer shrugging. Adora pushed her hands against the ground, kicking her legs over and opening the door to see...Lonnie.

"Oh, hey Lonnie."

Her hand remained on the doorknob as she tried to think why Lonnie might be visiting her.

"Hey." Her hand tightened around the strap of her linen tote bag and the two girls stood awkwardly at the entrance for a moment.

"Did you still wanna take a look at my PT stuff?" Lonnie said finally. Adora mentally slapped herself for forgetting.

"OH! Right, sorry, I forgot I asked about that. Come in," she opened the door wider, Glimmer peering around and offering a smile to Lonnie.

Adora led her through into the lounge, Glimmer following the two of them (despite her laptop and sketchbook sitting forgotten on the vanity table), the assignment apparently ditched. Lonnie sat opposite her on the floor, dumping her bag on the coffee table and pulling out various books.

Adora watched expectantly, eyeing the cover and title of each of them.

"How long did the course last?"

Lonnie flicked through her books, offering a view pages for Adora to read as she responded.

"A few months. It went as extra credit for P.E, and helped me get a job last summer."

Adora nodded, the various diagrams intriguing her. The content looked like everything she would enjoy, ranging from the

mechanics of the metabolism to creating training programs for a variety of clients.

"This looks amazing," she grabbed another book, Lonnie offering up more advice.

"Yeah, it's a few extra hours of homework a week. I'd say between ten to fifteen, but definitely worth it. You could even do it over the holidays, probably would be easier."

Adora nodded, her eyes lighting up as she put down the book. She hadn't felt academically invigorated in a long, long while.

"I think I want to do it. How do I, uhm, do that?"

She glanced at Glimmer, who was smiling at her.

"Mermista can set you up. Or Sea Hawk."

Adora nodded, closing the book and placing it with the stack.

"You can keep those, if you like. I have all my notes on a file, so I don't really use them anymore. If you want, I can send those to you as well, it's easy to make a copy."

"Really?"

"Yeah, sure."

Lonnie gave half a smile, and Adora returned it.

"I actually need to meet Kyle and Rogelio, but I'll see you?"

Adora nodded, standing up with Lonnie to show her to the door. She opened it, the girls giving each other a hug.

"Lonnie?"

Adora's eyes darted to the owner of that distinct voice, landing on Catra's slightly startled expression. They both retracted, Lonnie

turning around to face Catra, who was still staring at them with something akin to suspicion.

"What's up?"

Catra narrowed her eyes, glancing back and forth between the two girls.

"Nothing. Why're you here?"

"She was helping me with something," Adora cut in. Catra's stare suddenly turned icy.

"Uh huh....Sorry, helping you with what, exactly?"

Adora noted Lonnie's awkward expression as she was caught in their encounter.

"Just stuff," Adora shrugged. She didn't feel like giving Catra a detailed explanation when she claimed to want space. Space meant they didn't interfere with each other's business. Glimmer suddenly pushed in beside Adora, sticking her head out the door frame.

"What's going o- Oh, hey Catra!"

Glimmer waved before Adora shot her a look and lightly slapped her arm down. Glimmer winced, giving her an apologetic look.

"Sparkles, when's our next smoothie run?" She nodded her head with a smirk. Adora felt a beat of annoyance run through her at that. She knew Catra and Glimmer grabbed smoothies once a month (ever since their reconciliation), but she didn't think it would continue during their relationship hiccup. Glimmer's eyes ran to Adora before meeting with her sister's again.

"We'll chat later." Adora's annoyance only grew at that. Sure, they were sisters or whatever, but Glimmer was her friend first.

"Smoothie runs?"

She raised an eyebrow at Glimmer beside her, who dodged her gaze. Adora looked back at Catra, who was throwing a look at Lonnie.

"Come on, Lonnie," she nodded her to the hallway, Lonnie giving Adora a sincere smile before following Catra. Adora shut the door, folding her arms and glaring at Glimmer.

"What?"

Glimmer looked a bit sheepish, but her voice was innocent.

"Oh, Sparkles, when's our next smoothie run?" Adora flapped her hands around, rolling her eyes as she mocked Catra's voice in a high pitched tone.

"As much as I'm your best-est friend, she's also my sister. I can't stay mad at her!"

Adora groaned, flopping on the beanbag.

"Look, I like you both. You can't expect me to choose a side."

"But I want to do smoothie runs with Catra. Why do you get to go on a date with her?"

Adora whined, Glimmer whacking her (hard) with a cushion.

"Yuck, gross Adora! We're practically related, my sister, remember?"

Adora rubbed her face, trying to come back to her senses. God, she was being weirdly possessive. How could she be jealous of Glimmer for hanging out with Catra? She knocked her head back on the soft surface.

"Sorry, I'm just, I don't know. Forget it."

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The following few days were probably the most awkward experiences of Adora's life. Every time DT or Lonnie talked to her, she'd feel Catra's stare on them. And every time Glimmer smiled or made eye contact with Catra, Adora had to fight the urge to glare at both girls. She banged her head against the table, squinting at Bow.

"Bow, you're my one loyal friend," she dramatically cried.

"Adora, it's natural to be jealous, but think of how Glimmer's feeling," Bow bit into his apple. The pair were sitting in one of the libraries, books open idly in front of them.

"Imagine if Glim and I broke up, would you be able to pick a side and just ignore the other person?"

Adora gnawed on her lip, she hadn't thought of that.

"Exactly."

She felt something brush against her shoulder, and glanced up to see Catra standing behind her. Bow dropped his pencil, and Adora met the girl's eyes.

"I think we need another chat."

Bow mumbled some strange excuse about going to the bathroom and quickly left the table, Adora watching him leave as Catra took a seat beside her.

"We're killing our friends."

Adora twirled her pencil slowly in her hands, listening.

"I told Lonnie I don't want her hanging out with you, she got mad at me. And your conversation with Bow told me a similar thing might've happened with Sparkles?"

Adora nodded, still refusing to speak or look up at her.

"I don't think custody rights will work for us. And Bow's right, as much as I hate seeing my friends talk to you, I can't really do much about it."

"So..." Adora finally looked at her, waiting for Catra to continue.

"Let's just agree to be friends?"

Adora scoffed, raising her foot to rest on her chair and spinning the pencil faster.

"You can't seriously expect me to be around you and just act as friends, Catra."

Catra winced slightly at the word.

"Our lives can't avoid each other. And I think being friends might help deal with...everything."

Adora stopped abruptly, dropping the pencil on her page and nodding slowly with narrowed eyes. She looked over at Catra.

"So what I'm hearing, is that you want us to be...purely platonic?"

"Maybe. For now."

"What the fuck Catra? One second you're saying we need distance, now you want us to be friends?"

"Adora, listen to me. We can't avoid each other! Yeah, distance is ideal, but my sister is your best friend, and your gym buddy is my roommate. Lonnie doesn't want to cut you off, and too many of my friends are friends with your friends."

What Catra said made sense, but Adora couldn't fathom the thought of reverting back to just friends with her.

"Okay Catra. Friends, let's be besties, if that's what you want?"

Adora leaned close, hissing the word in the silence of the library. Catra leaned closer, their faces inches apart.

"Yeah. Fine by me," the pair glared at each other, neither moving.

"Shall we make friendship bracelets then?"

"Great idea, buddy."

Adora struggled not to react at that, something akin to satisfaction working itself into Catra's eyes.

"I'm pretty sure this is the furthest thing from distance," Adora realized how close they were.

"Just because I don't trust you doesn't mean you're not hot."

Catra looked down for a fraction at Adora's lips.

"That's not very 'friend' of you to say."

Adora paused, leaning back to look at her properly. What they were doing, saying...it wasn't healthy for either of them.

"What's the point of this, Catra? The teasing, flirting. It does nothing for either of us."

"I don't know, you're just...hard to stay away from."

"Likewise."

"I miss you."

"You're the one that asked for this. Deal with it." The words sounded harsh to her own ears.

"I know I did. I just miss having you around, you were as much my best friend as you were my girlfriend. And it pisses me off seeing my friends be your's."

Adora understood what Catra meant by that. She didn't have the trust to be in a relationship, but she missed Adora's company, her presence in her life.

"Look Catra, we can be civil, but I don't think it's possible for me to hug you and not feel butterflies, or be around you and not have the urge to kiss you. I would rather be your enemy than your friend."

Catra looked down at Adora's words.

"So sorry if you miss me, but I'm not willing to just be a couple of besties right now."

Adora packed up her materials, as well as Bow's discarded ones, and stood up to leave.

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Bloody Daggers and False Kisses

"Hey, Glimmer."

Adora looked up from her tablet as Glimmer attempted to sneak out the door quietly.

"Adoraaa! Hi!"

"Where ya off to?"

She sipped from her water bottle expectantly. They had about an hour before they needed to get ready for the play.

"Just...to the library, you know. Finishing that assignment."

Adora nodded slowly, and Glimmer spotted her opportunity.

"Okay, cool, bye!"

"Hang on!"

She paused on her mad dash out, stepping backwards as Adora examined her.

"You're going to see Catra, aren't you?"

Glimmer's silence spoke for her.

"Sit," she patted the seat beside her, and Glimmer sat down reluctantly.

"Catra and I aren't dating right now, and I have...feelings about that, but my complicated relationship with Catra shouldn't interfere with your's."

Glimmer looked up at her, surprised.

"You two have avoided each other for so long, I don't want to be the reason you do it again."

She grabbed Glimmer's hands in her own, looking down at them for a moment. Arms enveloped around her as she did, Glimmer's soft hair tickling Adora.

"Thank you. Really."

It stung, but Adora let go of her, and Glimmer stood up.

"I'll meet you backstage tonight?"

"Yeah, I'll see you."

Adora smiled against her will, letting Glimmer leave the dorm before wiping her eyes hurriedly.

———————

"Adora, my shining star! The centre of my artistry! My muse-"

"Double Trouble," Adora deadpanned, putting her hands on her hips. The flattery was annoyingly overdone that it almost became sarcastic. DT winked at her, of course, grabbing her forearm and dragging her into the wings of the stage.

"Now, I know you're having a hissy fit and all, but I need you to be in love with Catra."

Adora didn't bother correcting them, just nodded along.

"Easy."

"Not easy. Right now, you two are my main concern. This original play is about death and rulership, this adaption obviously contains those elements, but it's also about the ability of love to achieve power. Which is part of the reason I cast you two."

"Sorry to burst your bubble, but Catra and I never ruled or saved the universe."

"No, but you were close."

Adora ignored whatever they meant by that. DT adored speaking in riddles and innuendos.

"Look, I'm trying my best, but I'm not a professional actor. I can't just shove aside our history and be Macbeth."

She shrugged, cheeks flushing a bit in shame.

"Fine, if you can't ignore your history with Catra, can you embrace it?"

Her eyes narrowed in confusion as she tilted her head.

"Huh?"

"How intense are your emotions right now? Regardless of whether they're positive or not."

She didn't have to think twice about her answer. "Pretty goddamn intense."

"Excellent! Use them, channel them. When you're in a fight scene, think of her, when you're in a love scene, imagine your last kiss."

"So you want me to just think of her the entire play, then?"

"Exactly, darling."

They clapped their hands together giddily, smiling wildly at Adora with manic eyes.

"Oh, and one more thing." Adora waited.

"Fuck this up for me, and I'll destroy everything you love most."

Adora straightened at that. DT was probably the most melodramatic human she'd ever met.

"No pressure, I guess," she mumbled. DT giggled, pulling her in for a hug.

"Break a leg, my adora-ble little star."

Adora cringed at the intended pun, but nevertheless, returned the hug. DT finally released her, opening the door and dragging her through. They led her straight to Catra, sitting in a chair getting her costume laced on and makeup set.

"Catra, love!"

DT called out to her excitedly, gasping at the look.

"Oh, Flutterina, you truly are an artist."

Catra's makeup look was perfectly balanced between dark and innocent, for her character was a mastermind in the art of deception.

"Adora," her voice was sharp.

"Play nice, kitten. Don't forget you're obsessed with her character...or maybe her, same thing really."

Catra was silent, staring at Adora.

"We never rehearsed it, but I need you two to be ready for the kiss scene."

Both girls broke their stare to look at DT.

"The kiss what?"

"That was not a part of the play."

Their overlapping exclaims cancelled each other out, but DT got the hint.

"I swear that was in the script? No? Huh," they drummed their fingers against their chin in thought.

"Double Trouble," Catra warned.

"Me-ow, put your claws away, kitten." They imitated a cat showing off its claws.

"Honest mistake, probably Kyle's fault. But yeah, you two are meant to kiss after defeating Macduff. It's actually quite cute."

"That's the scene where I stab his dead body multiple times." Adora raised her eyebrow, head dropping slightly.

"Romantic, isn't it?"

Adora was prepared to argue it, but didn't bother. If that was DT's idea of a romantic kiss, she was deeply scared for their love interests.

"Anyway, did you two want to practice now, or....?"

DT moved their fingers around between them, only being met with silence from the two girls.

"If you say another fucking word, I'll probably end up killing you in your sleep," Catra threatened. Adora blinked at the dark words, but DT's expression brightened.

"Yes! Perfect, darling. That is precisely the energy we need tonight," DT did another joyous little clap, patting Catra on the head like a pet of their's. Adora watched her gaze darken with mild amusement of her own.

"Adora, go get dressed. You need to be fitted with your mic."

DT passed her a hangar from a nearby rack, shooing her into a room.

She quickly obeyed their orders, pulling the pants and tunic on and adjusting the armor. She shortly exited the small change room, immediately being dragged into a chair and dusted with minimal makeup while her hair was pulled back into a low bun. Another member of the backstage crew came around, doing

microphone checks and making sure the pack was concealed by Adora's costume.

Before she even knew what was happening, DT was standing at the side of the stage, introducing the play to the awaiting audience.

Adora's heart sped up, the lines running over and over in her head when she felt a presence by her side.

"A kiss?"

Catra's presence did anything but soothe her in that moment.

"Are you okay?"

Catra took a breath, neither girl turning to face each other but rather watching Double Trouble as they spoke to the crowd.

"No, if I'm being honest."

"I mean, it'll mean nothing," the words ached as she said them.

"Another lie? Really?"

Catra's tone was less humorous, and more pissed off if anything.

"Maybe it'll mean something," Adora admitted.

"We've been on a break for about a week. It'll mean more than something."

Adora took another breath to try and steady herself.

"Yeah, well, you're kissing Macbeth. Not me, so don't worry."

Her voice had an edge to it, and Catra didn't give back a retort.

"Here we go," Adora murmured as the lights dimmed, and she strode onstage.

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The play had been going perfectly, as Adora would describe it. DT was surprisingly correct, it was easier to connect to her emotions and act, rather than disassociate and pretend to be someone else. She'd almost even forgotten the fast approaching kiss scene.

Almost.

"Okay darlings, your big moment is coming. If you chicken out of this kiss I will be mad, so don't. You don't want to see me angry."

DT gave a soft warning before disappearing back into the shadows. Catra and Adora exchanged an awkward glance at one another before Adora stepped onstage and assumed her role once again.

"Macduff!"

She roared the name in the most infuriating male voice she could muster, brandishing her prop sword and bringing it down on the back of an unsuspecting Macduff. The actor, Swift Wind, made a noise filled with fear, and turned around in a last attempt to kill Macbeth. Adora dodged the attack, as they'd rehearsed, and drove her fake sword deeper into Macduff's 'heart.'

Swift Wind collapsed onto the floor, Adora watching the fake blood seep from a concealed bottle onto the stage. The audience made exclaims of shock, fuelling Adora's own performance. She knelt down, knowing this was Catra's cue to enter on the stage, and pulled out a small dagger.

"Have we won, my love?"

Adora drove the fake dagger into the wood, covering Swift Wind's body so the audience could only see her back and her arm moving the blade.

"Yes, my Queen."

She stood from her knelt position, holding up the bloodied dagger and sword as a symbol of victory. Catra gave a rolling laugh of wickedness, wrapping her arms around Adora's neck, who pulled her close. This was it, this was their cue to kiss.

Adora couldn't help but break character for a moment when she met Catra's eyes, and she knew Catra wasn't Lady Macbeth in that split second.

Is this real, or fake? Adora asked the question through her gaze.

Fake. We're not ready for it to be real.

One mistake, one lie, and everything we had is suddenly a deception?

Yes. A lie that lasted months and was hardly innocent.

Adora struggled to hide her hurt, but Catra quickly closed the distance between them, their lips meeting as the crowd reacted once more. Adora was fairly sure she heard a few shouts and whistles of encouragement, but those were hard to focus on when Catra was kissing her for the first time in seven days.

She disconnected their lips quickly, Catra's eyes frayed and glassed over. Adora imagined she looked like a worser image. It was meant to be a kiss of victory, but she doubted either of them looked victorious in that moment.

"Oh, Macbeth, what greatness we've achieved," Catra glazed over the moment where they both broke character, becoming Lady Macbeth once again.

Friend of Mara's?

"Am I thankful that's over."

DT collapsed into the chair beside her, Adora typing out a quick email to meet with Ms Ella. She desperately needed to review her portfolio before submission at the end of the year.

"You're telling me. Basketball season is finally over, that fashion show is done, the play is done. All that's left is exams, and a much needed break."

She was exhausted from the past few weeks. It had been two days since the final show, and Adora was thankful she didn't have to pretend to be a bloodthirsty conqueror anymore.

"Adora! Aren't you meant to be in class?"

Perfuma wandered past them with a mug in hand, smiling at the pair sitting in the library. Adora's gaze latched onto the steaming mug, a comical text reading 'You're Plantastic!!!' on the front of it, paired with a cartoon image of a flower.

"I have a study. Not sure about them, though," she tilted her head towards DT, who shot her a withering look for throwing them under the bus.

"Back to class for you, Double Trouble. Adora, if you wouldn't mind, I'd like a quick word."

Perfuma smiled gently, nodding her head towards a private study booth. Adora gulped, mind running through what Perfuma might want to discuss with her. She quickly followed her, grabbing her laptop and pencil case. She caught DT's inquisitive glance as she left.

"What did you want to chat about?"

She drummed her fingers on the table nervously in an attempt to occupy herself.

"Nothing bad, don't worry. I actually wanted to discuss your post-school options. Are you planning on going to college?"

"Yeah, I'd like to," Adora admitted shyly.

"Lovely. In that case, I'll set you up with the school counselor. She'll be happy to guide you through the process."

"Thanks, Dean Perfuma," Adora responded, feeling relieved that she didn't have to figure all this stuff out by herself.

"You're also due for a check-in with Dr Despondos. She sent an email to me last week requesting a catch up with you."

This news surprised Adora. Mara wanted to see her? She was pretty sure she was back to normal, in terms of her physical health.

"Oh, yeah, sure. When does she want to see me?"

"Up to you," Perfuma hummed, opening up her tablet and typing in Adora's name to find her timetable, organized into her personal online calendar.

"Could I maybe do this Friday? I'm being dragged through the mud with exam revision at the moment."

"Of course! Does five o'clock in the evening suit?"

Adora thought for a second before nodding. She watched Perfuma enter the time and event into her calendar.

"And for the counselor? How about during homeroom on Friday as well?"

"Sounds perfect, thank you."

Perfuma entered that in as well, Adora relaxing slightly in the chair.

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"Hey, Mermista?"

Adora hung back awkwardly as everyone exited the classroom, Sea Hawk packing away various pieces of equipment. The nonchalant teacher gave her a look of mild boredom.

"What? Don't tell me you're flaking out on your shift this week," she rolled her eyes. On anyone else, this action would be considered rude, but it was oddly natural for Mermista. Adora shook her head vigorously. She wouldn't dream of skipping her usual Saturday shift at the gym. It was a nice distraction from everything else going on in her life.

"No, no flaking. I actually wanted to talk about enrolling in a PT course? I know Lonnie did it sometime last year?"

She hugged her stack of books closer to her chest, waiting for a reply.

"PT course? Sure, why not?"

Adora beamed at the teacher, who blew a bubblegum bubble.

"I'll hook you up, kid. During summer?"

"Ideally," Adora babbled.

"Whatever," Mermista's signature remark acted as a cue of dismissal, Adora quietly slipping out of the room as Sea Hawk returned. She needed to head to the counselor's office now, so lingering for much longer wasn't necessary. She hastily pulled out her phone to send a text to Lonnie, letting her know the good news.

Adora focused her attention downwards, looking intently at the device and completely ignoring her surroundings...which promptly led her to walk into someone.

Oh.

It had been about two weeks since their 'break' begun, and not much progress had been make beyond Adora blocking Shadow Weaver.

"Sorry," she mumbled, collecting her items off the floor. Catra didn't say anything.

"How's...exam revision going?" Catra cautiously asked the question as they both stood up.

Was this really what their relationship had reduced to in the span of fourteen days? Asking cordial questions about study?

"Alright... You?"

She scratched the back of her neck, the pair being pushed to the side of the hallway as people moved by to reach their classes and lockers.

"Never better."

Catra bit her lip, as if restraining herself from saying something else. Adora debated moving the question past small talk, but decided against it. Fighting again and again would get them nowhere. If they had to start from scratch, she was willing to do it.

"I'm starting a PT course soon," Adora blurted. It was too awkward to stay silent. Catra's eyes lit up in interest.

"Really? That's very you of you."

She waved her hand over Adora's figure, scanning her up and down with a small smile. Adora chuckled at the movement,

nodding slightly.

"Yeah, well, I thought it was about time I started pursuing things I'm actually interested in."

Something twinkled in Catra's eyes as her smile widened.

"Is that what Lonnie was helping you with? Stubborn girl refused to tell me anything," she rolled her eyes.

Adora leaned against the edge of the wall, crossing one foot over another as she looked at her.

"Yup. No need to be jealous," she threw her pencil case into the air before catching it with a wink. Catra scoffed, intercepting the throw to catch Adora's pencil case herself.

"I'm not jealous."

"Who's lying now?"

"Still you," her voice lilted. Adora scrunched her face in annoyance, Catra tossing the pencil case back to her.

"As fun as this is, I've gotta run," she pushed herself off the wall. Catra looked mildly disappointed.

"Where?"

"Maybe it's none of your business."

That line must've stung, for Catra looked a little hurt. Adora faintly recalled saying something similar during their fight, and quickly amended it. She'd meant the words lightheartedly, but it seemed too have hit a sore spot.

"I'm meeting with the careers counselor. Talking about college and stuff."

"Ah," Catra nodded in understanding.

"I'll see you around then?"

Adora had a twinge of hope laced in both her question and expression. Catra took a second to think before answering.

"Sure, Blondie."

She smirked, fist bumping Adora's arm before walking off in the opposite direction. Adora had to restrain herself from dancing right there in the middle of the hallway, but the grin that spread on her face was unavoidable. She wasn't outright ignoring her like she had for the past few days. Catra was actually being...nice, almost friendly to her, and she'd called her 'Blondie.' Adora never would have thought she'd rejoice to the sound of that stupid nickname.

Walking on Cloud 9, Adora opened the door to the career's office, vaguely wondering who the counselor even was.

Probably, some random, completely unknown teacher who she had never seen in-

Or not.

Adora's jaw very nearly dropped when she spotted Madame Razz sitting in a wide leather chair far too big for her small frame.

"Razz?" Adora was incredulous. This woman was clearly unavoidable. She sat opposite her, placing her books on the desk while continuing to just stare.

"Mara, dearie!"

Adora was too shocked to bother correcting her.

"How do you have this many jobs?"

Her confusion over Razz's profession was the only thing occupying her mind. There was no way this woman could own a business while also being a school career's counselor. Adora recalled Mara

mentioning she was her professor in med school, further fueling her confusion.

"Magic, dearie!"

Adora just nodded, internally accepting that she'd never get a straight answer from this wacky lady.

"Now, I have some very important questions for you!"

Razz's frail hands clasped Adora's, who just stared at her.

"Rainforest or deserts?"

Adora didn't bother asking for an explanation. She was fairly used to it by now.

"Rainforest." Razz nodded, closing her eyes.

"Mango, or papaya?"

"Mango?"

Adora didn't really enjoy either, but mangos were probably more preferable.

"Hats or belts?"

"Hats," that was a no-brainer.

"Stars or the sun?"

"Stars," another no-brainer.

"Aha!"

Adora had no idea what the woman may have just realized, but it must've been something fairly important. She released Adora's hands, typing furiously into a keypad before spinning her massive chair around and around.

"Weehee, Adora dearie! You're going to the First One's University," she cackled.

"Woah, wait. How can you decide what university is best from those questions?"

Razz just shrugged, no explanation offered. She spun the computer around to face her.

"Number One, First One's. Number Two, Beast Island. Number Three, Black Garnet. And your backups are Seaworthy and Elberon."

Adora knew next to nothing about any of these colleges, but apparently she didn't need to. Razz had already made the decision for her. Something about that rubbed her the wrong way, even if Razz only had good intentions.

"No. Thank you, but no. Razz, I can't make those my preferences when I know nothing about these universities."

Something sparkled in the old woman's expression, no trace of anger or frustration able to be seen, and she quickly bent down before returning with a few pamphlets.

The First One's University, Beast Island University, and Black Garnet College.

She flicked through each of them, and couldn't help but admit that First One's was appealing to her the most.

"Could I have all of them?"

Razz obliged, providing her with a stack of booklets. She sat there for a few minutes, flicking through every page until she found her mind circling back to the first option.

Razz was right, First One's was her's.

"How on earth did you just know?"

She leaned back in the chair, looking at the glorious building depicted not the front cover of the booklet. Her eyes had even spotted an appealing course: A double degree in Health Science and Physiotherapy.

Razz just giggled in her chair, rocking back and forth in a manic manner.

"Magic!"

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Adora approached the front desk, waiting paitently for the man at the counter to address her.

"Hello, how may I help?"

"I'm here to see Dr. Despondos? I'm Adora."

She drummed her fingers against the surface, looking around anxiously. She'd come straight from school, still wearing her uniform, and the itchy woolen jumper was irritating her skin.

"Mara? Of course. Take a seat, she'll be with you in a moment."

Adora nodded, following his instructions and opening her phone. She didn't have to wait long, Mara coming out of her office barely a few minutes after she'd sat down.

The woman gave her a generous smile, pearly white teeth and dark, long brown hair shining in her high ponytail. Adora returned the smile, following Mara's nod into her office.

"How have you been, Adora?"

She sat down in the chair opposite Mara, who opened up the patient file on her monitor. Adora rubbed her palms against her thighs in an effort to soothe herself, properly meeting Mara's clear blue eyes for the first time.

"Physically, great. I'm basically back to normal, which is why I'm surprised you wanted to do a check-up?" She phrased her words into a question, glancing up quizzically at Mara.

The doctor rolled her chair closer to Adora, grabbing various reports and equipment from her desk.

"It's mostly routine stuff. You know what hospitals are like; check, check, double check."

She chuckled to herself and rolled her eyes, causing Adora to relax.

"Physically great, eh? What about mentally, socially... emotionally?"

Mara spoke as she gently lifted Adora's leg onto a surgical bench, scanning a device over her femur and knee.

"Those have room for improvement," she mumbled, but Mara seemed to catch every syllable.

"Broken leg's healed completely, so good news. Let's have a look at your CT scans," she wheeled herself back over to the desk.

"What's been going on with those other health dimensions, then?"

Adora found it fascinating how Mara could easily concentrate on both her job and engaging in conversation with Adora. Some weird doctor talent.

"Catra and I broke up. Well, we're on a break," Adora corrected herself.

This caused Mara to pause in her clicking, looking over at Adora for a moment.

"I never knew you guys were properly together, I mean, I had a hunch, but I'm sorry to hear that. You seemed close."

Mara's distraction broke, and her focus returned as she compared the previous scans to the new ones.

"Yeah, we were."

A few seconds of silence as Mara wrote a few notes on a page before looking back up at Adora.

"Bones are healed, the concussion's effect has lessened significantly."

Her sentence didn't seem to be complete, so Adora waited.

"You don't look particularly great, Adora, if I'm being completely honest. You're pale, and I think you've lost a bit of weight."

Adora had been exerting a lot of energy through exercise, without fueling herself with enough food. She wasn't exactly sure where the 'paleness ' had come from though, she'd spent days in the sun.

"How long has it been since the 'break'?"

Mara shut off her computer, giving her full attention to Adora.

"About two weeks."

Mara made a noise of slight alarm, leaning back in her desk chair.

"Do you know how much weight you've lost?"

Adora shrugged. "Maybe a few kilos?"

Mara's concern escalated, but she was fairly good at masking it.

"It takes about a month or so to lose healthy weight, so naturally, I'm concerned."

"I just need to eat a bit more," Adora knew the remedy to her own problem.

"I used to be a dietician, and judging from your stats-"

She flicked through Adora's files again.

"You need at least about two thousand and five hundred calories to meet your energy requirements."

"Eat more food? You got it, Doc," Adora sighed. Mara gave her a close lipped smile, scanning her face.

"This break up's hitting hard, huh?"

"It's a break, no 'up' in there," Adora snapped. She instantly regretted it though, because a shadow of hurt flashed on Mara's face before she gave Adora a small smile.

"This break is hitting hard, then?"

Adora nodded, leaning forward and resting her chin in her hands.

"Catra and I were both in the same orphanage when we were younger. My adoptive mother, Shadow Weaver, was our mentor. She favored me, was pretty mean to Catra."

Mara nodded, crossing her legs and listening intently.

"Fast forward a few years, Weaver adopts me and Catra and I don't see each other again until this year."

Adora took her hair tie off her wrist, wrapping the band around her finger as she spoke.

"We're together for a few months, and it's great. But during the months, during the whole year, actually, Weaver threatens me, she scolds me, she...yeah, all the shitty stuff."

Adora looked down at the hair elastic to avoid the sympathy in Mara's gaze.

"But I tell Catra none of it, because she spent time and energy forgetting about what that woman has done to her and I don't

want to be the person that brings it back into her life."

Her vision clouded, and she forced the tears to go back from wherever they came from. As if she was going to embarrass herself in front of Mara by crying.

"Well, two weeks ago, she finds a few texts. And accuses me of lying. Says she doesn't need me to protect her and that our trust is broken...that she needs space."

Adora despised that word.

"That's where we're at now, I guess."

She finally looked up, feeling in control of herself again. Mara looked next to tears herself.

"I know it provides little comfort, but Hope and I were also on a break."

"Really?"

"For a year. She proposed to me after a few years of dating, and I said yes. Three weeks later I find out she'd slept with one her clients to get information from them regarding their alibi. I was being a bit dramatic, in retrospect. She'd done it while we were still in the talking stage, but still, she'd lied about it for years. And besides, it was a mean thing to do, use someone like that."

Adora personally thought Mara wasn't being dramatic, but she didn't express that.

"I threw the ring at her, she came with flowers....more pining, apologies, but I had just found out I'd gotten into med school so I told her I needed to work on myself for a bit. A year later, she calls me, asking if we can have a chat, and I agree."

"Why?"

"Because I believe in second chances. And despite it all, I was still in love with her. A year never changed that, no matter how much I wanted it to."

"What should I do then? Wait a year and then call Catra like 'hey, let's talk!'" She mocked a phone call, looking expectantly at Mara.

"I'd work on Shadow Weaver, if I were you."

"I have, I told her to fuck off!"

Mara snorted, taking a drink from her water bottle.

"You ever heard the term 'emancipation?'"

Adora looked at her in surprise, humor erased by that singular word.

"As in, not making her my legal guardian anymore?"

"That's emancipation."

"I don't think I need to do that," Adora frowned.

Sure, Weaver was annoying and manipulative, but she'd still given Adora a home and comfort for eleven years. It felt unfair to ignore all of that.

"I've seen your scars, Adora. In all honesty, I've been concerned about that woman for a long time."

Mara's tone was both serious and concerned. It made Adora feel strange.

"Do you really think emancipation is necessary, though?"

"It'd be a simple process. Hope would get it done for you in about a month."

Adora felt an odd sense of protectiveness overwhelm her.

"Thanks, but I'm good. I can avoid her well enough through school and university, I don't need to do all of that," she tried to soften the sharpness of her voice. Mara seemed to get the hint though, for she instantly laid off.

"It's your decision, of course. I think you know what's best for yourself."

Mara gave her a final smile, and Adora returned it.

"I need to book another final check up with you three months from now. Is Feb the 4th good?"

"Should be," Adora replied.

"Wonderful," Mara flagged the date, standing and opening the door for Adora.

"I know I'm technically your doctor, but please feel free to come to me for anything. You have my number, Adora, you're always welcome to use it. I consider all my patients to be my friends."

"Thanks," Adora felt like she might take her up on that offer one day.

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Don't Worry, Dearie

Glimmer reached up, shaking Adora's shoulders excitedly as they walked into the parking lot.

"Are you excited?"

Adora shook with the movement, feeling slightly dizzy when Glimmer stopped.

"A little," she looked over at Bow, who was watching the pair of them with amusement. Glimmer bounced up and down, swinging open the car door.

"A little? Come on, Adora, we're finally picking them up!"

She was acting like a toddler high on sugar. Collecting their gala outfits was fun and all, but Glimmer was behaving as if she was picking up her wedding dress, or something.

"Bow, maybe you should drive," Adora barely trusted Glimmer behind the wheel when she wasn't this jittery.

"I was just about to suggest the same thing."

Glimmer rolled her eyes, placing the keys in a stand and turning on the engine. She dutifully ignored their comments, sticking her tongue out at Bow and Adora.

"Apparently you can't be excited and drive anymore? Seriously people, lighten up," she reversed mindlessly without checking the rearview mirror, spurring both passengers into a bit of a panic.

"Glim! Watch where you're going," Bow twisted his neck to make sure a car or pedestrian wasn't behind them.

"You guys are such funsuckers, I swear," she put the vehicle into drive, exiting the car park.

"How was your visit with the counselor?" Bow looked over his shoulder at Adora after some time, the girl broken out of her trance of staring out the window.

"Good. Oh yeah, did you guys know the counselor was Madame Razz?"

Glimmer scoffed, taking a right without flicking on her indicator. She was honked, causing both Bow and Adora to wince yet again.

"No it isn't. It's that lady with the mushroom hat."

Adora frowned in utter confusion, looking to Bow who just nodded.

"No, I swear it's Razz. She asked me a bunch of weird questions and then said my top preference should be First One's University."

"Adora, I visited the counselor barely a few days before you did to lock in my preferences. It's definitely mushroom lady," Glimmer sounded firm, but Adora knew she'd seen Razz that day. She decided to just drop the subject of who the counselor was, and her friends did too.

"First One's, huh? That has a pretty low acceptance rate," Bow offered.

"Does it?" Adora's worry peaked again, and Bow instantly detected it.

"Yeah, but it's not a bad thing. You can easily get in," Adora appreciated his confidence in her, but she wasn't inclined to agree with him.

"I doubt it, but thanks."

Glimmer turned into the driveway, parking horribly and tucking her keys into her bag.

"You have the tops marks in the whole grade, Adora. Don't sell yourself short," Glimmer opened the door, the others following suit. Adora smiled as the sunlight hit her, Glimmer's words settling in her mind. She opened the door to Razz's studio, holding it ajar for her two friends to pass through. The scent of incense and cedar floated through the room, reminding her instantly of the owner of the boutique.

"Razz?" Glimmer called out, the old woman appearing from thin air in front of them. Glimmer jumped back a bit in surprise as Razz grinned at the trio.

"Gala!"

That was the only word she said before disappearing again, in typical Razz fashion. She shortly returned with three large garment bags, pushing each of them into a change room. Before Adora could register what was even going on, the dusty pink curtains were closed around her. She tentatively placed the hangar on the hook, zipping open the dress.

Her mouth dropped open as she continued to unzip, folds and folds of fabric slowly being unveiled to her unsuspecting eyes. She gasped softly, pulling the dream white material out of the bag and marveling over it for a few seconds. She'd seen sketches of it, been fitted in the material countless times, but nothing compared to the final product. She slipped it on, holding the front of it against her chest and stepping out so Razz could lace up the back for her.

Gold chains brushed against her skin, causing her to flinch at the cold metal. But she didn't mind, the dress was worth any discomfort it gave her. Bow exited from his change room, adorned in a gorgeous lavender and royal purple suit. They smiled at each other as Razz finished tying Adora up, wordlessly shoving a pair of bronzed heels into Adora's hands. She sat down, careful not to disrupt the fabric, and slipped the shoes on, standing up again and looking in the mirror.

"Razz, you're incredible. This is-" she paused, unable to find the words to describe the vision she was seeing in the full length mirror.

Nothing about this dress was mundane or boring. The deep, swooping neckline paired with the golden chains rolling off her shoulders, and the brilliant cuffs that glowed when the light hit them just right.

"It matches you." Bow looked at her in the mirror before turning around, eyes widening. Adora smiled, knowing Glimmer had just walked out of the change room. She slowly turned around, unable to contain her smile at the sight.

Glimmer looked simply majestic, there was no other way to describe it. Layers of smooth salmon colored satin were draped by bubblegum tulle, the pale blue belt around her waist accentuating the dress perfectly. Razz climbed up on the couch, placing a thin silver diadem on Glimmer's head.

"Wow," Bow murmured under his breath, causing Glimmer to beam up at him. Adora felt intrusive watching them have their moment, but it was too sweet to look away from.

"You like it?"

"Like it? Glim, you look amazing," she giggled as he pulled her in, planting a kiss on her forehead.

"We match perfectly," she took a scan of his outfit before the couple returned their gazes to each other.

"Don't worry, dearie. She'll be back," Adora broke out of her trance as the voice whispered in her ear. She jolted a bit, looking to see Razz standing next to her on a stool.

"What?"

The old woman provided no further explanation, only winked and gave a tight lipped smile.

"Razzle Dazzle!"

Adora would never fail to be utterly perplexed by Razz, the old woman's exclaim catching her off guard for a few seconds. Her spontaneous shout drew Glimmer and Bow's attention back to Adora.

"Adora! Holy shit," Glimmer looked Adora up and down about five times, her expression only intensifying.

"Don't worry about Catra. She won't be able to keep her so-called 'distance' when you show up looking like that," Glimmer reassured her with a smirk. Bow elbowed her lightly.

"Filter, Love. For heaven's sake, filter," he nudged with wide eyes. Adora laughed at Glimmer's careless shrug, turning back around to Razz.

"Razz, you are the careers counselor, right?"

She needed to prove her point to her friends that Razz was in fact, the careers counselor she met a day before.

"Career's what? Dearie, are you sick," Razz raised a bony hand to feel Adora's temperature. The blonde leaned back, swatting the woman's arm away.

"I saw you! You told me I should attend the First One's University!"

Razz blinked her wide, old eyes at her, shrugging.

"First One's hooey? Come, Adora dearie, you're hallucinating. Have some ginger gumnut tea!"

Bow and Glimmer snickered as Adora turned to face them. They both reentered their respective change rooms, and Adora threw one last questioning look at Razz.

The old woman just winked at her knowingly, before ushering Adora back into the change room.

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Bitta This 'N' That...

"What are you doing?"

Adora glanced up from her phone, facing Glimmer. The light pink and lavender hair had been neatly styled into large rolling waves, with a side parting that made her look rather regal. She stood with her hands placed on her hips, looking eerily similar to Angella in that moment.

"Checking Instagram," she shrugged. Alarm clouded Glimmer's features as her gaze grew incredulous.

"We have two hours to get ready before leaving for the Gala, and you're checking Instagram?"

"Glimmer, two hours is more than enough time to get ready."

It was unnerving for Glimmer to be so distressed about being punctual. Usually, she didn't mind being a few minutes (or even a few hours) late to any event.

"You need to shower, get the dress on, do your hair, the makeup, accessories, photos-"

"Calm down, calm down," Adora waved her arms about to stop Glimmer's tangent.

"It's fine, I'm Adora," she emphasized her point by waving her arms over herself. Glimmer wasn't buying it, her annoyance visibly growing through her expression.

"If you're so worried, fine, I'll get ready now."

Adora tossed her phone on the coffee table, standing up to go take a bath. Glimmer huffed with a nod, watching Adora leave the lounge and enter the bathroom.

As expected, showering took her less than ten minutes, which meant she still had plenty of time to get ready. She slipped into the soft fabric of the dress, deciding she'd put the heels on last to avoid tripping and injuring herself. Glimmer marched into the bathroom, wearing her own gown and placing a bottle of something glittery on the bench. Swirls of shimmery pink liquid spun in the clear glass bottle. Adora was transfixed by it for a few moments.

"Body oil, go ahead."

Adora recalled using something similar for Catra's fashion show, and squeezed a few droplets of the shiny liquid into her palm. This one smelt like burnt sugar. She rubbed it along her collarbone and arms, before putting the golden cuffs on each of her wrists.

"How're you doing your makeup?"

Adora shrugged in response to the question, pointing at her back in a wordless gesture for Glimmer to tie her dress up. In all honesty, she'd nearly forgotten the Gala was today. She barely had time to think about her makeup look.

"Fine, I'll do it for you, then," Glimmer used a brush to blend her own foundation, taking all of forty minutes to perfect her look. She was brilliant at eyeliner, effortlessly swiping two metallic pink streaks on each of her lilac colored eyes. Adora waited patiently, deciding she'd work on her hair while Glimmer finished her makeup off. She still wasn't entirely confident in doing curls (though Glimmer had tried to teach her countless times), but straightening she could manage. It was simple to run the iron through her already relatively flat hair. Glimmer used some gel to slick it back for her, tucking the front strands behind her ears to showcase the gorgeous gold necklace Razz had let her borrow for the night.

"Dark makeup look, or nude?"

Adora thought for a second.

"Both?"

Glimmer smiled, nodding decisively. Within half an hour, she was done. Adora looked at her reflection in the mirror, gawking at herself for a few seconds. Glimmer had given her pure black eyeliner, which made the blue of her eyes shine even more. She'd added a light dusting of gold highlighter on the inner corner of her eyes, as well as her cheekbones, the rest of her face looking natural and light. Adora fastened her earrings on, along with her rings, continuing to stare at herself.

"Fall in love with the mirror, why don't you?"

"It's just-I look-"

"Powerful? Dominating? Hot as fuck?"

Adora reapplied the deep nude lipstick Glimmer had given her, smiling in the mirror.

"Yeah," she agreed.

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"What fucking Gala is this?" Adora hissed as the limo pulled up outside a building lined with a velvet fuchsia carpet.

"Don't worry, it's not the Met."

Bow's joke did nothing to soothe her sudden bout of stress as she eyed the lines of photographers on either side of the carpet.

"Brightmoon's Annual Gala is kind of a big deal," Glimmer sounded only the slightest smug.

"I swear I told you that?"

Adora recalled Bow and Glimmer raving about it, but she didn't think it was paparazzi level big. Then again, everyone attending

the school seemed to be famous themselves, or the children of influential people.

"Great," she groaned. Suddenly, she understood why Glimmer had made such a big deal about getting here on time. She took a breath, silently wishing Catra was there to steady her, and pushed open the door.

Lights blinded her vision, but Adora did her best to ignore it. DT's catwalk training was coming in useful here, this wasn't the first time she'd had the spotlight focussed on her. She fixed a camera-worthy smile onto her face, adjusting her dress and waiting for a few moments as Bow and Glimmer elegantly stepped out of the car. She looked at her friends, Glimmer giving a slight nod before the three of them walked down the carpet. Adora was surprised to hear a few of the photographers call out her name as she walked. Bow and Glimmer were obviously being called out to, but they had practically been born celebrities. Adora paused momentarily, letting a few of them get some photos before climbing up the steps to the entrance. Her heart pounded as she walked through, thankful that the noise and flashes were out of her vicinity at long last.

"Adora!"

She had never been more happy to see Angella Brightmoon, the woman standing near the entrance holding a flute of pink champagne. Though she may be a millionaire and former Hollywood Star, Adora still thought of her as simply Glimmer and Catra's mom. She reached up and gave her a brief hug as a waiter passed them. He offered a flute to Adora, who readily accepted it.

"No ID necessary," Angella winked.

"Supervised alcohol consumption never hurt anybody," Adora returned the smile, taking a sip. She could use the alcohol to get through the night.

"How are you? I heard about you and Catra."

Adora took a breath, it'd been about a month since the break begun and she still felt like it had happened yesterday.

"I'm managing," she offered. It didn't feel very appropriate to say 'Life without your daughter fucking hurts.'

Angella seemed to detect the lie, giving Adora a side hug. The woman's sheer shawl reminded Adora of butterfly wings, the fabric complementing her elegant pearl colored slip gown. Adora found that Angella could wear the most basic outfits and still be effortlessly breathtaking.

"Are you stuck here for the whole night?"

"I'm meant to greet all the guests, but once appetizers are served I'm free," she took another sip. Adora supposed that made sense, this being her event and all. Bow and Glimmer finally entered through the doorway, both slightly out of breath.

"Hey, Mom," Glimmer panted, giving Angella a hug. Bow did the same, Adora looking at the two of them in confusion.

"Why are you so puffed?"

"So. Many. Pictures."

Adora chuckled, but Angella tutted.

"Why did you answer every single one of them? You know better."

Glimmer made a face at Angella.

"Sorry, I felt like too much of a bitch ignoring them."

Adora snickered at Angella's expression, her laugh dying in her throat when she spotted Catra talking to DT by the bar.

"I'll...be back," she quietly murmured. In her peripheral vision she saw Bow nod, and took it as an invitation to slip out of the conversation.

"Hey, Catra," the words were now foreign coming from her tongue. She hadn't spoken to Catra in at least a week, potentially more. The girl straightened slightly, before slowly turning around to face her. Adora had to force herself not to stare.

Catra was exquisite, but of course, that was nothing new. She wore a gown made from navy and gilded threads, the glinting fabrics overlapping one another, and a delicate gold necklace with a sapphire stone shining on her chest. A sheer veil of blue was draped past her back in the form of a cape, attached to the thin golden straps framing her shoulders.

What drew Adora's attention was both the lack of neckline (rather just two columns of fabric draping down to her naval, connected by a satin belt) and the twin thigh high slits on either side. Her eyes couldn't help but flick to Catra's shoes, inner satisfaction crawling through her when she noticed Catra was wearing the ones she'd gifted her for her birthday. It was honestly puzzling to look at her, for the gold sheer fabric collided with the navy in such a mesmerizing manner, the light causing the dress to shift from sapphire to topaz. The same could be said for her elaborate eye makeup, warm amber surrounding blue, and cobalt painted around gold. Her hair was in loose ringlets, gilded leaves threaded through the dark locks and blue gems fastened to her ears.

"Hey, Adora," she freely looked Adora up and down, bicoloured eyes meeting her's after a lengthy examination. Adora peered over her shoulder to greet DT, but the person seemed to have disappeared, for now it was just her and Catra.

"You look good," Adora admitted.

"Like, really good."

Catra finished the rest of her champagne, passing it to the bartender with a smile and request.

"I know," she sighed, eyes continuing to glance over Adora's figure. She scoffed, finishing off her own flute and staring at

Catra. Another waiter waltzed around with a tray of glasses, and Adora didn't hesitate to grab another.

"Wow, someone's cocky. Care to return the compliment?"

"Begging for flattery is hardly dignified, isn't it, Adora?"

"Yes, because I'm begging, aren't I, Catra?" Adora raised her eyebrows. The bartender returned Catra's glass, the girl giving Adora an inscrutable look as she leaned closer.

"Wanna know a secret?"

She giggled, and that's what finally indicated to Adora that Catra was utterly, completely, drunk. She didn't know how she only just realized it. Adora moved closer, ready to ask how many drinks Catra had consumed, but Catra spoke first.

"I'm wearing zero underwear, right now." Her giggle was breathy and light headed.

It transformed into a whisper, low and soft. "None."

Adora's words left her brain and she just stared at Catra, resisting the urge to glance down at her body. Her cheeks heated, and she slowly pried the flute of champagne off Catra's hands. She forced her mind not to wander, trying to focus on the situation in front of her.

"Yeah, none of that on an empty stomach," her voice was strained.

Catra let her slide the glass out of her grip, but smirked. She caught Adora's hand in her own, holding it for a second.

"Yes?" Adora glanced down at the touch, knowing that it meant nothing coming from an intoxicated Catra.

"You look good, too." It wasn't so much the words that made Adora blush, but rather the way in which Catra said them. She let

go of her hand, putting her hands on her waist.

"How's life going?" Catra's question caught Adora off guard. She scrunched up her face in thought.

"Horrible without you in it," Adora gave her most charming smile.

"Obviouslyyyy," Catra extended the word in another breathy laugh.

"What about you? We haven't really spoken to each other," Adora set down her glass, looking at Catra expectantly.

"Oh you know, bitta this 'n' that," she leaned against the edge of the bar, tipping her head back in a stretch.

"I nearly cheated on you," she loosely revealed.

Whatever influence the champagne was slowly putting on Adora was abruptly put to a halt. She looked at Catra, completely affronted.

"What?"

"Yeah, I was being a sook, so Double Trouble, you know them? Yeah, well they dragged me out to a club about a week ago. I got pissed, because being drunk is wayyy better than being sad, right?"

She laughed, more to herself than to Adora.

"So then I see some blonde, and she reminds me of you."

"Because she was blonde?" Adora raised an eyebrow.

"Yupp. I start chatting to her, and then I'm this close," Catra squinted, pinching her fingers close together to demonstrate her words.

"To kissing her, but then I look at her, like properly, and she's not you."

"It took you a whole conversation to realize a random blonde wasn't me?" Adora was mildly offended, and very stung. Maybe they weren't actively in a relationship, but they were still committed to each other. Wasn't that the whole point of calling it a 'break'? Suddenly, she didn't want to be around Catra. In fact, she felt quite sick.

"Nooo, don't get sad," Catra reached out and touched her forearm. Adora didn't move.

"I didn't, I didn't cheat. And I really hated myself for considering it the morning after."

Adora just remained silent, a lump forming in her throat. She swallowed it down.

"You're the only one I like, dummy."

A note of sincerity found it's way into her drunk voice, but Adora didn't feel like getting emotional this early into the night. She drank the rest of the champagne in one gulp, retracting from Catra's touch.

"I'll see you later," she quickly left the girl's presence, trying to find her friends instead.

Galactivties

"What happened over there?" Bow was clearly concerned as Adora drifted towards him, clutching her purse like it was a lifeline.

"She drunkenly told me how she almost cheated on me last weekend. Saw another blonde and thought it was me," Adora whispered, careful to keep her voice hidden from prying ears. Bow nearly dropped his champagne glass, the concern deepening.

"Are you alright?"

Adora took a breath, glancing at Catra before looking back at him.

"Yeah, fine. Sorta." She gave a meek smile, giving herself a hug by wrapping her hands around her forearms.

"But she didn't do it, right?"

"No, but she was close to. I don't really know how to feel about that. She said she was sorry, but..." Adora gripped her arms tighter, shrugging. Bow pursed his lips, Glimmer wandering over to see what the fuss was about.

"What's going on guysss?" She looked at least three drinks in herself, but Bow's sentence sobered her up pretty quickly.

"Catra nearly cheated on Adora last weekend, that's what's going on." Unlike Bow, Glimmer actually did drop her champagne glass, the crystal cracking on the marble floor.

"Shit!" She sprang back, waiters and cleaners appearing from who knows where to tidy up the mess. Glimmer hurriedly thanked them, going bright red as half of the room turned to look at her. Bow quickly pulled both Adora and Glimmer into a nearby corner.

"No way did she cheat," Glimmer exclaimed.

"Did you not listen? Almost cheated, emphasis on almost," Bow repeated. Glimmer furrowed her eyebrows.

"That little shit, I'm gonna go chew her brains out right this motherfuc-"

"Easy, Glim," Adora rested her hands on her shoulders.

"You're not sober right now, and we're attending a heavily publicized function. I think yelling at Catra would only cause more problems for us. So let's not do that, 'kay?"

Adora was getting stressed out herself. On one hand, she wanted to throw something at Catra as much as Glimmer did, and on the other hand (the more logical hand), she knew she should just ignore it for the night. Not to mention a part of her also felt like going home and crying for an hour straight. Too many conflicting emotions, too many colliding ideas...now all she felt like doing was screaming.

"This is what's going to happen," Bow started off, looking at the two of them.

"We're going to smile and pretend like everything's perfect."

"That sounds hard, like really hard," Adora muttered.

"I know, but Glimmer and I will hardly leave your side, and we're keeping Catra far, far away from you tonight."

"Don't worry, I'll slap her tomorrow for you," Glimmer grumbled, folding her arms tightly across her chest.

"You're going to have fun, Adora. And it's just a few more hours, after that we can get out of here and go get ice cream."

Adora met the dark brown eyes, a weak smile forcing its way onto her face.

"Okay," she agreed. Bow returned the smile, guiding the two girls to their seats. Adora sat down in the plush gold brushed chair, staring at her place card to distract herself.

"Evening, Darling." She instantly smiled at the greeting, twisting in her seat to look up at Double Trouble. They looked quite extraordinary, wearing a dazzling teal jumpsuit with heels higher than Adora could fathom wearing, let alone walking in. They brandished a rose from some concealed pocket, their silver eyeliner glittering as the lights dimmed. Adora accepted the flower, examining the inky dark red of it.

"What's this for?"

"I think you know," DT purposely looked towards Catra, making Adora frown at the rose before her.

"Apology rose? From you?"

"For dragging the poor thing to a club when she was in a state of horrible despair," they raised the back of their hand to their forehead dramatically. Adora rolled her eyes at the gesture.

"You don't need to apologize for her choices."

"No, but she was vulnerable. Usually, I'd love this much drama in one night, but she's too sulky for me to properly enjoy it," they rolled their neck.

Adora didn't respond, nor look at the bright green eyes in front of her.

"Look, darling, I'm not making excuses for her. But it was a bad night, and I mistakenly thought drinks and a club would cheer her up," they sighed.

"I really should've just bought a bag of cat food and let her wallow in her misery."

"No, it's alright. You were trying to be a good friend," Adora said softly, smiling at the 'cat food' quip. DT's intentions were pure, she could see it in their sincere expression.

"I was. Don't be too hard on kitten."

They smiled gently before walking back to their own table, taking a seat beside Catra. Adora watched them for a moment, DT briefly meeting her eyes before looking towards the centre of the room, where a spotlight shone on Angella.

———————

"Bow!"

Lance and George tackled their son into a hug, the dads smiling at Adora and Glimmer over their son's shoulder. Once releasing Bow, they each pulled Adora and Glimmer for a hug.

"Bow showed me a photo of your She-Ra costume, Adora. I must say, I was quite impressed!" George marveled, smiling broadly. Adora laughed, recalling the uncomfortable dress and crown she'd worn.

"And how are you Glimmer?" Lance addressed the sparkly girl with a gentle smile that reminded Adora of Bow.

"Bow's been hiding you from us," George piped in, giving his son a look. Bow rubbed the back of his neck with a chuckle.

"Because the last time I visited, you two asked me when I'm proposing," Bow gave them both a targeted look, but Glimmer just blushed.

"Awe, proposing?" She looked up at Bow, who also blushed.

"It's never too early to get married," Lance winked at the couple, nudging Bow.

"I'd like to be a grandpa soon," George wrapped an arm around Lance.

"Woah, woah, calm down Dad. Number One, as much as I love Glimmer, we aren't getting married anytime soon. Number Two, slow downnn on the grandkids."

Bow offered an apologetic look at Glimmer, but she just smiled.

"You know, I wouldn't mind being an aunt," Adora waggled her eyebrows at the couple, causing both of them to go beet red.

"Adora," Glimmer gave her a scalding look. Adora just returned it with an innocuous shrug, but this sent George and Lance into fits of laughter.

"How long have you two been dating, anyway?"

"Six months tomorrow," Glimmer sang in a high pitched tone. Bow smiled, grabbing his girlfriend's hand. Adora so clearly remembered the day they got together, after playing 'Never Have I Ever' in a car, on the way to the snow.

"Ah, young love," Lance wiped away an imaginary tear.

"Dad, stop! You're embarrassing me," Bow said out of the corner of his mouth, furtively glancing around to make sure no one was watching.

Adora spotted Lonnie and politely excused herself to go have a quick chat. Glimmer squeezed her hand for reassurance before she left, and Adora gave both of her friends a smile to let them know she was alright.

"Heya, would you look who it is?"

Lonnie grinned, sporting an interesting look. Her jumpsuit was covered in obsidian, the black stone casting shadows as the light bounced off of it. What captured Adora's interest was the black bedazzled eyepatch Lonnie wore, with matching stone earrings.

"Unique outfit choice?"

"Mr Hawk gave me the idea for the eye patch," she pointed to it.

"I see," Adora nodded slowly in understanding. Mr Hawk was strangely obsessed with pirates.

"So? Having fun yet?"

Adora sighed, looking about as people milled near the centre of the room, a few dancing, some sitting and chatting at the dinner tables.

"Eh. Better than the beginning of the night, I guess."

"Mm," Lonnie nodded along.

"Angella's announcing Best Dressed soon, so that'll be fun," she offered.

"Doesn't Catra win Best Dressed every year?" Adora distantly remembered a conversation she'd had with Bow and Glimmer some time ago.

"Yeah, I think she really deserves it this year though. I've never seen her embrace her eye colours before."

Adora forbiddingly wondered if it was because she told Catra how much she loved her eyes. The thought was banished from her mind as quickly as it entered.

"Has Sea Hawk enrolled you for the course yet?"

Adora brightened at the reminder. She'd never gotten around to sending Lonnie that text.

"Yeah, actually! I'm starting twelfth of December. Two weeks after exams end."

"Great timing," Lonnie noted. Adora was rather glad that she had a break before starting it, and Glimmer mentioned that they were

going to one of her holiday houses during that period of time. Adora knew she would need the trip away. With everything that had happened lately, and exams starting in a few short weeks, she desperately needed to recharge.

Lonnie's gaze flicked up past Adora, causing Adora to look over her shoulder at...Catra. She stared at her for a few moments, detecting sobriety in her sombre expression.

"Hey, Cats," Lonnie looked down at the glass Catra was holding.

"That water, or vodka?"

She gave Catra a pointed look with a cheeky grin, causing the shorter girl to place the glass down on the smooth bench, sliding it past Adora to reach Lonnie. It moved across the marble surface like a hockey puck on ice.

"Take a sip and find out."

Lonnie took her up on the offer, drinking from the glass.

"Ah," Lonnie's reaction told Adora it was the healthier option, and that Catra was likely no longer as drunk as she was two hours ago.

"Bye, Lonnie!" Catra waved expectantly, but Lonnie didn't read the clue.

"I'm not going any-"

She paused, Catra folding her arms and looking harshly at her.

"Ohhhh, see ya Grayskull, good luck," she briefly touched Adora's shoulder as a form of farewell, whispering the last two words before disappearing in the sea of guests. Adora caught Glimmer's eyes watching her, and smiled to let her know she could handle it. She was curious as to what Catra would say anyway.

"I'm sorry," she started, something shining in her eyes.

"There's not much I can say to defend myself, I know. But I am truly sorry."

"Catra, were you ever planning on telling me about this?"

Adora asked the question carefully, watching for her reaction.

"No. I wasn't," she admitted. Adora nodded slowly, keeping her distance from her.

"If I wasn't shit-faced earlier tonight, I wouldn't have brought it up. But that's mostly because it never actually happened, and I genuinely thought that girl was you for a good three minutes." The sincerity in her tone pushed a chuckle out of Adora. She just imagined a drunk Catra babbling to some random stranger, thinking she was Adora, before the girl actually leaned forward and Catra realized it was not in fact Adora she was speaking to. But still, what she'd done wasn't easily excusable.

"You're really a hypocrite, you realize that, right? A few weeks ago, you got mad at me for hiding a few conversations I had with my own adoptive mother, but today I found out you nearly cheated on me and weren't intending on ever telling me about it?" She scoffed.

"That's not fair, Catra." The urge to take another step back was swallowed down.

Catra opened her mouth, ready to defend herself, but she paused. Adora followed her gaze to see a charging Angella walking towards them, eyes furrowed and a frown on her pink stained lips.

"Mom?" Catra held worry in her tone, exchanging a frightened glance with Adora. Adora had never seen Angella this unnerved before, even when she was about to lose her school to Horace Prime.

"Adora, come with me for a moment."

"Mom, what's wrong?"

Catra's worry piqued, but Angella only spared her a swift look.

"It's alright, Catra. I'm just borrowing Adora for a moment," Angella turned away from her daughter towards Adora.

"Can I come?" Adora shot her with a glare for the audacious request.

"No. You come, and then Glimmer and Bow are coming, and then half the press starts looking at you four suspiciously, and your names get dragged through the tabloids," she said in a low voice. Catra promptly shut up at the tone, meeting Adora's eyes again. Adora herself had no idea why Angella urgently needed to talk to her, but she obeyed, following the woman into the deserted foyer of the venue.

"Adora, it's Shadow Weaver."

No Cats Left Behind

Her heartbeat sped up as she tried to think what could've happened.

"She's been in a car accident. From the phone call, I imagine it's quite serious."

Adora felt her breaths getting shorter, the walls coming closer... was something ringing? She looked up at Angella, trying to think her words through, but the ringing was getting louder and the only thing she could see was Shadow Weaver dying on a hospital bed.

"When-Ho-When did it happen?" She struggled to form words, her mouth disobeying her mind. Angella placed her hand gently on her shoulder, acting as a source of stability for Adora. She focussed on the touch in an attempt to control her thoughts.

"I received a phone call ten minutes ago."

Ten min-Ten minutes.

"I need to leave."

"I called one of my cars as soon as it happened. They can take you to my jet, fly you out so you're home within three hours," Adora nodded, relief flooding her. Instinctively, without thinking, she hugged Angella, holding onto the woman tight. Angella returned the hug, wrapping her arms around Adora and stroking her hair slowly.

"Shhh, it's going to be okay. She's going to be okay," she reassured her. Adora didn't let go quickly, only held on tighter, and Angella let her.

The distressed girl finally leaned back after what felt like eternity, wiping tears she didn't realized had formed and sniffing slightly.

"Thank you, sorry I-"

"Don't apologize, Adora. You've done nothing wrong," Angella gave her a warm smile, causing a fresh set of tears to roll down her cheeks, probably smearing the makeup Glimmer spent time putting on her.

"Do you want company?"

Adora thought about it, thoughts instantly jumping to Bow and Glimmer. But they had never met Shadow Weaver, and they didn't see her how Adora did. No one really did. They only despised her, and Adora didn't want her adoptive mother to be judged right now.

"No, I'll be okay on my own. Thank you, Angella, really."

"Tell me how everything goes, okay?"

She wiped Adora's tears, pulling her in for a final hug.

"I will," Adora replied. She started walking towards the entrance when Angella called out again.

"Adora! Don't use that door. Swarming with photographers, go through this one instead. The car should be just around the block."

Angella led her down a set of dark stairs, a green exit sign hung above a stage door. She pressed a button, pushing it open for her.

"Thanks, I completely forgot about that," she breathed, holding the door open herself and taking a step outside onto the concrete.

"Take care," Adora gave her one last thankful smile, the door closing behind Angella. She took a breath, grateful she was surrounded by oxygen instead of being in that stuffy overcrowded room. She concentrated on putting one foot in front of the other, rounding the end of the building when-

"Adora!" The loud hiss stopped her right in her tracks. Adora walked backwards, trying to find the body connected to the voice. Instead, she was met with a pair of characteristic glowing eyes.

One gold, and the other an electric blue, of course. She rolled her eyes.

"Now's not the time, Catra, I've gotta go." That was all the explanation she offered before decisively walking away. She didn't manage to get very far, for a hand yanked her arm back, dragging Adora into the dark.

"Catra?" Adora was incredulous at the nerve.

"What happened to Weaver?"

"Car accident," Adora replied. There was no point trying to hide it.

"Fuck, is it bad?"

"I think so. Angella's flying me out in a jet, she wouldn't do that for nothing."

Catra swallowed, Adora noticing it despite the darkness.

"Speaking of which, bye," she quickly dashed off. But again, she didn't get very far. This time, Catra did a quick walk after her, matching her pace as they were both approaching a concealed car in the dark.

"What are you doing?" Adora tried to walk faster, but Catra was willing to jog in the stilettos to keep up with her.

"Coming with you."

Adora laughed, twirling around and stopping Catra in her tracks.

"No you're not. Did I invite you? No? I didn't think so." Catra didn't look the slightest hurt by her words, a defiant look crossing her features.

"You are not going alone."

"Yes I am." Adora was adamant.

"No you're not."

Adora opened her mouth, ready to have a full out argument, but Catra cut her off.

"I don't care how much you fight me on this, Blondie, I don't care how much you hate me for it, but I am coming with you and there is nothing you can do about it."

Fuck, there it was again. The tone. Adora knew it was futile to argue with her now.

"Fine, you can come, but you're not visiting her, unless I ask you to. You can go rent out a room in some swanky hotel if you're so hellbent on getting on that plane with me. And I'm not talking to you, I'm still mad."

Adora was fairly sure this would cause Catra to back off. It unfortunately didn't.

"Fine by me."

Of course Catra wouldn't care. If she wanted to do something, she was doing it. Adora groaned in exasperation at the stubborn girl, ignoring her and climbing into the car. Catra was smug as she followed her in.

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Adora shook her leg up and down, eyes darting all over the place in an effort to distract herself. In an enclosed box, trapped in the sky, no form of escape...she felt her heartbeat accelerate, and her palms get sweaty. The seatbelt was suddenly choking her, the leather rope tightening until she could hardly-

"Adora?"

The voice snapped her out of her panicked thoughts, Adora's dazed blue eyes meeting Catra's. She'd almost forgotten the girl was sitting next to her. Fifty spare seats in this luxury private aircraft, and Catra chose the one right next to her. Typical.

"I'm fine, no talking, remember?" She snapped. She wasn't fine, of course. Catra detected the lie instantly, reaching over and unbuckling her seatbelt for her.

"Better?"

Adora looked down in shock, before looking at Catra again. She glared, even though she was inwardly thankful. Some of the weight had been lifted off her chest with that simple movement.

"I thought you had to keep it on?" She murmured, averting her eyes.

Catra shrugged, undoing her own and stretching upwards.

"Different rules on a private jet."

Adora was still feeling antsy, but at least she was no longer restricted. She tried looking out the window, but that didn't help. Thoughts of Shadow Weaver penetrated any semblance of peace she'd had.

She suddenly turned to an unsuspecting Catra, who was simply minding her own business.

"Distract me."

"What? You just said you didn't want to talk?" Catra arched an eyebrow at the request, but Adora didn't care. She was going mad with the overwhelming silence.

"Forget it, just distract me. But don't say anything about the...what happened earlier." A screaming match was the last thing she needed right now.

She drummed her fingers against her shaking legs, drawing Catra's attention to the movement.

"Okay, uhm, you won Best Dressed tonight."

Adora leaned back, staring at her in pure shock.

"I said distract me, not lie to me."

"Not lying. Glimmer texted me when we were driving. I didn't tell you back then because you were still refusing to talk to me," she sounded slightly bitter in the second half of the sentence, but Adora still couldn't believe her ears.

"Me? Best Dressed?"

"Adora, have you looked in a mirror tonight? You quite literally look godly," Catra scanned her. Now her dress was in a bit of a mess, but it did look quite nice at the start of the evening. She couldn't deny that.

"But you, you look-I mean," Adora was at a loss for coherent sentences, a million different words running through her mind as she looked Catra up and down.

"Are you really not wearing any underwear?"

She mentally slapped herself. She could've hundreds of normal things, but that's what her mind ran too first? Catra looked a little stunned (albeit, amused), cheeks going red.

"Maybe," she groaned, hanging her head in her hands.

"I can't believe I said that to you," she laughed, rubbing her eyes. Both of their makeup looks were completely destroyed, along with their hairstyles. Adora chuckled at an embarrassed Catra. It was rare to see her like that.

"So confidently too," she mused. Catra punched her arm, still keeping one hand covering her face.

"Fuck offf," Adora just laughed harder at Catra's groan.

"No, but seriously, you looked amazing tonight. I honestly thought you were going to win Best Dressed," Adora admitted.

"Eh, I'm sick of collecting that stupid trophy. Got about four of 'em now, time to win something new," she smirked.

"DT will be out for your blood though. They hated me winning every year," Catra warned her.

"I'll tell Glimmer to keep a tight grip on my trophy then," Adora replied. Catra laughed lightly, brushing Adora's arm briefly that caused the both of them to look down for a moment. Something sparked between them, and she tried to ignore it. Catra had lied to her, and Weaver was on her deathbed. She tucked the forbidden question back into the folds of her mind, buckling up her seatbelt again as the pilot announced their arrival.

Visits To Home

"Anddd booked," Catra finished typing something on her phone, finally looking up at Adora.

"Booked what?" She was completely lost, having zoned out during the entire drive.

"The hotel room. Lorenz will drop you to Weaver's place, take me to the hospital, and then pick you up to take you to the hospital. Right, Lorenz?"

Lorenz, their driver, simply gave the girls a thumbs up in the rearview mirror, but Adora's mind was spinning with details and thoughts.

"Wait, Catra. Why am I stopping by the apartment? Lorenz, take me to the hospital now, please," she corrected.

"Adora, look at yourself. You need to at least change out of the dress and shoes."

Catra did have a point, her legs were aching and her feet were practically numb. Not to mention she was freezing in the thin layer of fabric.

"Fine. Why do you have to always be right?"

Catra radiated smugness as she leaned back in the leather seat, Lorenz pulling up right outside Adora's old apartment. The old cracked bricks, climbing their way up to the twentieth floor, where she had spent most of her life. She swallowed, staring at the building for a few long moments. It was everything and nothing altogether... she could hardly recall calling this place home.

"You okay?"

Catra was gentle, but Adora didn't turn to look at her, eyes refusing to leave the apartment block.

"Yeah, I'm good. Weaver always left a key in the plant," she murmured. Opening the car door while giving a final thanks to Lorenz and wishing Catra goodnight, Adora stepped outside. The air assaulted her lungs, noise filling her ears and the smell of smoke greeting her nose. She smiled despite it all, she hadn't had that experience in almost a year since living in Brightmoon.

She opened the door, waiting a few moments for the old, banged up elevator to arrive. Stepping inside, she pressed the button with her knuckle, unable to help wrinkling her nose at the funky smell. She couldn't remember it being quite this decrepit, but it had been some time since she'd visited. Thankfully, she didn't come across any of her neighbors. She didn't want to stop and have a conversation, or get funny looks for wearing a gown in the middle of the night with smudged eyeliner and splotchy foundation. The faded blue carpet creaked as her pointed heels dug into it, Adora reaching into the potted artificial plant to grasp the old key.

"Aha!"

She gasped to herself as her fingers met the metal, pulling the item out and sticking it into the door, forcing her way in.

Just looking at the place nearly brought tears to her eyes. The dining table she sat at for years, crying over algebra and trigonometry. The couch where she'd curl up with a book, the blanket she hid in when Weaver would stumble through the door, late into the night....It was preferable to ignore those particular memories.

The kitchen where she'd often make their meals, or where Weaver would offer her ice cream on a sporadic Friday night after completing her homework and chores. She climbed up the spiraling staircase, the wood squeaking as she walked. Her eyes flitted to her closed bedroom door, and she approached it, when-

She noticed a light, out of the corner of her eye. Adora paused, her handle on the doorknob. It was probably Shadow Weaver

accidentally leaving the light switch on, hurriedly jumping into her car to run errands and...

Adora sniffled, tucking her hair behind her ears. Perhaps that woman was awful to her, perhaps she did hate her...but on some level, some intrinsic part of her felt affection for Shadow Weaver, and gratitude for everything she'd given her. The thought of her dying or being in insufferable pain...Adora couldn't think of it happily. She approached the light, ready to flick it off and resume her reminiscing.

But the room wasn't absent...No, there was a figure, sitting in the bed. Adora noticed the shadow before the body, and her breath hitched. Unable to identify the person, she carefully slipped out of her heels, glad the stiletto looked sharp enough to act as a knife. She held her breath, wondering how the intruder wasn't frightened the minute they heard her unlock the door and walk up the stairs.

"Adora?"

Because it wasn't an intruder.

In an utterly perplexed state, Adora dropped her 'weapons,' knocking the door wide open to reveal...

A perfectly healthy, comfortable, Shadow Weaver, sipping from a mug in bed. Adora tried not to wince at seeing her without her veil covering half her face.

"Shadow Weaver? I thought the accident was serious?"

Weaver stared at her for a second, before bursting into a fit of laughter. Adora's confusion grew, she didn't get the joke.

"Oh, Adora, you didn't actually believe that, did you?"

Adora stumbled backwards, feeling the beginnings of a headache break its way through. Shadow Weaver climbed out of the bed,

cozy in a fluffy white robe, and approached Adora. She brought a finger under her chin, lifting the girl's head.

"Now, now, child, this just proves your immaturity. Can you see now why you are unable to make decisions for yourself?"

"What are you talking about?" She tried to rip her face out of Weaver's grip, but the boney hands tightened.

"One false phone call and you drop your bags, running to come see me. Gullible, foolish girl."

"Shadow Weaver. What's going on?"

Adora continued to struggle, hands gripping the entrance of the doorway so hard her knuckled whitened.

"I lied. I lied, and you believed it," she snarled. Adora felt herself shaking, another tear slipping out.

"Oh, and she's crying! How sweet, you shed tears for me," Shadow Weaver laughed again. It was a sound derived from cruelty and condescension.

"You were never in a car accident?"

"I hardly leave this apartment, Adora. You know that."

"But the call...Angella said it came from the hospital," Adora finally managed to break free out of her grasp, and took a few steps back, away from her.

"Creating a false phone call from the hospital took me less than two minutes." Her steps enclosed around Adora.

"Why?" she gasped, approaching the staircase. She wanted to get out of here, desperately.

"To test you. You want to decide your own future, fine. But look what happened tonight. Your judgement failed you, you were

weak."

"I was scared, I thought you had died!"

"Weak. I know you Adora, inside and out. I've calculated your every strength, and every weakness." Shadow Weaver's enunciation was precise, making the hairs on Adora's arm raise. She flinched, despising that word. Weak.

"You think you know everything, you think you're better than me. Well you're wrong, Adora. You are a child," her voice escalated, making Adora flinch.

But underneath the fear, breaking through the terror, was her anger. This woman, the woman she had spent years trusting, believing, had so heartlessly manipulated her. For what? To prove some sick point? All she did tonight was prove that she didn't care for Adora as a human, she thought of her as an asset, a tool to build her own strength. Shadow Weaver wasn't any better than Horace Prime himself. Adora hardened her fright into chips of icy rage, ready to hurl them at Weaver with all her force. She shook, meeting the old woman's faded green eyes.

"You miscalculated."

"I know what's best for you, Adora. One day, when you are ruling a country, as President Gray, you will thank me."

Adora gave her a cold look, narrowing her eyes. How many times did she need to tell this woman to get the idea into her thick skull?

"We're past that. Try again."

Weaver raised an arm, but suddenly, Adora was stronger, faster. She dodged the strike, shoving the frail old lady backwards. Not hard, but enough to defend herself. She don't know why she never protected herself earlier.

"I am not weak. My love is a strength, too bad it was wasted on someone like you," she spat. Shadow Weaver looked outraged, but she didn't move, nor say anything. Adora felt her fury fuel her words, looking the woman dead in the eyes.

"I am not afraid of you anymore, and I am not, nor will I ever be, in your control. You are nothing to me now, just a fucked up old lady." She thought of her next words, breathing them carefully so Shadow Weaver got the message, loud and clear.

"And I want nothing to do with you."

Unknowingly, Shadow Weaver had just pushed Adora over the edge. The word 'emancipation' was circling her mind now, and she found herself moving towards it, trying to grasp it. Mara was right, this woman was never good for her, and she never really loved her. Adora gave her a final glare, wrapping the straps of her heels around her wrist as she unlocked the front door. Shadow Weaver didn't dare to attempt to stop her, watching with beady eyes as Adora left the apartment without a second glance, for the final time.

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The Bad And Ugly

"Adora?"

The girl involuntarily shivered at the voice over the phone, hiding in a decrepit alleyway, still wearing the elaborate outfit. She'd spent the last hour or so crying, letting the tears flow until she was fairly sure there were none more to come. Calling Catra should've honestly been the first thing she'd done, but she didn't feel like crying in front of someone about this.

"Hi," she rasped. The cold had frosted her voice. Catra's sleepy tone magically vanished, tone becoming more urgent.

"Are you okay? It's past twelve," she was alarmed.

"No...I'll tell you everything later, could you just...pick me up?"

Her words were choked at the increasing concern in Catra's tone.

"I'm coming. Where are you?"

"I'll send my location," was all Adora offered because if she was being completely honest, she had no fucking idea where she was. She'd just ran, before walking, her feet cut and bleeding from being barefoot on the dingy streets.

The wind howled at her, pushing her hair back and attacking her skin. The fresh air had been a relief when she'd first felt it, but now it was drowning her. Her shivering intensified, and she hastily ripped the bottom half of her dress to wrap around herself in a makeshift dodgy shawl. A large part of herself felt guilty for ruining such a beautiful piece, but she couldn't help it, her skin was raw and battered from the weather. Several people had passed by her, some inching away like she was a stray animal, others leering closer like she was prey. She gripped the sharpened wooden slate in her hand, a measly weapon. But it acted as a deterrent, and she guessed that was good enough.

A car pulled up, and Adora nearly cried out in relief when Catra stepped out, wearing a long, oversized puffer and tracks made of faux fur. The hood was pulled on, but it flew off the minute she spotted Adora, for Catra had sprinted to meet her.

"Fuck, what happened?"

Adora couldn't stop the shivering, her teeth chattering against each other as Catra wrapped her arms around her. She held on tight, soaking the warmth and mint and musk the coat had to offer.

"Sh-Shad-ow W-w," she gave up, just clinging to Catra. The girl didn't push further, helping Adora reach the car. They piled into the backseat, the warmth flooding and soothing her skin. Despite it, the shivering persisted, even growing in strength.

"Lorenz, the hotel, please," Adora faintly heard Catra address the front seat, before the girl slid over next to Adora.

"You're colder than ice," she whispered, more to herself than Adora. She took her coat off, along with the woollen jumper she wore, wrapping both coats around Adora. Her arms followed, providing as much body heat as she could. The shivering slowly lessened, and was nearly gone by the time they arrived at the hotel. Lorenz gave Adora a concerned smile as they left the car, and Adora tried to return it.

She got a number of stares from both the hotel staff and the fancy guests lounging in the lobby, but Adora didn't have a single care to think too hard about it. Catra glared back at any person looking at them, tightly holding Adora's hand as they stepped into an elevator. The shivering came to a halt, but Adora felt like crying again at the look Catra was giving her. They walked into the room, Catra soundlessly switching the lights on in the bathroom and turning on the shower.

The silence stretched, but it was anything but awkward. It was comforting, Adora found. Catra slowly, but carefully, helped Adora

undress, before letting the girl step into the steaming shower and wash herself clean. Adora couldn't bring herself to speak, letting the water run over her face, scalding her icy skin, letting her forget about everything that had happened. Except she couldn't. Shadow Weaver's words broke through the peace of the bathroom, and she quickly turned the shower off, hair dripping. Catra had placed a spare set of clothes on the ledge for her, and Adora smiled at the considerate gesture. She dressed, body still aching and sore, before stepping out of the bathroom.

"Come here," Catra's tone and gaze was soft, warm. Adora obeyed, sitting cautiously on the bed. Catra held up alcohol swabs, and Adora winced as she wiped her cuts clean. She put a soothing cream over the wounds, before covering them with bandaids.

"Thank you," Adora breathed. Their eyes met.

"Always."

The word was enough to push Adora off the edge, the tears running without hesitation. She could barely hold them back in the shower, but now they forbiddingly spilled down her cheeks. Catra watched her for a split second before shifting back on the bed, her back meeting the headboard of the bed. She tucked herself under the covers, patting the spot next to her. Adora shifted closer, also putting her body under the duvet, and wrapped an arm around Catra's torso. Her head landed on her shoulder, and Catra leaned into the touch, her head resting atop Adora's as her fingers brushed her wet hair. She didn't seem to mind when Adora's tears seeped through her shirt, or when her arms tightened around her stomach. She didn't complain or make a single noise of discomfort.

And the pair lay there, wrapped around each other in silence, until they succumbed to sleep.

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Adora awoke the next morning with crusted eyes and muscles sore. She rubbed her eyes open, blinking as cracks of light peeked past the drawn curtains. She'd woken before Catra, both of them frozen in the same position they'd gone to sleep in, if anything they were more entwined with one another; Adora's leg was hooked through with Catra's. She didn't move, unwilling to disturb the peace she'd had asleep. Catra seemed to sense her wakefulness though, for her own eyes blinked open, and she shifted slightly, looking down at Adora who peered up at her.

"Morning," she whispered.

"Hi," she returned. Catra waited, and Adora hugged her closer, indicating that she wanted them to stay like this, at least for a little bit. Catra easily obliged, her eyes fluttering closed.

"You don't need to talk, I'm not asking you to. But are you okay?"

Catra continued to stroke her hair, twisting and weaving the strands. Adora felt the urge to give her an explanation.

"I'm better," to say she was 'ok' felt like a lie. And she didn't want to lie anymore. If Catra wanted to see the bad and ugly, she'd show her the bad and ugly.

"She wasn't in a car accident," she started out. Catra momentarily paused in playing with her hair in surprise, but quickly resumed.

"Weaver had lied. She'd staged a phone call to test me, see if I'd drop everything and come running home. Like an idiot, I did."

"You're the furthest thing from an idiot," Catra's voice was fierce. The soft tone had been dropped. Adora didn't reply, but inwardly smiled.

"You're a dummy, but..." she murmured, the rest of her sentence cutting off. Adora met her gaze inquisitively.

"I'm your dummy." She whispered slowly, unable to resist the blush that spread from the tips of her toes to her cheeks, and

neither could Catra. Choosing to glide past the moment, Adora continued.

"When I 'failed' her little test, she said it proved that I was a child. Said that I should trust her judgment for what's best for me because I didn't realize she was lying."

Catra didn't say anything at that, and Adora continued.

"She tried to hit me, I shoved her. And then I left, I told her I want nothing to do with her."

"Did you mean it?" Was all Catra asked.

Adora didn't hesitate for a second. "Yes. Every word. She doesn't love me, not like how a real parent loves their child. She just used me."

Adora suddenly understood the hatred Catra had always felt for her, that own hatred polluting whatever 'love' she once had for her adoptive mother.

"Mara suggested emancipation. I think I'm going to take her up on the offer."

"Are you sure? That's a big step," Catra was cautious, and Adora appreciated it, but she was sure.

"I don't want her to be my legal guardian. I don't want her to show up in my life, unannounced, claiming that she raised me and that she loves me. I'm done with being fucked with," Adora's tone was firm.

"Then I support you," Catra replied simply. Adora finally unwrapped her arms from around her, lifting her body up to face her.

"Thank you, really. I'm glad you came."

"I'm glad I came too," Catra gave her a weak smile. Adora let out an unsteady breath that turned into a small laugh, thinking about what would've happened if she was by herself.

"Can we go home?"

"Of course."

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Sure she got a few stares as she walked through the school, but she didn't mind it when Catra's hand slipped into her's seamlessly as a silent act of support. She focussed on that, rather than the looks people were giving her.

"Hey, girl, you alright?"

Lonnie's eyebrows furrowed as they passed her in the corridor, her arm lightly touching Adora's shoulder.

"Shadow Weaver stuff. I'm doing okay, though," she didn't mind questions, as long as they were genuine and not a pry for gossip. Lonnie nodded, continuing to walk forward. It wasn't rude that she didn't stop and pause for conversation, Adora was actually thankful for it.

"Are 'Kitten and Puff' back on the dating scene?" DT's eyes flashed as they walked behind them, catching up. Adora spotted Catra's roll of the eyes in her sideview, but wasn't offended or hurt by DT's insinuation.

"Back off Lizard," she turned around to look at them, but didn't let go of Adora's hand (nor did she answer the question).

"Ooo, ouch. Claws are out, I see," they mused, piranha smile widening.

"I mean it Double Trouble-"

"And the full name drop, isn't this delicious?"

Catra growled lowly, Adora deciding to intercept before her anger peaked.

"Nothing interesting is going on, DT, you can go bother someone else."

She quite frankly didn't mind their company, but she sensed Catra's annoyance and decided to respect that.

"Mmm, I'll be the judge of that. How's your trophy feeling?"

They really did not take a hint. Adora saw an opportunity to piss them off, using it to an advantage.

"Oh, amazing. You know, it being my first year and all, I didn't imagine how easy it'd be to win Best Dressed. Here I am, a complete newbie, and I just beat everyone there."

She'd struck a nerve, it was obvious in their face.

"Drama's calling my name. I'll see you two losers later," DT left as quickly as they arrived, and Adora winked at Catra.

"So easy to hit their weak spot."

Catra smirked back, her hand squeezing Adora's as they reached her dorm.

"Adora!"

Glimmer instantly jumped on her, startling Adora who rocked back slightly. Soft arms tightened around her neck as Glimmer lingered, Adora quickly returning her friend's hug. When Glimmer finally let go, Bow quickly assumed her place, though his hug was more gentle.

"What happened?"

Both pair of eyes looked at her's, and Adora sighed, sitting on the couch to go through the whole story.

No More Lies

"Wow," Bow said when she finished, leaning back into the sofa. Adora nodded, taking a deep breath.

"That's it, that's why I left."

Catra stayed silent, perched on the armrest next to Adora, hand casually spread past her shoulders as she stayed near. Adora appreciated the unspoken closeness, the familiarity of Catra around her. It was comforting when she felt like her entire world had been upended.

"I mean, you were pretty badass," Glimmer shrugged with a smile. Adora looked at her, surprised, before eliciting a small laugh. That was one way to see it.

"I kinda was, wasn't I?"

"More than badass," Catra murmured from beside her. Her words were low, but Adora easily caught them, flicking her head to look at her.

"What does that mean?"

Catra's cheeks reddened, making Adora all the more curious. She nudged her hip, silently pressuring Catra to elaborate.

"I'll leave it up to interpretation," Catra dodged her eyes.

"No you won't, out with it," Adora continued prodding. Catra finally sighed, rolling her eyes back and looking down at Adora.

"It was hot, Blondie."

Now it was Adora's turn to blush and avert her eyes. She looked at Bow and Glimmer, but the pair were staring at their interaction with saucepans for eyes.

"Wait, did you two get back-"

"No," Adora quickly cut in. Catra gave her an odd look, and Adora just looked at her with a slight shake of her head. They'd discuss it later, alone.

"C'mon guys, I need a distraction."

She waved her arms about, asking for her friends to be annoying just this one time.

"Poker?"

"Not in the mood to lie," Adora threw Catra a look at that.

"Never Have I-"

Catra yawned, cutting in. "Boring."

Glimmer rolled her eyes at her suggestion being shot down.

"Truth Dare Drink?" Bow offered again.

"If we had access to alcohol right now, yes. But we don't," Glimmer rebutted.

"....Movie?"

Adora's eyes lit up as she looked at Catra.

"Genius!"

Her eyes sparkled at Adora's enthusiasm, the blonde getting up to draw the curtains and flick off the lights. They still had three hours before the call for dinner, plenty of time to watch something.

"Okay, let's flip a coin to avoid fights."

Every time they had tried to watch a movie together in peace, they spent two hours deciding which movie to pick. Glimmer loved

action, Bow was a sucker for rom-coms as well as Disney, and Catra was obsessed with Mystery and Horror. Adora's preferences fluctuated, unlike the other three, but she always was a fan of adventure.

"No, Adora's choosing," Catra looked over to her.

"Mmmm, horror."

She required the ultimate distraction; fear. Something that would grip her nerves and crawl through her mind, so she didn't think about Shadow Weaver or that other nonsense. Catra gave Glimmer a sinister smile, who groaned. Bow didn't look too chuffed with her decision either, grabbing the blanket and spreading it between himself and Glimmer. Adora unravelled the lavender one nestled next to her, offering half of it to Catra to share. Both girls snuggled under the cozy sheet, Adora turning the TV on and flicking through various options.

"The Shining?"

Adora looked to her friends for approval.

"Up to you," Catra prompted. Adora nodded, pressing down on the button to play the film.

Her judgment was correct, the movie did an impeccable job of distracting her. Every time thoughts of reality weaved its way into her thoughts, a jump-scare managed to yank the unwanted memories away. Adora was glad for it, and even more grateful for the perfectly relaxed body next to her.

Seriously, Catra was completely unfazed by the movie, her breath steady and showing barely any reaction besides a slight gasp at certain moments. Still, her eyes remain fixated on the illuminated screen, the girl hushing her sister every time Glimmer yelped and clutched onto Bow.

Adora eventually found herself looking at Catra more than the movie itself, the time stretching from minutes to hours.

"Are you sure you've never seen this before?" Adora whispered, accidentally brushing against Catra's leg as she did so. She didn't lean back after saying the words, waiting.

"Not once."

Catra's gaze slid past Adora, to Bow and Glimmer. Despite being frightened for about half of it, the couple were peacefully dozing, Glimmer's head resting on Bow's chest. Adora smiled briefly at the sight, before returning her attention to Catra.

"You're insane."

She turned her head, jumping slightly as the gruesome scene presented itself in front of her. What she didn't realize until it was too late, was that she was practically sitting on Catra, their noses inches apart. Her breath instantly hitched, but she didn't dare move.

"Let's talk." Adora finally glanced down at her, Catra nodding slowly as Adora carefully slid off her lap.

"I'm sorry. For lying, almost cheating, all of it."

Adora watched her eyes soften, the sincerity shining true and clear in her expression. She could see the guilt that was eating away at Catra, and if she was being honest, she wasn't the slightest mad at her anymore. Too much had shifted in twenty-four hours.

"No more lies?" She breathed in the space between them, the sound of screaming from the television distracting neither of the girls.

"No more lies," Catra agreed. She waited for a second, thinking.

"What are we?" The question was barely above a whisper, Catra glanced at their positions.

"I don't know...But I'm not ready. It's too fresh, too... raw."

She nodded in understanding. Adora wanted to be in a relationship with her, but after the events of last night, it was unfair to both of them to rush into it.

"When you're ready, I'll be here."

Catra smiled, her words telling Adora that she'd moved on from the wounds of their argument a month prior. Adora slipped her hand into hers, under the blanket, and smiled to herself.

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Days blurred into weeks, and before Adora knew what was happening, she was sitting her final exams for the year.

"AHHHH I'm not ready, I'm not ready, I'm not ready," she paced up and down, annoying the shit out of her friends.

"Adora, I haven't seen you leave your desk for the past three weeks, you'll be fine," Glimmer shook her vigorously, trying to shake some sense into the girl.

"But what if I'm not? I mean, sure I've spent time at my desk, but half the time I'm thinking about what Hope said and-"

"The emancipation is basically complete, that's a good thing, Adora," Glimmer reminded her. Adora chewed her nails, flopping on the bed.

"I know, I know, but staying with Mara and Hope for the holidays? Isn't that...I dunno, weird?"

"Why's it weird?" Bow sat down next to her, as Adora stared at the roof.

"She's my doctor. Sure, we text once a week, but we met because I was her patient. And Hope," Adora scoffed.

"I'm still not entirely sure if I like her."

"Me neither," Catra mumbled, closing her laptop on the floor

"Okay, but you like Mara. And I don't think Mara would marry a bad person. She's probably just stand-offish," Bow suggested with a shrug.

"Maybe," Adora elongated the word. She was spending two weeks with Glimmer, Bow and Catra at Angella's holiday house, but after that...she was living with Hope and Mara. They weren't adopting her or anything, of course, but still...a whole six weeks.

"At least they live only twenty minutes from us," Catra offered.

"I'll come see you basically everyday."

Adora smiled at the girl with a hint of a blush. They still weren't dating, Adora had wanted everything to be finalized with Shadow Weaver before she thought about that, but they were close.

"Okay, that makes it a bit better, I guess," Adora replied, a little bit giddy with the thought of Catra specially coming to visit her. Catra smirked, as if reading Adora's thoughts.

"Can you two be official again already? It's killing me," Glimmer whined, pulling on Adora's arm like a child.

"Settle down, won't you?" Neither Catra or Adora actually responded to Glimmer's plea.

"Come on, the exam starts in thirty minutes, we need to get to the hall," Bow checked his watch, reminding the group.

"Oh, shit," Adora's panic returned, only momentarily relieved for a few minutes. She grabbed her dictionary and writing materials, throwing another quick smile at Catra as they left the dorm.

———————

Paradise.

"I dibs top bunk!"

Adora gave Bow a look as Glimmer squealed, sprinting through the forest of flowers and leaves to reach the large stone cottage in the middle of the field. This place was breathtaking, but Adora was glad in that moment she didn't have hay fever. The same couldn't be said for Catra, who stood grumpily, hands crossed over her chest with red eyes and an itchy nose. Adora chuckled at the sight, Bow scruffing her hair lightly before running after his girlfriend.

"Why is it called Paradise?" She grumbled under her breath, giving Adora a glare as they waded through the mass of flora.

"Because it's pretty!"

Adora twirled, laughing and spinning as her head spun with the motion. She wobbled, nearly tripping over herself in a flower filled daze.

"Yeah, pretty if you don't have allergies," Catra rolled her eyes, passing by her to approach the house. Angella and Micah had left the group a message informing them that they were stuck in a few emergency meetings and would arrive two days late. The round wooden door was thrown wide open, Bow and Glimmer's voices heard despite being three floors above them.

"Race you to the top?" Adora challenged. Catra looked sideways at her, a glint in her eye, all allergies apparently forgotten.

"You're on, Princess."

The two girls dashed towards the large wooden staircase, pushing and shoving to beat each other to the top like two animals. They ended up sprawled on top of one another, in a fit of laughter and completely out of breath. Bow and Glimmer came out of the

bedroom to inspect the commotion, the couple exchanging a look and smirking at the sight.

"I technically won," Adora argued, climbing off Catra and walking towards Bow and Glimmer.

"Yeah, by cheating," Catra huffed, following after her. There were more than enough bedrooms for the four friends to have one each, but where was the fun in that? Instead, the group opted for the largest bedroom, filled with two bunkbeds on opposite ends of the room. Bow and Glimmer had clearly taken the one closest to the door, with left the bunk by the window free for Catra and Adora.

"Which of us takes top?"

Adora asked the innocent question, perplexed when Catra gave her a teasing smile at it.

"I'll take top," she grabbed her bag, swinging it on the top bunk with ease before climbing up.

Adora started unpacking her items, placing her hands on her hips as she inspected the large room. Catra's sudden gasp escaped her lips, provoking Adora to turn around. A small, furry grey cat tentatively walked into the room.

"Melog! How did you get here?"

Catra gave Melog a few pets, looking around slightly confused.

"Surprise!"

Micah jumped in front of the door, smiling with jazz hands. Catra instantly gave him a hug, followed by Glimmer.

"Dad!"

Angella's wavy pastel hair peaked past the door frame, the woman's smile glowing and radiant as always.

"Mom!"

Catra and Glimmer both gave Angella a hug, before looking to their parents in confusion.

"But you said you were coming late?"

"We tricked you," Micah gave them both a smile and wink, seeming quite proud of his efforts. Angella warmly rubbed his shoulder, resting her hand there comfortably.

"Hello Bow, Adora," she met both pair of eyes past her daughters', Bow and Adora returning the favor.

"Alright, kiddos, who wants to go riding?"

Adora looked at Bow with a startled expression.

"Riding? As in...horses?"

Glimmer giggled, grabbing her hand and dragging her down the stairs.

"Yes, horses!"

She led them through a gate, dropping Adora's hand as she approached a stable. Adora had never seen a horse before, but her eyes practically glowed when she first laid eyes on the field filled with them.

"Adora, meet Twinkletoes."

"Woahhh," Adora was mesmerized by the grand creatures. Catra came up next her, stroking Melog, who was comfortably cradled in her arms. Catra gave her pet a rewarding nuzzle, before setting Melog down, away from the field of horses. Adora tugged on her arm, frozen in place.

"Horses," she couldn't take her eyes off the large, brilliant creatures, continuing to tug Catra's arm. Bow came up next to

Glimmer, reaching his hand out to Twinkletoes, who readily came closer.

A dark beauty approached Catra and Adora, instantly gravitating towards the brunette, who lovingly stroked it.

"Her name's Majesty. Majesty," she talked to the horse, "Adora," and gestured to Adora, who cautiously held out an arm. Majesty leaned into her, making a noise akin to approval before nuzzling Adora, who giggled at the affectionate touch.

"Hello there, Majesty," Catra was smiling at them. Adora continued to stroke Majesty's shiny black coat, when she felt a nudge behind her.

She turned around, a gorgeous horse with a light brown coat and dark locks. The horse inspected her, snorting and continuing to friendly nudge Adora. She laughed, already feeling bonded to the animal.

"What's this one's name?"

Angella came around to them, fitting Majesty with riding equipment and handing a helmet to both Adora and Catra.

"He doesn't have one. Would you like the honor? He seems to like you."

Angella fitted the unnamed horse with riding gear, gesturing to Adora, who tapped her chin in thought. Her face lit up.

"Horsey!"

Angella gave her a bit of an odd look, and Catra burst into laughter, but Adora was content with the name, and so was Horsey, who neighed in affirmation.

"Only you would name a horse, Horsey."

"You're named Catra, so don't talk." Adora was only teasing, and Catra knew.

"And you're Adora, so I guess it's a match made in heaven. Adora and Horsey," Catra mused. She demonstrated to Adora how to settle into the straddle, swiftly hooking her boot into the stirrup and swinging the other over. Adora carefully observed before mimicking the action. Horsey was patient with her.

"Off we go," Glimmer was astride Twinkletoes, Bow on an accompanying horse. She nodded her head, the group following after Angella and Micah as the sun shined over them.

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Adora lay in the grass, staring up at the moving clouds as the sun began to set. Glimmer was beside her, silent but conscious for perhaps the first time in her life. Bow and Catra came out of the house, the pair joining the girls sprawled in the middle of the flower field. They'd spent part of the afternoon doing various activities, Catra sleeping after the long horse ride, and Bow continuing to play with the animals.

"Can we stay like this forever?" Bow asked, his eyes fluttering closed for a second before opening again.

"I agree. This is great," Adora could see the couple's hands interlocking in the side of her gaze, and smiled for her friends. If someone told her a year ago that she'd be here, heart happy and full of friendship and love, she would've hardly believed them...yet here she was.

"We'll always be the Best Friend Squad, right guys?" Bow lifted his head slightly to look at each of them.

"We'll be friends, but we are not calling ourselves the Best Friend Squad," Catra responded dryly, though she couldn't hide the grin widening on her face.

"BEST FRIEND SQUAD!" Bow yelled, the sound echoing in the vast sea of nature surrounding them.

The girls laughed despite themselves, Adora smiling and happy beyond measure. Bow suddenly stood up, holding his hands out to Glimmer.

"Let's dance," he wildly suggested.

"There's no music," Glimmer was skeptical.

"So? Since when did you need music to dance?"

Glimmer thought about his question, before shrugging and accepting the offer. He pulled her to her feet, spinning her around in a horrible attempt at the waltz. The couple drifted further into the field, their laughter still audible to Catra and Adora remaining still on the ground. The silence acted as an opportunity for Adora to finally speak.

"I'm ready," she said randomly, but carefully. She had never not been ready, she just needed to be sure that this time was the final time. No more breaks, no chance of a break-up. She shifted in the field, the sky morphing from blue to purple as she looked at Catra.

"Me too," the girl breathed in response, looking from the colorful sky to Adora. They smiled as they met the other's gazes, fingers meeting each other's in the field. Catra sat up, Adora following the motion so they could face each other properly. She couldn't help but chuckle lightly when she saw Catra's mess of hair, various bits of flower tangled in the strands. Her hands found themselves picking the nature out of her hair, eyes locking with the gold and blue.

"Can I say something?"

Adora nodded, even though it wasn't really a request. Catra had a hint of desperation laced in her voice.

"I love you, not in a purely platonic way, but more of a 'I can never get enough of you, I'm in love with you' kind of way."

Catra blushed, but continued to meet Adora's eyes.

"I think I've always loved you, it just took me a while to realize it." Adora gave her a watery smile, swiping under her eyes with a sniff. She looked down for a second, collecting herself before looking at Catra again.

"I love you too, Catra. More than that, I fall in love with you more and more every single day. I don't know why it took me years to realize that," she sniffed, despite wiping her tears a few seconds ago.

"I'm a real dummy sometimes."

"But you're my dummy."

Catra reached her hand out, brushing Adora's tears for her as she held her face. She laughed, a few of her own tears escaping. Their foreheads touched, noses brushing the other.

"Yeah, I am," Adora admitted softly. She closed the distance between them, the feeling of fire and warmth returning to her after a long, long time. Their hands weaved into one another's, the kiss growing as the sun set behind them. Catra leaned backwards into the soft grass, apparently uncaring for the hives on her skin as Adora straddled her, pushing her hair past her shoulders as the kiss deepened.

A whistle sounded from in front of the couple, breaking their focus on one another. Adora looked up, seeing Bow and Glimmer with possibly the smuggest expressions she'd ever witnessed.

"I win, hand over the money loser."

Glimmer held out her arm, Bow grabbing a twenty from his wallet and passing it to her.

"Betting? Again? Come on guys," Adora rolled her eyes, but nothing could wipe the smile on her face.

"Could you two perverts leave us alone? We haven't made out in over a month," Catra raised an eyebrow, still under Adora.

"You know how long it's been?"

Catra's gaze was incredulous as she looked to Adora at the question. "You don't?"

"Nine hundred and thirty six hours...approximately," Adora murmured, leaning in to meet Catra's lips again. It was easy to do the math in her head.

"AWWW," Glimmer's exclaim startled both of them, Catra and Adora glaring at their two friends. Glimmer slapped her hands on her mouth, before holding up both arms in surrender.

"Sorry, sorry! We're leaving now," she grabbed Bow's hand, both girls watching until the pair were safely far away from them.

"You're really pretty, did you know that?"

Adora looked at Catra for a moment, hovering over her.

"You're such an idiot. Shut up and kiss me, dummy," Catra rolled her eyes with a breathy laugh. Adora willingly obliged, leaning forward and closing the distance between them once again as Catra's arms wrapped around her neck. She melted into the moment, sky becoming a dusty pink and the floral scent encompassing them, all the while she breathed in Catra. Just Catra.

This was it, this was her Paradise.

[Eight Years Later]

Adora rocked back and forth anxiously, eyes crawling around the exits, watching people roll their suitcases and luggage behind them. Her hearth thrummed in her chest, grip tightening around the small bouquet of flowers she'd stopped to buy. Quickly, her eyes travelled to the large screen, eyeing the "ARRIVED" sign suspiciously. The bold red words had been flashing for the past thirty minutes and there was still no sign of her. Her pocket was being weighed down, the black velvet box neatly placed inside of it suddenly feeling like it weighed ten pounds.

And then she saw her. Waves of dark brown, tired eyes and wearing a mess of clothes, Adora still couldn't help but gasp at the beautiful, disheveled sight of her. Without thinking, she waved her arms in the hair, standing on the low rail that divided the arrivals from visitors. The stares she received were harsh, but she couldn't care less when she hadn't seen her girlfriend in four weeks. Catra reddened as her eyes landed on Adora's, but her embarrassment couldn't smother the beaming smile on her face.

God, Adora loved that smile. The way her once weary eyes instantly brightened, the flush of her cheeks. She could feel her own grin broaden as Catra rounded the corner and finally reached her, abandoning her luggage to throw herself in Adora's arms.

Adora's hands tightened around Catra's waist, squeezing her back and she engulfed herself in that wonderful, knowing scent. No matter how many times Catra left for work trips, Adora would never be accustomed to her absence.

"I missed you so fucking much," Catra whispered in her hair before leaning back. She hastily swiped her eyes, though no tears had appeared. Adora smoothed out her dark hair, tucking behind loose strands so she could truly look at her girlfriend. Her hands moved to cup Catra's face, finally kissing her.

"I missed you more than you can imagine," she whispered against her lips, feeling Catra's smile. They broke apart, Adora mindlessly slipping her fingers into Catra's as they led their way to the carpark.

Catra spoke as they walked, telling her how Ingrid, her new marketing coordinator, had completely butchered the vision she had for her upcoming line. Adora listened attentively, sprinkling in suggestions when Catra seemed to be asking for them. Their hands only disconnected when they reached the gleaming cherry red car. The pair loaded Catra's luggage into the boot before sliding into the warmth of the vehicle.

"But I don't want to fire her, she has good experience and even though she's a pain in my ass, her ideas can be helpful."

Catra continued, buckling up her seatbelt. Adora did the same, bringing the engine to life.

"Do a few more one on one sessions with her, maybe? You could try sending her a few of those vision boards you spend hours working on?" Adora reversed out of the parking spot before swiftly exiting the carpark. Catra hummed in response, seemingly appeased by the idea.

"How's the gym going?"

She turned to Adora, who couldn't help but grin at the mention of her gym.

"I didn't think it'd get this much business in only a year, honestly." She admitted.

Most people were lucky if they even got to start a business straight out of college, Adora didn't expect her's to become so popular.

"Lonnie reckons we should expand with the profit we've got."

Catra's eyebrows shot up in pleasant surprise.

"Not a bad idea. Might as well take advantage of the good rep."

Adora nodded. Lonnie suggested Mystacor, and Adora was inclined to the idea. Considering Catra travelled there every few months or so, it meant they'd spend less time apart.

"I've got the best surprise for you at home, you're gonna adore it."

Adora winked with a smug smile, approaching the street where there apartment was located.

"Adore it, huh?"

Adora rolled her eyes at the implied joke.

"Shut up and be excited," she replied in a dull tone, still unable to weaken the smile on her face. Catra's distant chuckle could be heard as the wind pushed against them. With only a few weeks until Christmas, the weather was extra brutal. Adora hoped it would mean they were getting snow this year.

"Hurry," Catra urged as Adora fiddled with the keys. Her gloved hand kept a firm hold on the suitcase to stop it from rolling down the driveway. She finally freed the ID card from her wallet, unlocking the door and pushing it open for Catra to go in first.

The opted for the elevator, Catra making a snide remark as they walked in.

"Adora Gray, the most elite P.T in Brightmoon, taking the elevator instead of stairs?" She smirked with a gasp.

"Wow, aren't you funny?" Adora replied dryly with narrowed eyes. They reached their floor, the thick metal doors sliding open. Adora used her ID card again, putting the code in for the alarm quickly. She felt Catra sigh in contentment in beside her, and switched the light on.

"Home sweet-Holy fuck."

Adora licked her lips, the box in her coat suddenly very present again. This is what she'd been waiting for.

"Blondie, this is..."

Her voice trailed off, Adora looking around to admire her own work. In the centre of the broad apartment, in front of the couch, were a circle of roses. The flowers were scattered along their round white rug, paired with an assortment of gingerbread scented candles, and two wineglasses. Adora felt her stomach fall to the floor when Catra slowly turned around. She subtly dimmed the lights, all signs of tiredness erased from Catra's expression.

"Mm, Princess, what's all this for?"

Catra murmured the words, a glint in her eye. Adora tried (and failed) to not visibly gulp.

"Like I said, I really, really missed you," she whispered. Catra wasted no time, roughly pulling Adora down to meet her lips. The kiss unexpectedly grew hungry and desperate, Catra pulling their bodies onto the couch as Adora's mind struggled to remember something important.

"Forget fancy wine, all I want is-"

Her sentence got cut off with a hitched breath, Adora having made her way down her neck.

"You," she managed to exhale, wrapping her legs around Adora's waist and pulling her down closer.

All the while the candles continued to burn on the ground, wine left unopened, Adora's important plans slipping away into the night.

Adora felt her eyes blink open slowly, the unfamiliar feeling of soft cushions pressed around her. It wasn't unpleasant, but sleeping

on her bed would have been preferable over the couch. She smiled at the steady weight nestled against her chest, the comfortable rise and fall of Catra's breath. Adora rubbed small circles on her back, adjusting to carefully pull the box out of her pocket. Checking to make sure Catra was securely asleep, Adora pried the box open. Greeting her was a sparkling obsidian gemstone, dramatic but classy. Glimmer had assisted in the stone's choosing. Adora had learnt a lot about jewels in the six months it took to produce the ring. This one was incredibly rare, but so was Catra. It made perfect sense. Accompanying the large stone was a thin, diamond encrusted band. She gently closed the box, sighing at the abandoned romantic display. So much for a grand proposal. Now she had to think of something else. Taking out her phone, she messaged Glimmer, who had already sent a long string of texts.

Glim: Have you done it?

Glim: Is it done?

Glim: Adora.

Glim: ADORA

Glim: ffs am I a maid of honor or not?

Glim: seriously adora, this isn't funny.

Adora replied, informing Glimmer that 'it' was not in fact 'done.' When she'd asked Bow on proposal advice, he told her Glimmer knew it was happening before it actually happened. Adora was fairly certain Catra had no idea what was coming. They lived together, and had discussed marriage, but only light heartedly. Adora suddenly had the uneasy thought that Catra might reject her.

Right as the panicked thought flew into her mind, Catra stirred, sleepy eyes blinking open.

"You alright?"

Adora must've looked flustered, because those were the first words out of Catra's mouth.

"Uh huh," she choked. Catra raised herself, turning to face Adora properly with questioning eyes.

"What's wrong?"

Adora wanted to desperately blurt out "Would you marry me if I asked you?" But that would spoil the whole surprise. Instead, she coughed, making Catra even more suspicious.

"Areyouserious?" Adora said in one breath. Catra's eyebrows furrowed.

"About?"

"Us! You, me, couple?"

This definitely was not what Catra was expecting. Her expression softened in surprise, and she leaned back into the couch.

"Adora. I'm fucking living with you, you dense idiot," she muttered.

"So...you are serious?" Adora still found herself confused.

Catra clasped her hands with her's, meeting Adora's eyes.

"Yes. I'm crazy serious about you."

Adora sighed in relief, leaning back. Perhaps she would say 'yes' if she proposed? Now was definitely not the time to find out.

"Any more stupid questions?" Catra smirked at Adora, her eyes teasing. Adora couldn't help but redden and dodge her gaze.

"No?" She shrugged. Catra stood up from the couch with a chuckle, stretching her arms upwards.

"Let's do the tree today," she glanced back at Adora, who eagerly nodded. Her phone buzzed beside you, messages and calls coming from Glimmer. Catra looked down at the table curiously, but Adora snatched the device before she could look at it properly.

"I'll be right back, business call."

Catra's eyes lightened, and Adora could tell she was about to ask the details of this 'business call.' She quickly left the room before she had to fabricate more lies.

"Well? What happened?"

Glimmer's whisper was frantic enough to make Adora wince.

"Sex," Adora answered bluntly. She cringed at Glimmer's scream over the phone, holding it away from her ear.

"Really?"

Bow's chuckle in the background was unable to be missed. Adora smiled despite Glimmer's frustration.

"I spent an hour helping you set that up last night," she groaned. Adora sighed, sitting on the ottoman and whispering quietly.

"Sorry, I won't get distracted next time."

"What are you going to do now?"

Adora chewed her lip in thought. Honestly, it had been hard enough to think of her original proposal plan. Concocting a new one would be practically impossible.

"I don't know. I'll figure it out later. Listen, I've gotta go, she's going to get suspicious. I'll keep in touch, but don't spam me."

Adora hurriedly ended the call before Glimmer could respond, pacing up and down the room a few times. Her palms were clammy, face flushed. This proposal had to be perfect, nothing

could go wrong. She heard a soft knock at the bedroom door, halting her pacing.

"Adora?"

Catra's voice was tentative. Adora quickly smoothed her hands against her pants and opened the door.

"Important call?" Her voice was peppered with curiosity.

"Yeah," she tried not to gulp.

"Uh huh. What about? You look...scattered," Catra's eyes wandered up and down Adora's figure.

"Just gym stuff. Lonnie wants to...buy some new equipment! We're working around the budget," she nodded quickly, twisting around Catra to reach the door. Catra nodded, albeit hesitantly.

"O-kay. Come on, we need to get ready if we're tree hunting."

Catra strolled into their walk in wardrobe, moving to her side of the small room. Adora followed her, watching in fascination as Catra's eyes moved over the clothes. It was interesting to watch, completely unlike to when Catra was designing her pieces. Rather than her features taking on a pensive, glassy appearance, she seemed a lot more methodical when she chose garments to wear on herself. Her fingers flicked through the vast array of options, landing on a flexible maroon coat, a black turtleneck with cutouts, and slim black pants that flared at the bottom. She raised an eyebrow at Adora, who was still watching her.

"I told you to stop doing that," she remarked.

"I can't help it," Adora replied, turning back towards her own clothes. Her hands found themselves grabbing her plaid woolen coat, worn blue jeans, and white crewneck.

"Mm, I think I need to invest in a few more rings," Catra mused, wiggling her bare fingers in their bathroom mirror.

Adora dropped her hair elastic in surprise, bending down to pick it up.

Does she know?

She felt her pocket for the box. It was too anxiety inducing to leave the ring anywhere in their apartment for Catra to find, so Adora decided to just keep it with her 24/7.

"Adora?"

Catra looked down at her, and Adora realized she still had not risen from crouching on the floor. She hummed in false agreement.

"Mhmm mhm," she didn't trust herself to speak. Catra gave her an odd look, but didn't say anything. She finished her eyeliner, capping the pen and looking expectantly at Adora, who finished tying her hair into her signature ponytail.

"I'm driving," Catra said firmly.

"No I am."

This was an argument they had often. Never a serious one, but quite a common occurrence.

"I haven't seen my car in a month."

"Because you've been visiting the other three," Adora rebutted. Catra refused to be driven when on business trips. She claimed it made her feel like a child. So instead of hiring a driver, she bought three additional cars, each of which lived in her other residences.

"I miss the R8," she murmured lowly.

"Too bad."

Catra huffed, her eyes meeting Adora with intensity. She matched the stare, knowing the first to lose would automatically become

the passenger. Folding her arms, Adora leaned forward. Catra instantly blushed, eyes darting downwards for a second. But that signaled defeat, causing Adora to smile in satisfaction.

"Passenger princess," Adora sing sang as they exited the bedroom. Catra growled at the taunt, causing Adora's amusement to grow. She plucked her set of keys from the rack while Catra grabbed her bag.

Just to piss her off even more, Adora opened the car door for her, gesturing for Catra to sit. The smaller girl gave her a hard shove in response, swinging the door hard. Adora couldn't help but chuckle as she sat in the driver's seat.

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"That one?"

"Too short. Oooh, that one?"

"Too wide."

Catra and Adora weaved through the trees with matching assessing gazes, examining each and every one of them until they came across the tree.

"Adora."

Catra's tone was deadly quiet as she tugged on Adora's coat. She turned her head, eyes landing on the most magnificent, wondrous, perfect tree possible.

"That one," they said in perfect unison.

"You guard, I'll find an employee," Adora whispered. Catra nodded, still staring at the tree. Adora quickly left in search of a worker, only sourcing one after a few minutes.

"Hi, I'd like to get a tree," she smiled at the gentleman. He nodded, gesturing for her to show him which tree.

When they finally reached the tree, Adora spotted Catra staring down a tall man.

"This is my tree, back off."

Adora smiled at the worker next to her, pointing to the tree. The man approached Catra and her opponent.

"Who's tree is this?"

"Mine," they said in unison. Adora quickly slid next to Catra, but her girlfriend didn't pay attention to her.

"I saw it first," argued the man.

"No, I did."

Adora knew better than to step in. Catra had it handled. She wanted to win this.

"Listen, how about I just give you fifty, and I can get the tree."

Catra looked downright offended that this man thought he could bribe her out of the fight.

"How about I just pay you a kick up your ass, and I can get the tree."

Adora's eyes widened, and so did the man's.

"Excuse me?"

"You heard me," she folded her arms. He scoffed in response, holding out his arms in surrender.

"Fuck it. Take your stupid tree," he shook his head. Adora grinned, discreetly slapping Catra's palm in a hi-five and sliding their fingers together. Once the dispute was resolved, the worker agreed to have the tree delivered later in the afternoon to their apartment. Catra pulled out her phone, showing Adora a text.

"Are we going to Glimmer and Bow's, then?"

Glimmer had sent a message demanding a visit from her sister that she hadn't seen for a month. It was a bit dramatic, but that was Glimmer herself.

"Yep," she nodded.

Adora chuckled, disconnecting their fingers to wrap an arm around Catra's neck. Even with her most clunky boots, Catra could never quite reach Adora's height. Catra snuggled closer to Adora under her arm, the cold wind brushing against them.

"As much as I love spraying your perfume on the pillow, nothing hits the spot like the real thing."

Catra smiled up at her, nose and cheeks pink from the cold. Adora remembered that moment, only four years ago. They hadn't been living together at the time, but it still ached when Catra left Brightmoon for her work. She'd only done three trips, but the fourth is what caused the couple to gift each other a bottle of their signature perfumes. Every time they were in different cities or continents, Adora would spray Catra's perfume around her, and Catra would do the same. It was their way of missing each other a little less.

"Agreed," Adora murmured against her hair.

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"I said two. It's one."

Glimmer pointedly looked at her phone to prove her point, but Catra rolled her eyes.

"You become more like Mom everyday, I swear," she muttered as they entered the large apartment. Adora couldn't help but sneak a look at Glimmer's art studio through the window, spotting the latest piece she was working on.

"But the food's not ready!" Glimmer whined, following after them.

"Chill Sparkles. We're not after a gourmet meal, I get enough of those when I'm away."

The couple took their coats off, putting them in the coat cupboard. Bow smiled at them as they entered the living room, setting down his mug of tea.

"No rings, Catra?"

His eyes twinkled, and Adora felt her own widen in both annoyance and fear. Catra didn't seem fazed by the question though.

"In my suitcase, I haven't unpacked yet."

"Ah," Bow folded his book and placed it on the coffee table. Glimmer came around to the couch, taking a seat opposite Bow. Adora and Catra followed her, Adora eyes falling over the Christmas ornaments scattered around the room.

"Have you finally considered my request to make a Sparkle Collection?" Glimmer joked, her tone light and misty. Adora smirked at the thought of a line centered around Glimmer, and Catra snickered.

"In your dreams, Sparkles. My next collection is going to be inspired by nature."

Glimmer made a huff of indigence, one of which caused all of them to laugh.

"I've already made you clothes. Remember your wedding dress? That took me months," Catra raised an eyebrow at her, pulling a blush from Glimmer.

"It was a gorgeous dress," she admitted.

"Would you make your own wedding outfit?"

Bow's questions was so abrupt that it startled even Catra. Adora held her breath, shooting daggers at Bow with her eyes.

"If you were getting married, of course?" He extended. Catra looked to Adora for a moment, still deciding on her answer.

"My own? Yes, I think I would," she released a bubble of laughter, but it sounded forced.

"What about Adora's?" Glimmer chimed in. Adora was beginning to think that bringing Catra here so soon wasn't the brightest idea. Bow and Glimmer were too eager, they were going to expose her any minute now. Catra elicited more false laughter, her cheeks growing red. She turned to Adora, looking at her as she spoke.

"No, not her's. Relax with the wedding talk," she leaned back further into the couch, and Bow, Glimmer and Adora all exchanged a look at her tone.

Silence stretched for a few long moments until Glimmer spoke again, her voice a fraction too high.

"Right, well, food's ready!"

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Catra was quiet when they arrived back home, shaking out the roots of her hair with a sigh. Adora felt her mouth go dry, pushing back the need to fidget or distract herself. When Catra looked at her again, her eyes were pensive.

"Why are you acting so off?"

Adora narrowed her eyes, brain scrambling to produce a valid response.

"Why are you acting so off?" She rebounded the question, but Catra just rolled her eyes.

"I'm serious. You've been weird all day."

"Weird how?"

Adora tried to elongate the conversation rather than give an actual answer. The truth couldn't come out right now.

"First the strange questions in the morning. Then the secretive 'business call.' And you were on edge the entire time we were Bow and Glimmer's. What are you hiding?"

Catra poked her head around to inspect the room as if Adora was physically hiding an object or person.

"Nothing! I've just missed you, and the holiday season is hectic."

Adora mentally slapped herself for the weak excuse. Catra's suspicion intensified as she came closer, taking her coat off and hanging it on a nearby chair.

"I've seen you through a good eight Christmases, Adora. You're never this anxious."

Adora opened and closed her mouth like an idiot, trying not to look guilty. Her cheeks betrayed her, heat flushing her face. Suddenly, Catra's face softened. She looped her arms around Adora's neck, eyes running over her face.

"What is it, Princess? You can tell me."

She brushed the loose blonde strands sneaking out from the ponytail, hand resting on Adora's cheek. Adora leaned into the touch, relished it after time apart. Her heart ached, the words waiting to fall from her lips. She could do it right there, bend down on one knee and pull out the ring...

The idea was pushed back in her mind. Now wasn't the moment.

Instead she rested her hands on Catra's waist, pulling her close into a hug. She breathed in the moment, the feeling of Catra in

her arms, the steady heartbeat. And then she lied through her teeth.

"Lonnie's just been stressing me out. She wants to expand, but I don't think we're ready yet."

Adora desperately hoped Catra wouldn't give Lonnie a stern phone call.

"Okay, that's okay. Lonnie will understand, she's reasonable."

Adora was glad that they were still locked in the embrace. It was impossible to look directly at Catra and lie.

"Yeah, I don't want to worry about all that during the holidays though. It can wait."

Catra gently let go, a smile returning to her face.

"Let's decorate the tree."

———————

"Mara and Hope are leaving for Beast Island on Christmas Day, so they've called us for dinner on the Eve," Adora babbled as she hung up a bauble.

"Sounds perfect. Mom's demanding us for at least half of Christmas Day. All because I couldn't fly down in time for her birthday this year," Catra rolled her eyes. She was moving around the tree in an effort to hang up the lights.

"Well I'll personally give Angella a call and let her know we'll be there the whole day," Adora teased. She was given a glare for her joke.

"I bought you such an amazing, spectacular, show stopping gift this year," Catra said in a taunting voice. Every year, they had a tradition of competing with each other over Christmas gifts. Adora had almost forgotten about it, being so distracted with the ring

and proposal. She blinked, her hands accidentally losing purchase on the bauble. The trinket fell on the floor, and she quickly bent to pick it up.

"You can't beat me," she smoothly bridged the small silence. Catra scoffed, grabbing the Star to place on the top of the tree.

"I can, actually. It's quite easy," her eyes twinkled.

"We'll see about that," Adora folded her arms against her chest. Catra looked down at the star for a moment.

"This thing always reminds me of my first collection," she said unexpectedly. Adora looked at the star with her.

"A Starless Constellation?"

Catra nodded, a small smile growing on her face. She spun the ornament in her hands delicately.

"You walked in that," she suddenly remembered. Adora nodded solemnly.

"I did. It was a nightmare."

"Oh you loved it. Don't lie."

She couldn't push against the smile crawling on her face. She moved her arm around Catra's neck, planting a kiss against her head. They lay there for a few moments, Adora unable to pull back from their side hug.

"Maybe a little," she admitted softly. She felt her phone buzz in her pocket, and quietly pulled it out. A message from Glimmer to call her when she was able to. Adora glanced at Catra, preoccupied with trying to reach the top of the tree with the star glinting in her hand. She sent Glimmer a quick reply before pocketing her phone again, helping Catra get to the top.

"I was handling it, you know," Catra huffed in annoyance.

"Yeah, sure you were," Adora smirked.

Catra rolled her eyes, but reached for Adora's hand as she flicked on the lights. The tree was suddenly lit up, gold bulbs of light flashing at them. Catra yawned, checking the watch on her wrist.

"Time for bed," she stretched her arms. Her eyes landed expectantly on Adora, who struggled for an excuse.

"Yeah, I'll make us some hot chocolate and meet you in the room."

"I'll help you then," Catra started walking to the kitchen and Adora mentally slapped herself.

"Uhh, no need. You've spent the whole month working, I'll bring it to you."

Catra folded her arms against her chest.

"It'll be way quicker if we just do it together," she offered. Adora shook her head firmly, placing her hands on Catra's shoulders and spinning her around. Guiding her to their bedroom, her brain scrambled for words.

"We both know I'm the better chef-"

Catra opened her mouth to object, but Adora cut in with a whisper.

"Remember the burnt cheesecake last year? And your sesame matcha milkshake?"

Catra closed her mouth again with tinted cheeks.

"So I'll make the hot chocolates, and you will rest," she finished firmly, lightly shoving Catra into the bedroom with a kiss on her cheek.

Once Catra was safely on the other side of the apartment, Adora called Glimmer.

"What's your plan, Romeo?" She hissed into the phone.

"I don't have one," Adora replied calmly.

"YOU DON'T HAVE ONE?" She yelled. Adora held the phone away from her ear with a grimace.

"Pass the phone to Bow," she requested.

"You're already on speaker."

Adora sighed, she wouldn't expect anything less.

"I'm waiting for a burst of inspiration. I don't want it to be some elaborate, orchestrated thing."

"So you're going to just randomly pull a ring out and be like 'Hey Catra, wanna be my wife?' "

"That's a horrible imitation of me," Adora deadpanned.

"And I'm not planning on doing it randomly. Just when it feels right."

"Alright, that's a good plan. But you might want to have an idea of where you'll do it. Like a sunset walk or something?" Bow suggested.

Adora chewed her lip for a minute. A sunset walk felt to generic, but Bow did have a point.

"Yeah, okay. Is that all you guys want to know?"

She quickly boiled the milk for the hot chocolate, adding spoonfuls of the powder into two mugs.

"Well, yes," Glimmer said hesitantly.

"Great, cause I've gotta go," She quickly hung up, feeling a bit bad for cutting her friends off so bluntly. But Catra could walk in at any moment to see how the hot chocolates were progressing. She couldn't risk it. She poured the milk into the mugs, using an electric whisk to mix the contents. Finishing the drinks with whipped cream and marshmallows, she headed back towards the bedroom.

Catra had showered and changed into her pajamas, waiting on the bed with raised eyebrows.

"Why are you so red? And out of breath?"

"Sunburn," Adora blurted out mindlessly. She cringed a moment after when she saw the look on Catra's face.

"It's snowing."

Adora gulped, passing her the hot chocolate. Thankfully, Catra just shook her head and didn't push for an answer.

"I missed a call from DT while we were decorating the tree," she opened her phone. Before Adora could respond she saw Catra raise the phone to her ear. Whatever greeting DT had said caused Catra to chuckle. Adora gestured for her to put the call on speaker. She gave her a look, but complied.

"She's right next to me," Catra responded as she set the phone down.

"Oh, has the darling given you your early present this year?" Adora could practically hear the wink in their voice.

"Early Christmas present?" Catra looked up at Adora curiously.

"She knows how much you love your jewels," DT purred.

"No Double Trouble, I haven't given her the...early Christmas present," Adora forced a laugh, resisting the urge to strangle them over the phone.

"Hey, that's not fair. We agreed on three presents each," Catra crossed her arms.

"Yeah, it's one of the three," Adora lied. It was in fact a fourth 'present' if that's what they thought it to be.

"Oh, you'll love it, Kitten," DT continued.

"Arghh, nooo," Catra groaned painfully.

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Adora had the beginnings of an idea forming in the crevices of her mind. She sat down at the table, opposite Catra.

"I was thinking-"

"Stop right there," Catra quickly swallowed her coffee and spoke. Adora blinked in surprise.

"I'm taking you out today," Catra announced proudly. Adora was both intrigued and annoyed. She needed to surprise Catra, not the other way around.

"You've already spoilt me, it's my turn."

Catra stood and put her mug in the dishwasher, spinning around to face Adora.

"So what are we doing?"

A devious smile spread on Catra's face as she leant forward.

"Not for you to know. Get ready," she nodded towards the bedroom. Adora groaned. This wasn't good. This wasn't good at all.

"And wear something warm, or you'll freeze," Catra called out to her.

Adora sighed, digging out her puffer, boots and loose jeans, along with a few thermals. Catra followed her into their bedroom, leaning against their racks of clothing.

"Why are you so smug?" Adora said grumpily. All of her ideas for a perfect proposal were slipping out the window. She felt the ring practically screaming at her from her pocket.

"I get to boss you around."

Adora scoffed, eyes flicking to the set of handcuffs on their dresser.

"You always boss me around. This isn't new."

Catra followed her gaze before raising her eyebrows at Adora.

"So dirty minded."

"I learn it from you," Adora brushed past her shoulder purposefully, walking into the bathroom to change.

Catra made her own assessment of the wardrobe, choosing an outfit for herself before following Adora.

The blonde had finished the last of her minimal makeup, tying her hair up before leaning against the shower. Catra had always spent more time getting ready. Even on the days where she wore less or no makeup, she still managed to occupy the bathroom for at least forty minutes.

Once her eyeliner was perfected, Catra threw her hair into a loose braid, the hair falling down her shoulder. She packed up her makeup bag, stepping closer to Adora and winding her arms around her.

"Hmph, your coat's too big," Catra huffed against her. She moved to remove Adora's coat, hand landing on the pocket.

"What the fuck is in your pocket?"

Catra patted down on the surface, about to reach her hand inside when Adora tackled her. The couple landed on the floor in a mess, Adora snatching the coat off Catra's hands. She felt warm and out of breath, her heart jumping out of her chest. Catra continued to give her a bewildered look, trapped underneath her.

"Show me what's in the pocket." Her voice was icy, but Adora knew she couldn't comply with that request.

"It's nothing. Just part of your Christmas gift. So you can't see it yet."

She was quite proud of her lie, Catra easily bought it.

"Mmm...okay," Adora tried not to exhale too loudly. She slowly climbed off of Catra, holding a hand to help her up.

"I'm driving today."

Catra dusted herself off, still looking at Adora with narrowed eyes. Adora couldn't argue with the decision, she had no idea what Catra had in mind for the day. She smiled maliciously, plucking her keys off the rack along with her bag.

Adora was mildly surprised Catra didn't run to her car, especially after being apart from it for a month. In fact, Adora wasn't sure if Catra was in love with her, or the Audi. Probably both. Despite the vehicle's age, it still drove perfectly.

"Get comfy, it's not a short drive," Catra's eyes sparked with excitement. Adora found herself disliking the nervous energy she was building up. Catra seemed to love it.

Adora tried to search for clues along the drive. They'd left Brightmoon altogether, so Catra was taking her on some sort of day trip. The route seemed familiar, but more of a distant memory than anything else.

"Relax, will you?" Catra drummed her fingers against the wheel, placing her hand on Adora's thigh in an effort to calm her.

"I'm relaxed, perfectly calm," Adora snapped. She tried to avoid fidgeting or squirming in her seat.

"One hint?" She asked shyly. Catra grinned, her hand moving to grab her girlfriend's.

"Sorry Princess. You have to wait and see."

Adora was becoming increasingly restless, watching as the time ticked to two o'clock. She was hungry too, but the roads were becoming more and more familiar, very nostalgic in an odd sense.

"Catra..." she trailed off as her eyes found themselves glued out the window.

"Are we going to...your winter cabin?"

She looked over at her girlfriend incredulously, but she was still smiling.

"Ah, one of my favorites. Remember the first time we visited?"

Adora smiled to herself, recalling that memory.

"Never forgot it. When we became friends again."

Catra reached the wooden mansion, parking her car in the underground garage.

"Mom said we could stay the night. I think it was well deserved."

Adora couldn't agree more. A weekend of skiing, fireplaces and snow sounded tempting. Her grand proposal plan could wait. She'd been so wrapped up in the thought of marriage that she'd almost forgotten how long she and Catra had spent apart.

"It is. You've worked really hard, you deserved the break."

Catra gave her a small smile, leaning in for a hug.

"So do you. Just because you're not traveling all over the place like me doesn't mean you aren't working hard."

"Alright then. We both work hard." She rested her chin on Catra's head, pulling her closer.

"And we both deserve this."

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"Come on, one more hill," Catra urged.

"Nah, nope, definitely not. We're done." Adora panted. Despite being the more active one out of the couple, Catra was still the best at skiing. She checked the time again. They'd spent the past two hours going up and down slopes.

"Let's go have a nice sunset dinner or something," Adora suggested. Catra frowned, but followed her as she unclipped the skis and began trudging in the snow.

"Fine. But if we're going for dinner, I'm taking a shower first."

Adora nodded, nudging her head towards the cabin.

They were almost there when something caught Adora's eye. She glanced down, towards the frozen over lake.

"Heh, remember when I jumped in there like an idiot and you saved me?"

Catra frowned at the memory.

"You scared me so fucking much that day. I thought you were dead for a few seconds."

She lightly hit the back of Adora's head.

"Yeah, me too," Adora joked. Catra gave her a glare before something unexpected crossed over her expression.

"Why don't we skate on it?"

Adora shook her head firmly. She'd only gone skating once, and it was the most dismal experience possible. Worse than Bambi on ice.

"You can skate on it. I don't feel like dying today, thanks."

"Oh, come on you big baby." Catra took hold of Adora's hand, shaking it with a whine.

"We don't even have skates."

"There's plenty at the cabin," Catra countered her argument. Adora pursed her lips, looking at the ice suspiciously.

"Okay. But the second I fall we're going home."

"Deal."

Catra's face was alight with excitement as she eagerly walked to the cabin. She looped her arm through Adora's, pulling her so they walked faster.

Adora snorted when they reached the rack of skates. Glimmer's were easily identifiable, smothered with bright blue glitter and purple gems. Catra's were too, all black with deep purple laces. She pulled out a pair of ordinary brown ones for Adora to use, the blades sharp and clean.

"Come on, we'll put them on near the lake." Catra grabbed her own pair, wrapping the laces tightly around her wrist.

"Are you sure the ice is thick enough?"

Catra scoffed lightly at the question, skipping a little in the snow.

"It's the middle of winter. And I've skated on it before, we'll be fine," she brushed off Adora's concern.

Adora took a breath as they neared the white sheet of ice, a cloud of air surrounding her from the exhale. Catra took less than two minutes getting her skates on, standing up and holding an arm out for Adora. She gratefully latched onto it, keeping a firm grip of Catra as they neared the edge.

"Oh, look!"

She gasped quietly, pointing at the sky. Adora smiled gently at the sunset, purple blending into blue as the sun disappeared. Her feet hesitantly moved towards the ice, the first few skates unsteady.

Even after a few rounds, Adora still remained attached to Catra, who of course skated brilliantly. She laughed as Adora wobbled, carefully disconnecting their linked arms to grab her hand.

"I think you've improved."

The obvious mockery made Adora glare at her, but at least she hadn't fallen. Yet.

"Hey, Adora?"

Adora looked back at her. Their hands were still joint, but arms spread out. She turned to face Catra on the ice, for her tone was soft and serious.

"Yeah?"

Catra chewed on the inside of her cheek, eyes quickly darting from Adora's pocket back to her face.

"Your early Christmas present...I think I might know what it is."

Adora met her gaze, clear and open. She felt like she might vomit. This wasn't how it was supposed to happen. She laughed nervously in an effort to cover up the secret.

"Trust me, you don't."

Catra glanced again at the box, but her face was resolute.

"Are you going to make me wait until Christmas to find out?"

Adora sighed. She already knew, it was obvious in her voice. Fuck it.

"Catra Brightmoon," she started. Adora had been picturing this moment for eons. The words she'd use, how Catra would react. Her eyes widened as Adora began to kneel.

"Wait-fuck-Adora!" Catra nearly tripped over herself, her hands grabbing onto Adora's shoulders.

"I didn't think I was right!"

Adora smiled, but continued with her rehearsed spiel.

"I don't think there's a single person on this planet that understands me the way you do," she spoke slowly, already witnessing a few tears slip from Catra's eyes.

"You are intelligent, creative, witty, a million other-What are you doing?"

Adora stopped abruptly when she noticed Catra lowering herself, kneeling with her on the ice.

"As if I'm going to let you steal all the fun, dummy," she laughed through the tears.

"Catra," Adora spoke seriously.

"Adora," she matched her tone.

"Go on, you were listing all the incredible things about me."

Adora smiled, prying the box from her pocket.

"Cocky is definitely one of them. But I love you for it and everything else. You are the person I want to be with for the rest

of my life."

Catra clasped her hands over Adora's, the box accidentally tumbling out of the blonde's hand and onto the ice.

"This is really not going the way I imagined."

She felt the ice seeping through her pants, quickly grabbing the box and holding it out gain.

"It's perfect." Catra smiled.

"Catra, will you marry me?"

Without a second of hesitation, Catra threw her arms around Adora, the ring forgotten between them.

"Yes, yes, a million times yes. There is no one else I'd rather spend eternity with."

Adora kissed her, hands snaking around her waist to pull Catra closer. They retracted only long enough for Catra to slip the ring on her finger.

"Don't think I'm not buying one for you too," Catra murmured.

"You wouldn't be Catra if you didn't," Adora replied.

"Can we stand up now? My knees are numb," Catra whispered against her. Adora nodded, each of them helping the other get up. Catra instantly wrapped her arms around Adora, hands slipping under the big coat to reach her torso.

"I love you," Catra looked up at her.

"I love you too," Adora returned her smile, reaching down to kiss her again.

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